



ἄνδρα μοι ἔννεπε, μοῦσα, πολύτροπον

Tell me the man, Muse — the man of many turnings

HOMER'S ODYSSEY

ΟΔΥΣΣΕΙΑ

LINE FOR LINE TRANSLATION BY FABLE 5 · A CLAUDYSSEY



TRANSLATED BY
CLAUDE

24 books · 12,107 lines rendered from the Greek



The Odyssey

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The Odyssey

a line-for-line translation

FROM THE GREEK OF

Homer

TRANSLATED BY

Claude (Fable 5)

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Chris Duffy

ἄνδρα μοι ἔννεπε, μοῦσα, πολύτροπον

*Tell me the man, Muse — the man of many
turnings*

A Note on the Text

The Greek is A. T. Murray's text from the Loeb Classical Library edition (*Homer: The Odyssey*, 1919), as digitized by the Perseus Digital Library from the polytonic vulgate. The English translation is original to this project; each of the 12,107 English lines is keyed one-to-one to its Greek line.

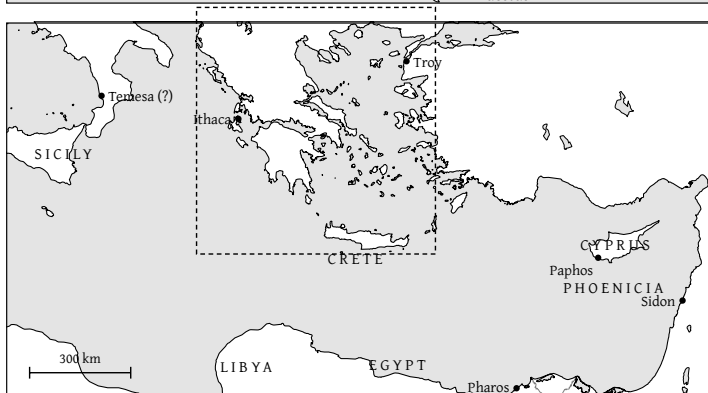
The scholarly apparatus — 1,260 notes across the poem — appears as endnotes at the close of each book. In the text a raised gold numeral marks a note; tap it to jump to the note, and tap the return arrow (↩) to come back to your place in the verse.

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Map



Places named in the Odyssey that can be located.
 The fabulous geography of Books 9 to 12 is not shown.
 Coastlines: Natural Earth (public domain).

Odyssey — Book 1

Athena comes to Ithaca; Telemachus resolves to seek his father.

- 1 Tell me the man, Muse — the man of many turnings, who was driven¹
- 2 wandering far, once he had sacked Troy's holy citadel:
- 3 many were the cities of men he saw, and he learned their minds,
- 4 many the griefs he suffered at heart on the open sea,
- 5 striving to win his own life and his companions' homecoming.
- 6 Even so he could not save them, hard though he strove:
- 7 they perished by their own recklessness,
- 8 fools, who ate the cattle of Helios Hyperion,
- 9 and the god took from them their day of homecoming.

10 Begin where you will, goddess, daughter of
Zeus — tell us, too, the tale.²

11 By then all the others, all who had escaped
sheer ruin,

12 were home, safely past the war and past the
sea.

13 Him alone — aching for homecoming and his
wife —

14 the queenly nymph Calypso, shining among
goddesses, held back³

15 in her hollow caves, hungry to make him her
husband.

16 But when the year came, in the wheeling round
of seasons,

17 in which the gods had spun the thread of his
return home

18 to Ithaca — not even there was he free of trials,

19 even among his own. And the gods pitied him,

20 all but Poseidon: he raged without rest

21 against godlike Odysseus, until the day he
reached his own land.

22 But now Poseidon was gone among the far-off

Ethiopians —

23 the Ethiopians, sundered in two, remotest of
mankind,

24 half where Hyperion sets and half where he
rises —

25 to receive a hecatomb of bulls and rams,

26 and there he sat at the feast, delighting. But
the other gods

27 were gathered together in the halls of
Olympian Zeus,

28 and among them the father of men and gods
began to speak,

29 for his heart was remembering blameless
Aegisthus,4

30 whom Agamemnon's son, far-famed Orestes,
killed.

31 Remembering him, he spoke among the
immortals:

32 "Shameful! — how mortals lay their blame
upon the gods.

33 From us, they say, all evils come — while they
themselves,

34 by their own recklessness, earn griefs beyond
their portion:5

35 as Aegisthus now, beyond his portion, took to
wife

36 the wedded bride of Atreus' son, and killed the
man at his homecoming,

37 knowing it meant sheer ruin — for we told him
beforehand,

38 sending Hermes down, the sharp-eyed slayer
of Argus,6

39 not to kill the man and not to court his wife:

40 for vengeance for the son of Atreus would
come from Orestes

41 the day he came of age and longed for his own
land.

42 So Hermes spoke, meaning him well — but the
mind of Aegisthus

43 he could not turn. Now he has paid for
everything at once.”

44 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed
Athena:7

45 “Father of us all, son of Cronos, highest of the

mighty,

46 that man, yes, lies in a ruin he richly earned —

47 so may any other perish who does such things.

48 But my heart is on fire for battle-wise

Odysseus,8

49 ill-starred man, who far from his own people
suffers long

50 on a sea-ringed island, at the navel of the sea.

51 A wooded island; a goddess has her dwelling
there,

52 the daughter of Atlas the deadly-minded, he
who knows

53 the depths of every sea, and himself grips the
pillars,

54 the tall ones, that hold earth and heaven apart.

55 It is his daughter who keeps that broken,
grieving man,

56 and always with soft words, with winding,
coaxing words,

57 she charms him to forget Ithaca. But Odysseus,

58 who would be glad to see even the smoke go
leaping up

59 from his own country, aches to die. And your
heart
60 does not turn for it, Olympian. Did Odysseus
never
61 please you, offering sacrifice beside the Argive
ships
62 in wide Troy? Why so at odds with Odysseus,
Zeus?"⁹
63 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered
her:
64 "My child, what a word has slipped the fence
of your teeth!"¹⁰
65 How could I ever forget godlike Odysseus,
66 who is beyond all mortals in mind, and beyond
all others gave
67 offerings to the deathless gods who hold wide
heaven?
68 No: it is Poseidon who holds the earth, in
anger
69 unbending, always, for the Cyclops, whose one
eye Odysseus blinded —
70 godlike Polyphemus, whose power is greatest

71 among all the Cyclopes. The nymph Thoösa
bore him,
72 daughter of Phorcys, a lord of the barren salt
sea,
73 when in her hollow caves she lay with
Poseidon.
74 Ever since, Poseidon the shaker of earth does
not kill
75 Odysseus, but drives him wandering from his
father's land.
76 But come, let all of us here take careful
thought together
77 for his homecoming — how he shall come.
Poseidon will let go
78 his anger. He cannot, against us all,
79 wrangle alone in the teeth of the deathless
gods.”
80 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed
Athena:
81 “Father of us all, son of Cronos, highest of the
mighty,
82 if this now truly pleases the blessed gods,

83 that Odysseus of the many designs come home
to his own house,
84 then let us dispatch Hermes, the guide, the
slayer of Argus,
85 to the island Ogygia, so that with all speed
86 he may tell the nymph of the lovely braids our
fixed decree:
87 the homecoming of enduring-hearted
Odysseus — that he shall return.
88 And I will go to Ithaca, to stir his son
89 the more, and set strength of purpose in his
heart
90 to call the long-haired Achaeans into assembly
91 and speak out to all the suitors, who day upon
day
92 slaughter his thronging flocks and his
shambling crook-horned cattle.**11**
93 And I will send him to Sparta and to sandy
Pylos
94 to ask after his dear father's homecoming, if he
may hear of it —
95 and so that good report among men may be

his.”

96 So she spoke, and bound beneath her feet the
beautiful sandals,

97 ambrosial, golden, that carry her over the
water

98 and over the boundless earth with the breath
of the wind;

99 and she took up her strong spear, edged with
sharp bronze,

100 heavy, huge, and solid, with which she breaks
the ranks of men,

101 of heroes, when the daughter of the mighty
Father is angered.

102 Down she went, darting from the peaks of
Olympus,

103 and stood in the land of Ithaca at Odysseus’
doorway,

104 on the courtyard’s threshold, the bronze
spear in her palm,

105 in the likeness of a stranger: Mentès, leader of
the Taphians.**12**

106 There she found the lordly suitors. They were

pleasing

107 their hearts with counters, out in front of the
doors,13

108 sitting on hides of oxen they themselves had
slaughtered,

109 with heralds and quick serving-men among
them:

110 some were mixing wine and water in the great
bowls,

111 and some were wiping the tables down with
porous sponges

112 and setting them out, and some carved meat
in plenty.

113 Godlike Telemachus saw her far the first,

114 for he sat among the suitors, sore at heart,

115 seeing his noble father in his mind's eye: if
only he would come

116 from somewhere, and make a scattering of the
suitors through the house,

117 and take back his honor, and be lord of his
own possessions.

118 So he brooded, sitting among the suitors —

and he saw Athena.

119 He went straight for the porch, indignant at
heart

120 that a stranger be left standing at the door;
and standing near her

121 he took her right hand, and relieved her of the
bronze spear,

122 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to
her:14

123 “Welcome, stranger. Here you will find
kindness — and afterward,

124 when you have tasted supper, you shall tell us
what you need.”

125 So saying he led the way, and Pallas Athena
followed.

126 And when they were inside the high-roofed
house,

127 he carried the spear to the tall pillar and set it
upright

128 inside the polished spear-rack, where already
other

129 spears stood in numbers, enduring-hearted

Odysseus' own;

130 and he led her to a high seat, spreading linen
beneath her,

131 a beautiful seat, cunningly worked, with a
footstool for her feet.

132 For himself he set a painted bench beside her,
apart from the others,

133 the suitors, for fear the stranger, sickened by
the din,

134 might lose all taste for supper, fallen among
bullies —

135 and so that he might ask him about his absent
father.

136 A handmaid brought water for their hands in
a pitcher,15

137 a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a
silver basin

138 for them to wash, and drew up a polished
table beside them.

139 The grave housekeeper brought bread and set
it before them,

140 laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of

her store;

141 a carver lifted platters of meat of every kind

142 and set them down, and placed gold cups
beside them,

143 and a herald kept coming round to them,
pouring the wine.

144 In came the lordly suitors, and they took their
seats

145 in order on the benches and the high-backed
chairs.

146 Heralds poured water over their hands,

147 slave-women heaped bread in baskets at their
sides,16

148 and young men crowned the mixing-bowls
with drink,

149 and their hands went out to the good things
spread before them.

150 But when they had put away desire for food
and drink,

151 the suitors — other things now filled their
hearts:

152 song and dance, for these are the ornaments

of a feast.

153 A herald put the beautiful lyre into the hands
154 of Phemius, who sang for the suitors under
compulsion,17

155 and he swept the strings and struck up his
lovely singing.

156 But Telemachus spoke to gray-eyed Athena,
157 leaning his head close, so that the others
might not hear:

158 “Dear stranger, will you take offense at what I
say?

159 These men care only for such things — the
lyre and song —

160 and easily, since unpunished they devour
another man’s living:

161 a man whose white bones rot somewhere in
the rain,

162 lying on a mainland shore, or the salt wave
rolls them.

163 But if they saw him once come home to
Ithaca,

164 every man of them would pray to be quicker

on his feet

165 rather than richer in gold and fine clothes.

166 But no — he has perished by an evil doom,
and for us there is

167 no comfort left, not though some man upon
the earth

168 should say he is coming still: his day of
homecoming is lost.

169 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

170 What man are you, and from where? Where
are your city and your parents? 18

171 On what kind of ship did you come? And how
did sailors

172 bring you to Ithaca? Who did they claim to
be?

173 For I hardly think you came here on foot.

174 And tell me this too, honestly, so that I may
know it:

175 is this your first coming here, or are you from
of old

176 my father's guest-friend? For many were the
men who came

177 to our house — since he, too, went much
among mankind.”

178 Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-
eyed Athena:

179 “Then I will tell you all of it, and truly.

180 I declare myself Mentès, son of wise
Anchialus,

181 and I am lord of the oar-loving Taphians.

182 Now I have put in here with my ship and my
companions,

183 sailing the wine-dark sea toward men of alien
speech,

184 to Temese, after copper; the cargo I carry is
gleaming iron.¹⁹

185 My ship stands off in the fields, away from the
city,

186 in the harbor of Rheithron, under wooded
Neion.

187 Guest-friends of each other’s houses we
declare ourselves

188 from the beginning — only go and ask the old
man,

189 the hero Laertes, who they say comes no more
190 to the city, but far out in the fields endures his
sorrows

191 with one old serving-woman, who sets his
food and drink

192 before him whenever weariness takes hold of
his limbs

193 as he creeps along the rise of his terraced
vineyard.

194 And now I have come. They said he was here
among his people —

195 your father. But no: the gods are thwarting his
road.

196 For noble Odysseus has not yet died anywhere
on earth;

197 he lives still, held back somewhere on the
wide sea,

198 on a sea-ringed island, and hard men have
him,

199 savages, who hold him there, I think, against
his will.

200 And now I will prophesy to you, as the

immortals

201 cast it into my heart, and as I believe it will be

—

202 though I am no prophet, no sure reader of
birds.

203 He will not now be long away from his own
dear country,

204 no, not if iron chains should hold him:

205 he will find a way to come home, for he is a
man of many devices.

206 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

207 whether you, grown so tall, are the son of
Odysseus himself.

208 The likeness is uncanny — the head, the fine
eyes.

209 We were often in each other's company, he
and I,

210 before he went up into Troy, where the others
also,

211 the best of the Argives, went in the hollow
ships.

212 Since that day I have not seen Odysseus, nor

he me.”

213 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
her:20

214 “Then I will tell you, stranger, all of it, and
truly.

215 My mother says I am his. For myself, I cannot
know:

216 no man yet has been witness to his own
begetting.21

217 Would that I had been the son of some blessed
man

218 whom old age overtook among his own
possessions!

219 Instead, the man born unluckiest of mortal
men —

220 his son, they say, I am. Since you ask me this.”

221 Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-
eyed Athena:

222 “The gods have not appointed your line to be
nameless

223 in time to come: Penelope has borne too fine
a son.

224 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:
225 What feast is this, what gathering? What is
your part in it?
226 A banquet? A wedding? For plainly no man
here brought his own share:22
227 so overweening, so past all bounds they seem
to me,
228 feasting through the house. A man would
burn with anger,
229 seeing shame upon shame — any man of
sense who entered.”
230 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:
231 “Stranger — since you ask me this and press
the question —
232 there was a time this house promised to be
rich and honored,
233 while that man was still here among his
people.
234 Now the gods have willed otherwise, plotting
evil:
235 they have made him vanish as no other man
has vanished,

236 no man on earth. For I would not grieve so
even for his death
237 had he gone down among his companions in
the Trojans' country,
238 or in the arms of his friends, once he had
wound the war to its end.
239 Then the whole Achaean people would have
built him a tomb,
240 and he would have won great fame in time to
come for his son as well.
241 Instead the whirlwinds have snatched him
away without glory; 23
242 he is gone — unseen, unheard-of — and to me
he has left
243 anguish and lament. Nor is he all I have to
mourn
244 and groan for: the gods have made me other
bitter cares.
245 All the great men who hold power among the
islands —
246 Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus

—

247 and all who lord it through rocky Ithaca:
248 so many woo my mother, and wear this house
away.

249 And she neither refuses the marriage she
loathes, nor can she

250 bring it to an end. And they eat on, wasting

251 my house. Soon they will tear me to pieces
too.”

252 Then, stung to anger, Pallas Athena spoke to
him:

253 “Shame on it! Great indeed is your need of the
vanished Odysseus,

254 to lay his two hands on these shameless
suitors.

255 If only he came now and stood at the outer
doors

256 of the house, with helmet and shield and a
pair of spears,

257 the man he was the first time I set eyes on
him

258 in our own house, drinking and glad at heart,

259 up from Ephyra, from Ilus son of Mermerus —

260 for Odysseus went there too, in his fast ship,
261 in search of a man-killing poison, so he might
have it
262 to smear on his bronze-shod arrows. Ilus
would not²⁴
263 give it, for he feared the undying gods'
displeasure;
264 but my father gave it him, for he loved him
terribly —
265 the man he was then! Let that Odysseus close
with the suitors:
266 quick would their fates be then, and bitter
their weddings.
267 But surely these things lie on the knees of the
gods:²⁵
268 whether he comes home and takes
repayment, or does not,
269 here in his own halls. As for you, I charge you:
consider
270 how you will thrust the suitors from the hall.
271 Come then, mark me now, and take my words
to heart.

272 Tomorrow call the Achaean heroes into
assembly
273 and speak your word to all, and let the gods
stand witness.
274 Command the suitors to scatter, each to his
own,
275 and your mother — if her heart is stirred
toward marriage,
276 let her go back to the hall of her father, that
powerful man:
277 there they will make the marriage and set out
the bride-gifts,
278 very many, all that should follow a beloved
child.
279 To you yourself my advice is close and
shrewd, if you will hear it.
280 Man a ship with twenty oars, the best there
is,
281 and go out asking after your long-gone father.
282 Some mortal man may tell you — or you may
hear the Rumor
283 that comes from Zeus, which most of all

carries word among men.**26**

284 Go first to Pylos, and question noble Nestor;
285 from there to Sparta, to fair-haired Menelaus,
286 for of the bronze-shirted Achaeans he came
home last.

287 If you hear your father is alive and homeward
bound,

288 then, ground down as you are, hold out one
more year.

289 But if you hear that he is dead, that he is no
more,

290 then come back to your own dear fatherland
291 and heap his burial mound, and over it pay
the death-rites,

292 very many, as is fitting, and give your mother
to a husband.

293 Then, when you have made an end of all this
and done it,

294 take counsel in your mind and in your heart

295 how in your halls you are to kill the suitors,

296 whether by guile or in the open. It is no
longer for you**27**

297 to hold to childish things: you are past that
age.

298 Or have you not heard what fame noble
Orestes took²⁸

299 among all mankind, when he killed his
father's killer,

300 Aegisthus of the crooked counsels, who cut
down his famous father?

301 You too, my friend — and I see how tall and
fine you are —

302 be brave, so that men not yet born will speak
well of you.

303 But now I will go down to my fast ship

304 and my companions, who I think grow
restless with waiting.

305 Let this be your own care. Take my words to
heart.”

306 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:

307 “Stranger, you say these things out of a kind
heart,

308 as a father to his son, and I will never forget
them.

309 But come now, stay a while, though you are
eager for the road,
310 so that bathed first, your own heart
gladdened,
311 you may go to your ship with a gift, rejoicing
in spirit —
312 a costly thing, and beautiful, to be your
treasure
313 from me: such things as dear guest-friends
give their guests.”
314 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed
Athena:
315 “Hold me back no longer; I long for the road.
316 The gift — whatever your own heart bids you
give me —
317 give it when I come again, for carrying home,
318 and choose one truly beautiful. It will bring
you its match in return.”
319 So gray-eyed Athena spoke, and she was gone,
320 flown up and away like a bird. And in his
heart²⁹
321 she had set strength and courage, and

brought his father to his mind

322 more even than before. And when he sensed
it in his mind,

323 he was awed at heart, for he guessed she was
a god.

324 And at once he went back among the suitors,
a man like a god himself.

325 For them the famous singer was singing, and
they in silence

326 sat and listened. He sang the Achaeans'
homecoming,

327 the bitter one, that Pallas Athena laid on them
out of Troy.

328 From her upper room she took into her heart
the god-filled song:

329 Icarius' daughter, watchful-minded
Penelope.30

330 She came down the steep stairway of her
house,

331 not alone: two handmaids came attending her.

332 And when she reached the suitors, shining
among women,

333 she stood beside the pillar of the close-built
roof,
334 holding her glistening veil before her cheeks,
335 a trusted handmaid standing on either side,
336 and in tears she spoke to the godlike singer:
337 “Phemius, you know many other spells for
mortal ears,³¹
338 deeds of men and gods, that singers make
renowned.
339 Sit and sing them one of those, and let them
drink
340 their wine in silence. But break off this song,
341 this bitter song that forever wears away the
heart
342 in my breast — for on me above all has fallen
grief past forgetting.
343 So dear a face I long for, remembering always,
344 the man whose fame goes wide through
Hellas and the heart of Argos.”
345 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:
346 “Mother, why grudge the trusted singer his
right

347 to please us however his mind is moved?
Singers are not
348 to blame: Zeus, surely, is to blame, who gives
349 to men who eat bread whatever he wills, to
each man singly.
350 There is no fault in him for singing the
Danaans' hard doom:
351 men will always give their louder praise to the
song32
352 that comes to its hearers newest on the air.
353 Let your heart and spirit steel themselves to
hear it.
354 Odysseus was not the only one to lose his day
of homecoming
355 at Troy: many other men were lost as well.
356 Go into the house and see to your own work,
357 the loom and the distaff, and command your
handmaids
358 to go about their work. The word belongs to
men —33
359 to all men, and to me above all: mine is the
power in this house.”

360 In wonder, she went back into the house,
361 for she laid her son's clear-headed word to
heart.
362 Climbing to her upper room with her serving-
women,
363 she wept there for Odysseus, her dear
husband, until
364 gray-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her
eyelids.
365 But the suitors broke into uproar through the
shadowy halls,
366 and every man of them prayed to lie beside
her in bed.
367 And clear-headed Telemachus began to speak
among them:
368 "Suitors of my mother, insolent past all
bearing,
369 for now let us feast and take our pleasure —
but with no more
370 shouting, since it is a fine thing to listen to a
singer
371 such as this man is, with a voice like the gods'.

372 But at dawn let us go and take our seats in
assembly,
373 all of us, so I may declare my word to you
outright:
374 get out of my halls. Go busy yourselves with
other feasts,
375 eating your own goods, moving from house to
house.
376 But if this seems to you the better thing, the
more profitable,
377 that one man's living be destroyed and
nothing paid,
378 then carve away. And I will cry to the gods
who live forever,
379 in hope that Zeus may grant deeds of requital
come to pass:
380 then you would die inside this house, and
nothing paid for you."
381 So he spoke, and all of them bit hard into
their lips,
382 marveling at Telemachus, that he spoke so
boldly.

383 Then Antinous spoke to him, Eupeithes'
son:34

384 "Telemachus, surely the gods themselves are
teaching you

385 to talk so high and speak with so much
daring.

386 May the son of Cronos never make you king in
sea-circled

387 Ithaca — though by blood it is your
inheritance."35

388 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:

389 "Antinous, will you take offense at what I say?

390 Even that I would be willing to take, if Zeus
should give it.

391 Do you say kingship is the worst thing that
can befall a man?

392 It is no bad thing to be king: at once a man's
house

393 grows rich, and the man himself more
honored.

394 But there are other kings enough among the

Achaeans

395 in sea-circled Ithaca, young men and old:

396 let one of them have it, since noble Odysseus
is dead.

397 But I will be lord of our own house

398 and of the slaves that noble Odysseus won for
me.”

399 Then Eurymachus, Polybus’ son, answered
him:

400 “Telemachus, truly these things lie on the
knees of the gods:

401 which of the Achaeans will be king in sea-
circled Ithaca.

402 Your goods you may keep, and be lord in your
own house;

403 may the man never come who would strip
your goods from you

404 by force, against your will, while Ithaca is yet
lived in.

405 But I would ask you, best of men, about the
stranger:

406 where does that man come from? What

country does he claim

407 for his own? Where are his kin, the plowlands
of his fathers?

408 Does he bring some message of your father's
coming,

409 or did he arrive here pressing a need of his
own?

410 How he leapt up and vanished in a moment!
He did not wait

411 to be known — and yet his face was in no way
base.”

412 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

413 “Eurymachus, my father's homecoming is
lost.

414 I put no more trust in messages, wherever
they come from,

415 nor give heed to any prophecy my mother

416 may seek, calling some diviner into the hall.

417 As for the stranger — a guest-friend of my
father's house, from Taphos;

418 he declares himself Mentès, son of wise
Anchialus,

419 and he is lord of the oar-loving Taphians.”
420 So spoke Telemachus. But in his heart he
knew the deathless goddess.
421 And they turned to dancing and the loveliness
of song
422 and took their pleasure, and waited for
evening to come on;
423 and while they took their pleasure the black
evening came.
424 Then they went home to bed, each man to his
own house.
425 But Telemachus — where his bedroom was
built high
426 off the beautiful courtyard, in a place with a
clear view all around —
427 went up to bed, turning many things over in
his mind.
428 Beside him, bearing blazing torches, walked
one whose thoughts were loyal:
429 Eurycleia, daughter of Ops, Peisenor’s son.
430 Laertes had bought her long ago with his own
goods,

431 when she was still in her first youth, at the
price of twenty oxen,³⁶
432 and honored her in his halls as he honored his
faithful wife —
433 but never took her to his bed: he shunned his
wife's anger.
434 She it was who carried the blazing torches
beside him, and of all
435 the house-slaves she loved him most: she had
nursed him when he was small.
436 He opened the doors of the close-built room,
437 sat down on the bed, and pulled his soft tunic
off,
438 and dropped it into the shrewd old woman's
hands.
439 She folded the tunic and smoothed it out,
440 hung it on a peg beside the corded bedstead,
441 and went out of the room, drawing the door
shut
442 by its silver handle, and slid the bolt home
with its strap.
443 There all night long, wrapped in the choice

fleece of the sheep,

444 he pondered in his heart the road Athena had shown him.

Notes

NOTES

1. πολύτροπον (*polytropon*), the poem's first epithet for its still-unnamed hero, means both "of many turnings" — much-traveled, much-buffed — and "of many turns" — wily, shifty, hard to pin. Translators usually must pick one; "the man of many turnings" is an attempt to keep the road and the mind inside a single word, as the Greek does. The man himself is not named until line 21. ↩
2. ἀμόθεν, "from somewhere in these things": the poet asks the Muse to choose the entry point, and she chooses the end — the story opens in the tenth year of wandering, with everything prior delivered later in flashback. This line is the poem's license for its in-medias-res structure. ↩
3. Calypso's name is transparent in Greek: καλύπτειν means "to cover, to conceal." The Concealer holds Odysseus in a hidden place off every map — which is why the gods' plan must begin with simply locating him. ↩
4. "Blameless Aegisthus" is a famous scandal: Aegisthus is an adulterer and a murderer, yet he receives the honorific epithet

ἀμύμων. In oral verse, epithets belong to names and meter, not to moral bookkeeping. I keep the collision rather than smooth it away. ↩

5. “By their own recklessness” (σφῆσιν ἀτασθαλίῃσιν) repeats exactly the phrase used of Odysseus’ crew in line 7. The first speech of the poem is a theodicy — Zeus insists mortals earn ruin “beyond their portion” — and the proem has already offered the crew as Exhibit A. The poem states its moral frame twice in its first forty lines. ↩
6. ἀργεῖφόντης, traditionally “slayer of Argus” (the hundred-eyed watchman set over Io), though the word was already opaque in antiquity; “shining one” has also been proposed. I keep the traditional story. ↩
7. γλαυκῶπις, rendered “gray-eyed” throughout: the word hovers between “gleaming-eyed” and “owl-eyed” (γλαύξ is the little owl, Athena’s bird). It is her fixed formula, and I keep it fixed — in this translation the recurring formulas recur verbatim, because the repetitions are the poem’s architecture, not padding to be varied away. ↩
8. The Greek plays sound against sense: δαΐφρονι δαίεται — “for battle-wise (*daiphron*) Odysseus my heart is kindled (*daietai*).” “My heart is on fire for battle-wise Odysseus” keeps at least the heat and the pairing. ↩
9. An untranslatable pun, and a load-bearing one: ὠδύσσο (“you are filled with wrath against”) echoes Ὀδυσσεύς. His grandfather Autolycus names him from this verb at 19.407–409 — the man of wrath, given and received. “At odds with Odysseus” is my shadow of it. ↩

10. “The fence of your teeth” (ἔρκος ὀδόντων) is formulaic: words are imagined as living things that escape past a barrier and cannot be called back. ↩
11. Both epithets of the cattle — εἰλίποδας (“rolling-footed”? “shambling”?) and ἔλικας (“crumple-horned”? “black”?) — were already disputed in antiquity. “Shambling crook-horned” follows the traditional guesses. ↩
12. Mentes of Taphos is Athena’s first disguise; in Book 2 she takes the near-twin name Mentor. The Taphians were known as seafarers and slave-raiders — a plausibly worldly guest for her purposes. ↩
13. πεσσοί: a board game played with stones, “counters.” The suitors’ idleness is staged before any of them says a word. ↩
14. ἔπεα πτερόεντα, “winged words,” kept in its traditional form: the formula marks direct speech launched at a hearer, and it will recur throughout the poem. ↩
15. Lines 136–143 are a hospitality *type-scene* — pitcher, silver basin, bread, carved meat, circulating wine — recurring nearly verbatim across the poem. Guest-friendship (*xenia*) is the Odyssey’s central social institution and its central test; the scene’s formality is the point, so I translate it formally each time it returns. ↩
16. δμῳαί I render “slave-women,” and δμῶες “slaves,” here and throughout: the Homeric great house runs on chattel slavery, and softer conventions (“maids,” “servants”) hide it. ἀμφίπολος, an attendant of vaguer status, I render “handmaid.” Eurycleia’s purchase price is given at 430–431. ↩

17. ἀνάγκη, “under compulsion”: Phemius sings for the suitors because he must. The poem remembers this detail — in Book 22 he pleads for his life on exactly this ground, and is spared. ↩
18. “What man are you, and from where?” — the formal interrogation owed to a stranger *after* he has been fed, never before. Telemachus performs *xenia* in the correct order; the suitors, by contrast, never earn a single meal they eat. ↩
19. Temese, a copper port, was placed by ancient readers variously in Cyprus or southern Italy; nobody knows. The trade run — iron out, copper in — is a rare glimpse of the poet’s own Iron Age poking through the poem’s Bronze Age setting. ↩
20. πεπνυμένος, “clear-headed” — Telemachus’ fixed epithet, recurring in the same answering formula seven times in this book alone. The word suggests sense, discretion, breath under control: the quality the Telemachy will test. ↩
21. Telemachus’ first characteristic utterance — wry, guarded, a little bitter. The coming books are the story of this speaker growing into his father’s plainer confidence. ↩
22. Athena runs through the recognized categories of feast: εἰλαπίνη (a great banquet), γάμος (a wedding feast), ἔρανος (a meal to which every guest contributes a share). The barb hides in the third: whatever this is, no one here is paying his share. ↩
23. ἄρπυιαι, “whirlwinds” — snatching storm-spirits, the later Harpies. To vanish at sea is to die without tomb and therefore

without κλέος, fame: this is why Telemachus says outright that a battlefield death would have been a comfort. ↩

24. A startling detail, unique in Homer: Odysseus once traveled abroad seeking poison for his arrowheads, and the pious Ilus refused him. The story arrives casually, in a stranger's reminiscence — and quietly foreshadows the bow, and the arrows, of Book 22. ↩
25. “On the knees of the gods”: a formula for what is undecided. Eurymachus will hand the same phrase back at line 400 — an irony, since a god is standing in the room deciding it. ↩
26. ὄσσα is Rumor personified: news that travels with no visible carrier and is therefore assumed to come from Zeus. ↩
27. The plot of the poem's second half — killing the suitors “by guile or in the open” — is stated here for the first time, and by Athena. The revenge is a divine assignment before it is ever a human decision. ↩
28. Orestes, avenger of Agamemnon, is held up as Telemachus' model throughout the early books. Zeus' Aegisthus speech (32–43) thus frames the whole poem: Telemachus is being invited to step into the exemplary story the gods have just finished telling each other. ↩
29. ἀνόπαια, describing Athena's exit, is one of the book's genuinely unknown words: “up through the smoke-vent,” “unseen,” and a species of bird have all been proposed since antiquity. “Up and away like a bird” commits only to the visible minimum. ↩
30. περίφρων, “watchful-minded” — Penelope's fixed epithet, as constant as Athena's “gray-eyed.” The word means thinking-

all-around: circumspect, unsurprisable. Her first act in the poem is to try to change what song is sung in her house; her son's first act of authority is to overrule her. ↩

31. θελκτήρια, “spells”: song in this poem is literal enchantment — the same root describes Calypso charming Odysseus at line 57, and later the Sirens. Penelope does not ask the singer to stop; she asks him to cast a different spell. ↩
32. The audience's taste for “the newest song” is the poem winking at itself: in the fictional world the bitter homecomings from Troy are the newest repertoire — and the Odyssey is, in ours, the newest song about them. ↩
33. μῦθος here is not “myth” but authoritative public speech — “the word.” Telemachus' claim to it, and to κράτος (“power”) in the house, adapts Hector's farewell to Andromache (*Iliad* 6.490–493: “war shall be men's concern”) with speech standing where war stood. The moment is harsh to modern ears and is meant to be a threshold: it is the first thing Telemachus does with the courage Athena has just put in him, and Penelope's silent wonder (360) registers that her son has, abruptly, come of age. ↩
34. Antinous and Eurymachus (399) are the suitors' two leaders, introduced here in the pairing they keep to the end: Antinous openly hostile, Eurymachus smooth. They will die in that order in Book 22. ↩
35. Kingship in Ithaca is evidently not automatic inheritance: Antinous can pray Telemachus never be king without absurdity, and Telemachus himself concedes (394–396) that others might take it. The Homeric βασιλεύς is nearer a

paramount chief whose standing must be held than a crowned successor. ↩

36. Twenty oxen is an enormous price — standard slaves in Homer are valued at four. Eurycleia also receives a two-generation genealogy (father and grandfather, line 429), an honor the poem otherwise reserves for heroes. It dignifies her exactly while stating plainly that she was bought. ↩

Odyssey — Book 2

The assembly at Ithaca; Penelope's web; Telemachus sails by night.

- 1 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,¹
- 2 the dear son of Odysseus rose up from his bed,
- 3 put on his clothes, slung his sharp sword about
his shoulder,
- 4 bound the beautiful sandals beneath his shining
feet,
- 5 and came out of his bedroom looking like a god.
- 6 At once he ordered the clear-voiced heralds
- 7 to cry the long-haired Achaeans into assembly.
- 8 The heralds cried the summons, and the men
gathered quickly.
- 9 And when they were assembled, all in one
gathering,
- 10 he went to the assembly, the bronze spear in
his palm,

11 not alone: two swift dogs followed with him,
12 and Athena poured a wondrous grace upon
him.

13 All the people gazed at him in wonder as he
came;

14 he sat in his father's seat, and the elders gave
way.²

15 Then the hero Aegyptius was first to speak
among them,³

16 a man bent with age, who knew things past
numbering.

17 His own dear son had gone with godlike
Odysseus

18 in the hollow ships to Ilium of the fine horses
—

19 Antiphus the spearman; the savage Cyclops
killed him

20 in his hollow cave, and made of him his last
supper.

21 Three other sons he had: one kept company
with the suitors —

22 Eurynomus — and two worked their father's

lands always.

23 Even so, he could not forget the one: grieving,
mourning him.

24 In tears for him, he now addressed the
assembly:

25 “Hear me now, men of Ithaca, hear what I say.4

26 Never once has our assembly met, has our
council sat,

27 since noble Odysseus went away in the hollow
ships.

28 Who has gathered us now? On whom has need
come down so hard,

29 whether among the young men or the elder-
born?

30 Has he heard some news of the army coming
home

31 which he might tell us plainly, having learned
of it first?

32 Or is there some other public matter he would
open and argue?

33 A good man he seems to me, a blessed one.
May Zeus

34 accomplish for him some good — whatever his heart desires.”

35 So he spoke, and the dear son of Odysseus rejoiced at the omen of the word,⁵

36 and sat no longer: desire took him to speak.

37 He stood in the middle of the assembly, and the scepter was put in his hand⁶

38 by the herald Peisenor, a man of clear-headed counsel.

39 Then he spoke, turning first to the old man:

40 “Old sir, that man is not far off — you shall see for yourself —

41 who called the people: it is I; grief comes down hardest on me.

42 I have heard no news of the army coming home

43 which I might tell you plainly, having learned of it first,

44 nor is there other public matter I would open and argue:

45 it is my own need, the evils fallen on my house

—

46 twofold. I have lost my noble father, who once
was king
47 among you here, and he was gentle as a father;
48 and now something far greater, which will
soon tear apart
49 my whole house utterly and destroy my living
altogether.
50 Suitors have set upon my mother — against
her will —
51 the own dear sons of the men who here are
noblest,
52 and they shrink from going to the house of her
father
53 Icarius, so that he might set his daughter's
bride-terms himself⁷
54 and give her to whom he will, whoever comes
and pleases her.
55 Instead they haunt our house day after day,
56 slaughtering our oxen and our sheep and our
fat goats,
57 feasting and drinking the fire-bright wine
58 with no reckoning. And the most of it is

wasted. For there is no man here

59 such as Odysseus was, to beat ruin away from
the house.

60 We are not the men to beat it back — believe
me, ever after

61 we would be pitiable men, and unschooled in
fighting.

62 Beat it back I would, if only the strength were
in me!

63 For what is done here is past all bearing; past
all decency

64 my house is ruined. Feel the outrage
yourselves;

65 feel shame before the peoples who are our
neighbors,

66 those who dwell around us; and dread the
wrath of the gods,

67 lest in fury at evil deeds they turn them back
on your heads.

68 I beg you — by Olympian Zeus, and by
Themis,⁸

69 who dissolves the assemblies of men and seats

them —

70 hold off, friends! Leave me alone to waste away

71 in my bitter grief. Unless perhaps my father,
good Odysseus,

72 in malice did the strong-greaved Achaeans
harm,

73 and in requital you do me harm in malice,

74 egging these men on. Better for me by far

75 if it were you yourselves devouring my
treasures and my herds:

76 were you the ones eating, there might one day
be repayment,

77 for then we would go up and down the town
pressing our claim,

78 demanding our goods back, until all was given
over.

79 Instead you heap on my heart pains past any
remedy.”

80 So he spoke in anger, and dashed the scepter
to the ground,⁹

81 bursting into tears. And pity took hold of all
the people.

82 Then all the rest stayed silent, and no one
dared
83 to answer Telemachus with hard words;
84 Antinous alone made him this answer:
85 “Telemachus, high talker, temper past
restraining — what a thing you have said,**10**
86 smearing us with shame! You would love to
hang the blame on us.
87 But it is not the Achaean suitors who are at
fault:
88 it is your own dear mother, whose cunning has
no equal.
89 For it is the third year now, and the fourth
soon coming,
90 that she has cheated the heart in the
Achaean’s breasts.
91 She gives hope to all, and makes promises to
every man,
92 sending out messages — while her mind wills
otherwise.
93 And here is another trick her heart devised:**11**
94 she set up a great loom in the halls and wove at

it,

95 fine-threaded, beyond all measure wide, and
told us straightway:

96 ‘Young men, my suitors — since noble
Odysseus is dead,

97 wait, though you burn for my wedding, till I
finish

98 this cloth — let my spinning not be wasted on
the wind —

99 a shroud for the hero Laertes, against the day

100 the ruinous doom of death that lays men low
will take him:

101 let no Achaean woman in the land hold it
against me

102 that a man who won so much should lie
without his winding-sheet.’¹²

103 So she spoke, and our proud hearts were
persuaded.

104 Then every day she wove at the great loom,

105 and every night she unwove it by torchlight.

106 Three years her trick escaped us, and she kept
the Achaeans persuaded;

107 but when the fourth year came, as the seasons
rolled on,

108 then one of her women, who knew it all, told
us,

109 and we caught her unweaving the shining
web.

110 So she finished it — against her will, under
force.

111 Now the suitors give you this answer, so that
you may know it

112 in your own heart, and all the Achaeans know
it:

113 send your mother away. Command her to
marry

114 whichever man her father bids, and who
pleases her.

115 But if she goes on tormenting the sons of the
Achaeans —

116 minding in her heart the gifts Athena gave her
beyond all women,

117 skill in beautiful work, and a noble mind,

118 and cunning past anything we hear of even in

the women of old,

119 the fair-braided Achaean women of the time
before,

120 Tyro and Alcmene and Mycene of the lovely
crown:13

121 not one of them had thoughts to match
Penelope's —

122 yet this one thought of hers was not well
thought.

123 For just so long will men devour your living
and your goods

124 as she holds to this purpose the gods are
setting

125 now in her breast. Great fame she is making

126 for herself — and for you, the ache of a
squandered living.

127 We are not going to our estates, or anywhere
else,

128 before she marries whichever Achaean she
will.”

129 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

130 “Antinous, there is no way I can thrust out of

the house, unwilling,

131 the one who bore me, who raised me — while
my father, somewhere on earth,

132 lives or is dead. And it would go hard with me
to pay back

133 Icarius so much, if of my own accord I send
my mother home.

134 From her father I would suffer evil; and
heaven would add

135 more, since my mother, leaving the house,
would call down

136 the loathed Furies; and the blame of men
would be14

137 upon me. No: I will never speak that word.

138 As for you — if your own hearts feel any
shame at it,

139 get out of my halls. Go busy yourselves with
other feasts,

140 eating your own goods, moving from house to
house.

141 But if this seems to you the better thing, the
more profitable,

142 that one man's living be destroyed and
nothing paid,
143 then carve away. And I will cry to the gods
who live forever,
144 in hope that Zeus may grant deeds of requital
come to pass:
145 then you would die inside this house, and
nothing paid for you.”**15**
146 So spoke Telemachus. And Zeus of the wide
voice sent him two eagles,**16**
147 flying from on high, from a mountain peak.
148 For a while the two flew on with the breath of
the wind,
149 close by one another, wings at full stretch;
150 but when they came dead over the many-
voiced assembly,**17**
151 they wheeled there, beating their wings thick
and fast,
152 and glared down on all their heads, and death
was in their gaze;
153 then they ripped with their talons at each
other's cheeks and throats

154 and shot away rightward, over the houses and
the town.

155 The men were astonished at the birds their
eyes had seen,

156 and turned over in their hearts what this
would bring to pass.

157 And among them spoke the old hero
Halitherses,

158 Mastor's son, who surpassed all men of his
day

159 in reading birds and speaking what fate
intends.

160 With good will toward them he spoke to the
assembly:

161 "Hear me now, men of Ithaca, hear what I say

—

162 though to the suitors above all I declare it:

163 on them a great wave of ruin is rolling. For
Odysseus

164 will not be long parted from his people;
already, somewhere

165 near, he is planting death and slaughter for

these men,

166 every one; and evil will come on many of the
rest of us

167 who live in clear-skied Ithaca. Long before
that,

168 let us think how to stop them — or let them
stop

169 themselves: the sooner the better, for their
own sake.

170 I prophesy as no novice; I know my art.

171 And for that man too I say it is all coming
home,

172 all I told him when the Argives went up into
Ilium

173 and Odysseus of the many designs went with
them.

174 I said that after long suffering, his
companions all lost,

175 unknown to everyone, in the twentieth year¹⁸

176 he would come home. And now it is all being
accomplished.”

177 Then Eurymachus, Polybus’ son, answered

him:

- 178 “Old man, off with you — go home and
prophecy to your children,
179 lest some evil overtake them in days to come.
180 In this I am a far better prophet than you.
181 Plenty of birds go back and forth beneath the
rays of the sun, 19
182 and not all of them are fate. As for Odysseus:
183 he is dead, far away — and how I wish that
you had perished with him.
184 You would not then be spouting all this
prophecy,
185 or whetting the anger of Telemachus —
186 angling for some gift for your household,
should he offer one.
187 But I will tell you this, and it will be
accomplished:
188 if you, who know so many things grown old
with you,
189 talk a younger man around with words and
stir him to fury,
190 for the man himself, first, it will go the

harder,

191 and in any case he will accomplish nothing for
all these words;

192 and on you, old man, we will lay a fine that in
the paying

193 will gall your heart: and the pain of it will be
hard.

194 And to Telemachus, before you all, my own
advice is this:

195 let him command his mother to go back to her
father's house.

196 There they will make the marriage and set out
the bride-gifts,

197 very many, all that should follow a beloved
child.

198 Not before, I think, will the sons of the
Achaeans quit

199 their courting — a grinding courtship. We fear
no one, not at all;

200 no, not Telemachus, for all his stream of
words;

201 nor do we care a whit for prophecy, old man,

that you

202 mouth to no accomplishment — it only makes
you the more hated.

203 His goods will be devoured as badly as ever,
and never made good,

204 so long as she puts the Achaeans off about

205 her marriage. And we, waiting all our days,

206 rival one another for her excellence, and do
not go after

207 other women, fit brides for any of us.”

208 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:

209 “Eurymachus, and all you other haughty
suitors:

210 I plead with you no further; I say no more of
this.

211 The gods know it now, and all the Achaeans.

212 But come, give me a fast ship and twenty
companions

213 to carry me on a journey there and back
again.

214 For I am going to Sparta and to sandy Pylos

215 to ask after the homecoming of my long-gone
father,
216 in hope some mortal man will tell me, or I
may hear the Rumor
217 that comes from Zeus, which most of all
carries word among men.20
218 If I hear my father is alive and homeward
bound,
219 then, ground down as I am, I could hold out
one more year;
220 but if I hear that he is dead, that he is no
more,
221 then I will come back to my own dear
fatherland
222 and heap his burial mound, and over it pay
the death-rites,
223 very many, as is fitting, and give my mother
to a husband.”
224 So he spoke, and sat down. And there rose
among them
225 Mentor, the companion of blameless
Odysseus,21

226 to whom, going aboard his ships, he had
entrusted his whole house —

227 that all should obey the old man, and he keep
everything safe.

228 With good will toward them he spoke to the
assembly:

229 “Hear me now, men of Ithaca, hear what I say.

230 Let no sceptered king ever again be willingly

231 kind and gentle, or know the right way in his
heart;

232 let him rather be harsh always, and act
outrage —

233 since no one remembers godlike Odysseus

234 among the people he ruled, and he was gentle
as a father.

235 It is not the lordly suitors I begrudge, not
really,

236 for their deeds of violence woven in an evil-
scheming mind:

237 they lay their own heads on the wager when
they devour²²

238 by violence the house of Odysseus, saying he

will come home no more.

239 It is the rest of the people I am angry at — the
way you all

240 sit there dumb, and never fasten on them
with words

241 and stop them: the suitors few, and you so
many.”

242 Then Leocritus, Evenor’s son, answered him:

243 “Mentor, wrecker, brain gone wandering —
what a thing you have said,

244 urging them to stop us. It is heavy work

245 to fight with men over a feast — men who
outnumber you at that.

246 Why, if Ithacan Odysseus himself came in on
us

247 and found the lordly suitors feasting in his
house

248 and set his heart on driving them out of the
hall,

249 his wife would have no joy of his coming,
however

250 she has ached for him: right there he would

meet an ugly death,²³

²⁵¹ if he fought men who outnumbered him.

What you have said misses the mark.

²⁵² Come now — people, scatter, each man to his own work.

²⁵³ As for this one, Mentor and Halitherses can speed his journey,

²⁵⁴ being companions of his father's house from the beginning.

²⁵⁵ Though I think he will sit here a long while yet, gathering his news

²⁵⁶ in Ithaca; that voyage he will never make.”

²⁵⁷ So he spoke, and dissolved the assembly on the instant.

²⁵⁸ They scattered, each man to his own house,

²⁵⁹ and the suitors went off to the house of godlike Odysseus.

²⁶⁰ But Telemachus walked apart, to the sand-beach of the sea,

²⁶¹ washed his hands in the gray salt water, and prayed to Athena:

²⁶² “Hear me, you who came yesterday, a god,

into our house,

263 and bade me go by ship over the misted sea

264 to ask after the homecoming of my long-gone
father.

265 All of it the Achaeans grind to a halt —

266 the suitors most of all, in their evil
overbearing pride.”

267 So he prayed, and Athena came to him, close
at hand,

268 in the likeness of Mentor, both his body and
his voice,

269 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words
to him:

270 “Telemachus, you will be no coward from this
day, and no fool,

271 if any of your father’s brave force is instilled
in you —

272 such a man he was for making good both deed
and word.

273 Then this journey of yours will be no idle
errand, and not unaccomplished.

274 But if you are not his son, his and Penelope’s,

275 then I have no hope you will accomplish what
you set your heart on.

276 Few sons, in truth, turn out the equals of their
fathers:24

277 the most are worse; a few are better men than
their fathers.

278 But since you will be no coward from this day,
and no fool,

279 and the cunning of Odysseus has not wholly
failed in you,

280 there is every hope you will accomplish this
work.

281 So now let the suitors' plotting and scheming
go —

282 mindless men, with neither sense nor justice
in them:

283 they know nothing of the death and the black
doom

284 that stands close by them, to destroy them all
in a day.

285 The journey you have set your heart on will
not be long delayed —

286 such a companion am I, out of your father's
house:

287 I will fit out a fast ship for you, and come
along myself.

288 You go back to the house now, and move
among the suitors;

289 make ready provisions, and stow them all in
vessels —

290 wine in two-handled jars, and barley meal,
the marrow of men, 25

291 in tight-sewn skins. And I, through the town,

292 will gather willing companions, and quickly.

There are ships

293 in plenty in sea-circled Ithaca, new ships and
old:

294 I will look them over for you and choose the
best,

295 and we will rig her fast and launch her on the
wide sea.”

296 So spoke Athena, daughter of Zeus. And no
longer then

297 did Telemachus linger, once he had heard the

voice of the god.

298 He went on his way to the house, his heart
heavy within him,

299 and found the lordly suitors there in the halls,

300 skinning goats and singeing fat hogs in the
courtyard.

301 Antinous came laughing straight at
Telemachus,

302 clamped a hand on his, and spoke a word, and
named him:

303 “Telemachus, high talker, temper past
restraining — let no other

304 evil trouble your breast, no other deed or
word.

305 Just eat with me, and drink, the way it used to
be.

306 The Achaeans will see to all those things of
yours —

307 a ship and picked oarsmen — so you may
come the sooner

308 to holy Pylos, after news of your proud
father.”

309 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:

310 “Antinous, there is no way, among you in your
insolence,

311 to eat my supper quietly and take my ease in
peace.

312 Is it not enough that all this while, suitors,
you carved up

313 my goods, so many and so fine, while I was
still a child?

314 Now — when I am grown, and hear the talk of
other men

315 and understand it, and the spirit swells inside
me —

316 I will try to hurl an evil doom upon you,

317 whether I go to Pylos or stay here in this land.

318 But go I will, and the journey I speak of will be
no idle errand —

319 a passenger on another’s ship, since master of
ship or oarsmen²⁶

320 I am not to be. That, no doubt, seemed the
more profitable to you.”

321 He spoke, and wrenched his hand from
Antinous' hand,

322 easily. And through the house the suitors
busied themselves with the feast,

323 and they mocked him and needled him with
words.

324 And thus would one of the arrogant young
men say:

325 “No question — Telemachus is planning our
murder!

326 He will bring back avengers from sandy Pylos,
327 or else from Sparta, since he is so terribly set
on it.

328 Or maybe he means to go to Ephyra, that rich
plowland,27

329 to fetch home poisons that eat the life away,

330 and drop them in the wine-bowl, and destroy
us all.”

331 And thus would another of the arrogant
young men say:

332 “Who knows? Maybe he too, once aboard the
hollow ship,

333 will wander far from his people and be lost —
just like Odysseus.

334 And that would double our work, wouldn't it:

335 we would have to divide all his goods among
us, and the house itself

336 hand over to his mother — hers, and the man
who marries her.”28

337 So they talked. But he went down to his
father's storeroom,

338 high-ceilinged and broad, where gold and
bronze lay piled,

339 and clothing in chests, and fragrant oil in
plenty;

340 and there stood great jars of old wine, sweet
to drink,

341 holding the unmixed divine drink within
them,

342 ranged in order along the wall — against the
day Odysseus

343 might come home even after all his pains.29

344 Doors were on it, close-fitted, bolted fast,

345 double doors; and a woman-steward was

there night and day

346 who guarded it all with her mind's deep
knowledge:

347 Eurycleia, daughter of Ops, Peisenor's son.

348 Telemachus called her into the storeroom and
spoke to her:

349 "Nurse, come — draw me off wine in two-
handled jars,30

350 the sweet wine, the finest-tasting after that

351 which you keep, thinking of him — the
luckless one — if from somewhere he should come:

352 Zeus-born Odysseus, having slipped past
death and the dooms.

353 Fill twelve, and fit them all with lids.

354 And pour me barley meal into well-sewn
skins:

355 twenty measures of mill-crushed barley grain.

356 Keep this to yourself. And let it all stand
gathered:

357 in the evening I will fetch it, when at last

358 my mother climbs to her upper room and
thinks of sleep.

359 For I am going to Sparta and to sandy Pylos
360 to ask after my dear father's homecoming, if I
may hear of it."

361 So he spoke, and his dear nurse Eurycleia
wailed aloud,

362 and grieving she spoke winged words to him:

363 "Why, dear child, why has this thought come
into

364 your mind? Where would you go across the
wide earth,

365 an only son, and beloved? He is dead far from
home —

366 Zeus-born Odysseus, in some strangers'
country.

367 And these men, the moment you are gone,
will plot evils behind you,

368 to kill you by treachery and divide all this
among themselves.

369 Stay here instead, sitting on what is yours.
There is no need

370 to suffer evils on the barren sea, and go
wandering."

371 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:

372 “Take heart, nurse. This plan is not without a
god.³¹

373 But swear you will not breathe a word to my
dear mother

374 before the eleventh day has come, or the
twelfth,

375 or she misses me herself and hears that I am
gone —

376 so she will not mar her lovely skin with
weeping.”

377 So he spoke, and the old woman swore the
great oath of the gods.

378 And when she had sworn and made an end of
the oath,

379 straightway she drew off wine for him in two-
handled jars

380 and poured him barley meal into well-sewn
skins;

381 and Telemachus went back to the hall to move
among the suitors.

382 Then the goddess thought of one thing more,

gray-eyed Athena.

383 In the likeness of Telemachus she went
everywhere through the town,32

384 and standing beside each man she spoke her
word,

385 bidding them gather at evening by the fast
ship.

386 Then she asked Noemon, the shining son of
Phronius,

387 for a fast ship; and he promised it gladly.

388 The sun went down, and all the ways grew
dark.33

389 Then she hauled the fast ship down to the
sea, and stowed in her

390 all the gear that well-benched ships carry,

391 and moored her at the harbor's edge. Around
her the brave companions

392 gathered in a body, and the goddess set each
man's heart on fire.

393 Then the goddess thought of one thing more,
gray-eyed Athena.

394 She went on her way to the house of godlike

Odysseus,

395 and there she poured sweet sleep over the
suitors,

396 addled them as they drank, and knocked the
cups from their hands.

397 They stumbled off to sleep through the town,
and sat no longer,

398 for sleep was falling on their eyelids.

399 But to Telemachus gray-eyed Athena spoke,

400 calling him out in front of the well-settled
halls,

401 in the likeness of Mentor, both his body and
his voice:

402 “Telemachus, your strong-greaved
companions are already

403 sitting at the oars, waiting on your word to
start.

404 Come, let us go; let us not hold the journey
long.”

405 So speaking, Pallas Athena led the way

406 swiftly, and he followed in the footsteps of the
god.

407 And when they had come down to the ship
and the sea,
408 they found the long-haired companions on
the beach,
409 and the sacred strength of Telemachus spoke
among them:34
410 “Come, friends, let us fetch the provisions:
everything now
411 stands gathered in the hall. My mother has
heard nothing,
412 nor the slave-women either; one alone was
told.”
413 So speaking he led the way, and they went
with him.
414 They carried everything down and stowed it
in the well-benched ship
415 as the dear son of Odysseus commanded.
416 Then Telemachus went aboard, Athena going
before him;
417 she sat down in the stern of the ship, and
close beside her
418 sat Telemachus. And the men cast off the

stern-lines

419 and came aboard themselves and took their
places at the oarlocks.

420 And gray-eyed Athena sent them a following
wind,

421 a fresh West Wind, singing over the wine-dark
sea.

422 Telemachus shouted to his companions,
commanding them

423 to lay hands on the rigging, and they heard
his urging:

424 they raised the pine mast and stepped it
inside the hollow mast-box,

425 set it up and made it fast with the forestays,

426 and hauled up the white sails by the well-
twisted ox-hide ropes.

427 The wind bellied out the middle of the sail,
and the wave

428 hissed dark and loud around the keel as the
ship went on,

429 and she ran down the waves, making her way.

430 Then, when they had lashed the tackle down

the fast black ship,

431 they set up mixing-bowls crowned brim-full
with wine

432 and poured to the deathless gods who are
forever,

433 and beyond all others to the gray-eyed
daughter of Zeus.

434 All night long, and into the dawn, the ship cut
her way.35

Notes

NOTES

1. ἤμος δ' ἠριγένεια φάνη ροδοδάκτυλος Ἥως — the most famous recurring line in Homer, appearing over twenty times in the *Odyssey*. My fixed rendering, “When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,” will return verbatim at every occurrence: the line is the poem’s clock, and it should chime the same way each time it strikes. ↩
2. A quiet coronation image: Telemachus takes his father’s seat, and the old men yield it. No one has sat there in twenty years. The book’s whole arc — the boy claiming public, adult space — is compressed into this one gesture before a word is spoken. ↩

3. Aegyptius (“the Egyptian” — the name is odd and unexplained) opens the assembly not knowing his son Antiphus is already dead, eaten last in the Cyclops’ cave. The audience knows the Cyclops story; the poet knows it; nobody in Ithaca does. This is the poem’s first taste of the dramatic irony that will saturate its second half. ↩
4. “Hear me now, men of Ithaca, hear what I say” — the assembly-speech formula, recurring three times in this book (25, 161, 229) from three speakers. As with the epithets, I keep it verbatim: the sameness of the opening throws the difference of the speakers into relief. ↩
5. φήμη: a chance word taken as an omen (a *kledon*). Aegyptius meant only a courteous blessing; Telemachus receives it as a sign, which is itself a Homeric habit of mind — the world is always possibly speaking. ↩
6. The scepter is the speaking-staff, passed to whoever holds the floor. When Telemachus dashes it to the ground in tears (80), he is breaking assembly decorum with grief — the same gesture as Achilles at *Iliad* 1.245. The allusion measures him: Achilles’ scepter-throw launched the *Iliad*’s wrath; the boy’s launches only pity. ↩
7. The marriage economics are contested even within the poem: here the suitors ought to approach Icarius, who would set the bride-terms (ἔεδνα can be gifts *from* the suitor’s side); at 196–197 the family “sets out the bride-gifts” with the daughter. The poem’s practices are a palimpsest of different customs, and I translate each passage as it stands rather than harmonize them. ↩

8. Themis is invoked in her precise capacity — the goddess of assemblies as institutions, who “seats and dissolves” them. Telemachus swears by due process itself. ↩
9. See note on 37. The detail that pity took “all the people” — and yet none of them acts, as Mentor will bitterly observe at 239–241 — is the book’s political diagnosis: sympathy without civic courage. ↩
10. ὑψαγόρη, “high talker”: Antinous throws Book 1’s taunt (1.385) into a fixed insult-formula, repeated when he accosts Telemachus again at 303. The suitors’ mockery has its own formulas, as the gods and heroes have theirs. ↩
11. The web. The poem’s most famous trick is told first here — by an enemy, as an accusation. It will be retold by Penelope herself at 19.137ff. and by a suitor’s ghost at 24.128ff., each telling angled differently. Note what Antinous concedes while complaining: her weaving-and-unweaving wins her “great fame” (κλέος, 125) — the currency of heroes — and that her intelligence outdoes the legendary women of old. The enemy’s indictment is the poem’s first full portrait of Penelope, and it is a portrait of a match for Odysseus. ↩
12. The clinching argument of Penelope’s ruse is shame-culture logic: a great lord lying without a winding-sheet would disgrace *her* before the women of the land. She weaponizes the very propriety the suitors cannot publicly deny. ↩
13. Tyro (loved by Poseidon), Alcmene (mother of Heracles), Mycene (eponym of the city): a miniature catalogue of legendary heroines, of the kind Odysseus will see at length in

the underworld in Book 11 — where Tyro and Alcmene duly appear. ↩

14. The Erinyes (Furies) enforce curses within the family, above all a parent's curse. Telemachus' refusal is not only sentiment: expelling his mother would expose him to her father's vengeance, her Furies, and public blame — a triple bind he lays out like a lawyer. ↩

15. Lines 139–145 repeat 1.374–380 verbatim in the Greek, and verbatim in this translation: the private ultimatum of last night is now sworn in public with the gods as witnesses. The repetition is escalation. ↩

16. The first omen of the poem: two eagles that fly *as a pair*, tear at each other's cheeks and throats, and veer off to the right (the lucky side) — over the town, implicating everyone. Interpreters ancient and modern have worried over the pair (Odysseus and Telemachus? the two facing parties?) and the self-tearing; Halitherses reads only the essential: destruction is near. ↩

17. πολύφημον, “many-voiced” assembly — the same adjective that is elsewhere the name Polyphemus. With the Cyclops invoked twenty lines earlier (19–20), the echo is hard to call an accident: the man-devourer's name hovers over a town full of devourers. ↩

18. “In the twentieth year”: Halitherses' old prophecy matches the poem's actual chronology exactly — ten years of war, ten of wandering. The seer's numbers are the narrator's numbers; prophecy in the Odyssey is never wrong, only disbelieved. ↩

19. “Plenty of birds go back and forth beneath the rays of the sun, / and not all of them are fate”: the most quotable statement of omen-skepticism in Homer — placed in the mouth of a man the birds have just marked for death. The poem lets rationalism speak beautifully, and be wrong. ↩
20. Lines 214–223 rerun Athena’s instructions from 1.281–292 nearly word for word, shifted to the first person; my translation repeats itself accordingly. Telemachus has learned the speech by heart — literally. A young man’s first plan is always someone else’s words, and the poem knows it. ↩
21. The real Mentor, at last: Odysseus’ steward-companion, whose likeness Athena borrows at 268 and 401 and through much of the poem. Every later use of English “mentor” descends from this disguise — the teacher who is really a goddess wearing a friend. ↩
22. “They lay their own heads on the wager”: Mentor’s gambling image concedes the suitors’ logic — they eat the house *because* they judge Odysseus dead, and their lives are the stake if they are wrong. The poem keeps insisting the suitors chose their risk; it is Zeus’ doctrine from 1.32–43 working itself out. ↩
23. Leocritus’ taunt — Odysseus himself would die if he tried to clear his own hall against superior numbers — is a precise, unwitting prophecy of Book 22, down to the detail that his wife’s longing would not save him. Every clause will be refuted in blood; Leocritus himself falls to Telemachus’ spear (22.294).
↩
24. “Few sons are the equals of their fathers”: Athena states the Telemachy’s central anxiety as a general law — then exempts

Telemachus from it conditionally. The whole journey to Pylos and Sparta is engineered to let him test the exemption. ↩

25. ἄλφιτα, μυελὸν ἀνδρῶν — “barley meal, the marrow of men.”
The startling kenning is Homer’s, not mine: staple food as the inside of the human frame. ↩

26. ἔμπορος; in later Greek “merchant,” but here still “one who travels on another’s ship” — a passenger. The sting is in the word: the heir of Odysseus must beg passage like a man with no ship of his own, and he says so to the men who arranged it. ↩

27. The suitors’ sneer unknowingly repeats a true story: Odysseus really did sail to Ephyra for arrow-poison (1.259–262, from Athena-as-Mentes). What they toss off as slander — poison in the wine-bowl, all of us destroyed — is nearly the shape of their actual deaths. The poem lets its victims write their own epitaphs as jokes. ↩

28. The second mocker’s fantasy — Telemachus lost at sea, the goods divided, the house handed to whoever marries the widow — is the suitors’ real program spoken aloud, and it hardens into the ambush plotted at the end of Book 4. Idle talk in this poem has a way of becoming policy. ↩

29. The storeroom is a shrine of deferred hope: the best wine stands “ranged in order along the wall” for a return nobody will name except conditionally. The economy of the house has been holding its breath for twenty years. ↩

30. μαῖα, “Nurse” — the affectionate address for an old family slave-woman. This scene quietly answers Book 1’s: the same

Eurycleia who carried the torches now becomes the sole human keeper of the plan; the boy's first conspiracy is with the woman who nursed him. ↩

31. "This plan is not without a god" — a litotes that is also simply accurate: Telemachus knows his visitor was divine (1.420). His confidence is not bravado but inference. ↩
32. Athena spends the evening in two shapes: as Telemachus she recruits his crew and borrows the ship from Noemon, and as Mentor she collects the boy. The recruiting-double is uncanny if you pause on it — the town sees Telemachus everywhere that night, asking for help and even for a ship; in a sense the goddess is teaching Ithaca to see him as a man who commands. ↩
33. "The sun went down, and all the ways grew dark" — another fixed formula-line, the poem's evening bell, kept identical at each return like the dawn line at 1. ↩
34. ἱερὴ ἰς Τηλεμάχοιο, "the sacred strength of Telemachus" — an epic periphrasis (like "the strength of Heracles") that names the man by his force. The poem grants it to him for the first time on the night of his first command; the elevation is the point, and I keep the strangeness rather than flatten it to "Telemachus." ↩
35. The book ends in open water, mid-journey, the ship "cutting her way" toward dawn and Pylos — narrative enjambment: Book 3 begins with the sun rising on the same run. It is the first time in twenty years that anyone from Ithaca has gone out to meet the world instead of waiting for it. ↩

Odyssey — Book 3

*Pylos: Nestor's tales of the returns; Telemachus rides for
Sparta.*

- 1 And the sun leapt up, leaving the beautiful
water,¹
- 2 into the bronze-bright heaven, to shine for the
immortals
- 3 and for mortal men across the grain-giving
plowland;
- 4 and they came in to Pylos, the strong-built city
of Neleus.
- 5 There on the beach of the sea the people were
offering victims,
- 6 bulls all black, to the earth-shaker with the
blue-black hair.²
- 7 Nine tiers of seats there were, five hundred
sitting in each,³
- 8 and before each company nine bulls were held
ready.

9 They had just tasted the innards, and were
burning thigh-cuts for the god,
10 when the ship came straight in: they brailed
the sails of the trim vessel,
11 furled them aloft, moored her, and stepped
ashore themselves;
12 and Telemachus stepped from the ship, Athena
going before him.
13 The goddess spoke to him first, gray-eyed
Athena:
14 “Telemachus, no more need of shyness now,
not a scrap of it:⁴
15 this is why you have sailed the sea — to learn
news
16 of your father: where the earth hides him,
what doom he met.
17 Come then, go straight to Nestor, breaker of
horses:
18 let us see what counsel he keeps hidden in his
breast.
19 Beg him yourself, so that he speaks unerring
truth.

20 He will tell you no lie: he is clear-headed
beyond most men.”⁵

21 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:

22 “Mentor, how am I to go up? How greet him?

23 I have no practice yet in close-woven speech —

24 and a young man is shy of questioning his
elder.”

25 Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-
eyed Athena:

26 “Telemachus, some of it your own heart will
see,⁶

27 and some a god will prompt. For I do not think

28 you were born and raised without the gods’
good will.”

29 So speaking, Pallas Athena led the way

30 swiftly, and he followed in the footsteps of the
god.

31 They came to the gathering-place of the men
of Pylos, the rows of seats,

32 where Nestor sat with his sons, and around
them companions

33 were readying the feast, roasting meats and

skewering others.

34 But when they saw the strangers they came all
in a crowd,

35 clasped their hands in welcome, and bade
them be seated.

36 First Peisistratus, Nestor's son, coming near,
37 took the hands of both, and settled them at the
feast

38 on soft fleeces over the sand of the sea,
39 beside his brother Thrasymedes and his father;
40 and he gave them portions of the innards, and
poured wine

41 into a golden cup, and pledging her he
addressed

42 Pallas Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus:
43 "Pray now, stranger, to the lord Poseidon,
44 for his is the feast you have found in coming
here.

45 And when you have poured and prayed, as is
right and custom,

46 give this man too the cup of honey-sweet wine
47 to pour, since he also, I think, prays to the

deathless ones:

48 all men have need of the gods.

49 But he is the younger, my own age to the year,

50 and so to you first I give the golden cup.”

51 With that he set in her hand the cup of sweet
wine;

52 and Athena rejoiced in the man — clear-
headed, just —7

53 because to her first he gave the golden cup;

54 and at once she prayed at length to the lord
Poseidon:

55 “Hear me, Poseidon who hold the earth, and do
not grudge

56 us who pray the accomplishment of these
works.

57 To Nestor first of all, and to his sons, grant
glory,

58 and then to all the rest give gracious
recompense,

59 to all the Pylians, for this splendid hecatomb.

60 And grant besides that Telemachus and I sail
home with the thing accomplished

61 we came here for, in our fast black ship.”
62 So she prayed — and she herself was
accomplishing it all.⁸
63 Then she gave Telemachus the beautiful two-
handled cup,
64 and the dear son of Odysseus prayed the same.
65 And when they had roasted the outer meats
and drawn them off,
66 they divided the portions and feasted the
glorious feast.
67 But when they had put away desire for food
and drink,
68 Gerenian Nestor the horseman began to speak
among them:⁹
69 “Now is the fairer time to inquire and ask
70 our guests who they are, now they have had
their joy of food.
71 Strangers, who are you? From where do you
sail the watery ways?¹⁰
72 Is it on some business — or do you rove at
random,
73 the way sea-raiders do, who wander

74 staking their own lives, bearing evil to
strangers?”

75 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him,
76 emboldened: Athena herself had set courage in
his heart,

77 so that he might ask about his absent father
78 and so that good report among men might be
his:

79 “Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of the
Achaean,

80 you ask from where we are, and I will tell you.

81 We have come from Ithaca, under Mount
Neion;

82 and the business I speak of is private, not the
people’s.

83 I follow the wide fame of my father, in hope I
may hear of him:

84 noble, enduring-hearted Odysseus, who once,
they say,

85 fought at your side when you sacked the
Trojans’ city.

86 All the others, all who warred against the

Trojans,

87 we have had word of — where each man died
his bitter death;

88 but his death the son of Cronos has left past
finding:

89 no one can say for certain where he perished,

90 whether he went down on the mainland at
enemy hands

91 or on the deep, under the waves of Amphitrite.

92 That is why I come now to your knees: in hope
you will consent

93 to tell his bitter death — whether you saw it

94 with your own eyes, or heard the tale of him
from another

95 wanderer. Beyond all men his mother bore him
for sorrow.

96 Do not soften anything from courtesy or
pity:11

97 tell me fully whatever sight you came upon.

98 I beg you — if ever my father, good Odysseus,

99 promised you word or work and made it good

100 in the Trojans' country, where you Achaeans

suffered your pains,

101 remember it for me now: tell me the unerring truth.”

102 Then Gerenian Nestor the horseman answered him:

103 “Dear boy — since you bring back the misery we endured

104 in that country, we headstrong sons of the Achaeans,

105 all our roving in ships across the misted sea

106 chasing plunder wherever Achilles led,

107 and all our fighting around the great city of lord Priam —

108 there, in those years, our best were killed.

109 There lies Ajax, dear to the war-god; there Achilles;12

110 there Patroclus, a counselor the equal of the gods;

111 there my own dear son, strong and without fault,

112 Antilochus — surpassing swift of foot, and a fighter.

113 And many other evils we suffered besides:
who among
114 mortal men could tell them all?
115 Not if you stayed five years — six years —
116 asking all the evils the noble Achaeans
suffered there:
117 you would go home to your own country worn
out first.
118 Nine years we stitched evils around them,
plotting¹³
119 with every kind of cunning — and the son of
Cronos barely brought it to an end.
120 And there no man would set his wits against
him openly —
121 willing, that is — for noble Odysseus won by
far,
122 in every kind of cunning: your father — if
truly
123 you are his blood. Awe takes me, looking at
you.
124 Your speech, at least, is his: you would not
think

125 a younger man could speak so like him.
126 In all that time, I and noble Odysseus
127 never spoke on opposite sides in assembly or
in council:
128 one heart between us — with sense and
considered counsel
129 we planned for the Argives how the best
might come about.
130 But when we had sacked Priam's steep city,14
131 and gone to our ships, and a god scattered the
Achaeans,
132 then, then Zeus devised in his heart a bitter
homecoming
133 for the Argives — since not all of us were men
of sense
134 or of justice. So many of them came to an evil
end
135 through the ruinous wrath of the gray-eyed
daughter of the mighty Father —15
136 who set strife between the two sons of Atreus.
137 The two of them called the Achaeans all to
assembly —

138 rashly, in no due order, at the setting of the
sun,
139 and the sons of the Achaeans came heavy
with wine —
140 and they spoke out the reason they had
gathered the army.
141 There Menelaus urged all the Achaeans
142 to remember homecoming across the broad
back of the sea;
143 and it did not please Agamemnon, not at all:
he wanted
144 to hold the army back, and offer holy
hecatombs
145 to heal the terrible anger of Athena —
146 the fool. He did not know she was not to be
persuaded:16
147 the mind of the gods who are forever does not
turn so fast.
148 So the two of them stood trading hard words;
149 and the strong-greaved Achaeans sprang up
150 with a huge din, and the counsel split them
two ways.

151 That night we lay on our anger, brooding hard
thoughts

152 against each other — for Zeus was readying
the stroke of evil —

153 and at dawn half of us hauled our ships to the
bright salt water

154 and loaded our goods aboard, and the deep-
girdled women.

155 Half the army held back, staying

156 there with Atreus' son Agamemnon, shepherd
of the people;

157 and half of us embarked and rowed. And the
ships ran fast,

158 for a god smoothed the sea over its monstrous
deeps.

159 Coming to Tenedos, we offered victims to the
gods,

160 aching for home. But Zeus had no thought yet
of homecoming —

161 iron-hearted, he stirred up evil strife a second
time.

162 Some turned their curved ships around and

went back —

163 those with Odysseus, the battle-wise lord, the
man of shifting counsels —

164 carrying favor once again to Atreus' son
Agamemnon.

165 But I, with the ships that followed me
gathered close,

166 fled on, for I knew the god was devising evils.

167 And the warlike son of Tydeus fled, and
roused his companions.

168 Late upon our track came fair-haired
Menelaus,

169 and caught us at Lesbos debating the long
crossing:

170 whether to sail above rugged Chios,

171 by the isle of Psyria, keeping Chios on our left,

172 or under Chios, past windy Mimas.

173 We asked the god to show a sign, and he
showed one, 17

174 and bade us cut across the middle sea to
Euboea,

175 to run out from under the evil quickest.

176 A whistling wind sprang up astern, and the
ships ran fast
177 down the fish-filled ways, and to Geraestus
178 they came in by night. And to Poseidon we
laid many
179 bulls' thighs on the fire, having measured the
great gulf.
180 It was the fourth day when in Argos the
companions
181 of Diomedes, breaker of horses, moored their
trim ships;
182 but I held on for Pylos, and the wind never
failed
183 from the day the god first sent it blowing.
184 So I came home, dear child, knowing nothing
— I cannot tell you
185 who of the Achaeans were saved and who
were lost.
186 But all I hear, sitting here in our halls,
187 you shall learn, as is right; I will hide nothing.
188 The Myrmidons, they say, those furious
spearmen, came home safe,

189 led by the shining son of great-hearted
Achilles;
190 safe too Philoctetes, Poias' splendid son;
191 and Idomeneus brought all his companions to
Crete,
192 all who escaped the war: the sea took none
from him.
193 And Atreus' son — you have heard yourselves,
far off as you live,18
194 how he came home, and how Aegisthus
plotted his bitter death.
195 But that man paid for it — grimly, in full.
196 How good a thing it is, that a son of the dead
man be left!
197 For that son took vengeance on the killer of
his father,
198 Aegisthus of the crooked counsels, who cut
down his famous father.
199 You too, my friend — and I see how tall and
fine you are —19
200 be brave, so that men not yet born will speak
well of you."

201 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

202 “Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of the
Achaean,

203 yes — that man took his vengeance in full,
and the Achaeans

204 will carry his fame wide, a thing for men to
come to hear of.

205 If only the gods would clothe me in strength
like that,

206 to pay the suitors back for their galling
trespass —

207 the insolent men who scheme their reckless
outrage against me!

208 But the gods have spun no such happiness for
me —

209 not for my father, not for me. Now, come
what may, I must endure.”

210 Then Gerenian Nestor the horseman
answered him:

211 “Dear boy — since you say it yourself and
bring it to my mind —

212 they tell me many suitors for your mother’s

sake

213 fill your halls against your will, devising evils.

214 Tell me: do you bow to it willingly, or do the
people

215 through the land hate you, following the voice
of a god?

216 Who knows whether one day he will come
and repay their violence —

217 alone, it may be, or all the Achaeans with
him?

218 If only gray-eyed Athena chose to love you

219 the way she cared in those days for glorious
Odysseus

220 in the Trojans' country, where we Achaeans
suffered our pains —

221 never have I seen the gods love a man so
openly

222 as Pallas Athena stood by him, in the open —

223 if she chose to love you like that, and care for
you in her heart,

224 then more than one of those men would
forget about marriage for good.”

225 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

226 “Old sir, I do not think that word will ever be
accomplished.

227 What you say is too great. Awe holds me. I
could not

228 hope for it to happen — not if the gods
themselves willed it.”

229 Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-
eyed Athena:

230 “Telemachus, what a word has slipped the
fence of your teeth!**20**

231 Easily, if he wills it, a god brings a man safe
home — even from far away.

232 And I would rather suffer pains in plenty first

233 and then come home, and look on my day of
homecoming,

234 than come and die at my own hearth, as
Agamemnon

235 died, by the treachery of Aegisthus and of his
own wife.**21**

236 But death — the death common to all — not
even the gods

237 can beat away from a man they love, once the
day comes

238 when the ruinous doom of death that lays
men low takes hold.”

239 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:

240 “Mentor, let us speak of it no longer, grieved
though we are.

241 For him no homecoming is real any more:
long since

242 the deathless ones have plotted his death and
black doom.

243 Now there is another word I want to ask,

244 of Nestor — since beyond other men he
knows judgments and wisdom;

245 three generations of men, they say, he has
ruled as king,²²

246 and to my eyes he seems like one of the
deathless ones.

247 Nestor, son of Neleus: tell me the truth of it —

248 how did Atreus’ son die, wide-ruling
Agamemnon?

249 Where was Menelaus? What death did the

schemer plot for him,

250 Aegisthus of the crooked counsels — since the
man he killed was far the better?

251 Was Menelaus not in Achaean Argos — was he
wandering

252 somewhere among men, that the other took
heart and killed?”

253 Then Gerenian Nestor the horseman
answered him:

254 “Then I will tell you, child, the whole truth of
it.

255 You have guessed yourself how it would have
gone,

256 if Atreus’ son, fair-haired Menelaus, coming
from Troy,

257 had found Aegisthus alive in the halls:

258 no man would have heaped the mounded
earth over his dead body —

259 dogs and birds would have torn him

260 as he lay on the plain far from the city, and
not one

261 of the Achaean women would have wept him:

too monstrous the thing he schemed.

262 For we were over there, winning our many
contests —

263 and he, at his ease in a fold of horse-grazing
Argos,

264 worked all the while at Agamemnon's wife
with charming words.

265 At first she pushed the shameful thing away
—

266 shining Clytemnestra — for her mind was still
sound;

267 and beside her, too, there was a singer, whom
Atreus' son²³

268 strictly charged, when he left for Troy, to
guard his wife.

269 But when the doom of the gods bound her to
her undoing,

270 then Aegisthus led that singer to a desert
island

271 and left him there, spoil and carrion for the
birds,

272 and led her — he willing, she willing — home

to his own house.**24**

273 Many thigh-cuts he burned on the gods' holy altars,

274 many offerings he hung up, woven things and gold,

275 having accomplished the enormity his heart had never hoped for.

276 Now we had sailed together on the way from Troy,

277 Atreus' son and I, in all friendship;

278 but when we reached holy Sunium, the headland of Athens,

279 there Phoebus Apollo came with his gentle arrows**25**

280 and killed the helmsman of Menelaus,

281 the steering-oar of the running ship still in his hands:

282 Phrontis, Onetor's son, who outdid all the tribes of men

283 at steering a ship when the storm-winds drive.

284 So Menelaus was held there, pressed though

he was for the road,

285 to bury his companion and pay the death-
rites over him.

286 But when he too, going on over the wine-dark
sea

287 in the hollow ships, came at a run to the steep
height

288 of Malea, then wide-voiced Zeus devised for
him

289 a hateful road: he poured on the breath of
screaming winds

290 and monstrous waves, swollen huge as
mountains.

291 There he split the fleet, and part he drove on
Crete,

292 where the Cydonians lived around the
streams of Iardanus.

293 There is a bare cliff, sheer to the salt water,

294 at the edge of Gortyn on the misted sea,

295 where the South Wind shoves the great swell
on the left headland,

296 toward Phaestus, and a little stone holds back

the great sea.

297 There part of them came in, and the men
escaped destruction

298 barely, but the waves smashed the ships on
the reefs;

299 and the other five ships with their dark-blue
prows

300 the wind and the water carried and beached
on Egypt.

301 So Menelaus, gathering much substance and
gold,

302 roved with his ships among men of alien
speech —

303 and in that very time Aegisthus schemed
those horrors at home.

305 Seven years he reigned over Mycenae rich in
gold,26

304 having killed Atreus' son, and the people were
broken under him;

306 but in the eighth his evil came on him: noble
Orestes,

307 back from Athens, cut down his father's killer

—
308 Aegisthus of the crooked counsels, who cut
down his famous father.

309 The killing done, he gave the Argives a
funeral feast²⁷

310 for his hateful mother and for spineless
Aegisthus;

311 and on that same day Menelaus of the great
war-cry reached him,

312 bringing home treasure, all the freight his
ships could bear.

313 You too, my friend: do not wander long and
far from home,

314 leaving your goods behind and men in your
house

315 of such overbearing insolence — or they will
devour it all,

316 dividing your goods among them, and your
journey come to nothing.

317 But to Menelaus I bid you go — I urge it:

318 he is newly home from foreign parts,

319 from among peoples no man would hope in

his heart

320 to return from, once the storm-winds had
driven him astray

321 into a sea so vast that not even the birds

322 can cross it in a year — so vast it is, and
terrible.

323 Go now, with your own ship and your
companions;

324 or if you would rather go by land, chariot and
horses are here,

325 and here are my sons, who will be your
escorts

326 to shining Lacedaemon, where fair-haired
Menelaus is.

327 Beg him yourself, so that he speaks unerring
truth.

328 He will tell you no lie: he is clear-headed
beyond most men.”

329 So he spoke; and the sun went down, and the
dusk came on.

330 And among them spoke the goddess, gray-
eyed Athena:

331 “Old sir, all this you have told rightly, in due
measure.

332 But come — cut up the tongues now, and mix
the wine,²⁸

333 so that we may pour to Poseidon and the
other immortals

334 and then think of sleep. It is the hour for it:

335 the light is gone already under the western
gloom, and it is not fitting

336 to sit long at the feast of the gods, but to go
home.”

337 So spoke the daughter of Zeus, and they heard
her voice.

338 Heralds poured water over their hands,

339 and young men crowned the mixing-bowls
with drink

340 and served all, pouring first drops in each cup
for the gods;

341 and they threw the tongues in the fire, and
stood, and poured above them.

342 But when they had poured, and drunk what
their hearts would have,

343 then Athena and godlike Telemachus
344 both made to go back to the hollow ship.
345 But Nestor held them back, catching at them
with his words:
346 “Zeus forbid it — and the other deathless gods
—
347 that you should go from my house to your fast
ship
348 as if from some man utterly cloakless and
poor,
349 who has no cloaks, no plenty of blankets in
his house,
350 no soft sleeping for himself or for his guests!
351 I have cloaks and beautiful blankets in plenty.
352 Never, while I live, shall the dear son of this
man Odysseus
353 lie down on a ship’s deck-planks — nor after,
354 while sons of mine are left in the halls
355 to host whatever guest arrives at my doors.”
356 Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-
eyed Athena:
357 “Well said, dear old friend — and it is fitting

358 that Telemachus obey you: far better so.
359 Let him go with you now, then, and sleep
360 in your halls. But I will go to the black ship
361 to hearten the companions and give them all
their orders.
362 For I may claim to be the only elder among
them:
363 the rest are younger men who follow out of
friendship,
364 all of an age with great-hearted Telemachus.
365 There let me lie down tonight, by the black
hollow ship;
366 and in the morning I go on to the great-
hearted Cauconians,
367 where a debt is owed me — no new thing
368 and no small one. But this man, since he has
come to your house,
369 send on with a chariot and a son of yours; and
give him horses,
370 your lightest runners, your strongest.”
371 So speaking, gray-eyed Athena went away
372 in the likeness of a sea-eagle; and amazement

took all who saw,²⁹

³⁷³ and the old man marveled, when his eyes had
seen it.

³⁷⁴ He took Telemachus' hand, and spoke a word,
and named him:

³⁷⁵ "Dear friend, I have no fear you will prove
base or spineless,

³⁷⁶ if the gods walk with you so, escorts, and you
so young!

³⁷⁷ For this was none other of those who hold
Olympus

³⁷⁸ than the daughter of Zeus, most glorious
Tritogeneia,³⁰

³⁷⁹ she who honored your noble father too
among the Argives.

³⁸⁰ Queen, be gracious! Grant me good fame —

³⁸¹ to me, to my children, to my honored wife —

³⁸² and I in turn will offer you a yearling heifer,
broad of brow,³¹

³⁸³ unbroken, that no man has ever led under the
yoke:

³⁸⁴ her I will offer to you, with gold poured round

her horns.”

385 So he spoke in prayer, and Pallas Athena
heard him.

386 Then Gerenian Nestor the horseman led them
—

387 his sons and his daughters’ husbands — to his
beautiful house.

388 And when they reached the lord’s famous
house,

389 they sat in order on the benches and the
high-backed chairs,

390 and for their coming the old man mixed a
bowl

391 of sweet-drinking wine, eleven years old,

392 which the woman-steward opened, loosening
the sealing cap.

393 Of this the old man mixed a bowl, and to
Athena

394 he prayed long, pouring, to the daughter of
aegis-bearing Zeus.

395 But when they had poured, and drunk what
their hearts would have,

396 the others went home to sleep, each man to
his own house,
397 but Gerenian Nestor the horseman laid him
down there —
398 Telemachus, dear son of godlike Odysseus —
399 on a corded bedstead under the echoing
porch,
400 and beside him Peisistratus of the good ash
spear, leader of men,
401 the one son in his halls still unwed;
402 and he himself slept in the inner room of the
high house,
403 where the lady his wife made ready his bed
and his rest.
404 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,
405 Gerenian Nestor the horseman rose up from
his bed,
406 and came out, and took his seat on the
polished stones
407 that stood before his high doors,
408 white, gleaming as if with oil. On these, in the

old days,³²

⁴⁰⁹ Neleus used to sit, a counselor the equal of
the gods;

⁴¹⁰ but he long since had gone down to Hades,
broken by fate,

⁴¹¹ and now Gerenian Nestor sat there in his turn,
warder of the Achaeans,

⁴¹² holding the scepter. Around him his sons
gathered in a body,

⁴¹³ coming from their rooms: Echephron and
Stratius,

⁴¹⁴ Perseus and Aretus and godlike Thrasymedes;

⁴¹⁵ and sixth came the hero Peisistratus to join
them,

⁴¹⁶ and they led godlike Telemachus and seated
him beside them.

⁴¹⁷ And Gerenian Nestor the horseman began to
speak among them:

⁴¹⁸ “Quickly, dear children, work my wish for me,

⁴¹⁹ so that first of all the gods I may propitiate
Athena,

⁴²⁰ who came to me in visible presence at the

god's rich feast.

421 Come then: one of you to the plain for a
heifer, fast as may be,

422 and let the cowherd drive her in;

423 one go down to great-hearted Telemachus'
black ship

424 and bring up all his companions — leave two
men only;

425 one bid the goldsmith Laerces come here

426 to pour gold round the heifer's horns.

427 The rest of you stay here together; and tell
the slave-women

428 inside to make ready a feast through the
famous house —

429 seats, and firewood round about, and shining
water.”

430 So he spoke, and they all fell to bustling. The
heifer came

431 up from the plain; from the fast trim ship
came

432 great-hearted Telemachus' companions; the
smith came

433 with his bronze tools in his hands, the
instruments of his art,
434 anvil and hammer and the well-made fire-
tongs
435 he worked the gold with; and Athena came
436 to receive her offering. And the old horseman
Nestor
437 gave gold, and the smith worked it and
poured it round
438 the heifer's horns, so the goddess might see
the glory and be glad.
439 Stratus and noble Echephron led her by the
horns;
440 Aretus came from the storeroom carrying
lustral water**33**
441 in a flowered basin, and in his other hand the
barley-grains
442 in a basket; and Thrasymedes, steadfast in
battle, stood by
443 with a sharp axe in his hand, to strike the
heifer down;
444 Perseus held the blood-bowl. And the old

horseman Nestor

445 began with the hand-water and the barley-
grains, and long to Athena

446 he prayed, making first offering, casting hairs
from the head into the fire.

447 And when they had prayed and thrown the
scattering barley,

448 straightway Nestor's son, high-spirited
Thrasymedes,

449 stood close and struck: the axe cut through
the tendons

450 of the neck, and undid the heifer's strength.
And the women cried aloud —34

451 the daughters and the sons' wives and the
honored wife

452 of Nestor, Eurydice, eldest of the daughters of
Clymenus.

453 Then the men lifted her up from the wide-
wayed earth

454 and held her, and Peisistratus, leader of men,
cut the throat.

455 And when the black blood had run out, and

the life had left the bones,

456 quickly they broke her apart, and at once cut
out the thigh-pieces

457 all in due order, and wrapped them deep in
fat,

458 folding it double, and laid raw flesh upon
them.

459 The old man burned them on the split wood,
and poured the fire-bright wine

460 over; and the young men beside him held the
five-tined forks.

461 And when the thighs were burned through,
and they had tasted the innards,

462 they carved up the rest and threaded it on
spits

463 and roasted it, holding the sharp spits in their
hands.

464 Meanwhile beautiful Polycaste had bathed
Telemachus —35

465 the youngest daughter of Nestor, Neleus' son.

466 And when she had bathed him and rubbed
him richly with oil,

467 she threw a beautiful mantle around him, and
a tunic,

468 and he stepped from the bath with the body
of an immortal,

469 and went and sat down beside Nestor,
shepherd of the people.

470 And when they had roasted the outer meats
and drawn them off,

471 they sat and feasted; and good men waited on
them,

472 pouring wine into cups of gold.

473 But when they had put away desire for food
and drink,

474 Gerenian Nestor the horseman began to speak
among them:

475 “My sons, come — yoke the fine-maned
horses for Telemachus,

476 lead them under the chariot, so he may be
making his way.”

477 So he spoke, and they listened well and
obeyed:

478 quickly they yoked the swift horses under the

chariot,

479 and the woman-steward put in bread and
wine

480 and cooked meats, such things as Zeus-
nurtured kings eat.

481 Then Telemachus mounted the beautiful
chariot,

482 and beside him Peisistratus, Nestor's son,
leader of men,

483 mounted the chariot and took the reins in his
hands,

484 and whipped them to a run; and the pair flew
on, nothing loath,

485 into the plain, and left the steep city of Pylos
behind.

486 All day long they shook the yoke they bore
between them.36

487 The sun went down, and all the ways grew
dark,

488 and they came to Pherae, to the house of
Diocles,

489 son of Ortilochus, whom Alpheus fathered.

490 There they slept the night, and he set guest-
gifts before them.
491 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,
492 they yoked the horses and mounted the inlaid
chariot
493 and drove out of the gateway and the echoing
porch;
494 and he whipped them to a run, and the pair
flew on, nothing loath.
495 They came to the wheat-bearing plain, and
there they pressed
496 to the journey's end: so well the swift horses
carried them.
497 The sun went down, and all the ways grew
dark.³⁷

Notes

NOTES

1. Book 3 opens not with the dawn formula but with a sunrise — the sun climbing out of the “beautiful water” into a heaven of

bronze — because the night belonged to Book 2's sea-run: the ship sailed all night, and the sun rises on arrival. The books are stitched together by the same continuous journey. ↩

2. Black victims for Poseidon (chthonic and marine powers take dark animals), offered by the sea itself; κυανοχαίτης, “with the blue-black hair,” is his fixed epithet. Telemachus lands in the middle of a festival for precisely the god who hates his father. ↩

3. Nine companies of five hundred men, nine bulls each: 4,500 participants and eighty-one bulls. The staggering arithmetic is the point — Pylos is the most pious place in the poem, and its piety is civic and enormous. ↩

4. αἰδώς — the shyness, shame, and deference proper to the young — is the emotion this whole episode is built to overcome. Athena names it, tells him to drop it, and twenty lines later (24) he confesses it anyway. The Telemachy is a course in when *aidōs* serves a man and when it starves him. ↩

5. “He will tell you no lie: he is clear-headed (πεπνυμένος) beyond most men.” The line recurs verbatim at 328 — said first of Nestor by Athena, then of Menelaus by Nestor — and the epithet is the same one fixed to Telemachus himself. The poem quietly places the boy in a chain of clear-headed men who tell the truth. ↩

6. “Some of it your own heart will see, and some a god will prompt”: the cleanest statement in the poem of Homeric double motivation — human intention and divine prompting as two descriptions of one event, not rivals. ↩

7. A small comedy of disguise: the goddess is delighted because the young man's protocol happens to give *her* the cup first — at a feast held in honor of Poseidon, her defeated rival in other stories and her opposite in this poem. Piety done right pleases gods the pious cannot see. ↩
8. “So she prayed — and she herself was accomplishing it all.” The narrator's wink: the prayer is addressed to Poseidon, but its fulfillment is already in the hands of the praying goddess. Prayer, in this scene, is a circle with Athena at both ends. ↩
9. Γερήνιος ἱππότα Νέστωρ — “Gerenian Nestor the horseman,” his unvarying formula (Gerenia was the town where, in legend, he was raised while Heracles sacked Pylos). Like all the fixed epithets in this translation, it returns identically every time. ↩
10. The piracy question — “who are you, trader or raider?” — is asked *after* the guests have eaten, which is the correct order of hospitality; the same verses recur when the Cyclops asks them of Odysseus (9.252–255) *before* offering anything, which is how the poem marks a monster. Note that the question treats sea-raiding as an ordinary profession, asked about politely. ↩
11. “Do not soften anything from courtesy or pity”: Telemachus asks to be treated as an adult — bad news unvarnished — in his first formal speech to a great man of his father's generation. Nestor's answering awe (123–125) confirms the request landed. ↩
12. The catalogue of graves: Ajax, Achilles, Patroclus — and then “my own dear son.” Nestor names Antilochus last, gives him two lines of praise, and moves on. The restraint is the grief; the

poem lets a father's economy of speech say what elaboration would cheapen. ↩

13. "We stitched evils around them" — ῥάπτουμεν, the verb of sewing. Plotting is stitchwork in Greek (the same image gives us "rhapsode," the song-stitcher); Penelope's loom in Book 2 and the war-craft here are the same skill in different threads. ↩
14. Lines 130–198 are our oldest surviving account of the Returns — the story told at length in the lost cyclic epic *Nostoi*: the quarrel of the Atreidae, the drunken twilight assembly, the fleet splitting apart by stages. Homer's audience knew the full story; the poem gives it as a veteran's compressed, first-person memory. ↩
15. Athena's "ruinous wrath" against the returning fleet had a famous cause — the sacrilege of Ajax son of Oileus, who dragged Cassandra from Athena's altar. Nestor does not name it, and the discretion has a dramatic edge: the wrathful goddess in question is sitting beside him disguised as an old family friend. ↩
16. νήπιος, "the fool" — the narrator's (here Nestor's) pitiless word for a man who acts not knowing what the audience knows; it was Zeus' word for the crew in the proem (1.8). "The mind of the gods does not turn so fast": Agamemnon's hecatombs cannot hurry forgiveness, a rare statement of divine emotional inertia. ↩
17. The choice at Lesbos is between coast-hugging routes and the open-water run to Euboea — blue-water sailing, done only with a god's explicit sanction. The itinerary (Lesbos, Psyria,

Chios, Mimas, Geraestus) is real Aegean pilotage, and the fear of the open sea in it is real too. ↩

18. The Aegisthus story is now told for the third time in three books — by Zeus (1.32–43), by Athena (1.298–300), and by Nestor here, expanded at 254–312. Each telling is angled at Telemachus more directly than the last. The poem uses the house of Atreus as a mirror held up to the house of Odysseus: same absent king, same courted wife, same son who must choose. ↩

19. Lines 199–200 repeat Athena’s exhortation from 1.301–302 word for word — now in Nestor’s mouth. Goddess and elder statesman, independently, say the same sentence to the boy. When the world repeats itself like that in Homer, it is fate talking. ↩

20. Athena borrows Zeus’ rebuke to her from 1.64 — “what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!” — and turns it on Telemachus. The formula travels down the hierarchy: father to daughter, goddess to boy. ↩

21. “By the treachery of Aegisthus *and of his own wife*”: Clytemnestra enters the poem’s version of the story here, and Nestor’s fuller account (264–272) is strikingly gentle with her — her mind “still sound” at first, her fall a matter of the gods’ binding doom, her consent given only at the end (“he willing, she willing”). Homer’s Clytemnestra is a woman worked on, not tragedy’s axe-wielder — which makes her a darker mirror for the besieged Penelope. ↩

22. Nestor’s proverbial age: he has ruled through three generations of men. His function in both epics is to be memory itself —

which is exactly what Telemachus, a boy with no memories of his father, has come to borrow. ↩

23. The nameless singer whom Agamemnon left to guard his wife — and whom Aegisthus marooned to die on a desert island — appears only here in all Greek literature. It is a bard's professional aside: in this poem's moral world, song is a guardian of faithfulness, and the seducer's first necessary crime is to silence the singer. Compare Phemius, singing for the suitors "under compulsion" (1.154). ↩

24. "He willing, she willing" — ἐθέλων ἐθέλουσαν, two words that carry the whole moral weight of the fall. After years of resistance and a divine doom, the Greek grants Clytemnestra exactly one word of agency, and it is enough to hang the story on. ↩

25. Death "by the gentle arrows" of Apollo is the Homeric idiom for sudden, unexplained natural death (Artemis' arrows for women). Phrontis the helmsman dies at the tiller in fair passage — the sea claims even the best pilot alive, at the exact headland where Athena's temple would later stand. ↩

26. Here the translation follows Murray's text, which prints line 305 before 304 (keeping the traditional numbers): the sense runs "Aegisthus schemed at home; seven years he reigned in Mycenae, having killed Atreus' son..." — the transposition smooths the sequence of thought. ↩

27. Orestes "gave the Argives a funeral feast for his hateful mother and for spineless Aegisthus." The *Odyssey* passes over the matricide in a single adjective and a shared grave-feast — no Furies, no trial, no torment. The poem needs Orestes as a clean

model for Telemachus, so the tragic machinery that Aeschylus will build is simply not here. ↩

28. The tongues of the victims, cut out and burned with a final libation, are the traditional last act of the sacrificial evening — the feast's closing signature. Athena the guest is the one who reminds her hosts of the god's due, which is both in character and quietly funny. ↩
29. Athena departs as a φήνη — a sea-eagle or bearded vulture. This is the second bird-exit in the poem (1.320), and the first read *precisely*: Telemachus in Ithaca sensed a god and no more, but Nestor names Athena on the spot and answers her. In Pylos the machinery of piety works entire — sign, recognition, vow, sacrifice, all in order. ↩
30. Τριτογένεια, “Tritogeneia” — an ancient cult title of Athena, already opaque to the poet's audience (born by Lake Tritonis? from Zeus' head beside the river Triton?). I transliterate rather than guess. ↩
31. The vow is precise votive economics: an unworked animal (never yoked), its horns sheathed in gold “so the goddess might see the glory and be glad” (438). The god must be *shown* the honor. The vow made here at evening is paid at dawn — the fastest-honored promise in the poem. ↩
32. The polished white stones “gleaming as if with oil” are the seat of kings before the high doors — Neleus sat on them, now Nestor does. Authority in this poem has furniture, and the furniture outlasts the men; the one-line obituary of Neleus in the middle is the *Odyssey's* whole theology of succession. ↩

33. Lines 440–463 are the fullest description of Greek animal sacrifice anywhere in Homer — lustral water, barley grains, the hair of the victim’s head cast in the fire as first offering, the axe-blow, the blood-bowl, thigh-pieces wrapped in double fat with raw flesh laid on, wine poured over the burning. Classicists mine this passage as a primary document of the rite; the poem offers it as Pylos simply being Pylos. ↪
34. ὀλόλυξαν — the *ololygē*, the high ritual cry raised by women at the instant of the kill. It is not a scream of horror but a formal acclamation: the moment of death belongs to the women’s voices, as the axe belongs to the men’s hands. ↪
35. Polycaste, Nestor’s youngest daughter, bathes and dresses the guest — the peak of honor a host’s house can pay, and he rises from her bath “with the body of an immortal.” Later tradition (a Hesiodic genealogy) married Polycaste to Telemachus; the poem plants only this one luminous, courteous scene. ↪
36. “All day long they shook the yoke they bore between them” — a whole day’s driving in a single line of horses’ bodies. The Homeric camera does not always linger; sometimes it cuts. ↪
37. The book closes on the sunset formula for the second time in eleven lines — day-line, night-stop, day-line — the rhythm of overland travel. Two sunsets bracket the leg from Pylos to the edge of Sparta, where Book 4 opens on Menelaus’ feast. ↪

Odyssey — Book 4

*Sparta: Helen and Menelaus remember Troy; Proteus;
the suitors set their ambush.*

- 1 And they came to hollow Lacedaemon, land of ravines,¹
- 2 and drove to the house of glorious Menelaus.
- 3 They found him giving a wedding-feast to his many kinsmen²
- 4 for his son and his blameless daughter, in his own house.
- 5 The daughter he was sending to the son of Achilles, breaker of ranks:
- 6 in Troy long ago he had promised her, had bowed his head
- 7 to give her, and now the gods were bringing the marriage to pass.
- 8 So now with horses and chariots he was sending her forth
- 9 to the famous city of the Myrmidons, whom

that man ruled.

10 For his son he was bringing home Alektor's
daughter out of Sparta —

11 the son born to him in his strength, well-loved
Megapenthes,

12 out of a slave-woman. For to Helen the gods
showed no more children

13 after the first time, when she bore her lovely
daughter

14 Hermione, who had the beauty of golden
Aphrodite.

15 So they were feasting through the great high-
roofed house,

16 the neighbors and kinsmen of glorious
Menelaus,

17 taking their pleasure; and among them a
godlike singer sang

18 to the lyre, and two tumblers among them,

19 as he led the song, went spinning through their
midst.

20 And the two of them halted at the gateway of
the house, themselves

21 and their horses — the hero Telemachus and
Nestor's shining son.

22 Lord Eteoneus came out and saw them,
23 the busy henchman of glorious Menelaus,
24 and went through the house to bring the news
to the shepherd of the people;

25 standing close he spoke winged words to him:

26 “Two strangers here, Menelaus, nurtured of
Zeus —

27 two men, and they look like the stock of great
Zeus.

28 Tell me: do we unyoke their swift horses for
them,

29 or send them on to another man, who may
welcome them?”

30 Then fair-haired Menelaus, greatly stirred,
replied:³

31 “You were no fool before, Eteoneus, son of
Boethous —

32 but now you are babbling nonsense like a child.

33 The two of us ate plenty of strangers' bread,

34 you and I, on the road home, hoping Zeus

might someday

35 give us rest from misery. Unyoke the strangers'
horses,

36 and bring the men themselves in, to share the
feast.”

37 So he spoke, and the man dashed back through
the hall, and called the other

38 busy henchmen to come along with him.

39 They loosed the sweating horses from under
the yoke

40 and tied them up at the mangers of the horses,

41 and threw them spelt, and mixed white barley
in with it,

42 and leaned the chariot against the gleaming
entrance-wall,

43 and led the men into the godlike house. And
they stared

44 in wonder through the house of the Zeus-
nurtured king:

45 for there was a sheen as of the sun or the
moon⁴

46 through the high-roofed house of glorious

Menelaus.

47 And when they had had their joy of gazing,
48 they stepped into the polished baths and
bathed.

49 And when the slave-women had bathed them
and rubbed them with oil,

50 and thrown about them fleecy cloaks and
tunics,

51 they sat down on high seats beside Menelaus,
Atreus' son.

52 A handmaid brought water for their hands in a
pitcher,

53 a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a
silver basin

54 for them to wash, and drew up a polished table
beside them.

55 The grave housekeeper brought bread and set
it before them,

56 laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of
her store;

57 a carver lifted platters of meat of every kind

58 and set them down, and placed gold cups

beside them.

59 And fair-haired Menelaus greeted them with a wave of the hand:

60 “Take of the bread, and be welcome. And afterward,

61 when you have tasted supper, we will ask what men

62 you are: for the stock of your parents is not lost in you —

63 you are of the stock of scepter-bearing kings,

64 nurtured of Zeus. No base men could father such sons.”

65 So he spoke, and set before them the fat roast chine of an ox,

66 lifting it in his hands — the portion of honor they had set for him.

67 And their hands went out to the good things spread before them.

68 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,

69 then Telemachus spoke to the son of Nestor,

70 leaning his head close, so that the others

might not hear:

71 “Look, son of Nestor, delight of my heart —5

72 the lightning of bronze through these echoing
halls,

73 the gold and the amber, the silver and the
ivory!

74 Such, I think, is the court of Olympian Zeus
within:

75 all this here, past speaking! Awe takes me,
looking at it.”

76 But fair-haired Menelaus caught what he was
saying,

77 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to
them:

78 “Dear children, with Zeus no mortal man could
vie:

79 his halls and his possessions are deathless
things.

80 Among men, another may match me in wealth
— or may not.

81 Much I suffered for it, and far I wandered

82 to bring it home in my ships: eight years gone

before I came,

83 driven wandering to Cyprus and Phoenicia and
the Egyptians;

84 I reached the Ethiopians, the Sidonians, the
Erembi,

85 and Libya, where the lambs come horned from
the birth,

86 for the ewes bear three times in the full round
of the year.

87 There no lord and no shepherd goes wanting

88 for cheese and meat and sweet milk:

89 the flocks give milk for the milking all the year
round.

90 But while I roamed those countries gathering

91 much substance, another man killed my
brother —

92 by stealth, off guard, through the treachery of
his cursed wife.⁶

93 So I take no joy in being lord of all this wealth.

94 You will have heard it from your fathers,
whoever they are:

95 I have suffered much, and I lost a house

96 well lived-in, full of many splendid things.
97 Would I lived here with a third part only of all
this,
98 and the men were alive who died in those
years
99 in wide Troy, far from horse-grazing Argos!
100 And yet — though I mourn them all, and
grieve,
101 often, sitting here in our halls,
102 and one hour ease my heart with weeping,
and the next
103 leave off, for men are quickly sated of cold
lament —
104 for all of them together I do not mourn so
much,
105 grieved though I am, as for one man, who
makes sleep hateful to me,
106 and food, when I remember: for no Achaean
labored
107 as Odysseus labored and endured. And the end
of it was
108 sorrow for him, and for me a grief never to be

forgotten —

109 that he is gone so long, and we know nothing,
110 whether he lives or is dead. They must be
mourning him now,
111 old Laertes, and steady-hearted Penelope,
112 and Telemachus, whom he left new-born in
the house.”

113 So he spoke, and stirred in the boy the ache to
weep for his father:

114 tears fell from his eyelids to the ground at his
father’s name,

115 and he lifted the purple cloak before his eyes

116 with both hands. And Menelaus noticed him,

117 and pondered then in his mind and in his
heart

118 whether to leave it to him to name his father,

119 or to question him first and test him point by
point.

120 While he was turning this over in his mind
and in his heart,

121 out of her fragrant high-roofed chamber came
Helen,⁷

122 looking like Artemis of the golden distaff;
123 and with her Adreste set out her well-made
reclining chair,
124 Alcippe brought a rug of soft wool,
125 and Phylo brought her silver basket, given her
126 by Alcandre, wife of Polybus, who lived in
Thebes
127 of Egypt, where the greatest wealth lies stored
in houses:
128 he gave Menelaus two silver baths
129 and a pair of tripods and ten talents of gold;
130 and apart from these his wife gave Helen
beautiful gifts of her own —
131 a golden distaff she gave, and a basket on
wheels,
132 silver, its rims finished off in gold.
133 This the handmaid Phylo brought and set
beside her,
134 stuffed with fine-spun yarn, and across it
135 lay the distaff, wound with wool of violet
darkness.
136 She sat down on the chair, with a footstool for

her feet,

137 and at once began asking her husband about everything:

138 “Do we know yet, Menelaus, nurtured of Zeus, who these men

139 declare themselves to be, who have come to our house?

140 Shall I lie, or speak the truth? My heart bids me speak.⁸

141 For never yet, I say, have I seen such a likeness,

142 in man or woman — awe takes me, looking at him —

143 as this boy is like the son of great-hearted Odysseus:

144 Telemachus, whom that man left new-born in the house

145 when for my sake — bitch-faced that I was — you Achaeans⁹

146 came up under Troy, with bold war in your hearts.”

147 Then fair-haired Menelaus answered her:

148 “I too see it now, wife, just as you liken him:

149 those were the very feet of the man, the very
hands,
150 the glance of his eyes, the head, the hair
above.
151 And just now, remembering Odysseus,
152 I was telling of all he labored and endured
153 for my sake — and the boy shed a bitter tear
from under his brows,
154 holding the purple cloak up before his eyes.”
155 Then Peisistratus, Nestor’s son, answered him:
156 “Menelaus, son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured,
leader of peoples,
157 this is indeed that man’s son, as you say.
158 But he is modest, and his heart is shy
159 of splashing forth big words on a first arrival
160 in front of you, whose voice delights us both
like a god’s.
161 Gerenian Nestor the horseman sent me out
162 to come with him as escort: he longed to see
you,
163 in hope you might set some word or work
before him.

164 For a son has many sorrows in the house
165 when his father is gone and no other helpers
stand by him —
166 as now with Telemachus: the father gone, and
no others
167 in all the land to beat trouble away.”
168 Then fair-haired Menelaus answered him:
169 “Well now! Truly the son of a beloved man is
in my house,
170 a man who fought through many trials for my
sake;
171 and I used to say that when he came I would
welcome him beyond all
172 the other Argives — if Olympian Zeus of the
wide voice
173 gave the two of us a homecoming over the sea
in our fast ships.
174 I would have settled him a city in Argos, and
built him a house,¹⁰
175 and brought him out of Ithaca with his goods
and his son
176 and all his people — emptying out one town

177 of those that lie around and own me as their
lord.

178 Being here, we would have mingled often; and
nothing

179 would have parted us then, loving and
delighting in each other,

180 until death's black cloud came folding round
us.

181 But such things, I suppose, the god himself
must have grudged,

182 who made that unlucky man — him alone —
the man who never came home."

183 So he spoke, and stirred in them all the ache
of lament.

184 Argive Helen wept, the daughter of Zeus,

185 and Telemachus wept, and Menelaus, Atreus'
son,

186 nor could the son of Nestor keep his eyes dry:

187 for his heart remembered blameless

Antilochus, **11**

188 whom the shining son of bright Dawn had
killed.

189 Remembering him, he spoke winged words:
190 “Son of Atreus, old Nestor always said
191 you were clear-headed beyond other mortals,
whenever we remembered you
192 in his halls, and questioned one another.
193 So now, if it may be, listen to me. I take
194 no pleasure in weeping after supper — and
dawn
195 will come, early-born, soon enough. Not that I
grudge
196 lament for any mortal who dies and meets his
doom:
197 this is the only honor left to miserable
mortals,**12**
198 to cut a lock of hair and let a tear fall down
the cheek.
199 For my brother died too — hardly the meanest
200 of the Argives. You would know him. I myself
never
201 met him, never saw him. But beyond other
men, they say,
202 Antilochus was surpassing swift of foot, and a

fighter.”

203 Then fair-haired Menelaus answered him:

204 “Dear friend — you have said all a clear-headed man

205 could say or do, even a man older than you.

206 From such a father you come; hence your clear-headed speech.

207 Easily known is the seed of a man for whom the son of Cronos

208 spins out happiness at his marriage and his begetting —

209 as now he has granted Nestor, through all his days,

210 to grow old sleek in his own halls,

211 and his sons to be wise and the best of spearmen.

212 So we will let the weeping go, which came on us before,

213 and think again of supper. Let them pour water

214 over our hands. And at dawn there will be tales again

215 for Telemachus and me to tell through to each other.”

216 So he spoke, and Asphalion poured water over their hands,

217 the busy henchman of glorious Menelaus,

218 and their hands went out to the good things spread before them.

219 Then Helen, daughter of Zeus, thought of one thing more:

220 into the wine they were drinking she straightway cast a drug¹³

221 that undoes grief and anger and brings forgetfulness of every evil.

222 Whoever swallowed it down, once mixed in the bowl,

223 would let no tear fall down his cheeks that day,

224 not though his mother and his father lay there dead,

225 not though before his face men put his brother or his own son

226 to the bronze, and his own eyes saw it.

227 Such were the subtle drugs the daughter of
Zeus possessed,
228 good drugs, given her by Polydamna, wife of
Thon,
229 the Egyptian — for there the grain-giving
plowland bears
230 drugs in greatest plenty, many good in the
mixing, many baneful;
231 and every man there is a healer beyond all
232 humankind: for they are of the race of
Paeon.
233 When she had cast it in, and bidden the wine
be poured,
234 she took up the talk again, and said:
235 “Menelaus, son of Atreus, nurtured of Zeus —
and you,¹⁴
236 sons of good men. To this man and that Zeus
gives
237 good and evil, now one, now another: for he
can do all things.
238 So now — feast where you sit in the halls
239 and take your pleasure in tales. And I will tell

one that fits the hour.

240 All of it I could not tell, could not so much as
number —

241 all the trials of enduring-hearted Odysseus;

242 but here is one thing that mighty man did and
dared¹⁵

243 in the Trojans' country, where you Achaeans
suffered your pains.

244 He beat his own body with disfiguring blows,

245 threw a foul rag over his shoulders, and like a
house-slave

246 he slipped into the wide-wayed city of his
enemies —

247 hiding himself, in the likeness of another
man,

248 a beggar: he who was nothing of the kind by
the Achaean ships.

249 In that shape he slipped into the Trojans' city,
and all of them

250 were taken in. I alone knew him for what he
was,

251 and questioned him; and he in his cunning

kept slipping away.

252 But when at last I was bathing him and
rubbing him with oil,

253 and had put clothes on him, and sworn a
strong oath

254 not to reveal Odysseus to the Trojans

255 before he reached the fast ships and the huts,

256 then at last he told me all the Achaeans had in
mind.

257 And he killed many Trojans with the long-
edged bronze

258 on his way back to the Argives, and brought
back a harvest of knowledge.

259 Then the other women of Troy wailed shrill.
But my heart

260 rejoiced — for my heart had turned already
toward going

261 home again, and I mourned too late the
madness Aphrodite

262 gave me, when she led me there from my own
dear country,

263 forsaking my child, my bridal chamber, and a

husband

264 lacking nothing, in mind or in beauty.”

265 Then fair-haired Menelaus answered her:

266 “Yes, wife: all this you have told rightly, in
due measure.

267 By now I have learned the counsel and the
mind

268 of many heroes, and traveled over much of
the earth,

269 but never yet have my eyes looked on such a
one

270 as the heart of enduring-hearted Odysseus.

271 Here is one more thing that mighty man did
and dared

272 inside the carved horse, where we sat, all the
best

273 of the Argives, carrying death and doom to
the Trojans.

274 Then you came there — some spirit must have
moved you, **16**

275 one that willed to hand glory to the Trojans —

276 and godlike Deiphobus came following after

you.

277 Three times you circled the hollow ambush,
stroking it,

278 and you called by name the best of the
Danaans,

279 making your voice the voice of each Argive's
wife.

280 And I and the son of Tydeus and noble
Odysseus,

281 sitting in the middle of them, heard you
calling;

282 and the two of us were wild to spring up

283 and come out, or answer at once from within.

284 But Odysseus held us down, and checked us
for all our longing.

285 Then all the other sons of the Achaeans kept
silence;17

286 Anticlus alone was bent on giving you an
answer —

287 but Odysseus clamped his great hands over
his mouth

288 and held them there, unyielding, and saved

all the Achaeans:

289 he held him so until Pallas Athena led you
away.”

290 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:

291 “Menelaus, son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured,
leader of peoples —

292 the more grief: for none of this kept bitter
death from him,

293 not though the heart inside him had been
iron.

294 But come — send us to bed now, so that at last

295 we may lie down and take our joy of sweet
sleep.”

296 So he spoke; and Argive Helen ordered the
slave-women

297 to set out bedsteads under the porch, and to
lay on them

298 beautiful purple blankets, and spread rugs
above,

299 and fleecy cloaks on top of all, for cover.

300 Out of the hall they went with torches in

their hands

301 and made the beds; and a herald led the
guests out.

302 So they slept there in the forecourt of the
house,

303 the hero Telemachus and Nestor's shining
son;

304 but Atreus' son slept in the inner room of the
high house,

305 and beside him lay long-robed Helen, shining
among women.

306 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,

307 Menelaus of the great war-cry rose up from
his bed,

308 put on his clothes, slung his sharp sword
about his shoulder,

309 bound the beautiful sandals beneath his
shining feet,

310 and came out of his bedroom looking like a
god.

311 He sat down beside Telemachus, and spoke a

word, and named him:

312 “What need has brought you here, hero
Telemachus,

313 to shining Lacedaemon, over the broad back
of the sea?

314 A public matter or private? Tell me the plain
truth of it.”

315 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

316 “Menelaus, son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured,
leader of peoples,

317 I came in hope you might tell me some word
of my father.

318 My house is being eaten; my rich fields are
ruined;

319 the house is packed with enemies, who day
upon day

320 slaughter my thronging flocks and my
shambling crook-horned cattle —

321 my mother’s suitors, with their overweening
insolence.

322 That is why I come now to your knees: in
hope you will consent¹⁸

323 to tell his bitter death — whether you saw it
324 with your own eyes, or heard the tale of him
from another
325 wanderer. Beyond all men his mother bore
him for sorrow.
326 Do not soften anything from courtesy or pity:
327 tell me fully whatever sight you came upon.
328 I beg you — if ever my father, good Odysseus,
329 promised you word or work and made it good
330 in the Trojans' country, where you Achaeans
suffered your pains,
331 remember it for me now: tell me the unerring
truth.”
332 Then fair-haired Menelaus, greatly stirred,
replied:
333 “Shame on them! Truly in the bed of a strong-
hearted man
334 they want to lie — the spineless creatures that
they are!
335 As when a deer beds down her newborn
suckling fawns¹⁹
336 in the thicket-lair of a mighty lion,

337 and goes questing the spurs and grassy
hollows,
338 grazing — and then the lion comes back to his
own bed
339 and lets an ugly doom loose on them both:
340 so Odysseus will let an ugly doom loose on
those men.
341 If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo! —
342 the man he was long ago in strong-founded
Lesbos,
343 when he rose on a challenge and wrestled
Philomeleides
344 and threw him hard, and all the Achaeans
cheered:
345 such as he was then, let that Odysseus close
with the suitors:
346 quick would their fates be then, and bitter
their weddings.
347 As for what you ask of me and beg me: I will
not
348 talk around it, swerving aside, and I will not
deceive you.

349 What the unerring Old Man of the Sea told
me,20

350 not one word of it will I hide or cover from
you.

351 In Egypt the gods still held me, hungry as I
was for home,

352 because I had not offered them their full
hecatombs —

353 and the gods will always have their
commandments remembered.

354 Now there is an island in the much-surging
sea

355 off the mouth of Egypt — Pharos, men call
it,21

356 as far out as a hollow ship runs in a whole day

357 with a whistling wind astern of her —

358 and in it a harbor, good anchorage, from
which men launch

359 their trim ships to sea, once they have drawn
black water.

360 There the gods held me twenty days: never
once the sea-winds

361 blowing fair, that speed ships
362 over the broad back of the sea.
363 And now all our stores would have been
spent, and the men's strength,
364 had not one of the gods pitied me and saved
me:
365 the daughter of mighty Proteus, the Old Man
of the Sea —
366 Eidothea. For I stirred her heart beyond the
rest²²
367 when she met me wandering alone, apart
from my companions —
368 for they were forever roving round the island,
fishing
369 with bent hooks, their bellies pinched with
hunger.
370 She stood close by me and spoke, and said:
371 'Are you a fool, stranger — so slack, so loose of
wit?
372 Or do you slacken by choice, and enjoy your
suffering?
373 So long you are held on the island, and can

find

374 no ending of it, while your companions'
hearts grow small.'

375 So she spoke, and I answered her:

376 'I will say this straight, whichever of the
goddesses you are:

377 I am not held here by any will of mine. I must
have sinned

378 against the deathless ones who hold wide
heaven.

379 But tell me — for the gods know all things —

380 which of the immortals shackles me here and
has bound my road,

381 and my homecoming — how I shall go over
the fish-filled sea.'

382 So I spoke, and the shining goddess answered
at once:

383 'Then I will tell you, stranger, and tell you
truly.

384 There haunts this place an unerring Old Man
of the Sea,

385 deathless Proteus of Egypt, who knows the

depths

386 of every sea — Poseidon's under-servant.**23**

387 He, they say, is my father, who begot me.

388 If you could somehow set an ambush and take
hold of him,

389 he would tell you the road, and the measures
of your journey,

390 and your homecoming — how you shall go
over the fish-filled sea.

391 And he would tell you too, Zeus-nurtured, if
you wish,

392 whatever evil and good have been done in
your halls

393 while you have been gone on your long and
grinding road.'

394 So she spoke, and I answered her:

395 'Devise the ambush yourself, for this old god
—

396 or he will see me first, or know beforehand,
and escape me.

397 A god is hard for a mortal man to master.'

398 So I spoke, and the shining goddess answered

at once:

399 'Then I will tell you, stranger, and tell you
truly.

400 When the sun bestrides the middle of heaven,

401 then the unerring Old Man of the Sea comes
out of the water

402 under the West Wind's breath, hidden in the
dark shiver of the sea,

403 and coming out he beds down under the
hollow caves;

404 and around him seals, the brood of the sea's
lovely daughter,²⁴

405 sleep in a crowd, come up out of the gray salt
water,

406 breathing out the sharp smell of the deep
brine.

407 There I will bring you at the showing of dawn

408 and bed you down in the row. Choose well
three companions,

409 the best you have by the well-benched ships.

410 And I will tell you all the old man's tricks.

411 First he will count his seals, and go over them;

412 and when he has told them off by fives and
seen them all,
413 he will lie down in their midst, like a
herdsman in his flocks.
414 The moment you see him settled down,
415 then let strength and force be all your
thought:
416 hold him there for all his struggling, however
he strains to escape.
417 He will make trial of everything, turning into
all things²⁵
418 that creep upon the earth — into water, into
god-kindled fire;
419 but hold him unshakably, and press him the
harder.
420 And when at last he questions you with words
himself,
421 in the same shape you saw him settle to sleep,
422 then leave off your force, hero: set the old
man loose,
423 and ask him which of the gods bears hard on
you,

424 and your homecoming — how you shall go
over the fish-filled sea.'

425 So speaking she plunged under the surging
sea.

426 And I went to the ships where they stood in
the sand,

427 and my heart ran dark with many things as I
went.

428 And when I had come down to the ship and
the sea,

429 we made our supper, and ambrosial night
came on,

430 and we lay down to sleep on the surf-line of
the sea.

431 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,

432 I set out along the shore of the wide-wayed
sea,

433 praying hard to the gods; and I took three
companions,

434 the three I trusted most for every venture.

435 She meanwhile had slipped under the wide

gulf of the sea

436 and brought up out of the deep four sealskins,

437 all fresh-flayed: she was plotting an ambush
against her own father.

438 She had scooped out beds in the sea-sand

439 and sat there waiting. And we came up close
beside her,

440 and she bedded us down in the row, and
threw a skin over each.

441 There our ambush would have been most
horrible: the deadly26

442 stench of the salt-bred seals ground us down
horribly —

443 who would lay himself down beside a beast of
the sea? —

444 but she herself saved us; she devised a great
relief:

445 she brought ambrosia and set it under each
man's nose,

446 breathing sweetness, and it killed the stench
of the beast.

447 All the morning we waited, with enduring

hearts,

448 and the seals came crowding up out of the
sea, and then

449 lay down in rows along the surf-line of the
sea;

450 and at midday the old man came out of the
sea, and found his fat

451 seals, and went over them all, and counted the
number —

452 and among the beasts he counted us the first,
his heart

453 never guessing the trick. Then he too lay
down.

454 Then we rushed him with a shout, and threw
our arms

455 around him; and the old man did not forget
his cunning art,

456 but first he turned to a great-bearded lion,

457 and then to a serpent, a leopard, a huge boar;

458 he turned to running water, to a tree in
towering leaf;

459 and we held on unshakably, with enduring

hearts.

460 But when at last the old man wearied, for all
his tricks,

461 then he questioned me with words, and said:

462 'Which of the gods, son of Atreus, laid the
plan with you

463 to take me by ambush against my will? What
do you need?'

464 So he spoke, and I answered him:

465 'You know, old man — why ask me sideways?

—

466 how long I am held on this island, and can
find

467 no ending of it, and the heart inside me grows
small.

468 But tell me — for the gods know all things —

469 which of the immortals shackles me here and
has bound my road,

470 and my homecoming — how I shall go over
the fish-filled sea.'

471 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:

472 'But you should have offered fair victims to

Zeus and the other

473 gods before embarking, to come most quickly

474 to your own country, sailing the wine-dark
sea.

475 For it is not your portion to see your own
people, to reach

476 your well-built house and your own
fatherland,

477 before you go back again to the waters of
Egypt,

478 the river fallen from Zeus, and offer holy
hecatombs²⁷

479 to the deathless gods who hold wide heaven.

480 Then the gods will give you the road you long
for.'

481 So he spoke, and my heart broke within me,

482 because he sent me back over the misted sea

483 to Egypt again — the long and grinding road.

484 Even so I answered him and said:

485 'All this I will do, old man, just as you
command.

486 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

487 did all the Achaeans come home unharmed in
their ships,

488 all whom Nestor and I left behind when we
sailed from Troy?

489 Or did any die a bitter death aboard his ship,

490 or in the arms of his friends, once he had
wound the war to its end?’

491 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:

492 ‘Son of Atreus, why ask me this? You have no
need

493 to know, no need to learn my mind. Not long,
I tell you,

494 will you keep from tears, once you have heard
the whole of it.

495 Many of them were broken, and many were
left;

496 but of the leaders of the bronze-shirted
Achaeans, two

497 alone died on the homeward way — the
fighting you saw yourself —

498 and one, still living somewhere, is held back
on the wide sea.

499 Ajax was broken among his long-oared
ships.28

500 Poseidon drove him first against the great
rocks

501 of Gyrae — and yet he saved him from the sea;

502 and he would have escaped his doom, though
Athena hated him,

503 had he not flung out an overweening word in
his great blindness:

504 he said it was in the gods' despite he had
escaped the great gulf of the sea.

505 Poseidon heard his loud boasting,

506 and straightway took his trident in his
massive hands

507 and struck the rock of Gyrae, and split it
apart:

508 one part held its place, but the broken piece
fell in the sea —

509 the piece where Ajax sat when the great
blindness took him —

510 and it carried him down into the boundless
surging deep.

511 So he died there, when he had drunk the salt
water.

512 But your brother somehow slipped the fates,
escaped them

513 in his hollow ships: the lady Hera saved him.

514 Yet when he was all but come to the steep
height

515 of Malea, then a storm-wind snatched him up

516 and carried him, groaning heavily, over the
fish-filled sea

517 to the border of the country where Thyestes
once

518 had his house, and now Thyestes' son
Aegisthus lived.

519 But when from there too a safe homecoming
showed,

520 and the gods turned the wind fair, and they
reached home —

521 oh, rejoicing he set foot on his fathers' land,29

522 and touched his country and kissed it: the hot
tears

523 streamed from him, so glad he was to see his

land.

524 But from a lookout a watchman saw him —
posted there

525 by Aegisthus of the crooked counsels, who
had promised him

526 two talents of gold for wages: a full year he
had watched,

527 so the king might not slip past unseen and
remember his fighting strength.

528 The man went with his news to the house, to
the shepherd of the people,

529 and at once Aegisthus laid his treacherous
craft:

530 he picked the twenty best men in the land

531 and set an ambush, and across the hall he
ordered a feast made ready;

532 and then he went to summon Agamemnon,
shepherd of the people,

533 with horses and chariots — and unspeakable
things in his mind.

534 He led him up unwitting of his death, and
killed him

535 at the dinner — as a man cuts down an ox at
the manger.³⁰

536 Not one of the companions of Atreus' son was
left, who followed him,

537 and not one of Aegisthus' men: they were
killed in the halls.'

538 So he spoke, and my heart broke within me,

539 and I wept, sitting there in the sand; my heart

540 had no more will to live and see the light of
the sun.

541 But when I had had my fill of weeping and
writhing,

542 then the unerring Old Man of the Sea said to
me:

543 'No more now, son of Atreus, this long
unbending

544 weeping: we shall find no cure in it. Quick as
you can,

545 try how you may come back to your own
fatherland.

546 Either you will find him alive — or Orestes

547 has already killed him first, and you may

come in time for the burying.'

548 So he spoke; and the heart and the proud
spirit in my breast,

549 for all my grieving, were warmed again,

550 and lifting my voice I spoke winged words to
him:

551 'These men I now know of. But name the third
man:

552 the one still living, held back on the wide sea

—

553 or dead. Grieved as I am, I want to hear it.'

554 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:

555 'The son of Laertes, whose home is in
Ithaca.**31**

556 I saw him on an island, letting the big tears
fall,

557 in the halls of the nymph Calypso, who holds
him there

558 by force; and he cannot come to his own
fatherland,

559 for he has no ships at hand, no oars, no
companions

560 to carry him over the broad back of the sea.
561 But for you, Zeus-nurtured Menelaus, it is not
fated32
562 to die in horse-grazing Argos and meet your
doom:
563 the deathless ones will carry you to the
Elysian plain
564 and the ends of the earth — where fair-haired
Rhadamanthus is,
565 where life is easiest of all for men:
566 no snow, no heavy winter, never rain,
567 but always Ocean sends up the breath of the
singing West Wind
568 to bring men coolness —
569 because Helen is yours, and you are son-in-
law to Zeus.’
570 So speaking he plunged under the surging
sea.
571 And I went to the ships with my godlike
companions,
572 and my heart ran dark with many things as I
went.

573 And when we had come down to the ship and
the sea,

574 we made our supper, and ambrosial night
came on,

575 and we lay down to sleep on the surf-line of
the sea.

576 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,

577 first of all we hauled our ships down to the
bright salt water

578 and set the masts and the sails in the trim
ships,

579 and the men came aboard and took their
places at the oarlocks,

580 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt
water with their oars.

581 Back to Egypt I brought the ships, to the river

582 fallen from Zeus, and I offered the full
hecatombs;

583 and when I had put to rest the anger of the
gods who are forever,

584 I heaped a mound for Agamemnon, that his

fame might never be quenched.³³

⁵⁸⁵ That done, I sailed for home, and the
immortals gave me

⁵⁸⁶ a wind, and brought me quickly to my own
dear country.

⁵⁸⁷ But come now — stay on in my halls

⁵⁸⁸ until the eleventh day, or the twelfth;

⁵⁸⁹ then I will send you off with honor, and give
you shining gifts:

⁵⁹⁰ three horses and a polished chariot; and
besides

⁵⁹¹ I will give you a beautiful cup, so that you may
pour

⁵⁹² to the deathless gods and remember me all
your days.”

⁵⁹³ Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:

⁵⁹⁴ “Son of Atreus, do not hold me here for long.

⁵⁹⁵ A year I could gladly sit here at your side

⁵⁹⁶ and no ache for home or parents would take
me:

⁵⁹⁷ such strange delight I have in hearing your

tales

598 and your words. But my companions chafe
already

599 in holy Pylos, and you would hold me long
here.

600 As for the gift you would give me — let it be
some treasure.

601 The horses I will not take to Ithaca: I will leave
them here³⁴

602 for you, for your own glory. For you are lord
of a wide plain,

603 where lotus grows in plenty, and galingale,

604 and wheat and spelt and broad white barley.

605 In Ithaca there are no wide courses, no
meadowland at all:

606 goat-pasture — and lovelier to me than horse-
pasture.

607 Not one of the islands that lean on the sea is
fit for driving horses,

608 or rich in meadows — and Ithaca beyond
them all.”

609 So he spoke; and Menelaus of the great war-

cry smiled,**35**

610 and stroked him with his hand, and spoke a word, and named him:

611 “You are of good blood, dear child — such things you say!

612 Then I will change the gifts for you; well I can.

613 Of all the treasures lying stored in my house

614 I will give you the most beautiful, the most honored:

615 I will give you a wrought mixing-bowl — all silver

616 it is, and its rims are finished off in gold —

617 the work of Hephaestus. The hero Phaedimus gave it,**36**

618 king of the Sidonians, when his house sheltered me

619 on my way home there. This I would send with you.”

620 So the two of them spoke such things to one another,

621 while the feasters came up to the godlike king’s house,

622 driving sheep before them, carrying wine that
puts heart in men,37

623 and their fair-veiled wives sent bread along
with them.

624 So they labored at the feast in the halls.

625 But the suitors, in front of Odysseus' hall,

626 were amusing themselves with discus and
javelin throws

627 on the leveled ground, insolent as ever, where
they always played.

628 There Antinous sat, and godlike Eurymachus,

629 chiefs of the suitors, in prowess far the best of
them all.

630 To them Noemon, Phronius' son, came up

631 and questioned Antinous, and said:

632 "Antinous, do we know at all — or not —

633 when Telemachus comes back from sandy
Pylos?

634 He went off with my ship, and now I need her

635 to cross to Elis of the wide dancing-grounds,
where I keep twelve

636 brood mares, with hard-working mules at the

teat,

637 unbroken: I would drive one off and break
him in.”

638 So he spoke, and their hearts were
astonished: they had never thought

639 he had gone to Neleian Pylos — surely he was
somewhere near,

640 out at the farms with the flocks, or with the
swineherd.

641 Then Antinous, Euphithes’ son, answered him:

642 “Tell me the truth of it: when did he go, and
what young men

643 went with him? Picked men of Ithaca — or his
own

644 hired hands and slaves? He could manage
even that!

645 And tell me this too, honestly, so that I may
know it:

646 did he take the black ship from you by force,
against your will,

647 or did you give it freely, because he begged
you with fine words?”

648 Then Noemon, Phronius' son, answered him:
649 "I gave it freely, myself. What would any man
do
650 when such a man, with cares heavy on his
heart,
651 asked? It would be hard to refuse the gift.
652 The young men who went with him are the
best in the land
653 after ourselves. And for their leader I marked
654 Mentor going aboard — or a god, the very
image of him.**38**
655 But here is what I wonder at: I saw noble
Mentor
656 yesterday at dawn, right here — and he had
boarded the ship for Pylos."
657 So he spoke, and went away to his father's
house.
658 And the proud hearts of the two of them were
stunned.
659 They sat the suitors down in a body and
stopped their games,
660 and among them spoke Antinous, Eupeithes'

son,

661 in anger: his black-brimming heart was
hugely

662 filled with fury, and his eyes were like blazing
fire:

663 “Damn it all — a great work insolently
accomplished,

664 this voyage of Telemachus! And we said it
would come to nothing.

665 In the teeth of all of us, a mere boy has simply
gone:

666 hauled down a ship, and picked the best men
in the land.

667 He will begin to be our ruin, and soon. May
Zeus

668 destroy his strength before he reaches the
measure of manhood!

669 But come, give me a fast ship and twenty
companions,39

670 so I may watch for him and ambush him on
his way home,

671 in the strait between Ithaca and rugged Samos

—
672 so this sailing after his father may cost him
grim and dear.”

673 So he spoke, and they all approved it and
urged it on.

674 They rose at once and went into the house of
Odysseus.

675 Nor was Penelope long in ignorance

676 of the schemes the suitors were brewing deep
in their hearts:

677 for the herald Medon told her, who had
overheard their plans,

678 standing outside the court while they wove
their plot within.

679 He went through the house to bring the news
to Penelope,

680 and as he crossed the threshold Penelope said
to him:

681 “Herald, why have the lordly suitors sent you
in?

682 To tell the slave-women of godlike Odysseus

683 to leave their work and make the feast ready

for them?

684 May they never woo again, never gather
anywhere else —

685 may this be the last supper they ever eat here,

686 they who swarm in day after day and shear
away the living,

687 the substance of clear-headed Telemachus!

Did you never hear,

688 in years gone by, when you were children,
from your fathers,

689 what kind of man Odysseus was among your
parents' generation?

690 Never a deed out of measure, never an unjust
word40

691 in all the land — though that is the way of
godlike kings:

692 one mortal a king will hate, another he may
love;

693 but that man never did outrage to a single
soul.

694 No — your hearts are on show, and your ugly
works:

695 there is no gratitude left, afterward, for good
deeds done.”

696 Then Medon answered her, a man of clear-
headed sense:

697 “Would to god, my queen, that this were the
worst of it.

698 A greater evil by far, and harder to bear,

699 the suitors are plotting now — may the son of
Cronos never accomplish it:

700 they are bent on cutting Telemachus down
with the sharp bronze

701 on his way home. He went for news of his
father

702 to holy Pylos and to shining Lacedaemon.”

703 So he spoke, and there where she stood her
knees went loose, and her heart;

704 for a long time speechlessness held her
words; her eyes

705 filled up with tears; the flower of her voice
was stopped.**41**

706 At long last she found words to answer him:

707 “Herald, why is my child gone? There was no

need

708 to board the fast-running ships, that are
men's horses⁴²

709 of the salt water, and cross the great wet
waste.

710 Is it so that not even his name should be left
among men?"

711 Then Medon answered her, a man of clear-
headed sense:

712 "I do not know whether some god stirred him,
or whether his own

713 heart drove him to go to Pylos, to learn

714 either his father's homecoming, or what doom
he met."

715 So he spoke, and went away down through the
house of Odysseus.

716 And heart-eating anguish poured around her;
she could no longer

717 bear to sit on a chair, though the house was
full of them,

718 but sank down on the threshold of her richly-
worked chamber,

719 moaning pitiably; and around her whimpered
the slave-women,
720 all of them, young and old, that the house
held.
721 And sobbing hard, Penelope said among them:
722 “Hear me, dear women. The Olympian has
given me sorrows
723 beyond all the women who were bred and
born beside me.
724 Long ago I lost my noble husband, the lion-
hearted, **43**
725 graced among the Danaans with every
excellence,
726 that noble man, whose fame goes wide
through Hellas and the heart of Argos.
727 And now again the storm-winds have
snatched my beloved son,
728 without glory, out of these halls, and I never
heard him go.
729 Hard-hearted! Not even you — not one of you
— thought
730 to wake me from my bed, though your hearts

knew well

731 the hour he went down to the black hollow
ship.

732 If I had learned that he was pondering this
journey,

733 then either he would have stayed, for all his
hunger for the road,

734 or he would have left me dead in these halls
behind him.

735 But now let someone run and call old
Dolius, **44**

736 my slave, whom my father gave me when I
first came here,

737 who keeps my orchard of many trees — so
that quickly

738 he may go sit beside Laertes and tell him all of
it.

739 Perhaps Laertes may weave some plan in his
heart,

740 and come out and weep before the people,
who are bent

741 on destroying his line and the line of godlike

Odysseus.”

742 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia said to her:

743 “Dear bride — kill me with the pitiless
bronze⁴⁵

744 or leave me in the house, but I will not hide
the story from you.

745 I knew all of it. I gave him what he ordered,

746 bread and sweet wine. And he took a great
oath from me

747 not to tell you before the twelfth day came,

748 or you missed him yourself and heard that he
was gone —

749 so you would not mar your lovely skin with
weeping.

750 Now bathe, and take clean clothing for your
body,

751 and go up to your upper room with your
attendant women,

752 and pray to Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing
Zeus:

753 she may yet save him, even out of death itself.

754 And do not grieve a grieving old man more. I

cannot think

755 the blessed gods have wholly hated the line

756 of Arceisius' son: someone will yet be left to
hold46

757 the high-roofed house and the fat fields far
around."

758 So she spoke, and lulled her lament, and
stayed her eyes from weeping.

759 And she bathed, and took clean clothing for
her body,

760 and went up to her upper room with her
attendant women,

761 and set the barley-grains in a basket, and
prayed to Athena:47

762 "Hear me, child of aegis-bearing Zeus,
Unwearied One.

763 If ever Odysseus of the many designs, in these
halls,

764 burned fat thigh-cuts of ox or sheep for you,

765 remember them for me now: save my dear
son,

766 and beat away the suitors in their evil

overbearing pride.”

767 So she cried the ritual cry; and the goddess
heard her prayer.

768 But the suitors broke into uproar through the
shadowy halls,

769 and thus would one of the arrogant young
men say:

770 “So the much-courted queen is making ready
a marriage

771 for one of us — and knows nothing of the
death prepared for her son.”

772 So they would say — knowing nothing of what
was prepared.48

773 And Antinous addressed them all, and said:

774 “Fools! Keep clear of overweening talk of any
kind —

775 or someone may carry the word inside.

776 Up now, in silence, and let us accomplish

777 the plan that pleased us all in our hearts.”

778 So he spoke, and picked the twenty best men,

779 and they went down to the fast ship and the
sand-beach of the sea.

780 First of all they hauled the ship down to deep
water,
781 and set the mast and the sails in the black
ship,
782 and fitted the oars into their leather slings,
783 all in due order, and spread the white sails
open;
784 and high-spirited henchmen carried down
their arms.
785 They moored her well out in the water, and
came ashore,
786 and there they took their supper, and waited
for evening to come.
787 But she in her upper room, watchful-minded
Penelope,
788 lay fasting, tasting neither food nor drink,
789 turning it over: whether her blameless son
would escape death,
790 or be broken under the overweening suitors.
791 As a lion turns and turns amid a crowd of
men,⁴⁹
792 in dread, as they draw the treacherous circle

round him,

793 so she was turning when the deep sleep came
upon her;

794 and she sank back and slept, and all her joints
went loose.

795 Then the goddess thought of one thing more,
gray-eyed Athena.

796 She made a phantom, fashioned in the
likeness of a woman —50

797 Iphthime, daughter of great-hearted Icarius,

798 wed to Eumelus, whose home was in Pherae —

799 and sent it to the house of godlike Odysseus,

800 so that it might bring Penelope, weeping and
mourning,

801 some pause from lamentation and tear-filled
grief.

802 Into the chamber it came, past the strap of
the bolt,

803 and stood above her head, and said to her:

804 “Do you sleep, Penelope, your heart worn
with grief?

805 No — the gods who live at ease will not have

you

806 weep and be anguished: for your son has his
homecoming

807 still; he is no sinner in the sight of the gods.”

808 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
her —

809 slumbering very sweetly at the gates of
dream:51

810 “Why have you come here, sister? You have
not been

811 used to come before: your home is far away.

812 And you bid me leave off my misery and all
the pains

813 that crowd my mind and heart.

814 Long ago I lost my noble husband, the lion-
hearted,

815 graced among the Danaans with every
excellence,

816 that noble man, whose fame goes wide
through Hellas and the heart of Argos.

817 And now again my beloved son has gone in a
hollow ship,

818 a mere boy, unpracticed in hardships and the
meetings of men.

819 It is for him I mourn even more than for that
other;

820 for him I tremble, for him I fear, that
something may strike him,

821 whether among the men of the land he has
gone to, or on the sea.

822 For many enemies are scheming against him,

823 hungry to kill him before he comes back to
his own country.”

824 And the dim phantom answered her:

825 “Take heart. Do not fear too greatly in your
mind.

826 Such an escort goes with him as other men

827 have prayed to have stand beside them — for
she has power —

828 Pallas Athena. And she pities you your
grieving:

829 it is she who sent me now to tell you this.”

830 Then watchful-minded Penelope said to her:

831 “If you are truly a god, and have heard the

voice of a god,

832 then come — tell me also of that other, that
man of sorrow:

833 does he live still somewhere, and see the light
of the sun,

834 or is he dead already, down in the house of
Hades?”

835 And the dim phantom answered her:

836 “Of him I will not tell the story through —

837 whether he lives or is dead. It is evil to speak
words empty as wind.”⁵²

838 So speaking it slipped away by the doorpost
bolt

839 into the breath of the winds. And the
daughter of Icarius

840 started up out of sleep, and her heart was
warmed:

841 so vivid a dream had rushed upon her in the
dark hour of the night.

842 But the suitors had embarked, and were
sailing the watery ways,

843 turning over in their hearts sheer murder for

Telemachus.

844 There is a rocky island in the middle of the sea,

845 midway between Ithaca and rugged Samos —

846 Asteris, no great place; but there are harbors in it

847 fit for ships to lurk in, open at either end.

There the Achaeans waited in ambush.⁵³

Notes

NOTES

1. κητώεσσον, “land of ravines” — an old puzzle-word: “full of hollows” (from the ravined Laconian landscape), or “full of sea-monsters” (κηῆτος), which fits the sea, not inland Sparta. I take the ravines; the strangeness was already ancient. ↩
2. The double wedding: Hermione is sent to Achilles’ son Neoptolemus (a marriage promised at Troy — tragedy later made it disastrous), while the home-wedding is for Megapenthes, Menelaus’ son by a slave-woman. Two facts are placed without comment: the gods gave Helen no child after Hermione, and Megapenthes’ name means “Great-Grief” — a son named for the sorrow of the years his father was winning Helen back. ↩

3. Menelaus' first act is to snap at his own herald for even *asking* whether to receive strangers — “we two ate plenty of strangers' bread.” Hospitality here is autobiography: the wanderer feeds wanderers. The scene is a deliberate foil to Ithaca, where the uninvited eat the host. ↩
4. “A sheen as of the sun or the moon” — the same line used of Alcinous' fairy-tale palace at 7.84. Sparta glows like Phaeacia; Telemachus has stepped out of his broken house into the two most luminous courts in the poem, one after the other. ↩
5. Telemachus' whisper of awe (σέβας μ' ἔχει, “awe takes me”) is answered at 142 by Helen using the identical phrase about *him*. The guest marvels at the house; the hostess marvels at the guest. It is the book's first hint of its master theme: recognition. ↩
6. “Another man killed my brother... through the treachery of his cursed wife.” The Agamemnon story keeps arriving before Odysseus' story can be told — here as the poison in Menelaus' wealth. Note that Menelaus blames the wife more directly than Nestor did; every speaker in the poem calibrates Clytemnestra differently. ↩
7. Helen's entrance is staged like an epiphany — “like Artemis of the golden distaff” — with a full inventory of her equipment, all of it Egyptian luxury: the silver basket on wheels, the distaff wound with violet-dark wool. The woman who caused the war enters as the image of chaste domesticity (Artemis! wool-work!), and the poem lets the irony stand without a word. ↩
8. “Shall I lie, or speak the truth? My heart bids me speak.” The question is formulaic — Nestor asks it nearly word for word at

Iliad 10.534 — and what it prefaces here is an identification, not a tale. But from Helen, weighing falsehood aloud in the act of performing sincerity, it can be heard as the key in which the whole evening's storytelling is set. ↩

9. κυνώπιδος, “bitch-faced that I was”: Helen's savage word for herself (as at *Iliad* 3.180). Whether it is real remorse or the performance of remorse — charming, disarming, unanswerable — is exactly what the poem declines to settle. ↩
10. Menelaus' fantasy for Odysseus: he would have *emptied a city* of its inhabitants to resettle his friend next door. The casualness of “emptying out one town” is a king's love-language — and a measure of the power Telemachus is standing in front of. ↩
11. Antilochus, Nestor's son, was killed by Memnon, “the shining son of bright Dawn” — a story from the lost *Aethiopis*, alluded to as known. Peisistratus weeps for a brother he was too young to meet (200–201): grief at one remove, the Telemachy's signature emotion. ↩
12. “This is the only honor left to miserable mortals, / to cut a lock of hair and let a tear fall down the cheek.” Peisistratus' definition of mourning is the poem's most compact statement of what the living owe the dead — and why denying Odysseus a funeral (he is neither alive nor buried) is an open wound. ↩
13. The famous νηπενθές, “nepenthes” — the drug “that undoes grief and anger and brings forgetfulness of every evil,” Egyptian, from Polydamna wife of Thon. The specification is chilling if read slowly: you could watch your brother butchered before your face and not weep *that day*. Helen administers chemical composure so that Troy can be discussed at dinner —

the hostess drugging her guests into painless memory. Everything told for the next seventy lines is told under its influence. ↩

14. Note who commands the room: Helen proposes the evening's entertainment, tells the first tale, and names its genre ("one that fits the hour"). Menelaus answers, seconds, and caps her. The marriage runs on her stage-management, and the poem lets us watch it run. ↩
15. "Here is one thing that mighty man did and dared" — the frame-line Helen and Menelaus each use (242, 271) to introduce their tales, and the hinge of the book's central irony. Helen's story: Odysseus came disguised as a beggar; *I alone* recognized him, helped him, kept his secret; my heart had already turned home. Menelaus' story, immediately after: you circled the horse imitating our wives' voices to lure us to our deaths — with your *new* Trojan husband Deiphobus at your side. Two Helens, mutually annihilating, told back to back over drugged wine, in perfect courtesy. The poem's deepest lesson in how memory is made — and it is also a preview: an Odysseus disguised in a beggar's rags, recognized only by a discerning woman, is the plot of Books 17–23. ↩
16. "Some spirit must have moved you" — Menelaus offers his wife the divine-agency excuse even while telling the story that damns her; courtesy and accusation in one clause. Deiphobus, named at 276, was the Trojan who married Helen after Paris' death: the detail quietly dates her "heart had already turned home" claim. ↩

17. The Anticlus episode (285–289) was suspected already in antiquity as an import from the epic cycle — Aristarchus athetized the lines. Genuine or grafted, the image earns its place: Odysseus saving the army by clamping a man’s mouth shut with his bare hands is endurance-cunning at its most physical. ↩
18. Lines 322–331 repeat Telemachus’ plea to Nestor (3.92–101) verbatim, and the translation repeats itself verbatim: the boy has a set speech for great men now, and the poem lets us hear him reuse it — a young envoy’s professionalism, learned in a week. ↩
19. The deer who beds her fawns in the lion’s lair: the suitors’ simile of doom, repeated later word for word when Telemachus reports this conversation to Penelope (17.124–131). The fawns are “newborn” and “suckling” — the pathos is with the doomed, and the poem does not flinch from it: that is what the lion’s homecoming means. ↩
20. γέρων ἄλιος νημερτής, “the unerring Old Man of the Sea” — Proteus’ fixed formula. His epithet is *truthfulness*; the shapeshifter is the poem’s most reliable informant. Forms lie; the voice, once you hold on long enough, cannot. ↩
21. Pharos — the island of the later lighthouse — is in fact a bowshot off the Egyptian coast, not “a whole day’s sail.” Poetic geography: the poem needs an island prison, so the map stretches. ↩
22. Eidothea betrays her own father’s resting-hour and provides the disguise, the ambrosia, everything — and the poem never says why. She is the first of the poem’s chain of women who rescue

a stranded hero — goddesses like Calypso under orders and Ino with her veil, and, mortal in the same office, Nausicaa at the river; the folk-tale does not require her motive, and Homer, unusually, does not invent one. ↩

23. Proteus is “Poseidon’s under-servant” (ὑποδμῶς) — the seal-herd of the hostile god, milked for intelligence behind his master’s back. Menelaus’ salvation runs through the enemy’s own household, as Odysseus’ will. ↩
24. “The brood of the sea’s lovely daughter” — Halosydne, “sea-born one,” a title of the sea-goddess (elsewhere of Thetis). The seals are her nursery; the Old Man counts them “by fives” like a herdsman tallying — the sea as a pastoral economy, complete with flocks, folds, and noon rest. ↩
25. The catalogue — lion, serpent, leopard, boar, running water, flowering tree — is the source of the word “protean.” Note the instruction: the shapes are endured, not fought; you win against transformation by gripping and waiting. It is hard not to read the poem’s own method in it: hold on through every disguise until the thing speaks in its true form. ↩
26. Epic comedy, rare and precious: four heroes gagging under fresh-flayed sealskins (“who would lay himself down beside a beast of the sea?”), saved by a goddess dabbing ambrosia under each nose. The *Iliad* puts ambrosia to solemn practical work — preserving Patroclus’ body (19.38–39), staying Achilles’ hunger — but only here is it a peg for the nose. ↩
27. The Nile is “the river fallen from Zeus” (διπτετός) — rain-fed from heaven, the standard Homeric epithet for rivers, but

applied to Egypt it carries the old Greek wonder at a river whose flood comes without rain. ↩

28. The death of the Oilean Ajax, in eleven lines: Poseidon saves him from the wreck Athena sent, and kills him only for the boast “I escaped in the gods’ despite.” The word *ἄασθη* — the blindness, the ruinous folly — tolls twice (503, 509). It is Zeus’ complaint from 1.32–43 played out to the letter: suffering beyond his portion, and Ajax himself handed the god the instrument. ↩
29. Agamemnon’s homecoming compressed to its cruelest arc: the kiss on home soil, the hot tears of joy — and the watchman already paid a year’s wages of gold to see him do it. Surveillance hired against joy itself. ↩
30. “As a man cuts down an ox at the manger” — the poem’s definitive line for Agamemnon’s death, repeated by his own ghost at 11.411. The king is slaughtered not as a warrior but as a stalled animal, at dinner — the perversion of the feast that the whole *Odyssey* is built to avenge in its own hall. ↩
31. The third man, at last: eight lines, and the poem’s first eyewitness image of its hero *as he now is* — not Helen’s and Menelaus’ remembered Odysseus inside Troy, but Odysseus on Calypso’s island “letting the big tears fall,” shipless, oarless, companionless. Telemachus came for exactly this: his father is alive, weeping, and held. Book 5 opens from this image. ↩
32. The Elysian plain: the earliest appearance of Elysium in Greek literature — no snow, no winter, no rain, Ocean’s singing West Wind forever. And the reason Menelaus is exempted from death is stated with shocking frankness: not virtue, not valor,

but marriage — “because Helen is yours, and you are son-in-law to Zeus.” Immortality by in-law. ↩

33. Menelaus heaps an empty mound (a cenotaph) for Agamemnon in Egypt “that his fame might never be quenched” — the exact honor Telemachus said he would perform for Odysseus if confirmed dead (2.222). Fame requires a marker; the poem keeps insisting on the architecture of memory. ↩
34. Telemachus’ refusal of the horses is his diplomatic coming-of-age: he declines a king’s gift, praises the giver’s plain, and turns his own island’s poverty into a boast — “goat-pasture, and lovelier to me than horse-pasture.” It is the poem’s love-song for thin soil, and Odysseus will sing the same key about Ithaca at 9.27 (“rough ground, but a good nurse of men”). ↩
35. Menelaus *smiles* — the first smile in the Odyssey — and strokes the boy’s hand: “You are of good blood, dear child.” The gift is upgraded, not withdrawn: the silver bowl by Hephaestus, from the king of Sidon. It will reach Ithaca in Book 15 and pass into the house’s treasury: the visit’s one durable object. ↩
36. The bowl’s pedigree is recited like a lineage: made by Hephaestus, given by Phaedimus king of Sidon, now passed to Telemachus. Great objects in Homer travel through chains of guest-friendship, and their history is their value — each gift carries the names of everyone who honored someone with it. ↩
37. A glimpse of how a great feast is provisioned: the guests drive the sheep and carry the wine, their wives send the bread. The Spartan feast is a contribution-feast (an *eranos*) — precisely the institution Athena said the suitors’ feasting was *not* (1.226). ↩

38. Noemon's puzzle — he saw Mentor here at dawn *and* boarding the ship — is a mortal noticing the seam in a divine disguise. He shrugs it off (“or a god, the very image of him”), which is exactly how the poem's ordinary people survive their brushes with the uncanny: by not pressing the question. ↪
39. “But come, give me a fast ship and twenty companions” — Antinous plots the murder in the *identical line* with which Telemachus asked for his voyage (2.212), and the translation repeats it word for word. The ambusher speaks in his victim's formula; twenty men to kill the boy who asked for twenty oars. ↪
40. Penelope's ideal-king speech: a king may hate one man and love another — favoritism is royal prerogative — “but that man never did outrage to a single soul.” It matches Mentor's bitter assembly-speech (2.230–234) almost thought for thought. Husband and wife keep the same political theology without having spoken in twenty years. ↪
41. “The flower of her voice was stopped” — θαλερή φωνή, literally her “blooming” voice choked off. The Greek gives grief a botany; I kept it. ↪
42. Ships as “men's horses of the salt water” — Penelope's kenning, and a mother's: to her the sea is a place her child has been carried off to by animals she never learned to ride. ↪
43. Lines 724–726 return verbatim at 814–816, in the dream: Penelope's lament for the lion-hearted husband has hardened into a formula of her own — grief so long practiced it has fixed wording. ↪

44. Dolius, the old orchard-slave who came with Penelope's dowry, will still be tending trees beside Laertes in Book 24, where he and his sons arm for the poem's last fight. The household's memory runs through its slaves; the poem keeps their genealogies as carefully as the kings'. ↩
45. νύμφα φίλη, "dear bride": Eurycleia addresses the gray-haired queen with the word for a young newlywed. For the nurse, time stopped the day the marriage was whole. One vocative carries thirty years. ↩
46. "The line of Arceisius' son": Arceisius fathered Laertes — the poem counts the endangered dynasty in its full four generations, one thread of it now asleep in Sparta and twenty ambushers waiting in the strait. ↩
47. Penelope's prayer is a sacrifice with no victim: barley-grains in a basket — the rite's opening gesture (cf. 3.445) offered by itself, with no victim behind it — and then the ὀλολυγή, the women's ritual cry that in Book 3 crowned the killing of the heifer (3.450). She performs the frame of sacrifice around an empty center. Athena hears her anyway. ↩
48. "So they would say — knowing nothing of what was prepared": the mockers think death is prepared for Telemachus; the narrator's line quietly reads both ways. What has been "prepared," two books deep and building, is theirs. ↩
49. The lion at bay — ringed by the hunters' "treacherous circle" — is Penelope: Homer's boldest reassignment of his most masculine simile. She is not the lion rampaging (that was Odysseus at 4.335–340); she is the lion surrounded, magnificent and cornered. The pair of lion similes, set at opposite ends of

the book, are the marriage in absentia: same animal, opposite predicaments. ↩

50. The εἶδωλον — a breathing phantom in the likeness of Penelope's sister Iphthime, sent by Athena, entering “past the strap of the bolt” like drift of air. Dream-physics in Homer is precise: dreams are manufactured objects, delivered through the keyhole, with authorized scripts — note that the phantom answers the Odysseus question with a flat refusal (836–837). Comfort is rationed exactly. ↩
51. “At the gates of dream” — ἐν ὀνειρείῃσι πύλῃσιν: the dream-world has an architecture with gates, which Penelope herself will map in her famous speech on the gates of horn and ivory (19.562–567). The image is planted here first, in her sleep. ↩
52. “It is evil to speak words empty as wind” — ἀνεμῶλια, wind-words. The phantom that is itself made of wind (it exits “into the breath of the winds,” 839) refuses to speak wind-words about Odysseus: even Athena's fabrications observe a strict economy of truth. Penelope wakes *warmed* — a mercy beyond the sweet sleep Athena has poured on her weeping before (1.363–364). ↩
53. The Telemachy closes not on the boy but on the trap: Asteris, the two-mouthed harbor, the picked twenty waiting. Four books have built a world where a feast can be an ambush and a strait can be a noose — and the poem now leaves everyone suspended there, and cuts, at last, to Olympus and Calypso's island: Book 5, and Odysseus himself. ↩

Odyssey — Book 5

*Calypso's island: the raft, Poseidon's storm, the landing
on Scheria.*

- 1 And Dawn rose from her bed beside lordly
Tithonus¹
- 2 to carry light to the immortals and to mortals;
3 and the gods were sitting down in council,
among them
- 4 Zeus who thunders on high, whose power is
greatest.
- 5 And Athena was telling over the many cares of
Odysseus,
- 6 remembering: it galled her that he was still in
the nymph's house:
- 7 "Father Zeus, and you other blessed gods who
are forever:
- 8 let no sceptered king ever again be willingly²
9 kind and gentle, or know the right way in his
heart;

10 let him rather be harsh always, and act outrage

—

11 since no one remembers godlike Odysseus

12 among the people he ruled, and he was gentle
as a father.

13 No — he lies on an island suffering strong pains

14 in the halls of the nymph Calypso, who holds
him there

15 by force; and he cannot come to his own
fatherland,

16 for he has no ships at hand, no oars, no
companions

17 to carry him over the broad back of the sea.

18 And now, besides, men are bent on killing his
beloved son

19 on his way home: he went for news of his
father

20 to holy Pylos and to shining Lacedaemon.”

21 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered
her:

22 “My child, what a word has slipped the fence
of your teeth!

23 Was it not you who framed this plan yourself —

3

24 that Odysseus should come home and take
vengeance on those men?

25 As for Telemachus: guide him with your skill —
you have the power —

26 so that he reaches his own fatherland
untouched,

27 and the suitors come back in their ship with
nothing done.”

28 He spoke, and turned to Hermes, his dear son:

29 “Hermes — you are our messenger in all things
else:

30 tell the nymph of the lovely braids our fixed
decree:

31 the homecoming of enduring-hearted
Odysseus — that he shall return

32 with no escort of gods and none of mortal
men:

33 on a raft bound plank to plank, and suffering
pains,

34 on the twentieth day he shall reach rich-soiled

Scheria,⁴

³⁵ the land of the Phaeacians, who are born close kin to the gods.

³⁶ They will honor him with all their hearts, like a god,

³⁷ and send him in a ship to his own dear fatherland,

³⁸ giving him bronze and gold and clothing in plenty,

³⁹ more than Odysseus would ever have carried out of Troy

⁴⁰ had he come home untouched with his fair share of the spoils.

⁴¹ For so it is his portion: to see his own people and come

⁴² to his high-roofed house and his own fatherland.”

⁴³ So he spoke, and the guide, the slayer of Argus, did not disobey.

⁴⁴ At once he bound beneath his feet the beautiful sandals,

⁴⁵ ambrosial, golden, that carry him over the

water

46 and over the boundless earth with the breath
of the wind;

47 and he took up the rod with which he charms
men's eyes⁵

48 to sleep, whose eyes he wills, and wakes others
from their slumber.

49 With this in his hands the strong slayer of
Argus flew.

50 He stepped down on Pieria, then dropped from
the high air to the sea

51 and skimmed along the waves like a
shearwater,⁶

52 the bird that down the terrible troughs of the
barren sea

53 hunts fish, and wets its beating wings in the
brine:

54 like that bird Hermes rode the crowding waves.

55 But when he reached the island, far away,

56 he stepped from the violet sea onto dry land

57 and went on till he came to the great cave
where the nymph

58 of the lovely braids was living; he found her
within.

59 A great fire was burning on the hearth, and the
smell7

60 of split cedar and citron-wood burning carried
far,

61 all over the island. Inside, she was singing in a
beautiful voice,

62 moving to and fro at the loom, weaving with a
golden shuttle.

63 And around the cave a wood grew tall and
flourishing:

64 alder and black poplar and sweet-smelling
cypress,

65 where long-winged birds made their roosts,

66 little owls and hawks and long-tongued crows

67 of the sea, whose business is the waters.

68 And there, trained over the hollow of the cave,
spread

69 a garden vine in its prime, heavy with clusters;

70 and four springs in a row ran with bright
water,

71 close by one another, turned each its own way;
72 and around them soft meadows of violet and
wild celery
73 were blooming. There even a deathless one,
arriving,
74 would gaze in wonder at the sight and be
gladdened at heart.
75 There the guide, the slayer of Argus, stood
gazing.
76 And when his heart had wondered at it all,
77 he went straight into the wide cave. Nor did
Calypso,
78 shining among goddesses, fail to know him
face to face:
79 for the deathless gods are not unknown to one
another,⁸
80 not even one whose dwelling lies far off.
81 But great-hearted Odysseus he did not find
within:
82 he sat weeping on the shore, where he always
sat,⁹
83 shredding his heart with tears and groans and

pains,

84 and over the barren sea he would gaze, letting
the tears run.

85 And Calypso, shining among goddesses,
questioned Hermes,

86 seating him on a chair all bright and gleaming:

87 “Why have you come to me, Hermes of the
golden rod,

88 honored guest and dear? You have not been
used to come before.

89 Say what is in your mind: my heart bids me do
it

90 if I can do it — if it is a thing that can be done.

91 But follow me in first, and let me set out guest-
fare.”

92 So speaking the goddess drew up a table for
him,

93 heaping it with ambrosia, and mixed the red
nectar;

94 and the guide, the slayer of Argus, drank and
ate.

95 And when he had supped, and steadied his

heart with food,

96 then he spoke out in answer to her question:

97 “You ask me why I come — goddess to god; and
I will tell you

98 the whole of it truly, since you bid me.

99 Zeus ordered me here. I did not want to come:

100 who would choose to cross so vast a stretch of
salt water,

101 past speaking? And no city of mortals near, to
offer

102 the gods their victims and their choice
hecatombs.

103 But there is no way for another god to slip
past¹⁰

104 or thwart the mind of Zeus who bears the
aegis.

105 He says there is a man with you — the most
miserable of all

106 the men who fought nine years around the
city of Priam

107 and in the tenth year sacked it, and turned for
home.

108 But on the way home they sinned against
Athena,
109 and she roused an evil wind against them, and
long seas.
110 There all the rest of his brave companions
perished,
111 but wind and wave carried him here.
112 That man Zeus bids you send on his way —
and quickly:
113 it is not his portion to die here, far from his
own people;
114 it is still his portion to see his own people and
come
115 to his high-roofed house and his own
fatherland.”
116 So he spoke; and Calypso, shining among
goddesses, shivered,
117 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words
to him:
118 “You are merciless, you gods — jealous beyond
all beings —11
119 who begrudge goddesses their sleeping with

men

120 openly, if one takes a man as her own dear
husband.

121 So when Dawn of the rose-red fingers took
Orion,

122 you gods who live at ease begrudged it to her,

123 until in Ortygia chaste Artemis of the golden
throne

124 came at him with her gentle arrows and killed
him.

125 So when Demeter of the lovely braids gave
way to her heart

126 and lay with Iasion in love in the bed

127 of a thrice-plowed fallow field — Zeus was not
long¹²

128 in hearing, and he killed him with a hurl of
the white lightning.

129 And so now me, you gods: you begrudge me a
mortal man beside me.

130 I saved him — riding astride his keel, alone,

131 after Zeus with a hurl of the white lightning
had shattered

132 his fast ship apart in the middle of the wine-
dark sea.

133 There all the rest of his brave companions
perished,

134 but wind and wave carried him here.

135 And I loved him, and I fed him, and I promised

136 to make him deathless and unaging all his
days.13

137 But since there is no way for another god to
slip past

138 or thwart the mind of Zeus who bears the
aegis —

139 let him go, if that one urges it and commands,

140 out over the barren sea. Only I will not convey
him:

141 I have no ships at hand, no oars, no
companions

142 to carry him over the broad back of the sea.

143 But with a willing heart I will counsel him,
and hide nothing,

144 so that he may reach his own fatherland
untouched.”

145 Then the guide, the slayer of Argus, answered
her:

146 “Send him so, then — and beware the wrath of
Zeus:

147 let him not turn against you afterward and
bear hard on you.”

148 So speaking, the strong slayer of Argus went
away.

149 And the queenly nymph went to great-
hearted Odysseus,

150 now that she had heard the message of Zeus.

151 She found him sitting on the shore. His eyes
were never

152 dry of tears; his sweet life was draining away

153 in mourning for his homecoming — the
nymph no longer pleased him.

154 True, at night he would sleep beside her — he
had to —14

155 in the hollow caves, unwilling man by willing
goddess;

156 but all his days he sat out on the rocks and the
beaches,

157 shredding his heart with tears and groans and
pains,

158 and over the barren sea he would gaze, letting
the tears run.

159 Standing near him, she spoke, shining among
goddesses:

160 “Luckless man, do not sit grieving here any
longer; do not let15

161 your life waste away. I am ready now — wholly
— to send you off.

162 Come: cut long timbers, and join with bronze

163 a wide raft; and fix an upper half-deck to it,

164 raised high, to carry you over the misted sea.

165 And I will put in bread and water and red wine

166 to your heart’s content, to keep hunger from
you,

167 and I will clothe you, and send a fair wind
behind you,

168 so that you may reach your own fatherland
untouched —

169 if the gods are willing, who hold wide heaven,

170 who are stronger than I to purpose and

accomplish.”

171 So she spoke; and much-enduring noble
Odysseus shuddered, 16

172 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to
her:

173 “Something else you are plotting here,
goddess — not my sending —

174 you who bid me cross the great gulf of the sea
on a raft,

175 that terror, that misery: not even the trim
fast-running

176 ships cross it, for all their joy in the wind of
Zeus.

177 I will not set foot on any raft against your will
—

178 not unless you bring yourself, goddess, to
swear me the great oath

179 that you are not planning some new evil
against me.”

180 So he spoke; and Calypso, shining among
goddesses, smiled,

181 and stroked him with her hand, and spoke a

word, and named him:

182 “You are a rogue indeed — no lightweight in
cunning —

183 to have thought of a speech like that to say to
me.

184 Now let Earth be witness, and the wide
Heaven above,¹⁷

185 and the down-dripping water of Styx — the
greatest oath

186 and the most terrible the blessed gods can
swear —

187 that I am not planning some new evil against
you.

188 No: I am thinking and advising exactly what I
would

189 devise for my own self, if such need came on
me.

190 My mind is honest through and through, and
the heart

191 in my breast is not made of iron. It knows
pity.”

192 So speaking she led the way, shining among

goddesses,

193 swiftly, and he followed in the footsteps of the
god.

194 They came to the hollow cave, the goddess
and the man, 18

195 and he sat down there on the chair from
which Hermes

196 had risen, and the nymph set out all manner
of food beside him,

197 to eat and drink, such things as mortal men
eat;

198 and she took her seat facing godlike Odysseus,

199 and slave-women set ambrosia and nectar
beside her.

200 And their hands went out to the good things
spread before them.

201 But when they had had their joy of food and
drink,

202 Calypso began, shining among goddesses:

203 “Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices — 19

204 so you would go home now, home to your

own dear country,

205 at once, this moment? Go, then — and joy go
with you even so.

206 But if you knew in your heart how full your
measure

207 of sorrow is before you reach your own
country,

208 you would stay here with me and keep this
house,

209 and be deathless — for all your longing to see

210 that wife of yours, whom you ache for all your
days.

211 And yet I dare say I am not beneath her —

212 not in form, not in stature: it is in no way
seemly

213 for mortal women to vie with immortals in
body and looks.”

214 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

215 “Goddess and queen, do not be angry with me
for this. I know it all20

216 myself, well enough: watchful-minded

Penelope

217 is less than you — slighter to look at, smaller

—

218 for she is mortal, and you are deathless and
unaging.

219 But even so I wish — and all my days I long —

220 to go home, and to look upon my day of
homecoming.

221 And if some god wrecks me again on the wine-
dark sea,

222 I will endure it, with a heart schooled in
enduring sorrows.

223 Much have I suffered already, much have I
labored

224 through waves and war. Let this be added to
the rest.”

225 So he spoke; and the sun went down, and the
dusk came on;

226 and the two of them went into the inner
hollow of the cave

227 and took their joy of love, and stayed side by
side.²¹

228 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,

229 straightway Odysseus put on a cloak and
tunic,

230 and she, the nymph, put on a great silver-
shining mantle,

231 fine-woven and graceful, and cast about her
waist a belt,

232 beautiful, golden, and set a veil on her head
above.

233 Then she turned her mind to the sending of
great-hearted Odysseus.

234 She gave him a great axe, fitted to his
palms,22

235 of bronze, sharpened on both edges, and set
in it

236 a beautiful handle of olive-wood, made firm
and fast;

237 then she gave him a polished adze, and led
the way

238 to the island's farthest edge, where the tall
trees grew:

239 alder and black poplar, and fir that reached
the sky,
240 long dry, dead-seasoned, that would ride for
him lightly.
241 And when she had shown him where the tall
trees grew,
242 Calypso went back to her house, shining
among goddesses,
243 and he set to cutting timbers, and the work
went quickly under him.
244 Twenty trees in all he felled, and trimmed
them with the bronze,
245 and dressed them smooth with skill, and
trued them to the line.
246 Meanwhile Calypso, shining among
goddesses, brought augers,
247 and he bored through every piece and fitted
each to each,
248 and drove her together with pegs and joinery.
249 As wide as a man lays out the round of the
hull of a broad
250 cargo ship — a man who knows his craft —

251 so wide Odysseus built his raft.
252 He set up half-decks, fitting them to close-set
ribs,
253 and finished with long gunwale planks.
254 He made a mast in her, and a yard fitted to it,
255 and he made besides a steering-oar to hold
her straight,
256 and fenced her round from stem to stern with
plaited willow
257 to break the wave, and heaped down brush for
ballast.
258 Meanwhile Calypso, shining among
goddesses, brought cloth
259 to make a sail; and he made that too, with
craft,
260 and lashed into her the braces, the halyards,
and the sheets.
261 Then on rollers he hauled her down to the
bright salt water.
262 It was the fourth day, and all his work was
done;**23**
263 and on the fifth shining Calypso sent him

from the island,

264 having bathed him and dressed him in
fragrant clothes.

265 And the goddess put a skin of dark wine
aboard,

266 one skin, and another, a great one, of water,
and provisions

267 in a sack, and set in plenty of comforting
meats;

268 and she sent up a fair wind for him, harmless
and warm.

269 Rejoicing in the wind, noble Odysseus spread
his sail,

270 and with the steering-oar he steered her,
craftsmanlike,

271 sitting there; and sleep never fell on his
eyelids

272 as he watched the Pleiades, and Boötes that
sets late, 24

273 and the Bear, that men also call by the name
of the Wagon,

274 who turns in her place and keeps her watch

on Orion,

275 and alone has no share in the baths of Ocean:

276 for Calypso, shining among goddesses, had
told him

277 to keep her on his left hand as he crossed the
sea.

278 Seventeen days he sailed on, crossing the
water,

279 and on the eighteenth appeared the shadowy
mountains

280 of the Phaeacians' land, where it lay nearest
him:

281 it looked like a shield laid on the misted sea.25

282 But the strong earth-shaker, coming back
from the Ethiopians,26

283 saw him far off, from the mountains of the
Solymi: he showed

284 to his eye, sailing the sea. And the god's heart
grew the angrier,

285 and shaking his head he spoke to his own
heart:

286 "Damnation! So the gods have changed their

counsels

287 about Odysseus while I was among the
Ethiopians —

288 and here he is, close to the Phaeacians' land,
where it is his portion

289 to slip the great noose of misery that has
come upon him.

290 But I say I will yet drive him deep enough in
trouble.”

291 So speaking he herded the clouds together,
and stirred up the sea,

292 the trident in his hands; and he roused all the
squalls

293 of every wind there is, and covered land and
sea alike

294 with cloud; and night rose up out of heaven.

295 East Wind and South fell on him together, and
the hard-blowing West,²⁷

296 and the North Wind born of the clear sky,
rolling a great wave.

297 And then Odysseus' knees went loose, and his
heart;

298 and deeply stirred he spoke to his own great
heart:28

299 “Ah, wretch that I am — what happens to me
at the last?

300 I fear the goddess spoke it all unerringly,
301 who said that on the sea, before I reached my
own country,

302 I would fill my measure of pains. Now it is all
coming to pass:

303 look how Zeus crowns the wide heaven with
cloud on cloud,

304 and has stirred up the sea, and the squalls of
every wind

305 there is come driving. Now my sheer
destruction is certain.

306 Three times blessed the Danaans, and four
times, who died29

307 in those years in wide Troy, doing the
Atreidae’s pleasure!

308 Would that I too had died so, met my doom,

309 on the day the Trojans in their hundreds
hurled

310 their bronze-tipped spears at me over the
dead son of Peleus.

311 Then I would have had my death-rites, and the
Achaean carried my fame;

312 now it is my lot to be taken in a miserable
death.”

313 As he said it, a great wave drove down on him
from above,

314 rushing terribly, and spun the raft around.

315 Far from the raft he fell, and the steering-oar

316 flew from his hands; the mast snapped in the
middle

317 under the terrible squall of winds meeting
from all quarters,

318 and sail and yard fell far off in the sea.

319 And the wave held him under a long time: he
could not

320 rise quickly from beneath the great sea’s
downrush,

321 for the clothes weighed on him that shining
Calypso gave.**30**

322 At long last he came up, spitting from his

mouth the bitter

323 brine that ran streaming in torrents down his
head.

324 Yet even so, ground down as he was, he did
not forget his raft:

325 he lunged after her through the waves and
caught hold,

326 and sat down in the middle of her, dodging
the end that is death,

327 while the great wave carried her with the
current, here and there.

328 As when the North Wind of autumn carries
thistledown31

329 across the plain, and the tufts cling close to
one another,

330 so the winds carried her over the open water,
here and there:

331 now the South Wind would toss her to the
North to carry,

332 now again the East would yield her to the
West to chase.

333 But the daughter of Cadmus saw him — Ino of

the beautiful ankles,³²

³³⁴ the White Goddess, who once was mortal,
with a mortal voice,

³³⁵ and now in the salt depths has her share of
honor from the gods.

³³⁶ She pitied Odysseus, driven wandering, worn
with pains,

³³⁷ and in the likeness of a shearwater she rose
on the wing from the water,

³³⁸ and perched on the close-bound raft, and
said:

³³⁹ “Luckless man, why is Poseidon the earth-
shaker

³⁴⁰ so terribly at odds with you, that he plants all
these evils for you?

³⁴¹ Yet he shall not destroy you, for all his fury.

³⁴² Only do exactly this — you do not seem to me
short of sense.

³⁴³ Strip off these clothes, and leave the raft for
the winds

³⁴⁴ to carry; strike out swimming with your
hands for a homecoming

345 on the Phaeacians' land, where it is your
portion to escape.

346 Here — spread this veil under your chest.33

347 It is immortal: no fear then of suffering or
death.

348 But the moment your hands take hold of dry
land,

349 untie it again and throw it into the wine-dark
sea,

350 far out from land, and turn your own face
away.”

351 So speaking the goddess gave him the veil,

352 and she herself sank back into the surging sea

353 in the likeness of a shearwater, and the black
wave closed over her.

354 But much-enduring noble Odysseus pondered,

355 and deeply stirred he spoke to his own great
heart:

356 “Ah me — let this not be some new snare of
the immortals34

357 woven against me, when she bids me abandon
my raft.

358 No: I will not obey her yet. Far off with my
own eyes
359 I saw the land where she said my refuge is.
360 I will do this instead — it seems to me the
best:
361 as long as the timbers hold in their fastenings,
362 so long I stay aboard and endure my
sufferings where I am;
363 but the moment the wave shakes the raft to
pieces,
364 I swim. There is no better plan to see.”
365 While he was turning this over in his mind
and in his heart,
366 Poseidon the earth-shaker heaved up a great
wave,
367 terrible and grim, arching over him, and
drove it down.
368 And as a violent wind tosses a heap of dry
chaff
369 and scatters the wisps this way and that way,
370 so it scattered the raft’s long timbers. But
Odysseus

371 got astride one beam, like a man riding a
racehorse, 35

372 and stripped off the clothes that shining
Calypso gave,

373 and spread the veil at once beneath his chest,

374 and plunged headfirst in the sea, arms spread
wide,

375 hungry to swim. And the strong earth-shaker
saw him,

376 and shaking his head he spoke to his own
heart:

377 “So — now suffer your many evils and drift
the sea,

378 until you come among a people nurtured of
Zeus.

379 But even so I do not think you will make light
of your trouble.”

380 So speaking he lashed his horses of the
beautiful manes

381 and came to Aegae, where his famous house
is.

382 But Athena, daughter of Zeus, thought of

other things.

383 She bound up the courses of all the other
winds

384 and commanded every one to rest and fall
asleep,

385 and roused the quick North Wind, and broke
the waves before him,

386 so that Zeus-born Odysseus might come
among the oar-loving

387 Phaeacians, having slipped past death and the
dooms.

388 Two nights then and two days on the close-
packed swell

389 he drifted, and many times his heart looked
destruction in the face.

390 But when Dawn of the lovely braids brought
the third day round,

391 then at last the wind fell, and a windless calm

392 came on; and he saw the land close by,

393 casting a sharp glance forward, lifted on a
great wave.

394 As when a father's life shows dear and

welcome to his children —**36**

395 a father who lies in sickness suffering strong
pains,

396 long wasting away, some hateful power upon
him,

397 and then, dear and welcome, the gods set him
free of his evil —

398 so welcome to Odysseus showed the land and
the trees,

399 and he swam hard, straining to set foot on
solid earth.

400 But when he was as far offshore as a man's
shout carries,**37**

401 he heard the boom of sea against the rock-
teeth:

402 the great swell thundered on the dry land's
edge,

403 belching terribly, and everything was
shrouded in salt spray.

404 For there were no harbors there to hold ships,
no roadsteads —

405 only jutting headlands, rock-teeth, and cliff-

faces.

406 And then Odysseus' knees went loose, and his
heart,

407 and deeply stirred he spoke to his own great
heart:

408 "Ah me — now that Zeus has given me sight of
land

409 unhopd for, and I have won across this gulf
at last,

410 no way out of the gray salt water shows
anywhere:

411 sharp crags offshore, and all around them the
wave

412 roaring and churning, and the rock running
up sheer,

413 and the sea deep close in — nowhere to stand

414 on both my feet and escape the evil.

415 If I try to climb out, the great wave may
snatch me

416 and hurl me on the standing stone, and my
try go for nothing.

417 But if I swim along still farther, hoping to find

418 shelving beaches somewhere, and harbors of
the sea,
419 I fear the storm-squall snatches me up again
420 and carries me, groaning heavily, over the
fish-filled sea —
421 or some power looses a monster on me out of
the brine,³⁸
422 one of the swarm that famous Amphitrite
pastures:
423 for I know how the famous shaker of earth is
at odds with me.”
424 While he was turning this over in his mind
and in his heart,
425 a great wave carried him onto the jagged
shore.
426 There his skin would have been stripped, his
bones smashed in,
427 had not the goddess, gray-eyed Athena, put a
thought in him:
428 lunging in, he seized the rock with both
hands
429 and clung there groaning while the great

wave went past.

430 That one he escaped so; but its backwash
leapt on him again

431 and struck him and threw him far out to sea.

432 As when an octopus is dragged out of its
den³⁹

433 and thick pebbles cling in the cups of its arms,

434 so from his bold hands the skin was stripped
away

435 against the rocks; and the great wave closed
over him.

436 There, before his time, wretched Odysseus
would have perished,

437 had not gray-eyed Athena given him clear
sense.

438 Coming up out of the surf where it belches at
the land,

439 he swam along outside it, looking to the shore
in hope of finding

440 shelving beaches somewhere, and harbors of
the sea.

441 But when, swimming, he came to the mouth

of a fair-flowing river,

442 there at last the ground seemed best to him,

443 clear of stones, and there was shelter from
the wind.

444 He felt the current flowing and prayed in his
heart:

445 “Hear me, lord, whoever you are. I come to
you — the much-prayed-to —40

446 a fugitive out of the sea, from the threats of
Poseidon.

447 Even to the deathless gods that man is sacred

448 who comes as a wanderer, as I come now

449 to your stream and to your knees, after much
labor.

450 Pity me, lord: I declare myself your
suppliant.”

451 So he spoke; and at once the god stayed his
current, held back the wave,

452 and made the water calm before him, and
brought him safe

453 into the river’s mouth. And he bent both
knees

454 and let his strong hands fall: the sea had
crushed the heart in him.

455 All his flesh was swollen, and the sea oozed in
streams

456 up through his mouth and nostrils. Breathless
and speechless

457 he lay, barely alive, and a terrible weariness
came over him.

458 But when he got his breath again, and the
spirit gathered in his chest,

459 then he unbound the goddess's veil from his
body

460 and let it go into the river running seaward,

461 and the great wave carried it back down the
current, and quickly Ino

462 took it in her own dear hands. And he turned
from the river,

463 sank down in the reeds, and kissed the grain-
giving earth;**41**

464 and deeply stirred he spoke to his own great
heart:

465 "Ah me, what now? What happens to me at

the last?

466 If I keep watch through the anxious night
here by the river,

467 the two together — the evil frost and the
soaking dew —

468 may finish me: weak as I am, my spirit
gasping;

469 and toward dawn a cold breeze blows off a
river.

470 But if I climb the slope to the shadowy wood

471 and fall asleep in the thick brush — supposing
cold

472 and weariness release me, and sweet sleep
comes —

473 I fear I become spoil and carrion for wild
beasts.”

474 Yet as he weighed it, this seemed the better
way:

475 he went up toward the wood, and found it
near the water

476 on a rise in the open. He crept in under a
double thicket

477 grown from a single stock — one wild olive,
one the planted tree.**42**

478 Through these no strength of wet-blowing
winds could pierce,

479 nor could the shining sun strike through with
its rays,

480 nor rain soak through them, so close they
grew,

481 laced into one another. Under these Odysseus

482 crept, and heaped himself at once a wide bed

483 with his own hands: for there was a drift of
fallen leaves there, deep,

484 enough to shelter two men or three

485 in the winter season, however hard it blew.

486 Seeing it, much-enduring noble Odysseus
rejoiced,

487 and he lay down in the middle and poured the
fallen leaves over him.

488 As when a man buries a burning log in a black
ash-heap**43**

489 at the far edge of the fields — a man with no
neighbors near —

490 saving the seed of fire, so as not to seek a
light elsewhere,
491 so Odysseus buried himself in the leaves. And
Athena
492 poured sleep upon his eyes, to free him
soonest
493 from his toil-worn weariness, when she had
folded his dear eyelids shut.

Notes

NOTES

1. The book opens with Dawn rising from the bed of Tithonus — her mortal lover, to whom the gods gave endless life without endless youth. It is not the standard dawn formula but a pointed variant: a goddess-and-mortal bed, on the morning the gods will order another goddess to give her mortal up. The frame is the theme. ↩
2. Lines 8–12 repeat Mentor’s bitter assembly-speech (2.230–234) word for word — Athena has carried the complaint of an old man in Ithaca to the floor of Olympus, and the translation repeats itself accordingly. The poem’s machinery of justice runs on quotation. ↩

3. Zeus' testy reply — "was this not your plan all along?" — is the poem smiling at its own structure. This second council restates the first (Book 1) so the Odysseus half of the poem can launch; analyst critics saw a seam, but Zeus turns the repetition into characterization: Athena is the author of this plot, and everyone on Olympus knows it. ↩
4. Zeus states the itinerary in advance — raft, suffering, twentieth day, Scheria, honor like a god, treasure greater than his Troy-share. Homeric narrative does not fear spoilers: the tension is never *what*, always *how*. And the arithmetic will keep: four days building, seventeen sailing (278), two adrift, landing on the twentieth. ↩
5. Hermes' rod — putting whom he wills to sleep, waking whom he wills — is the psychopomp's tool (it will herd the suitors' ghosts in Book 24). Here it merely travels with him: a reminder of what the messenger *is*, paying a call on the island where a man is kept deathless-in-life. ↩
6. Hermes skims the waves "like a shearwater... hunting fish." A god traveling as a seabird opens the book; Ino will surface and dive "in the likeness of a shearwater" to close its storm (337, 353). The same bird brackets the book — divine help, in this poem of the sea, wears gull-gray. ↩
7. The cave of Calypso (59–74) is the first full paradise-landscape in Greek literature: cedar smoke, the singing weaver at her golden shuttle, the vine heavy with clusters, four springs, meadows of violet and wild celery. The clincher is the connoisseur's touch: "even a deathless one, arriving, would gaze in wonder" — and one does; Hermes stands there

sightseeing (75). The poem builds paradise convincingly enough that the refusal of it, 150 lines later, means something.



8. “The deathless gods are not unknown to one another”: divine society has no disguises internally. All the recognition-labor in this poem — the aching, testing, tokened recognitions of mortals — belongs to the human world alone. Gods simply *know*; men must find out. ↩
9. The entrance of the hero, four and a half books in: not fighting, not scheming — weeping on a beach, “shredding his heart,” staring at the sea. The Odyssey introduces its protagonist at his absolute nadir, in a posture of pure longing, and lets the epithet “much-enduring” (171) gather its meaning from this image. ↩
10. “No way for another god to slip past or thwart the mind of Zeus”: Hermes says it as diplomacy (103–104); Calypso repeats it back verbatim as bitterness (137–138). The same couplet, submissive in one mouth and seething in the other, is a masterclass in what formula can do. ↩
11. Calypso’s protest is the poem’s frankest statement of the divine double standard: gods may take mortal women, but a goddess who takes a mortal man “openly” draws the jealousy of heaven — Dawn’s Orion shot down by Artemis, Demeter’s Iasion blasted by Zeus. Her argument is unanswerable, and the poem lets it stand unanswered; she yields to power, not persuasion. ↩
12. Demeter and Iasion “in the bed of a thrice-plowed fallow field”: the old sacred marriage of grain-goddess and farmer, earth as

the marriage bed. Zeus' lightning ends it — the new order striking down the older fertility rite even as the poem remembers it. ↩

13. “Deathless and unaging all his days” — the offer on the table, stated by Calypso to Hermes before we ever hear it made to Odysseus. The poem wants us holding the full price-tag through the whole episode: what the man on the beach is weeping *through* is an open offer of immortality. ↩
14. “Unwilling man by willing goddess” — παρ’ οὐκ ἐθέλων ἐθελούσῃ. The Greek grammar of consent, compressed to four words, and a deliberate inversion of Nestor’s Clytemnestra line (3.272), “he willing, she willing.” The poem tracks who wants what in every bed it mentions. ↩
15. κάμμορε, “luckless man” — Calypso’s address of tenderness, and the exact word Ino the sea-goddess will use at 339. Two goddesses of the sea, one keeping him and one saving him, call him by the same name: doom-burdened. ↩
16. He *shudders* at the offer of release — because a raft on the open sea reads to him as a plot. Seven years a goddess’s captive have taught him that gifts are traps; his demand for the great oath (178–179) is the captive’s earned paranoia, and Calypso’s smile at it (180) is her acknowledgment that he is exactly the man she says he is at 182: “a rogue, no lightweight in cunning.” ↩
17. The oath by Earth, Heaven, and “the down-dripping water of Styx — the greatest oath and the most terrible the blessed gods can swear.” She swears the maximum. Whatever else Calypso is, she is not, in the end, a deceiver; the poem gives her a clean

exit and a self-description — “my heart is not made of iron; it knows pity” — that we are given no reason to doubt. ↩

18. “The goddess and the man” — θεὸς ἡδὲ καὶ ἀνὴρ: the book’s whole polarity in one line-end. At dinner they eat from separate menus, he “such things as mortal men eat,” she served ambrosia and nectar (197–199) — one table, two natures, the gulf between them laid out in the place-settings. ↩
19. “Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices” — the hero’s full ceremonial address, here in its first occurrence, from Calypso’s mouth. It will recur throughout the poem from gods, kings, and ghosts alike, and this translation keeps it identical every time. ↩
20. The most consequential speech in the poem, and its manner is the point: he concedes everything. Yes, Penelope is “less” — slighter, smaller, mortal, aging. No counter-argument is offered, no comparison contested. The refusal rests on nothing but “even so I wish” — the unarguable preference for one’s own finite life over a perfect eternity that belongs to someone else’s world. And the closing shrug is pure Odysseus: “Let this be added to the rest.” ↩
21. The poem’s tact: having refused eternity with her, he goes to bed with her, and the narration gives it one clause and no commentary. Ancient readers found no contradiction; the modern reader is free to. The sun-goes-down formula does the discretion. ↩
22. The raft-building (234–261) is the fullest description of skilled handwork in Homer — axe, adze, twenty trees, augers, pegs

and joinery, ribs, half-decks, gunwales, mast, yard, steering-oar, willow bulwark against the wave, and a sail from the goddess's cloth. The embedded simile is professional: as wide as a shipwright lays out a cargo hull, "a man who knows his craft." Odysseus' identity as *maker* — which will climax in the secret of the olive-tree bed — is established here, in four days' honest carpentry. ↪

23. Fourth day, work done; fifth day, departure. Homer's calendars audit cleanly: with seventeen days' sailing and two adrift, the landing falls on Zeus' promised twentieth day (34). ↪
24. The star-course (272–277) is the earliest surviving text of Greek celestial navigation: steer by the Pleiades, late-setting Boötes, and the Bear "who turns in her place and keeps her watch on Orion, and alone has no share in the baths of Ocean" — i.e., never sets. Keeping her on the left hand means sailing east. The astronomy is real, and the Bear's exemption from Ocean's baths was already proverbial. ↪
25. The land "like a shield laid on the misted sea" — ῥινόν, an ox-hide shield: how a mountainous island actually looks, hull-down on the horizon. A sailor's simile. ↪
26. Poseidon returns from the Ethiopians — the plot-latch set at 1.22–26 now released. One god's vacation has been the whole window of opportunity: the Odyssey's Olympus runs on scheduling. ↪
27. All four winds at once — East, South, West, and "the North Wind born of the clear sky" — is not weather but signature: only a god unseats the compass itself. Athena's counter-move at 383–

385 is to *silence* three winds and choose one. Divine combat here is meteorology. ↩

28. “Deeply stirred he spoke to his own great heart” — the soliloquy formula, four times in this book (298, 355, 407, 464). Alone on the sea, the poem’s most social intelligence has no interlocutor but his own θυμός; Book 5 invents, in effect, the interior monologue of survival. ↩
29. “Three times blessed the Danaans, and four times, who died in wide Troy”: the drowning man’s arithmetic of envy. His terror is precise and cultural — not death but *this* death, wet and unwitnessed: no rites, no mound, no fame (311). It is Telemachus’ fear for his father (1.239–241) spoken now by the father himself. ↩
30. Calypso’s clothes drag him under. Read allegorically since antiquity, and the poem invites it: everything of hers must be stripped off (372) before her sea will let him live. Her last gift nearly finishes what her love could not. ↩
31. The raft rides the sea like autumn thistledown — the mightiest forces in the poem rendered through the lightest thing in a farmer’s field. The four named winds tossing her “now to the North to carry, now to the West to chase” play a game of catch; the terror is in the toy-scale. ↩
32. Ino Leucothea, “who once was mortal, with a mortal voice, and now in the salt depths has her share of honor” — a mortal woman who *became* a goddess, surfacing to save the man who has just refused to become a god. The symmetry is perfect and unremarked: the poem simply sets the two trajectories crossing in mid-storm. ↩

33. The κρήδεμνον — a woman's head-veil — as flotation and talisman: an intimate garment made life-line. It is a loan, not a gift: it must be thrown back seaward, face averted (349–350), and Ino's hands are waiting for it (461–462). Divine aid in this poem is exact about its terms. ↩
34. Offered a goddess's own rescue, he suspects a trap — and then hedges: keep the raft while it holds, swim when it shatters. “There is no better plan to see.” The empirical hero: no gift is trusted until tested, including salvation. That the suspicion is *wrong* this time does not make it unreasonable; the poem has taught him its world. ↩
35. Astride one beam “like a man riding a racehorse” — a flash of jaunty, almost comic athleticism in the middle of shipwreck. The image does double work: mastery and absurdity, the tactician reduced to a jockey on driftwood. ↩
36. The reversed family simile: land looks as welcome to Odysseus as a father's recovery looks to his children. The father starved of his own children for twenty years can feel relief only as a child of the thing that saves him. Homer's similes keep displacing this hero's longings into other people's households — the emotional bookkeeping of a man who has no household in reach. ↩
37. “As far offshore as a man's shout carries” — distance measured by the human voice, just as time is measured by meals and dawns. The Homeric world is calibrated in body-units. ↩
38. The fear of a sea-monster “of the swarm that famous Amphitrite pastures” — the deep as the hostile god's ranch,

stocked and grazed. Even Odysseus' terrors are precisely inventoried. ↩

39. The octopus simile, admired since antiquity for its cold-eyed reversal: when an octopus is dragged from its den, pebbles cling to its suckers; when Odysseus is dragged from the rock, his skin stays behind on it. The observation is a fisherman's; the application is a torturer's. Nothing else in Homer renders the sea's violence so anatomically. ↩
40. The prayer to the nameless river — "Hear me, lord, whoever you are" — is answered instantly, the fastest-granted prayer in the poem. Lines 447–450 state the doctrine of supplication in full: the wanderer is sacred even to the gods. A minor local god honors in four lines what Poseidon has spent a book violating. ↩
41. He kisses "the grain-giving earth" — the formulaic epithet suddenly literal: after eighteen days of salt, the first thing to bless about land is that bread grows in it. Agamemnon kissed his homeland soil (4.522); Odysseus kisses any earth at all. Homecoming has been beaten down to its minimum unit: dry ground. ↩
42. The double thicket "grown from a single stock — one wild olive, one the planted tree": wildness and cultivation sharing one root, and the poem's emblem of its hero, who survives by being both at once. The olive is Athena's tree; its marriage of wild and tame will return, grown into furniture, in the bed-secret of Book 23. He shelters, of course, exactly here. ↩
43. The last simile of the book: a solitary farmer "with no neighbors near" banks a burning log in ash, "saving the seed of fire."

Odysseus under his leaves is fire in latency — identity, banked;
heat, hidden; the whole coming poem held as a spark. And it is
Athena, keeper of that spark, who closes his eyelids over it. No
book of the Odyssey ends better. ↩

Odyssey — Book 6

*Nausicaa at the river; the naked stranger; the road to
the city.*

- 1 So he slept there, much-enduring noble
Odysseus,
2 overcome with sleep and weariness. But Athena
3 went her way to the land and city of the
Phaeacian men,
4 who once, in years past, lived in spacious
Hypereia,¹
5 near the Cyclopes, men of overweening pride,
6 who kept raiding them, and were the stronger
in force.
7 From there godlike Nausithous had uprooted
them and led them,
8 and settled them in Scheria, far from men who
eat bread,
9 and drove a wall around the city, and built
houses,

10 and made temples for the gods, and divided
out the plowlands.

11 But he long since had gone down to Hades,
broken by fate,

12 and now Alcinous ruled, his counsels known
from the gods.

13 To his house went the goddess, gray-eyed
Athena,

14 devising the homecoming of great-hearted
Odysseus.

15 She went into the richly-worked chamber
where a girl

16 lay sleeping, like the immortals in build and
beauty:

17 Nausicaa, daughter of great-hearted Alcinous;

18 and by her two handmaids, with beauty from
the Graces,

19 one at each doorpost; and the shining doors
were shut.

20 Like a breath of wind she swept to the girl's
bed²

21 and stood above her head, and spoke to her,

22 in the likeness of the daughter of Dymas,
famed for ships,
23 a girl her own age, and dear to her heart.
24 In her likeness gray-eyed Athena said:
25 “Nausicaa, how did your mother bear so
careless a girl?³
26 Your shining clothes lie there uncared-for —
27 and your wedding is near, when you must wear
beautiful things
28 yourself, and provide them for those who lead
you in procession:
29 it is from things like these that a good name
goes up
30 among the people, and a father and honored
mother are glad.
31 Come, let us go washing at the showing of
dawn:
32 I will come with you and work beside you, so
you may be ready
33 the sooner — for truly not much longer will
you be unwed:
34 already the best men through all the land of

the Phaeacians

35 are wooing you — and your own line is theirs.

36 Come then: press your famous father, before
the dawn,

37 to make ready the mules and a wagon to carry

38 the sashes and the robes and the shining
coverlets.

39 And for yourself, too, it is far more fitting so
than going

40 on foot: the washing-pools are a long way from
the city.”

41 So speaking, gray-eyed Athena went away

42 to Olympus, where they say the seat of the
gods stands fast⁴

43 forever: not shaken by winds, never soaked

44 by rain, nor does snow come near it, but clear
sky

45 spreads cloudless there, and a white radiance
runs over it;

46 in that place the blessed gods take pleasure all
their days.

47 There the gray-eyed one went, when she had

counseled the girl.

48 At once Dawn came on her fair throne, and
woke

49 Nausicaa of the lovely robe; and she wondered
at her dream

50 and went through the house to tell her
parents,

51 her dear father and mother. She found them
within:

52 her mother sat at the hearth with her
attendant women,

53 spinning yarn dyed sea-purple; her father she
met

54 at the door, on his way out to join the famous
kings

55 in council, where the lordly Phaeacians called
him.

56 She stood close to her dear father and said:

57 “Papa dear, won’t you make ready a wagon for
me,5

58 the high one with the good wheels, so I can
take the fine clothes

59 to the river for washing, that lie about me
dirty?

60 And for you too it is only proper, when you sit
among the first men

61 debating counsels, to have clean clothing on
your body.

62 And five dear sons have been born to you in
these halls —

63 two married, and three flourishing bachelors
—

64 and they are always wanting fresh-washed
clothes to wear

65 when they go to the dancing. All this is on my
mind.”

66 So she spoke: she was shy of naming ripe
marriage

67 to her dear father. But he saw it all, and
answered:

68 “I do not grudge you the mules, child, or
anything else.

69 Go: the slaves will make ready a wagon for you,

70 the high one with the good wheels, fitted with

its top-rack.”

71 So saying he called to the slaves, and they obeyed.

72 Outside, they made ready the smooth-running mule wagon

73 and led the mules under and yoked them to it;

74 and the girl brought the shining clothing from her room

75 and laid it in the polished wagon,

76 and her mother packed a box with heartening food

77 of every kind — put in delicacies, and poured wine

78 in a goatskin bag; and the girl climbed up on the wagon.

79 And she gave her soft olive oil in a golden flask,

80 so she and her attendant women might anoint themselves after bathing.

81 And she took up the whip and the glossy reins

82 and whipped the mules to a run; and there was a clatter of hooves,

83 and they strained on without slackening,

carrying the clothes and her —

84 not alone: her handmaids went along beside
her.

85 And when they came to the beautiful stream of
the river,

86 where the washing-pools never fail — plenty of
clear water

87 welling up through and running over, to clean
the dirtiest things —

88 there they loosed the mules from under the
wagon

89 and shooed them along the eddying river

90 to graze the honey-sweet water-grass; and
they lifted the clothes

91 from the wagon in armfuls and carried them
into the dark water,

92 and trod them briskly in the trenches, racing
one another.⁷

93 And when they had washed and rinsed away
all the dirt,

94 they spread everything out in rows along the
shingle of the sea,

95 where the waves washed the pebbles cleanest
against the shore.

96 And when they had bathed and rubbed
themselves richly with oil,

97 they took their meal by the banks of the river
98 and waited for the clothes to dry in the shining
of the sun.

99 And when she and her slave-women had had
their joy of food,

100 they threw off their head-veils and played at
ball,

101 and white-armed Nausicaa led them in the
singing.

102 As Artemis the arrow-pourer goes down the
mountains,8

103 down long Taygetus or Erymanthus,

104 delighting in the boars and the running deer,

105 and with her the nymphs, daughters of aegis-
bearing Zeus,

106 play across the wild country, and Leto's heart
is glad,

107 for she carries her head and brow above them

all

108 and is known at once, though all of them are
beautiful:

109 so the unwed girl outshone her handmaids.

110 But when she was about to fold the beautiful
clothes,

111 yoke the mules, and turn for home again,

112 then the goddess thought of one thing more,
gray-eyed Athena:

113 that Odysseus should wake, and see the lovely-
eyed girl,

114 and she should lead him to the city of the
Phaeacian men.

115 So the princess tossed the ball to one of her
handmaids;9

116 the handmaid she missed, and it fell in a deep
eddy,

117 and they shrieked aloud. And noble Odysseus
woke,

118 and sitting up he turned it over in his mind
and heart:

119 “Ah me — whose country have I come to now?

What men's?¹⁰

¹²⁰ Are they violent, savage, without justice,

¹²¹ or kind to strangers, with hearts that fear the
gods?

¹²² A female crying rang around me just now —
girls' voices:

¹²³ nymphs, who hold the sheer peaks of the
mountains

¹²⁴ and the springs of rivers and the grassy
water-meadows?

¹²⁵ Or am I now, can it be, near men with human
speech?

¹²⁶ Come — I will test it for myself, and see.”

¹²⁷ So speaking noble Odysseus slipped out from
the thicket,

¹²⁸ and from the thick wood with his heavy hand
he broke a branch

¹²⁹ in leaf, to hold about his body and screen a
man's privates.

¹³⁰ And he went like a mountain-bred lion, sure
of his strength,¹¹

¹³¹ who goes on through rain and wind, his two

eyes

132 burning, and he comes down on the cattle or
the sheep

133 or the wild deer, for his belly commands him

134 to make trial of the flocks — even to enter the
close-built fold:

135 so Odysseus was about to come among the
fair-braided girls,

136 naked as he was: for need had come upon him.

137 And he loomed terrible before them, crusted
with the salt sea's brine,

138 and they scattered, one here, one there, along
the jutting sandspits.

139 Alone the daughter of Alcinous stayed: for
Athena

140 set courage in her heart and took the
trembling from her limbs.

141 She stood and faced him, holding her ground.
And Odysseus weighed it, 12

142 whether to clasp the knees of the lovely-eyed
girl and beg,

143 or standing apart as he was, with honeyed

words,

144 to beg her to show him the city and give him
clothing.

145 And as he weighed it, this seemed the better
way:

146 to stand apart and beg with honeyed words,

147 lest the girl's heart take anger if he touched
her knees.

148 At once he spoke — a honeyed speech, and a
shrewd one:13

149 "I am at your knees, queen — goddess or
mortal, are you?

150 If you are one of the gods who hold wide
heaven,

151 then it is to Artemis, daughter of great Zeus,

152 that I liken you nearest — in beauty, in stature,
in bearing.

153 But if you are one of the mortals who live on
the earth,

154 three times blessed your father and your
honored mother,

155 three times blessed your brothers! Surely

their hearts

156 are warmed through with gladness always
because of you,

157 watching such a young shoot go stepping into
the dance.

158 But blessed at heart above all others is that
man

159 who weighs down the scales of the bride-gifts
and leads you home.

160 For my eyes have never seen a mortal like
you,

161 not man, not woman. Awe takes me, looking at
you.

162 In Delos once, beside Apollo's altar, I saw14

163 such a thing: the young shoot of a date-palm
springing up —

164 for I came there too, and a great host followed
me,

165 on that road where my bitter cares were to be
—

166 and just as, seeing that, I stood amazed at
heart

167 a long time, since no such stem had ever risen
from the earth,

168 so, lady, I wonder at you, amazed, and I am
terribly afraid

169 to touch your knees. But hard grief is upon
me.

170 Yesterday, on the twentieth day, I escaped the
wine-dark sea:

171 all that time the waves carried me, and the
driving storms,

172 away from the island Ogygia. And now some
power has cast me here —

173 to suffer some new evil in this place too, no
doubt: for I do not think

174 the evil will stop; the gods will accomplish
plenty more first.

175 But pity me, queen. After many hard labors

176 it is to you first I have come; I know not one

177 of the others whose city and land this is.

178 Show me the town, and give me a rag to throw
around me —

179 if perhaps you had some wrapping-cloth for

the linen when you came.

180 And may the gods grant you all your heart
desires:15

181 a husband and a house — and may they add
like-mindedness,

182 the good kind. For nothing is stronger or
better than that:

183 when two who think alike keep house
together,

184 a man and his wife — much grief to their ill-
wishers,

185 joy to their friends; and they themselves
know it best.”

186 Then white-armed Nausicaa answered him:

187 “Stranger — since you seem neither base nor
witless a man —

188 it is Olympian Zeus himself who deals out
fortune to mankind,

189 to good and bad, to each one as he wills;

190 and to you, I suppose, he gave this lot, and
you must bear it, come what may.

191 But now, since you have come to our city and

our land,

192 you shall not want for clothing, nor for
anything else

193 that is owed a hard-worn suppliant when he
comes.

194 I will show you the town, and tell you the
name of the people.

195 The Phaeacians hold this city and this land,

196 and I am the daughter of great-hearted
Alcinous,

197 on whom the strength and power of the
Phaeacians hang.”

198 She spoke, and called to her fair-braided
handmaids:

199 “Stand still, you girls! Where are you running
at the sight of a man?

200 You cannot think he is one of an enemy
people?

201 There is no living mortal, and there will be
none, **16**

202 who could come bearing war into the land

203 of the Phaeacian men. For we are very dear to

the deathless ones,

204 and we live apart, in the much-surging sea,
205 at the world's edge, and no other mortals mix
with us.

206 No — this is some poor wanderer come here
astray,

207 whom we must care for now. From Zeus they
come, all of them, 17

208 strangers and beggars; and a gift, though
small, is dear.

209 Come, girls: give the stranger food and drink,
210 and bathe him in the river, where there is
shelter from the wind.”

211 So she spoke; and they stood, and called to
one another,

212 and they set Odysseus down in the sheltered
place, as she commanded —

213 Nausicaa, daughter of great-hearted Alcinous
—

214 and laid a mantle and a tunic by him for
clothing,

215 and gave him soft olive oil in the golden flask,

216 and urged him to bathe in the streams of the river.

217 Then noble Odysseus spoke among the handmaids:

218 “Stand off there, girls, at a distance, so that I myself¹⁸

219 may wash the brine from my shoulders, and rub myself

220 with oil: it is long indeed since oil came near my skin.

221 But I will not bathe in front of you. I would be ashamed

222 to stand naked among fair-braided girls.”

223 So he spoke; and they went apart, and told the girl.

224 And noble Odysseus washed his body in the river,

225 sluicing off the brine that caked his back and broad shoulders,

226 and scrubbed from his head the salt-scurf of the barren sea.

227 And when he had washed all over, and rubbed

himself with oil,
228 and put on the clothes the unwed girl had
given him,
229 then Athena, born of Zeus, made him19
230 taller to look at, and broader, and down from
his head
231 she made the locks flow in curls, like the
hyacinth flower.
232 As when a man lays gold over silver — a
craftsman
233 whom Hephaestus and Pallas Athena have
taught
234 art of every kind, and he finishes works full of
grace —
235 so she poured grace over his head and
shoulders.
236 Then he went apart and sat on the shingle of
the sea,
237 shining with beauty and grace. And the girl
gazed at him,
238 and spoke among her fair-braided handmaids:
239 “Listen, my white-armed girls, while I say

something.

240 Not against the will of all the gods who hold
Olympus

241 does this man come among the godlike
Phaeacians.

242 Before, I confess, he seemed to me a sorry
sight;

243 now he is like the gods who hold wide heaven.

244 If only such a man might be called my
husband,20

245 living here — if only it pleased him to stay!

246 But come, girls: give the stranger food and
drink.”

247 So she spoke, and they listened well and
obeyed,

248 and set food and drink beside Odysseus.

249 And he drank and ate, much-enduring noble
Odysseus,

250 ravenously: it was long since he had tasted
food.21

251 But white-armed Nausicaa thought of one
thing more:

252 she folded the clothes and stowed them in the
beautiful wagon,

253 and yoked the strong-hoofed mules, and
mounted herself,

254 and called Odysseus on, and spoke a word,
and named him:

255 “Up now, stranger, and we go to the city, so I
may send you

256 to the house of my wise father — where, I
promise you,

257 you will meet the best men of all the
Phaeacians.

258 Only do exactly this — you do not seem to me
short of sense.22

259 While we are passing the fields and the works
of men,

260 walk with the handmaids, behind the mules
and wagon,

261 briskly; I will lead the way.

262 But when we are about to enter the city — a
high wall rings it,23

263 and a beautiful harbor lies on either side of

the town,

264 with a narrow causeway in; and the curved
ships are drawn up

265 along the road, for every man has his own slip
there;

266 and there is the gathering-place around
Poseidon's fine precinct,

267 fitted with quarried stones set deep in the
earth;

268 and there men see to the tackle of their black
ships,

269 the cables and the sails, and fine down their
oars —

270 for the Phaeacians care nothing for the bow
or the quiver,

271 but for masts, and ships' oars, and the trim
ships themselves,

272 in which they delight as they cross the gray
salt sea —

273 it is their ugly talk I shrink from: someone
behind my back

274 might sneer; there are insolent men enough

in the town;

275 and one of the meaner sort, meeting us, might
say:

276 'Who is this following Nausicaa — this tall
handsome

277 stranger? Where did she find him? A husband
for her, no doubt!

278 Some castaway she has taken up, off his ship,

279 a man from far parts — since nobody lives
near us;

280 or some god, long prayed-for, come down to
her

281 out of heaven in answer, and hers he will be
all her days!

282 Better so, if she has gone out and found
herself a husband

283 from elsewhere — since she scorns her own,
here in the land,

284 the Phaeacians, though many fine men are
wooing her!'

285 So they will say, and it would be a reproach
against me.

286 And I would blame another girl who did such
things myself:

287 who, against the will of her dear father and
mother living,

288 kept company with men before the day of
open marriage.

289 So, stranger, mark my word quickly, and you
will win

290 escort and homecoming from my father
soonest.

291 You will find a shining grove of Athena near
the road —

292 poplars; a spring wells up in it; a meadow lies
around it.

293 There is my father's park there, and his
flourishing orchard,

294 as far from the city as a man's shout
carries.25

295 Sit down there and wait a while, until we

296 have entered the town and reached my
father's house.

297 But when you judge that we have reached the

house,

298 then go into the city of the Phaeacians, and
ask

299 for the house of my father, great-hearted
Alcinous.

300 It is easily known: a little child could lead you
—

301 a baby; for the houses of the Phaeacians are
not built

302 anything like it — such is the house of the
hero

303 Alcinous. And once the buildings and the
court have hidden you,

304 go quickly straight through the great hall,
until you come

305 to my mother. She sits at the hearth in the
light of the fire, 26

306 spinning yarn dyed sea-purple — a wonder to
see —

307 leaning against a pillar, and her slave-women
sit behind her.

308 And there my father's chair is tilted close to

hers,

309 where he sits and drinks his wine like an
immortal.

310 Pass him by, and throw your arms around the
knees

311 of my mother — if you would see your day of
homecoming

312 with rejoicing, and quickly, though you come
from very far.

313 If she once takes kindly thought for you in her
heart,

314 then there is hope you will see your own
people, and come

315 to your well-built house and your own
fatherland.”

316 So speaking she touched the mules with the
shining whip,

317 and they quickly left the flowing river behind.

318 Well they trotted, well they wheeled their legs
along,

319 and she drove with care, so that the walkers
could keep pace —

320 the handmaids and Odysseus — and used the
lash with judgment.27

321 And the sun went down, and they came to the
famous grove

322 sacred to Athena. There noble Odysseus sat
down,

323 and at once he prayed to the daughter of
great Zeus:

324 “Hear me, child of aegis-bearing Zeus,
Unwearied One.28

325 Hear me now at last, since before you never
heard me

326 when I was broken — when the famous earth-
shaker broke me.

327 Grant that I come among the Phaeacians
pitied, and a friend.”

328 So he spoke in prayer, and Pallas Athena
heard him.

329 But she did not yet show herself to him face
to face: she stood29

330 in awe of her father’s brother, who raged on
furiously

331 against godlike Odysseus, until the day he reached his own land.

Notes

NOTES

1. The Phaeacian founding legend (4–10): refugees from Cyclops-raids in Hypereia, led out by Nausithous to Scheria, “far from men who eat bread.” The founder’s checklist — wall, houses, temples, division of plowland — is the exact program of Greek colonization in the poet’s own century; Phaeacia is a colonist’s dream written into fairyland. And the detail that they once lived *next to the Cyclopes* quietly links the poem’s two ends of the hospitality spectrum: the perfect hosts were once the monster’s neighbors, and moved. ↩
2. Athena enters “like a breath of wind” past shut doors — the same dream-physics as the phantom at 4.802, which slipped in “past the strap of the bolt.” Dreams are deliveries; the bedroom’s locks are no argument. ↩
3. The dream-speech is a small masterpiece of misdirection: Athena never mentions the man on the beach. She motivates the girl entirely within the girl’s own world — laundry, reputation, a wedding soon, what people will say — and lets the plot follow from the trousseau. The goddess of stratagem writes each mortal’s motive in that mortal’s own language. ↩

4. Olympus as the poets ever after inherited it: never shaken by wind, never wet by rain, no snow, cloudless clear air, “a white radiance runs over it.” The description matches Elysium (4.565–568) almost weather-clause for weather-clause — the gods live in the same eternal fair weather they grant their favorite son-in-law. Sophocles and Lucretius both rewrote these lines. ↩
5. πάππα φίλ’ — “Papa dear”: the only “papa” in Homer. The wheedling is expert — the wagon is for *his* council-clothes and *the boys’* dance-clothes, her own wedding never named — and line 67 gives the scene its grace: “he saw it all,” and granted everything without making her say it. Two sentences of family tact, complete. ↩
6. “She was shy of naming ripe marriage to her dear father” — αἴδετο, the same *aidōs* Athena told Telemachus to drop (3.14). In the boy it was a deficit; in the girl, decorum. The poem prices shame by context. ↩
7. “Racing one another” at treading laundry in the trenches: work as game. Phaeacia is the poem’s land of ease, and even its chores are competitive play — the detail sets up the ball game, and the ball game wakes the plot. ↩
8. Nausicaa as Artemis among her nymphs, Leto glad at heart — the narrator’s simile. Forty-nine lines later Odysseus, who has seen nothing of this, spontaneously offers *the same comparison* (151–152). His courtesy is instinctively exact: he divines the very image the poem has just certified as true. That convergence — his rhetoric landing on reality — is the measure of both his art and her quality. (Helen got the same simile at 4.122; the two

Artemis-women meet the same wandering house of
Atreus/Laertes at their thresholds.) ↩

9. The thrown ball, the missed catch, the shriek: the smallest hinge in epic. Athena's grand device for delivering the hero to his hosts is a botched throw in a girls' game. The poem loves to run destiny through the trivial. ↩
10. "Are they violent, savage, without justice, or kind to strangers, with hearts that fear the gods?" — the arrival-question, here in its first full form; Odysseus will ask it verbatim off the Cyclops' shore (9.175–176) and on unrecognized Ithaca (13.201–202). It is the poem's entire anthropology in two lines: societies are sorted by one metric only — what they do with a stranger. ↩
11. The lion simile, deliberately outsized: a starving, salt-crust, naked man holding a leafy branch advances on some girls doing laundry — "like a mountain-bred lion, sure of his strength." The mock-heroic surface has a real edge (the girls scatter; he is terrifying), and one working part: "his belly commands him." The γαστήρ, the belly as tyrant, enters the poem here and will become Odysseus' great theme as beggar. ↩
12. The deliberation is pure Odysseus: the *correct* suppliant procedure is to clasp the knees — and he rejects it, calculating that a touched girl may take anger where a distanced one will take pity. He chooses rhetoric over ritual, and it works. Tact, in this poem, is a survival technology. ↩
13. "A honeyed speech, and a shrewd one" — μειλίχιον καὶ κερδαλέον: the narrator files this masterpiece under *both* labels before it starts. Sincerity and calculation are not

alternatives in Odysseus; the speech is beautiful *and* engineered, and the poem sees no scandal in that. ↩

14. The Delos palm: the one moment of pure wonder Odysseus reports from his entire war itinerary — a young date-palm shooting up beside Apollo's altar, seen en route to Troy "on that road where my bitter cares were to be." He compares a girl to a tree and makes it the highest compliment in Greek literature: something singular, growing, sacred, and briefly capable of stopping an army-leader in his tracks. (Delos' sacred palm was the one Leto gripped giving birth to Apollo; the poem's audience knew.) ↩
15. The blessing of ὁμοφροσύνη — "like-mindedness": the poem's definition of marriage, given away by Penelope's husband to a marriageable girl on a beach. "When two who think alike keep house together... much grief to their ill-wishers, joy to their friends; and they themselves know it best." It is at once the most naked self-revelation in his rhetoric and its most perfectly aimed stroke — he blesses her with exactly the thing his whole voyage is for. The last clause — *they themselves know it best* — is a married man speaking. ↩
16. "There is no living mortal" — διεπὸς βροτός, a crux since antiquity (διεπὸς elsewhere means "wet"; "living" is the guess of the ancients, perhaps via "quick with sap"). However translated, the sense is her serene island-confidence: war cannot reach the Phaeacians. Book 13 will show what can. ↩
17. "From Zeus they come, all of them, strangers and beggars; and a gift, though small, is dear." The creed of xenia in its most quotable form — spoken by a princess, and repeated verbatim

later by a slave, the swineherd Eumaeus (14.57–58). The poem puts its deepest ethical sentence in the mouths of a girl and a herdsman; the suitors, who feast in a palace, never say anything like it. ↩

18. His refusal to bathe before the girls — “I would be ashamed” — answers her courage with courtesy: reciprocal *aidōs*. The man who has nothing left still has manners; it is the first gift he gives on Scheria, and the only one he can afford. ↩
19. Athena’s transformation, with the gold-over-silver simile: grace *poured over* him like gilding by a craftsman trained by Hephaestus and Athena herself. The entire passage returns verbatim at 23.156–162, when he is beautified for Penelope — the poem uses the same makeover, once for the girl who might have been and once for the wife who is. ↩
20. “If only such a man might be called my husband” — said aloud, but to the handmaids, in the optative of wishing. The poem’s most delicately handled might-have-been: her wish, his blessing (180–185), and the plot that must carry him past her. Alcinous will make the offer openly at 7.311–315; the poem lets the road not taken stay visible its whole length. ↩
21. “Ravenously: it was long since he had tasted food.” Between the two great courtesies — his speech, her welcome — the poem sets down the body’s plain fact. The belly that “commanded” the lion at 133 gets its due; heroism in the *Odyssey* always eats. ↩
22. “Only do exactly this — you do not seem to me short of sense”: Nausicaa reuses, word for word, the formula the sea-goddess Ino used to Odysseus in the storm (5.342). A girl instructing the

veteran in her own domain — the town, its gossip, its politics — with a goddess's formula: on Scheria, local knowledge outranks heroic experience, and he obeys her as he obeyed Ino. ↩

23. The city she sketches (262–272) is the idealized sailor-polis: double harbor, narrow causeway, every man his own ship-slip, the assembly-place by Poseidon's precinct, and the pointed disclaimer — “the Phaeacians care nothing for the bow or the quiver.” A city whose only weapons are masts and oars: seafaring entirely demilitarized, trade without raid — the exact inversion of Nestor's polite assumption (3.71–74) that any sailor might be a pirate. ↩
24. The gossip speech: to warn him, she must *perform* the slander, inventing a mocker and quoting him at length (276–284) — and her invented sneer includes the fantasy of a god come down from heaven to be hers “all her days.” The prim conclusion (286–288: *I would blame such a girl myself*) sits directly atop the wish she spoke at 244. Homer lets a marriageable girl's propriety and desire share one speech without reconciling them — psychological realism about three millennia ahead of schedule. ↩
25. “As far from the city as a man's shout carries” — the voice-measure again (5.400): Phaeacia mapped in the same body-units as the sea. ↩
26. The strategy of the hearth (303–315): pass the king, supplicate the *queen*. Arete at the fire, spinning sea-purple wool against a pillar, is the house's true center, and everyone in Phaeacia seems to know it. Why the queen's favor decides a suppliant's

fate here has been argued since antiquity (a trace of older custom? simply this queen's standing? — Book 7 will give her genealogy and her honors); the poem states the protocol through a daughter who reports it as plain fact. ↩

27. “She drove with care, so that the walkers could keep pace... and used the lash with judgment” — νόω, with mind. The last we see of Nausicaa in this book is a small portrait in competence: even her whip-hand is thoughtful. ↩

28. The prayer permits itself a reproach: “Hear me now at last, since before you never heard me.” Mortals may bill the gods for arrears, politely; the formula's first line is Penelope's (4.762), and the family resemblance between the two petitioners — the wife and the husband, praying to the same goddess in the same words — is the kind of rhyme this poem builds across oceans. ↩

29. Athena hears, and does not appear: she “stood in awe of her father's brother.” The book ends on Olympian family politics — the goddess managing her uncle's rage by working only behind the scenes — and its final line repeats the poem's opening problem (1.20–21) verbatim: Poseidon raging “against godlike Odysseus, until the day he reached his own land.” The clock set in Book 1 is still running; two more books of Phaeacia stand between the grove and that day. ↩

Odyssey — Book 7

The palace and gardens of Alcinous; Arete's question.

- 1 So he prayed there, much-enduring noble
Odysseus,
- 2 while the mules' strength carried the girl to the
city.
- 3 And when she reached her father's famous
house,
- 4 she halted at the gateway; and her brothers
around her
- 5 stood, men like the immortals, and from under
the wagon
- 6 they loosed the mules, and carried the clothing
in;
- 7 and she herself went to her room. And her fire
was lit
- 8 by an old woman of Apeire, the chamber-keeper
Eurymedusa,¹
- 9 whom once the curved ships brought from

Apeire:

10 they had picked her out as a prize of honor for
Alcinous,

11 because he ruled all the Phaeacians, and the
people listened to him as to a god.

12 She had nursed white-armed Nausicaa in the
halls,

13 and now she kindled her fire and made her
supper in her room.

14 And then Odysseus rose to go to the city; and
Athena,

15 with kind thought for Odysseus, poured a thick
mist around him,²

16 so that no great-hearted Phaeacian, crossing
his path,

17 might needle him with words and ask him who
he was.

18 But when he was on the point of entering the
lovely city,

19 there the goddess, gray-eyed Athena, met him,

20 in the likeness of a young girl, unwed, carrying
a pitcher.

21 She stopped in front of him, and noble
Odysseus asked her:
22 “Child, would you not guide me to the house of
a man
23 named Alcinous, who is lord among these
people?
24 I am a stranger, hard-worn, come here
25 from far away, out of a distant country: so I
know not one
26 of the people whose city and land this is.”
27 Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-
eyed Athena:
28 “Then I will show you, father stranger, the
house you bid me
29 show: for he lives close by my own blameless
father.
30 Only go in silence, so, and I will lead the way:
31 do not look at any of the people, and ask no
questions.
32 For these men do not much endure strangers,³
33 nor welcome with open love the man who
comes from elsewhere.

34 They trust instead in their fast ships, their
swift ones,
35 and cross the great gulf on them, since the
earth-shaker granted it:
36 ships swift as a wing, or as a thought.”⁴
37 So speaking, Pallas Athena led the way
38 swiftly, and he followed in the footsteps of the
god.
39 And the Phaeacians, famed for ships, never
marked him
40 going through the city among them: Athena
41 of the lovely braids would not allow it — the
dread goddess —
42 who poured a wondrous haze around him, with
kind thought in her heart.
43 And Odysseus wondered at the harbors and the
trim ships,
44 at the gathering-places of the heroes
themselves, and the walls,
45 long and high, fitted with palisades, a wonder
to see.
46 But when they came to the king’s famous

house,

47 the goddess, gray-eyed Athena, began to speak
among them:

48 “Here, father stranger, is the house you bid me
49 show you. You will find the Zeus-nurtured
kings

50 feasting at the feast. Go in, and let your heart
51 fear nothing: the bold man proves the better
man5

52 in every venture, though he come from
another country.

53 First you will come upon the mistress in the
halls:

54 Arete is the name she is called, and she comes
of the same6

55 parents, the very ones who fathered King
Alcinous.

56 Nausithous first was born from Poseidon the
earth-shaker

57 and Periboea, loveliest of women,

58 youngest daughter of great-hearted
Eurymedon,

59 who once was king over the overweening
Giants —

60 but he destroyed his reckless people, and was
destroyed himself.

61 With her Poseidon lay, and fathered a son,
62 great-hearted Nausithous, who ruled among
the Phaeacians;

63 and Nausithous fathered Rhexenor and
Alcinous.

64 Rhexenor — still without a son, a bridegroom
in his hall —

65 Apollo of the silver bow struck down, leaving
one only child,

66 Arete. Her Alcinous made his wife,

67 and honored her as no other woman on earth
is honored,⁷

68 of all the wives who now keep house under
their husbands:

69 so heartfelt is the honor she has held, and
holds still,

70 from her dear children and from Alcinous
himself

71 and from the people, who look on her as on a
god

72 and greet her with blessings when she walks
through the town.

73 For she herself has no lack of noble
understanding:

74 for those she favors — even men — she
dissolves quarrels.⁸

75 If she once takes kindly thought for you in her
heart,

76 then there is hope you will see your own
people, and come

77 to your high-roofed house and your own
fatherland.”

78 So speaking, gray-eyed Athena went away

79 over the barren sea, and left lovely Scheria,

80 and came to Marathon and wide-wayed
Athens,⁹

81 and entered the close-built house of
Erechtheus. But Odysseus

82 went toward the famous house of Alcinous,
and his heart

83 was churning as he stood there, before he
reached the threshold of bronze.

84 For there was a sheen as of the sun or the
moon¹⁰

85 through the high-roofed house of great-
hearted Alcinous.

86 Walls of bronze ran this way and that,

87 from the threshold to the inmost room, with a
frieze of blue enamel round them;

88 doors of gold closed the close-built house
within;

89 the doorposts standing on the bronze
threshold were of silver,

90 the lintel above was silver, and the door-
handle gold;

91 and on either side stood dogs of gold and
silver¹¹

92 that Hephaestus had made with his knowing
craft

93 to guard the house of great-hearted Alcinous

—

94 creatures deathless and unaging all their days.

95 And within, seats stood along the wall this way
and that,

96 from the threshold to the inmost room in an
unbroken line, and over them

97 were thrown fine close-spun coverings, the
work of women.

98 There the leaders of the Phaeacians would sit
99 drinking and eating: what they had never
failed.

100 And youths of gold on well-built pedestals
101 stood holding blazing torches in their hands,
102 lighting the nights through the house for the
feasters.

103 And fifty slave-women serve the house:12
104 some grind the apple-gold grain at the mill,
105 others weave at the looms and turn the
spindles,

106 sitting close as the leaves of a tall poplar,
107 and from the close-woven linen the soft oil
runs.

108 As far as the Phaeacian men are skilled
beyond all others

109 at driving a fast ship on the sea, so are their
women
110 masters of the loom: for Athena has given
them beyond others
111 knowledge of beautiful work, and noble minds.
112 And outside the courtyard, close by the doors,
is a great orchard¹³
113 of four acres, with a hedge driven round it on
both sides.
114 There tall trees grow in full leaf and flower:
115 pears and pomegranates and apple trees
bright with fruit,
116 sweet figs and olives in full flourish.
117 Their fruit never perishes, never fails,
118 winter or summer, the year round; but always
119 the breathing West Wind sets some growing,
ripens others:
120 pear grows old upon pear, apple upon apple,
121 grape-cluster upon cluster, fig upon fig.
122 And there his vineyard, heavy with fruit, is
rooted,
123 one part of it a drying-ground on level open

earth,

124 baking in the sun; other grapes they are
gathering,

125 and others they are treading; and out in front
are the unripe ones,

126 one row shedding its blossom, another
darkening toward purple.

127 And there, by the last row of vines, grow
ordered beds

128 of greens of every kind, shining the whole
year through;

129 and two springs: one is scattered through all
the garden,

130 the other dives under the courtyard threshold
and runs

131 toward the high house, where the townsfolk
drew their water.

132 Such were the shining gifts of the gods in the
house of Alcinous.

133 There much-enduring noble Odysseus stood
gazing.14

134 And when his heart had wondered at it all,

135 he stepped quickly over the threshold into the house.

136 He found the leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians

137 pouring from their cups to the sharp-eyed slayer of Argus,15

138 to whom they poured last of all, when they thought of sleep.

139 But much-enduring noble Odysseus went on through the house

140 wrapped in the thick mist Athena had poured around him,

141 until he came to Arete and to King Alcinous.

142 And Odysseus threw his arms around Arete's knees —16

143 and then, just then, the god-sent mist poured back off him.

144 And they fell dumb through the house at the sight of the man,

145 and stared in wonder. And Odysseus made his plea:

146 “Arete, daughter of godlike Rhexenor:

147 to your husband, to your knees, I come after
much labor —

148 and to these feasters. May the gods grant
them fortunate

149 lives; and may each hand down to his children
150 the wealth in his halls, and the honors the
people have given him.

151 But for me — speed my sending, that I may
come to my fatherland,

152 and quickly: for long now, far from my own
people, I suffer pains.”

153 So speaking he sat down on the hearth, in the
ashes¹⁷

154 by the fire; and they were all hushed in
silence.

155 At long last the old hero Echeneus spoke —

156 a man elder-born beyond the other
Phaeacians,

157 who excelled in speech, knowing many things
grown old with him;

158 with good will toward them he spoke to the
assembly:

159 “Alcinous, this is not the fairer way — it is not fitting —
160 a stranger sitting on the ground, on the hearth, in the ashes,
161 while these men hold themselves in, waiting for your word.
162 Come — raise the stranger up, and seat him on a chair
163 with silver studs, and bid the heralds
164 mix more wine, so that to Zeus who delights in thunder
165 we may pour also — the god who walks beside honored suppliants;18
166 and let the housekeeper give the stranger supper from her stores.”
167 And when the sacred strength of Alcinous heard it,19
168 he took the hand of battle-wise Odysseus, the man of shifting counsels,
169 raised him from the hearth and set him on a shining chair,
170 making his son stand up — kind-hearted

Laodamas,²⁰

¹⁷¹ who sat beside him, and whom he loved the most.

¹⁷² A handmaid brought water for their hands in a pitcher,

¹⁷³ a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a silver basin

¹⁷⁴ for them to wash, and drew up a polished table beside them.

¹⁷⁵ The grave housekeeper brought bread and set it before them,

¹⁷⁶ laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of her store;

¹⁷⁷ and he drank and ate, much-enduring noble Odysseus.

¹⁷⁸ And then the strength of Alcinous said to the herald:

¹⁷⁹ “Pontonous, mix the bowl, and serve out the wine

¹⁸⁰ to all in the hall, so that to Zeus who delights in thunder

¹⁸¹ we may pour also — the god who walks beside

honored suppliants.”

182 So he spoke, and Pontonous mixed the honey-
hearted wine

183 and served all, pouring first drops in each cup
for the gods.

184 But when they had poured, and drunk what
their hearts would have,

185 Alcinous addressed them all, and said:

186 “Hear me, leaders and counselors of the
Phaeacians,21

187 while I say what the heart in my breast
commands.

188 Now you have feasted: go home and take your
rest;

189 in the morning we will call more of the elders
together

190 and host the stranger in the halls, and offer
the gods

191 fine victims; and after that we will think also

192 of his sending, so that without labor or pain
this stranger

193 may come, under our escort, to his own

fatherland

194 rejoicing, and quickly, though he come from
very far,

195 and suffer no evil or harm midway

196 before he sets foot in his own land. There,
afterward,

197 he will suffer whatever Destiny and the grave
Spinners²²

198 spun in his thread at his birth, when his
mother bore him.

199 But if he is one of the deathless ones, come
down from heaven,²³

200 then this is some new thing the gods are
devising:

201 for always in time past the gods have shown
themselves openly

202 to us, whenever we offer glorious hecatombs,

203 and they feast beside us, sitting where we sit.

204 And if a lone traveler on the road meets them,

205 they use no disguise with us — for we are of
near kin,

206 like the Cyclopes and the wild tribes of the

Giants.”

207 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

208 “Alcinous, let your mind be easy on that
count. I am not²⁴

209 like the deathless ones who hold wide heaven,
210 not in build, not in bearing: I am like mortal
men.

211 Whoever you know among mankind who
carry the heaviest

212 loads of misery — it is to them I would
compare my pains.

213 Yes, and I could tell a still longer tale of evils,
214 all that I have labored through by the gods’
will.

215 But let me eat my supper, for all my grief:²⁵

216 for there is nothing more dog-shameless than
the hateful belly,

217 which commands a man to remember it, by
force,

218 however worn he is, however deep the sorrow
in his heart —

219 as I have sorrow in my heart, and still this
thing
220 forever bids me eat and drink, and makes me
forget
221 all I have suffered, and orders me: be filled.
222 But you — bestir yourselves at the showing of
dawn,
223 to set me, unlucky as I am, on my own fathers'
soil,
224 even after all I have suffered. And let life leave
me once I have seen26
225 my own possessions, my slaves, and my great
high-roofed house.”
226 So he spoke, and they all approved it and
urged
227 that the stranger be sent home, since he had
spoken rightly.
228 But when they had poured, and drunk what
their hearts would have,
229 the others went home to sleep, each man to
his own house,
230 and noble Odysseus was left behind in the

hall,

231 and beside him sat Arete and godlike

Alcinous,

232 while the handmaids cleared away the service
of the feast.

233 And white-armed Arete began to speak
among them —27

234 for she had recognized the mantle and the
tunic, seeing the beautiful

235 clothes she herself had made with her
attendant women —

236 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words
to him:

237 “Stranger, this question first, and I ask it
myself:

238 What man are you, and from where? Who
gave you these clothes?

239 Did you not say you came here wandering
over the sea?”

240 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

241 “It is hard, my queen, to tell my griefs straight

through²⁸

²⁴² to the end: the gods of heaven have given me
so many.

²⁴³ But this I will tell you, since you ask it of me
and inquire.

²⁴⁴ There is an island, Ogygia, lying far off in the
sea,

²⁴⁵ where the daughter of Atlas lives — guileful
Calypso

²⁴⁶ of the lovely braids, a dread goddess; and no
one

²⁴⁷ mixes with her, no god, no mortal man.

²⁴⁸ But me — unlucky me — some power brought
to her hearth

²⁴⁹ alone, after Zeus with a hurl of the white
lightning had shattered

²⁵⁰ my fast ship apart in the middle of the wine-
dark sea.

²⁵¹ There all the rest of my brave companions
perished,

²⁵² but I threw my arms round the keel of my
curved ship

253 and was carried nine days; and on the tenth,
in the black night,
254 the gods brought me near the island Ogygia,
where Calypso
255 lives, she of the lovely braids, the dread
goddess. And she took me in
256 and loved me and tended me devotedly, and
promised
257 to make me deathless and unaging all my
days;
258 but she never once persuaded the heart in my
breast.
259 There I stayed seven years unbroken, and
forever wet
260 with my tears the immortal clothing Calypso
gave me.
261 But when the eighth year came wheeling
round for me,
262 then at last she urged me — commanded me
— to go,
263 whether by some message from Zeus, or her
own mind had turned.29

264 She sent me off on a raft bound plank to
plank, and gave me much —
265 bread and sweet wine — and dressed me in
immortal clothing,
266 and sent up a fair wind for me, harmless and
warm.
267 Seventeen days I sailed on, crossing the water,
268 and on the eighteenth appeared the shadowy
mountains
269 of your land, and my own heart was glad —
270 ill-fated as I was: for I was yet to keep
company with misery
271 in plenty, sent upon me by Poseidon the
earth-shaker,
272 who loosed the winds against me and barred
my road,
273 and stirred up a sea past all speaking; nor
would the wave
274 let me be carried on my raft, for all my thick
groaning.
275 The squall then shattered the raft to pieces.
But I

276 swam — cut my way across that gulf — until
wind and water
277 carried me near, and brought me to your land.
278 There, as I climbed out, the wave would have
forced me onto the shore,
279 dashing me on the great rocks in a joyless
place;
280 but I gave way, and swam back out, until I
came
281 to a river, where at last the ground seemed
best to me,
282 clear of stones, and there was shelter from
the wind.
283 I dropped there, gathering my spirit back; and
ambrosial night
284 came on. I climbed out clear of the heaven-
fed river
285 and fell asleep in the bushes, and heaped the
fallen leaves
286 around me; and a god poured down boundless
sleep.
287 There in the leaves, my heart worn down with

grief,

288 I slept the whole night through, and dawn,
and midday;

289 the sun was slanting down when sweet sleep
let me go.

290 And I saw your daughter's handmaids on the
beach

291 at play, and she among them, like the
goddesses.

292 To her I made my plea. And she did not fail in
noble understanding —30

293 as you would not hope of the young when you
meet them

294 face to face: for the young are forever
thoughtless.

295 She gave me bread in plenty, and fire-bright
wine,

296 and a bath in the river, and gave me these
clothes.

297 That, for all my grieving, is the truth of it,
told through."

298 Then Alcinous answered him in turn, and

said:

299 “Stranger, in this one point, truly, my child
did not see

300 rightly: that she did not bring you with her
attendant women

301 to our house — when she was the first you
supplicated.”

302 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

303 “Hero, do not scold your blameless daughter
for that.31

304 She did tell me to follow along with her
handmaids;

305 it was I who would not — out of fear, out of
shame,

306 lest perhaps your own heart darken at the
sight:

307 we are jealous-minded things, we tribes of
men upon the earth.”

308 Then Alcinous answered him in turn, and
said:

309 “Stranger, the heart in my breast is not the

kind

310 to take fire for nothing. Due measure is better
in all things.

311 If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo! —32

312 being the man you are, and thinking as I
think,

313 you would take my daughter and be called my
son-in-law,

314 staying here: I would give you a house and
possessions —

315 if you stayed willingly. Against your will no
Phaeacian

316 shall hold you: father Zeus forbid such a thing.

317 As for your sending, I appoint it — be sure of it
—

318 for tomorrow. Till then you will lie mastered
by sleep,

319 and they will row the calm, until you come

320 to your fatherland and your house, and
whatever place is dear to you,

321 though it be far, much farther than Euboea —

33

322 which those of our people say is farthest of all

323 who saw it, when they carried fair-haired

Rhadamanthus

324 out to visit Tityus, the son of Earth.

325 They went all the way there, and finished it
without strain,

326 and on the same day accomplished the
journey home again.

327 And you shall know for yourself, in your own
heart, how far my ships

328 are the best — and my young men at throwing
up the sea with the oar-blade.”

329 So he spoke; and much-enduring noble
Odysseus was glad,

330 and he spoke in prayer, and said a word, and
named:

331 “Father Zeus, may Alcinous accomplish all

332 he has said: on the grain-giving earth his
fame

333 would be unquenchable — and I would come
to my fatherland.”

334 So the two of them spoke such things to one

another,

335 while white-armed Arete told her handmaids

336 to set out bedsteads under the porch, and to

lay on them³⁴

337 beautiful purple blankets, and spread rugs

above,

338 and fleecy cloaks on top of all, for cover.

339 Out of the hall they went with torches in their

hands;

340 and when they had briskly spread the close-corded bed,

341 they came and stood beside Odysseus and called him:

342 “Up, stranger, come and sleep: your bed is made.”³⁵

343 So they spoke; and welcome it seemed to him to sleep.

344 So he slept there, much-enduring noble Odysseus,

345 on a corded bedstead under the echoing porch;

346 but Alcinous lay down in the inner room of

the high house,³⁶

³⁴⁷ where the lady his wife made ready his bed
and his rest.

Notes

NOTES

1. Eurymedusa, the old chamber-keeper, gets the poem's standard slave-biography: where she was taken from (Apeire), how she came (by ship), and why she went to the king ("a prize of honor"). As with Eurycleia's twenty oxen (1.430–431), the poem dignifies the person while stating the transaction plainly. ↩
2. Athena's mist — the hero walking unseen through a marveling city to a royal hall — is the scene Virgil lifted whole for Aeneas' entry into Carthage (*Aeneid* 1.411ff.). The mist does double work: protection, and theatrical timing; it will burst at the exact moment of maximum effect (143). ↩
3. "These men do not much endure strangers": the guide-girl's warning sits oddly against Phaeacia's perfect hospitality — and that is the point. The blessed are insular; their kindness, once triggered by proper supplication, is flawless, but nothing about them goes looking for the world. They are hosts, not neighbors (they have none: 6.204–205, 279). ↩

4. “Ships swift as a wing, or as a thought” — the first hint of the marvel made explicit at 8.557–563: Phaeacian ships steer by thought, without helmsmen. Poseidon’s own grant (35), which makes what Poseidon later does about it a family matter. ↩
5. “The bold man proves the better man in every venture” — Athena’s parting maxim to a man about to walk into a strange hall with nothing. It is the disguised goddess’s variant of what she told Telemachus at 3.14; father and son get the same curriculum, adjusted for experience. ↩
6. Arete’s name is transparent in Greek: ἀρητός, “prayed-for” — both the long-desired only child of a dead father, and precisely the person to whom this book’s prayer must be addressed. The poem names its own protocol: to get home, pray to the Prayed-For. ↩
7. The claim is absolute: honored “as no other woman on earth is honored... of all the wives who now keep house under their husbands.” The genealogy behind it (uncle marrying his dead brother’s only child) makes her both queen and sole heiress of the founder’s line — one root of her extraordinary standing, though the poem rests the case on her mind (73–74), not her blood. ↩
8. “For those she favors — even men — she dissolves quarrels”: Arete exercises judicial authority, settling men’s disputes. No other mortal woman in Homer holds that power. Odysseus is being routed toward the one person on Scheria whose verdict functions like a court’s. ↩
9. Athena exits to “Marathon and wide-wayed Athens... the close-built house of Erechtheus” — one of the poem’s very few

notices of mainland cult: the goddess lodging in the old king's house on the Acropolis (the arrangement the Erechtheum later monumentalized). A quiet bow toward an Athenian audience, planted in fairyland. ↩

10. The palace (84–132) glows with the sun-and-moon line used of Menelaus' hall (4.45) — and then outbids it: walls of bronze, a frieze of κύαρος (blue glass-paste — a real Mycenaean architectural luxury; excavation found exactly such friezes at Tiryns), gold doors, silver posts and lintel. The poem's memory of the Bronze Age is sometimes archaeologically exact. ↩
11. Hephaestus' watchdogs of gold and silver, "deathless and unaging all their days" — automata, like the god's golden serving-women in *Iliad* 18. The phrase is the very one Calypso used of the immortality offered Odysseus (5.136). On Scheria, what he refused is lawn ornamentation. ↩
12. Fifty slave-women — grinding, weaving, spinning, "sitting close as the leaves of a tall poplar," the oil sheen running off the close-woven linen. Then the summary economy (108–111): the men are masters of ships, the women of looms, both by Athena's gift. It is the same praise-structure Antinous used of Penelope's skill (2.116–118) — Athena's gifts to women are real capital in this poem. ↩
13. The garden of Alcinoos — the most famous orchard in Western literature: four acres where fruit "never perishes, never fails, winter or summer," the West Wind ripening one crop while it starts the next, "pear grows old upon pear, apple upon apple." Eternal yield without labor — the agricultural face of the Olympus/Elysium weather (6.42–46, 4.566–568). Its deliberate

opposite waits at the far end of the poem: Laertes' orchard in Book 24, where every tree is known by name because every tree was dug, dunged, and counted — love's agriculture against paradise's. ↩

14. He stands and gazes until "his heart had wondered at it all" — the identical formula used of Hermes admiring Calypso's cave (5.75–76). The poem grades its paradises by making gods and heroes tourists in each other's. ↩
15. The last cup of the night is poured to Hermes — god of sleep-bringing (5.47–48) and safe conduct. The Phaeacians' nightcap piety is exactly the god a homeless traveler needs already in the room. ↩
16. The staged epiphany: he crosses the hall invisible, touches the queen's knees, and *then* the mist pours off — the suppliant materializing out of nothing at the one correct pair of knees. Athena has choreographed the supplication Nausicaa scripted (6.310–315) into a coup de théâtre. ↩
17. After the plea, he sits down "on the hearth, in the ashes": the suppliant's total self-abasement, placing himself at the house's sacred center as its lowest thing. The hall's stunned silence (154) is the ritual working; Echeneus' intervention states the norm the scene has been built to trigger — no stranger sits in ashes while men look on. ↩
18. "Zeus who delights in thunder... the god who walks beside honored suppliants" — Zeus Hiketesios, protector of suppliants, invoked twice in seventeen lines (164–165, 180–181). The doctrine Nausicaa cited on the beach (6.207–208) is here performed as liturgy by the state. ↩

19. “The sacred strength of Alcinous” — the same periphrasis of honor the poem gave Telemachus on the night of his first command (2.409). Applied to Alcinous it is nearly a title; the translation keeps the strangeness both times. ↩
20. To seat the suppliant, the king displaces Laodamas — the son “he loved the most,” from the chair nearest him. Precedence made physical: on Scheria the stranger outranks the favorite child. Remember the suitors, who would not yield a stool. ↩
21. “Hear me, leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians” — Alcinous’ assembly-formula, fixed here; it will toll through Books 8, 11, and 13, the Phaeacian counterpart of “Hear me now, men of Ithaca” (2.25). ↩
22. “Whatever Destiny and the grave Spinners spun in his thread at his birth” — the Κλωθες, the Spinners, appear by that name only here in Homer (elsewhere fate is spun by gods or by Aisa). Alcinous’ theology is precise: escort ends at the beach; thread resumes at the property line. ↩
23. Alcinous’ strange boast: gods dine with Phaeacians undisguised, “for we are of near kin, like the Cyclopes and the wild tribes of the Giants.” The genealogy is real (Poseidon fathered their founder; Periboea was a Giant’s daughter) — and unsettling: the perfect hosts locate themselves beside the poem’s monsters, kin to both. Civilization here is a choice made *within* that bloodline, not an escape from it — the Cyclops episode, one narrative hour away, is a family portrait. ↩
24. For the second time in three books, Odysseus is mistaken for (or offered the status of) a god, and refuses downward: “compare me instead to the most miserable of men.” His identity-claims

run consistently toward the mortal, the suffering, the hungry — which his next sentence makes literal. ↩

25. The belly speech: “nothing more dog-shameless than the hateful belly,” which makes even the deep-grieving eat, “and orders me: be filled.” Ancient critics were scandalized that an epic hero talks this way; it is precisely the poem’s signature. The γαστήρ that drove the lion at 6.133 here gets its full philosophy: grief is aristocratic, hunger is democratic, and the survivor obeys the latter to keep the former. No Iliadic hero could have said it; ten years of shipwreck teach a different physics. ↩
26. His stated wish: to see “my own possessions, my slaves, and my great high-roofed house” — and then die content. No wife named. To read it as coldness is to misread the room: he is a nameless stranger among strangers, and Penelope is the one possession of his heart he will not set on the table. The reticence is protective — and the poem lets it also be ominous: he does not yet know what he will find. ↩
27. Arete has waited out the whole evening — feast, speeches, the hall emptying — and then asks, with the two of them beside the fire, the poem’s standard identity question plus one of her own: “Who gave you these clothes?” She wove them; she knows. It is the shrewdest three lines any host asks in the Odyssey: courteous in form, and in substance a queen cross-examining a stranger who has appeared out of thin air wearing her household’s linen with her marriageable daughter unaccounted for. ↩

28. His answer (241–297) is the poem’s first extended self-narration: strictly truthful, strictly selective. No name, no Troy, no fame — the story begins at Ogygia and covers exactly what we watched in Books 5–6, reusing the very lines (Zeus’ thunderbolt = 5.131–132; deathless-and-unaging = 5.136; seventeen days and the shadowy mountains = 5.278–279; the river-mouth “clear of stones... shelter from the wind” = 5.442–443). He answers the clothes question fully, and the identity question not at all — and Arete lets it stand, for now. ↩
29. “Whether by some message from Zeus, or her own mind had turned” — he genuinely does not know why Calypso released him: Hermes’ visit happened offstage of his life. The poem is scrupulous about who knows what; its hero narrates from inside his own horizon, and the audience holds the fuller map. This discipline is about to matter enormously, four books of first-person narration ahead. ↩
30. Covering for Nausicaa begins with a general slander of the young (“forever thoughtless”) that she has just disproven — and proceeds, under Alcinous’ mild criticism, to a full gallant lie (304–305): *she* told him to follow; *he* refused from fear and shame. The reverse of the truth (6.257ff.), told to spare her the exact reproach she foresaw. Odysseus’ first lie on Scheria is told for someone else’s sake; Alcinous believes it, and the poem smiles. ↩
31. “Do not scold your blameless daughter”: he deploys ἀμύμων — the grand epic honorific — for a girl accused of a breach of etiquette, gently overweighting the scale in her favor. The word choice is itself part of the shield. ↩

32. Alcinous' offer — my daughter, a house, possessions, “being the man you are, and thinking as I think” (τά τε φρονέων ἅ τ' ἐγὼ περ). The father independently arrives at Nausicaa's own wish (6.244–245), and grounds it in *like-mindedness* — the very ὁμοφροσύνη Odysseus blessed her with on the beach (6.181–185). And then, in the same breath, the anti-Calypso clause: “against your will no Phaeacian shall hold you.” An offer that guarantees your freedom to refuse it is Phaeacia in one sentence — the good temptation, courteously declined by a man whose measure of marriage the family keeps unknowingly quoting back to him. ↩
33. Euboea as “farthest of all” — the geography of fairyland, for which the middle of the Greek world is the edge of the earth. The proof-voyage: they once ferried Rhadamanthus (the Elysian judge, 4.564) to visit Tityus son of Earth, and were home the same day. Ships that day-trip between paradise and the giants make short work of Ithaca — and the boast will draw Poseidon's eye (13.125ff.). ↩
34. The bed-making orders repeat Helen's verbatim (4.297–299), and the guest-bed line “on a corded bedstead under the echoing porch” is Telemachus' at Pylos (3.399). Odysseus has entered the same hospitality type-scene his son traveled through — father and son now sleeping in the poem's same formulaic bed, three seas apart. ↩
35. “Up, stranger, come and sleep: your bed is made.” After eighteen days of open water, cliff-faces, and leaf-piles, the poem gives the handmaids one line of plain human kindness — the simplest sentence in the book, and the most restorative. ↩

36. The closing couplet reworks the Nestor-night ending (3.402–403), lightly adapted to its new house: king in the inner room, wife making ready the bed. The book is one immense hospitality type-scene executed perfectly at every step — mist to knees to ashes to chair to feast to question to bed — and it closes on the form's quietest cadence: everyone, at last, in their right place. ↩

Odyssey — Book 8

The games; the song of Ares and Aphrodite; the wooden horse, and the weeping guest.

- 1 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,
- 2 the sacred strength of Alcinous rose up from his
bed,
- 3 and up rose Zeus-born Odysseus, sacker of
cities.¹
- 4 And the sacred strength of Alcinous led the way
- 5 to the Phaeacians' gathering-place, built there
beside the ships.
- 6 They came and sat down on the polished stones
- 7 side by side. And Pallas Athena went up and
down the city
- 8 in the likeness of a herald of wise Alcinous,
- 9 devising the homecoming of great-hearted
Odysseus,
- 10 and standing beside each man she spoke her

word:

11 “This way, come — leaders and counselors of
the Phaeacians —

12 to the gathering-place, to learn about the
stranger

13 who has come new to the house of wise
Alcinous

14 after wandering the sea — a man like the
immortals in body.”

15 So speaking she stirred the strength and spirit
of each,

16 and quickly the gathering-place and the seats
were filled

17 with men assembling; and many marveled at
the sight

18 of Laertes’ battle-wise son. For Athena

19 poured a wondrous grace over his head and
shoulders

20 and made him taller to look at, and broader,

21 so that he might be dear to all the Phaeacians,

22 and dreaded, and revered, and might
accomplish the many

23 trials in which the Phaeacians would test
Odysseus.

24 And when they were assembled, all in one
gathering,

25 Alcinous addressed them all, and said:

26 “Hear me, leaders and counselors of the
Phaeacians,

27 while I say what the heart in my breast
commands.

28 This stranger — I do not know who he is — has
come wandering to my house,

29 whether from the men of the east or of the
west;

30 he presses for a sending, and pleads that it be
made sure.

31 Let us then, as always before, speed his sending
on.

32 For no man, no — no one who ever comes to
my house

33 waits here long, grieving for his escort.

34 Come: let us haul a black ship down to the
bright salt water,

35 one on her first voyage, and let fifty-two young
men²

36 be chosen through the town, as many as have
proven best.

37 Lash your oars well to the benches, every one,
38 then come ashore; and afterward come to my
house

39 and see to a feast at speed: I will provide well
for all.

40 To the young men these are my orders. And
you others,

41 sceptered kings, come to my beautiful house,
42 so we may welcome the stranger in the halls —
43 let no man refuse. And call the godlike singer,
44 Demodocus: for to him the god has given song³
45 beyond all others, to delight men however his
heart is stirred to sing.”

46 So speaking he led the way, and the sceptered
kings

47 followed with him; and a herald went for the
godlike singer.

48 And the fifty-two young men, chosen out,

49 went, as he commanded, to the beach of the
barren sea.

50 And when they had come down to the ship and
the sea,

51 they hauled the black ship down to deep water,

52 and set the mast and the sails in the black ship,

53 and fitted the oars into their leather slings,

54 all in due order, and spread the white sails
open.

55 They moored her well out in the water, and
then

56 went their way to the great house of wise
Alcinous.

57 And the porticoes and courts and halls were
filled

58 with men assembling: there were many, young
and old.

59 For them Alcinous slaughtered twelve sheep,

60 eight white-tusked hogs, and two shambling
oxen;

61 these they flayed and dressed, and made the
lovely feast ready.

62 And the herald came near, leading the trusted
singer,
63 whom the Muse loved beyond other men, and
gave him good and evil both:⁴
64 she took away his eyes, and gave him sweet
song.
65 For him Pontonous set a silver-studded chair
66 in the middle of the feasters, leaning it on a
tall pillar,
67 and hung the clear-voiced lyre on its peg
68 just above his head, and showed him how to
reach it
69 with his hands; and set by him a basket and a
beautiful table,
70 and a cup of wine beside, to drink when his
heart should bid him.
71 And their hands went out to the good things
spread before them.
72 But when they had put away desire for food
and drink,
73 the Muse stirred the singer to sing the famous
deeds of men,

74 from that song whose fame had then already
reached wide heaven:

75 the quarrel of Odysseus and Achilles, Peleus'
son —5

76 how once they clashed at the gods' rich feast
77 with terrible words, and the lord of men
Agamemnon

78 rejoiced in his heart that the best of the
Achaeans were quarreling.

79 For so Phoebus Apollo had told him in
prophecy

80 at holy Pytho, when he crossed the stone
threshold

81 to consult the god: then the beginning of woe
was rolling down

82 on Trojans and Danaans alike, through the
counsels of great Zeus.

83 This the famous singer sang. But Odysseus6

84 took his great purple cloak in his heavy hands

85 and drew it down over his head, and hid his
handsome face:

86 he was ashamed to let the tears run under his

brows before the Phaeacians.

87 Whenever the godlike singer paused in his singing,

88 he would wipe the tears away, and take the cloak from his head,

89 and lifting the two-handled cup would pour to the gods;

90 but whenever he began again, and the best of the Phaeacians

91 urged him to sing, because they took joy in the tale,

92 Odysseus would cover his head again, and mourn.

93 From all the others he hid the tears he shed;

94 Alcinous alone remarked him and noticed,

95 sitting beside him, and heard his heavy groaning.

96 At once he spoke among the oar-loving Phaeacians:

97 “Hear me, leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians.

98 By now we have had our hearts’ fill of the

shared feast,

99 and of the lyre, which is the companion of the rich feast.

100 Now let us go out and try our hands at contests,

101 all of them — so that the stranger may tell his own people,

102 when he has come home, how far we surpass others

103 at boxing and wrestling and jumping and speed of foot.”

104 So speaking he led the way, and they went with him.

105 And the herald hung the clear-voiced lyre on its peg,

106 took Demodocus by the hand, and led him out of the hall,

107 guiding him along the same road the others

108 had gone, the best of the Phaeacians, to wonder at the games.

109 They went their way to the gathering-place, and a huge crowd followed,

110 thousands; and many fine young men stood
up.

111 Up rose Acroneus and Ocyalus and Elatreus,⁷

112 Nauteus and Prymneus and Anchialus and
Eretmeus,

113 Ponteus and Proreus, Thoon and Anabesineus,

114 and Amphialus, son of Polyneus, Tecton's son;

115 and up rose Euryalus, the equal of man-
destroying Ares,

116 Naubolus' son, who was best in beauty and
body

117 of all the Phaeacians after blameless
Laodamas.

118 And up stood the three sons of blameless
Alcinous:

119 Laodamas, and Halius, and godlike Clytoneus.

120 First they made trial of one another in the
footrace.

121 The course was stretched for them from the
turning-post, and all together

122 they flew off quickly, raising the dust of the
plain;

123 and far the best at running was blameless
Clytoneus:

124 by as much as the width of a mule-team's
furrow in fallow ground,⁸

125 by that much he outran the rest to the crowd,
and left them behind.

126 Then they made trial of grinding wrestling,

127 and there Euryalus outdid all the best;

128 at the jump Amphialus was first of them all;

129 with the discus far the best of all was Elatreus,

130 and at boxing Laodamas, Alcinous' good son.

131 And when they had all taken their hearts'
pleasure in the contests,

132 Laodamas, Alcinous' son, spoke among them:

133 "Come, friends, let us ask the stranger
whether he knows

134 any contest, and has learned it. In build, at
least, he is no mean man —

135 the thighs and calves of him, the two arms
above,

136 the massive neck, the great strength; nor does
he lack

137 the prime of youth — only he is broken by
many evils.

138 For I say there is nothing worse than the sea
139 to shatter a man, however strong he be.”

140 Then Euryalus answered him in turn, and
said:

141 “Laodamas, you have spoken this word in due
measure.

142 Now go yourself and challenge him, and speak
your speech.”

143 And when the good son of Alcinous heard it,
144 he went and stood in the middle, and
addressed Odysseus:

145 “Come you too, father stranger: try your hand
at the contests,

146 if you have learned any — and it is like you to
know contests:

147 for there is no greater fame for a man, while
he lives,⁹

148 than what he achieves with his own feet and
hands.

149 Come, make a trial; scatter the cares from

your heart.

150 Your road will not be long delayed now:
already

151 the ship is hauled down, and the companions
are ready.”

152 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

153 “Laodamas, why do you all urge this on me,
mocking?

154 Cares are closer to my heart than contests.

155 I have suffered much before now, much have I
labored,

156 and now I sit in your gathering hungry for
homecoming,

157 pleading with the king and with all the
people.”

158 Then Euryalus answered him — and jeered to
his face:

159 “No, stranger: I do not take you for a man of
contests,¹⁰

160 such as are held in plenty among mankind —

161 rather for one who plies to and fro in a many-

benched ship,

162 a master of sailors who are traders,

163 with a memory for cargo, an eye on his freight

164 and his grasping profits. You are no athlete.”

165 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus
of the many designs replied:11

166 “Stranger, you have not spoken well. You are
like a man blinded by folly.

167 So true it is that the gods do not give their
graces to all men12

168 alike — not build, and brains, and speaking-
skill together.

169 One man is slighter to look at, but the god

170 crowns his shape with words, and men gaze at
him

171 delighted, while he speaks on without a
stumble,

172 with honeyed modesty, and shines among the
gathered people,

173 and when he walks the town they look on him
as on a god.

174 Another again is like the immortals in beauty,

175 but no grace is set like a crown upon his
words.

176 So with you: your looks are striking — not a
god

177 could better them — but your mind is an
empty thing.

178 You have stirred the heart in my breast

179 by speaking out of all measure. I am no novice
at contests,

180 whatever you may say. I count myself among
the first,

181 as long as I could trust my youth and these my
hands.

182 Now I am held in misery and pain: I have
endured much,

183 cutting through wars of men and the grinding
waves.

184 But even so, for all my many evils, I will try
your contests:

185 your word has bitten to the heart, and your
speech has stung me to it.”

186 He spoke, and cloak and all he sprang up, and

seized a discus¹³

¹⁸⁷ bigger than the rest, and thick — heavier by
no small measure

¹⁸⁸ than the ones the Phaeacians threw among
themselves.

¹⁸⁹ He spun and let it fly from his massive hand,

¹⁹⁰ and the stone hummed; and down to the
ground they cowered —

¹⁹¹ the Phaeacians of the long oars, men famed
for ships —

¹⁹² under the rush of the stone. Past all their
marks it flew,

¹⁹³ running light off his hand. And Athena set the
mark,

¹⁹⁴ in the likeness of a man, and spoke a word,
and named him:

¹⁹⁵ “Even a blind man, stranger, could pick out
your token,

¹⁹⁶ groping — for it is not mixed in with the
crowd of them

¹⁹⁷ but far in front. Take heart, at least for this
contest:

198 no Phaeacian will reach this, let alone throw
beyond it.”

199 So he spoke; and much-enduring noble
Odysseus was glad,

200 rejoicing to find one true friend in the field.

201 And then with a lighter heart he spoke among
the Phaeacians:

202 “Now match that, young men — and soon
after, I think,

203 I will send another as far, or farther still.

204 As for the rest of you — whoever’s heart and
spirit bid him,

205 come out and be tried, since you have
angered me so:

206 at boxing, wrestling, running — I refuse
nothing —

207 any Phaeacian at all, except Laodamas
himself.¹⁴

208 He is my host: who would fight the man who
loves him?

209 Witless, worth nothing — that is the man

210 who challenges his own host to a bout of

games

211 in a strange country: he cuts himself off at the
knees.

212 But of the rest I refuse no one, scorn no one:

213 I want to know you, and be tried face to face.

214 I am not bad at anything — of all the contests
men keep.

215 I know well how to handle the polished
bow:15

216 first of a company I would strike my man with
an arrow

217 in the enemy crowd, though comrades in
plenty

218 stood close beside me shooting at the men.

219 Philoctetes alone outdid me with the bow

220 in the Trojans' country, whenever we
Achaean shot;

221 but of all others I say I am far the best,

222 all mortals now alive who eat their bread on
earth.

223 With the men of the past I will not seek to
rival —

224 not Heracles, not Eurytus of Oechalia,
225 who rivaled the very immortals with the bow.
226 That is why great Eurytus died so soon — old
age
227 never found him in his halls: Apollo in his
anger
228 killed him, for daring to challenge him at the
bow.
229 And I hurl a spear as far as another man
shoots an arrow.
230 Only at running I fear one of you might pass
me —16
231 one of the Phaeacians: I was broken past all
decency
232 among the many waves, with no steady keep
aboard ship;
233 and so the joints of my limbs are loosened.”
234 So he spoke, and they were all hushed in
silence.
235 Alcinous alone made him this answer:
236 “Stranger, nothing you say among us is said
ungraciously:

237 you are willing to show the prowess that
attends you,
238 in anger that this man stood up beside you in
the field
239 and taunted you — as no mortal would slight
your prowess
240 who knew in his heart how to speak things
fitly.
241 But mark my word now, so that you may tell it
242 to another hero, when in your own halls
243 you feast beside your wife and your children
244 and remember our prowess: what works Zeus
grants
245 to us as well, unbroken from our fathers' days.
246 For we are not flawless boxers, nor
wrestlers:17
247 but we run swift-footed, and we are best with
ships,
248 and always dear to us is the feast, the lyre, the
dances,
249 changes of clothing, hot baths, and beds.
250 Come then, dancers of the Phaeacians, all

your best,

251 and play — so the stranger may tell his own
people,

252 when he has come home, how far we surpass
others

253 in seamanship and running and dance and
song.

254 And let someone go quickly and fetch
Demodocus

255 the clear-voiced lyre, which lies somewhere in
our halls.”

256 So spoke godlike Alcinous; and a herald rose

257 to bring the hollow lyre from the king’s
house.

258 And chosen stewards stood up, nine in all,

259 public men, who at the gatherings set each
thing in order:

260 they smoothed a dancing-floor and widened a
fine ring.

261 And the herald came near, bearing the clear-
voiced lyre

262 for Demodocus; and he stepped to the middle,

and around him stood

263 boys in their first youth, skilled in the dance,

264 and they beat the shining floor with their
feet. And Odysseus

265 gazed at the flickerings of their feet, and
marveled in his heart.18

266 And the singer, striking the lyre, struck up a
beautiful song19

267 of the love of Ares and Aphrodite of the lovely
crown:

268 how first they lay together in the house of
Hephaestus,

269 in secret; and Ares gave her many gifts, and
shamed the marriage-bed

270 of the lord Hephaestus. But to him came a
messenger —

271 Helios, the Sun, who had seen the two of them
lying in love.

272 And when Hephaestus heard the heart-
stinging tale,

273 he went his way to his forge, brooding evils
deep in his heart,

274 and set the great anvil on the block, and
hammered out bonds
275 that could not break or slip, to hold them fast
where they stood.
276 And when he had made his snare, in his fury
against Ares,
277 he went his way to the chamber where his
own bed stood,
278 and around the bedposts he poured the bonds
in a circle everywhere,
279 and many hung down from above, from the
roof-beam,
280 fine as spider-webs, which no one could so
much as see —20
281 not even the blessed gods: for they were made
past all cunning.
282 And when he had poured his whole snare
around the bed,
283 he made as if to go to Lemnos, that strong-
founded city,
284 which is dearest to him by far of all lands.
285 And Ares of the golden reins kept no blind

watch:

286 he saw Hephaestus, famed for craft, going off,

287 and went his way to the house of famous

Hephaestus,

288 hungry for the love of Cytherea of the lovely

crown.

289 She was newly come from her father, the

mighty son of Cronos,

290 and had just sat down; and he came inside the

house

291 and clamped a hand on hers, and spoke a

word, and named her:

292 “Come, love — to bed, and take our joy

together lying close:

293 Hephaestus is no longer at home; by now, I

think,

294 he is off to Lemnos, among the wild-tongued

Sintians.”

295 So he spoke; and welcome it seemed to her to

lie with him.

296 So the two went to the bed and lay down; and

around them poured

297 the artful bonds of Hephaestus of the many
designs,
298 and they could not move a limb, could not lift
themselves —
299 and then they knew it: there was no escaping
now.
300 And near them came the famous god of the
two strong arms,
301 turned back on his road before ever reaching
Lemnos:
302 Helios had kept the watch for him, and told
him the tale.
303 He went his way to his house, his heart heavy
within him,
304 and stood in the gateway, and savage anger
gripped him,
305 and he cried out terribly, and called to all the
gods:
306 “Father Zeus, and you other blessed gods who
are forever:
307 come here — see something for laughter,
deeds past bearing —21

308 how Aphrodite, Zeus' daughter, forever
309 dishonors me for being lame, and loves that
destroyer Ares
310 because he is handsome and straight of limb,
while I
311 was born crippled. And whose fault is that? No
one's
312 but my two parents' — I wish they had never
bred me!
313 Look, see where the two of them sleep in love,
314 climbed into my own bed. And I watch, and it
eats my heart.
315 Yet I do not think they will want to lie so one
minute longer,
316 however much in love: soon enough the two
of them will lose
317 their taste for sleeping. But the snare and the
bond will hold them
318 until her father pays me back the bride-gifts,
every one, **22**
319 all I handed over for his bitch-eyed girl —
320 because his daughter is beautiful, and cannot

hold her heart.”

321 So he spoke, and the gods gathered to the
bronze-floored house:

322 Poseidon came, who holds the earth; and the
runner

323 Hermes came; and the lord who works from
far, Apollo.

324 But the goddesses stayed at home, for shame,
every one of them.23

325 So they stood in the gateway, the gods, the
givers of good things,

326 and unquenchable laughter rose among the
blessed gods

327 as they gazed on the craft of Hephaestus of
the many designs.

328 And thus one would say, with a glance at his
neighbor:

329 “Bad deeds do not prosper. The slow one
catches the swift —24

330 look, Hephaestus now, slow as he is, has taken
Ares,

331 the swiftest of the gods who hold Olympus:

332 lame, and by craft. Now the adulterer's fine is owing."

333 So they spoke such things to one another.

334 But the lord Apollo, son of Zeus, said to Hermes:

335 "Hermes, son of Zeus, guide, giver of good things:

336 would you be willing, pressed hard in strong bonds,

337 to sleep in that bed beside golden Aphrodite?"

338 Then the guide, the slayer of Argus, answered him:

339 "If only that could be, lord Apollo of the far arrows!²⁵

340 Let three times as many bonds hold me, past all number,

341 and you gods look on — yes, and all the goddesses too:

342 I would still sleep beside golden Aphrodite."

343 So he spoke, and laughter rose among the deathless gods.

344 But Poseidon did not laugh; he kept

pleading²⁶

³⁴⁵ with Hephaestus, the famous worker, to set
Ares free,

³⁴⁶ and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to
him:

³⁴⁷ “Release him. I promise you, before the
deathless gods,

³⁴⁸ he shall pay all that is fair, as you demand.”

³⁴⁹ Then the famous god of the two strong arms
answered him:

³⁵⁰ “Do not ask this of me, Poseidon who hold the
earth.

³⁵¹ Worthless the pledges you take for worthless
men.

³⁵² How could I hold you bound before the
deathless gods

³⁵³ if Ares slips both debt and bond and goes his
way?”

³⁵⁴ Then Poseidon the earth-shaker answered
him:

³⁵⁵ “Hephaestus, if Ares does slip his debt

³⁵⁶ and vanishes, I will pay you the fine myself.”

357 Then the famous god of the two strong arms
replied:

358 “It cannot be, and it would not be right, that I
refuse your word.”

359 So speaking, the strength of Hephaestus
undid the bond.

360 And the two of them, loosed from the bond,
strong as it was,

361 sprang up at once: he was gone to Thrace,

362 and she came to Cyprus, laughter-loving
Aphrodite —

363 to Paphos, where her precinct is, and her
altar fragrant with smoke.

364 There the Graces bathed her and rubbed her
with oil,²⁷

365 the immortal oil that blooms on the gods who
are forever,

366 and dressed her in lovely clothing, a wonder
to see.

367 This the famous singer sang; and Odysseus

368 took delight in his heart as he listened, and so
did the others,²⁸

369 the Phaeacians of the long oars, men famed
for ships.

370 Then Alcinous told Halius and Laodamas
371 to dance alone, since no one could rival them.
372 And when they had taken in their hands the
beautiful ball,
373 purple, which wise Polybus had made them,
374 one would bend far back and hurl it up toward
the shadowy clouds,
375 and the other, leaping high off the ground,
would catch it
376 lightly, with ease, before his feet came back to
earth.

377 And when they had tried their skill at the ball
thrown straight up,
378 then the two of them danced on the
nourishing earth,
379 passing it swiftly back and forth; and the
other young men
380 beat time, standing around the ring, and a
great din went up.

381 And then noble Odysseus addressed Alcinous:

382 “Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all
peoples,29

383 you promised your dancers were the best,
384 and here it stands accomplished. Awe takes
me, looking at it.”

385 So he spoke; and the sacred strength of
Alcinous was glad,

386 and at once he spoke among the oar-loving
Phaeacians:

387 “Hear me, leaders and counselors of the
Phaeacians.

388 This stranger seems to me a man of clear-
headed sense.

389 Come, let us give him a guest-gift, as is fitting.

390 Twelve glorious kings hold sway through this
land30

391 as leaders, and I myself am the thirteenth:

392 let each of you bring a fresh-washed mantle
and a tunic

393 and a talent of precious gold;

394 and let us bring it all together at once, so that
the stranger

395 may take it in his hands and go to supper glad
at heart.

396 And let Euryalus make it up to him, man to
man, with words

397 and with a gift: for his word was not spoken in
due measure.”

398 So he spoke, and they all approved it and
urged it on,

399 and each sent off a herald to bring his gifts.

400 And Euryalus answered him in turn, and said:

401 “Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all
peoples,

402 I will make it up to the stranger, as you
command.

403 I will give him this sword, all bronze, with a
hilt

404 of silver on it, and a scabbard of fresh-sawn
ivory

405 turned round it: it will be worth much to
him.”

406 So saying he set the silver-studded sword in
his hands,

407 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to
him:

408 “Hail, father stranger. If some word was
blurted out³¹

409 too harsh, may the storm-winds snatch it up
and carry it away.

410 And may the gods grant you to see your wife,
and to come

411 to your fatherland: for long, far from your
own people, you have suffered pains.”

412 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

413 “And to you, friend: hail, and warmly. May the
gods give you fortune,

414 and may you never feel the lack, hereafter, of
this sword

415 you have given me — you who made it up to
me with words.”

416 He spoke, and slung the silver-studded sword
about his shoulders.

417 And the sun went down, and the famous gifts
lay there before him.

418 The lordly heralds carried them to the house
of Alcinous,
419 and the sons of blameless Alcinous received
them
420 and set the beautiful gifts before their
honored mother.
421 And the sacred strength of Alcinous led the
way,
422 and they came and sat down on the high
seats.
423 And then the strength of Alcinous said to
Arete:
424 “Bring here a glorious chest, wife — the best
one —
425 and set in it yourself a fresh-washed mantle
and a tunic.
426 And heat the bronze cauldron over the fire,
and warm water,
427 so that once he has bathed, and seen well laid
together all
428 the gifts the blameless Phaeacians have
brought him here,

429 he may take joy in the feast, and in hearing
the singer's strain.

430 And I will give him this beautiful cup of mine,
431 golden, so that remembering me all his days
432 he may pour in his hall to Zeus and the other
gods."

433 So he spoke, and Arete told her slave-women
434 to set a great three-legged cauldron on the
fire with all speed.

435 They set the bath-cauldron on the blazing fire
436 and poured water in, and fed the wood
beneath till it flamed:

437 the fire wrapped round the belly of the
cauldron, and the water warmed.

438 Meanwhile Arete brought out from her
chamber a beautiful chest

439 for the stranger, and laid the fine gifts in it,
440 the clothing and the gold the Phaeacians had
given,

441 and in with them she laid a mantle and a
beautiful tunic,

442 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words

to him:

443 “See to the lid yourself now, and tie the knot
on it quickly,³²

444 for fear someone rob you on the voyage,
when later on

445 you sleep your sweet sleep as the black ship
carries you.”

446 And when much-enduring noble Odysseus
heard it,

447 at once he fitted the lid, and quickly tied upon
it

448 the intricate knot that the lady Circe once
taught him.³³

449 And straightway the housekeeper called him
to his bath,

450 to step in the tub; and his heart was glad at
the sight

451 of the hot water: for he had known no such
tending³⁴

452 since he left the house of fair-haired Calypso

—

453 though while he was there, he was tended like

a god without fail.

454 And when the slave-women had bathed him
and rubbed him with oil,

455 and thrown a beautiful cloak around him, and
a tunic,

456 he stepped from the bath and went to join the
men at their wine.

457 And Nausicaa, with her beauty from the
gods,35

458 stood by the pillar of the close-built roof,

459 and marveled at Odysseus as her eyes took
him in,

460 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words
to him:

461 “Farewell, stranger. And sometime, in your
own fatherland,

462 remember me — for to me first you owe the
price of your life.”

463 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

464 “Nausicaa, daughter of great-hearted
Alcinous:

465 only may Zeus grant it so — the loud-
thundering lord of Hera —

466 that I go home and look upon my day of
homecoming:

467 then even there I would pray to you as to a
god,

468 always, all my days. For you saved my life,
girl.”**36**

469 He spoke, and went to his seat beside King
Alcinous.

470 And already they were serving portions and
mixing the wine,

471 and the herald came near, leading the trusted
singer,

472 Demodocus, honored among the people, and
seated him

473 in the middle of the feasters, leaning him on a
tall pillar.

474 And then Odysseus of the many designs called
the herald —

475 cutting off a slice of the chine, with more left
over,

476 of the white-tusked hog, rich fat along it
either side:

477 “Herald — here, take this cut of meat to
Demodocus,

478 so he may eat; and I will pay my respects to
him, for all my grief.

479 For among all men upon the earth, singers³⁷

480 have their share of honor and reverence,
because the Muse

481 has taught them her paths, and loves the tribe
of singers.”

482 So he spoke, and the herald carried it and set
it in the hands

483 of the hero Demodocus; and he received it,
and his heart was glad.

484 And their hands went out to the good things
spread before them.

485 But when they had put away desire for food
and drink,

486 then Odysseus of the many designs said to
Demodocus:

487 “Demodocus, I praise you beyond all mortal

men.

488 Either the Muse taught you, Zeus' daughter,
or Apollo:

489 for all in due order you sing the fate of the
Achaeans —

490 all they did and suffered, all the Achaeans'
labors —

491 as if you had been there yourself, or heard it
from one who was.38

492 But come now, change your path: sing the
making of the horse

493 of wood, which Epeius built, and Athena with
him —

494 the snare that noble Odysseus brought up
into the citadel,

495 filled with the men who sacked Ilium.

496 If you tell me this tale too in its due measure,

497 then I will proclaim at once to all mankind39

498 how the god of his grace has given you divine
song.”

499 So he spoke; and the singer, stirred by the
god, began, and made the song appear,40

500 taking it up where the Argives had boarded
their well-benched ships
501 and were sailing away, after casting fire on
their camp,
502 while those others, around famous Odysseus,
already
503 sat in the Trojans' gathering-place, hidden
inside the horse:
504 for the Trojans themselves had dragged it up
into the citadel.
505 So it stood there, and they talked on and on,
undecided,
506 sitting around it; and three ways the counsel
pleased them:
507 to split the hollow timber with the pitiless
bronze,
508 or drag it to the height and hurl it down the
rocks,
509 or leave it standing, a great offering to
appease the gods —
510 and that was the way it was to end at last:
511 for it was their portion to perish when the city

took within it

512 the great horse of wood, where all the best of
the Argives

513 sat carrying death and doom to the Trojans.

514 And he sang how the sons of the Achaeans
sacked the city,

515 pouring from the horse, leaving their hollow
ambush;

516 he sang how they ravaged the steep city, each
man his own way,

517 and how Odysseus went, like Ares himself, to
the house

518 of Deiphobus, with godlike Menelaus beside
him;

519 and there, he sang, he dared the grimmest
fight of all —

520 and conquered, in the end, through great-
hearted Athena.

521 This the famous singer sang. And Odysseus

522 melted: the tears from under his eyelids wet
his cheeks.

523 As a woman weeps, fallen on the body of her

dear husband⁴¹

⁵²⁴ who has gone down before his city and his
people,

⁵²⁵ warding the pitiless day from his town and his
children:

⁵²⁶ she sees him dying, gasping his last,

⁵²⁷ and pours herself around him with a high thin
cry; and behind her

⁵²⁸ the spearmen, beating her back and shoulders
with their spears,

⁵²⁹ lead her away into slavery, to labor and
misery,

⁵³⁰ and her cheeks are wasted with a grief most
pitiful:

⁵³¹ so pitiful were the tears Odysseus let fall from
under his brows.

⁵³² From all the others he hid the tears he shed;

⁵³³ Alcinous alone remarked him and noticed,

⁵³⁴ sitting beside him, and heard his heavy
groaning.

⁵³⁵ At once he spoke among the oar-loving
Phaeacians:

536 “Hear me, leaders and counselors of the
Phaeacians —
537 and let Demodocus still his clear-voiced lyre
now:
538 for what he sings does not give joy to all alike.
539 Since the hour we supped, and the godlike
singer rose,
540 since then the stranger has never ceased
541 his grieving lament. Great sorrow, surely, has
fenced his heart around.
542 Come, let the singer hold, so that we may all
take pleasure
543 alike, hosts and guest together: far better so.
544 For all this has been made ready for our
honored guest —
545 his sending, and the friendly gifts we give him
in our love.
546 As dear as a brother is the stranger and the
suppliant⁴²
547 to any man whose wits have even a little
reach.
548 So do not hide now, behind shrewd

calculations,

549 whatever I ask you. To speak out is the fairer way.

550 Tell the name they call you there by, your mother and your father⁴³

551 and the others, in the town and dwelling round about.

552 For no one among mankind is altogether nameless,

553 base man or noble, once he has come into the world:

554 parents lay a name on every child they bear.

555 And tell me your land, your people, and your city,

556 so that our ships may carry you there, plotting the course by thought:⁴⁴

557 for the Phaeacians have no steersmen,

558 no steering-oars at all, such as other ships carry:

559 the ships themselves know the thoughts and minds of men,

560 and know the cities and rich fields of every

561 people, and swiftest of all things cross the gulf
of the salt sea

562 wrapped in mist and cloud; and never do they
fear

563 harm or wreck on any crossing.

564 Yet this I once heard my father Nausithous⁴⁵

565 say: he would tell us that Poseidon looked on
us with anger

566 because we are safe escorts of all men without
distinction;

567 and he said that one day, as a well-made ship
of the Phaeacian men

568 came home over the misted sea from such a
sending,

569 the god would smash it, and pile a great
mountain round our city.

570 So the old man said. And these things the god
may accomplish,

571 or may leave unaccomplished, as pleases his
own heart.

572 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

573 where have you wandered? To what countries

of men

574 have you come — the peoples, the cities well-
lived-in —

575 both the harsh among them, the savage and
unjust,46

576 and the kind to strangers, whose hearts fear
the gods?

577 And tell why you weep, and mourn within
your heart,

578 when you hear the fate of the Argive Danaans
and of Ilium.

579 That fate the gods made; they spun that
destruction for men,47

580 so that there might be a song for those still to
come.

581 Did some kinsman of yours die before Ilium —

582 a good man, a wife's father, a daughter's
husband? — those who stand

583 closest after our own blood and stock;

584 or perhaps a companion, a man dear to your
heart,

585 a good man? For no less than a brother⁴⁸
586 is a companion who is clear-headed and true.”

Notes

NOTES

1. πτολίπορθος, “sacker of cities” — Odysseus’ great war-epithet, used here for the first time in the poem, on the very morning that will end with him weeping at a song of the sack. The epithet and the widow simile (523–531) are this book’s two poles, and the poem sets them up in its third line. ↩
2. Fifty-two picked oarsmen — two beyond the poem’s standard crew of fifty. Phaeacian numbers are always crisp: twelve kings and a thirteenth, nine stewards, fifty-two rowers; fairyland is beautifully administered. ↩
3. Demodocus — the name means roughly “received by the people” (or “honored by the people”), a singer named for his audience. Alcinous’ description sets the terms the book will test: the god gave him song “to delight men however his heart is stirred” — but this evening, what delights the hall will twice devastate the guest. ↩
4. “She took away his eyes, and gave him sweet song”: the Muse’s double gift, stated with terrifying evenness — good and evil in one clause each. Antiquity read the blind singer of Scheria as Homer’s self-portrait (the blind bard of Chios in the *Hymn to*

Apollo reinforced it). Whatever the truth, the poem here prices poetry: it costs the eyes; it buys the world. ↩

5. The quarrel of Odysseus and Achilles at a feast of the gods is attested nowhere else in Greek literature — either a lost epic episode or (many suspect) invented for this scene: a song about *the best of the Achaeans* quarreling, brain against brawn, is precisely calibrated to this audience of one. Agamemnon “rejoiced” because Delphi had told him the war would end when the best fell out — the oracle-logic of a lost tradition, delivered in four lines as if everyone knew it. ↩
6. The cloak-ritual of grief (83–92), in iterative verbs: song, weep, pause, wipe, pour, song again, weep again. He mourns in installments, timed to the singer’s breath. And the poem’s tact is Alcinous’: he alone notices, and rather than ask, he invents an excuse to change the entertainment. Book-length courtesies: the question waits until 577. ↩
7. The catalogue of young Phaeacians is a roster of sea-puns: Acroneus (“Topship”), Ocyalus (“Swiftsea”), Elatreus (“Rower”), Nauteus (“Shipman”), Prymneus (“Sternman”), Anchialus (“Nearsea”), Eretmeus (“Oarsman”), Panteus (“Seaman”), Proreus (“Prowman”), Anabesineus (“Ship-boarder”), Amphialus son of Polyneus son of Tecton (“Seagirt, son of Manyships, son of Shipwright”) — and Euryalus (“Broadsea”). A whole society named from its element, the way Nausicaa and Nausithous are. I transliterate and let the note carry the joke. ↩
8. Distance measured by “the width of a mule-team’s furrow in fallow ground” — the plowman’s unit, like the shout-measure

(5.400) and the meal-clock. Even Phaeacian athletics are surveyed in farm-lengths. ↩

9. “No greater fame for a man, while he lives, than what he achieves with his own feet and hands” — the athletic creed of the young, delivered to the man whose fame rests on neither. Laodamas means it kindly; the poem means it as the book’s question: what is the glory of a man whose instrument is his mind? ↩

10. Euryalus’ insult reaches for the lowest available identity: a cargo-master “with a memory for freight and an eye on his grasping profits.” The aristocratic contempt for trade is period-real (and the poem’s Phoenicians will carry it), but the barb’s irony is exquisite: of all the identities Odysseus has worn, profit-trader is the one he never claims — and the accusation of *remembering cargo* is aimed at the man whose whole cargo is memory. ↩

11. ὑπόδρα ἰδών — the dark glare from under the brows: the Iliad’s battlefield formula, here imported to a garden party. The Trojan-war register switches on for exactly one speech and one throw, then switches off. The Phaeacians have never seen it before; the audience has. ↩

12. The gifts-of-the-gods speech (167–177): no man gets everything — build, brains, eloquence; there is the plain man whose words the god “crowns with shape” until the town watches him walk like a god, and the beauty with nothing behind the face. It is a self-portrait from the tradition (Antenor in *Iliad* 3.216ff. describes exactly this Odysseus: unimpressive until the words

come like winter snow), delivered as general wisdom to a beautiful fool. ↩

13. “Cloak and all” — he doesn’t trouble to strip, and takes the heavier discus. The throw’s aftermath is pure sound and posture: the stone hums, a nation of sailors ducks. One motion answers the whole afternoon of games. ↩
14. The host-exemption: he will meet anyone except Laodamas — “he is my host: who would fight the man who loves him?” A rule of *xenia* stated as though obvious, in a poem heading toward a hall where a hundred guests have made war on their host for three years. ↩
15. The bow-boast, with genealogy: better than all living men, second only to Philoctetes at Troy, and *deliberately* not to be measured against Heracles and Eurytus, who bent their bows against gods — a rivalry that killed Eurytus, cut down by angry Apollo. The modesty is theology, and the résumé is a plant: the poem’s audience knows an archery contest is coming (Book 21), and knows the bow at home in Ithaca came from Eurytus’ own son Iphitus. The skill announced here on a holiday field will next appear over a threshold heaped with dead men. ↩
16. The one conceded weakness — his legs, “loosened” by the sea. The confession is precise and bodily: this hero’s honesty about his own diminishment is part of the same realism as the belly speech (7.215ff.). ↩
17. Alcinous’ concession is the most disarming self-description in epic: “we are not flawless boxers... dear to us is the feast, the lyre, the dances, changes of clothing, hot baths, and beds.” A civilization declares comfort its excellence, without shame.

The line drew moralists' fire for centuries (Horace's "youths of Alcinous"), but the poem is not sneering: this softness will send Odysseus home; the hard men in Ithaca's hall will not. ↩

18. μαρμαρυγὰς — the "flickerings" of the dancers' feet: light-off-water shimmer applied to footwork. The connoisseur of every craft "marvels in his heart" — the same verb the poem gives him for palaces and harbors. Odysseus is the Odyssey's best audience. ↩
19. The Song of Ares and Aphrodite (266–366): a full comic epyllion at the poem's center. Its architecture mirrors the Odyssey's own: the husband deficient in glamour but supreme in craft; the glamorous intruder in his bed; the trap prepared in secret and sprung in public; the demand for restitution. The lame smith catches the swiftest of gods — and the moral the gods themselves draw (329) is "the slow one catches the swift": the Odyssey's whole plot, stated as a proverb inside its own entertainment. That this adultery-farce is sung to the husband of besieged Penelope — and that he *delights* in it (367–368) — is the poem at its most self-aware: he is hearing his own story told as a comedy where the craftsman wins. ↩
20. The bonds "fine as spider-webs, which no one could so much as see — not even the blessed gods": the craftsman's masterpiece is invisibility, the snare indistinguishable from the household it protects. Weaving imagery again — the trap for the lovers is spun, like Penelope's web and every plot in this poem. ↩
21. "Come here — see something for laughter, deeds past bearing": Hephaestus summons an audience for his own humiliation, and the Greek yokes the two words (γελαστά... οὐκ ἐπεικτά)

without resolving them. His speech swings from bitterness about his lameness to the wish his parents had never bred him — real pain inside the farce, which is what keeps the farce from weightlessness. ↩

22. The economics of the exposure: the bonds hold “until her father pays back the bride-gifts.” Adultery is actionable property law even on Olympus — the μοιχάγρια, “the adulterer’s fine” (332), is a real archaic institution. The comedy runs on a genuine legal chassis. ↩

23. “The goddesses stayed at home, for shame, every one of them” — one line establishing the gendered economy of spectatorship: the male gods gather and laugh; the goddesses may not even look. The poem notices exactly who is permitted to enjoy whose disgrace. ↩

24. “Bad deeds do not prosper. The slow one catches the swift.” The gods’ own moral, drawn amid their laughter — and the Odyssey’s thesis. Every slow thing in this poem catches its swift thing: the lame smith, the old beggar, the waiting wife, the twenty-year homecoming. ↩

25. Hermes’ answer — triple the bonds, all the goddesses watching, “I would still sleep beside golden Aphrodite” — is the bawdiest joke in Homer, and it *lands*: “laughter rose among the deathless gods.” Xenophanes and Plato would later cite this whole song as what poets must not say about gods; the poem’s answer is already in the text — the gods themselves find it funny. ↩

26. Poseidon does not laugh. He stands surety for the adulterer — the enforcer of debts, the guarantor of order among gods. The irony goes unspoken: the god acting as bond for a caught

transgressor is the same god whose grudge against one mortal man the whole poem must outlast. ↩

27. Aphrodite's exit through Paphos — bathed by the Graces, oiled with “the immortal oil that blooms on the gods,” dressed as “a wonder to see.” No punishment, no shame that adheres: she leaves the farce restored to full glory. The poem lets beauty be beauty even in disgrace — and the bath-and-oil-and-clothing formula is the same one mortals get; the difference is only that hers ends in Paphos. ↩

28. “Odysseus took delight in his heart as he listened.” The first Troy song made him weep under his cloak; the adultery-comedy delights him. He is moved by his own past, entertained by his own future — and the poem, with perfect economy, does not gloss the difference. ↩

29. “Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all peoples” — a new fixed vocative, and a plant: it is with this exact line that Odysseus will open the greatest speech of the poem, the beginning of his own tale, at 9.2. ↩

30. Twelve kings and Alcinous the thirteenth: the Phaeacian constitution in a line and a half. Thirteen basileis in council, one presiding — closer to Ithaca's contested plural kingship (1.394–396) than to any absolute monarchy; the fairyland polity is recognizably Greek. ↩

31. Euryalus' apology is a small masterpiece of the form: “may the storm-winds snatch it up and carry it away” — the insult reclassified as wind-words (the ἀνεμώλια family, 4.837). And his blessing — “may the gods grant you to see your wife” — makes him the *first person on Scheria to mention a wife for*

Odysseus. The man who insulted him is the one who guesses the shape of his heart. *Odysseus*' acceptance (413–415) returns grace for grace, with one glinting condition: may you never miss this sword — i.e., may you never need what you gave away.



32. Arete's send-off gift is advice: knot the chest yourself, "for fear someone rob you on the voyage" while you sleep. Even in fairyland the queen assumes crews pilfer. Her practicality is the counterweight to her husband's magic-ship raptures thirty lines later — between the two of them, the poem gets both Phaeacians on record. ↩
33. "The intricate knot that the lady Circe once taught him" — Circe, named for the first time in the poem, casually, as the source of a skill, well before she enters the tale *Odysseus* is about to tell. The poem trusts its audience to know the story already; the effect for them is not confusion but a shiver of prolepsis — and a hint that his year with her furnished practical arts as well as delays. ↩
34. His pleasure in the hot bath is dated precisely: no such tending "since he left the house of fair-haired Calypso — though while he was there, he was tended like a god without fail." The narrator's small honesty: captivity included excellent care. The poem never cheapens what he refused; that is why the refusal weighs. ↩
35. Nausicaa's farewell (457–462): she has slipped in to stand "by the pillar of the close-built roof" — the same doorway-pillar posture as Penelope's public appearances (1.333) — for twelve lines and two sentences: *Farewell; remember me; you owe me your*

life. ζώαγια, “the price of your life,” is the word for ransom paid by a spared captive: she names their whole story in a single legal metaphor, without one word of what might have been. ↩

36. His answer grants her the highest thing in his gift: “even there I would pray to you as to a god, always, all my days” — cult status in his homeland, the exact fulfillment of her beach-daydream transposed into the only register now possible. And the last word is κόρη — “girl”: tender, truthful, final. The romance that never was closes in perfect form, and neither of them says one word more than honor allows. ↩
37. “Among all men upon the earth, singers have their share of honor and reverence, because the Muse has taught them her paths” — the sacker of cities serving the best cut of pork to the man whose song just flayed him. Respect for the singer is respect for the truth of what the song did to him; the gesture is the argument. ↩
38. “As if you had been there yourself, or heard it from one who was”: the Homeric standard of poetic truth — eyewitness fidelity, at one remove at most. Odysseus certifies the singer’s accuracy from the only position that can: he *was* there. The poem is having its own veracity notarized by its hero. ↩
39. The commission’s payment: sing it rightly “and I will proclaim at once to all mankind” that your song is divine. Kleos for kleos — the hero offers the singer exactly the currency singers offer heroes. The economy of fame runs both directions through this scene, one professional to another. ↩

40. “Stirred by the god, he began, and made the song appear” — φαῖνε δ’ αἰοδῆν: song as manifestation, made visible like something summoned. The summary that follows (500–520) is our earliest connected account of the wooden horse — three fates debated (axe, cliff, offering), Troy’s own citizens dragging the ambush inside — compressed with the confidence of a poet whose audience knows every beat. ↩
41. The widow simile — the moral summit of the book, perhaps of the poem. Odysseus weeps *as* a woman weeping over her husband fallen defending his city, who is beaten from his body with spear-butts and led into slavery, “to labor and misery.” The sacker of cities (line 3) hears his triumph sung and grieves as its victim: the simile forces the victor through the vanquished’s exact experience — the widow it describes is a woman from a city such as *he* sacked. Nothing else in archaic literature crosses that line. The poem does not comment; it just holds the two mirrors — πολίπορθος and the widow — facing each other, with the man between them weeping. ↩
42. “As dear as a brother is the stranger and the suppliant / to any man whose wits have even a little reach” — Alcinous’ summa of guest-ethics, quietly seconding his daughter’s beach-creed (6.207–208) and Echeneus’ hearth-doctrine (7.165). Three generations of Phaeacians have now stated the law the suitors break nightly. ↩
43. The name-demand: “no one among mankind is altogether nameless... parents lay a name on every child they bear.” Identity in this poem is not private property but a social fact bestowed at birth — which is why withholding a name (as Odysseus has for two days) is such a charged act, and why the

alias he will build in the Cyclops' cave (Nobody, οὔτις) is a violation of the order of things clever enough to shake it. The book ends with the question that Book 9 answers in the poem's most famous self-naming. ↩

44. The thought-steered ships (556–563): no steersmen, no rudders; the ships “know the thoughts and minds of men,” know every city and field, and cross the sea wrapped in mist, unwreckable. Navigation without pilotage — the final Phaeacian marvel, and the fairy-tale inversion of everything Books 5 and 12 cost. Note the shadow inside the boast: “never do they fear harm” is spoken by a man about to recall a prophecy of exactly that harm. ↩
45. Nausithous' prophecy: Poseidon angered “because we are safe escorts of all men without distinction” — universal kindness itself is the offense — and one day a returning ship smashed, a mountain piled round the city. Alcinous reports his own doom and shrugs: “the god may accomplish it, or leave it unaccomplished” (570–571). The fatalism of the blessed. The poem will collect this debt at 13.159ff., with the same words, on the day Odysseus lands home. ↩
46. The wandering question borrows its categories from the arrival-formula (6.120–121) — one word swapped, “harsh” (χαλεποί) for “overweening” (ὕβρισταί): the harsh, savage, unjust versus the stranger-kind and god-fearing. Alcinous unknowingly hands Odysseus the organizing rubric of the next four books: the apologoi are, among everything else, a survey of exactly that taxonomy, port by port. ↩

47. “That fate the gods made; they spun that destruction for men, so that there might be a song for those still to come.” The deepest sentence in the book: suffering is the raw material of song, and song is the *purpose* the gods had in weaving the suffering. Helen says nearly the same in the *Iliad* (6.357–358). It is the poem’s own theodicy of art — offered here as consolation to a weeping man who is, though his host does not know it, the song’s subject, sitting in the audience of his own destruction. ↩

48. The book’s last thought before the great question: a true companion “is no less than a brother.” Alcinous guesses at the guest’s grief — kinsman? friend? — and his final guess lands nearest: what Odysseus lost at Troy and after was companions, all of them. The question mark hangs over the night; Book 9 opens with the answer the whole poem has withheld: *I am Odysseus, son of Laertes*. ↩

Odyssey — Book 9

“I am Odysseus”: the Cicones, the Lotus-eaters, and the Cyclops.

- 1 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:
- 2 “Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all peoples,¹
- 3 truly it is a fine thing to hear a singer
- 4 such as this man is, with a voice like the gods’.
- 5 For I say there is no accomplishment more graceful²
- 6 than when joy holds a whole people,
- 7 and feasters up and down the hall sit listening to a singer,
- 8 seated in order, and beside them the tables are loaded
- 9 with bread and meats, and the cupbearer draws wine
- 10 from the bowl and carries it round and fills the

cups:

11 this seems to my mind the fairest thing there
is.

12 But your heart has turned to asking after my
grievous

13 cares — so that I may mourn and groan the
more.

14 What first, then, what last shall I tell through?

15 For the gods of heaven have given me sorrows
past counting.

16 Now first I will tell my name, so that you too

17 may know it — and I hereafter, if I escape the
pitiless day,

18 may be your guest-friend, though my home is
far away.

19 I am Odysseus, son of Laertes — known to all
mankind³

20 for my cunning designs; and my fame has
reached heaven.

21 My home is Ithaca, clear-skied under its
mountain,

22 Neriton, tall in its shivering leaves; and around

it islands

23 lie in a cluster, close to one another —

24 Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus.

25 Ithaca itself lies low, farthest out in the sea

26 toward the dark of sunset — the rest face dawn
and the sun —

27 rough ground, but a good nurse of men. I
cannot⁴

28 see any sweeter sight, for my part, than a
man's own country.

29 The queenly goddess Calypso would have kept
me there beside her⁵

30 in her hollow caves, hungry to make me her
husband,

31 and so, in the same way, Circe detained me in
her halls,

32 the guileful lady of Aeaea, hungry to make me
her husband:

33 but they never once persuaded the heart in my
breast.

34 So true it is that nothing is sweeter than a
man's own country

35 and his own parents, even if he lives in a rich
house
36 far away in a strange land, cut off from his
parents.
37 But come — let me tell you also my journey
home, and all its cares,
38 which Zeus laid on me on the way from Troy.
39 From Ilium the wind bore me to the Cicones —
6
40 to Ismarus. There I sacked the city and
destroyed the men;
41 and out of the city we took their wives and
much substance
42 and divided all, so that no man might go
cheated of his share by me.
43 Then, you may be sure, I ordered a quick-
footed retreat —
44 and they, the great fools, would not obey.⁷
45 There and then much wine was being drunk,
and many sheep
46 they slaughtered along the shore, and
shambling crook-horned cattle;

47 and meanwhile Cicones went crying to
Cicones,
48 their neighbors inland — more of them, and
better men,
49 skilled at fighting men from chariots
50 and, where need was, on foot.
51 They came, then, thick as leaves and flowers
come in their season,
52 in the morning mist. Then an evil doom of
Zeus stood by us,
53 luckless men, to load us with pains in plenty.
54 They set their battle-line and fought by the
fast ships,
55 and each side pelted each with bronze-tipped
spears.
56 As long as it was morning, and the sacred day
still growing,
57 so long we stood them off and held our ground,
though they were more;
58 but when the sun turned over toward
unyoking-time,⁸
59 then the Cicones broke the Achaeans, and

mastered them.

60 Six from each ship, six strong-greaved
companions

61 were killed; the rest of us fled from death and
doom.

62 From there we sailed on further, grieved at
heart,⁹

63 glad to be out of death, having lost our dear
companions.

64 But my curved ships would not go forward

65 before we had called three times on each of
those poor companions¹⁰

66 who died on the plain, cut down by the
Cicones.

67 And Zeus who gathers the clouds roused the
North Wind against the ships

68 in a howling squall, and covered land and sea
alike

69 with cloud; and night rose up out of heaven.

70 The ships were swept along slantwise, their
sails

71 ripped into three and four rags by the strength

of the wind.

72 We lowered them into the hulls, in terror of
death,

73 and rowed the ships hard in toward the shore.

74 There for two nights and two days without a
break

75 we lay, eating our hearts with weariness and
pain together.

76 But when Dawn of the lovely braids brought
the third day round,

77 we set up the masts and hauled the white sails
open

78 and sat, and the wind and the steersmen held
them on course.

79 And now I would have come unharmed to my
own country,

80 but the wave and the current, as I rounded
Malea,¹¹

81 and the North Wind beat me off course and
drove me wide of Cythera.

82 From there for nine days I was carried by
ruinous winds

83 across the fish-filled sea; and on the tenth we
stepped ashore
84 in the land of the Lotus-eaters, who eat a
flower for food.¹²
85 There we set foot on the mainland and drew
water,
86 and the companions quickly took their meal
beside the fast ships.
87 And when we had tasted food and drink,
88 then I sent companions ahead to learn
89 what men they were who ate bread upon this
earth:
90 two men I chose, and sent a third with them as
herald.
91 They went their way at once, and fell in with
the Lotus-eater men;
92 and the Lotus-eaters had no thought of killing
93 our companions — but they gave them lotus to
taste.
94 And whoever of them ate the honey-sweet
fruit of the lotus¹³
95 no longer wished to bring back word or to

return:

96 there they wanted to stay, among the Lotus-eater men,

97 browsing the lotus, and to forget their homecoming.

98 These men I forced back weeping to the ships,

99 dragged them under the benches of the hollow ships and bound them,

100 and I ordered the rest of my trusted companions

101 to hurry and board the fast ships —

102 for fear some other might eat of the lotus and forget his homecoming.

103 And they came aboard at once and took their places at the oarlocks,

104 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt water with their oars.

105 From there we sailed on further, grieved at heart.

106 And we came to the land of the Cyclopes — the overweening,¹⁴

107 the lawless — who, trusting in the deathless

gods,

108 plant no crop with their hands, and plow
nothing:

109 everything springs up for them unsown,
unplowed,

110 wheat and barley, and vines that carry

111 wine in their heavy clusters, and Zeus' rain
swells it for them.

112 They have no counsel-bearing assemblies, no
established laws,

113 but live on the crests of the high mountains

114 in hollow caves, and each man lays down the
law

115 to his own wives and children — and they care
nothing for one another.

116 Now a scrubby island stretches outside the
harbor there,15

117 neither close in to the Cyclopes' land nor far
out,

118 wooded; and on it goats past counting breed,

119 wild goats: no tread of men scares them away,

120 no hunters push through to it, men who

suffer

121 hard days in the timber, working the
mountain crests;

122 it is held by no flocks and no plowed fields,

123 but unsown and unplowed all its days

124 the island is widowed of men, and feeds its
bleating goats.

125 For the Cyclopes have no red-cheeked ships,

126 and no shipwrights among them who might
labor out

127 well-benched vessels to accomplish every
need,

128 crossing to the cities of the world, the way
men

129 so often traverse the sea in ships to one
another:

130 such craftsmen would have made the island a
fair settlement too.

131 For it is not a bad island at all: it would bear
every crop in season.

132 There are meadows in it along the shores of
the gray salt water,

133 soft, well-watered; vines there would never
die;
134 there is level plowland, and a deep standing
harvest always
135 ready for the scythe in season, for the soil
beneath is rich.
136 And there is a harbor with safe anchorage,
where there is no need of mooring-line —
137 no anchor-stones to throw, no stern-cables to
make fast:
138 you beach her, and wait until the sailors'
139 hearts prompt them, and the breezes blow.
140 And at the harbor's head runs shining water,
141 a spring under a cave, with black poplars
growing round it.
142 There we sailed in — and some god was
guiding us —
143 through the dead of night, with nothing to be
seen ahead:
144 a fog lay thick around the ships, and the moon
145 showed nothing from heaven, shut in by
clouds.

146 No one's eyes made out that island then,
147 nor did we see the long combers rolling in
against the shore
148 before the well-benched ships ran up the
beach.
149 And with the ships beached, we took down all
the sails
150 and stepped out ourselves onto the surf-line
of the sea,
151 and there we dropped asleep, and waited for
shining Dawn.
152 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,
153 we walked that island marveling, all through
it.
154 And the nymphs, daughters of aegis-bearing
Zeus, started
155 the mountain goats, so my companions might
have their meal.
156 At once we fetched our curved bows and long-
socketed goat-spears
157 out of the ships, and forming in three bands

158 we shot; and quickly the god gave us game to
our hearts' content.

159 Twelve ships followed with me, and to each
160 nine goats fell by lot; for me alone they picked
out ten.

161 So then all day long till the setting of the sun
162 we sat feasting on meat past counting and
sweet wine.

163 For the red wine was not yet spent from out
our ships:

164 there was still some left, for each crew had
drawn off much

165 in two-handled jars when we took the
Cicones' holy citadel.

166 And we looked across at the land of the
Cyclopes, who were near:

167 smoke, and voices — theirs, and their sheep's
and goats'.16

168 And when the sun went down and the dusk
came on,

169 then we lay down to sleep on the surf-line of
the sea.

170 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,
171 then I called an assembly, and spoke among
them all:
172 ‘The rest of you stay here now, my trusted
companions,
173 while I with my own ship and my own crew
174 go and make trial of those men over there —
what they are:
175 whether violent, savage, without justice, 17
176 or kind to strangers, with hearts that fear the
gods.’
177 So speaking I went aboard, and ordered my
companions
178 to board in their turn and loose the stern-
cables.
179 And they came aboard at once and took their
places at the oarlocks,
180 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt
water with their oars.
181 But when we reached the place — it was not
far —

182 there on the land's edge, close by the sea, we
saw a cave,
183 high, overhung with laurels. There many
184 flocks — sheep and goats — were penned at
night; around it a yard
185 ran high-built, of stones set deep in the earth,
186 and tall pines, and oaks with lofty crowns.
187 And there a man slept, a monster of a man,
who shepherded¹⁸
188 his flocks alone and far apart; he kept no
company
189 with others, but held aloof, and his heart
knew no law.
190 For he was built a monstrous wonder —
nothing like
191 a man who eats bread, but like a wooded crag
192 of the high mountains, standing clear of all
the rest.
193 Then I ordered the rest of my trusted
companions
194 to stay there by the ship and guard the ship,
195 while I picked the twelve best of my

companions

196 and went. And I took a goatskin of dark wine,
197 sweet wine, that Maron gave me, Euanthes'
son,19

198 the priest of Apollo, the god who watches over
Ismarus —

199 because we had protected him, with his child
and his wife,

200 out of reverence: for he lived in the wooded
grove

201 of Phoebus Apollo. And he gave me shining
gifts:

202 he gave me seven talents of well-wrought
gold,

203 and he gave me a mixing-bowl all of silver,
and then

204 wine, drawn off in two-handled jars, twelve in
all,

205 sweet and unmixed, a drink for gods. Not one

206 of the slaves or handmaids in his house knew
of it —

207 only himself and his dear wife, and one

housekeeper only.

208 Whenever they drank that honey-sweet red
wine,

209 he would fill one cup and pour it into twenty
measures

210 of water, and a sweet smell would rise from
the bowl,

211 a marvel: no joy then in holding back.

212 Of this I filled a great skin and brought it, and
provisions too

213 in a sack: for my proud heart had a
foreboding, even then,

214 that a man would come against me clothed in
great strength,

215 a savage, knowing nothing of judgments or of
laws.

216 Quickly we came to the cave, and did not find
him

217 within: he was herding his fat flocks in the
pasture.

218 We went into the cave and stared in wonder at
everything:

219 crates sagging with cheeses; pens crowded20
220 with lambs and kids — each sort folded
separately,
221 the firstlings apart, apart the middle-born,
222 apart again the newborn; and every vessel
swimming with whey,
223 the pails and bowls, all made by hand, that he
milked into.
224 There first my companions begged me,
pleading:
225 take some cheeses and go back; then quickly,
226 driving the kids and lambs out of their pens
227 down to the fast ship, sail away over the salt
water.
228 But I would not listen — it would have been
far better —21
229 not until I saw him, and whether he would
give me guest-gifts.
230 And his appearing was to be no joy to my
companions.
231 We lit a fire there and made an offering, and
helped ourselves

232 to cheeses, and ate, and sat inside waiting for
him,
233 until he came back herding. He carried a huge
weight
234 of dry wood, to serve him at supper-time,
235 and flung it down inside the cave with a
crash;
236 and we in terror shrank away into the cave's
far corner.
237 He drove his fat flocks into the wide cavern —
238 all those he milked; the males he left outside,
239 the rams and he-goats, out in the deep yard.
240 Then he lifted high and set in place a huge
door-stone,
241 a massive thing: twenty-two carts, good
ones, 22
242 four-wheeled, could not have levered it off
the ground —
243 such a towering cliff of rock he set in the
doorway.
244 Then, sitting, he milked the ewes and bleating
goats,

245 all in due order, and set the young under
each.

246 And straightway he curdled half the white
milk

247 and gathered it and stored it in the plaited
baskets,

248 and half he stood in vessels, so it might be
there

249 for him to take and drink, and serve him at
supper-time.

250 And when at last he had hurried through his
work,

251 then he lit the fire — and saw us, and asked:

252 ‘Strangers, who are you? From where do you
sail the watery ways?23

253 Is it on some business — or do you rove at
random,

254 the way sea-raiders do, who wander

255 staking their own lives, bearing evil to
strangers?’

256 So he spoke, and our own hearts broke within
us

257 in terror of the deep voice and the monster
himself.

258 Even so I answered him, and said:

259 'We are Achaeans, blown off course from Troy
260 by every wind there is, across the great gulf of
the sea,

261 making for home — but by other routes, other
roads

262 we came: so Zeus, I suppose, chose to devise
it.

263 We declare ourselves the people of
Agamemnon, Atreus' son, 24

264 whose fame is now the greatest thing under
heaven,

265 so vast the city he sacked, so many the
peoples

266 he destroyed. But we, for our part, have come
to your knees

267 in hope you may offer guest-friendship — or
give besides

268 some gift, as is the right and custom done for
strangers.

269 Respect the gods, mighty one. We are your
suppliants,

270 and Zeus is the avenger of suppliants and of
strangers —

271 Zeus of Strangers, who walks beside honored
guests.’

272 So I spoke, and he answered me at once, with
pitiless heart:

273 ‘You are a fool, stranger — or you have come
from far away —25

274 you who tell me to fear the gods or shun their
anger.

275 The Cyclopes pay no heed to Zeus who bears
the aegis,

276 nor to the blessed gods: for we are the better
men by far.

277 I would not spare you or your companions to
dodge

278 the hatred of Zeus — not unless my own heart
bade me.

279 But tell me: where did you moor your well-
made ship when you came?

280 At the far end of the shore, or near? I want to know.'

281 So he spoke, testing; but I knew too much, and he did not catch me;

282 I answered him back with words of guile:

283 'My ship — Poseidon the earth-shaker
smashed her to pieces,26

284 driving her on the rocks at the border of your country:

285 he brought her against a headland, and the wind carried her in from the sea.

286 But I, with these men here, escaped sheer destruction.'

287 So I spoke; and out of his pitiless heart he answered nothing,

288 but sprang up and reached his hands out at my companions,

289 snatched up two together, and dashed them like puppies27

290 against the ground: their brains ran out on the earth, and wetted it.

291 He tore them limb from limb and made ready

his supper,

292 and he ate like a mountain-bred lion, and left
nothing —

293 the entrails, the flesh, the bones with their
marrow.

294 And we, weeping, lifted up our hands to Zeus

295 at the horror we watched, helplessness
holding our hearts.

296 And when the Cyclops had filled his great
belly,

297 feeding on man-flesh and washing it down
with unmixed milk,

298 he lay stretched out in the cave among his
sheep.

299 And I made a plan in my own great heart28

300 to steal close, draw the sharp sword from
beside my thigh,

301 and stab him in the chest, where the midriff
holds the liver,

302 feeling for the place with my hand. But a
second thought held me:

303 there we too would have perished in sheer

destruction,

304 for we could never have pushed back with our
hands

305 the massive stone he had set in the high
doorway.

306 So then, groaning, we waited for shining
Dawn.

307 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,

308 then he lit the fire, and milked his famous
flocks,

309 all in due order, and set the young under
each.

310 And when at last he had hurried through his
work,

311 he snatched up two men together again, and
made his meal ready.

312 And having fed, he drove his fat flocks out of
the cave,

313 lifting off the great door-stone with ease —
and then

314 set it back, the way a man sets the lid on a

quiver.**29**

315 With a great whistling the Cyclops turned his
fat flocks

316 toward the mountain; and I was left brooding
evil deep in my heart:

317 if somehow I might pay him back, and Athena
grant me the glory.

318 And this, as I turned it over, seemed to me the
best plan.

319 There lay beside a pen a great club of the
Cyclops',

320 green olive-wood: he had cut it to carry**30**

321 once it seasoned. Looking it over we judged it

322 big as the mast of a black twenty-oared ship,

323 a broad-beamed freighter, that crosses the
great gulf:**31**

324 that was its length, that its thickness to the
eye.

325 Standing to it, I cut off about a fathom's
measure

326 and handed it to my companions, and told
them to dress it down;

327 and they made it smooth, while standing by I
brought it to a point

328 at the tip, and then took it and hardened it in
the blazing fire.

329 And I laid it carefully by, hiding it under the
dung

330 that was strewn in a great deep litter through
the cave.

331 And I told the others to shake lots among
them

332 for who would dare, together with me, to lift
the stake

333 and grind it in his eye, when sweet sleep came
on him.

334 The lot fell on the very men I would have
chosen —

335 four of them, and I counted myself in with
them, the fifth.

336 At evening he came back, herding his fair-
fleeced flocks,

337 and drove those fat flocks straight into the
wide cavern,

338 all of them: he left not one outside in the deep
yard,

339 whether some foreboding moved him, or a
god so ordered it.**32**

340 Then he lifted high and set in place the great
door-stone,

341 and sitting, he milked the ewes and bleating
goats,

342 all in due order, and set the young under
each.

343 And when at last he had hurried through his
work,

344 he snatched up two men together again, and
made his supper ready.

345 And then I came up close and spoke to the
Cyclops,

346 holding in my hands an ivy-wood bowl of the
dark wine:

347 ‘Cyclops — here, drink wine, now you have fed
on man-flesh:**33**

348 so you may know what kind of drink our ship

349 carried stored. I was bringing it as an offering

for you, in hope

350 you might pity me and send me home. But
your madness is past all bearing.

351 Merciless one — how will any other man of all
the many

352 ever come near you again? What you have
done is past all measure.’

353 So I spoke; and he took it, and drank it down;
and it pleased him — terribly —

354 the sweet drink; and he demanded a second
helping:

355 ‘Give me more — be generous. And tell me
your name,

356 here, now, so I can give you a guest-gift that
will make you glad.

357 The grain-giving plowland bears wine for the
Cyclopes too —

358 fine clusters, and Zeus’ rain swells them for
us;

359 but this — this is a rivulet of ambrosia and
nectar!’

360 So he spoke, and I handed him the fire-bright

wine again.

361 Three times I brought and gave it; three times,
in his folly, he drained it.

362 And when the wine had come circling round
the Cyclops' wits,

363 then I spoke to him with honeyed words:

364 'Cyclops, you ask my glorious name? Then I

365 will tell it — and you give me the guest-gift, as
you promised.

366 Nobody is my name. Nobody is what they call
me —34

367 my mother and my father and all my
companions.'

368 So I spoke, and he answered me at once, with
pitiless heart:

369 'Nobody I will eat last of all his company,

370 and the others before him. That shall be your
guest-gift.'35

371 He spoke — and reeling back he fell flat, and
lay there

372 with his thick neck lolled over sideways; and
sleep

373 the all-subduer took him. And from his gullet
gushed wine

374 and gobbets of human flesh, as he belched in
his drunkenness.

375 And then I drove the stake under the deep
ash-heap

376 to heat; and with my words I put courage in
all

377 my companions, so no man might flinch and
hang back.

378 But when that olive stake in the fire, green
though it was,

379 was on the point of catching, and glowed
clean through, terrible —

380 then I brought it close out of the fire, and my
companions

381 stood round me; and a great power breathed
courage into us.

382 They took up the olive stake, sharpened at its
point,

383 and rammed it in his eye; and I, throwing my
weight on from above,

384 spun it — the way a man bores a ship-
timber**36**

385 with a drill, and his mates below keep it
running

386 with a strap they hold at either end, and it
spins on without stopping:

387 so we took the fire-pointed stake and spun it

388 in his eye, and the blood came boiling up
round its heat,

389 and the blast singed all his lids and brows
away

390 as the eyeball burned, and the roots of it
crackled in the fire.

391 As when a smith dips a great axe-head or an
adze**37**

392 in cold water, and it hisses loud and high,

393 tempering it — for that is what gives iron its
strength —

394 so his eye hissed round the olive stake.

395 And he let out a huge and hideous howl, and
the rock rang round it,

396 and we shrank back in terror. He wrenched

the stake

397 out of his eye, all fouled with streaming blood,

398 and flung it from him, flailing his arms in
agony,

399 and set up a great bellowing to the Cyclopes
who lived

400 around him in caves along the windy heights.

401 And they heard his cry and came thronging
from every side,

402 and standing round the cave they asked him
what was wrong:

403 'What in the world, Polyphemus? What hurt,
that you cry out so38

404 through the ambrosial night and make us
sleepless?

405 Surely no mortal is driving off your flocks
against your will?

406 Surely no one is killing you — by cunning or
by force?'

407 And out of the cave strong Polyphemus
answered them:

408 'Friends — Nobody is killing me, by cunning

and not by force!’

409 And they answered with winged words, and
gave it back:

410 ‘If nobody is forcing you, then — alone as you
are —39

411 it must be sickness from great Zeus, and there
is no escaping that.

412 Pray to our father, the lord Poseidon.’

413 So they spoke as they went; and my own heart
laughed,

414 how my name had utterly deceived him — the
name, and the flawless cunning.

415 But the Cyclops, groaning and heaving in his
agonies,

416 groped with his hands and lifted the stone
from the doorway,

417 and sat himself down in the door with both
arms spread,

418 in hope of catching anyone who tried to slip
out with the sheep:

419 such a fool, I suppose, he hoped to find in me.

420 But I was planning how it might all come out

best —

421 if I could find some release from death for my
companions

422 and for myself; and I wove every guile and
design, 40

423 as a man does for his very life: for the great
evil was close.

424 And this, as I turned it over, seemed to me the
best plan.

425 There were rams there, well-fed, thick in the
fleece,

426 fine big animals, their wool dark as violets.

427 These, working quietly, I lashed together with
plaited withies —

428 the ones that monster slept on, the outlaw —
in threes:

429 the middle one of each three carried a man,

430 and the other two walked either side,
protecting my companions.

431 So three sheep to each man. But for myself —

432 there was one ram, far the finest of all the
flock;

433 I caught him along the back and curled under
his shaggy belly

434 and lay there; and in that wondrous fleece,
with my hands

435 twisted fast, I hung on, with an enduring
heart.

436 So then, groaning, we waited for shining
Dawn.

437 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,

438 then the male flocks poured out toward
pasture,

439 and the un milked females bleated about the
pens

440 with their udders bursting. And their lord,
worn down

441 by evil agonies, ran his hands along the backs
of all his sheep

442 as they stood up straight — and never sensed
it, the fool:

443 my men bound under the breasts of his own
fleecy sheep.

444 Last of the flock the great ram walked toward
the doorway,
445 heavy with his wool — and with me, and my
crowding thoughts.41
446 And strong Polyphemus, running his hands
over him, said:
447 ‘Old sweetheart — my ram — why last of all
the flock42
448 through the cave this time? Before, you were
never one to lag behind:
449 first, always first, striding out to graze the
soft flowering grass,
450 first to reach the running rivers,
451 first in your longing to turn home to the fold
452 at evening. And now — last of all. Grieving,
are you,
453 for your master’s eye, that a coward of a man
put out,
454 with his miserable companions, when he had
crushed my wits with wine —
455 Nobody — who is not yet, I promise, clear of
destruction.

456 If only you could think with me, if only you
had a voice43

457 to say where that man is dodging from my
fury:

458 then his brains would be dashed against the
floor and spattered

459 this way and that through the cave, and my
heart would find

460 some ease from the evils this worthless
Nobody has brought me.'

461 So speaking he sent the ram away from him,
out the door.

462 And when we had gone a little way from the
cave and the yard,

463 first I loosed myself from under the ram, and
then set my companions free.

464 Swiftly then we drove those long-shanked
sheep, deep in fat,

465 turning again and again to look behind, until
we came

466 to the ship. And a welcome sight we were to
our dear companions —

467 we who had escaped death — but the others
they wept and wailed for.

468 I would not have it: I frowned each man's
tears back44

469 and ordered them quickly to fling the fine-
fleeced sheep

470 aboard in numbers, and sail out over the salt
water.

471 And they came aboard at once and took their
places at the oarlocks,

472 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt
water with their oars.

473 But when I was as far offshore as a man's
shout carries,

474 then I called to the Cyclops with jeering
words:

475 'Cyclops! Not so weak a man's companions,
after all,

476 were those you meant to eat by main force in
your hollow cave.

477 And your own evil deeds were bound to find
you out —

478 merciless one — you who did not shrink from
eating guests

479 in your own house. For that Zeus has paid
you, and the other gods.'

480 So I spoke, and the anger in his heart grew
fiercer,

481 and he tore off the peak of a great mountain
and hurled it,

482 and brought it down just ahead of the dark-
blue prow —

483 barely — it missed the tip of the steering-oar;

484 and the sea heaved up under the falling rock,

485 and the backwash carried the ship straight in
toward the land,

486 a flood-surge out of the deep, and drove her
toward the shore.

487 But I seized a long pole in my hands

488 and shoved her off and out, and roused my
companions,

489 ordering them to fall to their oars and get us
clear of the evil,

490 nodding hard with my head; and they bent to

it and rowed.

491 But when we were twice as far out over the
sea,

492 then I made to call to the Cyclops again; and
around me my companions

493 tried to hold me back with honeyed words,
this one and that one:

494 'Merciless man — why must you provoke a
savage⁴⁵

495 who even now, with that shot into the sea, has
driven the ship

496 straight back ashore — and we thought we
died there!

497 If he had heard a voice, heard any one of us
speaking,

498 he would have smashed our heads and the
ship's timbers together

499 with one jagged boulder: he throws that far.'

500 So they spoke, but they could not persuade
my great heart,⁴⁶

501 and I called back to him with fury in my
breast:

502 'Cyclops — if any mortal man ever asks you
503 who put the shameful blinding on your eye,
504 tell him: Odysseus, sacker of cities, blinded
me —⁴⁷

505 the son of Laertes, who has his home in
Ithaca.'

506 So I spoke, and he groaned aloud, and
answered:

507 'Ah, then it comes home to me — the old
prophecy!⁴⁸

508 There was a seer here once, a great man and a
good one,

509 Telemus, Eurymus' son, who excelled in
prophecy

510 and grew old prophesying among the
Cyclopes.

511 He told me all this would come to pass in time:

512 that I would lose my sight at the hands of an
Odysseus.

513 But I always watched for some big man, a
handsome one,

514 to come here, clothed in great strength;

515 and now a little man, a worthless thing, a
weakling,
516 has put out my eye — after he crushed me
with wine.
517 But come here, Odysseus — let me set out a
guest-gift for you, 49
518 and press the famous earth-shaker to give you
passage home.
519 For I am his son, and he declares himself my
father.
520 He himself, if he wills it, will heal me — and
no one else,
521 none of the blessed gods, and no mortal man.’
522 So he spoke; and I answered him and said:
523 ‘Would to god I could strip you of breath and
life
524 and send you down to the house of Hades
525 as surely as not even the earth-shaker will
ever heal that eye.’
526 So I spoke; and he then prayed to the lord
Poseidon,
527 stretching out his hands to the starry heaven:

528 'Hear me, Poseidon who hold the earth, dark-
haired one:50

529 if I am truly yours, and you declare yourself
my father,

530 grant that Odysseus, sacker of cities, never
come home —

531 the son of Laertes, who has his home in
Ithaca.

532 But if it is his portion to see his own people,
to reach

533 his well-built house and his own fatherland,

534 late may he come, and in evil case, all
companions lost,

535 on another man's ship — and find trouble in
his house.'

536 So he spoke in prayer, and the dark-haired
god heard him.51

537 Then once again he lifted a stone — far bigger
—

538 whirled it, and let it fly, putting his
measureless strength behind it,

539 and brought it down just astern of the dark-

blue ship —

540 barely — it missed the tip of the steering-oar;

541 and the sea heaved up under the falling rock,

542 and the wave carried her forward, and drove
her toward the far shore.

543 But when we came back to the island where
the other

544 well-benched ships waited all together, with
the companions

545 sitting round them weeping, watching for us
without end,

546 there we ran the ship up on the sands

547 and stepped out ourselves onto the surf-line
of the sea.

548 And taking the Cyclops' flocks out of the
hollow ship

549 we divided all, so that no man might go
cheated of his share by me.52

550 But the great ram — my strong-greaved
companions gave him

551 to me alone, when the flocks were shared, a
gift apart; and on the shore

552 I offered him to Zeus of the black cloud, the
son of Cronos,
553 lord of all, and burned the thigh-cuts. But he
took no heed of my offering:53
554 he was pondering, even then, how all my
well-benched ships
555 might be destroyed, and all my trusted
companions.
556 So then all day long till the setting of the sun
557 we sat feasting on meat past counting and
sweet wine;
558 and when the sun went down and the dusk
came on,
559 then we lay down to sleep on the surf-line of
the sea.
560 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,
561 then I roused my companions and ordered
them
562 to board in their turn and loose the stern-
cables.
563 And they came aboard at once and took their

places at the oarlocks,

564 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt
water with their oars.

565 From there we sailed on further, grieved at
heart,54

566 glad to be out of death, having lost our dear
companions.

Notes

NOTES

1. The vocative planted at 8.382 pays off exactly here: the greatest speech in the poem opens with the same ceremonial line Odysseus used to compliment the dancers. From this line to the end of Book 12 — over 2,200 lines — the “I” of the poem is Odysseus, and Homer’s own voice waits outside the tale. ↩
2. The proem-before-the-name: peace, a full hall, a singer, loaded tables — “this seems to my mind the fairest thing there is.” Plato was scandalized (a hero ranking dinner-parties as life’s *telos*), but the sentence is engineered: he blesses precisely the civilization his hosts embody, from the mouth of the man about to narrate its every opposite — famine, lawlessness, caves, and man-eating. The apologoi are framed as the

photographic negative of the Phaeacian feast at which they are told. ↩

3. “I am Odysseus, son of Laertes — known to all mankind for my cunning designs; and my fame has reached heaven.” Eight and a half books withheld, the name arrives with a claim attached: he identifies himself not by war or kingship but by δόλοι — cunning — and states his own celebrity as plain fact. The whole scene is the poem’s economy of kleos made visible: last night Demodocus sang of him as of a dead legend; now the legend stands up in the audience and takes over the singing. ↩
4. “Rough ground, but a good nurse of men” — the praise of thin-soiled Ithaca that Telemachus offered Menelaus in nearly the same breath (4.605–608: “goat-pasture, and lovelier to me than horse-pasture”). Father and son, who have never spoken, love the island in the same argument. And then the sentence the whole poem rests on: “I cannot see any sweeter sight than a man’s own country.” ↩
5. Calypso and Circe, dispatched in five lines and made grammatically identical — each “hungry to make me her husband” (the phrase from 1.15). He opens his story’s summary with the theme of detention refused — establishing before the adventures begin that the ending was never in doubt where his own will was concerned. ↩
6. The first adventure, told without a flicker of apology: “There I sacked the city and destroyed the men; and out of the city we took their wives and much substance.” The tale begins with Odysseus doing to Ismarus exactly what was done to the widow of his own simile (8.523–531) — the poem placing the

raid and its grief back to back across a single night of storytelling. His one note of pride is distributive justice among his own: “so that no man might go cheated of his share by me” (repeated verbatim of the Cyclops’ sheep at 549 — his bookkeeping survives everything). ↪

7. “The great fools would not obey” — μέγα νήπιοι, the proem’s own word for the crew (1.8). The account-ledger of blame the proem opened is now kept by Odysseus himself, entry by entry: ordered retreat, refused; wine drunk, cattle slaughtered (the exact idiom of the suitors’ feasting); six men per ship dead. Seventy-two lost to disobedience before anything supernatural has happened at all. ↪
8. “When the sun turned over toward unyoking-time” — βουλευτόνδε, the hour the plowman unyokes his oxen: time told by farm-work even in battle, like the mule-furrow of 8.124. ↪
9. The refrain of the apologoi, fixed here: “From there we sailed on further, grieved at heart, / glad to be out of death, having lost our dear companions.” It will toll between episodes through three more books — the wanderings counted out in identical griefs. ↪
10. Calling each dead man’s name three times before sailing: the rite owed to the unburied, a voice-cenotaph. The poem’s care for death-rites (Elpenor will die of their neglect) begins in its hero’s punctiliousness even in flight. ↪
11. Malea and Cythera — the last real place-names. Nine days of storm from rounding the Peloponnese, and the ships pass off the map: everything from the Lotus-eaters to Phaeacia

happens in a geography that ancient and modern readers alike have tried and failed to chart. The poem gives the boundary a name and a wind. ↩

12. The Lotus-eaters: the gentlest danger in the poem — no violence, no malice, only a fruit after which “they wanted to stay... and to forget their homecoming.” The first adversary of the *nostos* is not death but oblivion — the will itself dissolving. Odysseus’ response is proportionate and terrible: the weeping men dragged back and bound under the benches. Homecoming, in this poem, can be a thing done to you by force. ↩
13. What the lotus was — jujube? poppy? — was already guessed at in antiquity and never settled. The poem needs no botany: “honey-sweet,” and it eats memory. ↩
14. The Cyclopes ethnography, all negations: no planting, no plowing, no assemblies, no laws (θέμιστες), each a law to his own household, “and they care nothing for one another.” Civilization is defined by its absence — and with a barb: everything grows for them anyway, “trusting in the deathless gods.” Lawlessness with divine subsidy. Odysseus the raider-king describes them with the fascinated contempt of a man cataloguing everything his own world is not. ↩
15. The goat island (116–141) is surveyed with a colonist’s eye: meadows, deep soil, a harbor needing no anchor-stone, a spring — “it would bear every crop in season.” The island is “widowed of men” only because the Cyclopes have no ships, “no shipwrights” — seafaring as the exact boundary between having a world and having a cave. This passage, the eighth-

century reader's own colonial appraisal form, is the poem's clearest window onto its age of western settlement. ↩

16. "Smoke, and voices — theirs, and their sheep's and goats": the reconnaissance is aural. Compare Odysseus on Ogygia, aching "to see even the smoke leaping up" from Ithaca (1.58): smoke on a horizon is this poem's sign of inhabited land — hearth-fire, the first legible mark of *any* society, kind or monstrous. ↩
17. The arrival-question, verbatim from 6.120–121 — but there he asked it of Phaeacia, and the answer was the kindest people in the poem. Asked here, the answer is the Cyclops. The formula is a coin the poem keeps flipping; the two faces land in adjacent books. ↩
18. The first sight of him is all isolation-words: alone, far apart, no company, aloof, "his heart knew no law" (ἄθεμίστια ᾗδῃ — *themis* again). And then scale: not like a bread-eating man but "like a wooded crag... standing clear of all the rest." He is landscape, not society — the ethnography of 112–115 condensed into one body. ↩
19. Maron's wine: the episode's engine, and a parable of *xenia's* economy. Because Odysseus once *spared* a priest — reverence, not profit — he was given a wine so potent it takes twenty parts of water; because a monster despises guest-law, that wine destroys him. The gift-chain is the theology: what you do at your door comes back at someone else's. Even its secrecy is loving detail — one wife, one housekeeper, no one else in the house knew. ↩
20. The cave interior is a model dairy: cheese-crates, lambs sorted by age in three pens, every vessel brimming. The monster is a

meticulous husbandman — the horror ahead is not chaos but *order*, a well-run farm whose livestock now includes men. ↩

21. “But I would not listen — it would have been far better”: the narrator convicts his younger self in mid-sentence. The motive is stated with terrible honesty: to see him, “and whether he would give me guest-gifts.” Curiosity, and the desire to collect *xenia* from the uttermost edge of the world — the collector’s greed of a connoisseur of hospitality. Six men will pay for it. ↩
22. The door-stone that twenty-two four-wheeled carts could not shift: the number is absurdly exact, an engineer’s estimate. It is also the plot: the stone converts the cave into a problem force cannot solve (299–305), which is why this, of all adventures, belongs to Nobody. ↩
23. The Cyclops asks Nestor’s question — the piracy formula of 3.71–74, word for word — but before welcome, from above his own supper-fire. In *Pylos* the question followed the feast and was courtesy; flung at suppliants before any word of greeting, it is the signature of the monster. The poem has waited six books to spring this reuse. ↩
24. Odysseus’ plea leans on Agamemnon’s fame and sack-count — the credentials of a raider offered to a hermit who has never heard of Troy — and then rises to the full doctrine: “Zeus is the avenger of suppliants and of strangers — Zeus of Strangers.” The theology Echeus and Nausicaa and Alcinous all recited is here spoken to its one perfect unbeliever. ↩
25. “The Cyclopes pay no heed to Zeus... for we are the better men by far.” The only speech of genuine atheism in Homer — not doubt but contemptuous superiority. And his follow-up

question (where is your ship?) shows cunning inside the savagery: he tests, Odysseus lies (283–286), and the lie — the ship wrecked by Poseidon — saves the crews and is, prophetically, half true. ↩

26. The instant lie — ship wrecked by Poseidon, survivors only — protects the crew at the shore and the fleet at the island in one stroke. It is also, unknowingly, half a prophecy: wreck does await — the fleet under the Laestrygonian rocks, the last ship under Zeus' bolt, and Poseidon saving his wrath for the raft. In this poem even the lies come true; the liar just doesn't know how. ↩
27. "Like puppies" — the most sickening simile in the poem precisely because of its smallness: not battle-death but the casual destruction of something young by something huge. Then the lion formula, and the total consumption — "entrails, flesh, bones with their marrow" — the feast type-scene inverted into a meal without fire, portion, or god. ↩
28. The sword-impulse checked: kill him now and die entombed. The stone forces the plot's grammar — βίη (force) is useless; everything must run through μῆτις (cunning). The episode is built as a demonstration-proof of the hero's defining quality, with the door-stone as the theorem's given. ↩
29. "The way a man sets the lid on a quiver": the boulder no twenty-two carts could shift, handled like an archer's kit — scale comedy, and a reminder between the horrors that to him this is housekeeping. ↩
30. The stake is *olive* — green olive-wood, Athena's tree, the wood of the bed at 23. The instrument of vengeance and the symbol of

the marriage are cut from the same timber; the poem's materials are never neutral. ↩

31. Measured against “the mast of a black twenty-oared ship, a broad-beamed freighter” — the second time Odysseus sizes timber by merchant shipping (the raft-hull at 5.249–251). Euryalus' sneer (8.161–164) keeps being half-right: the hero's imagination is genuinely nautical-commercial. The poem lets the insult be observation. ↩
32. This once, the Cyclops drives *all* the flock inside, rams included — “whether some foreboding moved him, or a god so ordered it.” Without that unexplained variance there is no escape under the rams. The narrator leaves the door open between chance and providence, and it is the tale's only such shrug: even Odysseus cannot say who arranged his instrument. ↩
33. The wine-offer is staged as a grievance-gift: “I was bringing it as an offering... but your madness is past all bearing.” He serves the destroying draught in the language of the very hospitality being violated — and the Cyclops, delighted, promises a guest-gift in return, completing the parody: the exchange-of-gifts scene performed by a poisoner and a cannibal. ↩
34. Οὔτις — “Nobody.” The man who spent eight books refusing to be named (and heard last night that “no one among mankind is altogether nameless,” 8.552) weaponizes namelessness itself. The alias is also a self-annihilation with a truth in it: stripped of ships, companions, and fame, what is he in this cave but nobody? The name he gives falsely is the condition he is actually in. ↩

35. “Nobody I will eat last... that shall be your guest-gift.” The Cyclops’ single joke — and it is a real one, the ghastly wit of parodied *xenia*. The poem gives its monster exactly one flash of humor, and it is about eating-order. ↩
36. The blinding runs on two craftsman similes back to back: the shipwright’s bow-drill (spun with a strap by mates below — precise, collaborative, professional) and the smith quenching an axe-head, “for that is what gives iron its strength.” The atrocity is narrated as skilled labor — Odysseus the carpenter of the raft and the bed at his trade — and the second simile is knowingly anachronistic: iron-tempering is the poet’s own technology, imported into the bronze-age tale for the sound of the hiss. ↩
37. The quench-simile carries a workshop aside — “for that is what gives iron its strength” — a craftsman’s parenthesis on metallurgy in the middle of an atrocity. The poet knows his trade-lore and cannot resist sharing it, even here. ↩
38. Polyphemus is named at last — by his worried neighbors, 403 lines into his episode. The name means “much-famed” (or “much-speaking”): Fame-himself, blinded by Nobody. The pun-architecture of the episode is total. ↩
39. The trap sprung: “if nobody is forcing you” — Greek μή τις, one breath away from μήτις, *cunning*. The neighbors’ diagnosis (“sickness from Zeus — pray to our father Poseidon”) is wrong in the first clause and disastrous in the second: their prescribed prayer is exactly what will curse the escaping trickster. And at 414 the narrator lands the pun openly: the name deceived him — “the name, and the flawless *mētis*.”

Nobody and cunning are, in Greek, nearly the same word: the alias was the trait, spelled aloud. ↩

40. “I wove every guile and design, as a man does for his very life” — plotting as weaving yet again (Penelope’s loom, Hephaestus’ snare-webs, Nestor’s “stitched evils”). The poem has one master-metaphor for intelligence, and every member of this family uses it. ↩
41. “Heavy with his wool — and with me, and my crowding thoughts”: the great ram carries a double freight, fleece and mind. The zeugma is the escape itself in miniature — the monster’s own best possession loaded with the *mētis* that ruined him. ↩
42. The address to the ram — the episode’s astonishing mercy. The cannibal, in agony, speaks to his lead animal with the tenderness the poem has shown nowhere else in the cave: *first always first, to the grass, to the rivers, home at evening — now last. Grieving, are you, for your master’s eye?* For ten lines the monster is a shepherd who loves his beast and is loved in his imagination by it, and the listening hall — and we — are forced to pity him with the escaping hero literally hanging beneath the words. ↩
43. “If only you could think with me” — ὁμοφρονέοις: the *homophrosynē* word, the like-mindedness Odysseus blessed Nausicaa with as the best thing two people can have (6.181–184). The Cyclops wishes it of a sheep. It is the loneliest line in the poem: the creature with no society, no law, and now no sight, reaching for the poem’s word for marriage — toward the animal carrying his enemy out the door. ↩

44. “I frowned each man’s tears back”: grief for the six left in the cave is suppressed by a movement of the brows — mourning deferred by command, as at the Cicones it was rationed to three calls of the name. The captain’s arithmetic: weep later, row now. ↩
45. The companions’ plea is the sanest speech in the episode — and it fails. “They could not persuade my great heart” (500): the identical formula for heroic obstinacy the poem elsewhere uses admiringly. This is the hero’s great flaw scene: the need to *sign the deed* overrides survival itself. ↩
46. “They could not persuade my great heart” — the formula of heroic resolve, used here for the one decision in the poem that everyone, crew and listener alike, can see is wrong. The epic language of steadfastness deployed against sane advice: obstinacy and heroism share a vocabulary, and the poem knows it. ↩
47. The boast: “tell him: Odysseus, sacker of cities, blinded me — the son of Laertes, who has his home in Ithaca.” Name, title, patronymic, address — a herald’s full formula, delivered to the one auditor who can turn it into a curse. Kleos demands attribution; Nobody saves your life, but Nobody gets no credit. The claiming of the deed is at once his signature virtue (fame) and the single costliest sentence he speaks in ten years. ↩
48. The Cyclops had a prophecy too — Telemus foretold blinding “at the hands of an Odysseus” — and he had mis-imagined his enemy: “I always watched for some big man, a handsome one.” Expectation as blindness before the stake: he was watching for

the wrong shape. File this beside every person in Ithaca who will look at a beggar and watch for a king. ↩

49. The monster's second hospitality-parody: *come back, let me give you a guest-gift, my father will escort you home*. The vocabulary of *xenia* (ξείνια, πομπή — gifts, sending) in the mouth that ate six guests. Odysseus' refusal wishes him to Hades; the exchange of courtesies is complete. ↩
50. The curse — and it is the plot of the *Odyssey* dictated by its villain: *never come home; or if it is his portion* (the fate-formula from Proteus, 4.475–477, respected even by a praying monster) — *late, in evil case, all companions lost, on another man's ship, and find trouble in his house*. Every clause will be executed: ten years late; the borrowed Phaeacian ship; the hundred and eight suitors. Poseidon's grudge, announced at 1.20–21 and unexplained for eight books, is here given its cause and its exact text. ↩
51. “And the dark-haired god heard him.” Four words, and the poem's engine is installed. Compare 6.328: Athena heard Odysseus' prayer in the grove. Both prayers of this pair of enemies are heard; the whole poem is the interference-pattern. ↩
52. The distributive-justice line repeated verbatim from the Cicones (42): loot or livestock, the shares are always even, “so that no man might go cheated by me.” And the crew's answering grace — the great ram voted to him “a gift apart” — is the campaign's one moment of pure solidarity, promptly spent on a rejected sacrifice. ↩

53. “He took no heed of my offering: he was pondering, even then, how all my ships might be destroyed.” This is Odysseus’ theology of his own catastrophe — Zeus as premeditating destroyer — and it stands in unresolved friction with Zeus’ own opening speech (1.32–43: mortals blame the gods for what their recklessness earns). The poem lets its hero’s bitter reading and its god’s self-defense coexist; between them sits every ship and man lost to Thrinacia’s cattle, where both explanations will be tested at once. ↩
54. The refrain closes the book as it closed the Cicones — same grief, same relief, same dead. One adventure per moral: the raid cost six per ship by disobedience; the cave cost six by the captain’s curiosity and six more words at the rail. The ledger sails on. ↩

Odyssey — Book 10

*Aeolus and the bag of winds; the Laestrygonians; a year
with Circe.*

- 1 We came next to the Aeolian island; and there
lived
- 2 Aeolus, Hippotas' son, dear to the deathless
gods,
- 3 on a floating island: all around it a wall¹
4 of bronze, unbreakable, and the cliff runs up
sheer.
- 5 Twelve children of his live in his halls,
6 six daughters and six sons in their prime,
7 and he has given his daughters to his sons to be
their wives.²
- 8 They are always feasting beside their dear
father
- 9 and their honored mother, and good things past
counting are set before them;
- 10 all day the house is savory with roasting, and

the courtyard rings with the sound;

11 and at night they sleep beside their honored
wives

12 among blankets, on corded bedsteads.

13 To their city, then, we came, and their beautiful
house.

14 A full month he made much of me, and
questioned me on everything —

15 Ilium, the Argives' ships, the Achaeans'
homecoming —

16 and I told him all of it through, in its due order.

17 And when I in my turn asked for the road, and
begged him

18 to send me on, he refused me nothing: he
prepared my sending.

19 He gave me a bag — the flayed hide of a nine-
year ox —3

20 and in it he bound the courses of the
blustering winds:

21 for the son of Cronos made him steward of the
winds,

22 to still them or to rouse them, whichever he

will.

23 In my hollow ship he lashed it fast with a
shining cord

24 of silver, so that not the smallest breath could
slip past;

25 and for me he sent out the West Wind's breath
to blow,

26 to carry the ships and the men. But it was not
to be

27 accomplished: we were destroyed by our own
folly.⁴

28 Nine days and nights alike we sailed on,

29 and on the tenth our fathers' fields were rising
into view —

30 so near, we could see men tending their fires.⁵

31 Then sweet sleep came over me, worn out as I
was:

32 all that time I had worked the ship's sheet
myself, yielding it

33 to no other companion, to bring us home the
faster.

34 And the companions began to talk to one

another,

35 and said I was bringing home gold and silver
for myself,

36 gifts of great-hearted Aeolus, Hippotas' son.

37 And thus would one of them say, with a glance
at his neighbor:6

38 'Look at him — how loved he is, how honored,
39 among all men, whatever city or land he comes
to!

40 He carries out of Troy a mass of beautiful
treasure,

41 his plunder — while we, who have
accomplished the same long road,

42 come home with empty hands.

43 And now Aeolus, obliging him in friendship,
has given him

44 this besides. Quick, then — let us see what is in
it:

45 how much gold, how much silver the bag
holds.'

46 So they talked, and the companions' evil
counsel won.

47 They opened the bag — and all the winds burst
out,
48 and the storm snatched them up at once and
swept them seaward,
49 weeping, away from their fathers' land. And I,
50 waking, debated in my own blameless heart
51 whether to drop from the deck and drown in
the sea7
52 or endure in silence and stay among the living.
53 I endured, and I stayed. Covering my head
54 I lay where I was; and the ships were carried by
the evil blast of the storm
55 back to the Aeolian island; and my companions
groaned.
56 There we set foot on the mainland and drew
water,
57 and the companions quickly took their meal
beside the fast ships.
58 And when we had tasted food and drink,
59 then I took with me a herald and one
companion
60 and went to the famous house of Aeolus. I

found him

61 feasting beside his wife and his children.

62 We came into the house and sat down by the
doorposts

63 on the threshold; and they were amazed at
heart, and asked:

64 'How are you here, Odysseus? What evil power
attacked you?

65 Surely we sent you off with all care, to reach
66 your fatherland and your house, and whatever
place is dear to you.'

67 So they spoke; and I, grieving at heart,
addressed them:

68 'My evil companions ruined me — they, and a
pitiless

69 sleep. But heal it, friends: the power is yours.'

70 So I spoke, plying them with soft words;

71 and they fell silent. And the father answered:

72 'Out of this island — fast — you vilest thing
alive!⁸

73 It is against all right for me to harbor or to
send on his way

74 a man the blessed gods detest.
75 Out! — since you come here hated by the
deathless ones.’
76 So speaking he sent me from his house,
groaning heavily.
77 From there we sailed on further, grieved at
heart.
78 And the men’s spirit was worn down by the
grinding rowing —
79 our own fault: no sending wind showed any
more.
80 Six days and nights alike we sailed on,
81 and on the seventh we came to Lamus’ steep
citadel —
82 Telepylus of the Laestrygonians, where
herdsman hails herdsman:9
83 the one driving in calls, and the one driving
out answers.
84 There a sleepless man could have earned a
double wage,
85 one herding cattle, one pasturing silvery
sheep:

86 so close together are the paths of night and
day.
87 There, when we came into the famous harbor
— a sheer cliff10
88 runs unbroken all around it, on both sides,
89 and jutting headlands, facing one another,
90 thrust out at the mouth, and the entrance is
narrow —
91 there all the others steered their curved ships
in,
92 and moored them inside the hollow harbor,
close together:
93 for no wave ever swelled in there, great or
small,
94 but a white calm lay all around it.
95 I alone held my black ship outside,11
96 there at the edge, and made the cables fast to
the rock;
97 and I climbed a broken lookout-height and
stood there.
98 No works of oxen or of men showed anywhere;
99 we saw only smoke springing up from the land.

100 Then I sent companions ahead to learn
101 what men they were who ate bread upon this
earth:
102 two men I chose, and sent a third with them
as herald.
103 They went ashore and took a level road, by
which the wagons
104 hauled timber down to the city from the high
mountains,
105 and before the city they met a girl drawing
water,12
106 the sturdy daughter of Laestrygonian
Antiphates.
107 She had come down to the fair-flowing spring
108 Artacia, from which they carried water to the
town;
109 and they came up beside her and spoke to her,
and asked
110 who was king of these people, and whom he
ruled;
111 and she pointed them at once to her father's
high-roofed house.

112 But when they entered the famous house,
they found his wife
113 huge as a mountain peak — and they were sick
with horror at her.
114 She called famous Antiphates straightway
from the gathering-place —
115 her husband — and he plotted their wretched
destruction:
116 he snatched up one of my companions on the
spot and made his meal of him,
117 and the other two sprang away and came
flying to the ships.
118 Then he raised the war-cry through the city;
and hearing it
119 the mighty Laestrygonians came thronging
from every side,
120 thousands of them — not like men, but like
the Giants.13
121 From the cliffs they pelted us with man-heavy
stones,
122 and at once an evil din rose up along the ships

—

123 the scream of dying men, the crunch of
shattering hulls.

124 Spearing them like fish, they carried home
their loathsome meal.14

125 While they were slaughtering those inside the
deep harbor,

126 I drew the sharp sword from beside my thigh

127 and cut the cables of my dark-blue-prowed
ship,

128 and quickly I roused my companions and
ordered them

129 to fall to their oars and get us clear of the evil;

130 and they tore up the sea together, in terror of
death.

131 Gladly my ship fled out to open water, away
from the beetling

132 cliffs; but the others were destroyed there, all
together.

133 From there we sailed on further, grieved at
heart,15

134 glad to be out of death, having lost our dear
companions.

135 And we came to the island of Aeaea; and there
lived

136 Circe of the lovely braids, dread goddess with
a mortal's voice,16

137 own sister of Aeetes the deadly-minded:

138 both born of Helios, who carries light to
mortals,

139 and of Perse their mother, whom Ocean
fathered.

140 There we brought the ship silently to the
shore

141 and into a harbor fit for ships; and some god
was guiding us.

142 We stepped ashore there, and for two days
and two nights

143 we lay, eating our hearts with weariness and
pain together.

144 But when Dawn of the lovely braids brought
the third day round,

145 then I took my spear and my sharp sword

146 and went up quickly from the ship to a
viewing-place,

147 in hope of seeing men's works, or catching a
voice.

148 I climbed a broken lookout-height and stood
there,

149 and smoke showed to my eyes, rising from the
wide-wayed earth

150 in Circe's halls, up through the dense brush
and the timber.

151 And I debated then in my mind and in my
heart

152 whether to go and look, since I had seen the
fire-bright smoke.

153 And as I weighed it, this seemed to me the
better way:17

154 to go first to the fast ship and the shore of the
sea,

155 give the companions their meal, and send
them out to learn.

156 But when, on my way down, I was near the
curved ship,

157 then some god took pity on me, alone as I was,

158 and sent a great high-antlered stag into my

very path.18

159 He was coming down to the river from his
forest pasture

160 to drink, for the sun's force was heavy on him;

161 and as he stepped out I struck him on the
spine, mid-back:

162 the bronze spear went clean through,

163 and down he dropped in the dust with a cry,
and the life flew from him.

164 I set my foot on him and drew the bronze
spear

165 out of the wound, and laid it down there on
the ground

166 and left it; then I pulled brushwood and
withies

167 and plaited a rope, a fathom's length, well-
twisted

168 all along, and bound together the feet of the
huge beast,

169 and went down to the black ship carrying him
slung across my neck,

170 leaning on my spear: there was no carrying

him on the shoulder

171 with one hand — he was a very great beast.

172 I flung him down before the ship, and woke
my companions

173 with gentle words, standing by each man in
turn:

174 ‘Friends — for all our grief, we will not go
down

175 to the house of Hades before our destined day.

176 Come then, while there is food and drink in
the fast ship,

177 let us think of eating, and not be worn away
with hunger.’

178 So I spoke, and they quickly heeded my words:

179 they uncovered their heads there by the shore
of the barren sea

180 and marveled at the stag: he was a very great
beast.

181 And when they had had their joy of gazing,

182 they washed their hands and made the
glorious feast ready.

183 So then all day long till the setting of the sun

184 we sat feasting on meat past counting and
sweet wine;
185 and when the sun went down and the dusk
came on,
186 then we lay down to sleep on the surf-line of
the sea.
187 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,
188 then I called an assembly, and spoke among
them all:
189 'Hear my words, companions, for all your
suffering.
190 Friends — we do not know where the dark is,
or where the dawn,19
191 or where the sun that carries light to mortals
goes under the earth,
192 or where he rises. Let us think, then — quickly
—
193 whether any device is left us. I do not believe
there is.
194 I climbed a broken lookout-height and saw
195 an island, wreathed round with the boundless

sea;

196 the island itself lies low, and in the middle of
it my eyes

197 caught smoke, up through the dense brush
and the timber.'

198 So I spoke, and their own hearts broke within
them,

199 remembering the deeds of Laestrygonian
Antiphates

200 and the violence of the great-hearted man-
eating Cyclops.

201 They wept aloud, letting the big tears fall —

202 but nothing came of all their mourning.**20**

203 Then I counted off all my strong-greaved
companions

204 into two bands, and gave each band a leader:

205 I led the one, and godlike Eurylochus the
other.**21**

206 We shook the lots quickly in a bronze helmet,

207 and out jumped the lot of great-hearted
Eurylochus.

208 So he set out, and with him two-and-twenty

companions,

209 weeping — and they left us behind in tears as well.

210 In a forest glen they found the house of Circe, built

211 of polished stones, in a place with a clear view all around;

212 and around it were mountain wolves and lions

—22

213 creatures she herself had bewitched, giving them evil drugs.

214 And these did not spring at the men, no:

215 they rose and fawned around them, waving their long tails.

216 As when dogs fawn around their master coming from a feast —

217 for he always carries home some sweet morsel for them —

218 so the strong-clawed wolves and the lions fawned

219 around them; and they were terrified at the sight of the dread huge creatures.

220 They stood in the gateway of the goddess of
the lovely hair,

221 and inside they heard Circe singing in a
beautiful voice,23

222 moving to and fro at her great imperishable
loom — the weaving

223 goddesses do: fine-spun work, graceful and
shining.

224 And Polites began to speak among them — a
leader of men,

225 who of all my companions was closest and
dearest to me:

226 ‘Friends — someone inside there, moving at a
great loom,

227 is singing, beautifully — the whole floor hums
with it —

228 goddess or woman. Quick, let us call out to
her.’

229 So he spoke, and they lifted their voices and
called.

230 And she came out at once, and opened the
shining doors,

231 and invited them in; and all together, in their
innocence,
232 they followed her. Only Eurylochus stayed
behind, suspecting a snare.
233 She led them in and seated them on benches
and chairs,
234 and stirred them a mixture: cheese and barley
meal and pale honey²⁴
235 in Pramnian wine. And into the dish she
blended
236 baleful drugs, to make them wholly forget
their fathers' land.
237 And when she had served it and they had
drunk it down, at once
238 she struck them with her wand and penned
them in the pigsties.
239 And they had the heads of pigs — the voice,
the bristles,
240 the body — but their minds stayed steady,
exactly as before.²⁵
241 So they were penned there weeping; and Circe
threw them

242 acorns of oak and ilex, and cornel berries,
243 the things pigs eat, the wallowers on the
ground.
244 But Eurylochus came running back to the fast
black ship
245 to bring the news of the companions and
their bitter fate.
246 And he could not get one word out, for all his
straining —
247 struck to the heart with his great anguish; his
eyes
248 brimmed full of tears, and his spirit was all
lament.
249 But when we questioned him, all of us, in our
amazement,
250 at last he told the destruction of the other
companions:
251 ‘We went up through the brush, as you
commanded, glorious Odysseus, 26
252 and in a forest glen we found a beautiful
house, built
253 of polished stones, in a place with a clear view

all around.

254 And there someone at a great loom was
singing, clear and high —

255 goddess or woman. And they lifted their
voices and called.

256 And she came out at once, and opened the
shining doors,

257 and invited them in; and all together, in their
innocence,

258 they followed her. But I stayed behind,
suspecting a snare.

259 And they vanished — all of them together. Not
one of them

260 appeared again, though I sat a long time
watching.

261 So he spoke; and I slung my silver-studded
sword

262 about my shoulders — the great bronze one —
and my bow with it,

263 and ordered him to lead me back by the same
way.

264 But he seized me with both hands, clasping

my knees,

265 and wailing he spoke winged words to me:

266 'Do not take me back there — Zeus-nurtured
— against my will. Leave me here.

267 For I know it: you will not come back yourself,
and you will not bring

268 one of your companions. No — with these
men here, quickly,

269 let us run: we may still escape the evil day.'

270 So he spoke, and I answered him and said:

271 'Eurylochus — stay here, then, where you are,
272 eating and drinking beside the hollow black
ship.

273 But I am going. Hard necessity is on me.'

274 So speaking I went up from the ship and the
sea.

275 But just as, threading the sacred glens, I was
about

276 to reach the great house of Circe of the many
drugs,

277 there Hermes of the golden rod met me

278 as I came toward the house — in the likeness

of a young man

279 with his first down on his lip, in the loveliest
season of youth.

280 He clamped a hand on mine, and spoke a
word, and named me:

281 'Where now, poor doomed man, alone along
the heights,

282 a stranger to the country? Your companions
there in Circe's house

283 are penned like pigs, packed in their hidden
sties.

284 Is it to free them you are going? You will not
come back yourself,

285 I tell you: you will only stay there with the
others.

286 But come — I will release you from the evil, I
will save you.

287 Here. Take this good drug with you into
Circe's house —

288 it will keep the evil day away from your head.

289 And I will tell you all the deadly designs of
Circe.

290 She will mix you a potion, and cast drugs into
the dish;

291 but even so she will not have power to
bewitch you: the good drug

292 I give you will not let her. And I will tell you
everything.

293 The moment Circe strikes at you with her
long wand,

294 that instant draw the sharp sword from
beside your thigh

295 and go for Circe as though you meant to kill
her.

296 She will be seized with terror, and invite you
to her bed.

297 Do not, then, refuse the bed of the goddess —

29

298 if you want her to free your companions and
host you well —

299 but order her to swear the great oath of the
blessed ones

300 that she is not planning some new evil
against you:

301 lest she strip you naked and make you a
coward, an unmanned thing.'

302 So speaking, the slayer of Argus handed me
the drug,

303 pulling it out of the ground, and showed me
its nature:

304 at the root it was black, but its flower like
milk.**30**

305 Moly, the gods call it. And it is hard for mortal
men

306 to dig — but the gods have power to do all
things.

307 Then Hermes went away over the wooded
island

308 toward high Olympus; and I went on to the
house of Circe,

309 and my heart ran dark with many things as I
went.

310 I stopped at the doors of the goddess of the
lovely hair,

311 and standing there I shouted; and the goddess
heard my voice.

312 And she came out at once, and opened the
shining doors,
313 and invited me in; and I followed her, grieved
at heart.
314 She led me in and seated me on a silver-
studded chair,
315 beautiful, cunningly worked, with a footstool
for my feet,
316 and made me a potion in a golden cup, for me
to drink,
317 and slipped a drug in it, with evil purpose in
her heart.
318 And when she served it and I drank it off —
and it did not bewitch me —
319 she struck me with her wand, and spoke a
word, and named me:
320 ‘Off to the sty now. Lie down with the rest of
your companions.’
321 So she spoke; and I drew the sharp sword from
beside my thigh
322 and went for Circe as though I meant to kill
her.

323 And she shrieked, and ran under the blade,
and seized my knees,
324 and wailing she spoke winged words to me:
325 'What man are you, and from where? Where
are your city and your parents?31
326 Wonder holds me: you drank these drugs and
were not bewitched —
327 and no other man, no, not one, has withstood
these drugs
328 once he drank them, once they passed the
fence of his teeth.
329 The mind in your breast is proof against
enchantment.
330 Surely you are Odysseus — the man of many
turnings — whom32
331 the golden-rodded slayer of Argus always told
me would come,
332 on his way home from Troy in his fast black
ship.
333 Come now — put your sword in its sheath, and
let the two of us
334 mount my bed together, so that mingled there

335 in the bed of love, we may come to trust one
another.'

336 So she spoke, and I answered her and said:

337 'Circe — how can you bid me be gentle with
you?

338 You who turned my companions into pigs in
your own halls,

339 and keep me here, and — scheming still —
invite me

340 to your chamber, to climb into your bed,

341 so that stripped naked I may be made a
coward, an unmanned thing.

342 I will not consent to climb into your bed

343 unless you bring yourself, goddess, to swear
me the great oath

344 that you are not planning some new evil
against me.'

345 So I spoke, and she swore it at once, as I
demanded.

346 And when she had sworn, and made an end of
the oath,

347 then I mounted the surpassingly beautiful bed

of Circe.³⁴

³⁴⁸ Meanwhile four handmaids were busy
through the halls —

³⁴⁹ the serving-women who keep her house in
order,

³⁵⁰ daughters of the springs and the groves³⁵

³⁵¹ and the sacred rivers that flow out to the sea.

³⁵² One of them threw beautiful covers over the
chairs,

³⁵³ purple above, with linen spread beneath;

³⁵⁴ another drew silver tables up before the
chairs

³⁵⁵ and set out golden baskets on them;

³⁵⁶ the third mixed honey-hearted wine, sweet
wine,

³⁵⁷ in a silver bowl, and set out golden cups;

³⁵⁸ and the fourth brought water and kindled a
great fire

³⁵⁹ under a huge cauldron, and the water
warmed.

³⁶⁰ And when the water boiled in the bright
bronze,

361 she set me in the tub and bathed me from the
great cauldron,

362 tempering it to my liking, pouring it over my
head and shoulders,

363 until she had taken the heart-wasting
weariness from my limbs.

364 And when she had bathed me and rubbed me
richly with oil,

365 and thrown a beautiful cloak around me, and
a tunic,

366 she led me in and seated me on a silver-
studded chair,

367 beautiful, cunningly worked, with a footstool
for my feet;

368 and a handmaid brought water for my hands
in a pitcher,

369 a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a
silver basin

370 for me to wash, and drew up a polished table
beside me.

371 The grave housekeeper brought bread and set
it before me,

372 laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of
her store,

373 and pressed me to eat. But my heart was not
in it:

374 I sat with my thoughts elsewhere, and my
spirit boded evil.

375 And when Circe saw me sitting there, not
reaching

376 my hands to the bread, gripped in a strong
grief,

377 she came near, and spoke winged words to
me:

378 ‘Why do you sit like this, Odysseus, like a man
struck dumb,

379 eating your heart, and touching neither food
nor drink?

380 Do you suspect some other snare? You have
no cause

381 to fear: I have already sworn you the strong
oath.’

382 So she spoke, and I answered her and said:

383 ‘Circe — what man with any decency in him36

384 could bear to taste of food and drink
385 before his companions were set free, and he
saw them with his eyes?
386 If you press me in good faith to eat and drink,
387 then free them — let my eyes see my trusted
companions.’
388 So I spoke, and Circe went out through the
hall,
389 wand in hand, and opened the doors of the
sty,
390 and drove them out — in the shape of nine-
year fattened hogs.
391 They stood there facing her; and she went
among them
392 anointing each with another drug;
393 and the bristles the baleful drug had grown
on them —
394 the drug the lady Circe gave them — dropped
from their limbs,
395 and they were men again — younger than
they were before,³⁷
396 far more beautiful, and taller to the eye.

397 They knew me; and each man clung to my
hands;
398 and a passionate weeping came over us all,
and the house
399 rang terribly around us; and the goddess
herself was moved to pity.
400 She came close beside me and spoke, shining
among goddesses:
401 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices —
402 go now to your fast ship and the shore of the
sea.
403 First of all, haul the ship up onto dry land,
404 and stow your goods and all the tackle in the
caves;
405 then come back yourself, and bring your
trusted companions.'
406 So she spoke, and my proud heart consented.
407 I went my way to the fast ship and the shore
of the sea,
408 and there by the fast ship I found my trusted
companions

409 in pitiful lamentation, letting the big tears
fall.

410 As when farmyard calves around the herded
cows³⁸

411 that come back to the dung-yard, filled with
grazing,

412 all skip and frisk to meet them — the pens no
longer

413 hold them, but lowing without pause they run

414 around their mothers: so those men, when
their eyes took me in,

415 poured around me weeping. And to their
hearts it felt

416 as if they had come to their fatherland, to
their very town

417 in rugged Ithaca, where they were bred and
born.

418 And wailing, they spoke winged words to me:

419 'At your return, Zeus-nurtured, we rejoice

420 as if we had come home to Ithaca, our fathers'
land.

421 But come — tell the destruction of the other

companions.'

422 So they spoke, and I answered with soft
words:

423 'First of all, let us haul the ship up onto dry
land,

424 and stow our goods and all the tackle in the
caves;

425 then bestir yourselves, all of you, and come
with me,

426 so you may see our companions in the sacred
halls of Circe,

427 eating and drinking: what they have never
fails.'

428 So I spoke, and they quickly heeded my
words.

429 Only Eurylochus tried to hold back all my
companions,

430 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to
them:

431 'Poor fools — where are we going? Why do
you hanker after these evils —39

432 to go down into Circe's hall, who will turn

433 every one of us into pigs or wolves or lions
434 to guard her great house for her — and guard
it we must —
435 the way the Cyclops did his work, when our
companions
436 came to his inner yard, and the reckless
Odysseus with them:
437 it was that man's blind folly killed them too.'
438 So he spoke; and I turned it over in my mind
—40
439 whether to draw the long-edged sword from
beside my thick thigh,
440 strike off his head and bring it down in the
dust,
441 kinsman by marriage though he was, and a
close one. But my companions
442 held me back with honeyed words, this one
and that one:
443 'Zeus-born — this man, if you command it, we
will leave
444 here by the ship, to stay and guard the ship;
445 lead the rest of us to the sacred house of

Circe.’

446 So speaking they went up from the ship and
the sea;

447 and Eurylochus was not left behind by the
hollow ship —

448 he followed. For he feared my terrible rebuke.

449 Meanwhile, in her house, Circe had bathed
the other companions

450 with kind care, and rubbed them richly with
oil,

451 and thrown about them fleecy cloaks and
tunics,

452 and we found them all feasting well in the
halls.

453 And when the men saw one another, face to
face, and knew each other,

454 they wept and lamented, and the house rang
round them.

455 And she came close beside me and spoke,
shining among goddesses:41

457 ‘No more of this swelling lament now. I know
it myself —

458 all you have suffered on the fish-filled sea,
459 all the harm lawless men have done you on
dry land.
460 Come now: eat your food, and drink your
wine,
461 until you gather back the spirit in your
breasts
462 that was yours when you first left your
fathers' land
463 of rugged Ithaca. Now you are withered,
spiritless,
464 forever brooding on the misery of your
wandering — your hearts
465 never in the feast, for truly you have suffered
much.'
466 So she spoke, and our proud hearts
consented.
467 So there, day after day, for the full round of a
year, 42
468 we sat feasting on meat past counting and
sweet wine.
469 But when the year was out, and the seasons

turned in their wheel,
470 as the months waned and the long days came
round,
471 then my trusted companions called me out,
and said:
472 'You are possessed! It is time to remember
your fatherland —43
473 if it is truly decreed that you be saved, and
come
474 to your high-roofed house and your own
fatherland.'
475 So they spoke, and my proud heart consented.
476 So then all day long till the setting of the sun
477 we sat feasting on meat past counting and
sweet wine;
478 and when the sun went down and the dusk
came on,
479 the men lay down to sleep through the
shadowy halls,
480 but I climbed into the surpassingly beautiful
bed of Circe
481 and clasped her knees in supplication; and the

goddess heard my voice.

482 And lifting my voice I spoke winged words to
her:

483 'Circe — make good now the promise that you
made me,

484 to send me home. My spirit strains for it
already,

485 and my companions' too: they wear my heart
away,

486 mourning around me whenever you are
elsewhere.'

487 So I spoke, and she answered at once, shining
among goddesses:

488 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices:

489 stay no longer in my house against your will.

490 But there is another journey you must
accomplish first: you must go down44

491 to the house of Hades and dread Persephone

492 to consult the ghost of Theban Tiresias,

493 the blind seer, whose mind stands fast:

494 to him, even dead, Persephone has granted

understanding —

495 to him alone the power of thought. The rest
flit past as shadows.45

496 So she spoke, and my heart broke within me,
497 and I wept, sitting there on the bed; my heart
498 had no more will to live and see the light of
the sun.

499 But when I had had my fill of weeping and
writhing,

500 then I answered her with words, and said:

501 'Circe — and who will be pilot on that voyage?

46

502 No man ever yet reached Hades in a black
ship.'

503 So I spoke, and she answered at once, shining
among goddesses:

504 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices:

505 let no lack of a pilot at the ship concern you.

506 Set up the mast, spread the white sails open,

507 and sit: the breath of the North Wind will
carry her.

508 But when in your ship you have crossed the
stream of Ocean,
509 there is a scrub shore there, and the groves of
Persephone —
510 tall black poplars, and willows that shed their
fruit unripened,47
511 Beach the ship there, on Ocean's deep-eddying
edge,
512 and go on yourself into the dank house of
Hades.
513 There into Acheron pour Pyriphlegethon
514 and Cocytus, which is a branch broken off the
water of Styx;
515 and there is a rock, at the meeting-roar of the
two rivers.
516 Draw close to it there, hero, as I command
you,
517 and dig a pit about a cubit's measure this way
and that,48
518 and around it pour a drink-offering to all the
dead —
519 first with milk and honey mingled, then with

sweet wine,

520 the third time with water; and sprinkle white
barley over it.

521 And entreat, over and over, the strengthless
heads of the dead:

522 vow that, come to Ithaca, you will offer in
your halls

523 a barren heifer, your best, and heap the pyre
with good things;

524 and to Tiresias, apart, alone, you will sacrifice
a ram

525 all black, the one that stands out from all your
flocks.

526 Then, when with prayers you have entreated
the glorious tribes of the dead,

527 sacrifice a ram and a black ewe,

528 bending their heads toward Erebus — but
turn yourself away,

529 facing the river's streams. And there will
come, in crowds,

530 the souls of the dead who are gone.

531 Then rouse your companions, and command

them

532 to flay the sheep that lie there slaughtered by
the pitiless bronze,

533 and burn them, and pray to the gods —

534 to mighty Hades and dread Persephone.

535 And you: draw the sharp sword from beside
your thigh

536 and sit, and do not let the strengthless heads
of the dead

537 come near the blood before you question
Tiresias.

538 And quickly then the seer will come, leader of
peoples,

539 and he will tell you the road, and the
measures of your journey,

540 and your homecoming — how you shall go
over the fish-filled sea.'

541 So she spoke; and at once Dawn of the golden
throne came on.

542 She dressed me then in my clothes, a cloak
and a tunic,

543 and she, the nymph, put on a great silver-

shining mantle,⁴⁹

⁵⁴⁴ fine-woven and graceful, and cast about her
waist a belt,

⁵⁴⁵ beautiful, golden, and set a veil on her head
above.

⁵⁴⁶ And I went through the halls and roused my
companions

⁵⁴⁷ with gentle words, standing by each man in
turn:

⁵⁴⁸ ‘No more lying now, drowsing in sweet sleep.

⁵⁴⁹ Let us go: the lady Circe has shown me the
way.’

⁵⁵⁰ So I spoke, and their proud hearts consented.

⁵⁵¹ But not even from there could I bring my
companions off unharmed.⁵⁰

⁵⁵² There was one, Elpenor, the youngest of all —

⁵⁵³ no great fighter in war, no steady mind on
him —

⁵⁵⁴ who had lain down apart from his
companions in the sacred house of Circe,

⁵⁵⁵ heavy with wine, wanting the cool air.

⁵⁵⁶ Hearing the noise and stir of his companions

moving,

557 he leapt up all at once — and forgot, in his
fuddled wits,

558 to come back down again by the long ladder;

559 he fell headlong from the roof, and his neck
560 snapped from the spine; and his soul went
down to Hades.

561 And as my men were setting out I spoke
among them:

562 ‘You think, no doubt, that you are going
home, to your own

563 dear fatherland. But Circe has marked out
another road for us:

564 to the house of Hades and dread Persephone,

565 to consult the ghost of Theban Tiresias.’

566 So I spoke, and their own hearts broke within
them:

567 they sat down right where they were, and
wailed, and tore their hair —

568 but nothing came of all their mourning.

569 And while we walked to the fast ship and the
shore of the sea,

570 grieving, letting the big tears fall,
571 Circe meanwhile had gone down, and beside
the black ship
572 had tethered a ram and a black ewe —
573 slipping past us with ease. Who could see a
god51
574 against the god's will, moving here or there?

Notes

NOTES

1. A floating island ringed by an unbroken bronze wall: Aeolia is a sealed system, drifting free of the world's map. Everything about the place — the wall, the cliff, the closed marriages, the perpetual feast — is circular and self-contained; the visitor who leaves it twice will find the circle closed against him. ↪
2. Six sons married to six daughters, feasting forever beside their parents: the incest is reported without a flicker of censure, as divine-household economics (Zeus and Hera are siblings, after all; Alcinous married his niece). Aeolus' family is the wind-system itself — twelve of them, paired and self-contained, going nowhere. ↪
3. The bag of winds is world folklore (sailors bought wind-knots from witches into the nineteenth century), but Homer's

version is precise: Aeolus is Zeus' appointed "steward of the winds," the bag is the flayed hide of a nine-year ox, and the seal is a silver cord. What the companions mistake for treasure is treasure — the only wealth that matters at sea, a fair wind home, packaged. ↩

4. "We were destroyed by our own folly" — ἀφραδίησιν. The ledger-word again, and this time the entry is collective: the catastrophe requires the crew's envy *and* the captain's secrecy (he never told them what was in the bag) *and* his sleep. The poem lets the blame sit distributed and unresolved. ↩

5. "So near, we could see men tending their fires": ten years of war and ten days of sailing end within sight of the home smoke — and then sleep. The cruelest near-miss in Greek literature, and the poem will do it to him again (he sleeps at Thrinacia while the cattle die, 12.338): both of Odysseus' great disasters begin the moment his vigilance finally fails. The man who cannot delegate (32–33: he held the sheet nine days, "yielding it to no other") is destroyed precisely by the one nap his body forced on him. ↩

6. The envy speech — the crew's grievance quoted in full, and it is *reasonable*: same war, same road, empty hands, while the captain collects gifts at every port. The poem gives the mutineers a real economics before it gives them their catastrophe; the "evil counsel" (46) is not stupidity but distributive resentment, the plunder-sharing theme (9.42, 549) turned inside out. ↩

7. The suicide deliberation, weighed in one breath: drown now, or "endure in silence and stay among the living." Then the

plainest sentence in the poem: “I endured, and I stayed.” The epithet πολύτλας — much-enduring — is earned in exactly these two verbs, with his head covered, saying nothing. ↩

8. Aeolus’ expulsion is the theology of hospitality’s limit: “It is against all right (θέμις) for me to harbor... a man the blessed gods detest.” A returned gift is proof of divine hatred; the second visit that xenia cannot cover. He is not wrong — Poseidon’s curse is on the guest — and he is not kind: the poem lets both stand. Note that the friendly month-long host and the shrieking expeller are the same man; the difference is one piece of evidence. ↩
9. Telepylus of the Laestrygonians, “where herdsman hails herdsman” — the night-shepherd coming in as the day-shepherd goes out, “so close together are the paths of night and day,” where a sleepless man could earn double wages. Ancients and moderns alike have read the midnight sun of the far north into these lines; whatever the source, the poem uses compressed daylight to signal the world’s rim — and the double wage is a laborer’s-eye view of the marvel: more light means more work. ↩
10. The harbor is described as perfection — sheer shelter, narrow mouth, “a white calm” — and it is a killing-jar. Every feature that makes it safe from waves makes it fatal under thrown stones: no room to scatter, no swell to ride out, one narrow exit. The poem builds the trap out of the very vocabulary of refuge (contrast the goat island’s genuinely safe harbor, 9.136–139). ↩

11. "I alone held my black ship outside." No reason is given — suspicion, habit, the lookout's instinct — and the silence is the point: this unexplained mooring decision is the entire difference between one surviving ship and eleven destroyed. The poem lets the captain's caution stand as pure practice, not announced wisdom; he does not even claim credit for it in the telling. ↩
12. The approach runs the standard arrival sequence — road, girl drawing water at a named spring, directions to the king's house — the exact template that on Scheria (Athena with her pitcher, 7.19ff.) led to welcome. Point-for-point the same protocol, ending in the host eating the guest: the poem re-runs its own hospitality scene as a horror film. ↩
13. "Not like men, but like the Giants" — the third appearance of the Giants at the world's edges: the Phaeacians and Cyclopes are named their kin (7.205–206), and the Laestrygonians are merely *likened* to them here. The far world keeps monstrous company, and the Phaeacians are its one civilized branch. ↩
14. "Spearing them like fish, they carried home their loathsome meal." Eleven ships' companies — the poem's greatest single loss, greater than everything Poseidon ever does — dispatched in one line with a fishing simile. The economy is deliberate: the horror is industrial, a harvest. After the refrain at 133–134, "we" means one ship's company, and every later "we" in the Odyssey is the survivors of this harbor. ↩
15. The refrain returns exactly as after the Cicones — but now it closes the loss of the fleet. The identical formula for six men

and for five hundred: grief in this poem is a liturgy, not an arithmetic. ↩

16. Circe: “dread goddess with a mortal’s voice” (αὐδήεσσα — the same word that marked Ino, 5.334): a divinity who speaks human speech, which is precisely her danger. Daughter of Helios the all-seeing, sister of Aeetes (keeper of the Golden Fleece — one line of genealogy quietly hooks the Odyssey into the Argonaut saga). Her island is where the sun’s family lodges at the world’s eastern rim. ↩
17. The deliberation runs captain-fashion: dinner for the crew first, reconnaissance second. After the Laestrygonian harbor, his procedure has visibly hardened — feed them, scout in force, split the company by lot. The Circe episode opens as a study in learned command. ↩
18. The stag “some god” sends: providence as protein. The scene is pure hunter’s vignette — the beast heavy with the sun’s heat coming down to drink, the spine-shot, the plaited withy rope, the carry across the neck with the spear for a staff — and its function is morale: the captain who cannot yet free anyone can at least feed everyone. His twice-repeated wonder (“he was a very great beast,” 171, 180) is a hunter’s honest pride, kept intact in the retelling. ↩
19. “We do not know where the dark is, or where the dawn”: total loss of orientation — east and west themselves gone. For a sailor this is annihilation: no course can exist. And from the master of devices, the bleakest sentence he speaks in the poem: “whether any device (μήτις) is left us. I do not believe

there is.” The mētis-hero declaring mētis bankrupt — the episode’s true low point, before any magic happens. ↩

20. “Nothing came of all their mourning” — the line will recur verbatim at 568. Twice in one book the poem lets grief run and then audits it: zero. Not contempt — the weeping is always allowed first — but the survivor’s bookkeeping. ↩
21. Eurylochus enters: leader of the second search party, kinsman by marriage (441), and the poem’s licensed dissenter. The lots are shaken in a helmet — command decisions by fair chance once again — and his lot “jumped out”: the man who will refuse the house is chosen by luck to find it. ↩
22. The wolves and lions “fawning like dogs around their master coming from a feast” — the most unsettling tameness in Homer. The simile’s content is domestic comfort (the master, the treats, the wagging); the reality is predators chemically stripped of themselves. Drugged docility wearing the image of home — Circe’s whole island in one picture. ↩
23. Circe at her great loom, singing — the identical posture in which Hermes found Calypso (5.61–62): the divine woman weaving and singing alone at the world’s edge. The loom is the island goddess’s signature — and weaving is this poem’s other name for plotting. ↩
24. The kykeon — Pramnian wine, grated cheese, barley, pale honey — is a real archaic posset (Nestor drinks nearly the identical mixture in *Iliad* 11.624ff.). The horror is served in comfort food: the drug rides in on the taste of home, and its stated purpose is the lotus-purpose — “to make them wholly forget their fathers’ land.” ↩

25. “But their minds stayed steady, exactly as before” — νοῦς
ἔμπεδος: the transformation’s exquisite cruelty. Pig body,
human mind, weeping in the sty over acorns. Circe’s magic
inverts the lotus exactly: the lotus left the body free and
dissolved the will; the wand keeps the will intact inside a body
that cannot use it. Between them the two islands map the
poem’s whole anatomy of the self. ↩
26. Eurylochus’ report repeats the narrative almost line for line —
Homeric messenger-convention, but with one adjustment: “I
stayed behind, suspecting a snare” becomes his signature. He
is the man who is right about danger and wrong about
everything to do in its presence: correct to suspect, correct to
survive — and paralyzed, speechless, and finally mutinous on
the strength of it. ↩
27. “But I am going. Hard necessity is on me.” — κρατερὴ δέ μοι
ἔπλετ’ ἀνάγκη. No plan exists yet; the sword and bow he slings
on are props against sorcery. The captain’s necessity is not
strategy but obligation: twenty-two men in a sty. The rescue
begins as pure duty walking uphill. ↩
28. Hermes as a youth “with his first down on his lip, in the
loveliest season of youth” — the god’s favorite mortal disguise
(so he meets Priam in *Iliad* 24), met on a path here exactly as
his Olympian errands frame the poem (Books 1, 5). His speech
does something unique in the apologoi: it scripts the future in
detail — potion, wand, sword-rush, bed, oath — and the scene
then executes the script beat for beat. Odysseus survives Aeaea
the way an actor survives a play: by knowing the lines in
advance. ↩

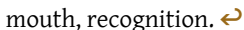
29. “Do not refuse the bed of the goddess” — the instruction no other epic would give its hero as tactical advice, complete with the safeguard oath and the stated risk: “lest she strip you naked and make you a coward, an unmanned thing” (κακὸν καὶ ἀνὴρ νοσῶν — the emasculation fear said straight out). Divine sex here is an instrument of policy with a liability clause. The oath-formula is Calypso’s from 5.178–179, verbatim — but repurposed: there it guarded a departure plan against a trap; only here is the contract language brought to a goddess’s bed.



30. Moly: black at the root, flower like milk, “hard for mortal men to dig — but the gods have power to do all things.” The most famous plant in Western literature, and the poem never shows it working: no brandishing, no antidote-drinking dramatized — Circe’s drug simply fails (318). But Hermes is explicit about the cause: the good drug he gives “will not allow” her enchantment (291–292) — counter-magic that operates invisibly, its working as hidden as its name. Identifications (snowdrop? rue?) have been guessed at for millennia; “the gods call it” moly — its true name is not in mortal vocabulary at all.



31. Beaten, Circe reaches for the poem’s standard identity-question — “What man are you, and from where? Where are your city and your parents?” (=1.170) — and then answers it herself. The interrogation formula that every host asks becomes, in her mouth, recognition.



32. “Surely you are Odysseus — the man of many turnings” — πολύτροπος. The proem’s first epithet for its hero (1.1), used *nowhere else in the poem except these two places*. The word the

poet chose to open the *Odyssey* is spoken inside it only once — by the witch, at the moment her drugs fail — as if only she and the Muse know his true name-tag. Hermes had foretold him to her: the trap and the marriage of minds were both scheduled.



33. He answers her invitation with the oath-demand he once made to Calypso, verbatim (5.178–179 = 10.343–344) — same words, new work: there the oath safeguarded his passage home; only here does it stand guard over a bed. The hero's consistency across islands is itself formulaic — the poem's way of saying this is *procedure*, not romance. ↪
34. “Then I mounted the surpassingly beautiful bed of Circe.” Consent, stated plainly, after terms. The poem never equates Aeaea with Ogygia: with Calypso he wept daily on the shore, “unwilling man by willing goddess” (5.155); here he bargains, beds, and stays a year without a recorded tear — until the crew intervenes. The difference is not virtue but liberty: Circe's door, after the oath, is open. ↪
35. Circe's four handmaids are daughters “of the springs and the groves and the sacred rivers”: nymphs of wild water doing housework — the wilderness itself domesticated into table-service, exactly as the wolves are domesticated into dogs. On Aeaea nature is staff. ↪
36. The refusal of food until the companions are freed — from the man who preached the tyranny of the belly at 7.215ff. The one force in the poem that outranks the γαστήρ is φιλότις; he will not eat in front of the sty. Circe yields, and the counter-drug scene (388–396) is the book's hinge from horror to healing. ↪

37. Restored, they come back “younger... more beautiful, and taller”: Circe’s magic overshoots mere reversal into rejuvenation. The gift previews the year of ease to come — Aeaea, once its terms are settled, is a spa. The weeping reunion that follows (397–399) moves even the goddess: “the house rang terribly” is the same phrase-world as grief’s other outbreaks, and she pities what she caused. ↩
38. The calves simile: penned calves breaking loose to frisk around the returning herd, “lowing without pause” — homecoming in miniature, complete with the poem’s own gloss: “as if they had come to their fatherland.” Every joy in the *Odyssey* is measured on the nostos-scale; the crew’s relief at seeing one man alive registers as a rehearsal of Ithaca. ↩
39. Eurylochus’ mutiny speech reaches its climax in the poem’s most loaded word: our companions died at the Cyclops’ yard “by that man’s ἀτασθαλίῃσιν” — *recklessness*, the poem’s term for the crew’s own fatal folly (1.7) and Zeus’ term for mortal self-destruction (1.34). Hurling at the captain by his own kinsman, and the poem lets the counter-indictment stand unanswered: from inside the crew, the six dead in the cave were the price of one man’s curiosity. Both ledgers — the poem’s and Eurylochus’ — remain open to the end. ↩
40. The captain’s response to the accusation is nearly a beheading — of a close kinsman by marriage — checked only by the crew’s plea. The poem does not flinch from what command has become by mid-voyage: the sword-reflex against internal dissent, one honeyed-word intervention away from kin-murder. That the accusation had truth in it is exactly what made the sword move. ↩

41. Here the translation follows Murray's text, which omits the traditional line 456 (a variant of the "she came close and spoke" formula); the line-numbering accordingly steps from 455 to 457, as in the Greek. ↩
42. A year, in three lines. The man who refused an immortal's eternity loses twelve months to a comfortable enchantress without noticing — no spell alleged, just meat, sweet wine, and a beautiful bed. Comfort is the drug that needs no drug: the lotus in its most respectable form. ↩
43. "You are possessed! It is time to remember your fatherland." The great role-reversal: the crew de-lotuses the captain. The men he dragged weeping from the lotus and bound under the benches (9.98–99) now perform the same rescue on him, with a word — δαιμόνιε, "you are possessed" — that treats his contentment as the seizure it is. The poem's fairness to the companions peaks here: they are the keepers of the nostos this once, and he consents with the same formula he used for their good advice. ↩
44. "You must go down to the house of Hades" — the sentence that breaks him flat on the bed, wishing not to live. The road home runs through the country no black ship has ever reached; the homecoming must first pass through death. Structurally this is the poem's center of gravity: Circe, keeper of the eastern threshold, sets the itinerary that makes Book 11 the pivot of the entire epic. ↩
45. Tiresias "whose mind stands fast... to him alone the power of thought. The rest flit past as shadows." Homeric death-psychology in two lines: the dead lose νόος, coherent mind,

and become flittering shades; Persephone's grant to Tiresias is the single exemption. This is the metaphysics the whole Nekyia will run on — held with a poet's looseness: Elpenor talks before any blood is poured, and the rite's drink restores recognition and memory more than bare speech. ↩

46. The sailor's objection to metaphysics: fine — *who pilots?* “No man ever yet reached Hades in a black ship.” Even at the threshold of the underworld, Odysseus' first question is navigational. Circe's answer keeps the register: set the mast, sit down, the North Wind does it. The land of the dead has a sailing direction: downwind, all the way. ↩
47. Persephone's groves: black poplars and “willows that shed their fruit unripened” — trees of barrenness for the country of the unfulfilled dead. The catalogue of underworld rivers (Pyriphlegethon “fire-blazing,” Cocytus “wailing,” branch of Styx “the hateful”) flows into Acheron by a rock at “the meeting-roar”: Greek eschatology's entire river-map, given as pilotage. ↩
48. The necromantic rite (517–540) is the oldest full necromancy in Greek literature, and it is *ritual*, not magic: a cubit-square pit, triple libation (honeyed milk, wine, water), white barley, vows of future sacrifice, black victims bled with heads bent toward Erebus, the officiant's face averted, and the drawn sword rationing the blood to which the strengthless dead will crowd. Every detail was studied by ancient religion and echoed by every later katabasis. Circe delivers it as she delivered the sailing directions: precisely, and without comment. ↩

49. Circe dresses in Calypso's exact wardrobe — the great silver-shining mantle, golden belt, veil (= 5.230–232, line for line). The two island goddesses share a formulaic dressing-scene as they share an oath-scene: the poem builds them as variations on one figure — and the differences (consent, release, help freely given) stand out the sharper against the identical clothes. ↩
50. Elpenor: “the youngest of all — no great fighter in war, no steady mind on him.” Drunk, he slept on the cool roof; woke at the bustle; forgot the ladder; broke his neck. The obituary is three understatements and a fall — the least heroic death in epic, refused none of the poem's care. His unburied ghost will be the first to meet Odysseus in Hades (11.51ff.), before Tiresias, before his own mother: the poem's ethics of burial made plot. On the island of enchantments, the killer is wine and a ladder. ↩
51. The book closes on a small theological shiver: Circe has passed them invisibly to tether the black victims at the ship — “Who could see a god against the god's will, moving here or there?” The narrating Odysseus generalizes from his own tale: divinity is seen only by consent (Athena will state the doctrine at 16.161). It is the apologoi's quiet epistemology — the gods move through these stories exactly as visibly as they choose — offered as a sailor's shrug on the way to the land of the dead. ↩

Odyssey — Book 11

*The dead: Tiresias' prophecy, Anticleia, the heroines,
Agamemnon, Achilles, Ajax.*

- 1 And when we had come down to the ship and the sea,
- 2 first of all we hauled the ship down to the bright salt water,
- 3 and set the mast and the sails in the black ship,
- 4 and took the sheep and put them aboard, and ourselves
- 5 went aboard grieving, letting the big tears fall.
- 6 And for us, behind the dark-blue-prowed ship,
- 7 a following wind that filled the sail, a good companion,
- 8 was sent by Circe of the lovely braids, dread goddess with a mortal's voice.
- 9 So when we had seen to the tackle through the ship,
- 10 we sat, and the wind and the steersman held

her on course.

11 All day long her sail was stretched as she
crossed the water;

12 and the sun went down, and all the ways grew
dark.¹

13 She came to the limits of deep-flowing Ocean.

14 There is the land and city of the Cimmerian
men,²

15 shrouded in mist and cloud: never does the
shining

16 sun look down on them with his rays,

17 not when he climbs toward the starry heaven,

18 not when he turns back from heaven to earth,

19 but deadly night is stretched over wretched
mortals.

20 Coming there we beached the ship, and took
out the sheep,

21 and walked along the stream of Ocean

22 until we came to the place that Circe had
appointed.

23 There Perimedes and Eurylochos held the
victims,³

24 and I drew the sharp sword from beside my
thigh
25 and dug a pit about a cubit's measure this way
and that,
26 and around it I poured a drink-offering to all
the dead —
27 first with milk and honey mingled, then with
sweet wine,
28 the third time with water; and I sprinkled
white barley over it.
29 And I entreated, over and over, the
strengthless heads of the dead:
30 vowing that, come to Ithaca, I would offer in
my halls
31 a barren heifer, my best, and heap the pyre
with good things;
32 and to Tiresias, apart, alone, I would sacrifice a
ram
33 all black, the one that stands out from all our
flocks.
34 And when with vows and prayers I had
entreated them,

35 the tribes of the dead, I took the sheep and cut
their throats
36 over the pit, and the dark-clouded blood ran;
and they gathered,
37 the souls of the dead who are gone, up out of
Erebus:⁴
38 brides, and unwed youths, and old men worn
by long suffering,
39 and tender girls with the fresh grief on their
hearts,
40 and many men gashed by the bronze-tipped
spears,
41 men killed in war, in armor caked with their
blood.
42 In crowds from every side they came flocking
about the pit
43 with a sound that had no earthly likeness; and
the pale terror took me.
44 Then I roused my companions, and
commanded them
45 to flay the sheep that lay there slaughtered by
the pitiless bronze,

46 and burn them, and pray to the gods —
47 to mighty Hades and dread Persephone;
48 and I myself, drawing the sharp sword from
beside my thigh,
49 sat there, and would not let the strengthless
heads of the dead
50 come near the blood before I had questioned
Tiresias.
51 First came the soul of my companion Elpenor,5
52 for he was not yet buried under the wide-
wayed earth:
53 we had left his body behind in Circe's hall,
54 unwept and unburied, since another task was
driving us.
55 I wept to see him, and my heart pitied him,
56 and lifting my voice I spoke winged words to
him:
57 'Elpenor — how did you come here, under the
misty dark?
58 You have outstripped me — on foot, and I in
my black ship.'6
59 So I spoke, and he groaned aloud, and

answered:

60 ‘Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices,

61 the evil doom of a god blinded me — that, and
wine past measure.⁷

62 Lying down to sleep in Circe’s hall, I never
thought

63 to come back down again by the long ladder;

64 I fell headlong from the roof, and my neck

65 snapped from the spine; and my soul came
down to Hades.

66 Now I beg you — by those left behind, those
not here beside us:

67 by your wife; by your father, who reared you
when you were small;

68 by Telemachus, whom you left an only child in
your halls.

69 For I know that when you go from here, from
the house of Hades,

70 you will put in again with your well-made ship
at the island of Aeaea:

71 there, my lord, I charge you: remember me.

72 Do not go on and leave me behind you unwept,
unburied,⁸

73 turning away — lest I become a cause of gods'
wrath against you —

74 but burn me with all the armor that is mine,

75 and heap me a mound on the shore of the gray
salt sea:

76 an unlucky man's marker, for men to come to
learn of.

77 Accomplish this for me — and fix upon the
mound the oar⁹

78 I rowed with when I lived, when I was among
my companions.'

79 So he spoke, and I answered him and said:

80 'All this, poor luckless man, I will accomplish
and do.'

81 So the two of us sat trading grim words,

82 I on one side, holding my sword over the
blood,

83 and across from me the phantom of my
companion, talking on.

84 Then came the soul of my dead mother,¹⁰

85 Anticleia, daughter of great-hearted Autolycus,
86 whom I had left alive when I went to holy
Ilium.

87 I wept to see her, and my heart pitied her;
88 but even so, for all my thick grief, I would not
let her

89 come near the blood before I had questioned
Tiresias.

90 Then came the soul of Theban Tiresias,
91 holding a golden scepter; and he knew me, and
spoke:¹¹

92 ‘Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices —

93 what now, unlucky man? Why have you left the
light of the sun

94 and come to see the dead, and this place
without joy?

95 Draw back from the pit; hold off your sharp
sword,

96 so that I may drink of the blood, and tell you
the unerring truth.’

97 So he spoke, and I stepped back, and drove the

silver-studded sword

98 home in its sheath. And when he had drunk
the dark blood,

99 then at last the blameless seer addressed me:

100 'It is honey-sweet homecoming you seek,
shining Odysseus,

101 and a god will make it grim for you. For I do
not think

102 the shaker of earth will fail to see you — the
grudge is set in his heart,

103 raging because you blinded his dear son.

104 Yet even so, though you suffer evils, you may
still come home,

105 if you are willing to hold hard your own heart
and your companions',

106 from the hour when you first bring your well-
made ship

107 in to the island Thrinacia, escaping the violet
sea,

108 and find at pasture there the cattle and the
strong flocks

109 of Helios, who sees all things and hears all

things.¹²

¹¹⁰ If you leave them unharmed, and keep your
mind on homecoming,

¹¹¹ then you may yet reach Ithaca, though you
suffer evils.

¹¹² But if you harm them, then I foretell
destruction

¹¹³ for ship and companions; and even if you
yourself escape,

¹¹⁴ late you will come, and in evil case, all
companions lost,¹³

¹¹⁵ on another man's ship; and you will find
trouble in your house —

¹¹⁶ overweening men, who eat away your living,

¹¹⁷ courting your godlike wife and offering bride-
gifts.

¹¹⁸ Yet, truly, you will come and repay their
violence.

¹¹⁹ And when you have killed the suitors in your
halls,

¹²⁰ whether by guile or in the open, with the
sharp bronze,

121 then go on a journey, taking a well-shaped
oar,14

122 until you come to men who know nothing of
the sea,

123 men who eat no food that is mixed with salt,

124 who know nothing of red-cheeked ships,

125 nothing of well-shaped oars, which are wings
for ships.

126 And I will tell you a sign, unmistakable: it will
not escape you.

127 When another traveler, meeting you on the
road,

128 says you carry a winnowing-fan on your
shining shoulder,15

129 then and there fix the well-shaped oar in the
earth

130 and offer fine victims to the lord Poseidon —

131 a ram, a bull, and a boar that has mounted
sows —

132 and turn away home, and offer holy
hecatombs

133 to the deathless gods who hold wide heaven,

134 to all of them, each in order. And death will
come to you

135 from the sea, so gentle a death, and take
you16

136 worn down under sleek old age; and around
you the peoples

137 will be prosperous. This I tell you is unerring
truth.'

138 So he spoke, and I answered him and said:

139 'Tiresias — all that, no doubt, the gods
themselves have spun.17

140 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly.

141 I see here the soul of my dead mother:

142 she sits in silence near the blood, and cannot
bring herself

143 to look her own son in the face, or speak to
him.

144 Tell me, lord: how may she know me for the
man I am?'

145 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:

146 'An easy word I will tell you, and set it in your
mind.

147 Whomever of the dead who are gone you
allow
148 to come near the blood, that one will speak
you truth;
149 whomever you begrudge it, that one will draw
back and go.’
150 So speaking, the soul of the lord Tiresias went
back
151 into the house of Hades, when he had told out
the decrees of fate.
152 But I stayed rooted where I was until my
mother
153 came and drank the dark-clouded blood. And
at once she knew me,
154 and wailing she spoke winged words to me:
155 ‘My child — how did you come here, under the
misty dark,
156 alive? Hard it is for the living to look on all
this:
157 for between lie great rivers, and terrible
waters —
158 Ocean first of all, which there is no crossing

on foot,

159 never, unless a man has a well-made ship.

160 Are you only now come wandering here from
Troy —

161 after all this time — with ship and
companions? Have you not yet

162 been to Ithaca — not seen your wife in your
own halls?’

163 So she spoke, and I answered her and said:

164 ‘Mother, need brought me down to Hades:

165 to consult the soul of Theban Tiresias.

166 For not yet have I come near Achaea — not yet

167 set foot on our own land; I have wandered
without pause, in misery,

168 since the day I first followed noble
Agamemnon

169 toward Ilium of the fine horses, to fight the
Trojans.

170 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

171 what doom of death, that lays men low,
mastered you? **18**

172 A long illness? Or did Artemis the arrow-

pourer

173 come with her gentle arrows, and kill you?

174 And tell me of my father, and the son I left
behind:

175 does my honor still rest safe with them, or
does some other

176 man hold it now — do they say I will come
home no more?

177 And tell me the mind and purpose of my
wedded wife:

178 does she stay by the boy and keep all things
safe?

179 Or has the best man of the Achaeans married
her already?’

180 So I spoke, and at once my honored mother
answered:

181 ‘Oh yes — she stays, and more: with an
enduring heart19

182 she is there in your halls; and always in
misery

183 her nights waste away, and her days, in tears.

184 Your fine honor no man holds yet: at his ease

185 Telemachus farms the estates unchallenged,
and feasts
186 at the equal banquets it is fitting a lawgiving
man should tend:
187 for all men issue him the summons. But your
father stays out there
188 on the farm, and never comes down to the
city. Bedding
189 he has none — no bedstead, no cloaks, no
shining blankets:
190 through the winter he sleeps where the slaves
do, in the house,
191 in the ashes by the fire, and puts poor clothing
on his skin;
192 but when summer comes, and the heavy
autumn,
193 then anywhere along the rise of his vineyard
plot
194 a bed of fallen leaves is thrown on the ground
for him,
195 and there he lies grieving, and the sorrow
grows great in his heart,

196 aching for your homecoming; and hard old
age comes on him.20

197 And so it was with me: so I too died and met
my doom.

198 Not in the halls did the keen-eyed arrow-
pourer

199 come with her gentle arrows and kill me;

200 no illness fell upon me, of the kind that most
often

201 draws the life from the limbs in hateful
wasting:

202 no — it was longing for you, your counsels,
shining Odysseus,

203 your gentle-heartedness, that robbed me of
honey-sweet life.'21

204 So she spoke; and I, my mind stirred, longed

205 to take the soul of my dead mother in my
arms.

206 Three times I started toward her, and my
heart bade me hold her;22

207 three times, out of my hands, like a shadow or
a dream

208 she flew. And the grief grew sharper in my
heart each time,
209 and lifting my voice I spoke winged words to
her:
210 ‘Mother — why will you not stay for me, when
I long to hold you,
211 so that even here in Hades, throwing our arms
around each other,
212 the two of us might take our fill of icy
mourning?
213 Or is this a phantom queenly Persephone
214 has sent me, so that I may weep and groan the
more?’
215 So I spoke, and at once my honored mother
answered:
216 ‘Ah me, my child, luckless beyond all mortal
men —
217 in no way does Persephone, the daughter of
Zeus, deceive you:
218 this is the settled way of mortals, when one
dies.23
219 The sinews no longer hold the flesh and bones

together:

220 all that, the strong fury of the blazing fire

221 breaks down, as soon as the life has left the
white bones,

222 and the soul flits away like a dream, and
hovers.

223 But press on toward the light, as fast as you
can. And mark

224 all these things — to tell them to your wife
hereafter.’**24**

225 So the two of us traded words. And then the
women

226 came — for queenly Persephone sent them on
—**25**

227 all who had been the wives and daughters of
the great.

228 They came flocking in crowds around the
dark blood,

229 and I considered how I might question each in
turn.

230 And this, as I turned it over, seemed to me the
best plan:

231 drawing the long-edged sword from beside
my thick thigh,
232 I would not let them drink the dark blood all
together.
233 So they came up one by one, in file, and each
declared
234 her lineage; and I questioned them all.
235 There the first I saw was Tyro, born of a noble
father,²⁶
236 who said she was the child of blameless
Salmoneus,
237 and called herself the wife of Cretheus,
Aeolus' son.
238 She fell in love with a river — divine Enipeus,
239 far the most beautiful of rivers flowing on the
earth —
240 and she would haunt Enipeus' beautiful
streams.
241 And the earth-holder, the shaker of earth,
took the river's likeness
242 and lay beside her at the mouths of the
eddy water;

243 and a dark-gleaming wave stood up around
them, mountain-high,
244 arched over, and hid the god and the mortal
woman.
245 He loosed the girdle of her maidenhood, and
poured sleep over her.
246 And when the god had finished the works of
love,
247 he clamped a hand on hers, and spoke a word,
and named her:
248 'Rejoice in this love, woman. As the year turns
round
249 you will bear glorious children — for the beds
of the immortals
250 are not fruitless. Tend them, and rear them.
251 Now go home, and hold your peace, and name
no name.
252 But know it: I am Poseidon, shaker of the
earth.'
253 So speaking he plunged under the surging
sea.
254 And she conceived, and bore Pelias and

Neleus,

255 who both grew to be strong servants of great
Zeus;

256 Pelias lived in wide-dancing-grounded Iolcus,

257 rich in flocks, and Neleus in sandy Pylos.

258 And her other sons this queen among women
bore to Cretheus:

259 Aeson, and Pheres, and Amythaon the
chariot-fighter.

260 After her I saw Antiope, Asopus' daughter,

261 who could boast she had slept in the very
arms of Zeus,

262 and she bore two sons, Amphion and Zethus,

263 who first founded the seat of seven-gated
Thebes27

264 and walled it round — for without walls they
could not

265 live in wide-dancing-grounded Thebes, strong
though they were.

266 After her I saw Alcmene, Amphitryon's wife,

267 who bore Heracles, the lion-hearted, bold in
the fight,

268 after she lay mingled in the arms of great
Zeus;
269 and Megara, daughter of high-spirited Creon,
270 whom Amphitryon's son held as wife — the
man whose strength never wore.
271 And I saw the mother of Oedipus, beautiful
Epicaste,²⁸
272 who did a monstrous thing in the ignorance
of her mind,
273 marrying her own son; and he, who had killed
his father,
274 married her; and the gods made it known
among men at once.
275 Yet he ruled on over the Cadmeians in lovely
Thebes,
276 suffering pains, through the gods' deadly
designs;
277 and she went down to the house of Hades,
strong warden of the gate,
278 fastening a noose to hang sheer from the high
roof-beam,
279 gripped by her anguish — and left behind for

him the pains

280 past counting that a mother's Furies bring to
pass.

281 And I saw Chloris, beautiful past telling,
whom Neleus once

282 married for her beauty, bringing bride-gifts
past number:

283 youngest daughter of Amphion, Iasus' son,

284 who once ruled in strength in Minyan
Orchomenus.

285 She was queen of Pylos, and bore him shining
children:

286 Nestor, and Chromius, and lordly
Periclymenus,

287 and after them she bore that wonder of
mortals, strong Pero, 29

288 whom all the neighboring men were courting;
but Neleus

289 would give her to no man who could not drive
off

290 the crook-horned, broad-browed cattle of
mighty Iphicles

291 out of Phylace — a dangerous herd. Only the
blameless seer
292 undertook to drive them; and the hard doom
of a god bound him fast,
293 the cruel bonds, and the herdsmen of the
wild.
294 But when at last the months and the days
were coming to fulfillment,
295 as the year rolled round and the seasons came
again,
296 then at last mighty Iphicles set him free,
297 when he had told out all the decrees of fate.
And the design of Zeus was accomplished.
298 And I saw Leda, wife of Tyndareus,
299 who bore to Tyndareus two strong-hearted
sons:
300 Castor the horse-breaker, and Polydeuces
good with his fists.
301 These two the life-giving earth holds — both
of them living:30
302 even under the earth they have honor from
Zeus,

303 and live turn about, one day each in turn,
304 and each in turn are dead. They have won
honor equal to the gods’.

305 After her I saw Iphimedeia, wife of Aloeus,
306 who could say that she had lain with
Poseidon,
307 and she bore two sons — but short-lived they
proved —
308 godlike Otus, and far-famed Ephialtes:31
309 the tallest men the grain-giving earth ever
nourished,
310 and far the most beautiful, after famous
Orion.

311 At nine years old they measured nine cubits
312 across, and stood nine fathoms high;
313 and they threatened the very immortals — to
carry
314 the din of furious war up into Olympus.

315 Ossa they strained to pile on Olympus, and on
Ossa
316 Pelion of the shivering leaves, to make heaven
scalable.

317 And they would have accomplished it, had
they reached the measure of manhood;
318 but the son of Zeus, whom fair-haired Leto
bore, destroyed them
319 both, before the down had bloomed beneath
their temples
320 and thickened on their chins in the flower of
a young beard.
321 And Phaedra I saw, and Procris, and beautiful
Ariadne, 32
322 the daughter of Minos the deadly-minded,
whom Theseus once
323 carried off from Crete, making for the hill of
holy
324 Athens — and had no joy of her: Artemis
killed her first,
325 on sea-ringed Dia, on the testimony of
Dionysus.
326 And Maera I saw, and Clymene, and hateful
Eriphyle, 33
327 who took precious gold as the price of her
own husband.

328 But all of them I could not tell through or
name —

329 all the wives and daughters of heroes I saw
there:

330 the divine night would waste away first. No —
it is the hour

331 for sleep, whether I go down to the fast ship
and the crew

332 or stay here. My sending rests with the gods,
and with you.”

333 So he spoke; and they were all hushed in
silence, 34

334 held fast under the spell, through the
shadowy halls.

335 And white-armed Arete began to speak
among them:

336 “Phaeacians — how does this man appear to
you now:

337 his looks, his stature, the balanced mind
within?

338 And he is my guest — though each of you
shares the honor.

339 Do not hurry, then, to send him off, and do
not cut short
340 your gifts to one so needy: for many are the
treasures
341 lying in your halls by the gods' good will."
342 And among them spoke the old hero
Echeneus,
343 the man elder-born beyond the other
Phaeacians:
344 "Friends — not wide of the mark, not short of
our own thought,
345 are the words of our watchful-minded queen.
Heed them.
346 But on Alcinous here depend both word and
deed."
347 Then Alcinous answered him in turn, and
said:
348 "This word shall stand — so surely as I
349 live and rule the oar-loving Phaeacians.
350 Let the guest endure it, then, for all his
hunger for homecoming:
351 let him stay till tomorrow, until I make our

whole

352 gift complete. His sending shall be the men's
concern —

353 all men's, and mine above all: for mine is the
power in this land.35

354 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

355 "Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all
peoples,

356 if you bade me stay here even for a year

357 and readied my sending, and gave me shining
gifts,

358 even that I would choose; and it would profit
me far more36

359 to come to my own dear country with a fuller
hand:

360 so should I be more honored, and more dear,
to all

361 the men who saw me sailing home to Ithaca."

362 Then Alcinous answered him in turn, and
said:

363 "Odysseus — looking at you, we cannot liken

you

364 to a cheat or a thief — the kind the black
earth breeds37

365 in such crops, scattered everywhere:

366 men who build lies out of what no eye could
ever test.

367 There is a shape upon your words, and a noble
mind within them,

368 and you have told your tale with knowledge,
like a singer —38

369 the grim sorrows of all the Argives, and your
own.

370 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

371 did you see any of your godlike companions,
who went

372 to Ilium with you, and met their doom there?

373 This night is long — marvelously long. It is
not yet time

374 to sleep in the hall. Tell me the deeds of
wonder.

375 I could hold out until the shining dawn, if
only you

376 could bear, here in the hall, to tell me your sorrows.”

377 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:

378 “Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all peoples —

379 there is an hour for many tales, and an hour for sleep.

380 But if you long to listen still, I would not

381 grudge you the telling of things more pitiful still:

382 the sorrows of my companions, who perished afterward —

383 who slipped out of the Trojans’ battle-cry and its groaning

384 only to die on the homeward way, by an evil woman’s will.39

385 Now when holy Persephone had scattered

386 the women’s souls this way and that,

387 there came the soul of Agamemnon, Atreus’ son,

388 grieving; and around him others were

gathered — all who

389 died with him in the house of Aegisthus, and
met their doom.

390 He knew me at once, when he had drunk the
dark blood,

391 and he wept, shrill and loud, letting the big
tears fall,

392 stretching his hands toward me, straining to
reach me —

393 but there was no strength grounded in him
now, no force40

394 such as once filled his supple limbs.

395 I wept to see him, and my heart pitied him,

396 and lifting my voice I spoke winged words to
him:

397 ‘Most glorious son of Atreus, Agamemnon,
lord of men —

398 what doom of death, that lays men low,
mastered you?

399 Did Poseidon master you in your ships,

400 rousing the wretched blast of hard winds?

401 Or did hostile men cut you down on dry land

402 as you carved away their cattle and their fine
flocks of sheep,

403 or fought them for their city and their
women?’

404 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:

405 ‘Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices:

406 Poseidon did not master me in my ships,

407 rousing the wretched blast of hard winds,

408 and hostile men did not cut me down on dry
land.

409 Aegisthus built my death and my doom,

410 and killed me — with my cursed wife — after
calling me to his house

411 and feasting me: as a man cuts down an ox at
the manger.41

412 So I died the most pitiable of deaths; and
around me my other

413 companions were killed without pause, like
white-tusked

414 swine slaughtered in the house of a rich and
powerful man

415 for a wedding, a club-feast, or a swelling
banquet.42

416 You have stood in the killing of many men
before now,

417 cut down singly, or in the crush of battle —

418 but you would have grieved at heart above all
to see that sight:

419 how around the wine-bowl and the loaded
tables

420 we lay in the hall, and the whole floor
steamed with blood.

421 And the most pitiful voice I heard was Priam's
daughter's —

422 Cassandra's, whom Clytemnestra of the
crooked counsels killed43

423 over my body; and I, dying, tried to raise my
hands

424 and beat them down on the sword-blade —
and she, the bitch-faced,

425 turned her back: she could not bring herself,
though I was going down to Hades,

426 to draw my eyelids shut with her hands, or

close my mouth.⁴⁴

⁴²⁷ So true it is that nothing is more dread, more
dog-shameless, than a woman

⁴²⁸ who can set her mind on deeds like these —

⁴²⁹ the way that woman plotted her unspeakable
work,

⁴³⁰ building the murder of her own wedded
husband. And I had thought

⁴³¹ to come home welcome to my children and
my slaves!

⁴³² But she — that mistress of atrocity — has
poured out shame

⁴³³ on her own head, and on all women after her,

⁴³⁴ the female kind — yes, even on the doer of
good.'

⁴³⁵ So he spoke, and I answered him and said:

⁴³⁶ 'Ah, gods — how terribly has Zeus of the wide
voice hated

⁴³⁷ the seed of Atreus from the beginning, and
through the designs

⁴³⁸ of women: for Helen's sake we died in our
thousands,

439 and for you Clytemnestra set her snare while
you were far away.'

440 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:

441 'Then never be gentle, you too, even to your
own wife.45

442 Do not tell out to her the whole word that you
know:

443 say part, and let part stay hidden.

444 But not for you, Odysseus, will murder come
from a wife.

445 Too understanding she is, too watchful the
mind in her breast —

446 the daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded
Penelope.

447 A young bride we left her, when we went

448 to the war; and a boy was at her breast,

449 an infant, who now, I suppose, sits numbered
among men —

450 the fortunate one! His dear father will see
him, coming home,

451 and he will embrace his father: that is the
right way of things.

452 But my wife did not let me fill even my eyes
453 with my own son. She killed me before that —
killed the man himself.

454 And I will tell you another thing: lay it up in
your heart.

455 In secret — not in the open — bring your ship
in46

456 to your own dear country. For there is no
trusting women any more.

457 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

458 do you hear whether my son is still alive,
somewhere —

459 in Orchomenus perhaps, or in sandy Pylos,

460 or with Menelaus in wide Sparta?

461 For noble Orestes has not yet died on the
earth.'

462 So he spoke, and I answered him and said:

463 'Son of Atreus, why ask me this? I know
nothing —

464 whether he lives or is dead. It is evil to speak
words empty as wind.'47

465 So the two of us stood trading grim words,

466 grieving, letting the big tears fall.
467 And there came the soul of Achilles, Peleus'
son,
468 and of Patroclus, and of blameless
Antilochus,**48**
469 and of Ajax, who was first in beauty and in
body
470 of all the Danaans, after the blameless son of
Peleus.
471 And the soul of swift-footed Aeacides knew
me,
472 and mourning he spoke winged words to me:
473 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices —
474 reckless man! What deed will your mind plot
now, still greater?**49**
475 How did you dare come down to Hades, where
the dead
476 live without wits — the phantoms of worn-out
mortals?'
477 So he spoke, and I answered him and said:
478 'Achilles, son of Peleus, far the mightiest of

the Achaeans —

479 I came for Tiresias, out of need: in hope he
might tell

480 some plan for reaching rugged Ithaca.

481 For not yet have I come near Achaea — not yet

482 set foot on my own land: evil is with me
always. But you, Achilles —

483 no man before you was more blessed, and
none will be after:

484 living, we Argives honored you like the gods,

485 and now you rule in strength among the dead,

486 here where you are. Do not grieve at dying,
then, Achilles.’

487 So I spoke, and he answered me at once:

488 ‘Do not talk death over sweetly to me, shining
Odysseus.50

489 I would rather be bound to the plow-land,
hired out to another —

490 some man without a land-lot, without much
living —

491 than be king over all the wasted dead.

492 Enough — tell me word of that proud son of

mine:

493 did he follow to the war, to be a champion, or
did he not?

494 And tell me of blameless Peleus, if you have
heard:

495 does he still hold his honor among the
Myrmidon crowds,

496 or do they slight him now through Hellas and
Phthia,

497 because old age has hold of him, hand and
foot?

498 For I am no longer his defender under the
rays of the sun —

499 no longer the man I was when in wide Troy

500 I cut down the best of their host, in the
Argives' defense.

501 Could I come, that man, even for an hour, to
my father's house,51

502 I would make my fury and my unconquerable
hands a horror

503 to those who do him violence and shut him
from his honor.'

504 So he spoke, and I answered him and said:
505 'Of blameless Peleus I have heard nothing.
506 But of your own dear son, Neoptolemus,
507 I will tell you the whole truth, as you ask.
508 I myself carried him, in my trim hollow ship,
509 out of Scyros to join the strong-greaved
Achaean.
510 And whenever we framed our counsels
around the city of Troy,
511 he was always first to speak, and his words
never missed:
512 godlike Nestor and I alone outdid him.
513 And whenever we fought on the Trojan plain
with the bronze,
514 he never lingered back in the mass of men or
the crush,
515 but ran far out in front, yielding his fury to no
one,
516 and he cut down many men in the terrible
fighting.
517 All of them I could not tell through or name —
518 all the host he killed in the Argives' defense;

519 but such a man was the son of Telephus he
brought down with the bronze,
520 the hero Eurypylus — and around him his
Ceteian
521 companions in crowds were slain, for the sake
of a woman's gifts.52
522 He was the handsomest man I ever saw, after
noble Memnon.
523 And when we climbed down into the horse
Epeius built —
524 we, the best of the Argives — and it all lay
upon me,
525 to throw open our close-packed ambush or to
shut it,
526 then the other leaders and counselors of the
Danaans
527 kept wiping tears away, and each man's legs
shook under him;
528 but him — never once did my eyes see
529 his beautiful skin go pale, or catch him wiping
530 a tear from his cheeks. No: he begged me,
over and over,

531 to let him out of the horse, and kept fingering
his sword-hilt

532 and his spear heavy with bronze, with evil in
his heart for the Trojans.53

533 And when we had sacked the steep city of
Priam,

534 he boarded his ship with his share and a fine
prize of honor —

535 unscarred: never touched by a thrown spear,
never gashed

536 in the close work, the way it happens so often

537 in war. For Ares rages blind, and makes no
distinctions.’

538 So I spoke; and the soul of swift-footed
Aeacides

539 went away with long strides across the
meadow of asphodel,54

540 rejoicing that I had said his son was
preeminent.

541 And the other souls of the dead who are gone

542 stood grieving, and each asked after what was
dear to it.

543 Alone of them all, the soul of Ajax, Telamon's
son,
544 stood apart, still raging over the victory55
545 I won against him, pleading my case by the
ships,
546 for the arms of Achilles. His honored mother
set the prize,
547 and the sons of the Trojans judged it, and
Pallas Athena.
548 Would to god I had never won a contest like
that one:
549 such a head the earth closed over for those
arms' sake —
550 Ajax, who in beauty and in every deed of war
stood first
551 of all the Danaans, after the blameless son of
Peleus.
552 Him I addressed with honeyed words:
553 'Ajax, son of blameless Telamon — could you
not, then,
554 even in death forget your anger at me for
those cursed

555 arms? The gods made them a scourge for the
Argives —

556 such a tower fell when you fell. For you the
Achaeans

557 grieve without ceasing, as for the very head

558 of Achilles, Peleus' son. And no one else

559 bears the blame, but Zeus: he hated the army
of the Danaan

560 spearmen with a terrible hatred, and laid
your doom on you.

561 Come here, lord — come hear our word, our
speech.

562 Master your fury; break that proud heart
down.'

563 So I spoke. He answered me nothing. He went
his way⁵⁶

564 after the other souls, into the Erebus of the
dead who are gone.

565 There, even so, for all his anger, he might yet
have spoken to me,

566 or I to him. But the heart in my breast

567 wished to see the souls of the other dead.

568 There I saw Minos, the shining son of Zeus,57
569 holding a golden scepter, delivering law
among the dead —
570 he seated, and around him the dead pleading
their cases before the lord,
571 sitting and standing through the wide-gated
house of Hades.
572 And after him I marked out huge Orion
573 herding the wild beasts together across the
meadow of asphodel —
574 the very beasts he had killed on the lonely
mountains —
575 a club in his hands, all bronze, forever
unbroken.
576 And I saw Tityus, the son of glorious Earth,
577 laid out on the ground: over nine roods he
sprawled,
578 and two vultures, sitting either side, tore at
his liver,58
579 plunging into the caul; and his hands could
not beat them off:
580 for he had assaulted Leto, the honored

consort of Zeus,

581 as she walked toward Pytho through
Panopeus of the lovely dancing-grounds.

582 And Tantalus too I saw, holding his hard
agonies,

583 standing in a pool that lapped against his chin

—

584 and he strained with thirst, and could not
reach a drop to drink:59

585 as often as the old man stooped, in a fury to
drink,

586 so often the water was swallowed away and
gone, and around his feet

587 the black earth showed, parched dry by a god.

588 And trees in tall leaf poured their fruit above
his head,

589 pears and pomegranates and apple trees
bright with fruit,

590 sweet figs and olives in full flourish;60

591 and whenever the old man reached out to
close his hands on them,

592 the wind would toss them away toward the

shadowing clouds.

593 And Sisyphus too I saw, holding his hard
agonies,

594 wrestling a monstrous stone with both his
arms.

595 Bracing himself — straining with hands and
feet —

596 he would shove the stone uphill toward the
crest; but each time,

597 just as he was about to heave it over the top,
the sheer weight wheeled it round,

598 and down to the plain again rolled the
shameless stone.61

599 And he would strain again, and shove — the
sweat streaming

600 off his limbs, and the dust rising off his head.

601 And after him I marked the strength of
Heracles —

602 his phantom: for the man himself, among the
deathless gods,62

603 delights in the feasting, with fair-ankled Hebe
for his wife,

604 the child of great Zeus and of Hera of the
golden sandals.

605 Around that phantom rose a clamor of the
dead, like birds

606 scattering in panic every way. And he, like
black night,

607 the bow bare in his hand, an arrow on the
string,

608 glared terribly about him, forever like a man
on the point of shooting.

609 And terrible was the baldric crossing his
chest,

610 the sword-belt all of gold, where deeds of
wonder had been worked —

611 bears, and wild boars, and lions with fire in
their eyes,

612 and combats, and battles, and murders, and
the killings of men.63

613 May the man who designed that belt design
nothing further —

614 whoever took such work into his craft!

615 And he in his turn knew me, the moment his

eyes fell on me,

616 and mourning he spoke winged words to me:

617 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices —

618 poor man! So you too are dragging out an evil
doom64

619 such as I bore beneath the rays of the sun?

620 I was a son of Zeus, of Cronos' line — and my
misery

621 had no end: for I was bound in service to a
man

622 far worse than I, who laid hard labors on me,

623 and once he sent me here, to fetch the Hound:
no other

624 labor, he reckoned, could be mightier than
that one.

625 I carried the Hound up and out of Hades,

626 and Hermes saw me on my way, and gray-
eyed Athena.'

627 So speaking he went back into the house of
Hades;

628 but I stayed rooted there, in hope some other

might yet come

629 of the hero men who died in the time before.

630 And now I would have seen still earlier men,
the ones I longed for —

631 Theseus and Pirithous, glorious children of
the gods —65

632 but first the tribes of the dead came
gathering, thousand

633 on thousand, with a sound that had no
earthly likeness; and the pale terror took me

634 that queenly Persephone might send out of
Hades

635 the Gorgon head of the dread monster against
me.66

636 Straight to the ship I went, and ordered my
companions

637 to board in their turn and loose the stern-
cables;

638 and they came aboard at once and took their
places at the oarlocks.

639 And the wave of the current bore her down
the river of Ocean —

640 the rowing first; and afterward, a beautiful following wind.

Notes

NOTES

1. One day's sail, and the sunset line — and the ship is at “the limits of deep-flowing Ocean.” Hades is a single day downwind from Circe's island: the geography of fairyland compresses to the exact length of the formula. ↩
2. The Cimmerians: a people wrapped in mist at the world's edge, on whom the sun never looks — real twilight-dwellers guarding the border of the dead. Ancient geographers hunted them from the Crimea (whose name some have derived from theirs, though the link is disputed) to the volcanic fields near Naples; the poem needs only their darkness — the sun of Helios' own daughter Circe cannot reach the doorstep of Hades. ↩
3. Lines 23–50 execute Circe's protocol (10.517–540) nearly word for word, and the translation repeats itself accordingly: the cubit-square pit, the triple libation, the barley, the vows, the black victims, the sword over the blood. The instructions and their performance are the same liturgy heard twice — ritual language is exact or it is nothing. ↩

4. The dead come up *before* they drink — drawn to blood like gulls to bait. The catalogue of the arriving dead (38–41) is the poem’s census of mortality: brides, unwed boys, worn old men, girls “with the fresh grief on their hearts,” and the war-dead still in their bloody armor. Death is presented not as a place but as a *population* — and the sound they make is “θεσπεσίῃ ἰαχῇ,” a cry past mortal likeness. Then the plainest confession in the poem: “the pale terror took me.” ↩
5. Elpenor first — before the seer, before his own mother — because the unburied travel faster than protocol. The poem’s ethics of burial made into queue order: the corpse left “unwept and unburied” on Aeaea outruns the black ship to the door of Hades. ↩
6. Odysseus’ greeting is the gentlest dark joke in epic: “You have outstripped me — on foot, and I in my black ship.” Grief in this poem is allowed wit; the wit is the tenderness. ↩
7. “The evil doom of a god blinded me — that, and wine past measure”: Elpenor’s self-obituary splits the blame evenly between heaven and the bottle, with the poem’s word for ruinous folly (ἄσσε, from atē) doing the work. No one in Homer lies about how they died. ↩
8. His plea is the poem’s doctrine of burial stated from the inside: unburied, he becomes “a cause of gods’ wrath”; buried, a marker “for men to come to learn of.” Even the least of the dead is owed his mound and his name — and Odysseus’ one-line promise (80) will be kept to the letter at 12.8–15. ↩
9. The tomb-furniture he asks for is not a sword but his oar — “the oar I rowed with when I lived, when I was among my

companions.” An ordinary man asks to be remembered as a man who pulled his weight, in the company he pulled it with. The image returns transfigured forty-four lines later in Tiresias’ prophecy (121): another oar planted in earth, at the other end of the world, as the sign of a labor finished. ↩

10. Anticleia comes to the blood — and he holds his sword against his own mother, keeping her from speaking until Tiresias has drunk. The discipline of the errand over the claim of the heart: no moment in the poem costs him more, and none is narrated with fewer words (88–89, “for all my thick grief”). ↩
11. Tiresias knows him *before* drinking — the one exemption (10.494–495) working exactly as specified: his mind stands fast. He drinks not to recognize but to prophesy: blood is the medium of truth-telling, not of identity. ↩
12. Helios “who sees all things and hears all things” — the formula that makes Thrinacia a theological trap: the cattle belong to total surveillance. The prophecy’s practical content is a single self-command: *hold hard your own heart and your companions’* — everything else is consequence. ↩
13. Lines 114–115 repeat the Cyclops’ curse (9.534–535) almost word for word — late, in evil case, all companions lost, on another man’s ship, trouble in the house. The curse has become the itinerary: what Polyphemus prayed, Poseidon heard, and Tiresias now simply *reads out*. Fate in this poem has an audit trail, and the translation keeps the language identical at every stage of it. ↩
14. The oar journey: inland until the sea is not even a rumor — men who eat unsalted food, who have never seen a ship, to whom

an oar reads as a farm tool. The errand's meaning has been argued for millennia: Poseidon's cult carried to those who have never had reason to fear him; the sea-man's reconciliation with the land. It is the poem's strangest and most beautiful invention — the hero's final task is to walk far enough that his defining tool becomes unrecognizable. ↩

15. ἀθηρηλοιγόν — “chaff-destroyer,” a winnowing-fan: the shovel that throws grain to the wind so the chaff blows clear. The sign is a misreading: when a stranger *gets the oar wrong*, the journey is over. The instrument of wandering, mistaken for the instrument of harvest, in a country where the confusion is possible — that mistake is the destination. ↩

16. “Death will come to you from the sea, so gentle a death” — ἐξ ἁλός, the most argued two words in the poem: “from the sea” or “away from the sea”? The Greek permits both an ocean-borne death and a death far from salt water; later tradition (the *Telegony*) took the first route. The prophecy's tone is what matters: gentle (ἀβληχρός), in “sleek old age,” the people prosperous — the softest death-sentence in epic, and deliberately ambiguous about its address. ↩

17. His whole response to the prophecy of his own death: “all that, no doubt, the gods themselves have spun” — one line of acceptance, and then immediately, “But come, tell me this”: how do I speak with my mother? The pivot from fate to family in a single breath is the man entire. ↩

18. “What doom of death, that lays men low, mastered you?” — the question-formula he will ask Agamemnon in the identical

words (398). In Hades all interviews open with the same door:
how did you die? ↩

19. Anticleia's report is the poem's status dispatch from home, delivered from the far side of death: Penelope enduring in tears; Telemachus farming "unchallenged" (the news is years stale — the dead know only what they knew); and Laertes — the poem's first full picture of him — sleeping in the ashes with the slaves in winter, on fallen leaves in the vineyard in autumn, "aching for your homecoming." The king's father bedded like the poorest laborer on his own land: grief expressed as self-abasement, held in reserve by the poem until Book 24. ↩
20. Note what Anticleia does *not* know: nothing of the suitors. Her Ithaca is sad but uninvaded. The poem is scrupulous with its dead — they are informants with a cutoff date. ↩
21. Her cause of death, in the poem's most devastating diagnosis: not Artemis' arrows, not wasting illness — "it was longing for you, your counsels, shining Odysseus, your gentle-heartedness (ἀγανοφροσύνη), that robbed me of honey-sweet life." The mother died of the son's absence — of missing precisely his *mind* and his *gentleness*, the two things the epithets never advertise. He learns in Hades that his wandering has already cost a life at home. ↩
22. The three embraces: "Three times I started toward her... three times, out of my hands, like a shadow or a dream she flew." The most imitated lines in Western literature — Virgil borrowed them twice (Creusa, Anchises), Dante and Milton after him. The failed embrace is the Nekyia's whole metaphysics enacted

in gesture: knowledge crosses the blood-line; touch does not.



23. Anticleia's anatomy of death — sinews gone, flesh and bone burned down once the life leaves “the white bones,” the soul flitting off “like a dream” — is the plainest statement of Homeric death-physiology, delivered as a mother's comfort: *Persephone is not tricking you; this is simply the settled way (δίκη) of mortals*. Consolation by physics. ↩
24. Her last words: “mark all these things — to tell them to your wife hereafter.” From inside death, the mother directs the son's memory toward the living woman. The Nekyia keeps pointing home; and he will, in fact, tell Penelope everything (23.322ff.). ↩
25. The Catalogue of Heroines (225–332): Persephone curates a procession of the great women of legend, and Odysseus interviews them “one by one” at sword-point rationing. A female counter-epic embedded in the poem — mothers of dynasties, wronged wives, hanged queens — told to a hall ruled, as Odysseus has noticed, by a queen. The audience-within-the-poem shapes the tale: this catalogue is aimed at Arete, and it is she who speaks first when it ends (335). ↩
26. Tyro, who loved a river: Poseidon takes the river's own shape, and the wave arches “mountain-high” over god and girl — the sea's grandest bed-curtain. His parting speech is divine etiquette complete: praise, promise (“the beds of the immortals are not fruitless”), gag order, and self-identification in the same breath. From this union: Pelias and Neleus — hence Nestor's whole line, and half the Argonaut world. ↩

27. Amphion and Zethus “first founded seven-gated Thebes and walled it” — Homer’s Thebes begins with the twins, with no word of Cadmus — and even they, strong as they were, “could not live in Thebes without walls”: civilization’s minimum requirement stated in passing, by the poem whose Cyclopes have no walls at all. ↩
28. Epicaste — Homer’s name for Jocasta — and the Oedipus story in six lines, differing from tragedy’s version at every joint: the gods reveal the incest “at once”; she hangs herself; *he rules on in Thebes*, suffering but enthroned, hounded by “a mother’s Furies.” No self-blinding, no exile, no Antigone. Sophocles is three centuries downstream; here the tale is a mother’s catastrophe, filed under her name, not his. ↩
29. The Pero digression — Neleus’ bride-price of the cattle of Iphicles, and “the blameless seer” (Melampus, unnamed) who alone dared drive them, was bound a year, and freed himself by prophecy — is told in the clipped, allusive manner of a story every listener already knows. The poem’s audience carried a library; Homer footnotes it with a gesture. ↩
30. Castor and Polydeuces, “both of them living” beneath the earth — alive and dead on alternate days, “honor equal to the gods’.” The strangest afterlife in Homer, stated without explanation: the shared immortality Zeus granted the twins, time-sliced. Even death, for some families, is negotiable — the Nekyia’s rule (the dead are witless shades) admits exceptions at every rank. ↩
31. Otus and Ephialtes: nine years old, nine cubits wide, nine fathoms tall — fairy-tale arithmetic for the boys who stacked

Ossa on Olympus and Pelion on Ossa “to make heaven scalable,” and would have *done it* had they reached manhood. Apollo kills them before their beards bloom. The pathos is deliberate: even the world-stormers enter the catalogue as their mother’s short-lived sons. ↩

32. Ariadne’s variant is the dark one: Theseus “had no joy of her — Artemis killed her first, on sea-ringed Dia, on the testimony of Dionysus.” No abandonment on Naxos, no wedding to the god: instead the god as *witness for the prosecution* in a divine execution the poem does not explain. Whatever the lost story was, Homer’s audience knew it; we hold only the four-line verdict. ↩
33. The catalogue ends on its one moral judgment: “hateful Eriphyle, who took precious gold as the price of her own husband” — bribed with a necklace to send Amphiaraus to his death. Between Clytemnestra behind him in the tale and Eriphyle at the catalogue’s close, the Nekyia is building a jury for the question the poem never stops asking: what may a man trust in a wife? The answer sits in Ithaca. ↩
34. The Intermezzo (333–384): mid-tale, mid-Hades, the poem surfaces to Phaeacia — the hall “hushed in silence, held fast under the spell” (κηληθμῶ: the enchantment-word, cousin of Circe’s charms). Storytelling as literal spellbinding; the audience of the poem watches an audience bound by it. ↩
35. Alcinous seals his promise with the very formula of authority Telemachus used against his mother (1.359: “mine is the power in this house”) — here, “mine is the power in this land”

(κράτος). The idiom of sovereignty travels intact from a boy's first assertion to a king's guarantee. ↩

36. Odysseus' answer to "stay another day" is cheerful, unembarrassed avarice: he would stay a *year* if it filled his hands, since a richer return means a more respected return. Gift-wealth is honor's raw material, and he says so — the same frank materialism as "let me see my possessions, my slaves, and my great high-roofed house" (7.225). The hero's accounting is always shown, never hidden. ↩
37. Alcinous' certification: you are not one of the cheats "the black earth breeds in such crops... who build lies out of what no eye could ever test." The praise is double-edged in the poem's own hands — building untestable lies is *exactly* what Odysseus will do professionally through the second half (the Cretan tales) — and the compliment defines the craft while acquitting the craftsman. ↩
38. "There is a shape upon your words... you have told your tale with knowledge, like a singer." The poem's boldest self-reference: its hero is credentialed as an αοιδός by his royal audience, mid-performance, in the poem's own terms of praise (μορφή ἐπέων — form upon words). Odysseus has become Demodocus; the apologoi are certified as song from inside. Every question about the tale's truth is deliberately left alive inside the compliment. ↩
39. The resumption headline: companions who escaped Troy "only to die on the homeward way, by an evil woman's will." The second half of the Nekyia is announced as Clytemnestra's section — the war's survivors murdered by the peace. ↩

40. Agamemnon reaches for him, weeping — “but there was no strength grounded in him now, no force such as once filled his supple limbs.” The lord of men cannot complete a handclasp. Where Anticleia’s failed embrace was metaphysics, this one is pure pathos: the king’s grip was his scepter, and it is gone. ↩
41. “As a man cuts down an ox at the manger” — the line the poem fixed at 4.535 (Proteus’ telling), now spoken by the victim himself, verbatim. Three tellings of Agamemnon’s death (Nestor’s, Proteus’, and now the ghost’s own), and the ox-line is the constant: slaughtered as livestock, at dinner, in trust. ↩
42. The companions die “like white-tusked swine... for a wedding, a club-feast, or a swelling banquet” — the same three feast-categories Athena listed on Ithaca (1.226: banquet? wedding? no shared feast). Men butchered as the catering at the very institutions of hospitality: the feast-corruption theme at its ghastliest, told by its casualty to the man whose own hall hosts an endless uninvited feast. ↩
43. Cassandra — “the most pitiful voice I heard” — killed by Clytemnestra “over my body.” One line for the prophetess, and the epithet transferred: Clytemnestra is δολόμητις, “of the crooked counsels,” Aegisthus’ fixed tag (1.300) now branded onto the wife. In the ghost’s telling she has absorbed the plot entirely. ↩
44. The detail Agamemnon cannot forgive is not the sword: “she could not bring herself... to draw my eyelids shut with her hands, or close my mouth.” The last offices — the small mercies owed the dead by their nearest — withheld. His bitterness fixes not on being murdered but on being left

unclosed: even Clytemnestra's atrocity is measured, in this poem, by an omitted ritual of care. ↩

45. Agamemnon's counsel — never be gentle, tell her part and hide part, land in secret — comes with its own retraction in the middle: "But not for you, Odysseus, will murder come from a wife. Too understanding she is, too watchful the mind in her breast" — and the ghost speaks her full formula, "the daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded Penelope," the fixed epithet sounding like a verdict. The poem lets its worst husband certify its best wife — and Odysseus will still follow the advice (the secret landing, the testing) to the letter. Trust and technique are kept separate to the end. ↩

46. "There is no trusting women any more" — οὐκέτι πιστὰ γυναῖξιν: the ghost's bitter general law, ten lines after exempting Penelope from it. The poem stages misogyny as damage — a murdered man's wound talking — and shows the exception standing in Ithaca before the law is even uttered. Both the wound and the exception are in the text; neither cancels the other. ↩

47. His refusal to speculate about Orestes reuses the phantom's line from 4.837 verbatim: "It is evil to speak words empty as wind." The living son he cannot report on is the one man whose story every listener knows — the poem's audience holds the ending (Orestes lives, avenges) that the speakers in Hades cannot reach. ↩

48. Achilles enters flanked by Patroclus, Antilochus, Ajax — the dead of the *Iliad* and its aftermath in one file. The lineup is the

war's honor roll, and the book will speak with the first and last of them: the best of the Achaeans, and the best after him. ↩

49. Achilles' greeting — σκέτλιε, "reckless man! What deed will your mind plot now, still greater?" — is half rebuke, half admiration, entirely in character: dying has not changed his opinion that Odysseus over-schemes. And his description of his own realm is definitive: "where the dead live without wits — the phantoms of worn-out mortals" (βροτῶν εἴδωλα καμόντων). No one rates Hades lower than its king. ↩

50. The recantation: "I would rather be bound to the plow-land, hired out to another — some man without a land-lot, without much living — than be king over all the wasted dead." The θής — the landless hired man — is the *lowest* free status Greek society knew, beneath even the slave in security. The Iliad's whole wager (short glorious life over long obscure one) is repudiated by its winner, in four lines, to the man who will spend the rest of the Odyssey choosing survival over glory at every fork. This is the hinge on which the two epics turn their backs to each other — and note that the poem does not let it be Achilles' last word. ↩

51. Because his last fury is not for himself: it is Peleus — the old father possibly scorned, unshielded — that pulls the old Iliadic fire out of him: "Could I come, that man, even for an hour, to my father's house..." One hour, for the father. Achilles in Hades has become what Odysseus is: a son and a father first. The Nekyia turns every hero it touches toward family. ↩

52. Eurypylus and his Ceteians died "for the sake of a woman's gifts" — Priam bribed the hero's mother with a golden vine to

send her son. Another woman, another payment, another dead man: Eriphyle's golden necklace (326–327) has a twin in the tale Odysseus chooses to tell. The Nekyia's economy of women-and-gold is consistent to the smallest digression. ↩

53. The report on Neoptolemus is built as a father's checklist — counsel (first to speak; only Nestor and I better), battle (always in front), the horse (the others wept and trembled; he begged to be let out), and the return (unscarred, “for Ares rages blind”). Every clause is calibrated to the listener; whether every clause is *true* is a question the certified singer's tale politely does not raise. It is the kindest speech in the book. ↩
54. The one happy exit in Hades: Achilles “went away with long strides across the meadow of asphodel, rejoicing that I had said his son was preeminent.” The asphodel meadow — gray, spectral pasture of the dead — crossed for once at a warrior's pace, in joy. Fatherhood is the only good news death can receive. ↩
55. Ajax: still furious over the judgment of Achilles' arms — the contest Odysseus won “pleading my case by the ships,” which drove Ajax to madness and suicide (the lost *Little Iliad*'s matter; Sophocles' later). Odysseus' own verdict now: “Would to god I had never won a contest like that one” — the prize acknowledged as ruin, the dead man ranked “first after Achilles” without reservation. ↩
56. “He answered me nothing. He went his way after the other souls, into the Erebus of the dead.” The most celebrated silence in literature — Longinus called it more sublime than any speech. Ghost after ghost has talked; the one man with the

unanswerable grievance, appealed to directly, refuses the only thing the living visitor came for. And Odysseus' obituary for the moment (565–567) admits the wound stayed open: he might have spoken, *or I to him* — but curiosity, as ever, pulled the survivor onward. The poem's greatest apology is left unaccepted forever. ↩

57. Minos “delivering law among the dead... the dead pleading their cases”: Hades has a docket. Not punishment — jurisdiction: the dead bring lawsuits, the wide-gated house has a sitting judge with a golden scepter. Homer's underworld bureaucracy, one line before its athletes (Orion, still herding the beasts he killed — occupation continued, forever). ↩

58. With Tityus the register changes: the punished. Nine roods of him, vultures at the liver (seat of appetite), for assaulting Leto. Then Tantalus and Sisyphus — but note who is *not* explained: Homer gives Tityus' crime and leaves Tantalus' and Sisyphus' unstated, as if the punishments were labels enough. The great sinners arrive in this poem already proverbial. ↩

59. Tantalus: the water “swallowed away and gone” at every stoop, the black earth showing “parched dry by a god” — deprivation administered with personal attention. English *tantalize* was minted from these ten lines. ↩

60. The fruit above Tantalus' head is Alcinous' orchard, tree for tree — “pears and pomegranates and apple trees bright with fruit, sweet figs and olives in full flourish” (=7.115–116, verbatim; kept verbatim here). Paradise's own catalogue, replanted in hell as apparatus: the identical line describing eternal abundance and eternal denial. Whether the echo is design or

the formula's indifference, the effect for the listening Phaeacians is exquisite — the damned man starves under their own garden. ↩

61. Sisyphus, in the poem's most kinetic lines: the stone shoved "straining with hands and feet," the crest almost gained, and then "the shameless weight" (λαῖας ἀναιδής — the stone itself gets a moral adjective) wheeling him round, "and down to the plain again rolled the pitiless stone... the sweat streaming off his limbs, and the dust rising off his head." Ancient critics heard the labor in the meter itself — slow spondees uphill, the rock tumbling home in quick dactyls. The dust off the head is the detail genius adds: effort has a weather. ↩
62. The Heracles split — "his phantom: for the man himself, among the deathless gods, delights in the feasting, with Hebe for his wife" — is the boldest metaphysical patch in Homer: the hero both deified on Olympus and stalking Hades as an εἶδωλον. Ancient critics flagged the lines as a later harmonizing insertion (the apotheosis doctrine grafted onto the older dead-Heracles), and they may be; the poem as we have it simply pays both theologies. What no interpolator supplied is the figure itself: bow drawn, arrow nocked, "forever like a man on the point of shooting" — the hero's essence looped for eternity, menace with no target left. ↩
63. The golden baldric — bears, boars, lions, "and combats, and battles, and murders, and the killings of men" — draws from Odysseus a craftsman's curse: "May the man who designed that belt design nothing further." The connoisseur of workmanship (rafts, palaces, brooches) recoils for the only

time: some things are made too well. It is the poem's one review of art as atrocity. ↩

64. Heracles' fellow-feeling — “So you too are dragging out an evil doom such as I bore beneath the sun” — is the strongest of the Nekyia's mirrors: the son of Zeus who served “a man far worse” and was sent to fetch the Hound, greeting the son of Laertes still serving his own long labor. The catalogue of encounters ends with the hero who *finished* his labors and was translated; Odysseus' are not finished, and the poem sends him back up the river to them. ↩

65. He waited for Theseus and Pirithous — “the ones I longed for” — the connoisseur of heroes hoping for one more exhibit even at the rim of Hades. What ends the Nekyia is not satisfaction but crowd-panic: the ten-thousand tribes gathering with the unearthly cry, and the fear of one face. ↩

66. The Gorgon head: the terror that Persephone might send up “the head of the dread monster” — petrification, the one fate that would end all homecomings — finally moves the man whom nothing else in Hades could move to his feet. The pale terror of line 43 returns as the book's exit-spring; the boundary of the tellable is a monster's face. Then oars, then a fair wind: the dead are left behind at rowing-speed, and the longest night of storytelling in Greek literature closes with the current of Ocean carrying the ship — and the tale — back toward the light. ↩

Odyssey — Book 12

The Sirens; Scylla and Charybdis; the cattle of the Sun.

- 1 Now when the ship had left the stream of the river Ocean
- 2 and come out into the swell of the wide-wayed sea
- 3 and the island of Aeaea — where the house of early-born¹
- 4 Dawn is, and her dancing-grounds, and the risings of the sun —
- 5 we ran her in there onto the sands
- 6 and stepped out ourselves onto the surf-line of the sea,
- 7 and there we dropped asleep, and waited for shining Dawn.
- 8 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with fingers of rose,
- 9 then I sent companions ahead to the house of Circe

10 to bring the body of Elpenor, who had died.
11 We cut billets of wood, quickly, and where the
headland ran out highest
12 we buried him, grieving, letting the big tears
fall.
13 And when the dead man was burned, and the
dead man's armor,
14 we heaped a mound, and dragged a pillar-stone
onto it,
15 and on the very top of the mound we fixed his
well-shaped oar.²
16 So we saw to it all, each thing. And our coming
up from Hades
17 was not lost on Circe: she readied herself and
came
18 quickly, and her handmaids with her carried
19 bread and meat in plenty and fire-bright red
wine.
20 And she stood in our midst and spoke, shining
among goddesses:
21 'Hard men — you who went down living into
the house of Hades:

22 twice-dying, when other men die once.³
23 Come now: eat your food, and drink your wine,
24 here, all day long. And when dawn shows
25 you shall sail; and I will point out your road,
and make each thing
26 plain, so that no grinding evil design,
27 on sea or on land, can catch you and make you
suffer.’
28 So she spoke, and our proud hearts consented.
29 So then all day long till the setting of the sun
30 we sat feasting on meat past counting and
sweet wine;
31 and when the sun went down and the dusk
came on,
32 the men lay down to sleep beside the ship’s
stern-cables,
33 but she took me by the hand, apart from my
dear companions,
34 and made me sit, and lay beside me, and asked
me everything;
35 and I told it all through to her, in its due order.
36 And then the lady Circe spoke to me in words:

37 'So all that has been brought to its end. Now
hear⁴

38 what I will tell you — and a god himself will
bring it back to your mind.

39 First you will come to the Sirens, who enchant

40 all mankind — whoever comes upon them.

41 Whoever in ignorance draws near and hears
the voice

42 of the Sirens — no wife, no little children

43 will ever stand beside that man to welcome
him home;

44 no — the Sirens enchant him with their clear-
toned song,

45 sitting in a meadow; and around them is a
great heap of the bones⁵

46 of rotting men, and the skins are shriveling on
them.

47 Drive past them; and knead honey-sweet wax

48 and stop your companions' ears with it, so that
none of the others

49 may hear. But you yourself — listen, if you
will:⁶

50 only let them bind you in the fast ship, hand
and foot,
51 upright in the mast-step, with the rope-ends
made fast to the mast itself,
52 so that you may hear the two Sirens' voice, and
delight in it.
53 And if you beg your companions — if you order
them to free you —
54 then let them bind you down with still more
bonds.
55 But when your companions have driven past
them,
56 from there I will not spell it out for you to the
end —
57 which of two roads will be yours. You yourself
58 must weigh it in your heart. But I will tell you
both.
59 On the one side, overhanging rocks; and
against them
60 roars the great swell of dark-eyed Amphitrite.
61 The blessed gods call them the Wandering
Rocks.

62 That way not even winged things pass — not
even the shy doves⁷

63 that carry ambrosia to father Zeus:

64 the sheer rock always takes one even of those,

65 and the Father sends in another to keep the
number full.

66 That way no ship of men has ever yet escaped,
whichever came,

67 but ships' planks and men's bodies together

68 are carried off by the waves of the sea and the
squalls of deadly fire.

69 One seagoing ship alone has sailed past there

—

70 Argo, whom all minds know — sailing home
from Aeetes;⁸

71 and even her the wave would have flung swiftly
on the great rocks,

72 but Hera sent her through, because Jason was
dear to her.

73 On the other side are two crags: one reaches
the wide heaven

74 with its sharp peak, and a dark-blue cloud

rings it,

75 never drawing off — no clear sky ever holds

76 that summit, not in summer, not in harvest-
time.

77 No mortal man could climb it, or set foot on
the top,

78 not if he had twenty hands and twenty feet:

79 the rock is smooth — as if dressed smooth all
around.

80 And in the middle of the crag is a misty cave

81 turned toward the dark, toward Erebus — the
very way you

82 will steer your hollow ship, shining Odysseus.

83 Not even a strong man's arrow, shot from a
hollow ship,

84 could reach up into that vaulted cave.

85 And in it lives Scylla — yelping horribly.

86 Her voice, truly, is no more than a newborn
puppy's,⁹

87 but she herself is an evil monster: no one

88 could look at her and rejoice — not a god, if a
god should meet her.

89 Twelve feet she has, all of them dangling;**10**
90 six necks, immensely long, and on each one
91 a hideous head, and in each three rows of
teeth,
92 thick-set and crowded, full of black death.
93 Waist-deep she is sunk in the hollow of the
cave,
94 but she holds her heads out of that terrible pit
95 and fishes there, quivering with hunger
around the crag,
96 for dolphins and dogfish, and whatever bigger
beast
97 she can seize, of the thousands deep-moaning
Amphitrite pastures.
98 Past her no sailors yet can boast
99 to have fled unharmed with their ship: with
each head
100 she carries off a man, snatched from the dark-
blue-prowed vessel.
101 The other crag is lower — you will see it,
Odysseus —
102 close by the first: a bowshot would carry

across.

103 On it stands a great fig tree, dense in leaf,
104 and beneath it shining Charybdis gulps down
the black water.11

105 Three times a day she spouts it forth, three
times she gulps it down —

106 terribly. May you not chance to be there when
she gulps:

107 no one could save you from that evil then —
not the earth-shaker himself.

108 No: keep close to Scylla's crag, and quickly
109 drive the ship past. It is far better
110 to mourn six companions from your ship than
all together.'12

111 So she spoke, and I answered her and said:

112 'Come then, goddess — tell me this, and tell it
true:

113 might I somehow slip out from under deadly
Charybdis

114 and stand off the other, when she strikes at
my companions?'

115 So I spoke, and she answered at once, shining

among goddesses:

116 'Hard man! So even now your heart is set on
the works of war¹³

117 and struggle. Will you not yield even to the
deathless gods?

118 She is not mortal — she is an immortal evil,
119 terrible, grim, savage, not to be fought.

120 There is no defense. To flee her is the best
courage.¹⁴

121 For if you linger by the rock to arm yourself,

122 I fear she will dart out a second time and
catch you

123 with all six heads, and take six men again.

124 No — row past with all your force, and call on
Crataeis,¹⁵

125 the mother of Scylla, who bore her, a plague
on mortals:

126 she will stop her then from darting out again.

127 And you will come to the island Thrinacia.
There in plenty

128 graze the cattle of Helios, and his strong
flocks:

129 seven herds of cattle, and as many fine flocks
of sheep,16
130 fifty in each. No young are born to them,
131 and they never die away. Goddesses are their
shepherds,
132 nymphs of the lovely braids, Phaethusa and
Lampetie,
133 whom shining Neaera bore to Helios
Hyperion.
134 Their honored mother, when she had borne
and reared them,
135 settled them far away, on the island Thrinacia,
136 to keep their father's sheep and his crook-
horned cattle.
137 If you leave these unharmed, and keep your
mind on homecoming,17
138 then you may yet reach Ithaca, though you
suffer evils;
139 but if you harm them, then I foretell
destruction
140 for ship and companions. And even if you
yourself escape,

141 late you will come, and in evil case, all
companions lost.’

142 So she spoke; and at once Dawn of the golden
throne came on.

143 Then she went away up the island, shining
among goddesses,

144 and I went to the ship and roused my
companions

145 to board in their turn and loose the stern-
cables;

146 and they came aboard at once and took their
places at the oarlocks,

147 and sitting in order they struck the gray salt
water with their oars.

148 And for us, behind the dark-blue-prowed ship,

149 a following wind that filled the sail, a good
companion,

150 was sent by Circe of the lovely braids, dread
goddess with a mortal’s voice.

151 So when we had seen to the tackle through the
ship,

152 we sat, and the wind and the steersman held

her on course.

153 Then, grieving at heart, I spoke among my
companions:

154 'Friends — it is not right that one man only, or
two, 18

155 should know the decrees that Circe told me,
shining among goddesses.

156 No: I will speak, so that knowing them we may
die —

157 or swerve aside, and escape death and doom.

158 First she commands us to shun the marvelous
Sirens —

159 their voice, and their flowering meadow.

160 Me alone she bade listen to their song. But
bind me

161 in a bond that bites, so that I stay fixed where
I stand,

162 upright in the mast-step, with the rope-ends
made fast to the mast itself.

163 And if I beg you — if I order you to free me —

164 then squeeze me down with still more bonds.'

165 So I went through it all, telling my

companions,

166 while the well-made ship ran swiftly on

167 toward the island of the two Sirens: a fair
wind drove her.

168 Then all at once the wind fell still, and a calm

169 came, breathless: some power lulled the waves
to sleep.19

170 My companions rose and furled the sails

171 and stowed them in the hollow ship, and
sitting to the oars

172 they whitened the water with the polished
blades of fir.

173 And I with my sharp bronze cut a great round
cake of wax

174 into little pieces, and kneaded them in my
heavy hands;

175 and quickly the wax grew warm, for my great
strength pressed it,

176 and the beam of the lord Helios, Hyperion's
son;20

177 and one by one I stopped the ears of all my
companions.

178 And they bound me in the ship, hand and foot
together,

179 upright in the mast-step, and made the rope-
ends fast to the mast itself;

180 and sitting down they struck the gray salt
water with their oars.

181 But when we were as far off as a man's shout
carries,

182 running swiftly, the sea-quick ship did not slip
past them

183 unseen as she leapt near — and they raised
their clear-toned song:

184 'Come here, come, much-praised Odysseus,
great glory of the Achaeans:21

185 bring your ship in, so you may hear the voice
of us two.

186 For no man yet has rowed past this place in
his black ship

187 before hearing the honey-voiced song from
our lips —

188 no: he has his delight of it, and goes his way
knowing more.22

189 For we know all that in wide Troy
190 the Argives and the Trojans labored through
by the gods' will;
191 and we know all that comes to pass on the
nourishing earth.'
192 So they sang, sending out their beautiful
voice; and my heart
193 longed to listen, and I ordered my
companions to free me,
194 signaling with my brows; but they threw
themselves forward and rowed.23
195 And at once Perimedes and Eurylochus rose
196 and bound me with more bonds, and squeezed
them tighter.
197 But when they had driven past them, and we
could no longer
198 hear the Sirens' voice, or their singing,
199 quickly my trusted companions took out the
wax
200 I had stopped their ears with, and loosed me
from my bonds.
201 But when we had left the island behind, at

once

202 I saw smoke, and a great wave, and heard a booming.

203 The men were terrified: the oars flew from their hands

204 and clattered, all of them, along the current; and the ship stopped

205 dead, since their hands no longer drove the tapered blades.

206 And I went through the ship, heartening my companions

207 with gentle words, standing by each man in turn:

208 'Friends — we are not unschooled in evils, not we.

209 This evil that stands over us now is no greater than when the Cyclops²⁴

210 penned us in his hollow cave by brute force —

211 and even from there, by my prowess and my counsel and my mind,

212 we escaped. Someday, I think, we will remember this one too.

213 Come then — all of us — do exactly as I say.
214 You, keep to your benches and strike the deep
surf
215 of the salt sea with your oar-blades, in hope
Zeus somehow
216 may grant us to slip clear of this destruction;
217 and you, steersman, here is my order — lay it
up
218 in your heart, since you handle the steering-
oar of our hollow ship:
219 keep the ship outside that smoke and that
surf,
220 and hug the crag, for fear the ship, before you
know it,
221 shears off toward the other side — and you
pitch us into the evil.’
222 So I spoke, and they quickly heeded my
words.
223 But Scylla I did not speak of — that hopeless
horror —**25**
224 for fear my companions, terrified, might drop
225 the oars and pack themselves into the hold.

226 And then — Circe's hard command, that I
should not
227 arm myself — I let it slip from my mind:26
228 I put on my famous armor, took two long
spears
229 in my hands, and went up to the half-deck at
the bow,
230 for it was from there I expected the first sight
231 of Scylla of the rock, bringing ruin on my
companions.
232 And I could not glimpse her anywhere; my
eyes grew weary
233 scanning every hand-span of the misty rock.
234 So we sailed up the narrows, wailing:
235 on this side Scylla; on that, shining Charybdis
236 gulped down, terribly, the salt water of the
sea.
237 When she vomited it up, like a cauldron over a
great fire27
238 she would seethe and boil in all her churning
depth, and the spray
239 fell high on the very tops of both the crags;

240 but when she gulped the salt sea down again,
241 all her churning depth showed open, and the
rock around her
242 roared terribly, and at the bottom the earth
showed,
243 dark-blue with sand. And the pale terror took
them.
244 We looked to her, then, in our dread of
destruction —28
245 and that was when Scylla snatched from the
hollow ship
246 six of my companions, the best in hands and
strength.
247 Turning to look at the fast ship, after my men,
248 I caught their feet and hands already above
me,
249 swung high aloft; and they cried out and
called to me
250 by name — for the last time — in the anguish
of their hearts.29
251 As when a fisherman on a jutting rock, with
his long rod,30

252 casts down baits as a snare for the little fishes,
253 dropping into the sea the horn of a field-ox,
254 and each fish he catches he flings up gasping
onto the land:

255 so they were swung gasping up toward the
rocks.

256 And there in her doorway she devoured them,
shrieking as they were,

257 stretching their hands toward me in the
terrible struggle.

258 That was the most pitiful thing my eyes ever
looked on

259 of all I suffered searching out the pathways of
the sea.

260 Now when we had escaped the rocks, and
dread Charybdis

261 and Scylla, we came quickly then to the god's

262 blameless island: there were the beautiful
broad-browed

263 cattle, and the many strong flocks, of Helios
Hyperion.

264 And while I was still at sea, in the black ship,

265 I heard the lowing of cattle being folded³²
266 and the bleating of sheep; and there fell upon
my heart the word
267 of the blind seer, Theban Tiresias,
268 and of Circe of Aeaea, who charged me over
and over
269 to shun the island of Helios, the delight of
mortals.
270 Then, grieving at heart, I spoke among my
companions:
271 ‘Hear my words, companions, for all your
suffering,
272 so I may tell you the prophecies of Tiresias
273 and of Circe of Aeaea, who charged me over
and over
274 to shun the island of Helios, the delight of
mortals:
275 there, she said, is the most terrible evil
waiting for us.
276 No — drive the black ship on, wide of the
island.’
277 So I spoke, and their own hearts broke within

them.

278 And at once Eurylochos answered me — with
a hateful word:

279 ‘You are a hard one, Odysseus. Your strength
is beyond us; your limbs³³

280 never tire. Truly you are made of iron
through and through —

281 you who will not let your companions, worn
down with labor

282 and sleeplessness, set foot on land, where on
this

283 sea-ringed island we might at last make ready
a savory supper;

284 no — just as we are, through the fast-falling
night, you order us

285 to wander, driven off the island, over the
misted sea.

286 Out of the nights are born the hard winds,³⁴

287 the wreckers of ships. How would a man
escape sheer destruction

288 if somehow, suddenly, a squall of wind should
come,

289 South Wind or hard-blowing West, which
more than any others
290 smash ships to pieces — in despite of the gods
our lords?
291 No: for now let us yield to black night
292 and make our supper ready, staying by the
fast ship;
293 at dawn we will board, and stand out onto the
wide sea.’
294 So spoke Eurylochus, and the other
companions approved.
295 And then I knew it: some power was plotting
evils —
296 and lifting my voice I spoke winged words to
him:
297 ‘Eurylochus, you force my hand: I am one man
alone.35
298 But come — every one of you swear me a
strong oath:
299 if we find some herd of cattle or great flock
300 of sheep, let no man in his evil recklessness36
301 kill one cow, one sheep. No: sit quiet

302 and eat the food immortal Circe gave.’
303 So I spoke, and they swore at once, as I
demanded.
304 And when they had sworn, and made an end
of the oath,
305 we moored the well-made ship in the hollow
harbor
306 close by a spring of sweet water, and the
companions went
307 ashore, and skillfully made their supper
ready.
308 But when they had put away desire for food
and drink,
309 they fell to weeping, remembering their dear
companions
310 whom Scylla had snatched from the hollow
ship and eaten;
311 and as they wept, a deep sleep came upon
them.
312 But in the night’s third watch, when the stars
had crossed their height,
313 Zeus who gathers the clouds roused a raging

wind against us

314 in a howling squall, and covered land and sea
alike

315 with cloud; and night rose up out of heaven.

316 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,

317 we dragged the ship up and made her fast in a
hollow cave

318 where the nymphs had their fine dancing-
floors and seats;

319 and then I called them all together, and said:

320 'Friends — there is food and drink in the fast
ship:

321 let us keep our hands off these cattle, or we
shall suffer for it.

322 These are the cattle and the strong flocks of a
terrible god —

323 Helios, who sees all things and hears all
things.'37

324 So I spoke, and their proud hearts consented.

325 Then for a whole month the South Wind blew
without let, and no other

326 wind rose after that, except the East and the
South.

327 As long as the men had bread and red wine,
328 they kept their hands from the cattle: they
wanted to live.

329 But when all the ship's provisions were spent,
330 and need drove them roaming after game —
331 fish, birds, whatever came to their dear hands

—

332 with bent hooks, while hunger wore their
bellies down,38

333 then I went away up the island, to pray
334 to the gods, in hope one might show me a
road home.

335 And when, crossing the island, I had left my
companions behind,

336 I washed my hands where there was shelter
from the wind

337 and prayed to all the gods who hold Olympus

—

338 and they poured sweet sleep upon my
eyelids.39

339 And Eurylochos began his evil counsel to the
companions:
340 'Hear my words, companions, for all your
suffering.
341 All deaths are hateful to wretched mortals —
342 but to die of hunger, and meet doom that way,
is the most pitiful.⁴⁰
343 Come then: let us drive off the best of the
cattle of Helios
344 and sacrifice them to the immortals who hold
wide heaven.
345 And if we come to Ithaca, our fathers' land,
346 we will build at once a rich temple to Helios
Hyperion
347 and set up in it fine offerings, many of them.
348 But if, in anger over his straight-horned
cattle, he wills
349 to destroy our ship, and the other gods go
with him —
350 I would rather gulp once at the wave and lose
my life⁴¹
351 than be starved slowly to death on a desert

island.’

352 So spoke Eurylochus, and the other
companions approved.

353 And at once they drove off the best of the
cattle of Helios,

354 from close by — for not far from the dark-
blue-prowed ship

355 the beautiful broad-browed crook-horned
cattle were grazing —

356 and they stood around them and prayed to
the gods,

357 plucking the tender leaves of a high-crowned
oak:42

358 for they had no white barley aboard the well-
benched ship.

359 And when they had prayed, and cut the
throats, and flayed,

360 they carved out the thigh-pieces and wrapped
them deep in fat,

361 folding it double, and laid raw flesh upon
them;

362 and they had no wine to pour over the blazing

offerings,

363 so they made libation with water, and roasted
all the entrails.

364 And when the thighs were burned through,
and they had tasted the innards,

365 they carved up the rest and threaded it on
spits.

366 Then it was that the deep sleep fled from my
eyelids,

367 and I went down to the fast ship and the shore
of the sea.

368 But as I came near the curved ship,

369 the sweet smell of the fat's smoke drifted all
around me,

370 and I groaned aloud, and cried out to the
deathless gods:

371 'Father Zeus, and you other blessed gods who
are forever —

372 it was for my ruin, then, that you laid me
down in that pitiless sleep,

373 while my companions, waiting, devised this
monstrous thing.'

374 Swiftly the word came to Helios Hyperion:
375 long-robed Lampetie brought it — that we had
killed his cattle.
376 And at once, with anger in his heart, he spoke
among the immortals:
377 ‘Father Zeus, and you other blessed gods who
are forever:
378 make them pay — the companions of
Odysseus, Laertes’ son —
379 who in their insolence have killed my cattle:
the cattle
380 I took my joy in, every day I climbed toward
the starry heaven
381 and every day I turned from heaven back
toward earth.
382 If they do not pay me a fitting price for the
cattle,
383 I will go down into Hades and shine among
the dead.’⁴³
384 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered
him:
385 ‘Helios — you shine on among the immortals,

surely,

386 and among mortal men across the grain-
giving plowland;

387 and as for those men: their fast ship I will
soon strike

388 with the white lightning, and shatter it to
splinters in the middle of the wine-dark sea.'

389 — This I heard afterward from fair-haired
Calypso;⁴⁴

390 and she said she heard it herself from Hermes
the guide. —

391 Now when I had come down to the ship and
the sea,

392 I went up and down and rebuked them, man
by man; but no remedy

393 could we find anywhere: the cattle were dead
already.

394 And soon the gods began to show forth
portents among the men:

395 the hides crawled; the meat on the spits was
lowing;⁴⁵

396 the roasted and the raw; and there rose a

sound as of cattle crying.

397 Six days after that my trusted companions
398 feasted on the cattle of Helios they had driven
off, the best of them;⁴⁶

399 but when Zeus the son of Cronos set the
seventh day upon us,

400 then at last the wind fell from its raging
squall,

401 and we boarded at once and stood out onto
the wide sea,

402 stepping the mast and hauling up the white
sails.

403 But when we had left the island behind, and
no other

404 land showed anywhere — only sky and sea —

405 then the son of Cronos set a dark-blue cloud

406 over the hollow ship, and the deep went black
beneath it.

407 And she ran on not much longer: for all at
once came the shrieking

408 West Wind, raging in a great squall,

409 and the storm-blast snapped both forestays of

the mast:

410 the mast toppled backward, and all its tackle
spilled

411 down into the bilge; and in the stern of the
ship the mast

412 struck the steersman's head, and crushed the
bones of the skull

413 all together; and like a diver he dropped47

414 from the half-deck, and his proud life left his
bones.

415 And Zeus thundered in the same instant, and
hurled his bolt into the ship,

416 and she shivered stem to stern, struck by the
bolt of Zeus,

417 and filled with the reek of sulfur; and the men
fell from the ship.

418 Like sea-crows around the black hull

419 they were carried off on the waves; and the
god took away their homecoming.48

420 But I kept moving through the ship, until the
surge

421 tore the sides loose from the keel, and the

wave carried her stripped bare,
422 and snapped the mast off at the keel. But over
the mast
423 the backstay had been flung — a thing made
of ox-hide;
424 with it I lashed the two together, keel and
mast,49
425 and settling myself on them, I was carried
before the deadly winds.
426 Then indeed the West Wind fell from its
raging squall,
427 but the South came fast in its place, bringing
anguish to my heart:
428 that I should measure back my way to deadly
Charybdis.
429 All night I was carried; and with the rising
sun
430 I came to Scylla's crag, and to dread
Charybdis.
431 She was gulping down the salt water of the
sea —
432 but I, swinging up high toward the tall fig

tree,

433 caught it and clung there like a bat. And there
was no way50

434 to plant my feet firm anywhere, no way to
climb it:

435 the roots were far below, and the branches
out of reach,

436 long and great boughs that shadowed
Charybdis.

437 I clung there without slackening, until she
should vomit back

438 the mast and keel again. And to my longing,
late,

439 they came: at the hour when a man rises from
the assembly for supper —51

440 the judge of many quarrels among
contending young men —

441 at that hour the timbers reappeared out of
Charybdis.

442 I let go, feet and hands, from above,

443 and dropped with a crash into the water
beyond the long timbers,

444 and settling on them, I rowed hard with my hands.

445 And Scylla — the father of men and gods did not let her52

446 see me again: I would not have slipped clear of sheer destruction.

447 From there I was carried nine days; and on the tenth, in the black night,

448 the gods brought me near the island Ogygia, where Calypso

449 lives, she of the lovely braids, the dread goddess with a mortal's voice,

450 and she loved me and cared for me. But why tell that tale over?53

451 Only yesterday I told it in this house — to you

452 and to your strong wife. And it is hateful to me

453 to tell a tale over again that has been told out plainly.”

Notes

NOTES

1. Aeaea is now located “where the house of early-born Dawn is, and her dancing-grounds, and the risings of the sun” — the uttermost East, though nothing in the voyage there had promised any such thing. The fairyland compass does not resolve: Circe is Helios’ daughter, so her island is wherever the sun gets up. Homer’s wanderings run on mythic adjacency, not bearings — which is why every attempt to chart them since antiquity has ended in the cartographer’s despair. ↩
2. Elpenor’s funeral, exactly as the ghost prescribed (11.74–78): burned with his armor, the mound, the pillar-stone — and the oar fixed on the very top. The promise of 11.80 kept to the letter, first thing, before Circe, before the road. It is the only funeral Odysseus ever conducts in the poem, performed for the least of his men. ↩
3. “Twice-dying” — *δισθανέες*, a word Circe appears to coin on the spot for men who will owe death two visits. Her greeting is the wanderings’ running theme in one syllable-cluster: Odysseus does everything twice — two Charybdis passages, two prophecy-briefings, two great sleeps, and death itself once in advance. ↩
4. The second briefing. Note the change of genre: Tiresias gave destiny (what must be), Circe gives pilotage (what to do about it) — wax, cords, course-choices, even the escape-clause prayer to Scylla’s mother. And at the fork she withdraws: “You yourself must weigh it in your heart.” The gods of this poem

brief; they do not decide. The deciding is what the hero is *for*.



5. The Sirens' setting is the poem's most economical horror: a flowering meadow, and in it "a great heap of the bones of rotting men, and the skins are shriveling on them." No claws, no cave — just the voice, the flowers, and what remains of the audience. The listeners stayed; that is the entire mechanism. Note that no appearance is ever described: the Sirens are the one monster in the Odyssey who are only sound. ↩
6. "But you yourself — listen, if you will": the arrangement is Circe's gift to *his* curiosity, unasked. She knows her man: he will want the song, so she engineers a way to have it without dying of it — desire licensed under restraint, the whole Odysseus-problem solved in ship's tackle. The image of the bound listener has been philosophy's property ever since; the poem invented it as seamanship. ↩
7. Even Zeus' ambrosia-doves pay a toll of one to the Wandering Rocks, "and the Father sends in another to keep the number full." Heaven's own supply line runs on attrition and replacement — a two-line glimpse of cosmic bookkeeping, casually terrifying. ↩
8. "Argo, whom all minds know" — Ἀργὸν πᾶσι μέλουσα: Homer cites another epic as universally famous in three words, the oldest literary cross-reference in Greek. The Argonaut saga (Aeetes, Jason, Hera's patronage) is assumed knowledge; the Odyssey positions its own route one island over from a rival poem's — and sends its hero the *other* way. ↩

9. Scylla's voice "is no more than a newborn puppy's" — the Greek puns her name on σκύλαξ, *puppy*. A six-headed devourer that whimpers like something you would pick up and hold: the mismatch of sound and thing is the horror, in a poem whose last monster was all voice and honey. ↩
10. The anatomy is exact and unvisualizable — twelve dangling feet, six enormously long necks, triple rows of teeth "full of black death," body sunk waist-deep in rock. She is a fishing creature; men are simply the largest catch that passes. The bowshot-wide strait with a monster on each side is the poem's geometry of the unchoosable — and she takes one man per head, a tax collected in sixes. ↩
11. Charybdis under her fig tree: not a creature at all but a schedule — three times a day, down and up. Scylla is appetite with heads; Charybdis is pure physics. Between a predator you can count and a tide you cannot, Circe's seamanship is unsentimental: choose the one that takes six, not everything. ↩
12. "Far better to mourn six companions from your ship than all together": the coldest sentence of command in the poem, handed to him in advance by a goddess. The captain sails the strait already carrying the arithmetic — and the poem lets us watch him pay it out in real men at 245–250. ↩
13. His reflex — *can I fight her?* — draws Circe's exasperated diagnosis: "So even now your heart is set on the works of war... Will you not yield even to the deathless gods?" The last time anyone called him σχέτλιος like this it was Achilles' ghost

(11.474). The Iliadic reflex is the one thing ten years of sea have not washed out of him. ↩

14. “To flee her is the best courage” — φυγέειν κάρτιστον: flight as the superlative of strength. No sentence in the poem is less Iliadic; it is the wanderings’ whole revaluation of heroism in four words. ↩

15. Crataeis — “Force” — is Scylla’s mother, invocable to call her daughter off. Even the unfightable has a parent who can be petitioned: the poem’s world remains, to the last monster, a web of families. ↩

16. Seven herds of fifty, seven flocks of fifty: 350 cattle and 350 sheep, breeding never, dying never. Ancient readers did the sum and saw the days of the lunar year in each — the cattle of the Sun as the sun’s own calendar, guarded by daughters named Shining (Phaethusa) and Radiant (Lampetie). To eat them is to eat time itself; the allegory was already old when Aristotle heard it, and the poem neither confirms nor forbids it. ↩

17. Circe’s Thrinacia warning repeats Tiresias’ prophecy nearly verbatim (11.110–115), and the translation repeats with it. The two authorities of the two worlds — the dead seer, the deathless witch — issue one text. No event in the poem is more thoroughly notarized in advance than the crew’s destruction. ↩

18. He briefs the crew in the name of shared knowledge — “it is not right that one man only, or two, should know” — and tells them the Sirens in full... and Scylla not at all (223–225). Full disclosure as principle, censorship as practice, each defended

in its place: the captain manages truth like any other ration. The poem hands us both passages sixty-nine lines apart and lets us do the ethics ourselves. ↩

19. The wind dies at the Sirens' island — “some power lulled the waves to sleep.” The becalming is the trap's velvet: silence so total the song will be the only sound on the sea. Rowing into it, the men whiten still water while their captain kneads the wax soft. ↩
20. The wax warms under “my great strength... and the beam of the lord Helios” — the sun himself, whose cattle will destroy this crew, here helps seal their ears. The gods lend their forces indifferently; the poem notes the courtesy without comment. ↩
21. The Song. They address him “much-praised Odysseus, great glory of the Achaeans” — μέγα κῦδος Ἀχαιῶν, the honorific otherwise reserved for Nestor (3.79): the Sirens speak flawless epic diction, and their opening move is his own fame recited back to him. For this hero the fatal bait is not flesh but *renown and information* — they offer Troy complete (the war he cannot stop weeping over in Books 8's songs) plus omniscience: “all that comes to pass on the nourishing earth.” The Sirens are epic poetry weaponized — the song of kleos with the homecoming subtracted. The bone-meadow is an audience that never left the recital. ↩
22. “He has his delight of it, and goes his way knowing more” — the Sirens' prospectus is a lie with a true clause: the delight is real, the going-away is not. Odysseus, bound, becomes the single

exception that proves their sales-pitch: the only man who did hear and did leave — knowing more. ↩

23. The system absorbs its designed failure: he signals with his brows to be freed (the same brow-signal that commanded silence at 9.468), and Perimedes and Eurylochus — *acting on his own prior orders* — add rope. Ulysses bound is the West's founding image of precommitment: the self that plans outranking the self that wants. The poem states it without a word of theory: they rowed; they bound; they passed. ↩
24. The heartening speech runs on the captain's résumé: "no greater evil than the Cyclops... and even from there, by my prowess and my counsel and my mind, we escaped." True — and edited: the cave was also entered by his curiosity and signed with the boast that bought Poseidon's curse. Command rhetoric curates the past; the poem, having shown us the whole ledger, lets the speech work anyway. "Someday, I think, we will remember this one too" echoes his own 20-year brand of consolation — memory as the promised land beyond every horror. ↩
25. The withheld briefing: Scylla is edited out "for fear my companions... might pack themselves into the hold." Six men will die unwarned. Militarily impeccable, morally unresolved — and narrated by the man himself years later without apology or defense, which is its own kind of confession. ↩
26. "Circe's hard command... I let it slip from my mind": he arms anyway, two spears, up on the foredeck, scanning rock. The one order the man cannot obey is *don't fight* — the armor is useless, the enemy never shows herself to him, and the poem

lets his obsolete magnificence stand there in full bronze,
watching the wrong monster. ↩

27. Charybdis as kitchen-physics: a cauldron over a great fire, seething to the rim — then the gulp, and “at the bottom the earth showed, dark-blue with sand.” The seafloor exposed is the sea turned inside out — the one sight sailors are never meant to see; the pale terror (χλωρόν δέος, the Nekyia’s own fear-formula) is its correct price. ↩
28. The trap’s true mechanism: “We looked to her” — all eyes on the spectacle of Charybdis — “and that was when Scylla snatched...” Attention itself is the toll. The strait charges you six men for looking at the wrong danger, exactly as Circe’s geometry promised. ↩
29. “They cried out and called to me by name — for the last time.” His name — the thing he boasted to the Cyclops, the thing the Sirens sang — is the last word of six men being lifted into a mouth. The poem’s economy of the name closes its darkest circuit here. ↩
30. The angler simile: a fisherman on a rock, long rod, ox-horn line-guard, flinging the little fish “gasping onto the land.” The men are the little fish; the tackle is described with a professional’s precision; the scale is the cruelty. It is the Laestrygonian image (men speared like fish, 10.124) miniaturized and made leisurely — slaughter at the tempo of a pastime. Homer’s similes keep domesticating his horrors, and that is what makes them unbearable. ↩
31. “The most pitiful thing my eyes ever looked on of all I suffered searching out the pathways of the sea.” The superlative of ten

years — awarded not to Polyphemus or Hades but to six pairs of reaching hands. The teller ranks his own griefs, and the ranking is the man. ↩

32. He hears the cattle while still at sea — “the lowing of cattle being folded” carries over water — and the prophecy lands on his heart in the same instant. For once fore-knowledge and temptation arrive together, sound first: Thrinacia is audible doom, as the Sirens were audible desire. ↩
33. Eurylochus’ “you are made of iron” speech is mutiny with a case: the men are exhausted, night passages kill ships, the winds born of darkness are real (“wreckers of ships” is sound pilotage). The poem gives the rebellion its best arguments — rest tonight, sail at dawn — and then lets the weather, not the logic, spring the trap: the dawn that was promised brings a month of imprisoning wind. ↩
34. “Out of the nights are born the hard winds”: a genuine sailor’s proverb doing the work of rhetoric. Everything Eurylochus says is true; that is what makes the scene tragedy rather than folly. Odysseus yields to a sound argument — and knows, in the same breath, that “some power was plotting evils.” ↩
35. “You force my hand: I am one man alone” — βιάζετε μῶνον ἑόντα: command’s arithmetic stated plainly, one against a crew. The oath he extracts is the only instrument left to a captain outvoted; it will hold exactly as long as the food does. ↩
36. The oath’s key word is the proem’s: ἀτασθαλίῃσι — let no man “in his evil recklessness” kill a cow. The poem’s opening indictment (1.7: they perished by their own recklessness) is

here written into a sworn contract, in advance, in the perpetrator's hearing. When they break it, they break it under its proper name. ↩

37. His warning ends on the surveillance formula: "Helios, who sees all things and hears all things" (= 11.109). On an island owned by total observation, the crew will wait for the captain to fall asleep — as if the only eye were his. ↩

38. Bent hooks, birds, "whatever came to their dear hands," hunger wearing the belly — the stranded-crew cluster shared with Menelaus' men on Pharos (4.368–369), its closing line word for word. The apologoi keep meeting the Telemachy's stories at the seams: same sea, same hunger, same grammar. ↩

39. The fatal sleep again. Aeolus' bag within sight of home; now Thrinacia; the pattern is exact — catastrophe enters only when his vigilance lapses, and the lapse is always bodily, blameless, human. "It was for my ruin that you laid me down" (372): he reads his sleep as the gods' instrument, and the poem does not correct him. A hero whose weakness is not pride or lust but the simple need to close his eyes: that is the Odyssey's realism about limits. ↩

40. Eurylochus' second speech is the belly-doctrine turned catechism: "all deaths are hateful, but to die of hunger is the most pitiful." It is Odysseus' own theology (7.216: nothing more dog-shameless than the belly) recited by the mutineer to justify the unforgivable. The poem built its hero's materialism carefully for five books precisely so this speech would be irrefutable in his own terms. ↩

41. “I would rather gulp once at the wave and lose my life than be starved slowly” — the sailor’s ranking of deaths, and a wish the poem grants with horrible precision: he will get exactly that death, mouth open at the wave, within the week. In the *Odyssey*, stated preferences about dying are always heard by someone. ↩
42. The sacrilege is performed as scrupulous ritual with every material wrong: oak leaves for barley, water for wine, prayers over stolen victims, a temple vowed from the proceeds. Form perfect, substance inverted — piety’s grammar spoken in theft. The poem’s most detailed sacrifice scene after Nestor’s (3.430ff.) is this parody of it; the two scenes are each other’s mirror at ten books’ distance. ↩
43. Helios’ threat: “I will go down into Hades and shine among the dead.” Four words from a minor god, and the cosmos tilts: the sun proposes to invert the universe — light for the dead, darkness for the living — unless compensated. Zeus’ answer is a settlement (keep shining; I’ll handle it), and the affair closes like a lawsuit between great houses: the thunderbolt as damages. ↩
44. “This I heard afterward from fair-haired Calypso; and she said she heard it herself from Hermes the guide.” Unique in Homer: the narrator cites his sources — for an Olympian conversation he could not have witnessed, a two-link chain of transmission is produced on the spot. The apologist’s one gesture of documentation is also its quietest boast: the rest, we are to take it, he saw — though the oath-taking and the sacrilege on Thrinacia he tells us himself he slept through. Storytelling inventing source criticism, in the middle of the *Bronze Age*. ↩

45. The portents: “the hides crawled; the meat on the spits was lowing, the roasted and the raw.” The uncanniest lines in Homer — the meal refusing to become food, the sacrilege bellowing from the fire. And the sentence that follows is the true horror: “Six days after that my trusted companions feasted.” Not one meal in madness — six days of eating meat that cries. The crew’s doom is not a lapse but a persistence. ↩
46. “The best of them” — even in cataloguing the sin, the connoisseur’s precision: they stole the *best* cattle. The poem’s fair-division captain (9.42, 549) reports the crime with the same bookkeeping he brought to the loot. ↩
47. The steersman dies “like a diver” — the man of steering dropped head-first from his post, his craft converted in one simile to falling gracefully. It is the poem’s last professional death: the storm kills the helmsman first, then the ship. ↩
48. “The god took away their homecoming” — the proem’s exact clause (1.9: “the god took from them their day of homecoming”), executed at last, twelve books later, on the men the proem indicted in its seventh line. The sea-crows simile gives the crew their final form: small dark birds around a black hull, then nothing. Every death the poem promised in its first ten lines has now been delivered. ↩
49. Keel and mast lashed with the ox-hide backstay: the raft of Book 5 anticipated at its absolute minimum — two timbers and a strap, rigged in a breaking sea by the man who built a twenty-tree vessel with axe and auger. Craft scales down to whatever is left; that is its definition. ↩

50. Hanging “like a bat” from the fig tree over Charybdis — feet unable to reach, branches too high, roots too far — while she digests his raft. The greatest survivor in literature spends the crisis as a small nocturnal animal, waiting. Endurance here is not muscle but grip and timing. ↩
51. The judge simile: the timbers resurface “at the hour when a man rises from the assembly for supper — the judge of many quarrels among contending young men.” Time told by a magistrate’s working day, cited by a naked man clinging over a whirlpool at the edge of the world. The poem’s clocks are all civic and agricultural (the plowman’s supper, the mule-furrow, the shout) — the wanderer measures even the abyss in units of the ordered human town he is trying to get back to. It is the most homesick simile in the poem. ↩
52. Zeus hides him from Scylla — the Father’s single direct intervention in all the wanderings, one line, unexplained. The poem’s theology in miniature: named mercy, unnamed motive. ↩
53. The ending: “But why tell that tale over? Only yesterday I told it in this house... it is hateful to me to tell a tale over again that has been told out plainly.” The four-book performance closes with the performer’s professional ethic — no encores of finished material — and with the ring sealed exactly where Book 7’s short account began: Calypso. The joke underneath is exquisite: the most repetition-built poem in existence ends its greatest recital by declaring repetition hateful. The singer knows the difference between formula, which is architecture, and retelling, which is padding — and so does Homer, who now

takes the poem back from his hero. The wanderings are over;
every subsequent mile is Ithaca's. ↩

Odyssey — Book 13

*The sending home; the ship turned to stone; Athena and
Odysseus on Ithaca.*

- 1 So he spoke; and they were all hushed in
silence,¹
- 2 held fast under the spell, through the shadowy
halls.
- 3 Then Alcinous answered him in turn, and said:
- 4 “Odysseus — now that you have come to my
house with its floor of bronze,
- 5 its high roof, I do not think you will be driven
wandering
- 6 back again as you return, however much you
have suffered.
- 7 And to each man of you I say this, laying it on
you —
- 8 you who in my halls forever drink the elders’
fire-bright
- 9 wine, and listen to the singer:

10 clothing for the guest lies packed already in
the polished chest,
11 with gold of intricate work and all the other
12 gifts the counselors of the Phaeacians brought
him here.
13 Come now, let us give him besides a great
tripod and a cauldron,
14 each man of us; and we in turn will gather it
back from the people:
15 it is hard on one man to give so freely without
repayment.”²
16 So spoke Alcinous, and his word pleased them
well,
17 and they went home to sleep, each man to his
own house.
18 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,
19 they hurried to the ship, carrying the bronze
that does honor to a man,
20 and the sacred strength of Alcinous stowed it
well,
21 going himself through the ship, under the

benches, so that it might not

22 hamper any of the crew at the rowing, when
they leaned to the oars.

23 Then they went to the house of Alcinous and
saw to the feast.

24 For them the sacred strength of Alcinous
slaughtered an ox

25 to Zeus of the black cloud, the son of Cronos,
lord of all.

26 They burned the thigh-cuts and shared the
glorious feast,

27 rejoicing; and among them sang the godlike
singer,

28 Demodocus, honored among the people. But
Odysseus

29 kept turning his head toward the blazing sun,3

30 willing it to set: for now his whole heart
strained toward home.

31 As when a man aches for his supper — all day
long4

32 his two wine-dark oxen have dragged the
jointed plow through fallow ground,

33 and welcome to him is the setting of the sun's
light,
34 the going home to supper, and his knees
buckle as he walks:
35 so welcome to Odysseus was the setting of the
sun's light.
36 At once he spoke among the oar-loving
Phaeacians,
37 and to Alcinous above all he declared his word:
38 "Lord Alcinous, most renowned among all
peoples:
39 pour the offering, and send me on my way
unharméd. And yourselves — farewell.
40 For now all that my own heart wished is
brought to pass:
41 a sending, and gifts of friendship. May the gods
of heaven
42 make them a blessing! And may I come home
and find my blameless wife⁵
43 there, with those I love unharméd.
44 And you who stay: may you be the joy of your
wedded wives

45 and of your children; and may the gods grant
prosperity
46 of every kind, and no evil come to dwell among
your people.”
47 So he spoke, and they all approved it and urged
48 that the guest be sent home, since he had
spoken rightly.
49 And then the strength of Alcinous said to the
herald:
50 “Pontonous, mix the bowl, and serve out the
wine
51 to all in the hall, so that with a prayer to father
Zeus
52 we may send the guest to his own fatherland.”
53 So he spoke, and Pontonous mixed the honey-
hearted wine
54 and served it to all in turn; and they poured to
the blessed
55 gods who hold wide heaven, there where each
man
56 sat. But noble Odysseus rose to his feet
57 and set the two-handled cup in Arete’s hand,

58 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to her:

59 “Fare well, my queen, through all the years,
until old age

60 comes, and death, which stand over every one of us.

61 I go now. And you — have joy of this house,

62 of your children and your people and Alcinous the king.”

63 So speaking, noble Odysseus stepped across the threshold,

64 and the strength of Alcinous sent the herald with him

65 to lead him to the fast ship and the shore of the sea;

66 and Arete sent slave-women along with him,

67 one carrying a fresh-washed mantle and a tunic,

68 another she sent to bring the close-packed chest,

69 and a third carried bread and red wine.

70 And when they had come down to the ship and

the sea,

71 the lordly escorts took it all at once and stowed
it

72 in the hollow ship, all the food and drink;

73 and for Odysseus they spread a blanket and a
linen sheet

74 on the half-deck of the hollow ship, so that he
might sleep

75 unwaking, at the stern. And he came aboard
himself and lay down

76 in silence. And they took their places at the
oarlocks, each in

77 order, and loosed the cable from the pierced
stone.

78 And the moment they leaned back and tossed
the sea with the oar-blade,

79 that moment sweet sleep fell upon his eyelids
—7

80 unwaking, sweetest sleep, and most like death.

81 And the ship — as on the plain a team of four
stallions⁸

82 springs forward all together under the lash's

strokes,

83 and rearing high they swiftly accomplish their
road:

84 so her stern reared and plunged, and behind
her the great

85 dark-gleaming wave of the loud-roaring sea
rushed on.

86 And she ran sure and steady, never yielding:
not even the hawk

87 could have kept beside her, the falcon,
nimblest of winged things.

88 So running lightly she cut the waves of the sea,

89 carrying a man with counsels like the gods' —

90 a man who before had suffered pains in plenty,
heart-deep,

91 cutting through wars of men and the grinding
waves,

92 and who now slept without a tremor, all he had
suffered forgotten.9

93 When the brightest of stars was rising, the one
that comes

94 above all others announcing the light of early-

born Dawn,

95 then the seagoing ship was drawing near the island.

96 There is a harbor of Phorcys, the old man of the sea,10

97 in the land of Ithaca: two jutting headlands in it,

98 sheer on the seaward side but sloping down toward harbor,

99 which shelter it from the great waves the hard-blowing winds raise

100 outside; and within, the well-benched ships ride

101 without a mooring-line, once they have reached anchoring-ground.

102 At the head of the harbor is a long-leafed olive,

103 and near it a lovely cave, full of sea-mist,

104 sacred to the nymphs that men call Naiads.

105 In it are mixing-bowls and two-handled jars

106 of stone; and there the bees lay up their honey.

107 And in it are long looms of stone, where the
nymphs
108 weave cloth of sea-purple, a wonder to see;
109 and ever-flowing waters. It has two doors:11
110 one toward the North Wind, by which men
come down;
111 the other, toward the South, is for the gods: by
that way
112 men do not enter — it is the immortals' road.
113 In there they rowed, knowing the place of old.
And the ship
114 ran up on the shore a full half of her length,
115 at speed: such was the drive of the rowers'
arms.
116 And they stepped from the well-benched ship
onto dry land,
117 and first they lifted Odysseus out of the hollow
ship,
118 linen sheet and shining blanket and all,
119 and laid him down on the sand, still mastered
by sleep;12
120 and they lifted out the goods that the lordly

Phaeacians

121 had given him for his journey home, through
the grace of great-hearted Athena.

122 These they set in a heap by the trunk of the
olive,

123 out of the path, for fear some passer-by

124 might come and pillage them before Odysseus
woke;

125 and they themselves set off for home again.

But the shaker of earth

126 had not forgotten the threats he had made at
the first

127 against godlike Odysseus; and he asked out the
design of Zeus:

128 “Father Zeus, I shall have honor no longer
among the deathless

129 gods, when mortals honor me not at all —

130 the Phaeacians, who are of my very own
line.13

131 I said just now that Odysseus should suffer
evils in plenty

132 before he came home — his homecoming

itself I never

133 wholly denied him, once you had promised it
and bowed your head —

134 and look: they have carried him sleeping over
the sea in their fast ship

135 and set him down in Ithaca, and given him
gifts past speaking,

136 bronze and gold in heaps and woven clothing,

137 more than Odysseus would ever have carried
out of Troy¹⁴

138 had he come home untouched with his fair
share of the spoils.”

139 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered
him:

140 “Shame on you, wide-ruling shaker of earth —
what a thing to say.

141 The gods do not dishonor you: it would be a
hard thing

142 to pelt our eldest and best with dishonor.

143 As for men — if any man, yielding to his own
force and power,

144 fails to honor you, vengeance is yours, now

and always after.

145 Do as you will: whatever is dear to your heart.”

146 Then Poseidon the earth-shaker answered him:

147 “I would have done it at once, lord of the black cloud, as you say;

148 but I always shrink before your anger, and I avoid it.

149 Now, then: that beautiful ship of the Phaeacians,

150 coming home over the misted sea from her sending —

151 I will smash her, so that they hold off at last and cease

152 their escorting of men; and I will pile a great mountain round their city.”

153 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered him:

154 “Friend — hear how it seems best to my own mind.15

155 When all the people are watching her from

the city

156 as she drives in, turn her to stone close
offshore —

157 a stone in the likeness of a fast ship, so that all
mankind

158 may marvel; and pile the great mountain
round their city.”

159 And when Poseidon the earth-shaker heard it,

160 he went his way to Scheria, where the
Phaeacians are born and bred,

161 and there he waited. And she came close in,
the seagoing ship,

162 running lightly on. And the shaker of earth
came near her,

163 and turned her to stone, and rooted her to the
sea-floor

164 with one downward stroke of the flat of his
hand. And he was gone.

165 And they spoke to one another with winged
words,

166 the Phaeacians of the long oars, men famed
for ships;

167 and thus one would say, with a glance at his
neighbor:

168 “Ah me — who has shackled our fast ship on
the open sea

169 as she drove for home — in full view, every
timber of her?”**16**

170 So they would say — knowing nothing of how
it had been done.

171 And Alcinous addressed them all, and said:

172 “Ah, then it comes home to me — the old
prophecy**17**

173 of my father, who would tell us that Poseidon
looked on us with anger

174 because we are safe escorts of all men without
distinction.

175 He said that one day, as a beautiful ship of the
Phaeacian men

176 came home over the misted sea from such a
sending,

177 the god would smash her, and pile a great
mountain round our city.

178 So the old man said. And now it is all being

accomplished.

179 Come then — all of us — do exactly as I say:

180 cease your escorting of mortals, whoever
comes

181 to our city hereafter; and to Poseidon let us
sacrifice

182 twelve chosen bulls, in hope he may take pity

183 and not pile the long mountain round our
city.”

184 So he spoke; and they were afraid, and made
the bulls ready.

185 So they were praying to the lord Poseidon,

186 the leaders and counselors of the land of the
Phaeacians,

187 standing around the altar.18 — And noble
Odysseus woke

188 out of sleep in his own fathers’ land — and did
not know it,

189 so long had he been gone. For the goddess had
poured a mist around him,

190 Pallas Athena, daughter of Zeus, so that she
might make him

191 unknowable to all, and tell him everything
through,
192 lest his wife should know him, and his
townsmen, and his friends,
193 before the suitors paid for all their trespass.19
194 And so to their lord all things showed strange

—

195 the long straight paths, the anchorages that
take ships from every wind,
196 the sheer-climbing rocks and the trees in full
leaf.
197 He sprang up and stood, and stared at his own
fatherland,
198 and then he groaned aloud, and struck both
thighs
199 with the flats of his hands, and spoke in raw
lament:
200 “Ah me — whose country have I come to now?
What men’s?20
201 Are they violent, savage, without justice,
202 or kind to strangers, with hearts that fear the
gods?

203 Where am I to carry all this treasure? Where
am I myself

204 to wander? Would it had stayed with the
Phaeacians, all of it,

205 there where it was — and I had come to some
other mighty king,

206 who would have hosted me kindly and sent
me on my way home.

207 As it is, I have nowhere to put it — and I will
not leave it

208 here, to fall as plunder to other men.

209 Shame on them — not righteous through and
through, then, and not just,

210 the leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians,

211 who carried me off to a strange country! They
said, truly,

212 they would bring me to clear-skied Ithaca —
and did not do it.

213 May Zeus of Suppliants pay them for it, who
watches over

214 all mankind, and punishes whoever goes
astray.

215 But come — let me count my goods and look
them over,21
216 in case they carried something off with them
in the hollow ship.”
217 So speaking he counted up the surpassingly
beautiful tripods
218 and the cauldrons, and the gold, and the fine
woven clothing —
219 and missed not one thing. Then, mourning for
his fatherland,
220 he crept along the shore of the loud-roaring
sea,
221 grieving without pause. And Athena came
near him
222 in the likeness of a young man, a herder of
sheep,22
223 delicate-skinned, such as the sons of kings
are,
224 a fine-made double cloak hanging from her
shoulders,
225 sandals under her shining feet, a javelin in
her hand.

226 Odysseus rejoiced at the sight of her, and
came to meet her,
227 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to
her:
228 “Friend — since you are the first I meet in this
country,
229 hail to you! And may you come at me with no
evil purpose:
230 save these things, and save me. To you as to a
god
231 I pray, and I come to your knees in
supplication.
232 And tell me this too, honestly, so that I may
know it:
233 what land is this? what people? what men are
born here?
234 Is it some clear-skied island — or is it a
headland
235 of the rich-soiled mainland, shelving down
into the sea?”
236 Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-
eyed Athena:

237 “You are a fool, stranger — or you have come
from far away —23

238 if you ask about this land. It is not so very

239 nameless as all that: very many men know
her,

240 both all who live toward the dawn and the
sun

241 and all who live back westward, toward the
misty dark.

242 Rough she is, truly — no ground for driving
horses —

243 yet not too poor a land, though no wide one
either:

244 grain grows in her past speaking, and wine as
well,

245 and the rain never fails her, or the fresh dew;

246 good pasture she is for goats and cattle; there
is timber

247 of every kind, and watering-places that flow
the year round.

248 And so, stranger, the name of Ithaca has
reached even to Troy —24

249 and that, they say, lies far from this Achaeon
land.”

250 So she spoke; and much-enduring noble
Odysseus was glad,

251 rejoicing in the land of his fathers, at the word
252 of Pallas Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing
Zeus.

253 And lifting his voice he spoke winged words
to her —

254 yet he did not speak the truth: he swallowed
the word back down, 25

255 forever steering, in his breast, the mind of
many profits:

256 “I heard tell of Ithaca even in wide Crete,

257 far over the sea. And now I have come here
myself

258 with all this treasure — and left as much again
for my children —

259 a fugitive: for I killed the dear son of
Idomeneus,

260 Orsilochus the swift-footed, who in wide
Crete

261 outran all bread-eating men with his quick
feet.
262 He meant to strip me of all my Trojan
plunder,
263 the winnings I had suffered pains for, heart-
deep,
264 cutting through wars of men and the grinding
waves —
265 all because I would not oblige his father and
serve
266 under him at Troy, but led my own command.
267 So I struck him with my bronze-tipped spear
as he came in
268 from the fields — lay in ambush by the road
with one companion.
269 Black night held the sky that night: no living
soul
270 saw us; I took his life unseen.
271 And when I had cut him down with the sharp
bronze,
272 I went straight to a ship of the lordly
Phoenicians

273 and begged their grace, and gave them
plunder to content their hearts:

274 I asked them to take me aboard and set me
down at Pylos,

275 or at shining Elis, where the Epeians hold
power.

276 But the wind's force beat them off that course

—

277 much against their will: they had no wish to
cheat me —

278 and driven wide, we came here in the night.

279 We rowed hard into the harbor, and not one
of us

280 had a thought of supper, hungry for it as we
were:

281 we simply stepped ashore, all of us, and lay
down as we landed.

282 Then sweet sleep came over me, worn out as I
was,

283 and they lifted my goods out of the hollow
ship

284 and set them down where I myself lay on the

sands,

285 and boarded, and went off toward well-
peopled Sidon —

286 and I was left behind, my heart aching.”

287 So he spoke; and the goddess smiled, gray-
eyed Athena, 26

288 and stroked him with her hand — and now
her body was a woman’s,

289 beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious
handwork —

290 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words
to him:

291 “A sharp one he would have to be, a master-
thief, to slip past you 27

292 in all your manifold tricks — even a god, if
one should meet you.

293 You hard man — shifting-crafted, glutton for
guile — so not even

294 here, in your own country, would you leave
off the cheating

295 and the thieving tales that are dear to you
from the ground of your heart!

296 But come, no more of this now. We are both
old hands
297 at profit: you are far the best of all mortal
men
298 in counsel and in words, and I among all the
gods
299 am famed for cunning and for profit. And yet
you did not know
300 Pallas Athena, daughter of Zeus — I who
stand
301 beside you in every labor, always, and keep
watch over you,
302 and who made you dear to all the Phaeacians.
303 Now I have come here to weave a design with
you,**28**
304 and to hide the goods the lordly Phaeacians
305 gave you for your journey home — by my own
thought and counsel —
306 and to tell you all the cares that fate must fill
307 your well-built house with. You must endure
them — there is no choice —
308 and tell no one, no man and no woman,

309 none of them all, that it is you, come home
from your wandering. No:

310 in silence suffer your many pains, and submit
to men's violence."

311 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

312 "Hard it is, goddess, for a mortal man who
meets you to know you,29

313 however knowing he be: for you take what
likeness you will.

314 This I know well — that you were kind to me
once,

315 as long as we sons of the Achaeans made war
at Troy;

316 but after we had sacked Priam's steep city,

317 and gone to our ships, and a god scattered the
Achaeans,

318 from then on I never saw you, daughter of
Zeus — never marked you

319 setting foot on my ship to beat some grief
away from me.

320 No: I wandered on, always carrying a heart

torn open

321 in my breast, until the gods released me from
evil —

322 until that day, in the rich land of the
Phaeacian men,

323 when you heartened me with your words, and
led me to the city yourself.

324 Now I beg you by your father — for I cannot
think

325 I have truly come to clear-skied Ithaca: it is
some other

326 country I am turned loose in, and you are
mocking me

327 when you tell me this, to lead my wits astray
—

328 tell me: am I really come to my own dear
fatherland?"

329 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed
Athena:

330 "Always the same — that mind in your
breast!30

331 And that is why I cannot forsake you in your

misery:

332 because you are civil, and quick-witted, and
steady-souled.

333 Gladly would any other man, come home
from wandering,

334 have rushed to his hall to see his children and
his wife;

335 but you — you have no wish yet to learn or to
ask

336 until you have made trial of your wife besides
— who sits

337 as ever in your halls, and always in misery

338 her nights waste away, and her days, in
tears.**31**

339 I, though — I never doubted it: I knew in my
heart

340 you would come home with all your
companions lost.

341 But I had no mind, you see, to fight Poseidon,

342 my father's brother, who set the grudge in his
heart,

343 raging because you blinded his dear son.

344 Come — I will show you the ground-plan of
Ithaca, so you will believe.

345 This is the harbor of Phorcys, the old man of
the sea;³²

346 and this, at the head of the harbor, the long-
leafed olive;

347 and near it the lovely cave, full of sea-mist,

348 sacred to the nymphs that men call Naiads —

349 there is the wide vaulted cavern where you
used to offer

350 the nymphs so many perfect hecatombs;

351 and this is the mountain Neriton, clothed in
its forest.”

352 So speaking, the goddess scattered the mist —
and the land showed plain.

353 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus rejoiced

—

354 he exulted in his own land, and kissed the
grain-giving earth;³³

355 and at once he prayed to the nymphs, lifting
up his hands:

356 “Nymphs of the springs, daughters of Zeus — I

told myself

357 I would never see you again. Now take my
greeting

358 and my gentle prayers. And we will give you
gifts, as in the old days,

359 if the daughter of Zeus, the driver of spoils, in
her grace

360 lets me live, and brings my dear son to his
manhood.”

361 Then the goddess spoke to him again, gray-
eyed Athena:

362 “Take heart: let none of that weigh on your
mind.

363 Rather let us stow the goods in the innermost
hollow of the wondrous

364 cave, this instant, so that they stay there safe
for you;

365 and let us two take counsel how the best may
come about.”

366 So speaking, the goddess plunged into the
misty cave,

367 searching along its hiding-holes; and

Odysseus

368 carried everything close in — the gold, the
wear-proof bronze,

369 and the well-made clothing the Phaeacians
gave him.

370 He laid them carefully by; and a stone was set
at the door

371 by Pallas Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing
Zeus.34

372 Then the two of them sat down at the trunk of
the sacred olive35

373 and plotted death for the overweening
suitors.

374 And the goddess began to speak, gray-eyed
Athena:

375 “Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices —

376 consider how you will lay your hands on the
shameless suitors,

377 who for three years now have lorded it
through your hall,

378 courting your godlike wife and offering bride-

gifts;³⁶

³⁷⁹ and she — grieving without pause for your
homecoming, heart-deep,

³⁸⁰ gives hope to all, and makes promises to
every man,

³⁸¹ sending out messages — while her mind wills
otherwise.”³⁷

³⁸² Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

³⁸³ “Ah, gods — so I was to have perished by the
same evil doom

³⁸⁴ as Agamemnon, Atreus’ son, in my own halls,

³⁸⁵ had you not told me each thing rightly,
goddess, in its measure.

³⁸⁶ Come then — weave a design, how I shall pay
them back;³⁸

³⁸⁷ and stand beside me yourself, breathing bold
fury into me,

³⁸⁸ as on the day we loosed the shining head-veil
of Troy.³⁹

³⁸⁹ Were you to stand by me with that same fire,
gray-eyes,

390 I would fight three hundred men together —
391 with you, sovereign goddess, when you choose
in your heart to help me.”

392 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed
Athena:

393 “Oh, I will be with you — be sure of it — you
will not slip my sight

394 when the hour comes and we are at this work.
And more than one, I think,

395 of the suitor-men who eat away your living

396 will spatter the vast floor with his blood and
brains.40

397 But come: I will make you unknowable to
every mortal.

398 I will wither the fine skin on your supple
limbs;

399 I will strip the fair hair from your head; I will
wrap you in rags

400 such that a man would shudder to see a
human being wear;

401 and I will dim those eyes, so beautiful before,

402 so that you seem a vile thing to all the suitors

—

403 and to your wife, and to the son you left in
your halls.41

404 And you yourself: go first of all to the
swineherd,

405 the keeper of your pigs — whose heart is loyal
to you all the same,

406 who loves your boy, and steady-hearted
Penelope.

407 You will find him sitting by the swine; and
they are at pasture

408 by the Rock of the Raven, at the spring
Arethusa,42

409 eating acorns to their hearts' content and
drinking

410 black water — the things that feed the rich fat
on swine.

411 Stay there; sit by him and question him of
everything,

412 while I go on to Sparta, the country of
beautiful women,

413 to summon Telemachus — your own dear son,

Odysseus —

414 who went to wide-dancing-grounded

Lacedaemon, to Menelaus,

415 seeking news of you, whether you were still
alive anywhere.”

416 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

417 “Why did you not tell him, then — you whose
mind holds everything?43

418 So that he too might wander in misery over
the barren

419 sea, while other men eat away his living?”

420 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed
Athena:

421 “Do not let him weigh too heavily on your
heart.

422 I myself was his escort, so that he might win
himself

423 a good report by going there. He has no
hardship — he sits

424 at his ease in the house of Atreus’ son, with
plenty before him.

425 True — the young men lie in ambush for him
with their black ship,44

426 hungry to kill him before he reaches his
fathers' land.

427 But I do not look for that. No: sooner will the
earth close over

428 more than one of the suitor-men who eat
away your living.”

429 So speaking, Athena touched him with her
wand.

430 She withered the fine skin on his supple
limbs;

431 she stripped the fair hair from his head; and
about all his limbs

432 she set the skin of an aged old man;

433 and she dimmed those eyes, so beautiful
before,

434 and threw about him a foul rag and a tunic —

435 tattered things, filthy, black with reeking
smoke —

436 and over them she dressed him in the great
hide of a swift deer,45

437 worn bald. And she gave him a staff, and a
miserable pouch,
438 ragged full of holes, slung on a rope of twisted
cord.
439 So the two of them, their plot laid, parted.
And she46
440 went off to shining Lacedaemon, after the son
of Odysseus.

Notes

NOTES

1. The opening couplet repeats 11.333–334 verbatim — the spellbound hall — and the translation repeats with it. The same silence greets the Intermezzo and the finished tale: four books of story are framed, fore and aft, by an audience forgetting to breathe. ↩
2. Alcinous' last gift-order comes with the poem's frankest line of political economy: a tripod and cauldron from each king, "and we in turn will gather it back from the people: it is hard on one man to give so freely without repayment." Royal generosity is a tax passed downward, stated without embarrassment. Fairyland keeps books. ↩

3. Odysseus watching the sun, “willing it to set”: the man who told four books of adventures now cannot bear one more afternoon of hospitality. The greatest guest in literature has reached the end of being a guest. ↩
4. The plowman simile: supper-hunger after a day at the plow, oxen-weary, knees buckling on the walk home. For the sack of his longing the poem reaches past kings and heroes to a tired farmhand — the wanderings end where the poem’s clocks have always pointed, at the working day and its supper (the judge at 12.439, the unyoking-hour at 9.58). Twenty years of war and sea are calibrated, at the last, against one laborer’s evening. ↩
5. His farewell wish: to find at home “my blameless wife... with those I love unharmed.” Before the Phaeacians — who offered him a princess — he wishes for his wife openly now, in his own person and not through the tale (the Nekyia had already named Penelope). The reticence of 7.225 (possessions, slaves, house — no wife), first loosened inside the storytelling, is dropped entirely now that the ship is waiting and it stops being protective. ↩
6. The farewell to Arete is the courtliest sentence in the poem: joy to her until old age and death, “which stand over every one of us.” He came to her knees as a nameless suppliant; he leaves wishing her the whole of a human life. The queen who held his homecoming in her hands (7.75–77) receives the last cup and the last word. ↩
7. The sleep: “unwaking, sweetest sleep, and most like death.” The man crosses from fairyland to Ithaca unconscious — carried over the threshold of his own story like a corpse or a bride.

Twenty years of vigilance, and the final leg is pure surrender; the poem marks it with its boldest oxymoron, the sweetness that resembles dying. Ancient readers saw the death-and-rebirth shape; the poem needs no doctrine — only the fact that the great watcher does not get to watch his own arrival. ↪

8. Two similes race each other: the ship as a four-horse team springing under the lash, then outrunning the falcon, “nimblest of winged things.” The Phaeacian marvel gets land’s fastest image and the sky’s in ten lines — and between them, the cargo: “a man with counsels like the gods’,” asleep. ↪
9. “All he had suffered forgotten” — λελασμένος ὅσσ’ ἐπεπόνθει.
The lotus promised oblivion of home; sleep grants, for one night, oblivion of the suffering. The poem’s tenderest clause: forgetting, which was the enemy all through the wanderings, is here the mercy. ↪
10. The harbor of Phorcys and the cave of the Naiads: stone bowls, stone jars, bees laying up honey, stone looms where nymphs weave sea-purple cloth, waters that never fail. No passage of Homer was more allegorized in antiquity — Porphyry wrote a whole treatise (*On the Cave of the Nymphs*) reading it as the cosmos: souls descending by one door, gods by the other, the honey and the weaving as generation itself. The poem’s own picture is enough: Ithaca’s front hall is a working sanctuary where nature keeps house — the island answer to Calypso’s cave and Circe’s halls, wild and holy and nobody’s prison. ↪
11. Two doors: the north for men, the south “the immortals’ road.”
The cave where mortal and divine traffic use separate

entrances is about to host exactly that: a man and a goddess, entering together, to hide treasure and plot a war. ↩

12. They carry him ashore asleep — the hero delivered onto Ithaca like freight, laid on the sand with his blankets, his treasure heaped by the olive. Twenty years of striving for this beach, and the arrival happens without him. The poem's profoundest irony about homecoming: the moment itself cannot be experienced — only, like everything else in this poem, told afterward. ↩
13. Poseidon's grievance is family shame: the Phaeacians "are of my very own line" (his son Nausithous founded them). The god's honor is wounded worst by his own descendants' kindness — and his complaint concedes the whole war: "his homecoming itself I never wholly denied him." The curse only ever ran to *late and in evil case*; the ledger closes with Poseidon himself reading out its limits. ↩
14. Poseidon's bitterest clause repeats Zeus' own prophecy from 5.38–40 verbatim — more treasure than Troy would have given him — and the translation repeats it. What Zeus promised in council, Poseidon must now watch delivered on a beach; the same line is triumph in one god's mouth, salt in the other's. ↩
15. Zeus' amendment to the plan: don't just smash the ship — turn her to stone "close offshore... so that all mankind may marvel," and pile the mountain. An ancient variant (known to Aristophanes of Byzantium) read "and do *not* pile the mountain," softening Zeus into mercy. Murray's text keeps the harder reading: Zeus improves the punishment into a monument. The poem then leaves the Phaeacians mid-

sacrifice, praying against the mountain (183–187), and never returns to them: the kindest people in the poem exit the epic frozen between marvel and doom — unresolved forever, in payment for one act of grace. ↩

16. The watcher's line — “who has shackled our fast ship... in full view, every timber of her?” — is answered by the narrator's dry refrain from 4.772: “knowing nothing of how it had been done.” The stone ship in the roadstead was still being shown to travelers off Corfu in antiquity, and is still pointed out today: the poem planted a landmark and geography obliged. ↩
17. “Ah, then it comes home to me — the old prophecy”: Alcinous receives fulfillment in the *identical line* Polyphemus used (9.507), and the translation repeats it exactly. The two hosts of the wanderings — the monster who ate his guests and the king who enriched them — get the same formula for the same discovery: contact with Odysseus was foretold, and it costs. Lines 173–178 then replay Nausithous' prophecy from 8.565–569 nearly word for word, as promised when the glossary flagged it: prophecy in this poem is a text, quoted precisely by everyone who owns a copy. ↩
18. The scene-cut is merciless: the Phaeacians “standing around the altar” — and mid-line, the poem turns its back on them forever to wake Odysseus. Two clauses share one verse: the last we hear of Scheria, and the first breath of the homecoming. No book-division in ancient literature does more work in half a line. ↩
19. Athena's stated reasons for the mist and the disguise: he must not be known “before the suitors paid for all their trespass” —

ὑπερβασίην, the legal-moral word (3.206). The unrecognizable Ithaca is not a trick played on him but the first move of the revenge plot: estrangement as strategy. Still, the poem lets the cruelty land — the man who wept toward this island for ten years gets to see it first as a stranger's coast. ↩

20. The arrival-taxonomy, third and last time (= 6.120–121 = 9.175–176): “violent, savage, without justice, or kind to strangers?” — in Books 6 and 13 preceded by the same bewildered whose-country-is-this, a preamble the Cyclops' coast never got. Asked of Phaeacia, the answer was the kindest people in the poem; of the Cyclops' coast, the cruelest. Asked of *Ithaca*, the question stops being rhetorical: his own island now contains both answers — the loyal swineherd and the hall full of men eating his house. The formula has been aimed at this target for seven books. ↩
21. Grief, then audit: he laments his betrayal — and immediately counts the tripods. “And missed not one thing.” The inventory clears the Phaeacians of theft (they are innocent; he now knows it) and restores the world to order the only way this man trusts: by arithmetic. Mourning and bookkeeping share one heart; the poem has never pretended otherwise (9.42, 549).
↩
22. Athena as a shepherd boy “delicate-skinned, such as the sons of kings are,” with a fine double cloak and a javelin — an aristocrat's idea of a shepherd, a disguise wearing a disguise. Meeting her, Odysseus takes no chances either way: he prays to the possible god and lies to the possible man in the same breath. ↩

23. Her teasing opens with the put-down formula the Cyclops used on him (“You are a fool, stranger, or you have come from far away,” 9.273) — recycled now as affectionate irony. And her description of Ithaca answers everything its exiles have said of it: rough, no horse-country (Telemachus at 4.601–608; his own “rugged, but a good nurse of men,” 9.27) — and then grain, wine, rain, dew, goat-pasture, timber, watering-places: a bounty the lovers never claimed. She identifies the island by praising it past its own praisers. ↩
24. “The name of Ithaca has reached even to Troy”: the goddess certifies his homeland’s fame by the measure of his own war. The compliment is engineered to test — anyone else would cry out at the name. What he does instead is the next note. ↩
25. “He did not speak the truth: he swallowed the word back down, forever steering, in his breast, the mind of many profits.” Told he stands on Ithaca — the word he has bled twenty years to hear — his first act is a lie. The first Cretan tale (256–286) is a masterpiece of instant fabrication: a plausible exile (a killing over loot, an ambush by night, hired Phoenicians, a wind off course), studded with true details relocated — the treasure, the sleep, the beach landing are his actual morning, re-plotted as crime fiction. He lies the way other men flinch: as a reflex of self-protection, and the poem admires and exposes the reflex in the same line. ↩
26. The recognition: she *smiles* — the second smile of the poem’s gods on him — strokes him with her hand (the gesture kings and goddesses reserve for favorites: Menelaus at 4.610, Calypso at 5.181), and drops the shepherd for “a woman beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious handwork”: Athena as she is, the

weaver-goddess. The lie did not offend her. It delighted her. Nowhere else in ancient literature does a deity fall in love with a mortal's *dishonesty*. ↩

27. The speech that names him better than his name: “A sharp one he would have to be, a master-thief, to slip past you... You hard man — shifting-crafted, glutton for guile — not even in your own country would you leave off the cheating and the thieving tales that are dear to you from the ground of your heart.” Then the great leveling: “We are both old hands at profit: you are far the best of all mortal men in counsel and in words, and I among all the gods am famed for cunning and for profit.” The patron-goddess declares the partnership explicitly — one craft, two planes of being. It is the poem’s theology of intelligence: *mētis* is the one field where a mortal and a god can be colleagues. And her mild rebuke — “yet you did not know Pallas Athena” — is also the point: perfect craft means even your patron can stand before you unrecognized. ↩

28. “To weave a design with you” — μήτιν ὑφίηνω: the master-metaphor (Penelope’s loom, Hephaestus’ snare, the Nekyia’s “wove every guile”) now spoken by the goddess of weaving herself, proposing joint work. The revenge on the suitors is, from this line, a co-production. ↩

29. His answer to the revelation is not worship but a grievance and a cross-examination: where were you for ten years? — and then, incredibly, a demand for proof that this is really Ithaca, “for I think you are mocking me... to lead my wits astray.” He doubts the goddess of truth-by-cunning to her face, on the theory that a being who can look like anything might be lying

about geography. It is the most in-character prayer ever prayed. ↩

30. Her delighted verdict: “Always the same — that mind in your breast!” — followed by the poem’s formal citation of his virtues: ἐπιτήης, ἀγχίνοος, ἐχέφρων — civil, quick-witted, steady-souled. And then the observation that defines the second half of the epic: any other man would have run home to his wife and children; “you have no wish yet to learn or to ask until you have made trial of your wife besides.” Testing before trusting, even of Penelope, even now. Athena states it without censure — it is *why* she cannot forsake him. The gods love in others what they are. ↩
31. Her report on Penelope retells Anticleia’s dispatch from the Nekyia (11.181–183), its closing line word for word: sitting in the halls, nights and days wasting in tears. Mother and goddess file the same report — the last line in the same words — the poem’s fixed image of the waiting wife, stable across every witness. ↩
32. The proof is the ground-plan itself, point by point, reusing the narrator’s own lines from 96–104: the harbor of Phorcys, the long-leafed olive, the Naiads’ cave, Neriton. She adds the one detail that clinches it as *his*: the cave “where you used to offer the nymphs so many perfect hecatombs” — identification by his own history of piety. Home is the place where your old sacrifices are on file. ↩
33. The mist scatters, “and the land showed plain” — and he kisses the grain-giving earth, the gesture last performed by a half-drowned nobody in the reeds of Scheria (5.463). Then, before

any human greeting, he prays to the springs: “I told myself I would never see you again.” His first words home are to the island’s water. The homecoming is real now — not when his foot touched sand, but when he could *see* it and speak to it. ↩

34. The treasure sealed in the cave, “and a stone was set at the door by Pallas Athena.” The last time the poem set a stone at a cave door, the hand was the Cyclops’ (9.240–243). The poem’s doors keep their memory: this one closes on wealth, not victims, and opens on the poem’s endgame. ↩
35. The war council under the sacred olive: the goddess and the man sitting at the root of Athena’s own tree — the tree of the double thicket that sheltered him (5.477), of the stake (9.320), of the bed to come (23.190) — “and plotted death for the overweening suitors.” The whole second half of the poem is planned in this shade, on the ground of Ithaca, between the two best minds in the epic. ↩
36. Athena’s briefing quotes Tiresias’ prophecy word for word — “courting your godlike wife and offering bride-gifts” (11.117) — seer and goddess filing the identical clause. Note her “three years”: the poem’s chronology of the siege of the house, consistent with Antinous’ “third year, soon the fourth” (2.89).
↩
37. And then she quotes *Antinous* — “gives hope to all, and makes promises to every man, sending out messages — while her mind wills otherwise” (2.91–92, verbatim, kept verbatim). The suitor’s complaint, in the goddess’s mouth, as praise: what Antinous called cheating, Athena reports as strategy. Penelope’s double game is confirmed at the highest level, in

her enemy's own words — the poem's final word on whose side that famous ambiguity is on. ↩

38. “Weave a design, how I shall pay them back” — he asks the goddess for exactly what she offered (303), in the same metaphor. Then the old soldier's requisition: stand beside me “as on the day we loosed the shining head-veil of Troy” — and I'll fight three hundred. The Iliadic partnership, reactivated on a beach, for a war of one household. ↩

39. Troy's fall as the loosing of a veil — κρήδεμνα, the word for a woman's headdress (Ino's life-saving veil, 5.346; Penelope's, 1.334). The sacked city is a woman unveiled by force: the poem's own widow-simile (8.523–531) compressed into a single genitive. That Odysseus uses it as a happy memory — *our* great day — while the audience holds Book 8's weeping is the kind of double exposure this poem trusts its listeners to develop. ↩

40. Her battle-promise, delivered with relish: more than one suitor “will spatter the vast floor with his blood and brains.” The gray-eyed goddess of wisdom talks like a soldier when the work is settled. Book 22 is signed for, here, in advance, by its second combatant. ↩

41. The disguise's cruellest clause, stated without softening: you will seem vile “to all the suitors — and to your wife, and to the son you left in your halls.” The mask must deceive the enemies *and* the beloved; the plot requires his wife's and son's revulsion at the sight of him. He accepts it without a word of protest — the price of the test is being untested-against, unrecognizable to the very people whose recognition is the poem's goal. ↩

42. The swineherd is introduced by his loyalty before his name (he will not be named until 14.55): keeper of pigs “whose heart is loyal to you all the same... who loves your boy, and steady-hearted Penelope.” His address is given like a deed’s coordinates — the Rock of the Raven, the spring Arethusa, the acorns and black water “that feed the rich fat on swine.” The poem’s aristocratic machinery now routes its king through the hut of a slave; Book 14, the great pastoral of the poem, is on the itinerary. ↩
43. The father’s flash of anger at the goddess — why did you *let* the boy sail into danger, “you whose mind holds everything?” — earns him the coolest divine answer in the epic: I took him myself, “so that he might win himself a good report.” Kleos requires risk; the goddess runs the son on the same curriculum as the father, and tells the father so to his face. Parenting, Olympian style. ↩
44. She discloses the ambush with a shrug — yes, they lie in wait, “but I do not look for that” — and caps it with the poem’s running death-sentence formula: sooner will the earth close over the suitors. The threat to Telemachus, live since Book 4, is defused in tone before it is defused in fact (Book 16); Athena spends suspense the way she spends everything — deliberately. ↩
45. The transformation, executed clause by clause as promised — withered skin, stripped hair, dimmed eyes, smoke-black rags — plus the finishing touch: “the great hide of a swift deer, worn bald.” The man whom Menelaus imaged as the lion returning to the fawns’ lair (4.335–340) will enter his own hall dressed as *the deer*. The staff and the holed pouch on its twisted cord

complete the poem's most consequential costume: the king as the least of the earth, the beggar who tests the world — and the world, from now to Book 22, will be judged by how it treats him. ↩

46. The parting line closes the book like a hinge: “their plot laid” — βουλεύσαντε, the dual: *the two of them*, plotting as one grammatical unit — and she is away to Sparta after the son. Father and son now stand at the two ends of the poem's map with one goddess shuttling between them, and every plot-thread of Books 1–4 begins to reel back in. The wanderings are over; the *design* has begun. ↩

Odyssey — Book 14

*The hut of Eumaeus: the slave's welcome, the second
Cretan tale, the cloak story.*

- 1 But he went up from the harbor by a rough
track
- 2 through wooded country, along the heights,
where Athena
- 3 had shown him the noble swineherd — the man
who cared¹
- 4 for his substance beyond all the house-slaves
noble Odysseus had acquired.
- 5 He found him sitting in the fore-court, where
his yard
- 6 was built up high, in a place with a clear view all
around,
- 7 big and handsome, with a cleared run round it.
The swineherd
- 8 had built it himself for the swine of his absent
master —²

9 without his mistress, without old Laertes —
10 out of quarried stones, and coped it with wild
pear;
11 and outside he had driven stakes the whole
circuit, this way and that,
12 close-set and thick, split out of the black heart
of the oak;
13 and inside the yard he had made twelve sties
14 hard by one another, bedding for the swine;
and in each one
15 fifty wallowing sows were penned,
16 breeding females. The boars slept outside,
17 far fewer: for the godlike suitors kept thinning
them
18 at their feasts — the swineherd forever sending
in³
19 the best of all the fatted hogs;
20 and these numbered three hundred and sixty.
21 And beside them four dogs always slept — like
wild beasts,
22 raised by the swineherd, a leader of men.⁴
23 He himself was fitting sandals to his feet,

24 cutting them from a well-tanned oxhide. The
others
25 had gone their ways, this man here, that man
there, with the herded swine —
26 three of them; the fourth he had sent off to the
city
27 to bring a hog to the overweening suitors —
forced to it —
28 so they might slaughter it and glut their hearts
with meat.
29 Suddenly the baying dogs caught sight of
Odysseus:
30 they rushed him, yelping. And Odysseus⁵
31 sat down — pure craft — and the staff dropped
from his hand.
32 There, at his own farm, he would have suffered
shameful hurt,
33 but the swineherd came fast on his quick feet
after them,
34 darting through the gateway — the hide flew
from his hand —
35 and shouting he scattered the dogs this way

and that

36 with a shower of stones. And he addressed his
master:

37 “Old man — the dogs came one breath short of
tearing you

38 to pieces, and the shame of it would have
poured on me.

39 And the gods have given me griefs enough
besides, and groaning:

40 here I sit, mourning a godlike master,⁶

41 and fatten hogs for other men

42 to eat, while he, perhaps, is starving for bread

43 and wanders the lands and towns of men of
alien speech —

44 if indeed he lives still, and sees the light of the
sun.

45 But follow me — into the hut, old man, so that
you too,

46 when you have had your fill of bread and wine,

47 may say where you come from, and all the
cares you have borne.”

48 So speaking the noble swineherd led him to

the hut,

49 brought him in and set him down: he heaped
springy brushwood

50 and spread on it the skin of a shaggy wild goat

—

51 his own bedding, big and thick. And Odysseus
was glad⁷

52 that he received him so, and spoke a word, and
named him:

53 “May Zeus grant you, stranger, and the other
deathless gods,

54 whatever you wish most — since you
welcomed me with all your heart.”

55 And you answered him, Eumaeus the
swineherd:⁸

56 “Stranger, it is not right for me — not though a
worse man came —

57 to slight a stranger: for from Zeus they come,
all of them,⁹

58 strangers and beggars; and a gift, though
small, is dear —

59 from such as we are: for that is the way of

slaves,

60 always afraid, when the masters who hold the
power

61 are the young ones. As for him — the gods have
bound his homecoming,

62 the man who would have loved me devotedly,
and given me possessions —

64 a house, a plot of land, a wife that many men
had courted —10

63 such things as a kind-hearted master gives his
house-slave

65 who has labored hard for him, whose work a
god makes prosper,

66 the way this work of mine prospers, at which I
hold my post.

67 For that my master would have paid me richly,
had he grown old here.

68 But he is dead. — And I wish Helen's whole
breed had gone down11

69 on its knees to destruction, for she loosed the
knees of many men:

70 he too went off for the sake of Agamemnon's

honor

71 to Ilium of the fine horses, to fight the
Trojans.”

72 So speaking he quickly belted in his tunic with
his sash

73 and went to the sties, where the tribes of
young pigs were penned.

74 He took two out of there, and slaughtered
them both,

75 singed them, cut them small, and threaded
them on spits,

76 and when he had roasted all of it, he brought
and set it by Odysseus

77 hot on the spits themselves, and dusted it with
white barley,

78 and mixed honey-sweet wine in an ivy-wood
bowl,

79 and sat down facing him, and pressed him on:

80 “Eat now, stranger — what house-slaves have
to offer:12

81 young pig. The fatted hogs — the suitors eat
those,

82 with no thought in their hearts of the gods'
watching eye, no mercy.

83 Yet the blessed gods love no ruthless
dealing:13

84 they honor justice, and the right acts of men.

85 Why — even enemies, even raiders, who land

86 on a foreign coast, and Zeus grants them
plunder,

87 and they fill their ships and set off home —

88 even on their hearts falls the strong fear of the
watching eye.

89 But these men — these men know something;
they have heard some god's own voice

90 telling his grim death: that is why they will not
woo

91 in the right way, nor go home to their own, but
at their ease

92 they devour the goods, high-handed, and spare
nothing.

93 For every night and every day that comes from
Zeus,

94 they slaughter victims — never one, and never

only two —

95 and wine they draw off past all measure, and
waste it.

96 For his livelihood was past speaking. No hero
anywhere

97 had so much — not on the dark mainland,

98 not on Ithaca itself; no twenty men together

99 have wealth so great. I will count it through for
you:14

100 twelve herds of cattle on the mainland; as
many flocks of sheep;

101 as many droves of pigs; as many ranging herds
of goats

102 in the care of foreigners and of his own
herdsmen there.

103 And here, at the island's end, wide-ranging
herds of goats

104 graze, eleven in all, with good men watching
over them,

105 and every day each man of them drives up a
beast for those others —

106 whichever of the fatted goats looks best;

107 and I keep guard over these sows, and protect them,

108 and choose out the best of the swine, and send it in.”

109 So he spoke; and Odysseus ate his meat and drank his wine,

110 ravenous, silent — planting evils for the suitors.**15**

111 But when he had supped, and steadied his heart with food,

112 the swineherd filled the cup he drank from himself

113 brim-full of wine and gave it; and he took it, glad at heart,

114 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to him:

115 “Friend — who was the man who bought you with his goods,

116 the master rich and powerful as you describe?

117 You say he perished for the sake of Agamemnon’s honor:

118 name him — I may know him, being such a

one as he was.

119 For Zeus knows, I suppose, and the other
deathless gods,

120 whether I have seen him and could bring you
news. I have wandered far.”

121 Then the swineherd answered him, a leader of
men:

122 “Old man — no wanderer coming with news of
him

123 could persuade his wife now, or his dear son.

124 Drifters in need of keep — they lie¹⁶

125 at random, and have no wish to speak the
truth.

126 Every vagrant who finds his way to the land of
Ithaca

127 goes to my mistress and babbles his deceits;

128 and she receives him kindly, and treats him
well, and questions everything,

129 and as she grieves the tears come falling from
her lids,

130 as is the right way of a wife whose husband
dies far off.

131 You too, old man, would have a story stitched
together fast enough17

132 if someone would give you clothing — a cloak
and a tunic.

133 But him — by now the dogs and the quick
birds

134 have torn the skin from his bones, and the life
has gone out of him;

135 or the fish have eaten him in the sea, and his
bones

136 lie on a shore somewhere, wrapped deep in
drifting sand.

137 So he is dead and gone over there, and grief is
left behind

138 for all who loved him — for me above all: for
never again

139 will I find a master so gentle, wherever I go —

140 not though I came again to my father's and
my mother's

141 house, where I was born, and where they
reared me.

142 And it is not even for them I mourn so much,

for all my longing

143 to see them with my eyes again in my own
country:

144 no — it is longing for Odysseus, who is gone,
that takes hold of me.

145 I shrink from naming him, stranger, even now
he is absent, 18

146 for he loved me beyond measure, and cared
for me at heart.

147 I call him ‘my beloved lord,’ even far away.”

148 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus spoke to
him again:

149 “Friend — since you deny it flat, and say that
he

150 will come no more, and your heart is set in
disbelief —

151 then I will say it not just so, but with an oath
upon it:

152 Odysseus is coming home. And let my reward
for the good news

153 come the moment he arrives at his own halls:

154 dress me then in a cloak and a tunic, fine

clothing.

155 Before that — though I stand in sore need — I
will take nothing.

156 For hateful to me as the very gates of Hades¹⁹

157 is the man who yields to poverty and babbles
deceits.

158 Now Zeus be my witness, first of the gods, and
this table of friendship,

159 and the hearth of blameless Odysseus, to
which I have come:

160 all this shall be accomplished exactly as I say.

161 Within this very turning of the light Odysseus
will be here:²⁰

162 between this month's waning and the rising
of the next,

163 he will come home; and he will punish
whoever

164 dishonors his wife and his shining son in this
place."

165 And you answered him, Eumaeus the
swineherd:

166 "Old man, I will never be paying that reward

for good news,

167 and Odysseus will come home no more. Drink
your wine

168 in peace, and let us turn our minds to other
things. Do not

169 remind me of all this: for the heart in my
breast

170 aches whenever anyone recalls my faithful
master.

171 As for the oath — we will let it be. But may
Odysseus

172 come — as I wish it, as Penelope wishes,

173 and old Laertes, and godlike Telemachus.

174 And now it is the boy I mourn past all
forgetting — Odysseus' own son

175 Telemachus. The gods reared him like a young
tree,

176 and I thought he would stand among men no
whit behind

177 his own dear father, a wonder in build and
beauty —

178 and some immortal crippled the balanced

mind within him,

179 or some man did: he has gone for news of his
father

180 to holy Pylos. And the lordly suitors lie in wait

181 for his homecoming — so that the line of
godlike Arceisius²¹

182 may perish out of Ithaca and leave no name.

183 Well — we will let him be, whether he is taken

184 or escapes, and the son of Cronos stretches a
hand over him.

185 But come, old man, tell me your own troubles
now;

186 and tell me this too, honestly, so that I may
know it:

187 What man are you, and from where? Where
are your city and your parents?²²

188 On what kind of ship did you come? And how
did sailors

189 bring you to Ithaca? Who did they claim to
be?

190 For I hardly think you came here on foot.”

191 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered

him:

192 “Then I will tell you all of it, and truly.

193 If only there were food for the two of us, for a
good while,

194 and sweet wine here inside the hut,

195 to feast on quietly while others did the work

—

196 then I could go on easily for a full year

197 and still not finish out the tale of my heart’s
cares,

198 all that I have labored through by the gods’
will.23

199 Out of wide Crete I claim my lineage:24

200 a rich man’s son. Many other sons besides

201 were born and bred in his hall, true-born,

202 sons of his wife. My mother was bought — a
concubine.

203 Yet Castor, Hylax’ son — the man whose blood
I claim —

204 honored me equally with his lawful sons.

205 In those days the Cretan people honored him
like a god

206 for his fortune, his wealth, and his glorious
sons.

207 But the death-spirits came and carried him
away

208 to the house of Hades. And his high-hearted
sons

209 divided up the living and cast lots for it,

210 and to me they gave a pittance, and allotted
me a house.

211 Still, I won myself a wife from a family of wide
holdings —

212 by my own worth: for I was no empty man, 25

213 no shirker of the fight. Now it is all gone from
me;

214 but even so, I think, looking at the stubble

215 you can tell the standing grain. Since then,
trouble past measure has held me.

216 Ares and Athena, yes, they gave me boldness

217 and the strength that breaks men's ranks.

Whenever I picked

218 the best men for an ambush, sowing evils for
the enemy,

219 my proud heart never once looked forward to
death:

220 far the first, I would leap out and take my
man with the spear —

221 whichever of the enemy gave me his back in
flight.

222 Such I was in war. But field-work I never
loved,

223 nor the housekeeping that rears shining
children:26

224 what I loved, always, was the oared ships,

225 and wars, and polished javelins, and arrows —

226 grim things, that other men shudder at.

227 But I loved what the god, I suppose, set in my
heart:

228 one man delights in one work, another in
another.

229 For before the sons of the Achaeans set foot
on Troy,

230 nine times I led men and fast-running ships

231 against foreign peoples, and rich takings came
my way.

232 From it I drew out my pleasure, and much fell
to me

233 by lot besides. My house grew great at once,
and thereafter

234 I walked among the Cretans feared and
respected.

235 But when Zeus of the wide voice devised at
last

236 that hateful road that loosed the knees of
many men,

237 then they pressed me and glorious Idomeneus

238 to lead the ships to Ilium. There was no
device

239 for refusing: the people's hard talk held us to
it.27

240 There we sons of the Achaeans made war nine
years,

241 and in the tenth we sacked Priam's city and
set off

242 home with our ships; and a god scattered the
Achaeans.

243 But for me — wretched me — Zeus the deviser

designed evils.

244 One month, no more, I stayed, delighting in
my children,

245 my wedded wife, and my possessions. And
then

246 my heart bade me fit out ships and sail

247 for Egypt, with my godlike companions.28

248 Nine ships I fitted out, and the crews
gathered fast.

249 Six days after that my trusted companions

250 feasted, and I gave victims in plenty

251 for sacrifice to the gods, and for the men to
make their feast.

252 On the seventh we boarded, and from wide
Crete

253 we sailed with a fresh fair North Wind behind
us,

254 easily, as if downstream. No ship of mine

255 took harm: unhurt and whole

256 we sat, and the wind and the steersmen held
them on course.

257 On the fifth day we reached the fair-flowing

river of Egypt,

258 and in the river of Egypt I moored my curved
ships.

259 Then, you may be sure, I ordered my trusted
companions

260 to stay there by the ships and guard the ships,

261 and I sent out scouts to the lookout places.

262 But they gave way to arrogance — followed
their own force —29

263 and straightway began to pillage the beautiful
fields

264 of the Egyptian men: they carried off the
women and small children,

265 and killed the men. And quickly the cry
reached the city.

266 Hearing the shout, at the showing of dawn
the people

267 came; and the whole plain filled with infantry
and horses

268 and the lightning of bronze. And Zeus who
delights in thunder

269 threw an evil panic on my companions, and

no man dared

270 stand and face it: for destruction ringed us
everywhere.

271 There they killed many of us with the sharp
bronze,

272 and others they led up alive, to slave for them
by force.30

273 But as for me — Zeus himself put this thought
in my mind

274 (would I had died instead, and met my doom

275 there, in Egypt! for more grief stood waiting
to receive me):

276 at once I took the well-made helmet from my
head,

277 and the shield from my shoulders, and
dropped the spear from my hand,

278 and went straight toward the king's chariot,

279 and clasped his knees and kissed them. He
spared me, and had mercy,31

280 and sat me in his car, and took me, weeping,
to his house.

281 Truly, man after man came lunging at me

with the ash spear,
282 raging to kill me — for they were angered
beyond all measure —
283 but he held them off: he feared the wrath of
Zeus
284 of Strangers, who above all feels fury at evil
deeds.
285 There I stayed seven years, and I gathered
much wealth
286 among the Egyptian men: for all of them gave.
287 But when the eighth year came wheeling
round for me,
288 then there came a Phoenician, a man well-
schooled in deceits —32
289 a gnawer of men, who had already done the
world much harm.
290 He talked me round, that one, and took me
with him to Phoenicia,
291 where his house and his possessions lay,
292 and there I stayed with him for the full round
of a year.
293 But when at last the months and the days

were coming to fulfillment,
294 as the year rolled round and the seasons came
again,
295 he put me aboard a seagoing ship for Libya —
296 a lying scheme: I was to help him run a cargo
there,
297 but there he meant to sell me, and take a
boundless price.
298 I went with him aboard — suspecting it, but
forced.
299 And she ran on with a fresh fair North Wind
behind her,
300 on the mid-sea track above Crete. And Zeus
was devising their destruction:
301 for when we had left Crete behind, and no
other33
302 land showed anywhere — only sky and sea —
303 then the son of Cronos set a dark-blue cloud
304 over the hollow ship, and the deep went black
beneath it.
305 And Zeus thundered in the same instant, and
hurled his bolt into the ship,

306 and she shivered stem to stern, struck by the
bolt of Zeus,
307 and filled with the reek of sulfur; and all the
men fell from the ship.
308 Like sea-crows around the black hull
309 they were carried off on the waves; and the
god took away their homecoming.
310 But as for me — Zeus himself, though my
heart was full of anguish,
311 put the huge mast of the dark-blue-prowed
ship
312 into my two hands, so that I might yet escape
the evil.
313 Wrapped around it I was carried before the
deadly winds.
314 Nine days I was carried; and on the tenth, in
the black night,
315 a great rolling wave brought me near the
Thesprotians' land.
316 There the king of the Thesprotians, the hero
Pheidon,
317 took me in — and asked no price: his own dear

son³⁴

³¹⁸ had found me beaten down by cold and weariness, and led me home,

³¹⁹ raising me up by the hand, until we reached his father's halls;

³²⁰ and he put clothing on me, a cloak and a tunic.

³²¹ It was there I heard of Odysseus. For the king said³⁵

³²² he had hosted him, a guest and friend, on his way home to his fathers' land,

³²³ and he showed me all the treasure Odysseus had gathered —

³²⁴ bronze and gold and iron worked with labor —

³²⁵ enough to feed a man's line to the tenth generation,

³²⁶ such a store of it lay in the lord's halls.

³²⁷ Odysseus, he said, was gone to Dodona, to hear³⁶

³²⁸ the will of Zeus out of the god's own high-crowned oak:

329 how he should come home to the rich land of
Ithaca,
330 openly or in secret, after so long away.
331 And he swore an oath to me, pouring the
libation in his house,
332 that a ship was hauled down and a crew
standing ready
333 to convey him home to his own dear
fatherland.
334 But me he sent off first: for a Thesprotian ship
335 happened to be sailing for Dulichium, rich in
wheat.
336 He charged them to bring me there, with all
care, to King Acastus.
337 But an evil counsel about me pleased their
hearts instead —
338 so that I might yet come down to the last
dregs of misery.
339 When the seagoing ship was far out from the
land,
340 they set about contriving, then and there, my
day of slavery.³⁷

341 They stripped me of my clothing, cloak and
tunic both,
342 and threw around me different gear — this
foul rag
343 and this torn tunic — the very ones you see
with your own eyes;
344 and at evening they reached the tilled fields
of clear-skied Ithaca.
345 There they lashed me tight in the well-
benched ship
346 with a twisted rope, and went ashore
themselves
347 and hurried their supper along the margin of
the sea.
348 But the gods themselves undid my lashing —
349 easily. And wrapping my rag about my head,
350 I slid down the polished lading-plank,
breasted the sea,
351 then struck out with both arms, swimming,
352 and very soon I was out of the water, clear of
them.
353 I climbed up where a thicket of flowering

brush stood,

354 and lay there, crouched. And they, groaning
loud,

355 cast about; but there seemed no profit for
them

356 in searching further, so they went back again

357 aboard their hollow ship. And the gods hid me

358 easily, and brought me on my way to the
steading

359 of an understanding man. For it is still my
portion to live.”

360 And you answered him, Eumaeus the
swineherd:

361 “Poor luckless stranger — truly you have
stirred the heart in me,

362 telling all this through, all you have suffered,
all your wandering.

363 But one part is not in order, and you will
never persuade me —

364 that about Odysseus. Why should a man like
you38

365 lie into the empty air? I know it well myself,

366 my master's homecoming: how the gods all
hated him,
367 utterly — since they did not bring him down
among the Trojans,
368 or in the arms of his friends, once he had
wound the war to its end.
369 Then the whole Achaean people would have
built him a tomb,39
370 and he would have won great fame in time to
come for his son as well.
371 Instead the whirlwinds have snatched him
away without glory.
372 And I — I keep apart, with my pigs. I do not go
373 to the city, unless perhaps watchful-minded
Penelope
374 bids me come, when news arrives from
somewhere;
375 then they all sit around the newcomer and
question everything —
376 those who grieve for their long-gone lord,
377 and those who rejoice, eating up his living
unpunished.

378 But I have no love of asking and inquiring,
379 ever since an Aetolian cheated me with his
tale —40
380 a man who had killed someone, and
wandered over the wide earth,
381 and came to my house; and I received him
with open arms.
382 He said he had seen him among the Cretans,
at Idomeneus' side,
383 mending the ships the storms had shattered
on him,
384 and said he would come by summer, or by
harvest-time,
385 bringing much wealth, together with his
godlike companions.
386 So you, old man of many sorrows — since
some power has brought you to me —
387 do not court my favor with lies, do not charm
me:41
388 it is not for that I will respect you or befriend
you,
389 but out of fear of Zeus of Strangers, and out of

pity for yourself.”

390 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

391 “Truly the heart in your breast is past all
persuading —

392 such a man you are: not even my oath won
you over; nothing convinces you.

393 Come then, let us make a bargain of it — and
above the two of us

394 let the gods who hold Olympus stand witness
on both sides.

395 If your master comes home, to this very
house,

396 you dress me in a cloak and a tunic, and send
me on

397 to Dulichium, where my own heart longs to
be;

398 and if your master does not come as I say he
will,

399 set your slaves on me: pitch me down from
the great rock —42

400 so that the next beggar too may think twice

before he cheats.”

401 And the noble swineherd answered him, and
said:

402 “Stranger — yes! and a fine name I would win
among mankind

403 for goodness, now and ever after,

404 I who led you to my hut and gave you a
guest’s due,

405 if then I killed you and took the dear life out
of you:

406 with a clean heart, after that, I could pray to
Zeus the son of Cronos!43

407 But it is supper time. Soon now my
companions

408 should be in, so we can make a savory supper
in the hut.”

409 So the two of them spoke such things to one
another;

410 and the swine came near, and the men who
herd them.

411 They shut the sows in their pens for the
night’s sleep,

412 and a clamor past speech went up as the
swine were folded.

413 Then the noble swineherd called to his
companions:

414 “Bring the best of the hogs, so I may slaughter
it for a guest⁴⁴

415 from far away. And we will have some good of
it ourselves,

416 who bear the misery of these white-tusked
swine and suffer for it

417 so long, while others eat our labor and pay
nothing.”

418 So speaking, he split the firewood with the
pitiless bronze,

419 and they brought in a hog, well fattened, five
years old,

420 and stood it by the hearth. Nor did the
swineherd

421 forget the deathless ones: for his mind was set
on good.⁴⁵

422 No — beginning the rite, he cast into the fire
the head-bristles

423 of the white-tusked hog, and prayed to all the
gods

424 that wise Odysseus might come home to his
own house.

425 Then he lifted an oak billet, left over from the
splitting,

426 and struck: and the life left the hog; and the
others cut the throat,

427 and singed it, and quickly quartered it out.
And the swineherd,

428 beginning the offering, laid raw flesh from
every limb

429 in the rich fat, and cast the pieces in the fire,

430 sprinkled over with barley meal; and they
carved the rest

431 and threaded it on spits, and roasted it with
care,

432 and drew it all off, and heaped it on the
platters. And the swineherd

433 stood up to divide it: for his mind knew what
was fair.

434 Into seven portions he divided the whole:46

435 one he set aside, with a prayer, for the
Nymphs and for Hermes,
436 Maia's son; the rest he served out to each
man;
437 and Odysseus he honored with the long
unbroken chine
438 of the white-tusked hog — and made his
master's heart proud.⁴⁷
439 And Odysseus of the many designs lifted his
voice and said:
440 "Eumaeus — may you be as dear to father
Zeus
441 as you are to me: for you honor such a man as
I am now with the best."
442 And you answered him, Eumaeus the
swineherd:
443 "Eat, my god-touched guest, and take your
pleasure in such things
444 as are here. The god will give one thing and
let another go,
445 whatever his own heart wills: for he can do all
things."⁴⁸

446 He spoke, and burned the first-cuts to the
gods who are forever,
447 and poured the fire-bright wine, and set the
cup in the hands
448 of Odysseus, sacker of cities; and sat down to
his own portion.
449 And Mesaulius served them bread — a man
the swineherd
450 had got for himself, alone, while his master
was away,⁴⁹
451 without his mistress, without old Laertes:
452 he had bought him from the Taphians with
goods of his own.
453 And their hands went out to the good things
spread before them.
454 But when they had put away desire for food
and drink,
455 Mesaulius took away the bread; and they,
filled
456 full of bread and meat, bestirred themselves
for bed.
457 And the night came on, foul, at the moon's

dark, and Zeus rained⁵⁰

⁴⁵⁸ the whole night through, and the wet West
Wind blew big without ceasing.

⁴⁵⁹ Then Odysseus spoke among them, testing
the swineherd —

⁴⁶⁰ whether he would strip off his own cloak and
give it,

⁴⁶¹ or urge it out of one of his companions, since
he cared for him so:

⁴⁶² “Hear me now, Eumaeus, and all you other
companions,

⁴⁶³ while I speak a word of boasting: it is the
crazing wine⁵¹

⁴⁶⁴ that commands me — wine, that sets even the
deep-minded singing

⁴⁶⁵ and giggling softly, and stirs him up to dance,

⁴⁶⁶ and tosses out many a word better left
unspoken.

⁴⁶⁷ Still, since I have blurted once, I will hide
nothing.

⁴⁶⁸ Would I were young, and my strength stood
firm in me,

469 as on the day we laid our ambush and led it
under Troy.

470 Odysseus led, and Atreus' son Menelaus,
471 and with them I was third in command: they
asked it themselves.**52**

472 When we had come up to the city and the
steep wall,

473 we lay around the town in the dense
brushwood,

474 crouched under our arms among the reeds
and marsh-grass,

475 and a foul night came on, the North Wind
dropping down,

476 freezing; and snow came falling on us like
hoarfrost,

477 bitter cold, and ice crusted thick on the
shields.

478 Then all the others had their cloaks and
tunics,

479 and slept at their ease, shoulders wrapped in
their shields;

480 but I had left my cloak behind with my

companions —

481 fool that I was — never thinking I would
freeze:

482 I had come with only my shield and my
shining waist-guard.

483 But in the night's third watch, when the stars
had crossed their height,53

484 then I spoke to Odysseus — he was there
beside me —

485 nudging him with my elbow; and he listened
on the instant:

486 'Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices,

487 I shall not be among the living long: this cold

488 is killing me. I have no cloak. Some power
tricked me

489 into a single tunic. And now there is no way
out.'

490 So I spoke; and he then held this plan in his
heart —

491 such a man he was for counsel, and for
fighting —

492 and speaking low, close in my ear, he said:

493 'Quiet now, lest some other Achaean hear
you.'⁵⁴

494 Then he propped his head on his elbow and
spoke out:

495 'Hear me, friends. A divine dream came to me
in my sleep.'⁵⁵

496 We have come out too far from the ships. Let
someone go

497 and tell Atreus' son Agamemnon, shepherd of
the people,

498 to send more men from the ships to join us
here.'

499 So he spoke; and up jumped Thoas,
Andraemon's son,

500 fast, and flung off his purple cloak,

501 and set off running for the ships. And I, in
that man's garment,

502 lay glad until Dawn shone on her golden
throne.

503 Would I were young like that now, and my
strength stood firm:

504 then someone in this steading might give a
swineherd's cloak —
505 both ways at once: in kindness, and in respect
for a good man.56
506 As it is, they scorn me for the foul clothes on
my skin.”
507 And you answered him, Eumaeus the
swineherd:
508 “Old man — that is a blameless fable you have
told:57
509 not one word of it off the measure; nothing
said without its profit.
510 So you shall not lack for clothing, nor for
anything else
511 that is owed a hard-worn suppliant when he
comes —
512 tonight. But at dawn you will knock about in
those rags of yours again:
513 for there are not many cloaks here, or changes
of tunic,
514 to put on — one only for each man.
515 But when the dear son of Odysseus comes,

516 he will give you clothing himself, a cloak and a tunic,

517 and send you wherever your heart and spirit bid you go.”

518 So speaking he sprang up and set a bed for him

519 close by the fire, and threw on it skins of sheep and goats.

520 There Odysseus lay down; and over him the swineherd threw a cloak,

521 thick-woven and big, that he kept by him for a change

522 of clothing, to put on when some terrible storm arose.

523 So Odysseus slept there, and beside him slept

524 the young men. But the swineherd — a bed in that place

525 did not please him, to sleep apart from his swine;

526 he armed himself to go outside. And Odysseus was glad58

527 that he took such care of his substance while

he was far away.

528 First he slung his sharp sword over his sturdy
shoulders,

529 then wrapped himself in a wind-breaking
cloak, thick-woven,

530 and took up the fleece of a big well-fattened
goat,

531 and took his sharp javelin, to hold off dogs
and men,

532 and went out to lie where the white-tusked
boars

533 slept, under a hollow rock, in the lee of the
North Wind.

Notes

NOTES

1. “The noble swineherd” — δῖος ὑφορβός: the epithet of kings and heroes (δῖος Ὀδυσσεύς) attached, calmly and repeatedly, to a slave who tends pigs. No word in the poem does more social work. And the next line prices the paradox: the man who “cared most for his substance” is one of the οἰκῆξ “noble Odysseus had *acquired*” — the poem states the ownership and

the nobility in one breath and declines to feel the contradiction. Book 14 is built on that refusal. ↩

2. The steading itself is a character-witness: yard, coping, oak-heart palisade, twelve sties — built by Eumaeus “himself... without his mistress, without old Laertes,” for an absent master’s swine. Unbidden, through the master’s long absence: capital improvement as an act of faith. The poem introduces its most loyal man through his masonry before a word of his speech. ↩
3. The audit of the herd: six hundred breeding sows within, only three hundred and sixty boars outside — “for the godlike suitors kept thinning them,” one fatted hog per day. The arithmetic of the house’s ruin is kept in livestock, by the man who must ship the tribute himself. (Ancient allegorists, counting 360, saw the days of the year being devoured; the swineherd counts only his losses.) ↩
4. “The swineherd, a leader of men” — συβώτης, ὄρχαμος ἀνδρῶν: the title elsewhere given to princes (Peisistratus, 3.400). Homer promotes the pig-keeper to the officer class by formula, and will keep doing so. Together with “noble swineherd” it makes Book 14’s music: aristocratic diction wrapped around absolute poverty, and meaning every word. ↩
5. The dogs’ attack, and the trick that saves him: he *sits down* — genuine dog-lore (a seated figure defuses the charge), instantly deployed — while the staff falls from his hand. But the poem marks what it costs: “there, at his own farm, he would have suffered shameful hurt.” The king of the island one bite from mauling by his own watchdogs, saved by his slave’s stones: the

homecoming's true condition, acted out in the first thirty lines. ↩

6. Eumaeus' first speech mourns his master to a total stranger, unprompted, before the guest is even seated: I fatten hogs for other men "while he, perhaps, is starving for bread" somewhere. The irony is exact and double: the master is standing in front of him, and *is* hungry. The poem will spend three books cashing that sentence. ↩
7. The guest-bed is "his own bedding, big and thick" — the wild-goat skin Eumaeus himself sleeps on. The man gives the thing he sleeps in. Menelaus gave purple blankets; the swineherd gives his bed. The poem has been grading hospitality since Book 1, and the scale just recalibrated. ↩
8. "And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd" — προσέφη: the poet breaks the third person and speaks to his character, here for the first of fifteen times. In the Iliad this apostrophe belongs above all to Patroclus — the most loved and doomed of men; in the Odyssey, only Eumaeus receives it. Explanations (metrical convenience, formulaic inheritance) exist and fail: the effect on any listener is tenderness — the narrator cannot keep his distance from this man. The translation keeps every occurrence. ↩
9. The creed: "it is not right (θέμις) for me — not though a worse man came — to slight a stranger: for from Zeus they come, all of them, strangers and beggars; and a gift, though small, is dear." Lines 57–58 repeat Nausicaa's beach-creed verbatim (6.207–208), as the glossary promised — princess and slave alone in the poem speak the law of Zeus Xenios in its pure

form. But Eumaeus adds a codicil no princess could: “from such as we are: for that is the way of slaves, always afraid, when the masters who hold the power are the young ones.” Hospitality practiced *from below*, under fear — the same commandment, costlier obedience. It is the moral center of the poem, and the poem knows exactly whom it gave the speech to. ↩

10. Here the translation follows Murray’s text, which prints line 64 before 63 (the second of his two transpositions, catalogued with 3.304–305): the sense runs “possessions — a house, a plot, a much-courted wife — such things as a kind master gives his slave.” Note what Eumaeus’ dream *is*: not freedom, which the poem’s world barely imagines, but the good master’s full reward — house, land, wife. The horizon of a slave’s hope, stated without bitterness, which is its own indictment. ↩
11. “I wish Helen’s whole breed had gone down on its knees to destruction, for she loosed the knees of many men.” The war seen from below: to the great, Helen is a face and a grievance; to the slave whose master she cost him, a breed to be cursed root and branch. The κατ’ γούνατα wordplay (may her line fall to its knees, who unstrung so many men’s) is a hater’s pun, and the poem gives it to the gentlest man in it. ↩
12. “Eat, stranger — what house-slaves have to offer: young pig. The fattened hogs — the suitors eat those.” The menu is the class system: sucklings below, fattened hogs above, and the slave apologizes for the difference while the disguised owner of every pig on the table eats his own property as charity. ↩

13. Eumaeus' theology is the poem's argument in miniature: the gods "honor justice and the right acts of men" — even *pirates*, he says, who raid with Zeus' own leave, feel "the strong fear of the watching eye" (ὄπις) and go home. The suitors do not. In the swineherd's ethics, professional sea-raiders stand a full rung above gentlemen who eat a neighbor's house: the raider at least knows he owes; the suitor believes it's free. No character indicts the suitors more precisely, and none has read less philosophy. ↩
14. The estate audit, "I will count it through for you": twelve herds of cattle, twelve of sheep, twelve of swine, twelve goat-ranges on the mainland, eleven more here, plus his own six hundred sows. Eumaeus carries the entire wealth of Odysseus in his head, itemized — the bookkeeping loyalty of a steward who has balanced a dead man's accounts for twenty years and cannot stop. The master listening is the ledger's owner; the poem lets him hear his fortune recited as an elegy. ↩
15. "Ravenous, silent — planting evils for the suitors": the great double-clause. The beggar's body eats; the king's mind sows (φύτευεν — the farming verb). Every meal in these books is also a war council of one. ↩
16. Eumaeus' epistemology of vagrants: "drifters in need of keep lie at random, and have no wish to speak the truth"; each one reaches Penelope and "babbles his deceits" while she weeps and questions. The report is doubly loaded: it is true (we will watch beggar-tales manipulate her), it describes *exactly what the listening beggar is about to do* — and it establishes the tragic economy of hope in the house: lies are the only news supply, so

all news is discounted to zero. Odysseus learns here that the truth, when he tells it, will not be believed either. ↩

17. “You too, old man, would have a story stitched together fast enough if someone would give you clothing,” Eumaeus states, to Odysseus’ face, the precise exchange-rate of the coming books: tales for cloaks. The poem’s most-repeated transaction is quoted in advance by its most clear-eyed victim — who will pay out the cloak anyway (520–522), knowingly, which is the whole difference between him and a fool. ↩
18. “I shrink from naming him, stranger, even now he is absent... I call him ‘my beloved lord’ (ἡθελῖον)” — the address of a younger brother to an elder. The name has become taboo through grief; in its place, a kinship term. The slave has promoted the master to family — and the master, sitting three feet away, must hear himself so named and stay silent under the disguise. ↩
19. “Hateful to me as the very gates of Hades is the man who yields to poverty and babbles deceits” — Achilles’ line, almost exactly (Iliad 9.312–313: hateful as the gates of Hades the man who hides one thing in his heart and says another), the most famous anti-lying credo in Greek. Spoken here by the poem’s champion liar, *inside a lie*, as a warranty for the true oath he is about to swear. The audacity is the art: he quotes the code of the man who despised him, to notarize the one thing he says all evening that is strictly true — Odysseus is coming. ↩
20. The prophecy is precise: “within this very turning of the light (λυκάβας)... between this month’s waning and the rising of the next.” The dark of the moon — which is exactly when the festival of Apollo falls in Book 20, the day of the bow. The

beggar names the true date of the revenge to the day, under oath, and is not believed. Prophecy in this poem is never wrong, only discounted — and this time the prophet is the event. ↩

21. Eumaeus' grief widens to the son: the ambush may end "the line of godlike Arceisius... and leave no name." The slave counts the dynasty's generations like the family's own (four, as at 4.755) and fears its extinction as his own catastrophe — which, in the world of 61–67, it literally would be: a slave's whole fortune is the quality of his masters. ↩
22. The identity-questions, verbatim from Telemachus' to Athena (1.170–173) down to the small joke, "for I hardly think you came here on foot." A slave interrogates the stranger with the same formula princes use — Book 14's leveling machine at work again — and receives, as answer, the poem's longest and best lie. ↩
23. The preamble to the Cretan tale — give me food and quiet "and I could go on easily for a full year" — signals the genre: this is a professional's performance, with the fee (food, wine, and peace to talk) named up front. What follows (199–359) is the greatest of the Cretan tales: 160 lines of fiction built, like all his best work, almost entirely out of relocated truth. ↩
24. The false autobiography is a variant self: Cretan, a bought concubine's son honored equally with the true-born — then cheated of the inheritance by the legitimate heirs. A man of Odysseus' talents starting from *no* position: the tale runs his own qualities (ambush-craft, restlessness, command) through a harder childhood. His fictions are always thought-

experiments on himself — Odysseus minus one advantage, compounding differently. ↩

25. “I was no empty man, no battle-shirker... looking at the stubble you can tell the standing grain.” The harvest-metaphor for ruined greatness — the finest line the beggar-persona ever gets, and it does double duty: it begs respect for the fiction and pleads, through the mask, for the real man in the rags. ↩
26. The confession of vocation: field-work and housekeeping “I never loved... what I loved, always, was the oared ships, and wars, and polished javelins, and arrows — grim things, that other men shudder at. But I loved what the god, I suppose, set in my heart: one man delights in one work, another in another.” The most honest sentence in the lie: it is Odysseus’ own psychology, barely translated. The poem’s theory of temperament — desire as a god-given allotment, beyond praise or blame — is delivered by a fictional Cretan and believed by everyone, including, perhaps, the speaker. ↩
27. “There was no device for refusing: the people’s hard talk held us to it” — δήμου φῆμις, the voice of the community as a compulsion no lord can defy. One line on how the levy for Troy actually worked: reputation-pressure, not conscription. The real Odysseus feigned madness to dodge the draft (a tale the poem knows but never tells); his fiction goes quietly, dreading gossip. ↩
28. The Egypt raid replays the Cicones (9.39–61) beat for beat — landfall, the captain’s orders ignored, the crew’s greed, the countryside roused, dawn counterattack, rout. He has folded his own worst command failure into the fiction, unimproved.

Even his lies keep honest accounts of how expeditions die: not by monsters, but by indiscipline between one landfall and the next dawn. ↩

29. “They gave way to arrogance (ὑβρεῖ)... carried off the women and small children, and killed the men.” The raid is narrated without euphemism — this is what his profession *is* when it goes to plan, and the fictional crew’s atrocity is the real trade’s routine. Told in a slave’s hut, to a man whom exactly such a raid enslaved as a child (15.403ff.), by the man who owns him. The poem’s ironies do not come tighter. ↩
30. “Others they led up alive, to slave for them by force” — δούλιον ἦμαρ hangs over the whole tale. The Cretan’s companions become slaves in Egypt; the Cretan himself will be nearly sold twice more before the tale ends. To his audience of one slave, slavery is the fiction’s recurring weather — the fate the teller keeps grazing and dodging, which his listener did not dodge. ↩
31. The supplication scene: helmet off, shield down, spear dropped, the king’s knees kissed — and it *works*: “he spared me, and had mercy... he feared the wrath of Zeus of Strangers, who above all feels fury at evil deeds.” The Egyptian king is the anti-Polyphemus: identical doctrine (9.269–271), opposite verdict. In Odysseus’ fictions the xenia-law functions — his invented world is more pious than the one he has actually sailed. ↩
32. The Phoenician “gnawer” (τρώκτης) — the swindling trader who sells passengers — is the stock villain of Greek sea-lore (the type returns in Eumaeus’ own life story, 15.415ff.). Note the economy of prejudice: Phaeacians are the fantasy of seafaring (escort freely given), Phoenicians its libel (passage as

kidnapping). Both are mirrors of the Greek trader looking at himself. ↩

33. Lines 301–309 reuse the true shipwreck of Book 12 nearly verbatim — the dark-blue cloud (12.403–406), the thunderbolt, sulfur, men like sea-crows, “the god took away their homecoming” (12.415–419) — and the translation repeats itself accordingly. The liar plagiarizes his own catastrophe: the realest thing that ever happened to him is cut and pasted into the fiction, because nothing invented could beat it. For the poem’s audience, who heard it three books ago as truth, the effect is vertiginous — the same verses, now load-bearing in a lie. ↩

34. Pheidon takes him in “and asked no price” (ἀπριάτην) — the word marks the alternative fate: a castaway is salvage, and decency is declining to sell him. The Thesprotian interlude is built to be checkable-sounding: a named king, the king’s own son for a rescuer, an oath over libation. This same tale, nearly verbatim, will be retold to Penelope (19.269ff.) — he is drafting, tonight, the version his wife will hear. ↩

35. Inside the lie, the truth, one ring out: Odysseus alive, heavy with banked treasure (“enough to feed a man’s line to the tenth generation” — a hoard to rival the Phaeacians’), the man himself weighing “how he should come home... openly or in secret.” That last clause is this very evening’s actual question, placed in a fictional king’s mouth. The Cretan tales converge on fact asymptotically — alive, rich, deliberating his return — while the Thesprotian bank and the Dodona errand remain scaffolding, invented like the narrator. ↩

36. Dodona: Zeus' oldest oracle, where the god speaks from the rustling of "the high-crowned oak." The poem's second oracle-consultation (Agamemnon at Pytho, 8.79–81) — heroes check with heaven before the last leg. That the fictional Odysseus consults an oak about *open versus secret* return while the real one sits disguised in rags is the tale winking at its teller. ↩
37. "My day of slavery" — δούλιον ἦμαρ: the threatened fate arrives at Ithaca's very coast — stripped, re-dressed in "the very rags you see with your own eyes" (the boldest touch: his actual costume, sourced within the lie), lashed in the ship. Then the escape: gods loosen the rope, the swim, the flowering thicket, "the gods hid me easily." The fiction lands its hero on Ithaca by night, hunted, hidden by gods — which is precisely how the real one arrived at dawn this very day. He is telling Eumaeus the truth at one remove, and the poem lets us grade the fit. ↩
38. Eumaeus' verdict is a masterpiece of critical method: the travelogue moves him ("you have stirred the heart in me") but "one part is not in order (οὐ κατὰ κόσμον)... that about Odysseus." He audits the tale and strikes the one stretch of it that carries the truth — the Odysseus section, its factual core bundled with its invented Thesprotian trimmings. Twenty years of hope-vendors have taught him a filter that now screens out the fact. The poem's meditation on testimony: a lie detector calibrated by grief will fail exactly once — on the truth. ↩
39. Lines 368–371 repeat Telemachus' lament verbatim (1.238–241): the tomb the Achaeans would have built, the fame for the son, "the whirlwinds have snatched him away without glory." Son and slave, who have never compared notes, grieve in the same

fixed sentences — the household's sorrow has a liturgy, and the poem keeps it word-perfect across twelve books. ↩

40. The Aetolian — a killer on the run who paid for welcome with a tale of Odysseus in Crete, “back by summer or by harvest” — is Eumaeus’ inoculation story, the specific betrayal behind his disbelief. Note the detail: that liar also used *Crete*. When the real Odysseus chose a Cretan persona tonight, he picked, by black luck or the poem’s design, the exact provenance already poisoned for this listener. ↩
41. The great sentence of the book: “do not court my favor with lies, do not charm me: it is not for that I will respect you or befriend you, but out of fear of Zeus of Strangers, and out of pity for yourself.” Kindness fully decoupled from credence: I do not believe you, and it changes nothing about what I owe you. Every other host in the poem was testing the stranger’s story; Eumaeus alone declares the story irrelevant to the duty. It is the purest statement of unconditional hospitality in Greek literature — from the man with least to give. ↩
42. Odysseus raises the stakes to a gambler’s contract: if I’m wrong, have your slaves throw me off the cliff, “so that the next beggar too may think twice before he cheats.” He offers his life as a performance bond on his own truthfulness — safely, since he is the collateral event. The bravado is real and the risk is zero: the house always wins when the house is Odysseus. ↩
43. Eumaeus’ refusal drips with the poem’s driest irony: “a fine name I would win for goodness... if having given you a guest’s due I then killed you — with a clean heart, after that, I could pray to Zeus!” He declines the wager because accepting it

would make him the Cyclops: host-murder as the one unthinkable. Then, without a beat: “But it is supper time.” The moral abyss surveyed and dismissed between courses. ↩

44. For the stranger, Eumaeus breaks his own rationing: “the best of the hogs” — a fatted five-year-old, the class of animal reserved for the suitors’ tribute. His stated accounting: we who suffer for these swine deserve some good of them, “while others eat our labor and pay nothing” (νήποινον — the suitors’ word since 1.377). One pig, reclaimed from the expropriators, spent on a beggar: the little feast is a small act of economic justice, and everyone at the table knows it. ↩
45. The sacrifice-scene in miniature, scrupulous at every step — bristles to the fire, prayer, first-cuts wrapped in fat, barley — “for his mind was set on good.” And the prayer itself: “that wise Odysseus might come home to his own house” — offered over the fire while wise Odysseus watches from the guest-seat. The swineherd’s rite is answered before it is finished; no prayer in the poem has a shorter delivery distance. ↩
46. Seven portions: one for the Nymphs and Hermes (the herdsman’s gods — the local spring-nymphs of 13.356 and the patron of flocks and luck), five for the men, and the seventh — the poem lets us do the arithmetic — for the server himself last. Distributive justice at a slave’s table, conducted “for his mind knew what was fair”: the same ἰσῆς-ethic Odysseus practiced with his loot (9.42) practiced here with a single pig. ↩
47. The guest is honored with the chine — the hero’s cut, exactly what Menelaus served Telemachus at Sparta (4.65–66) — “and

made his master's heart proud" (κύδαине δὲ θυμὸν ἄνακτος). The Greek is a loaded double exposure: the swineherd honors the beggar and, unknowing, thereby honors *the master himself* — the heart the line gladdens is ἄνακτος, the hidden owner's. The poem's grammar knows who is at the table. ↩

48. "The god will give one thing and let another go, whatever his own heart wills: for he can do all things." Eumaeus' grace before meat is Helen's theology (4.236–237) in a slave's plain diction — the same clause, δύναται γὰρ ἅπαντα, closing both. Sparta's queen and Ithaca's pig-keeper keep one creed; the poem's religion has no class accent. ↩
49. Mesaulius: bread-server, and a slave *owned by a slave* — bought by Eumaeus "with goods of his own," from Taphian traders, "without his mistress, without old Laertes" (the formula of his self-reliance, repeated from 9). The poem's most granular economics: property runs all the way down, and even at the bottom of the pyramid a man saves, buys, and staffs. No ancient text otherwise bothers to record that a swineherd could hold an asset; Homer files it twice. ↩
50. The cloak-night: moonless dark, all-night rain, wet west wind — and Odysseus "testing the swineherd" one more time. He has been fed, blessed, bedded; now he probes the last increment: will the man strip his own back? The test is engineered as entertainment — what follows is the most elegant con in the poem, run for a blanket. ↩
51. The wind-up is a disclaimer-performance: blame the wine, "that sets even the deep-minded singing... and tosses out many a word better left unspoken." He licenses the boast before

making it — the professional storyteller’s liability waiver, and a wink the audience can price: this speaker has drunk exactly enough to seem loose while being surgical. ↩

52. The fable (αἶνος): an ambush under Troy — led by *Odysseus*, with the teller as third officer. The disguised man inserts his real self into the story as a separate character, then narrates his own legendary cunning from the outside: the freezing night, the forgotten cloak, and “*Odysseus*” solution — a fake dream, a fake tactical errand, and Thoas sprinting off leaving his purple cloak behind. A lie (the Cretan) telling a story (the ambush) containing a lie (the dream) that produced a cloak: three nested fictions, each generating real warmth. It is the poem’s compactest model of its own hero — and of itself. ↩
53. “In the night’s third watch, when the stars had crossed their height” — the same star-clock as Thrinacia (12.312), here timing not a divine storm but a freezing man’s calculation. The formulas serve comedy and catastrophe with equal precision. ↩
54. “Quiet now, lest some other Achaean hear you” — the in-fable *Odysseus*’ first move is sound-discipline, whispered “in a small voice.” The real *Odysseus*, telling it, is performing his own legend’s tradecraft in miniature: even the fictional rescue begins with operational security. ↩
55. The fake dream is a small masterpiece of plausible orders: gods send dreams (everyone believes it — cf. 4.795ff.), positions do get overextended, Agamemnon should be told. Thoas volunteers because the errand is *plausible glory* — and the cloak falls to the schemer. Note whom the fable robs: a named hero,

Thoas son of Andraemon, still alive and ruling in Aetolia — and Eumaeus' one bad experience was with an *Aetolian* (379). The tale's textures interlock like joinery. ↪

56. The moral, spelled out twice so no one can miss it: “someone in this steading might give a swineherd's cloak... in kindness, and in respect for a good man. As it is, they scorn me for the foul clothes on my skin.” The ask, at last, in the open — clothed (the only word) as nostalgia. ↪

57. Eumaeus' response is the book's crown: “that is a blameless fable (αἶνος ἀμύμων)... nothing said without its profit (νηκερδής).” He names the genre, praises the craftsmanship, *itemizes the angle* — “not without profit” is a critic identifying the con — and then pays out anyway: the cloak comes (520–522), his spare, the storm-cloak. He is the poem's ideal audience: alert to the angle and generous in the same motion. Where Alcinous certified the teller as singer (11.368), the swineherd certifies him as operator — and both reward the performance. He sees the fable's profit even as the larger disguise holds: the listener who catches the con is the one who gives most freely. ↪

58. The close: the young men sleep inside by the fire, but Eumaeus arms — sword, wind-cloak, goat's fleece, javelin “against dogs and men” — and walks out into the rain-black night to sleep under a rock beside the boars. “And Odysseus was glad that he took such care of his substance while he was far away” (526–527): the master watching his slave choose the storm for the sake of property whose owner, as far as the slave knows, is dead. Gladness is the poem's word; the audience may supply the rest. The book's final line (533) leaves Eumaeus bedded

under the hollow rock — Book 14 ending as it began, with Eumaeus guarding what he believes is a ghost's estate, while the ghost, warm under the guard's own cloak, takes notes. ↩

Odyssey — Book 15

*Telemachus called home; Theoclymenus; the life of
Eumaeus.*

- 1 But Pallas Athena went her way to wide-
dancing-grounded Lacedaemon
- 2 to remind the shining son of great-hearted
Odysseus
- 3 of his homecoming, and to stir him to return.
- 4 She found Telemachus and Nestor's splendid
son
- 5 sleeping in the forecourt of glorious Menelaus
—
- 6 Nestor's son, at least, mastered by soft sleep;
- 7 but no sweet sleep held Telemachus: through
the ambrosial night¹
- 8 cares for his father kept his heart awake.
- 9 And gray-eyed Athena stood near him and
spoke:
- 10 "Telemachus, it is no longer good, this roaming

far from home

11 with your goods abandoned, and men in your
own house

12 of such overbearing insolence — or they will
devour it all,

13 dividing your goods among them, and your
journey come to nothing.

14 Rouse Menelaus of the great war-cry — quickly
—

15 to send you off, so you may find your blameless
mother still at home.

16 For already her father and her brothers press
her²

17 to marry Eurymachus: he outbids all the
suitors

18 in gifts, and keeps raising the bride-price
higher.

19 Take care nothing is carried from the house
against your will.

20 You know what kind of heart is in a woman's
breast:³

21 she wants to swell the house of the man who

marries her,

22 and of her former children, of the wedded
husband she has lost,

23 she thinks no more once he is dead. She asks
nothing.

24 No — go back yourself and put everything in
the hands

25 of whichever of the slave-women seems the
best to you,

26 until the gods reveal to you your honored
bride.

27 And another word I will tell you: lay it up in
your heart.

28 The best men of the suitors lie in wait for you
— deliberately —

29 in the strait between Ithaca and rugged Samos,

30 hungry to kill you before you reach your
fathers' land.

31 But I do not look for that. No: sooner will the
earth close over⁴

32 more than one of the suitor-men who eat away
your living.

33 Keep your well-made ship far out from the
islands,
34 and sail by night as well as day: that one of the
deathless ones
35 who guards and keeps you will send a breeze
behind you.
36 And when you reach the first shore of Ithaca,
37 send the ship and all the companions on to the
city,
38 but yourself, before all else, go to the
swineherd
39 who keeps your swine — whose heart is loyal
to you all the same.
40 Sleep the night there; and send him into the
city
41 to carry the news to watchful-minded
Penelope:
42 that you are safe, and have come home from
Pylos.”
43 So speaking, she went away to high Olympus.
44 And he woke Nestor’s son out of his sweet
sleep,

45 rousing him with a kick of his heel, and said to
him:⁵

46 “Wake up, Peisistratus, son of Nestor. Bring out
the strong-hoofed

47 horses and yoke them under the chariot, so we
can be on our road.”

48 Then Peisistratus, Nestor’s son, answered him:

49 “Telemachus — however we press for the road,
there is no

50 driving through the pitch-dark night. And it
will soon be dawn.

51 Wait, then, until the hero Atreus’ son,
Menelaus

52 famed for the spear, brings his gifts and sets
them in the chariot

53 and sends us on our way with kindly words.

54 For a guest remembers, all his days,⁶

55 the host who shows him kindness.”

56 So he spoke; and at once Dawn of the golden
throne came on.

57 And Menelaus of the great war-cry came up to
them,

58 fresh-risen from his bed, from beside fair-haired Helen.

59 When the dear son of Odysseus caught sight of him,

60 he hurried the shining tunic on about his body

61 and threw his great mantle over his sturdy shoulders —

62 the young hero — and went out; and coming up beside him,

63 Telemachus, dear son of godlike Odysseus, said:

64 “Menelaus, son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured, leader of peoples:

65 send me back now, at last, to my own dear fatherland,

66 for now my heart is longing to go home.”

67 Then Menelaus of the great war-cry answered him:

68 “Telemachus — far be it from me to hold you here for long,

69 when you strain for home. I would blame another man

70 as much for it — a host who loved beyond
measure⁷

71 or hated beyond measure: due measure is
better in all things.

72 It is equal wrong to push out a guest who does
not wish

73 to go, and to hold one back who is eager.

74 Cherish the guest who is with you; speed the
one who would leave.

75 Only wait until I bring my gifts and set them in
the chariot —

76 beautiful gifts; your own eyes will see them —
and I tell the women

77 to lay a meal in the hall from the plenty stored
within.

78 It is both honors at once — the glory and the
profit —

79 to dine before you go, over the wide and
boundless earth.

80 And if you care to swing through Hellas and
the heart of Argos,⁸

81 I will go with you myself: I will yoke you horses

82 and guide you through the cities of men; and
no one will send us
83 away as we came — each will give us one thing
at least to carry:
84 some tripod of fine bronze, or a cauldron,
85 or a pair of mules, or a golden cup.”
86 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:
87 “Menelaus, son of Atreus, Zeus-nurtured,
leader of peoples,
88 I want to go home to our own place now. For
when I left
89 I set no guard behind me over my possessions:
90 I fear I may perish myself, hunting my godlike
father,
91 or some fine treasure vanish from my halls.”
92 And when Menelaus of the great war-cry heard
it,
93 at once he told his wife and her slave-women
94 to lay a meal in the hall from the plenty stored
within.
95 And Eteoneus, Boethous’ son, came up to him,
96 just out of bed — for he lived not far away —

97 and Menelaus of the great war-cry bade him
light the fire
98 and roast some of the meat. He heard, and did
not disobey.
99 And Menelaus himself went down to his
fragrant treasure-chamber —
100 not alone: Helen went with him, and
Megapenthes.
101 And when they came to where his treasures
lay,
102 Atreus' son took up a two-handled cup,
103 and bade his son Megapenthes carry the
mixing-bowl
104 of silver; and Helen stood by the chests
105 where her robes lay, worked all over with
figures — she had made them herself.⁹
106 Helen lifted one of them out, shining among
women:
107 the one loveliest in its weaving, and the
amplest,
108 glittering like a star; it lay lowest of all the
rest.

109 Then they went back up through the house
until they reached

110 Telemachus; and fair-haired Menelaus said to
him:

111 “Telemachus — your homecoming, as your
heart desires it,

112 may Zeus accomplish, the loud-thundering
lord of Hera.

113 Of all the treasures lying stored in my house

114 I will give you the most beautiful, the most
honored:10

115 I will give you a wrought mixing-bowl — all
silver

116 it is, and its rims are finished off in gold —

117 the work of Hephaestus. The hero Phaedimus
gave it,

118 king of the Sidonians, when his house
sheltered me

119 on my way home there. This I would send with
you.”

120 So speaking, the hero Atreus’ son set the two-
handled cup

121 in his hands; and strong Megapenthes carried
in
122 the shining mixing-bowl of silver and set it
123 before him; and Helen of the lovely cheeks
stood by
124 with the robe in her hands, and spoke a word,
and named him:
125 “I too have a gift for you, dear child — this:11
126 a keepsake of Helen’s hands, against the hour
of the marriage
127 you long for, for your bride to wear. Until then
let it lie
128 in your dear mother’s keeping. And may you
come rejoicing
129 to your well-built house and your own
fatherland.”
130 So speaking she set it in his hands; and he
received it gladly.
131 And the hero Peisistratus took the gifts and
stowed them
132 in the chariot-basket, wondering at them all
in his heart.

133 Then fair-haired Menelaus led them into the
house,
134 and the two of them sat down on benches and
high seats.
135 A handmaid brought water for their hands in
a pitcher,
136 a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a
silver basin
137 for them to wash, and drew up a polished
table beside them.
138 The grave housekeeper brought bread and set
it before them,
139 laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of
her store;
140 and close by, Boethous' son carved the meat
and shared the portions,
141 and the son of glorious Menelaus poured the
wine.
142 And their hands went out to the good things
spread before them.
143 But when they had put away desire for food
and drink,

144 then Telemachus and Nestor's splendid son
145 yoked the horses and mounted the inlaid
chariot
146 and drove out of the gateway and the echoing
porch.
147 And after them came Atreus' son, fair-haired
Menelaus,
148 bearing honey-hearted wine in his right hand,
149 in a golden cup, for them to pour before they
went.
150 He stood before the horses, and pledging
them he spoke:
151 "Farewell, young men — and carry my
greeting to Nestor,
152 shepherd of the people: truly he was gentle as
a father to me
153 while we sons of the Achaeans made war at
Troy."
154 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:
155 "All this, Zeus-nurtured, just as you say,
156 we will tell him when we come. And would
that I as surely,

157 arriving home in Ithaca, might find Odysseus
in the house,
158 and tell him how I came from you, having met
with every kindness,
159 and bring home treasures many and fine.”
160 And even as he spoke, a bird flew by on the
right hand:12
161 an eagle, carrying in its talons a huge white
goose,
162 a tame one, out of the yard; and men and
women
163 streamed after it, shouting. And the eagle,
closing near them,
164 shot off to the right, in front of the horses. At
the sight
165 their hearts lifted: the spirit warmed in every
breast,
166 and among them Peisistratus, Nestor’s son,
began:
167 “Read it, Menelaus, Zeus-nurtured, leader of
peoples:
168 is it for us two the god has shown this sign, or

for yourself?”

169 So he spoke; and Menelaus, dear to Ares,
pondered

170 how he might read it rightly and reply.

171 But long-robed Helen was before him, and
spoke out: **13**

172 “Hear me — and I will prophesy as the
immortals

173 cast it in my heart, and as I think it will be
accomplished.

174 As this eagle snatched the goose fattened in
the house,

175 coming out of the mountain where his kin are,
and his birthplace,

176 so Odysseus, after much suffering and much
wandering,

177 will come home and take his vengeance — or
even now he is

178 home already, planting evil for all the suitors.”

179 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:

180 “May Zeus grant it so, the loud-thundering
lord of Hera:

181 then even there I would pray to you as to a
god.”¹⁴

182 He spoke, and laid the whip to the horses; and
they, full of fire,

183 sprang quickly through the city toward the
plain.

184 All day long they shook the yoke they bore
between them.

185 The sun went down, and all the ways grew
dark,

186 and they came to Pherae, to the house of
Diocles,

187 son of Ortilochus, whom Alpheus fathered.

188 There they slept the night, and he set guest-
gifts before them.

189 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,

190 they yoked the horses and mounted the inlaid
chariot

191 and drove out of the gateway and the echoing
porch;

192 and he whipped them to a run, and the pair

flew on, nothing loath.¹⁵

¹⁹³ And soon they came to the steep citadel of
Pylos.

¹⁹⁴ Then Telemachus spoke to the son of Nestor:

¹⁹⁵ “Son of Nestor — will you undertake a thing
for me and see it

¹⁹⁶ done, as I ask? Guest-friends from of old we
may call ourselves,

¹⁹⁷ from our fathers’ friendship — and we are of
one age besides,

¹⁹⁸ and this journey has set us still more of one
mind.

¹⁹⁹ Do not drive me past my ship, Zeus-nurtured:
leave me there —

²⁰⁰ or the old man will keep me in his house
against my will,¹⁶

²⁰¹ aching to host me. And I must get home
quickly.”

²⁰² So he spoke; and Nestor’s son debated with
his heart

²⁰³ how he might undertake it rightly, and see it
done.

204 And as he weighed it, this seemed to him the
better way:
205 he turned the horses toward the fast ship and
the shore of the sea,
206 and in the ship's stern he unloaded the
beautiful gifts,
207 the clothing and the gold that Menelaus gave;
208 and urging Telemachus on, he spoke winged
words to him:
209 "Aboard with you now — quick — and order
all your companions,
210 before I reach home and bring the old man
the news.
211 For I know this well, in my mind and in my
heart:
212 so overpowering is his spirit, he will not let
you go —
213 he will come down here himself to summon
you, and I tell you
214 he will not go back empty-handed. Angry he
will be, whatever happens."
215 So speaking he drove the fine-maned horses

back

216 to the city of the Pylians, and quickly reached
the house.

217 And Telemachus called to his companions and
commanded them:

218 “Set the tackle in order, companions, through
the black ship,

219 and let us board ourselves, and be on our
road.”

220 So he spoke, and they listened well and
obeyed:

221 and they came aboard at once and took their
places at the oarlocks.

222 So he busied himself; and by the stern of the
ship he prayed

223 and sacrificed to Athena. And there came up
beside him a man

224 from a far country, in flight from Argos for
killing a man —

225 a seer, of the lineage of Melampus, 17

226 who once, in time past, lived in Pylos mother
of flocks,

227 a rich man among the Pylians, in a house of
great wealth;
228 but he fled to another people, away from his
fatherland
229 and from great-hearted Neleus, proudest of
living men,
230 who held his vast estate by force a full year
round;
231 while Melampus, all that time, in the halls of
Phylacus
232 lay bound in bitter bonds, suffering strong
pains
233 for the sake of Neleus' daughter, and the deep
blindness of heart
234 that the goddess laid on him, the Fury who
strikes the house.
235 Yet he escaped his doom, and drove the deep-
lowing cattle
236 from Phylace to Pylos, and paid the ugly deed
237 of godlike Neleus back, and led the woman
home
238 to be his brother's wife. And he himself went

to another people,

239 to horse-pasturing Argos: there it was fated
for him

240 to live from then on, ruling over many
Argives.

241 There he married a wife and built a high-
roofed house,

242 and fathered Antiphates and Mantius, strong
sons both.

243 Antiphates fathered great-hearted Oicles,

244 and Oicles Amphiaraus, the rouser of armies,

245 whom Zeus who bears the aegis and Apollo
loved

246 in their hearts, with every kind of love; yet he
never reached

247 the threshold of old age: he died at Thebes —
a woman's bribes.18

248 And to him were born sons, Alcmaeon and
Amphilochus.

249 And Mantius, in his turn, fathered
Polypheides and Cleitus —

250 but Cleitus golden-throned Dawn snatched

away,¹⁹

²⁵¹ for his beauty's sake, to live among the
immortals;

²⁵² and of high-hearted Polyphoides Apollo made
a seer

²⁵³ far the best among mortals, once Amphiaras
was dead.

²⁵⁴ He moved to Hyperesia, angry at his father,

²⁵⁵ and dwelling there he prophesied for all men.

²⁵⁶ It was this man's son who now came up —
Theoclymenus

²⁵⁷ was his name — and stood beside Telemachus.

²⁵⁸ He found him pouring wine and praying by
his fast

²⁵⁹ black ship, and he raised his voice and spoke
winged words:

²⁶⁰ "Friend — since I find you burning offerings
in this place,

²⁶¹ I beg you by these offerings, and by the god,
and then

²⁶² by your own head, and your companions' who
go with you:

263 tell me truly what I ask; hold nothing back.

264 What man are you, and from where? Where
are your city and your parents?"20

265 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:

266 "Then I will tell you, stranger, and tell you
truly.

267 By birth I am of Ithaca; my father is Odysseus
—

268 if he ever was; by now he has died some grim
death.

269 That is why I took companions and a black
ship

270 and came out for news of my father, so long
gone."

271 Then godlike Theoclymenus said to him:

272 "So I too am out of my country: I killed a man

273 of my own tribe; and his brothers and
kinsmen are many21

274 in horse-pasturing Argos, with great power
among the Achaeans.

275 It is their death I flee — the black doom of

their hands —

276 since now it is my lot to wander among men.

277 Take me aboard your ship, since in my flight I
have found you

278 begging; or they will kill me. I think they are
on my track.”

279 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

280 “Then I will not push you, willing as you are,
from the trim ship.

281 Come with us: there you will be made
welcome from what we have.”

282 So he spoke, and took the man’s bronze spear
from him

283 and laid it flat along the deck of the curved
ship;

284 and he himself stepped aboard the seagoing
vessel

285 and sat down in the stern, and beside him

286 he seated Theoclymenus. And his men cast off
the stern-lines.

287 And Telemachus called to his companions and
commanded them

288 to lay hands on the tackle; and they obeyed
him swiftly:

289 they raised the fir mast and stepped it in the
hollow

290 mast-box, made it fast with the forestays,

291 and hauled the white sail up by the twisted
ox-hide halyards.

292 And gray-eyed Athena sent them a following
wind

293 rushing hard through the clear sky, so the
ship might run

294 her course at speed across the salt water of
the sea.

295 And they ran past Crouni, and Chalcis of the
lovely streams.

296 The sun went down, and all the ways grew
dark,

297 and the ship bore on for Pheae, driven by the
wind of Zeus,

298 and along bright Elis, where the Epeians hold
power.

299 From there again he steered her for the Sharp

Islands,²²

³⁰⁰ wondering whether he would slip past death,
or be taken.

³⁰¹ And in the hut, meanwhile, Odysseus and the
noble swineherd

³⁰² were at supper; and the other men were at
supper with them.

³⁰³ When they had put away desire for food and
drink,

³⁰⁴ Odysseus spoke among them, making trial of
the swineherd —²³

³⁰⁵ whether he would still befriend him with all
care and press him

³⁰⁶ to stay there at the farmstead, or start him
toward the city:

³⁰⁷ “Hear me now, Eumaeus, and all you other
companions.

³⁰⁸ At dawn I want to go off to the city and beg
there,

³⁰⁹ so as not to wear you down — you and your
men.

³¹⁰ Only advise me well, and send along a good

guide

311 to bring me there. And through the town I will
drift on my own —

312 I must — in hopes someone will hand me a
cup and a crust.

313 And I would come to the house of godlike
Odysseus

314 and give my news to watchful-minded
Penelope,

315 and mix with those suitors in their insolence
—

316 they might spare me a dinner out of their
endless plenty.

317 I would serve well among them, whatever
they wanted done.

318 For I will tell you this — take it in, and hear
me out:

319 by the favor of Hermes the guide, who lends
the grace²⁴

320 and glory to all the labor of men's hands,

321 no other mortal can compete with me at
service:

322 at building up a fire, at splitting seasoned
wood,

323 at carving and at roasting meat, at pouring
wine —

324 all that lesser men do, waiting on the great.”

325 Then, greatly stirred, you answered him,
Eumaeus the swineherd:25

326 “Ah, stranger — why has such a thought come
into

327 your mind? You must be hungry to die on the
spot,

328 if you truly mean to walk into that crowd

329 of suitors, whose arrogance and violence
reach the iron sky.26

330 Their serving-men are nothing like you:

331 they are young, well-dressed in cloaks and
tunics,

332 sleek their heads always, and handsome their
faces —

333 those are the men who wait upon the suitors’
polished tables,

334 loaded down with bread and meat and wine.

335 No — stay. Nobody is put out by your being
here,
336 not I, and not any of my companions with me.
337 But when the dear son of Odysseus comes,
338 that man will clothe you in a cloak and a
tunic,
339 and send you wherever your heart and spirit
bid you go.”**27**
340 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus
answered him:
341 “Eumaeus — may you be as dear to father
Zeus
342 as you are to me: for you have stopped my
wandering and my grim misery.
343 Nothing is more wretched for mortal men
than roaming:**28**
344 it is for the cursed belly’s sake men take hard
pains,
345 when wandering and sorrow and grief have
come upon them.
346 But now, since you hold me here to wait for
that young man,

347 come, tell me of godlike Odysseus' mother,
348 and his father, whom he left on the doorsill of
old age:

349 are they still living, somewhere under the
rays of the sun,

350 or dead by now, and down in the house of
Hades?"

351 Then the swineherd answered him, a leader of
men:

352 "Then I will tell you, stranger, and tell you
truly.

353 Laertes is living still, but praying always

354 to Zeus that the life may waste out of his
limbs in his own halls:

355 so terribly he mourns for his son who is gone,

356 and for the wise wife of his youth — her death
above all

357 has broken him, and brought him raw old age
before his time.

358 And she died of grief for her son, for her
famous son —29

359 a wretched death. May no one die so who

lives here

360 and is a friend to me, and has dealt with me in
kindness.

361 While she still lived, for all her endless sorrow,

362 it was some pleasure to me to ask for her and
after her,

363 because she reared me herself, with long-
robed Ctimene, 30

364 her stately daughter, the youngest child she
bore.

365 With her I was raised, and honored little less.

366 But when the two of us came to the threshold
of our prime,

367 they gave her in marriage to Same — and got
a fortune for her —

368 while me the lady dressed in a mantle and
tunic,

369 fine clothes, and bound good sandals on my
feet,

370 and sent me to the farm. But she loved me
from the heart still more.

371 Now I go without all that. And yet the blessed

gods

372 make the work prosper under my hand, the
work I keep to:

373 from it I have eaten and drunk, and given to
those I owe respect.

374 But from the mistress herself there is nothing
sweet to hear,

375 no word, no kindness, since that evil fell upon
the house —

376 those overweening men. And slaves miss it
greatly,31

377 speaking before the mistress, and learning all
the news,

378 and eating and drinking, and carrying
something afterward

379 off to the fields — the things that warm a
slave's heart.”

380 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

381 “Well — how small you must have been,
swineherd Eumaeus,

382 when you were carried so far from your

country and your parents.

383 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

384 was it a wide-wayed city of men that was
sacked,

385 the one where your father and your honored
mother lived,

386 or were you alone with your sheep or with
your cattle

387 when raiders took you into their ships and
carried you over

388 to this man's house, and he paid a worthy
price?"32

389 Then the swineherd answered him, a leader
of men:

390 "Stranger, since you ask me this, and want it
all —

391 listen in silence now, and take your ease, and
sit

392 drinking your wine. These nights go on past
telling.33

393 There is time enough for sleep, and time to
take joy in listening;

394 no need to bed down before the hour: even
sleep grows a weariness.

395 As for the rest of you — whoever's heart and
spirit bid him,

396 go out and sleep; and at the showing of the
dawn

397 eat, and follow out the swine of our master.

398 But we two in the hut, over our drink and
food,

399 will take our pleasure in each other's grim
sorrows,

400 remembering them. For afterward a man
finds pleasure even in pains,³⁴

401 when he has suffered much and wandered far.

402 So I will tell you what you ask me, what you
probe for.

403 There is an island called Syrie — you may
have heard of it —

404 above Ortygia, where the turnings of the sun
are:³⁵

405 not so crowded with people, but a good land,

406 rich in herds, rich in flocks, full of wine, deep

in wheat.

407 Famine never enters that country, nor does
any

408 hateful sickness fall on wretched mortals
there:

409 but when the generations of men grow old in
the town,

410 Apollo of the silver bow comes with Artemis

411 and visits them with his gentle arrows, and
kills them.36

412 Two cities are there, and everything is halved
between them,

413 and over both of them my father was the king

—

414 Ctesius, son of Ormenus, a match for the
immortals.

415 There Phoenicians came — men famed for
ships,

416 gnawers, with countless trinkets in their black
vessel.37

417 Now in my father's house there was a
Phoenician woman,

418 beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious
handwork;38

419 and the Phoenicians, subtle-minded, led her
astray.

420 Washing clothes by the hollow ship, one of
them first

421 lay with her in love — the thing that leads
astray39

422 the minds of women, even one whose works
are honest.

423 Then he asked her who she was, and where
she came from,

424 and she pointed at once to my father's high-
roofed house:

425 'I claim my birth from Sidon, rich in bronze,

426 and I am the daughter of Arybas, a man of
flowing wealth.

427 But Taphian pirates snatched me as I came
in40

428 from the fields, and carried me over the sea
and sold me

429 to this man's house; and he paid a worthy

price.’⁴¹

⁴³⁰ Then the man who had lain with her in secret
said:

⁴³¹ ‘Then would you come home again with us, to
look on

⁴³² the high-roofed house of your father and
mother — and on them?

⁴³³ For they are living still, and are called
wealthy.’

⁴³⁴ Then the woman answered him and said:

⁴³⁵ ‘Even that could be, if you sailors were willing
⁴³⁶ to bind yourselves by oath to bring me home
unharméd.’

⁴³⁷ So she spoke, and they all swore the oath she
demanded.

⁴³⁸ And when they had sworn and sealed the
oath entire,

⁴³⁹ the woman spoke among them again and
answered:

⁴⁴⁰ ‘Silence, now. Let none of your company say a
word

⁴⁴¹ to me, meeting me in the street or at the well,

442 or someone may go to the house and tell the
old man;
443 and he, suspecting, would bind me in hard
bonds,
444 and set his mind on death for all of you.
445 Keep the word in your hearts, and press the
buying of your cargo.
446 But when your ship is full and freighted with
goods,
447 let a message come quickly to me at the
house.
448 For I will bring gold too — whatever comes
under my hand.
449 And there is another thing I would gladly give
for my passage:
450 I nurse a child of this fine man in the halls —
451 such a knowing little thing, always running
out beside me.⁴²
452 I would bring him aboard the ship, and he
would fetch you
453 a boundless price, wherever you sell him
among strange-tongued men.'

454 So speaking, she went off to the beautiful
house.

455 And they stayed among us a whole year long,
456 and bought and gathered goods in their
hollow ship;

457 and when the hollow hull was freighted for
their crossing,

458 they sent a messenger up to bring the woman
word.

459 A man came, deep in cunning, to my father's
house

460 with a necklace of gold, strung here and there
with amber.43

461 And in the hall the slave-women and my
honored mother

462 kept turning it in their hands and drinking it
with their eyes,

463 offering him their price; and he nodded to the
woman in silence.

464 He nodded — then went his way to the hollow
ship;

465 and she took me by the hand and led me out

through the doors.

466 In the forecourt she found the cups and the
tables

467 of the banqueters, the men who attended on
my father:

468 they had gone out to the people's session and
debate.

469 Quickly she hid three goblets away at her
breast

470 and carried them off. And I followed — in my
child's witlessness.⁴⁴

471 The sun went down, and all the ways grew
dark,

472 and we came at a run to the famous harbor,

473 where the sea-swift ship of the Phoenician
men was lying.

474 Then they embarked, and went their way over
the watery paths,

475 with the two of us aboard; and Zeus sent
down a wind.

476 Six days we sailed on, alike by day and night;

477 but when Zeus, the son of Cronos, brought the

seventh day,

478 then Artemis the shooter of arrows struck the
woman,

479 and she dropped with a thud into the bilge,
like a sea-tern.45

480 They heaved her overboard, spoil for the seals
and fishes,

481 and I was left alone, my heart aching.

482 Then wind and water carried them along to
Ithaca,

483 and there Laertes bought me, with his own
possessions.

484 So it was my eyes first looked upon this land.”

485 Then Odysseus, seed of Zeus, answered him
with words:

486 “Eumaeus, you have deeply stirred the heart
here in my breast,

487 telling all these things — the sorrows your
heart has suffered.

488 And yet, I say, Zeus set the good beside the
evil for you,46

489 since after all that pain you came to the

house of a kind

490 man, who provides your food and drink with
every care,

491 and you live a good life — while I come to you
here

492 as I am: still wandering through the many
cities of men.”

493 So they spoke to each other of such things,

494 then lay down to sleep — no long time, a little
only,

495 for soon Dawn came on her fair throne. And
on the shore

496 the companions of Telemachus were striking
sail:

497 they took the mast down smartly and rowed
her in to anchorage,

498 and threw the mooring-stones out, and made
the stern-lines fast;

499 and they themselves stepped out into the
breaking surf

500 and readied a meal, and mixed the sparkling
wine.

501 And when they had put away desire for food
and drink,
502 clear-headed Telemachus began and spoke
among them:
503 “Row the black ship on now, all of you, to the
city.
504 I will make my way to the fields and to the
herdsmen,
505 and at evening, once I have looked over the
farmlands, I will come down.
506 In the morning I will set before you the wages
of the voyage:
507 a good feast of meats, and honey-hearted
wine.”
508 Then godlike Theoclymenus said to him:
509 “And where shall I go, dear child? Whose
house shall I come to,
510 of the men who hold power in rocky Ithaca?
511 Straight to your mother’s house — is that
where I go — and yours?”
512 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:
513 “At any other time I would tell you: come to

our house —

514 there is no lack there of what a guest is given.

But for you, now,

515 it would be the worse way: I will be gone, and
my mother

516 will not see you. For not often before the
suitors in that house

517 does she appear: apart from them she weaves
at her loom, upstairs.

518 But I will name you another man you might
go to:

519 Eurymachus, glorious son of thoughtful
Polybus, 47

520 whom now the men of Ithaca look on like a
god.

521 For he is far the best man there — and
hungriest of all

522 to marry my mother and take the honor that
was Odysseus’.

523 But Zeus the Olympian, who has his home in
the bright sky,

524 knows whether before any wedding he will

bring their evil day.”

525 And even as he spoke, a bird flew by on his
right hand:

526 a hawk, the swift messenger of Apollo. In its
talons48

527 it held a dove, and was tearing it, and shook
the feathers down

528 to the ground, midway between the ship and
Telemachus himself.

529 And Theoclymenus called him apart from his
companions,

530 and pressed his hand, and spoke a word, and
named him:

531 “Telemachus, not without a god did that bird
fly past on the right:

532 I knew it, looking at it face-on, for a bird of
omen.

533 There is no line more kingly than your own

534 in the land of Ithaca. No: yours is the power
forever.”49

535 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

536 “Ah, stranger, if only that word might be

accomplished:

537 then you would quickly know my friendship,
and gifts

538 in plenty from me — any man who met you
would call you blessed.”

539 And he turned and spoke to Piraeus, his
trusted companion:

540 “Piraeus, son of Clytius — you who in other
things obey me

541 most of all the companions who followed me
to Pylos:

542 now too, I ask you, take this stranger to your
house

543 and care for him kindly, and honor him, until
I come.”

544 Then Piraeus, famous for the spear, answered
him:

545 “Telemachus, even if you should stay out
there a long while,

546 I will look after this man; no guest’s due shall
he lack.”

547 So speaking, he went aboard the ship, and

called the companions

548 to come aboard themselves and loose the
stern-lines;

549 and they came aboard at once and took their
places at the oarlocks.

550 And Telemachus bound his beautiful sandals
under his feet

551 and took his strong spear up from the deck of
the ship,

552 sharp-tipped with bronze. And the men cast
off the stern-lines:

553 they shoved out and sailed on to the city, as
they were ordered

554 by Telemachus, dear son of godlike Odysseus.

555 But his feet carried him swiftly, striding, until
he reached the yard50

556 where his swine past counting were; and
beside them the swineherd

557 slept, a good man, whose heart was loyal to
his masters.

Notes

NOTES

1. The book opens by splitting the sleepers: Peisistratus sleeps, Telemachus cannot. It is the same night in which, at the end of Book 14, Odysseus lay awake testing Eumaeus for a cloak. Father and son are wakeful at the two ends of the poem's map, and the narrative now begins pulling them toward a single hut. ↩
2. Athena sharpens the truth to move the boy. The family pressure is real — Penelope herself will say her parents urge her to remarry (19.157–159) — but the Eurymachus particular appears nowhere else, and Penelope's own conduct answers it. The goddess of *mētis* tells the anxious son the version that will make him move fastest. ↩
3. This cold little essay on women's hearts — the remarrying widow forgets her first children and dead husband — is Athena speaking, not the poet, and it is aimed like a goad. Its cynicism is precisely calibrated to Telemachus' worst fear (cf. Odysseus' own darker version of the same anxiety at 11.441–456, from Agamemnon). The poem as a whole spends its second half refuting the generalization through Penelope. ↩
4. Lines 31–32 repeat Athena's assurance to Odysseus at 13.427–428 word for word — the goddess makes the same promise about the same ambush to father and son separately. The English repeats verbatim. ↩
5. A homely detail unique in Homer: Telemachus wakes his friend “rousing him with a kick of his heel” (λάξ ποδὶ κινήσας). The

gesture is affectionate roommate-familiarity, and marks how far the shy boy of Book 1 has come. ↩

6. “A guest remembers, all his days, / the host who shows him kindness” — Peisistratus’ gentle rebuke states the whole social theory of *xenia* in two lines: hospitality is an investment in memory. ↩
7. Menelaus’ famous maxims of measured hospitality: blame alike for the host who “loves beyond measure” and who “hates beyond measure”; “equal wrong to push out a guest who does not wish to go, and to hold one back who is eager”; and the summary couplet, “cherish the guest who is with you; speed the one who would leave.” After the near-imprisoning warmth of Sparta in Book 4 (and with Nestor’s clutching hospitality about to be dodged at 199–201), the maxim is also mildly self-aware comedy. ↩
8. Menelaus’ counter-offer — a gift-collecting tour through Hellas with himself as guide — is princely generosity that is also exactly the delay Athena warned against. Telemachus’ refusal (88–91) shows the new sharpness of purpose the journey has given him. ↩
9. Helen’s robes, “worked all over with figures — she had made them herself,” recall the weaving Helen of Iliad 3.125–128, who wove the battles fought for her sake into a web. Here the artistry is turned to a wedding gift. ↩
10. Lines 113–119 repeat Menelaus’ offer at 4.613–619 word for word — there interrupted by the wedding feast, here finally performed. The English repeats the earlier rendering verbatim: the silver mixing-bowl with gold-finished rims, work

of Hephaestus, gift of Phaedimus king of the Sidonians. Note that Sidon returns three hundred lines later in a darker key: Eumaeus' treacherous nurse is Sidonian too (425–429). Phoenicia in this book gives with one hand and kidnaps with the other. ↩

11. Helen's gift-speech is one of the loveliest small speeches in the poem: a robe that is "a keepsake of Helen's hands," to lie in Penelope's keeping until Telemachus' wedding day, when his bride will wear it. The most notorious bride in the world weaves for the marriage of her guest's son — Helen quietly writing herself into a future domestic happiness she never had. ↩
12. The eagle bearing off the tame white goose "out of the yard" is the book's first omen and a transparent allegory: the wild raptor from the mountains (Odysseus from his long absence) seizing the fattened domestic bird (the suitors, fed tame in another man's yard). Penelope will dream the same image, geese and eagle, at 19.536–550. ↩
13. Helen "was before him" — she out-prophesies her husband, who is still pondering. To her roles in Book 4 (hostess, drug-mistress, storyteller who recognized Odysseus in disguise) the poem adds mantis: "I will prophesy as the immortals cast it in my heart." Her reading is flawless, down to the alternative "or even now he is home already" — which is in fact the truth. ↩
14. Telemachus' farewell — "then even there I would pray to you as to a god" — repeats, word for word, his father's promise to Nausicaa (8.467): the formula of gratitude that elevates a mortal benefactor to cult. Spoken to Helen, of all women, it

lands with peculiar force; his last word in Sparta is to her, not Menelaus — and the son, unknowing, speaks in his father's exact words. ↩

15. Lines 184–192 repeat the outbound journey's lines (3.486–494) verbatim — the day of driving, sunset at Pherae with Diocles, and the dawn departure. Ring-composition closes the Telemachy's Peloponnesian loop in the same words that opened it. ↩
16. The dodge of Nestor: Telemachus begs to be dropped at the ship because “the old man will keep me in his house against my will, / aching to host me.” Peisistratus' answering assessment of his own father — he will come down and summon you personally, “and he will not go back empty-handed” — is the poem's fondest joke about hospitality as benevolent captivity, the comic inverse of Menelaus' maxim at 72–74. ↩
17. The Melampus digression (225–255) is told in the poem's densest genealogical shorthand, and it completes a story the Nekyia left as a riddle: at 11.287–297 we heard of the “blameless seer” bound in Phylacus' halls for Neleus' daughter Pero and the cattle of Iphiclus, without ever being named. Here he is named — Melampus — and the sequel added: escape, the driving of the cattle, revenge on Neleus, the bride delivered to his brother (Bias), and emigration to Argos. The whole pedigree exists to authenticate Theoclymenus: great-grandson of a seer whose gift ran in the blood. ↩
18. Amphiaraus, beloved of Zeus and Apollo, “died at Thebes — a woman's bribes”: Eriphyle, bribed with the golden necklace of Harmonia to send her husband to the war of the Seven, where

he knew he would die. The poem has already set her among the damned wives at 11.326–327 (“hateful Eriphyle, who took precious gold for the life of her own husband”). Note the quiet rhyme with this book’s other fatal necklace: the gold-and-amber strand that transfixes the women of Ctesius’ hall at 460–464 while a child is stolen. ↩

19. Cleitus snatched by golden-throned Dawn “for his beauty’s sake” belongs with Orion (5.121–124) and Tithonus (5.1) in the poem’s set of mortals taken by the goddess of morning — a one-line flash of myth in the middle of a pedigree. ↩
20. The identity-question formula — “What man are you, and from where? Where are your city and your parents?” — recurs here from 1.170, 10.325, 14.187. Theoclymenus asks it of Telemachus as a suppliant, inverting the usual direction: the stranger interrogates the host. ↩
21. Theoclymenus is a fugitive homicide — “I killed a man of my own tribe” — received without hesitation. In heroic custom the exiled killer is a standard suppliant figure (cf. Patroclus in *Iliad* 23.85–90). The mirror is precise: in the hut across the island, Odysseus’ invented Cretan is also a fugitive killer (13.259–275). Telemachus here passes the same test of receiving the dangerous stranger that his father is setting the swineherd — and that he himself will face again with the beggar in his own hall. ↩
22. The “Sharp Islands” (νήσοισιν ἐπιπρόεηκε θοῆσιν) are probably the Echinades off the Acarnanian coast; the route past Crouni, Chalcis, Pheae, and Elis runs up the western Peloponnese before the crossing. Line 300 leaves Telemachus suspended —

“wondering whether he would slip past death, or be taken” — and the poet cuts away to the hut for two hundred lines: suspense by scene-change. ↩

23. The second formal test of Eumaeus (after the cloak-story of 14.459–522): Odysseus proposes to leave for the city and beg. The stakes are practical — the plot needs to know whether the swineherd’s care is durable — but the scene’s pleasure is the disguise itself deepening: see 319–324. ↩
24. The king lists his qualifications as a servant: fire-laying, wood-splitting, carving, roasting, wine-pouring — “all that lesser men do, waiting on the great” — under the patronage of Hermes, god of profitable skill and service. The man who strung the bow and sacked Troy inventories the menial arts flawlessly, because a Homeric noble does command these skills (Odysseus can build his own bed, raft, and house). The irony cuts both ways: aristocratic self-sufficiency and the beggar’s servility are the same competence in different clothes. ↩
25. The apostrophe again — “you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd” — the poet’s second-person address reserved in this poem for Eumaeus (see note at 14.55). It recurs throughout this book (325, and again in the exchanges below) at moments of the swineherd’s strongest feeling. ↩
26. “Their arrogance and violence reach the iron sky” — Eumaeus’ hyperbole for the suitors repeats the formula of 17.565 in advance; the “iron heaven” (σιδήρεον οὐρανόν) is the sky as unbreakable vault. His horrified portrait of the suitors’ own serving-men — young, sleek-headed, handsome, in fine cloaks

— measures the social gulf: even the servants of the wicked outdress an honest beggar. ↩

27. Lines 337–339 repeat 14.515–517 nearly verbatim (wait for Telemachus, who will clothe you in mantle and tunic and send you where you wish). The refrain “...a cloak and a tunic, / and send you wherever your heart and spirit bid you go” is the hut’s standing promise, kept at 16.78–79 and finally at 21.339 by Penelope. ↩

28. Odysseus’ blessing (341–342) repeats his oath-frame of 14.440–441 (“May you be as dear to father Zeus as you are to me...”), and then restates the belly-doctrine of 7.216–221 and 17.286–289: “it is for the cursed belly’s sake men take hard pains.” Wandering, the poem’s own subject, is here named the worst of mortal conditions — by its most famous wanderer, disguised, to a man whom wandering sold into slavery. ↩

29. Anticleia “died of grief for her son — a wretched death”: Eumaeus confirms exactly what her shade told Odysseus in the underworld (11.202–203 — not the arrows of Artemis, but “longing for you... took the honey-sweet life from me”). The listener already knows this is true; the teller does not know the listener is the son in question. The dramatic irony is the engine of the whole hut-sequence. ↩

30. A jolt of household history: Eumaeus was reared by Anticleia herself alongside Ctimene, Odysseus’ younger sister — nowhere else mentioned in the poem — and “honored little less” than the daughter of the house. The slave was almost family; then Ctimene was married to Same (“and got a fortune for her” — the bride-price noted with a servant’s precision)

and Eumaeus was sent to the farm. The kindness is real, and so is the sorting: one child of that nursery was sold in, one married out, and the line between them held. ↩

31. The most remarkable piece of social observation in Homer: what slaves miss when the great house fails — “speaking before the mistress, and learning all the news, and eating and drinking, and carrying something afterward off to the fields.” Conversation, information, commensality, and a small perquisite to carry home: a complete anthropology of the well-run household from below, in four lines, spoken by a slave. ↩
32. “He paid a worthy price” (ἄξιον ὦνον ἔδωκε): note the phrase, because Eumaeus will use it again at 429 — of the Phoenician nurse’s own sale. Master and nurse, kidnapper and kidnapped, are links in one chain of transactions; the formula’s repetition is the poem’s quiet way of showing that the trade in persons is systemic, not episodic. ↩
33. “These nights go on past telling” (νύκτες ἀθέσφατοι) — the long nights near the solstice invite storytelling; “even sleep, too much of it, becomes a weariness.” Eumaeus frames his autobiography with the poem’s own justification for its existence: the night is long, the wine is poured, and a story is the proper pleasure. ↩
34. “We two... will take our pleasure in each other’s grim sorrows, / remembering them. For afterward a man finds pleasure even in pains, / when he has suffered much and wandered far.” This is the poem’s aesthetic credo in miniature — suffering transmuted by memory and telling into terpsis, delight — spoken by a slave to the disguised master whose own epic

works exactly this way (cf. Odysseus weeping at Demodocus' songs, 8.83–92, 521–531, and Alcinous' reflection at 8.579–580 that the gods wove ruin “so there might be song for men to come”). ↩

35. Syrie “above Ortygia, where the turnings of the sun are” (ὄθι τροπαὶ ἡελίοιο): perhaps “toward the solstice-point,” i.e., the west or the sun's turning-places — the geography is fabulous rather than mappable, like Alcinous' Scheria. The island's blessedness (no famine, no sickness, painless death from Apollo's gentle arrows) marks Eumaeus' origin as a lost golden world — the swineherd is an exiled prince of a near-paradise. ↩

36. Death by the “gentle arrows” (ἀγανοῖς βελέεσσιν) of Apollo and Artemis is the Homeric formula for sudden, painless death — the kindest end the poem knows (Penelope prays for exactly this at 18.202; cf. 3.279–280, 11.172–173). On Syrie it is the only way anyone dies. The same goddess's arrow, at 478–479, kills the treacherous nurse — the gentle formula turned executioner. ↩

37. “Gnawers” (τρῶκται) — the same contemptuous word for Phoenician traders that the Cretan tale used at 14.289. Homer's Phoenicians are the poem's masters of the sea-borne swindle: brilliant sailors, sellers of trinkets, stealers of persons. Eumaeus' story and Odysseus' invented voyage with the swindling captain (14.287–297) agree on this ethnography — though the stereotype admits exceptions: his Book 13 Phoenicians land him, and his goods, untouched (13.272–286). ↩

38. The nurse is introduced with the formula “beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious handwork” — the very words that described Athena’s assumed shape at 13.289. The poem uses its formula for an admirable woman precisely where the woman will prove treacherous; the dissonance is the point. ↩
39. Eumaeus’ gnome — sex “leads astray the minds of women, even one whose works are honest” — is the bitter verdict of the man whose childhood it cost. But the story he then tells complicates his own maxim: the woman is herself a stolen child (see next note), bargaining with the only assets she has for the one thing she wants, which is to go home. The poem lets the gnome and the biography argue with each other. ↩
40. The nurse’s own history, in her own words: daughter of a rich man of Sidon, kidnapped by Taphian pirates from the fields, sold into Ctesius’ house. She is Eumaeus before Eumaeus: an abducted child of good family sold overseas. What she then does — steal another such child to buy her own passage home — makes her both the villain of his story and its first victim; the wrong she suffered is precisely the wrong she commits. ↩
41. “And he paid a worthy price” — her sale, in the identical formula Odysseus used of Eumaeus’ sale at 388. See note there. In her mouth the phrase carries a further edge: she quotes the market’s judgment of her own worth. ↩
42. “Such a knowing little thing” (κερδαλέον δὴ τοῖον): the child Eumaeus is described with the *kerdos*-word — “shrewd, profit-quick” — that elsewhere attaches to Odysseus himself (6.148, 13.291). In the nurse’s sales-pitch the word is literal: the boy’s brightness is his market value (“he would fetch you a

boundless price”). The poem’s darkest use of its favorite virtue.



43. The necklace “of gold, strung here and there with amber” is the trap: while the household women turn it in their hands, “drinking it with their eyes,” the trader nods the signal and the theft begins. Amber (ἄλεκτρον) marks the far-northern trade Phoenicians brokered. The scene rhymes deliberately with Eriphyle’s necklace at 247 (see note): in this book, gold necklaces buy lives. ↩

44. Three goblets and a king’s son: the loot of the abduction, precisely inventoried by its victim a lifetime later. “In my child’s witlessness” (ἄσιφροσύνησι) — the grown Eumaeus passing judgment on the toddler who trustingly followed his nurse’s hand. The detail that the father’s table-service was left out in the forecourt because the men “had gone out to the people’s session” gives the theft its exact domestic hour. ↩

45. Artemis’ arrow — sudden painless death, the blessing of Syrie (411–412) — strikes the nurse on the seventh day at sea, and she drops “like a sea-tern” (εἰναλίη κήξ) into the bilge, is thrown to “the seals and fishes” (κύρμα γενέσθαι — the body left as prey, the poem’s image of unburied death, cf. ἔλωρ at 3.271, 5.473, 14.135), and vanishes from the story. Divine justice, if that is what it is, arrives without comment; the child is simply “left alone, my heart aching” (= 14.286’s line-shape) — and sold on Ithaca all the same. The punishment saves no one. ↩

46. Odysseus’ consolation is the book’s hardest sentence to hear well: “Zeus set the good beside the evil for you, / since after all

that pain you came to the house of a kind man” — the good beside the evil of kidnapping and sale is enslavement to a gentle owner, with food and drink, “and you live a good life.” Set against Eumaeus’ own accounting at 371–379 (and the poem’s verdict at 17.322–323 that Zeus takes half a man’s worth away the day slavery seizes him), the comfort is real, limited, and spoken by the man who owns him — who then, keeping his disguise, ranks his own state lower still: “while I come to you here... still wandering.” The poem does not resolve this; it sets the two lives side by side in the dark and lets the wine go round. ↩

47. Bitter courtesy: unable to host Theoclymenus himself, Telemachus directs him to Eurymachus — “whom now the men of Ithaca look on like a god... hungriest of all / to marry my mother and take the honor that was Odysseus’.” Whether this is despairing irony, a test of the seer, or camouflage (naming the man of power a stranger would be safest with), the lines curdle as he speaks them — and the hawk interrupts before the recommendation can stand. ↩
48. The hawk, “swift messenger of Apollo,” tearing a dove between Telemachus and his ship, is the omen that cancels the Eurymachus plan; Theoclymenus, reading it apart and pressing his hand, delivers his first prophecy: “There is no line more kingly than your own / in the land of Ithaca... yours is the power forever.” The seer pays for his passage at once — and Telemachus quietly reroutes him to Piraeus instead. The dove-tearing hawk will find its fulfillment in the omen-reader’s terrible vision at 20.351–357. ↩

49. “There is no line more kingly than your own” — the omen’s meaning in one sentence. Theoclymenus’ function in the poem is to say true things at right angles to the action, and this is the first: the kingship stays in the house of Odysseus. ↩
50. The book ends with the two travelers converging: the ship rowing for the city, and Telemachus on foot, striding for the yard where the swineherd sleeps beside his herds — “a good man, whose heart was loyal to his masters.” The sentence completes itself, but the scene does not: Book 16 opens in the same yard at the same hour — the division is a breath, not a break — and in the hut the father is waiting. ↩

Odyssey — Book 16

Father and son: the recognition at the swineherd's hut.

- 1 But the two in the hut, Odysseus and the noble swineherd,
- 2 had lit a fire and were readying breakfast at dawn,
- 3 and had sent the herdsmen out with the gathered swine;
- 4 and around Telemachus the yapping dogs went fawning,¹
- 5 and did not bark as he came. And noble Odysseus noticed
- 6 the dogs fawning, and the sound of footsteps came to him.
- 7 At once he spoke winged words to Eumaeus:
- 8 “Eumaeus, surely some companion of yours is coming,
- 9 or another man well known, since the dogs are not barking

10 but fawn around him; and I hear the thud of feet.”

11 The word was not all spoken when his own dear son

12 stood in the gateway. The swineherd sprang up amazed,

13 and out of his hands fell the vessels he was busy with,2

14 mixing the sparkling wine. He went to meet his master,

15 and kissed his head, and both his beautiful eyes,

16 and both his hands; and a warm tear fell from him.

17 And as a father, in the fullness of his heart, embraces his son3

18 come from a far country in the tenth year,

19 an only son, late-born, for whom he has suffered many sorrows —

20 so then the noble swineherd took godlike Telemachus

21 in his arms and kissed him all over, as one

escaped from death;

22 and sobbing he spoke winged words to him:

23 “You have come, Telemachus — sweet light! I
told myself⁴

24 I would never see you again, once you had
gone by ship to Pylos.

25 Come in now, come, dear child, so my heart
may take

26 its joy of looking at you, newly here from
elsewhere.

27 You do not often visit the farm and the
herdsmen;

28 you stay in town: so, it seems, it has pleased
your heart —

29 to look on that deadly crowd of the suitor-
men.”

30 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

31 “So be it, old father. It is for your sake I have
come here,⁵

32 to see you with my eyes, and to hear you tell
me

33 whether my mother still remains in the halls,

or by now

34 some other man has married her, and
Odysseus' bed

35 lies empty of sleepers, holding only foul
spider-webs.”⁶

36 Then the swineherd answered him, a leader of
men:

37 “Indeed she remains, with an enduring heart,
38 in your own halls; and always in misery
39 her nights and her days waste away in
weeping.”

40 So speaking, he took the bronze spear from
him,

41 and Telemachus went in and crossed the stone
threshold.

42 As he came on, his father Odysseus yielded his
seat;⁷

43 but Telemachus, from his side, checked him
and said:

44 “Sit, stranger. We will find a seat elsewhere
45 in our own farmstead. Here is the man who
will set one.”

46 So he spoke; and Odysseus went back and sat
down. And the swineherd
47 strewed green brushwood under, and a fleece
on top,
48 and there the dear son of Odysseus seated
himself.
49 And the swineherd set before them platters of
roasted
50 meat, which they had left from their eating the
day before,
51 and briskly heaped up bread in the baskets,
52 and mixed honey-sweet wine in an ivy-wood
bowl,
53 and himself sat down opposite godlike
Odysseus.
54 And their hands went out to the good things
spread before them.
55 But when they had put away desire for food
and drink,
56 then Telemachus spoke to the noble
swineherd:
57 “Old father, where has this guest of yours come

from? How did sailors⁸

⁵⁸ bring him to Ithaca? Who did they claim to be?

⁵⁹ For I hardly think he came here on foot.”

⁶⁰ And you answered him, Eumaeus the
swineherd:

⁶¹ “Then I will tell you, child, the whole truth of
it.

⁶² He claims his birth from Crete of the wide
dancing-grounds,

⁶³ and says he has wandered rolling through
many cities

⁶⁴ of mortal men: so a god has spun it for him.

⁶⁵ Now, run off from a ship of Thesprotian men,

⁶⁶ he has come to my farmstead; and I put him in
your hands.⁹

⁶⁷ Do as you will. He declares himself your
suppliant.”

⁶⁸ Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

⁶⁹ “Eumaeus, this word of yours cuts to the heart.

⁷⁰ How am I to receive this guest in my house?¹⁰

⁷¹ I am young myself, and have no faith yet in my
hands

72 to defend a man, when someone picks a quarrel first.

73 And my mother's heart is divided in her breast, two ways:¹¹

74 whether to stay here with me and keep the house,

75 respecting her husband's bed and the voice of the people,

76 or to follow now whichever of the Achaeans is best

77 among her suitors in the halls, and offers the most.

78 But as for this guest, since he has come to your house,

79 I will dress him in a cloak and a tunic, fine clothing,¹²

80 and give him a two-edged sword, and sandals for his feet,

81 and send him wherever his heart and spirit bid him go.

82 Or if you will, keep him and care for him at the farmstead,

83 and I will send clothing here, and all his bread
84 to eat, so he will not wear you down, you and
your men.

85 But in among the suitors I would not let him
86 go: too reckless is the insolence they carry —
87 they would mock him, and it would be a
terrible grief to me.

88 It is hard for one man to get anything done
among many,

89 even a strong man: they are far the more
powerful.”

90 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus spoke to
him:

91 “Friend — since surely it is right for me to
answer also —

92 truly my heart is eaten through as I listen,

93 hearing you tell what reckless things the
suitors

94 devise in the halls, against the will of such a
man as you.

95 Tell me: do you bow to it willingly, or do the
people

96 through the land hate you, following the voice
of a god?

97 Or have you some fault to find with brothers —
those a man

98 trusts to fight beside him, though a great feud
rise?

99 Ah, would that I were as young as this anger of
mine,**13**

100 or were a son of blameless Odysseus, or the
man himself —

102 then straightway might some stranger cut the
head from my neck**14**

103 if I did not walk into the hall of Laertes' son

104 Odysseus, and become an evil to every man of
them.

105 And if they overpowered me by their
numbers, alone as I am,

106 I would rather die cut down in my own halls

107 than look on forever at these disgraceful
doings:

108 guests roughly handled, and men hauling the
slave-women**15**

109 shamefully through the beautiful house,
110 and wine drawn off and squandered, and them
eating my bread
111 idly, recklessly, endlessly — for a work never to
be finished.”
112 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:
113 “Then I will tell you, stranger, exactly how it
is.
114 It is not that the whole people hates me and
bears a grudge,
115 nor have I fault to find with brothers — those
a man
116 trusts to fight beside him, though a great feud
rise.
117 For so the son of Cronos has made ours a line
of only sons:16
118 Arceisius fathered Laertes, an only son;
119 his father got Odysseus, an only son; and
Odysseus
120 fathered only me, and left me in the halls, and
had no joy of me.
121 And that is why enemies past counting are in

the house.

122 All the great men who hold power among the
islands —17

123 Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus

—

124 and all who lord it through rocky Ithaca:

125 so many woo my mother, and wear this house
away.

126 And she neither refuses the marriage she
loathes, nor can she

127 bring it to an end. And they eat on, wasting

128 my house. Soon they will tear me to pieces
too.

129 But surely these things lie on the knees of the
gods.

130 Old father, you go — quickly — and tell steady-
hearted Penelope

131 that I am safe for her, and have come back
from Pylos.

132 I will stay here. And you return to this place

133 when you have told her — her only. Let none
of the other Achaeans

134 learn it: for there are many devising evil
against me.”

135 And you answered him, Eumaeus the
swineherd:

136 “I know. I understand. You order a man who is
thinking it too.18

137 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

138 shall I go the same road with the news to
Laertes

139 as well? Poor man — for a long while, for all
his great grief

140 for Odysseus, he still would oversee the field-
works, and in the house

141 would drink and eat with the slaves, whenever
the heart within him bade.

142 But now, from the day you went by ship to
Pylos,

143 they say he no longer eats and drinks as
before,

144 nor looks to the field-works, but with
moaning and groaning

145 sits mourning; and the flesh wastes away

around his bones.”¹⁹

¹⁴⁶ Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

¹⁴⁷ “The harder for it; but all the same we will let him be, though it grieves us.

¹⁴⁸ For if everything whatever could be had for the choosing by mortals,²⁰

¹⁴⁹ we would choose first the day of my father’s homecoming.

¹⁵⁰ No — give your message and come back; do not go wandering

¹⁵¹ over the fields after him. But tell my mother

¹⁵² to send her handmaid, the housekeeper, quickly —

¹⁵³ and secretly: she could carry the news to the old man.”

¹⁵⁴ He spoke, and roused the swineherd, who took his sandals in his hands,

¹⁵⁵ bound them under his feet, and set off for the city. And it did not

¹⁵⁶ escape Athena, that Eumaeus the swineherd was gone from the farm:

¹⁵⁷ she came near; and in body she was like a

woman

158 beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious
handwork.21

159 She stood at the door of the hut, showing
herself to Odysseus;

160 but Telemachus did not see her before him,
did not sense her —

161 for the gods do not appear manifest to
everyone —22

162 but Odysseus saw her, and the dogs: and they
did not bark,

163 but whimpered and shrank in fear to the far
side of the farmstead.

164 She signaled with her brows; and noble
Odysseus understood,

165 and came out of the hall, past the great wall of
the yard,

166 and stood before her; and Athena said to him:

167 “Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices:

168 now speak your word to your son. Hide it no
longer —

169 so that you two may fit death and doom to the
suitors

170 and go to the famous city. And I myself

171 will not be long away from you: I am hungry
for battle.”**23**

172 She spoke, and Athena touched him with her
golden wand.

173 First she laid a well-washed mantle and a
tunic

174 about his chest, and filled out his frame and
his youth:

175 dark color came back to his skin, his jaws grew
full,

176 and the beard about his chin turned blue-
black again.

177 That done, she went away again; and Odysseus

178 went into the hut. His dear son was struck
with wonder,

179 and turned his eyes aside, afraid, in case it was
a god,

180 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to
him:

181 “Stranger, you look other to me now than a moment ago:

182 you wear other clothes; your skin is not the same.

183 Surely you are some god, one of those who hold wide heaven.

184 Be gracious, then! — and we will give you pleasing sacrifices,

185 and wrought gifts of gold. Only spare us.”24

186 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus answered him:

187 “I am no god. Why do you liken me to the immortals?

188 No: I am your father — for whose sake you go groaning25

189 and suffer many pains, and take men’s violence on yourself.”

190 So speaking, he kissed his son, and down his cheeks

191 a tear fell to the ground. Before, he had held them back, always.26

192 But Telemachus — for he did not yet believe it

was his father —

193 found words again, and said to him in answer:

194 “You are not Odysseus, not my father. A god is
casting27

195 a spell on me, so I may sob and grieve still
more.

196 No mortal man could ever contrive these
things

197 by his own wit — not unless a god in person
came

198 and made him young or old at a stroke, at will.

199 Just now, I know, you were old, and meanly
dressed;

200 and now you are like the gods who hold wide
heaven.”

201 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

202 “Telemachus, it is not right, when your own
father is here,

203 to marvel at him past measure, or stand
amazed.

204 No other Odysseus will ever come to you

here:

205 he is I — such as you see, having suffered,
having wandered long —

206 come in the twentieth year to my father's
land.28

207 But this — this is the work of Athena, driver
of the spoil,29

208 who makes of me whatever she wills — for
she has the power —

209 now like a beggar man, and now again

210 like a young man with fine clothes upon his
body.

211 It is easy for the gods who hold wide heaven

212 to glorify a mortal man — or to break him.”

213 So speaking he sat down; and Telemachus,

214 flinging his arms around his noble father,
wept and shed tears,

215 and in both of them rose the longing for
lament.

216 They cried shrill, in bursts thicker than the
cries of birds —30

217 of ospreys, or of vultures with crooked talons,

whose young

218 the country people have taken from the nest
before they were fledged:

219 so pitifully the tears fell from beneath their
brows.

220 And the light of the sun would have gone
down on their weeping

221 had not Telemachus suddenly spoken to his
father:

222 “What ship was it, dear father, whose sailors
brought you

223 here to Ithaca? Who did they claim to be?

224 For I hardly think you came here on foot.”31

225 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus spoke to
him:

226 “Then I will tell you, child, the truth of it.

227 The Phaeacians brought me, famed for their
ships, who give32

228 passage to other men too, whoever comes to
them.

229 They carried me asleep in a fast ship over the
sea

230 and set me down in Ithaca, and gave me
shining gifts,
231 bronze and gold in plenty, and woven clothing
—
232 all lying now in caves, by the gods' will.
233 And I have come here at Athena's prompting,
234 so we may plan together the slaughter of our
enemies.
235 Come, count me off the suitors, one by one,
236 so I may know how many they are, and what
men;
237 then I will weigh it in my blameless heart, and
decide
238 whether we two can stand against them by
ourselves,
239 alone, or should look for others.”
240 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:
241 “Father, I have always heard your great fame:
242 a spearman with your hands, and weighty in
counsel.
243 But what you say is too great. Awe holds me.

It could not be³³

²⁴⁴ for two men to fight with many, and strong
men too.

²⁴⁵ The suitors are no exact ten, nor two tens
only,

²⁴⁶ but many more. You shall have the count here
and now.

²⁴⁷ From Dulichium, two-and-fifty young men,³⁴
²⁴⁸ chosen, and six serving-men follow with
them;

²⁴⁹ from Same there are four-and-twenty men;

²⁵⁰ from Zacynthus, twenty young Achaeans;

²⁵¹ and from Ithaca itself, twelve, all of them the
best;

²⁵² and with them are Medon the herald, and the
godlike singer,

²⁵³ and two henchmen skilled in the carving of
meats.

²⁵⁴ If we come against all of these inside the
house,

²⁵⁵ beware: your avenging of their violence could
cost too bitter, too grim a price.

256 No — you, if you can think of some defender,
257 think of one who would stand by us two with
a willing heart.”

258 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus
answered him:

259 “Then I will tell you — mark me now, and
listen.

260 Consider: will Athena, with father Zeus beside
her,35

261 be enough for us two? Or shall I think of some
other defender?”

262 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:

263 “Good defenders indeed, those two you name,
264 though they sit high among the clouds; and
they rule

265 all others — men in their power, and the
deathless gods.”

266 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus
answered him:

267 “Those two will not stand long apart from the
strong

268 din of battle, when between the suitors and
ourselves
269 the war-strength of Ares is put to trial in my
halls.
270 But you, for now: go home at the showing of
the dawn
271 and mix among the overweening suitors;
272 and later the swineherd will bring me to the
city,
273 looking like a beggar, wretched and old.
274 And if they treat me shamefully in the house,
let the heart36
275 in your breast endure it while I suffer —
276 even if they drag me by the feet through the
hall to the door,
277 or throw things and hit me: look on, and hold
yourself in.
278 Tell them, yes, to stop their follies —
279 win at them with gentle words. They will not
listen,
280 not at all: for their fated day is standing near.
281 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in

your heart.

282 When Athena of the many counsels puts it in
my mind,

283 I will nod to you with my head; and when you
see it,

284 take all the weapons of war that lie about the
hall

285 and store them up in the corner of the high
chamber —

286 all of them; and when the suitors miss them
and ask you,

287 talk them around with soft words:

288 'I laid them out of the smoke: they no longer
looked like the arms37

289 Odysseus left behind when he went to Troy —

290 they are fouled over, as far as the breath of
the fire reached.

291 And a greater fear the son of Cronos put into
my heart:

292 that in your wine you might raise a quarrel
among you

293 and wound one another, and shame the feast

294 and the wooing. For iron of itself draws a man
on.'38

295 But for us two alone leave out two swords,
two spears,

296 and two oxhide shields for our hands to seize,

297 so we can rush and take them up; and the
suitors —

298 Pallas Athena and Zeus the counselor will
daze them.

299 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in
your heart.

300 If you are truly mine, and truly of our
blood,39

301 then let no one hear that Odysseus is within
—

302 not Laertes: he is not to know it; nor the
swineherd,

303 nor any of the household; no — not Penelope
herself.

304 You and I alone will learn the set of the
women;

305 and we might test this or that man of the

slaves as well:⁴⁰

³⁰⁶ where one honors the two of us, and fears us
in his heart,

³⁰⁷ and where one cares nothing, and slights you
— such as you are.”

³⁰⁸ Then his shining son spoke out and answered
him:

³⁰⁹ “Father — you will come to know my heart
hereafter,

³¹⁰ I think; there is no slackness in me — none.

³¹¹ But I do not believe this plan will be a profit

³¹² to us both. Think again, I urge you.⁴¹

³¹³ You will be a long time going round the farms
and testing

³¹⁴ each man, one by one; and meanwhile in the
halls, at their ease,

³¹⁵ they eat through our goods with a high hand,
and spare nothing.

³¹⁶ The women — yes, I would have you find out

³¹⁷ which ones dishonor you, and which are
guiltless.

³¹⁸ But the men about the farmsteads — I for one

would rather

319 we not test them now. Keep that work for
later,

320 if you truly know some sign from Zeus who
bears the aegis.”

321 So they spoke to each other of such things.

322 And meanwhile the well-built ship was
putting in to Ithaca,

323 the ship that carried Telemachus from Pylos
with all his companions.

324 When they had come inside the deep harbor,

325 they hauled the black ship up onto the land,

326 and high-spirited henchmen carried off their
gear

327 and took the beautiful gifts straight to Clytius’
house.⁴²

328 And they sent a herald ahead to the house of
Odysseus

329 to bring the news to watchful-minded
Penelope —

330 that Telemachus was in the country, and had
ordered the ship

331 to sail on to the city — lest the strong queen
332 take fright at heart, and let the soft tear fall.
333 And the two of them met, the herald and the
noble swineherd,
334 come on the same errand, to bring the woman
word.
335 But when they reached the house of the
godlike king,
336 the herald spoke out in the midst of the slave-
women:**43**
337 “Already, O queen, your dear son has come
home.”
338 But the swineherd stood close to Penelope
and told her
339 everything her dear son had charged him to
say.
340 And when he had delivered the whole of his
commission,
341 he went his way to his swine, and left the
walls and the hall.
342 But the suitors were downcast, dejected in
spirit,

343 and came out of the hall past the great wall of
the yard,

344 and there before the gates they sat
themselves down.

345 And Eurymachus, Polybus' son, began to
speak among them:

346 "Friends, here is a great work brought off
insolently —

347 this voyage of Telemachus. We swore it would
never be done.⁴⁴

348 Come — let us drag down a black ship, the
best we have,

349 and gather seamen for rowers, to carry word

350 quickly to those two out there: come home at
speed."

351 He had not finished speaking when
Amphinomus, turning⁴⁵

352 in his place, saw the ship inside the deep
harbor,

353 the crew furling the sail and holding the oars
in their hands.

354 He broke into easy laughter and called to his

companions:

355 “No need now to send any message. They are
in.

356 Either some god told them, or they saw the
ship themselves

357 passing by — and could not catch her.”

358 So he spoke; and they rose and went to the
shore of the sea.

359 Quickly the men hauled the black ship up
onto the land,

360 and high-spirited henchmen carried off their
gear;

361 and they themselves went in a body to the
assembly-place, and allowed

362 no one else to sit among them, young or
old.**46**

363 And Antinous spoke among them, Eupeithes’
son:

364 “Damn it all — see how the gods have slipped
this man out of harm’s reach!**47**

365 Day after day our watchers sat on the windy
headlands,

366 relief upon relief of them; and with the sun
gone down
367 we never passed a night ashore, but afloat on
the sea
368 in our fast ship we waited for the bright
Dawn,
369 lying in ambush for Telemachus, to take him
370 and kill him. And all the while some god has
brought him home.
371 Then let us here devise a wretched death
372 for Telemachus — not let him slip between
our hands. For I tell you,
373 while he lives, this business of ours will not be
brought off.
374 He is shrewd himself now, in counsel and in
mind,
375 and the people no longer look on us with any
favor.**48**
376 Act, then — before he can call the Achaeans
together
377 to assembly. He will not hang back, I promise
you:

378 he will keep his anger; he will stand up among
them all and tell

379 how we wove sheer murder for him — and
could not catch him.

380 And they will not praise us, hearing of evil
deeds.

381 Beware they do not do us harm, and drive us

382 out of our own country, and we come to the
land of strangers.

383 Take him first: catch him in the field, far from
the city,

384 or on the road. His livelihood and goods we
hold ourselves,

385 dividing them share and share among us; the
house

386 we would give his mother to keep — hers and
the man who weds her.49

387 But if this word displeases you, and you
choose instead

388 that he live, and keep all that was his father's
—

389 then let us not go on gathering here to eat

away

390 his store of pleasant things. Let each man
from his own hall

391 court her with bride-gifts, seeking her; and
she then

392 may wed the man who gives the most, and
comes as her fate.”

393 So he spoke; and they all fell silent and still.

394 Then Amphinomus rose and spoke among
them —

395 the shining son of Nisus, of the lord Aretias’
line,

396 who from Dulichium, land of wheat and grass,

397 led the suitors; and beyond the others he
pleased

398 Penelope with his talk, for his mind was set
on good.**50**

399 With good intent he rose and spoke among
them:

400 “Friends, I for one would have no wish to kill

401 Telemachus. Dreadful it is to kill the blood of
kings.**51**

402 No — first let us ask what is the counsel of the gods.

403 If the ordinances of great Zeus approve it,

404 I will kill him myself, and bid all the rest to help;

405 but if the gods turn us aside, I say: stop here.”

406 So spoke Amphinomus, and his word pleased them well.

407 They rose at once and went to the house of Odysseus,

408 and coming in they sat on the polished chairs.

409 Then watchful-minded Penelope thought of one thing more:52

410 to show herself to the suitors in their overweening insolence.

411 For she had learned of her son’s death plotted in the halls —

412 the herald Medon told her, who had overheard their counsels.53

413 She went down to the hall with her attendant women.

414 And when she reached the suitors, shining

among women,

415 she stood beside the pillar of the close-built
roof,

416 holding her glistening veil before her
cheeks,54

417 and rebuked Antinous, and spoke a word, and
named him:

418 “Antinous — insolence itself, deviser of evils!
And they say55

419 that in the land of Ithaca you are the best of
your years

420 in counsel and in speech. You were never
such a man.

421 Madman! Why do you weave death and doom
for

422 Telemachus, and pay no heed to suppliants —
over whom

423 Zeus stands witness? It is unholy to weave
evil against each other.

424 Do you not know the day your father came
here in flight,56

425 in terror of the people? For they were bitterly

enraged,

426 because he had joined with Taphian pirates
427 to harry the Thesprotians — men who were
our allies.

428 They wanted to destroy him, to tear the dear
heart out of him,

429 and to swallow his great and pleasing
livelihood whole;

430 but Odysseus held them back and checked
them, hot as they were.

431 His house you now eat up scot-free; you woo
his wife;

432 you would kill his son; and me you grieve to
the core.

433 Stop, I command you. And command the rest
to stop.”

434 Then Eurymachus, Polybus’ son, answered
her:

435 “Daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded
Penelope,⁵⁷

436 take heart. Do not let these things trouble
your mind.

437 The man does not exist, will not exist, cannot
be born

438 who shall lay hands upon your son
Telemachus

439 while I am alive and look upon the light of the
earth.

440 For I will say this outright, and it will be
accomplished:

441 in an instant his black blood would run down
my spear —58

442 that man's. For Odysseus, sacker of cities —
many a time

443 he sat me on his knees, and put roast meat

444 into my hands, and held the red wine to my
lips.

445 And so Telemachus is to me by far the dearest

446 of all men; and I tell him he need not tremble
at death —

447 not from the suitors. From the gods there is
no escaping.”

448 So he spoke to soothe her — and was himself
preparing the boy's destruction.59

449 But she climbed to her shining upper room,
450 and wept there for Odysseus, her dear
husband, until
451 gray-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her
eyelids.**60**
452 And at evening the noble swineherd came
back
453 to Odysseus and his son. They were making
their supper,
454 busy about it, having killed a year-old pig. But
Athena
455 came and stood close by Laertes' son
Odysseus,
456 and struck him with her wand and made him
an old man again,
457 and dressed his body in miserable clothes —
lest the swineherd**61**
458 look at him face to face and know him, and go
with the news
459 to steady-hearted Penelope, not holding it
fast in his heart.
460 And Telemachus was first to speak to him:

461 “You have come, noble Eumaeus. What news
in the town?

462 Are the haughty suitors back inside by now,
463 home from their ambush — or still watching
for me on my way?”

464 And you answered him, Eumaeus the
swineherd:

465 “I had no mind to ask about that, going down
466 through the town. My heart said: tell your
message

467 and be quick, and come back here again.

468 And a swift messenger from your companions
overtook me,

469 a herald — and he spoke to your mother first.

470 But this much more I know; this I saw with
my eyes.

471 I was already above the city, where the hill of
Hermes⁶²

472 stands, on my way, when I saw a fast ship
coming down

473 into our harbor. There were many men
aboard her,

474 and she rode heavy with shields and double-pointed spears.
475 I thought it was they — but I cannot know.”
476 So he spoke; and the sacred strength of Telemachus smiled,⁶³
477 and his eyes went to his father — slipping past the swineherd’s.
478 And when they had ceased their labor and made the meal ready,
479 they feasted; and no man’s appetite went short of the equal feast.
480 But when they had put away desire for food and drink,
481 they remembered their beds, and took the gift of sleep.⁶⁴

Notes

NOTES

1. The dogs that nearly tore the disguised Odysseus apart at 14.29–31 fawn on Telemachus without a bark. The book runs a quiet experiment in recognition by species: dogs know the beloved

familiar (here), cower at divinity (163), and — in the poem's most famous case, waiting at 17.291 — one old hound will know the master himself. ↩

2. The dropped vessels are the Homeric seismograph of feeling: work stops; the wine spills; the body answers before the mind. ↩
3. The first of the book's two great inverted similes: the swineherd welcomes the prince "as a father embraces his son... come from a far country in the tenth year." The real father sits three feet away, unrecognized, listening. Homer gives Eumaeus the father-simile *before* the recognition scene, so that the true reunion must share its tenderness with a slave's. ↩
4. "You have come, Telemachus — sweet light!" (γλυκερὸν φάος): Penelope will greet him with the identical exclamation at 17.41. The slave hears the homecoming first and coins its cry; the mother, a book later, repeats the swineherd word for word — one greeting shared out between the two people who feared most. ↩
5. "Old father" — ἄττα, a child's word for a beloved elder, the nursery address a grown man keeps for the man who part-raised him. Telemachus uses it to Eumaeus here and throughout (57, 130; again in 17); it is the same intimacy in the other direction as the poet's own "you" to the swineherd. ↩
6. The empty bed "holding only foul spider-webs" (κάκ' ἀράχνια): the most desolate image of the whole absence — twenty years of marriage reduced to what accumulates where no one sleeps. Telemachus can imagine his mother remarried; what he images first is not her new house but the abandoned bed. ↩

7. The disguised king rises to give his son the seat. Guest yields to host's son; beggar yields to prince; father yields to child — the gesture is correct in every register at once, and Telemachus, refusing it, courteously waves his unknown father back into his own chair. ↩
8. Lines 57–59 recycle the question Telemachus himself was asked by disguised Athena at 1.171–173 — “How did sailors / bring you to Ithaca?... For I hardly think you came here on foot” — and he will put it again, person-shifted, to his revealed father at 222–224. The island's standing joke (nobody walks to Ithaca) is also its standing security question. ↩
9. “I put him in your hands” — ἐγγυαλίζω, the formal verb of handing over a charge. Eumaeus transfers the suppliant up the chain of protection with legal punctilio: the slave has fed the guest two nights, and now delivers him — with full disclosure of his story — to the master of the house. That the story is false and the guest owns the house is the scene's silent second floor. ↩
10. Telemachus' answer is the poem's most honest confession of weakness: he cannot guarantee a guest's safety in his own house. The failure of xenia at the palace is total when the heir must ask a swineherd to keep his guest for him. ↩
11. The divided mind of Penelope, as her son reads it: keep the house and honor “her husband's bed and the voice of the people,” or marry the best and biggest bidder. He states it without blame — a boy calmly reporting that his mother stands at a fork. Athena used a crueller version of the same fork to hurry him home (15.20–23). ↩

12. The clothing promise a third time (14.515–517, 15.337–339) — but upgraded from the hut’s version: to the cloak and tunic Telemachus adds “a two-edged sword, and sandals for his feet.” The formula’s fixed close, “send him wherever his heart and spirit bid him go,” stands. What the beggar is actually about to receive is a bow. ↩
13. The triple wish — young as my anger, or Odysseus’ son, or Odysseus himself — is the beggar playing horseshoes around the truth: the third wish is the fact. He voices his own identity as an impossible hypothesis and dares the room not to notice. ↩
14. Murray’s text omits line 101 (bracketed in other editions: “... might come back from his wandering; for there is still a portion of hope”); the numbering passes from 100 to 102, as at 10.456. ↩
15. The catalogue of what cannot be watched: guests abused, slave-women dragged through the house, wine squandered, bread eaten “for a work never to be finished” (ἀτέλεστον — the wooing that can have no wedding). The last item is the coldest: the whole outrage is not even *for* anything. ↩
16. The genealogy of only sons — Arceisius, Laertes, Odysseus, Telemachus, one thread of a line four generations long. The Greek hammers ποῦνον three times at line-start. No brothers to fight beside him (97–98) is not a misfortune of this generation but the house’s structure: everything always hangs on one life. ↩
17. Lines 122–128 repeat 1.245–251 verbatim — the suitor catalogue by island and the “she neither refuses... nor can she bring it to

an end” analysis, first spoken to disguised Athena, now to disguised Odysseus. Telemachus has been giving this same briefing to gods in beggar’s clothing since the poem began. Line 129 caps it with the “knees of the gods” formula (1.267).



18. “I know. I understand. You order a man who is thinking it too” (γινώσκω, φρονέω) — Eumaeus’ answer compressed to two verbs. The swineherd’s mind runs ahead of instruction; it is the same competence Odysseus will trust with the armory keys of Book 21. ↩
19. Laertes’ decline, stage two: in Book 15 he still lived and prayed to die (15.353–357); now, since Telemachus sailed, he neither eats nor drinks nor oversees the work, “and the flesh wastes away around his bones.” Each report of the old man is worse; the poem is preparing the terrible testing scene of Book 24, where the father kept in the dark here will be made to weep by Odysseus himself before the revealing. ↩
20. “If everything whatever could be had for the choosing by mortals, / we would choose first the day of my father’s homecoming.” Telemachus says this while looking at the stranger who is that day. The pathos is engineered: the wish is already granted and he cannot see it — the last hour of his fatherlessness spent wishing. ↩
21. Athena’s woman-shape once more “beautiful and tall, and skilled in glorious handwork” — third appearance of the formula (13.289, 15.418). Odysseus and the dogs see her; Telemachus cannot: “the gods do not appear manifest to

everyone” (161) — a rule stated exactly once in the poem, at the moment it protects the surprise. ↩

22. The line is doctrine and stagecraft at once: divine visibility is selective, so the son can sit oblivious while the father is summoned outside. The dogs, who see her, do not bark this time but whimper away — the third of the book’s three canine verdicts (fawn at the familiar, cower at the god). ↩
23. “I am hungry for battle” (μεμαυῖα μάχεσθαι): the goddess of craft declaring appetite. Her promise “I will not be long away from you” is kept at 22.205ff, when she joins the hall-fight as Mentor. ↩
24. Telemachus responds to the transfiguration with liturgy: sacrifices and wrought gold, “only spare us” — the correct protocol for a divine epiphany (cf. Odysseus to Nausicaa, 6.149ff, working the same script in courtship). The scene needs him to be wrong in the pious direction: he has no category for “father” except “god.” ↩
25. Nine words end twenty years: “I am no god... I am your father.” The revelation is phrased as a correction of theology — and then defines fatherhood not by begetting but by cost: “for whose sake you go groaning and suffer many pains.” ↩
26. “Before, he had held them back, always” — νωλεμὲς αἰεὶ. One line measures the whole discipline of the disguise: through Eumaeus’ tears, through his own lies, through the night on the threshold of his house. He kisses his son and lets go of exactly one tear’s worth. ↩

27. Telemachus' refusal — "a god is casting a spell on me, so I may sob and grieve still more" — is the poem's recurring epistemology of reunion: joy this large reads first as malicious enchantment. Penelope will mount the same defense at greater length in Book 23; the family resemblance is precisely their disbelief. ↩
28. "In the twentieth year" — the phrase that has tolled since 2.175 (Halitherses' prophecy) and 19.222ff hereafter. Odysseus states his identity in the poem's own units: not name and lineage first, but suffering, wandering, and the count of years. ↩
29. Athena "driver of the spoil" (ἄγελεύς) — the plunderer's epithet, apt for the goddess managing this homecoming as a military operation. Odysseus' explanation of his shape-shifting — "she makes of me whatever she wills" — hands his own πολυτροπία (many-turnedness) back to its divine sponsor. ↩
30. The second inverted simile, crueller than the first: father and son, reunited, weep "thicker than the cries of birds... whose young the country people have taken from the nest before they were fledged." The comparison for reunion is bereavement — parents robbed of children. Twenty stolen years are mourned at the moment of recovery; what they weep for is everything the reunion cannot give back. ↩
31. The ship-question again (see note at 57) — now from son to father, in the same fixed close: "For I hardly think you came here on foot." Practicality reasserts itself after the weeping, and the interrogation formula that opened the poem's first disguise scene now serves its most honest conversation. ↩

32. To his son, Odysseus tells the plain truth — Phaeacians, sleep, treasure in the caves — where Eumaeus got a Cretan lie running on invented mechanics of its own (14.321ff: Thesprotia, a king's safekeeping, the Dodona errand). The poem grades honesty by intimacy: gods get recognition, sons get truth, everyone else gets craft. ↩
33. “What you say is too great. Awe holds me” — Telemachus said exactly this to Nestor at 3.226–227, refusing to believe Odysseus could ever come home and take revenge. The line returns verbatim with the situation transformed: then he could not hope it; now the plan itself stands before him asking for a head-count. ↩
34. The arithmetic of the odds, at last made explicit: 52 from Dulichium (plus six servants), 24 from Same, 20 from Zacynthus, 12 from Ithaca — 108 suitors, with herald, singer, and two carvers besides — against a father, a son, and (unknown yet) two herdsmen. The catalogue is epic convention turned tactical briefing. ↩
35. Odysseus' answer to “find a defender” is a riddle with one pious solution: will Athena and Zeus *do*? Telemachus' reply — good defenders, “though they sit high among the clouds” — has a young man's dry realism about divine assistance; his father's correction (267–269) is a veteran's: those two never miss a real fight. ↩
36. The hardest order in the plan: watch your father be abused and endure it. The trials come exactly as forecast — the footstool (17.462), the ox-hoof (20.299), the taunts — and Telemachus' obedience, biting down rage at each, becomes his coming-of-

age. The command “look on, and hold yourself in” is the family discipline: Odysseus has been obeying it himself since Book 13.



- 37. The prepared speech about the armor is a masterpiece of plausible lying, and Odysseus scripts it verbatim for his son: soot-damage plus a proverb. Telemachus delivers it, lightly adapted, at 19.5–13. Teaching your child a cover story, speech by speech, is also a form of inheritance. ↩
- 38. “Iron of itself draws a man on” (αὐτὸς γὰρ ἐφέλκεται ἄνδρα σίδηρος) — the poem’s most quoted proverb: weapons in reach create the violence they wait for. That it appears inside a fabricated excuse does not make it less true; the plan works because the lie is wisdom. ↩
- 39. “If you are truly mine, and truly of our blood” — the recognition is minutes old and already conditional, a test wrapped in an endearment. The secrecy list that follows — not Laertes, not Eumaeus, not Penelope herself — is breathtaking in its exclusions: the wife who has held the house twenty years is ranked with the servants for operational security. The poem will spend Books 19 and 23 paying the cost of that decision. ↩
- 40. Testing the slaves — who honors, who slights — is the seed of the poem’s harshest justice: the loyal (Eumaeus, Philoetius) will be armed and elevated; the disloyal (Melanthius, the twelve women) will die terribly in Book 22. The household is about to be audited. ↩
- 41. Telemachus amends his father’s plan — respectfully, precisely: testing the farm-men one by one wastes time while the suitors eat; test the women, defer the men. And Odysseus accepts it

silently (the plan proceeds as amended). The son's first act after recognition is to out-plan the master planner on a point of economy; nothing could please the poem — or the father — more. ↩

42. Piraeus son of Clytius took charge of Theoclymenus and the gifts at 15.539ff; the treasure goes to his father's house for safekeeping. The seer waits offstage until 17. ↩
43. The two messengers, graded by manner: the herald blurts the news "in the midst of the slave-women" — broadcast, artless; the swineherd "stood close to Penelope" and delivers privately, exactly as charged (133: "her only"). One line each, and the poem has drawn the whole difference between an employee and a loyalist. ↩
44. "We swore it would never be done" — Eurymachus convicts the suitors out of his own mouth: the voyage they mocked in Book 2 is "a great work brought off insolently" (ὑπερφιάλως — their own signature adverb, handed to Telemachus almost with respect). ↩
45. Amphinomus enters the poem laughing — "easy laughter," seeing the ambush ship come home empty. He is introduced at 394–398 as the decent one: best-liked by Penelope, "his mind was set on good." His speech (400–405) merely postpones the murder pending an omen, and that half-decency is enough for Odysseus to try to save him at 18.119ff — and not enough to save him from Telemachus' spear at 22.89ff. The poem gives its most sympathetic suitor a coward's virtue: he objects, and stays. ↩

46. A private assembly: the suitors take the public ἀγορή of Ithaca — dormant since Book 2 — and let “no one else... sit among them, young or old.” The civic organ of the island is briefly a gangsters’ caucus; Antinous’ speech inside it is an open conspiracy to murder the man who convened the real assembly. ↩
47. Antinous’ speech is the conspiracy stripped of pretense: the ambush confessed in operational detail (watchers on the headlands, relays, nights afloat), the failure blamed on a god, and the conclusion drawn without a blush — kill him faster. Note what he fears: not guilt, but publicity — Telemachus telling the assembly, the people’s anger, exile (376–382). Antinous’ conscience is entirely political. ↩
48. “The people no longer look on us with any favor” — the suitors know the δῆμος has turned. The line quietly answers Odysseus’ question at 95–96 (does the town hate Telemachus?): no — it is coming to hate *them*. The revenge of Book 22, lawless as it looks, will have public opinion behind it — until Book 24 tests even that. ↩
49. The two options Antinous offers are annihilation or divestment: murder Telemachus and split his goods (the house thrown to the mother and her new man), or disband the siege and woo like decent men with bride-gifts from their own halls. The second option — simply behaving properly — has been available for three years. It is offered here only as leverage, and no one takes it. ↩
50. Amphinomus “pleased Penelope with his talk, for his mind was set on good” — the single line that will weigh most in his

scenes to come. See note at 351. ↩

51. “Dreadful it is to kill the blood of kings” (δεινὸν δὲ γένος βασιλῆϊόν ἐστιν κτείνειν): Amphinomus’ scruple is dynastic taboo, not mercy — and even it must be sub-contracted to Zeus for permission. Still, in this company, a superstition against regicide passes for a conscience. ↩
52. “Then watchful-minded Penelope thought of one thing more” — the ἐνόησε formula (2.382 family) that elsewhere launches Athena’s and Nausicaa’s stratagems here powers Penelope’s boldest public act so far: she comes down to face her son’s would-be murderers with the plot still warm. ↩
53. Medon the herald — the suitors’ own crier — overheard their council and told the queen, just as he carried her their first murder-plot in Book 4 (4.677–679): the machine’s standing leak. Odysseus will spare him for it in the slaughter (22.357ff), on Telemachus’ word. ↩
54. The veil-and-pillar lines repeat 1.333–334 exactly — Penelope’s fixed entrance. But in Book 1 she came down to stop a song; now she comes down to stop a murder. Same doorway, same glistening veil, and the poem lets the identical frame measure how far the stakes have risen. ↩
55. Penelope’s rebuke of Antinous is the sharpest speech she has made: insult (“insolence itself”), demolition of his reputation (“they say you are the best... You were never such a man”), indictment (suppliants, Zeus as witness), and then the unanswerable family history: your father ran to this house for his life, and Odysseus saved him. The debt is precise —

Eupeithes owed Odysseus his life, his son repays it by devouring the house and plotting the heir's murder. ↩

56. The Eupeithes backstory — Taphian piracy against allied Thesprotians, the mob, Odysseus' protection — is new information, planted with terrible economy: this same Eupeithes will lead the kinsmen's revolt in Book 24, raging for the son Odysseus kills, having forgotten the life Odysseus gave him. The poem's moral bookkeeping spans both ends of the epic through one minor name. ↩

57. "Daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded Penelope" — the ceremonial vocative (first appearance; it will recur through Books 17–24). Eurymachus reaches for maximum formality because he is about to tell maximum lies. ↩

58. Eurymachus' oath is engineered irony at its cruellest: "his black blood would run down my spear — that man's" — while he plots that man's death; and the childhood memory he cites (Odysseus dandling him, roast meat, red wine held to his lips) is presumably true, which makes it worse. At 22.79ff Eurymachus will draw on Odysseus and die with the sacker of cities' arrow in his liver — his own blood, the spear the other way. The narrator's flat epilogue (448) has already convicted him. ↩

59. "So he spoke to soothe her — and was himself preparing the boy's destruction": the narrator's single-line exposure, the poem's coldest use of its omniscience. No rhetoric; just the two clauses set side by side. ↩

60. Lines 450–451 repeat 1.363–364 verbatim: she weeps for Odysseus until Athena gives sleep. The refrain of Penelope's

nights closes appearance after appearance like a door; it will sound again at 19.602–604 and 21.357–358. Within it the queen’s entire interior life is kept — offstage, nightly, unchanged for twenty years. ↩

61. The re-disguise, with reason given: not that Eumaeus is disloyal, but that he could not hold such news — he would run to Penelope with it. The poem is exact about the swineherd’s one weakness: an incontinence of love. The wand works both ways, and the family’s circle of knowledge closes back to two. ↩
62. The hill of Hermes (Ἑρμῆος λόφος) — a landmark cairn of the god of wayfarers, exactly where a traveler pauses and looks back at the harbor. Eumaeus’ report is the observant countryman’s: hull heavy in the water, the glint of shields and spears — the ambush ship home, armed and empty-handed. ↩
63. “The sacred strength of Telemachus smiled, / and his eyes went to his father — slipping past the swineherd’s.” The first fruit of the recognition: a shared glance over a servant’s unknowing head. The periphrasis ἱερὴ ἰς Τηλεμάχοιο (“sacred strength,” the honorific formerly reserved for Alcinous) marks the promotion: the boy is now a conspirator in his own house, smiling at what he knows. ↩
64. “They remembered their beds, and took the gift of sleep” — the book that began with dogs who would not bark closes the hut in a single quiet line: father, son, and swineherd under one roof, two of them sharing a secret, all of them armed with nothing yet but sleep. ↩

Odyssey — Book 17

*The beggar comes to his own house; Argus; Antinous’
footstool.*

- 1 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,¹
- 2 then Telemachus bound the beautiful sandals
under his feet —
- 3 Telemachus, dear son of godlike Odysseus —
- 4 and took his strong spear, which fitted his palm
well,
- 5 straining toward the city; and he spoke to his
swineherd:
- 6 “Old father, I am off to the town, so my mother
- 7 may see me. I do not think she will leave off
- 8 her hateful weeping and her tearful mourning
before
- 9 she sees me in the flesh. And this is my charge
to you:
- 10 take this luckless stranger to the city, so there

11 he can beg his dinner; whoever wishes will give
him

12 a crust and a cupful. I cannot carry every man
13 who comes, not I — I have griefs enough at
heart.

14 And if the stranger takes it hard, so much the
worse

15 for him. I like to say the truth of things straight
out.”²

16 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

17 “Friend, I have no wish myself to be kept back
here.

18 Better for a beggar to beg his dinner in the
town

19 than in the fields; whoever wishes will give to
me.

20 I am no longer of an age for staying on at
farmsteads,

21 obeying in everything the word of an overseer.

22 Go on, then. This man will bring me, as you
order,

23 as soon as I have warmed myself at the fire,
and the sun's heat comes.3

24 These clothes I have are terribly bad: the
morning frost

25 might be too much for me — and the town, you
say, is far.”

26 So he spoke; and Telemachus went out through
the farmstead,

27 stepping fast, planting evils for the suitors.

28 And when he reached the well-settled house,

29 he set his spear against a tall pillar, carrying it
in,

30 and went inside himself, over the stone
threshold.

31 And far the first to see him was the nurse
Eurycleia,4

32 spreading fleeces over the inlaid chairs;

33 with a burst of tears she came straight toward
him, and around him

34 the other slave-women of enduring-hearted
Odysseus

35 gathered, and kissed his head and shoulders,

welcoming him.

36 And out of her chamber came watchful-
minded Penelope,

37 like Artemis, or golden Aphrodite,⁵

38 and threw her arms around her dear son,
weeping,

39 and kissed his head, and both his beautiful
eyes,

40 and sobbing spoke winged words to him:

41 “You have come, Telemachus — sweet light! I
told myself⁶

42 I would never see you again, once you had
gone by ship to Pylos —

43 secretly, against my will, for news of your dear
father.

44 Come now, tell me over: what sight of him did
you meet?”

45 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:

46 “Mother mine, do not stir up weeping in me,
nor rouse

47 the heart in my breast — I have just escaped
sheer death.

48 No: bathe, and take clean clothing for your
body,

49 and go up to the upper room with your
attendant women,

50 and vow to all the gods that you will offer
perfect

51 hecatombs, if Zeus may some day accomplish
works of requital.

52 And I will go to the assembly-place, to call in

53 a guest who followed with me as I traveled
here.

54 I sent him on ahead with my godlike
companions,

55 and told Piraeus to take him home with him

56 and care for him kindly, and honor him, until I
come.”

57 So he spoke; and for her the word stayed
wingless.⁷

58 And she bathed, and took clean clothing for
her body,

59 and vowed to all the gods that she would offer
perfect

60 hecatombs, if Zeus might some day accomplish
works of requital.

61 Then Telemachus went on out through the
hall,

62 spear in hand; two swift dogs followed with
him,

63 and Athena poured a wondrous grace upon
him.

64 All the people gazed at him in wonder as he
came;⁸

65 and around him the lordly suitors gathered,

66 speaking him fair, but brooding evils deep in
their hearts.

67 He slipped away from their thick crowd

68 and went where Mentor sat, and Antiphus, and
Halitherses,⁹

69 who were his father's companions from the
beginning,

70 and sat down there; and they questioned him
on everything.

71 And Piraeus, famous for the spear, came near
them,

72 leading his guest through the town to the
assembly-place; and Telemachus
73 did not stand off long from his guest, but went
to him.
74 And Piraeus spoke to him first:
75 “Telemachus, send women to my house at
once,
76 so I can send you back the gifts Menelaus gave
you.”
77 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:
78 “Piraeus — we do not know yet how these
matters will fall.**10**
79 If the lordly suitors kill me in my halls
80 by treachery, and divide up all my father’s
goods,
81 I would rather you keep the gifts and have the
joy of them
82 than any of those men. But if I plant death and
doom for them,
83 then bring them, glad, to my house — and glad
I shall be.”
84 So speaking, he led the travel-worn stranger

home.

85 And when they reached the well-settled house,

86 they laid their mantles down on the couches
and chairs

87 and stepped into the polished baths and
bathed.

88 And when the slave-women had bathed them
and rubbed them with oil,

89 and thrown about them fleecy cloaks and
tunics,

90 they came out of the baths and sat down on
the couches.

91 A handmaid brought water for their hands in a
pitcher,

92 a beautiful golden one, and poured it over a
silver basin

93 for them to wash, and drew up a polished table
beside them.

94 The grave housekeeper brought bread and set
it before them,

95 laying out delicacies in plenty, giving gladly of
her store;

96 and his mother sat opposite, by the pillar of
the hall,
97 leaning back in her chair, spinning fine threads
of yarn.¹¹
98 And their hands went out to the good things
spread before them.
99 But when they had put away desire for food
and drink,
100 watchful-minded Penelope began to speak
among them:
101 “Telemachus, I am going up to my upper room
102 to lie on the bed that has become a bed of
groaning for me,¹²
103 forever stained with my tears, since the day
Odysseus
104 went with the sons of Atreus to Ilium. And
you have not brought yourself,
105 before the lordly suitors come back into this
house,
106 to tell me plainly of your father’s
homecoming — if you heard anything.”
107 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:

108 “Then I will tell you, mother, the truth of it.13

109 We went to Pylos, and to Nestor, shepherd of
the people;

110 and he received me in his high house

111 and gave me loving welcome, as a father would
his son

112 come home at last from far away: with such

113 kindness he tended me, he and his glorious
sons.

114 But of enduring-hearted Odysseus, alive or
dead,

115 he said he had heard nothing from anyone on
earth.

116 He sent me on, with horses and a bolted
chariot,

117 to Atreus’ son, Menelaus famed for the spear.

118 There I saw Argive Helen, for whose sake

119 the Argives and the Trojans labored so much,
by the gods’ will.

120 And Menelaus of the great war-cry asked me
at once

121 what need had brought me to shining

Lacedaemon;

122 and I told him the whole truth of it.

123 And then he answered me with these words:

124 'Shame on them! Truly in the bed of a strong-
hearted man

125 they want to lie — the spineless creatures that
they are!

126 As when a deer beds down her newborn
suckling fawns¹⁴

127 in the thicket-lair of a mighty lion,

128 and goes questing the spurs and grassy
hollows,

129 grazing — and then the lion comes back to his
own bed

130 and lets an ugly doom loose on them both:

131 so Odysseus will let an ugly doom loose on
those men.

132 If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo! —

133 the man he was long ago in strong-founded
Lesbos,

134 when he rose on a challenge and wrestled
Philomeleides

135 and threw him hard, and all the Achaeans
cheered:

136 such as he was then, let that Odysseus close
with the suitors:

137 quick would their fates be then, and bitter
their weddings.

138 As for what you ask of me and beg me: I will
not

139 talk around it, swerving aside, and I will not
deceive you.

140 What the unerring Old Man of the Sea told
me,

141 not one word of it will I hide or cover from
you.

142 He said he saw him on an island, in strong
pain,

143 in the halls of the nymph Calypso, who holds
him there

144 by force; and he cannot come to his own
fatherland,

145 for he has no ships at hand, no oars, no
companions

146 to carry him over the broad back of the sea.’
147 So spoke Atreus’ son, Menelaus famed for the
spear.
148 That done, I came away; and the deathless
ones gave me
149 a breeze, and brought me quickly to my own
dear country.”
150 So he spoke, and stirred the heart in her
breast.
151 And godlike Theoclymenus spoke among them
too:
152 “Honored wife of Laertes’ son Odysseus,
153 truly he does not know it plainly. Mark my
word:
154 I will prophesy to you exactly, and hide
nothing.
155 Zeus be witness now, first of the gods, and this
table of guest-right,**15**
156 and this hearth of blameless Odysseus to
which I have come:
157 Odysseus is already in his own dear country —
158 sitting still, or moving — learning of these evil

doings,

159 and planting evil for all the suitors.

160 So clear was the bird of omen I marked

161 as I sat on the well-benched ship, and I cried it
out to Telemachus.”

162 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

163 “Ah, stranger, if only that word might be
accomplished:16

164 then you would quickly know my friendship,
and gifts

165 in plenty from me — any man who met you
would call you blessed.”

166 So they spoke to one another of such things.

167 But the suitors, in front of Odysseus’ hall,

168 were amusing themselves with discus and
javelin throws

169 on the leveled ground, insolent as ever, where
they always played.17

170 But when it was dinner-time, and the flocks
came in

171 from the fields all around, led by the men who

always led them,

172 then Medon spoke to them — for he of all the
heralds

173 pleased them best, and was always by them at
the feast:

174 “Young men — now that you have all
delighted your hearts with games,

175 come toward the house, so we can lay the
meal.

176 There is nothing the worse in a dinner taken
on time.”

177 So he spoke; and they rose and went, and
obeyed his word.

178 And when they reached the well-settled
house,

179 they laid their mantles down on the couches
and chairs

180 and slaughtered big sheep and fat goats,

181 slaughtered sleek hogs and a heifer of the
herd,

182 making their meal ready. And meanwhile
from the country

183 Odysseus and the noble swineherd were
stirring themselves

184 to go to the city; and the swineherd began, a
leader of men:

185 “Stranger — since you are set on going to the
town

186 today, as my master ordered — though for
myself

187 I would rather have left you here to guard the
farmstead,

188 but him I respect and fear: he might scold me

189 afterward, and a master’s reproofs are hard to
bear —18

190 come then, let us be off: the day is mostly

191 gone already, and toward evening you will feel
the cold.”

192 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

193 “I know. I understand. You order a man who is
thinking it too.19

194 Let us go, then — and you lead the whole way
through.

195 And give me a staff to lean on, if you have one
196 cut anywhere, since you say the road is
treacherous.”

197 He spoke, and slung about his shoulders his
beggar’s pouch,

198 full of holes, hanging by a twisted cord,

199 and Eumaeus gave him a stick that suited
him.**20**

200 The two set out; and the dogs and the
herdsmen stayed

201 behind, guarding the farm. And he led his
master toward the city

202 in the likeness of a beggar, wretched and old,

203 leaning on a stick, with miserable clothing on
his body.

204 But when, making their way down the rugged
road,

205 they were near the town, and came to the
fountain,

206 well-built, fair-flowing, where the people of
the town drew water —

207 made by Ithacus and Neritus and Polycctor;**21**

208 around it stood a grove of water-nourished
poplars,
209 circling it on every side, and the cold water
ran down
210 from the rock above; and on top an altar was
built
211 to the nymphs, where all wayfarers made
their offerings —
212 there Melanthius the son of Dolius overtook
them,22
213 driving his goats, the ones that stood out in all
the herds,
214 a dinner for the suitors; and two herdsmen
followed with him.
215 Seeing the pair he broke out against them —
named them
216 in words beyond all bounds, indecent — and it
stirred Odysseus' heart:
217 “Now here is the vile leading the vile, no
mistake —
218 as ever, the god is bringing like and like
together!23

219 Where are you taking that glutton, you pitiful
swineherd,
220 that beggar-pest, that licker of feast-plates?²⁴
221 He is the sort to stand rubbing his shoulders
on many doorposts,
222 whining for scraps — not for swords and
cauldrons.
223 Give him to me, to keep watch over my
farmstead,
224 to sweep the pens and carry green shoots to
the kids —
225 and drinking whey he might put some meat
on that thigh.
226 But no: he has learned bad ways, and he will
not
227 set himself to work; he would rather cringe
through the town
228 begging, to feed that bottomless belly of his.
229 But I will tell you this, and it will be
accomplished:
230 if he comes to the house of godlike Odysseus,
231 many the footstools flying round his head

from men's hands²⁵

²³² that his ribs will wear away with, pelted
through the house.”

²³³ So he spoke; and passing, the fool, he lashed
out a heel

²³⁴ at his hip — yet did not knock him off the
path:

²³⁵ he stood there, steady. And Odysseus weighed
it —²⁶

²³⁶ whether to spring after him and take his life
with the stick,

²³⁷ or lift him by the middle and dash his head
against the ground.

²³⁸ But he mastered himself, and held it in. And
the swineherd

²³⁹ rebuked the man to his face, and lifting his
hands prayed aloud:

²⁴⁰ “Nymphs of the spring, daughters of Zeus — if
ever Odysseus²⁷

²⁴¹ burned thigh-pieces for you, wrapped in rich
fat,

²⁴² of lambs or of kids, grant me this my prayer:

243 that the man himself come back, and a god
guide him home.

244 He would scatter all those airs of yours,

245 every one — that you now wear so insolently,
forever drifting

246 around the town, while bad herdsmen ruin
the flocks.”

247 Then Melanthius the goatherd answered him:

248 “Well, well! How the cur talks — nothing but
mischief in him!

249 One day I will take him on a black well-
benched ship

250 far from Ithaca, where he could fetch me a
good living.

251 If only Apollo of the silver bow would strike
Telemachus

252 today in the halls, or the suitors bring him
down,

253 as surely as for Odysseus, far away, the day of
homecoming is dead!”

254 So speaking he left them there, walking
slowly on,

255 and strode off, and came very quickly to the
master's house.

256 He went straight in and sat down among the
suitors,

257 opposite Eurymachus: for him he loved best of
all.29

258 The serving-men set a portion of meat beside
him,

259 and the grave housekeeper brought bread and
set it by him

260 to eat. And meanwhile Odysseus and the
noble swineherd

261 came up close and stopped; and around them
came the ringing

262 of the hollow lyre: for Phemius was striking
up

263 his song among them. And Odysseus took the
swineherd's hand and said:

264 "Eumaeus — surely this is the beautiful house
of Odysseus.30

265 Easy it is to know it, to pick out at a glance
among many.

266 One part is joined to another; the courtyard is
finished

267 with wall and coping; the double doors are
strong

268 and well-fenced. No man could storm it with
contempt.

269 And I can tell that a crowd of men is feasting

270 in it: the smell of roasting rises, and the lyre

271 is ringing there, which the gods made
companion to the feast.”

272 And you answered him, Eumaeus the
swineherd:

273 “Easily known — you, who are not slow-witted
in anything else.

274 But come, let us think how these things are to
go.

275 Either you go first into the well-settled house

276 and slip in among the suitors, and I stay
behind here;

277 or, if you like, you wait, and I go on ahead.

278 But do not linger long, or someone may see
you outside

279 and throw something, or strike you. Think on
it, I say.”

280 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus
answered him:

281 “I know. I understand. You order a man who is
thinking it too.

282 You go on ahead; I will stay behind here.

283 I am not unacquainted with blows and
peltings:

284 my heart is a patient one — I have suffered
much evil

285 from waves and from war. Let this be added to
the rest.

286 But a ravening belly there is no hiding
away,³¹

287 that accursed thing, which gives so many
evils to men;

288 for its sake even the well-benched ships are
rigged

289 to cross the barren sea, bearing evil to
enemies.”

290 So they spoke to one another of such things.

291 And a dog lying there lifted his head and ears:
292 Argus, the dog of enduring-hearted Odysseus,
whom once he32
293 raised himself — and had no joy of him: too
soon he was gone
294 to holy Ilium. In the old days the young men
took him
295 out after wild goats, and roe deer, and hares;
296 now he lay neglected, his master gone away,
297 on the deep pile of dung that the mules and
cattle33
298 dropped in heaps before the doors, until
Odysseus' slaves
299 could cart it off to manure his great estate.
300 There lay the dog Argus, covered with dog-
ticks.
301 And now, as he sensed Odysseus near him,
302 he wagged his tail, and laid both his ears back
flat,
303 but no longer had the strength to come any
closer
304 to his master. And Odysseus, glancing aside,

wiped away a tear —34

305 easily hidden from Eumaeus — and at once he questioned him:

306 “Eumaeus — a strange thing: this dog lying on the dung-heap.

307 His frame is beautiful; though this I cannot tell for certain:

308 whether he had speed to run to match this beauty,

309 or was merely one of those table-dogs men keep,

310 the kind their masters tend for show alone.”

311 And you answered him, Eumaeus the swineherd:

312 “Only too true: this is the dog of a man who died far away.

313 If he were now in form and action such

314 as Odysseus left him, going away to Troy,

315 you would stare at the speed and strength of him.

316 Nothing escaped him in the deep places of the wood,

317 no game he chased: he was surest of all on a trail.

318 Now he is in a bad way: his master has perished

319 far from home, and the women are careless and give him no tending.

320 Slaves — when their masters lose the upper hand,35

321 they will no longer do their work as it should be done:

322 for Zeus of the wide voice takes half the worth away

323 from a man, the day the day of slavery seizes him.”

324 So speaking he entered the well-settled house

325 and went straight down the hall among the haughty suitors.

326 But Argus — the doom of black death took him36

327 the moment he had seen Odysseus, in the twentieth year.

328 And godlike Telemachus was far the first to

see

329 the swineherd coming down the house; and
quickly then

330 he nodded, calling him over. Glancing about,
he took a stool

331 that lay there, where the carver would sit

332 while carving meat in plenty for the suitors
feasting through the house;

333 this he carried and set at Telemachus' table,

334 opposite him, and sat down on it himself. And
a herald

335 took up a portion and set it before him, with
bread lifted from the basket.

336 And close behind him Odysseus entered the
house

337 in the likeness of a beggar, wretched and old,

338 leaning on a stick, with miserable clothing on
his body.

339 He sat down on the ash-wood threshold,
inside the doors,37

340 leaning against the cypress doorpost, which a
carpenter

341 once planed with skill and trued to the line.
342 And Telemachus called the swineherd to him
and said —
343 taking a whole loaf out of the beautiful
basket,
344 and meat, as much as his two cupped hands
could hold —
345 “Take these and give them to the stranger,
and tell him this:
346 to go the round of the suitors, every one, and
beg.
347 Shame is no good companion to a man in
need.”**38**
348 So he spoke; and the swineherd went when he
heard the word,
349 and standing close he spoke winged words:
350 “Telemachus gives you these, stranger, and he
bids you
351 go the round of the suitors, every one, and
beg.
352 Shame, he says, is no good thing in a beggar-
man.”

353 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

354 “Lord Zeus — grant me that Telemachus be
blessed among men,

355 and that all his heart desires be brought to
pass.”

356 He spoke, and took it in both hands, and set it
down

357 there at his feet, on the shabby pouch,

358 and ate, all the while the singer sang in the
halls;

359 and when he had done his meal, the godlike
singer ended.

360 And the suitors raised a din through the hall.
But Athena

361 came and stood close by Laertes’ son Odysseus

362 and urged him on: to go gathering crusts
among the suitors,

363 and learn which of them were decent and
which were lawless —

364 though even so she had no mind to save one
man of them from ruin.39

365 So he set off, going right-handed round,
begging from each man,
366 stretching out his hand on every side, as if he
had begged all his life.40
367 And they pitied him and gave, and wondered
at him,
368 and asked each other who he was and where
he came from.
369 And Melanthius the goatherd spoke among
them:
370 “Hear me, you suitors of the far-famed queen,
371 about this stranger: I have seen him before.
372 It was the swineherd, no other, brought him
here;
373 the man himself I do not know for certain —
where he claims his birth.”
374 So he spoke; and Antinous laid into the
swineherd:
375 “You — swineherd — everyone knows you.
Why did you bring
376 this thing to town? Have we not vagrants
enough already,

377 beggar-pests, lickers of feast-plates?
378 Do you think it a small matter that they
gather here
379 and eat your master's living away — and now
you invite one more?”
380 And you answered him, Eumaeus the
swineherd:
381 “Antinous — well-born you may be, but that
was not well spoken.
382 Who ever goes himself and invites a stranger
383 from abroad — unless it be one of the public
workers:41
384 a seer, a healer of sickness, a builder in
timber,
385 or an inspired singer, who delights with his
singing?
386 Those men are invited the wide earth over;
387 but a beggar — who would invite a beggar, to
eat him bare?
388 No: of all the suitors you are always hardest
389 on the slaves of Odysseus, and beyond all on
me. But I —

390 I care nothing, so long as steady-hearted
Penelope
391 lives in the halls, and godlike Telemachus.”
392 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:
393 “Hush — do not trade long speeches with this
man.
394 It is Antinous’ way, forever needling, ugly,
395 with hard words; and he sets the others on as
well.”
396 He spoke, and then to Antinous said winged
words:
397 “Antinous — how finely you care for me, as a
father for his son,⁴²
398 you who order me to drive this stranger from
my hall
399 with a word of command! May god never
bring that to pass.
400 Take and give to him. I do not grudge it — I
order it, I myself.
401 And have no fear of my mother in this, nor of
any

402 of the slaves in the house of godlike Odysseus.
403 But no — no such thought is in your breast:
404 you would far rather eat it yourself than give
to another.”
405 Then Antinous answered him and said:
406 “Telemachus, high talker, temper past
restraining — what a thing to say.
407 If all the suitors handed him as much as I
will,43
408 this house would keep him at arm’s length
three full months.”
409 So he spoke, and snatched up the footstool
from under the table and showed it —
410 the stool where he propped his sleek feet
while he feasted.
411 But all the others gave, and they filled the
pouch
412 with bread and meat. And soon Odysseus was
to go
413 back to the threshold, to taste the Achaeans’
free bounty;
414 but he stopped beside Antinous, and spoke a

word to him:

415 “Give, friend. You do not look to me the
meanest of the Achaeans —

416 no, the noblest of them: you have the look of a
king.44

417 So it is right that you should give even better
than the others —

418 bread; and I would spread your fame over the
boundless earth.

419 For I too once lived in a house among men,

420 a fortunate man in a wealthy one, and I often
gave to a wanderer,

421 whoever he might be and whatever need he
came in.

422 Slaves I had past counting, and everything in
plenty

423 by which men live well and get the name of
rich.

424 But Zeus the son of Cronos stripped it all —
such, no doubt, was his will —

425 he who sent me out with roving pirates

426 to Egypt, a long road, to be destroyed there.45

427 And in the river of Egypt I moored my curved
ships.

428 Then, you may be sure, I ordered my trusted
companions

429 to stay there by the ships and guard the ships,

430 and I sent out scouts to the lookout places.

431 But they gave way to arrogance — followed
their own force —

432 and straightway began to pillage the beautiful
fields

433 of the Egyptian men: they carried off the
women and small children,

434 and killed the men. And quickly the cry
reached the city.

435 Hearing the shout, at the showing of dawn
the people

436 came; and the whole plain filled with infantry
and horses

437 and the lightning of bronze. And Zeus who
delights in thunder

438 threw an evil panic on my companions, and
no man dared

439 stand and face it: for destruction ringed us
everywhere.

440 There they killed many of us with the sharp
bronze,

441 and others they led up alive, to slave for them
by force.

442 But me they gave to a guest-friend who met
them there, for Cyprus —

443 Dmetor, Iasus' son, who ruled Cyprus by his
strength.

444 From there I have come here now, suffering
hardship.”

445 Then Antinous answered him and raised his
voice:

446 “What god has brought this plague here to
sour the feast?

447 Stand off there, in the middle, away from my
table,

448 or you may come soon to a bitter Egypt and a
bitter Cyprus —46

449 a bold and shameless beggar you are!

450 You stand by every man in turn, and they give

451 recklessly: there is no holding back, no
scruple

452 in being generous with other men's goods —
each has plenty at hand.”47

453 Then Odysseus of the many designs drew back
and said:

454 “Well, well. So the wits in you are no match
for the looks!

455 You would not give so much as a grain of salt
from your own stores,48

456 you who sit now at another man's table and
cannot

457 bring yourself to take of the bread and give it
— and plenty is at hand.”

458 So he spoke; and Antinous grew the angrier at
heart,

459 and glaring from under his brows he spoke
winged words:

460 “Now I do not think you leave this hall so
prettily

461 after all — not now you take to insults too.”

462 With that he seized the footstool and threw it,

and struck the right shoulder⁴⁹

⁴⁶³ low, at the base of the back. And he stood like
rock,

⁴⁶⁴ steady: the cast of Antinous did not stagger
him.

⁴⁶⁵ He only shook his head, silent, brooding evils
deep in his heart.⁵⁰

⁴⁶⁶ Then he went back to the threshold and sat,
and laid down

⁴⁶⁷ the well-filled pouch, and spoke out among
the suitors:

⁴⁶⁸ “Hear me, you suitors of the far-famed queen,

⁴⁶⁹ while I say what the heart in my breast
commands.

⁴⁷⁰ There is no grief in the mind, no sorrow
worth the name,

⁴⁷¹ when a man is struck fighting for his own
possessions,

⁴⁷² for his cattle, say, or his silver-white sheep.

⁴⁷³ But Antinous struck me for my wretched
belly’s sake,

⁴⁷⁴ that accursed thing, which gives so many

evils to men.

475 If anywhere there are gods and Furies for
beggars,51

476 may death's end find Antinous before any
wedding."

477 Then Antinous answered him, Eupeithes' son:

478 "Sit still and eat, stranger, or take yourself
elsewhere —

479 or for words like these the young men will
drag you through the house

480 by hand or foot, and flay the skin from every
part of you."

481 So he spoke; but all the rest were angered
beyond measure,

482 and one of the arrogant young men would
say:

483 "Antinous — that was not well done, striking
the luckless wanderer.

484 Doomed man! — what if he should be some
god come down from heaven?

485 And the gods do go about, in the likeness of
strangers52

486 from far countries, taking every shape, and
move through the cities,

487 watching over the violence of men, and the
good order they keep.”

488 So the suitors spoke; but he paid no heed to
their words.

489 And Telemachus nursed a great grief swelling
in his heart

490 for the striking of him; yet he let no tear fall
to the ground,

491 but only shook his head, silent, brooding evils
deep in his heart.**53**

492 And when watchful-minded Penelope heard
of it —

493 the man struck in the hall — she said among
her slave-women:

494 “So may Apollo the famed archer strike you,
Antinous!”

495 And the housekeeper Eurynome added her
word:**54**

496 “If an end could only come in answer to our
prayers,

497 not one of these men would live to see fair-
throned Dawn.”

498 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
her:

499 “Nurse, they are enemies all, for they all plot
evil;

500 but Antinous most of all is like black doom
itself.⁵⁵

501 Some luckless stranger wanders through the
house

502 begging alms of the men — his poverty
commands him —

503 and all the others filled his pouch and gave,

504 but that one struck him with a footstool at
the base of the right shoulder.”

505 So she spoke among her attendant slave-
women,

506 sitting in her chamber. And meanwhile noble
Odysseus was at his meal.

507 And she called the noble swineherd to her
side and said:

508 “Go, noble Eumaeus. Tell the stranger to

come here,

509 so I may greet him a little, and ask him

510 whether he has heard anything of enduring-
hearted Odysseus,

511 or seen him with his eyes. He looks a far-
wandered man.”

512 And you answered her, Eumaeus the
swineherd:

513 “If only the Achaeans would keep silence for
you, queen:

514 the things he tells would charm your very
heart.

515 Three nights I had him, three days I kept him
with me

516 in the hut — for I was the first he came to,
running from a ship —

517 and even so he never finished the tale of his
sufferings.

518 As a man gazes at a singer, who sings to
mortals⁵⁶

519 lessons of longing that the gods have taught
him,

520 and they ache to hear him on and on, as long
as he will sing —

521 so that man cast his spell on me, sitting in my
house.

522 And he says he is a guest-friend of Odysseus'
father's line,

523 and lives in Crete, where the race of Minos is.

524 From there he has come here now, suffering
hardship,

525 tumbled on and on; and he swears he has
heard of Odysseus

526 near, in the rich land of the Thesprotian men,

527 alive — and bringing treasures home in
plenty.”

528 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

529 “Go, call him here, so he can tell it to my face.

530 And those men — let them sit at the doors
and amuse themselves,

531 or here in the house, since their hearts are
merry.

532 Their own possessions lie untouched at home,

533 bread and sweet wine: their house-folk eat
that,
534 while they crowd our house day after day,
535 slaughtering our oxen and sheep and fat
goats,
536 feasting away and drinking the sparkling wine
537 recklessly. The most of it is wasted. For there
is no man here,
538 such as Odysseus was, to ward ruin from the
house.
539 But if Odysseus came — if he reached his own
country —
540 quickly, with his son, he would repay these
men their violence.”
541 So she spoke; and Telemachus sneezed — a
great sneeze — and round about58
542 the whole house rang terribly with it. And
Penelope laughed,
543 and quickly spoke winged words to Eumaeus:
544 “Go — please — and call the stranger here
before me.
545 Do you not see how my son sneezed on all I

said?

546 So may death be not unaccomplished for the
suitsors —

547 for every man of them; not one shall slip out
of death and the fates.

548 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in
your heart.

549 If I find that everything he says is true,

550 I will dress him in a cloak and a tunic, fine
clothing.”59

551 So she spoke; and the swineherd went when
he heard the word,

552 and standing close he spoke winged words:

553 “Stranger — father — watchful-minded
Penelope is calling for you,60

554 the mother of Telemachus. Her heart bids her
ask

555 about her husband, for all the griefs she has
borne.

556 And if she finds that everything you say is
true,

557 she will dress you in a cloak and a tunic — the

things you need

558 most of all. And your bread you can beg
through the town

559 and feed your belly; whoever wishes will give
to you.”

560 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus
answered him:

561 “Eumaeus, I would tell it all, truly, and at once,
562 to the daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded
Penelope —

563 for I know about that man well: we have taken
up the same misery.61

564 But I am afraid of this mob of hard suitors,
565 whose arrogance and violence reach the iron
sky.62

566 Just now, when that man hit me and gave me
pain

567 as I went through the hall doing no harm at
all,

568 neither Telemachus nor any other man
stepped in.

569 So tell Penelope to wait in the halls,

570 however eager, until the sun goes down;**63**
571 and then let her ask me about her husband's
day of homecoming,
572 giving me a seat closer to the fire: for the
clothes
573 I wear are miserable. You know it yourself — I
begged you first of all.”
574 So he spoke; and the swineherd went when he
heard the word.
575 And as he crossed the threshold Penelope
said:
576 “You do not bring him, Eumaeus? What has
the wanderer in mind?
577 Is he too much afraid of someone? Or shy for
some other cause,
578 here in the house? A shy man makes a bad
beggar.”**64**
579 And you answered her, Eumaeus the
swineherd:
580 “He speaks as is right — as anyone would
judge who thought it through —
581 wanting to keep clear of the insolence of these

overbearing men.

582 He asks you to wait until the sun goes down.

583 And for you too, queen, it is far the better
way:

584 to speak your word to the stranger alone, and
hear him alone.”

585 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

586 “The stranger is no fool. He guesses what
could happen:65

587 for I think there are no men anywhere, none
among mortals,

588 who plot such reckless evil in their
insolence.”

589 So she spoke her say; and the noble
swineherd went off

590 into the crowd of the suitors, when he had
told her everything,

591 and at once he spoke winged words to
Telemachus,

592 leaning his head close, so the others would
not hear:

593 “Friend, I am going back, to watch the swine
and all that is there —
594 your living and mine. And everything here —
let it be your care.
595 Keep yourself safe first of all, and be watchful
at heart
596 that nothing happens to you. Many of the
Achaean think evil —
597 may Zeus wipe them out before harm comes
to us!”
598 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:
599 “So be it, old father. Go when you have had
your evening meal;
600 and in the morning come again, and bring
fine beasts for slaughter.
601 All the rest shall be my care, and the deathless
ones’.”
602 So he spoke; and the other sat down again on
the polished stool,
603 and when he had filled his heart with food
and drink,

604 he went his way to his swine, and left the
walls and the hall
605 full of banqueters; and they were delighting
in dance and song,
606 for already the day had come on to
evening.67

Notes

NOTES

1. The dawn formula here opens the poem's great single day — or nearly: Books 17 and 18 run to this evening, Book 19 fills the night, and Book 20 wakes into the day of the bow. From this sunrise on, the poem's clock slows almost to real time, and everything converges on the house — the farm and the road up to town filling the morning before the hall claims the rest. ↩
2. Telemachus plays his part with relish: brusque, put-upon, disclaiming the stranger ("I cannot carry every man who comes"). The rudeness is camouflage — he owes the beggar nothing in public — but the closing tag, "I like to say the truth of things straight out," is a private joke buried in the performance: everything he has just said is theater. ↩
3. The beggar's reasons for lingering — warm the fire out of his bones, let the frost burn off, the town is far — are a poor man's

calculations rendered without condescension. The poem knows what cold means to a man in rags; so does the king wearing them. ↩

4. Eurycleia “far the first” to see him — the nurse outstrips the mother by a room’s length, as the swineherd outstripped them both by a day. The poem keeps strict account of the order in which love arrives. ↩
5. “Like Artemis, or golden Aphrodite” — the double comparison held ready for Penelope’s re-entries (it returns at 19.54). Chastity and desirability at once: the two goddesses between whom her whole situation is strung. ↩
6. “You have come, Telemachus — sweet light!” — Penelope repeats, word for word, the greeting Eumaeus cried at 16.23. Mother and swineherd share one cry between them, a book apart; neither will ever know the other said it. ↩
7. “For her the word stayed wingless” (ἄπτερος ἔπλετο μῦθος) — the poem’s strangest small formula: the reply that never takes flight. She obeys in silence — no answer rises to her lips at all. It recurs at 19.29, 21.386, 22.398, always of a woman receiving instruction wordlessly; here it carries a mother’s whole swallowed protest. ↩
8. Lines 62–64 repeat Telemachus’ first walk to the assembly (2.10–13): the two swift dogs, Athena’s wondrous grace, the people gazing. The frame returns with the situation transformed — then he went to plead and fail; now he comes back from the sea with a father hidden behind him and “evils planted” for the men who mocked him. ↩

9. Mentor, Antiphus, Halitherses — the loyal remnant, “his father’s companions from the beginning.” Antiphus is a bitter name to find alive here: his namesake, Aegyptius’ son, is the man the Cyclops ate last (2.19–20). The poem seats Telemachus with the old guard — Mentor and Halitherses, the very men who spoke for Odysseus in the Book 2 assembly. ↩
10. Telemachus’ answer to Piraeus is estate-planning by a man who expects to be murdered: if the suitors kill me, keep the gifts yourself — better a friend enjoy them than those men. The heir has learned to hold even treasure lightly, and the grim proviso (“but if I plant death and doom for them...”) no longer sounds like bravado. ↩
11. Penelope at the pillar of the hall, “spinning fine threads of yarn,” while the men eat: the poem’s emblem of her — present, apart, working wool. The image will hold until the bow takes its place. ↩
12. “The bed that has become a bed of groaning for me, forever stained with my tears” — Penelope’s own account of the marriage bed matches her son’s spider-web image (16.35) from the other side: he imagined it empty; she reports it occupied nightly by grief. ↩
13. Telemachus’ report is truthful and strategically cropped: Pylos, Sparta, Helen, Menelaus’ words — and not one syllable of the ambush, of Theoclymenus’ omen, or of anything since. He has adopted his father’s information discipline whole: the truth, less everything operational. ↩
14. The deer-in-lion’s-lair simile arrives on schedule (= 4.335–340 verbatim, with the whole Menelaus speech 124–141 = 4.333–

350): the suitors as fawns bedded in the lion's lair, doomed the moment the owner returns. Spoken in Sparta as consolation, it is relayed here — in the lion's own hall, while the lion himself is still making his way up from the farm — as prophecy at one remove. Lines 142–146 likewise repeat the Proteus report (= 4.556–560, the Calypso block). ↩

15. Theoclymenus swears the strongest guest-oath in the poem — Zeus, the table of guest-right, the hearth of Odysseus — and delivers his second true prophecy: Odysseus is already in the country, “sitting still, or moving,” planting evil. It is exact to the hour. Penelope answers with the fixed courtesy formula (163–165 = 15.536–538), warm and disbelieving: the truth has been told to her outright, under oath, and it cannot land — the poem's tragedy of information in one exchange. ↩
16. Lines 163–165 repeat 15.536–538 word for word — Telemachus' reply to the seer's first prophecy, now his mother's reply to the second. Mother and son answer the same true prophecy with the same blessing-formula; neither can afford belief. ↩
17. Lines 167–169 repeat 4.625–627 exactly: the suitors at their discus and javelins “insolent as ever, where they always played.” In Book 4 the games filled the gap after the ambush plot was hatched; here they fill the hour before the ambushers' target walks in — the idle men's idleness, formulaic because it never changes. ↩
18. Eumaeus on Telemachus: “him I respect and fear: he might scold me... a master's reproofs are hard to bear.” A window on the slave's world even at its kindest — affection and fear are not

alternatives but one braided feeling; the “gentle” master is still the man whose word is weather. ↩

19. “I know. I understand. You order a man who is thinking it too” — Eumaeus’ own compressed formula (16.136), now handed back to him by the disguised Odysseus, and again at 281. Master and slave have begun to speak each other’s sentences; the poem lets the borrowed phrase measure their growing likeness. ↩
20. The costume is completed with props: pouch, holes, twisted cord, and a stick from Eumaeus’ hand. The line’s quiet irony is regal — this is a σκῆπτρον, the same word as the staff of kings and speakers in assembly. Odysseus enters his kingdom carrying the scepter Eumaeus gave him. ↩
21. The fountain of Ithacus, Neritus, and Polyctor — civic archaeology: the town’s founders named as builders of its waterworks, with the poplar grove and the nymphs’ altar “where all wayfarers made their offerings.” The poem builds a real, loved, ordinary place — then stages the book’s ugliest encounter beside it. ↩
22. Melanthius son of Dolius: Eumaeus’ structural opposite — where the swineherd feeds strangers and prays for the master’s return, the goatherd drives the best goats to the suitors’ table, kicks beggars, and wishes the heir dead. His sister Melanthe will be his mirror among the women (18.321ff). The disloyal family is met on the road exactly where the loyal one lives in a hut. ↩
23. “The god is bringing like and like together” — the proverb (ὡς τὸν ὁμοῖον ἄγει θεὸς ὡς τὸν ὁμοῖον) delivered as a sneer: trash

leads trash. Its truth runs the other way — the two men he mocks are indeed alike: the two most loyal hearts on the island, one of them its king. ↩

24. “Licker of feast-plates” (δαιτῶν ἀπολυμαντήρα) — Melanthius’ coinage; Antinous will reuse the same phrase at 377, master and lackey sharing one vocabulary of contempt. The insult catalogue (doorpost-rubbing, scrap-whining, whey-drinking) is the poem’s richest specimen of low-life abuse — aimed, unknowingly, up. ↩
25. Melanthius’ threat is a prophecy in the poem’s ironic mode: “many the footstools flying round his head” — and at 462 Antinous throws exactly that. The goatherd knows his masters’ manners perfectly; what he cannot know is that every footstool is being counted. ↩
26. The deliberation formula — kill him with the stick, or dash his head on the ground — then “he mastered himself, and held it in”: the same inner motion as 20.10–21 (the heart growling at the maids). Odysseus’ revenge discipline is built of these swallowed executions; Melanthius’ actual death (22.474–477) will be the worst in the poem, and this kick is the first installment of its price. ↩
27. Eumaeus answers the kick not with his fists but with a prayer to the nymphs of the very spring they stand beside — citing Odysseus’ old burnt offerings as credit (“if ever Odysseus burned thigh-pieces for you...”). The theology of reciprocity, invoked by a slave at a roadside altar, with its subject standing next to him pretending not to own the debt. ↩

28. Melanthius' answer escalates to open treason: he wishes Telemachus dead today — by Apollo's arrow or the suitors' hands — "as surely as for Odysseus the day of homecoming is dead." Spoken to Odysseus' face. The νόστιμον ἡμῶν formula, the poem's most sacred phrase, used as a corpse to swear by: no speech in the poem buys its speaker a worse death. ↩
29. Melanthius sits "opposite Eurymachus: for him he loved best of all" — the goatherd has a patron among the suitors, as Medon "pleased them best" among the heralds (172–173). The poem maps the collaborators precisely: every tyranny runs on such seating arrangements. ↩
30. Odysseus admires his own house aloud, room by room, wall and coping and double doors, as a stranger would — "surely this is the beautiful house of Odysseus." Twenty years, and he tours it with his voice, praising the fortifications he is about to need ("no man could storm it with contempt"). The lyre "which the gods made companion to the feast" is Phemius, singing for the occupation. ↩
31. The belly-doctrine reaches its widest claim: not just that hunger drives beggars, but that "for its sake even the well-benched ships are rigged... bearing evil to enemies" — commerce, piracy, war itself traced to the stomach. Spoken at his own gate by the man whose war took him twenty years, it is as close as the poem comes to a materialist theory of the Trojan expedition. ↩
32. Argus, "whom once he raised himself — and had no joy of him" (οὐδ' ἀπὸνῆτο): the identical verb and grief as the line of only sons — Odysseus "fathered only me... and had no joy of me"

(16.120). Dog and son take the same clause; the man left both unfinished, and the poem files both under the war's unpaid debts. ↩

33. The dung-heap before the doors, waiting until the slaves cart it out to manure “his great estate” (τέμενος μέγα): even the filth of the house is wealth in waiting. On that waiting store lies the dog — the household's loyalty, discarded onto the compost of its economy. ↩
34. The recognition no disguise can defeat: Athena remade the man's skin, hair, and eyes, and the dog needs none of them. The tear Odysseus wipes — “easily hidden from Eumaeus” — is the only tear the disguise concedes between Book 13 and the recognition scenes, and it falls for a dog. Then, in the same breath, the actor recovers: “Eumaeus — a strange thing; this dog...” The question that follows (a champion? or a table-dog kept for show?) invites praise of his own hound. ↩
35. Eumaeus' verdict on slavery, spoken over Argus: “Zeus of the wide voice takes half the worth away from a man, the day the day of slavery seizes him.” The poem's single most quoted line on the institution, delivered by a slave, about careless slave-women, in front of the enslaved dog of an absent master — and in front of the master. Its companion doctrine at 15.371–379 (what slaves miss) gives the same law from inside. ↩
36. “But Argus — the doom of black death took him / the moment he had seen Odysseus, in the twentieth year.” The first in Ithaca to know him unaided — Telemachus had to be told (16.187–189); the dog simply *knows* — and the knowing kills him: he had, it turns out, been waiting, and the waiting was his

life. The poem grants him the epic dignity of the μοῖρα-formula and the count of years — an obituary in the same units as his master's war. ↩

37. The ash-wood threshold, inside the doors, against the cypress doorpost “planed with skill and trued to the line”: the beggar's station for the rest of the poem — just inside the border of the house, admitted no further. The loving carpentry detail is the owner's eye again: this is a man who knows what a trued post costs. ↩

38. “Shame is no good companion to a man in need” — Telemachus' proverb, relayed by Eumaeus with the paraphrase “no good thing in a beggar-man” (352). The command performs charity while ordering reconnaissance: begging the round of the suitors is a muster-inspection in disguise (Athena makes it explicit at 363). ↩

39. “Though even so she had no mind to save one man of them from ruin” — Athena's test sorts the decent from the lawless with the verdict pre-sealed. The poem states the theological terms of Book 22 flatly: discrimination now, no clemency later. Whatever the audit finds, the account is already closed. ↩

40. “As if he had begged all his life” — the highest compliment the poem pays its actor. The verb is professional: hand out on every side, working the room right-handed, technique without a seam. The king is now performing poverty better than the poor. ↩

41. Eumaeus' sociology of invitation: the δημιοεργοί — “public workers” — seer, healer, carpenter, singer, are summoned across the wide earth; no one invites a beggar. The list is the

poem's census of valued skill (note the singer, last and most lovingly described), and its economics are exact: hospitality follows utility, except at the hearths of the good. ↩

42. "How finely you care for me, as a father for his son" — Telemachus' sarcasm has its own hidden floor: his actual father sits on the threshold listening. The speech performs the son's role brilliantly — defiant, ironic, protective of the guest — for an audience of one. ↩
43. Antinous' joke is bookkeeping: if every suitor gave the beggar a footstool (that is what he means by "as much as I will"), the house would be rid of him three months. He shows the stool to the table like a wit displaying his epigram — premeditated, displayed, and aimed at a suppliant. ↩
44. The begging speech to Antinous opens with the flattery of kings — "you have the look of a king" — and then produces, as beggar's credentials, the Egypt tale: lines 427–441 repeat 14.258–272 word for word from the Cretan story told to Eumaeus. The fiction is stable across performances (the mark of the practiced liar), but the ending is customized: instead of seven fat years in Egypt, he is handed to Dmetor of Cyprus — a new misery invented for a new audience, and a discreet compliment threaded through it: I once had a house, slaves past counting; I know what you are supposed to be. ↩
45. "To be destroyed there" — ὄφρ' ἀπολοίμην: the tale-teller assigns Zeus a purpose for his ruin with a bitter final-clause shrug. The grammar of a man for whom catastrophe has become syntax. ↩

46. “A bitter Egypt and a bitter Cyprus” — Antinous turns the beggar’s biography into a threat: I’ll show you Egypt. Cruelty by quotation — the mark of a man who was listening only for material. ↩
47. Antinous’ theory of the other suitors’ charity: “no scruple in being generous with other men’s goods.” It is true — and it is a self-indictment lifted whole: no man present has given anything of his own for three years. The one accurate moral observation Antinous ever makes, and he makes it as an excuse for giving nothing. ↩
48. “Not so much as a grain of salt” — the proverbial minimum of giving. The beggar’s retort measures Antinous exactly: looks of a king (416), wits beneath a table-scrap. Odysseus is grading his enemies aloud now. ↩
49. The footstool lands where Melanthius’ prophecy aimed it (231–232), on the right shoulder at the base of the back — and “he stood like rock, steady.” The simile is geological because the provocation is calculated: Antinous’ best throw cannot move what is coming for him. First blood of the revenge is Odysseus’ own, absorbed on the threshold of his own hall. ↩
50. “He only shook his head, silent, brooding evils deep in his heart” — and twenty-six lines later (491) his son, watching, does exactly the same in the identical line. Father and son now share a fixed verse the way they share the secret: the poem’s formula-system used as a family resemblance. ↩
51. The beggar’s curse — “if anywhere there are gods and Furies for beggars, may death’s end find Antinous before any wedding” — is the book’s live ammunition. It is answered to the letter:

Antinous dies first of all the suitors, at the feast, arrow through the throat, cup in hand (22.8–21), before any wedding. The Furies of beggars exist; one of them threw the curse. ↩

52. The anonymous suitor's warning is the poem's theology of hospitality spoken entire: gods walk the cities "in the likeness of strangers from far countries... watching over the violence of men, and the good order they keep." Every audience knows the scene it describes is the scene it is in — with the correction that the watcher is no god but the owner, which is worse. Antinous "paid no heed": the poem's damnation-formula at its driest. ↩
53. See note at 465: the son's silence in his father's exact line. What Telemachus is learning in these books is given a grammatical form — he is being conjugated into the same verse. ↩
54. Eurynome the housekeeper, first named here, praying the suitors dead by dawn: even the domestic staff now curses in daylight. Penelope calls her "nurse" and out-curses her — Antinous is "like black doom itself" — while retelling the footstool-throw she never saw, detail-perfect down to "the base of the right shoulder": the house's grapevine runs fast, and the queen is on it. ↩
55. "Like black doom itself" (μελαίνῃ κηρὶ ἔοικε): Penelope's image for Antinous is the poem's death-word κήρ. She means he resembles death in his malice; the poem means he resembles his own imminent fate. Even her curses are proleptic. ↩
56. The singer-simile, from the poem's most honest man: the beggar's lying tales hold a listener "as a man gazes at a singer... and they ache to hear him on and on." Alcinous made the same

comparison to the same storyteller (11.363–369). The poem twice certifies its hero as its own equal — the fiction-maker praised in the poet’s own coin, here by a man who does not know the tales were false. ↩

57. Eumaeus relays the Thesprotian rumor — Odysseus near, alive, rich — exactly as the beggar designed it to travel. The news now reaches Penelope twice in one afternoon (Theoclymenus’ oath, the beggar’s report at one remove), from independent sources, both true in substance. She will sit down with the source himself at nightfall. ↩

58. Telemachus’ sneeze detonates on the exact clause — “he would repay these men their violence” — and Penelope laughs: her first laugh in the poem. The sneeze-omen (an involuntary truth-mark on spoken words) is folk-divination, and she rides it instantly into a formal death-wish for every suitor. Under the grief, the queen keeps a gambler’s eye for signs; the laugh is the sound of odds shifting. ↩

59. Penelope takes up the clothing formula in her own voice — “I will dress him in a cloak and a tunic” — the same promise made by Eumaeus (14.516), Telemachus (16.79), and relayed to the beggar at 557–558. The whole loyal household now stands in a queue to dress this man; the poem lets the formula accumulate like a debt paid at last in Book 23, when Eurynome bathes him and dresses him in the house’s own cloth (23.153–155). ↩

60. “Stranger — father” (ξεῖνε πάτερ): the swineherd’s honorific for an old man, and the poem lets the address do double work — Eumaeus keeps calling Odysseus “father” without knowing it,

as Telemachus calls Eumaeus “old father” while his own father listens. ↩

61. “I know about that man well: we have taken up the same misery” (ὁμῆν ἀνεδέγγμεθ’ οἴζυν) — the disguised man’s densest truth yet: literally claiming shared suffering with himself. Every listener hears sympathy; the sentence is a confession. ↩
62. “Whose arrogance and violence reach the iron sky” = 15.329, Eumaeus’ hyperbole handed back to him by the man he warned. The borrowed line is also an argument: you yourself told me what these men are. ↩
63. Odysseus dictates the terms of the Book 19 interview: after sunset, by the fire, close — and Eumaeus, relaying the message, adds “alone.” He gives the pretext of his rags, but the stagecraft is exact — firelight, the suitors gone — and his best stagehand quietly improves the blocking. The most important conversation of the homecoming is being laid out in advance by its director; even Penelope’s own summons must run on his schedule. Her approving comment (586–589: “the stranger is no fool”) grades his caution correctly and misses whose caution it is. ↩
64. “A shy man makes a bad beggar” (κακὸς δ’ αἰδοῖος ἀλήτης) — Penelope has proverbs for beggars too; it is the exact inverse of her son’s at 347 (“shame is no good companion to a man in need”). Mother and son quote the same folk-wisdom from opposite ends; the house thinks in shared maxims, as it weeps in shared formulas. ↩

65. Penelope's verdict — “the stranger is no fool: he guesses how it might be” — rests on her own bitter superlative: no men on earth contrive reckless outrage *like these* (ὥδε). The queen has become the connoisseur of her hall's evil; the beggar's caution is, by her own measure, simply accurate. ↩
66. “So be it, old father” — Telemachus closes with the same words that opened the book (16.31's formula at 17.6 “old father”), sending Eumaeus home to the pigs he guards, with orders for the morning's beasts. The book ends as it began, in the language of the foster-bond — while the true father sits on in the hall among his enemies. ↩
67. The day ends in “dance and song” — the suitors' pleasure machine running on into the evening, unaware it has been inspected. The beggar has begged their measure man by man; Argus is dead; the footstool has been thrown and counted; and the interview by firelight is set for Book 19, once Book 18's brawling has burned through the evening. “Already the day had come on to evening”: the poem's slow clock strikes once, quietly. ↩

Odyssey — Book 18

*The fight with Irus; the warning to Amphinomus;
Penelope shines before the suitors.*

- 1 And there came a public beggar, who used to beg¹
- 2 through the town of Ithaca, notorious for his ravening belly,
- 3 eating and drinking without end; no strength was in him
- 4 and no force, but in bulk he was very big to look at.
- 5 Arnaeus was his name — his honored mother gave it him
- 6 at birth; but Irus all the young men called him,
- 7 because he would run messages whenever anyone bade him.
- 8 He came now to drive Odysseus from his own house,²
- 9 and abusing him he spoke winged words:

10 “Off the porch, old man — or be dragged off
quick by the foot.

11 Don’t you see how they’re all winking at me,
12 telling me to drag you? I am ashamed to, even
so.

13 Up, then — before our quarrel comes to fists.”

14 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus
of the many designs replied:

15 “Man possessed — I do you no harm, I say you
none;

16 I grudge no one giving to you, however much
he takes up.

17 This threshold will hold the two of us. You have
no need³

18 to grudge what is other men’s. You seem to me
a wanderer

19 just as I am — and prosperity is the gods’ to
give.

20 Only do not challenge me too far with your
fists, or you will anger me,

21 and old as I am I will spatter your chest and
lips

22 with blood. And I would have the more peace
for it

23 tomorrow: for I do not think you would come
back

24 a second time to the hall of Laertes' son
Odysseus."

25 Then Irus the vagrant answered him in anger:

26 "Listen to the glutton — how he rattles on,

27 like an old woman at her oven! I'll plan him a
nasty turn:4

28 hit him with both hands and knock every
tooth

29 from his jaws to the ground, like a crop-raiding
sow's.

30 Belt up now, so all these men may know us

31 as we fight. But how would you fight a younger
man?"

32 So, before the high doors, on the polished

33 threshold, the two of them bristled at each
other with whole hearts.

34 And the sacred strength of Antinous took note
of them,5

35 and breaking into easy laughter he called to
the suitors:

36 “Friends — nothing like this has ever
happened yet:

37 what sport the god has brought into this
house!

38 The stranger and Irus are wrangling with each
other

39 to fight it out with fists. Quick — let us match
them!”

40 So he spoke; and they all sprang up laughing

41 and crowded round the ill-dressed beggars.

42 And Antinous spoke among them, Eupeithes’
son:

43 “Hear me, lordly suitors, while I say a word.

44 There are goats’ paunches lying at the fire,
which we set by⁶

45 for supper, filled with fat and blood.

46 Whichever of the two wins and proves the
better man,

47 let him stand up and take his pick of them;

48 and ever after he shall feast with us, and no

other

49 beggar will we let inside to beg among us.”

50 So spoke Antinous, and his word pleased them
well.

51 Then Odysseus of the many designs, with craft
in mind, spoke among them:

52 “Friends, there is no way an old man can fight

53 a younger one — a man worn down by misery.
But the belly,

54 that worker of evil, eggs me on, to go down
under his blows.

55 Come then, all of you swear me a strong oath:7

56 that no one, doing Irus a favor, will strike me

57 a foul blow with a heavy hand, and force me
under for him.”

58 So he spoke; and they all swore the oath as he
demanded.

59 And when they had sworn and sealed the oath
entire,

60 the sacred strength of Telemachus spoke
among them:

61 “Stranger — if your heart and your proud spirit

move you

62 to beat this man off, fear none of the other

63 Achaeans: whoever strikes you will have more
than one to fight.

64 Your host is myself; and the kings second it,

65 Antinous and Eurymachus, sound-thinking
men both.”⁸

66 So he spoke, and they all approved. And
Odysseus

67 girded his rags about his loins, and bared his
thighs —

68 beautiful, massive — and his broad shoulders
came to light,

69 his chest, his heavy arms. And Athena

70 came close and filled out the limbs of the
shepherd of the people.⁹

71 And the suitors, every one, were amazed
beyond all measure,

72 and a man would say, with a glance at his
neighbor:

73 “Irus un-Irused soon — a self-invited
beating!”¹⁰

74 Look what a thigh the old man shows from
under those rags.”

75 So they spoke; and Irus’ heart was stirred — for
the worse.

76 Even so the serving-men girded him and led
him out

77 by force, in terror, the flesh trembling on his
limbs.

78 And Antinous rebuked him, and spoke a word,
and named him:

79 “Better you were not alive, you ox of a
braggart, nor ever born,

80 if you shiver and fear so terribly before this
man —

81 an old man, worn out with the misery that has
found him.

82 But I will tell you this, and it will be
accomplished:

83 if this man beats you and proves the better
man,

84 I will throw you in a black ship and send you to
the mainland,

85 to King Echetus, the maimer of all mankind,**11**

86 who will slice away your nose and ears with
the pitiless bronze

87 and tear off your parts and give them raw to
the dogs to share.”

88 So he spoke; and a still greater trembling
seized Irus’ limbs.

89 But they led him into the middle; and both
men put up their hands.

90 Then much-enduring noble Odysseus
debated**12**

91 whether to hit him so the life would leave him
where he fell,

92 or to hit him gently and just stretch him on
the ground.

93 And as he weighed it, this seemed to him the
better way:

94 to strike gently, so the Achaeans would not
take note of him.

95 Then both put up their guard; Irus drove at the
right shoulder,

96 but he struck the neck under the ear, and

crushed the bones

97 inward: at once the red blood came up in his
mouth,

98 and he went down bleating in the dust, teeth
clenched together,**13**

99 heels drumming the ground. And the lordly
suitors

100 threw up their hands and died laughing. Then
Odysseus**14**

101 took him by the foot and dragged him out
through the porch

102 to the courtyard and the colonnade gates; and
there he propped him

103 against the courtyard fence, sitting up, and
pushed his stick into his hand,

104 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to
him:

105 “Sit there now, and keep off the pigs and
dogs,**15**

106 and stop lording it over strangers and
beggars,

107 wretch that you are, or a worse evil yet may

find you.”

108 He spoke, and slung about his shoulders his
beggar’s pouch,

109 full of holes, hanging by a twisted cord,

110 and went back to the threshold and sat down.

And they went inside

111 laughing sweetly, and saluted him with words:

112 “May Zeus give you, stranger, and the other
deathless gods,16

113 whatever you most desire, whatever is dear to
your heart —

114 you who stopped that insatiable one from
begging

115 through the land! For soon we will haul him to
the mainland,

116 to King Echetus, the maimer of all mankind.”

117 So they spoke; and noble Odysseus rejoiced at
the omen of the words.

118 And Antinous set beside him the great
paunch,

119 filled with fat and blood; and Amphinomus

120 took up two loaves from the basket and set

them by him,

121 and pledged him with a golden cup, and said:

122 “Your health, father stranger! May happiness
be yours

123 in time to come — though now you are held
fast in many evils.”

124 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

125 “Amphinomus — you seem to me a man of
good sense,

126 and such was the father you come from: I have
heard his good name —

127 Nisus of Dulichium, a brave man and a rich
one.

128 They say you are his son; and you seem a civil
man.17

129 So I will tell you something. Mark it; hear me
out.

130 The earth breeds nothing feebler than a man
—18

131 of all things that breathe and move on the face
of it.

132 He tells himself he will never suffer evil in
time to come,
133 as long as the gods lend him prowess and his
knees are quick;
134 but when the blessed gods bring hard days too
to pass,
135 these too he bears — unwilling, on an
enduring heart.
136 For such is the mind of men who live on earth:
137 it is weather — whatever day the father of
gods and men brings on.19
138 I too was once set fair to be fortunate among
men,
139 and I did many reckless things, giving way to
my force and power,
140 trusting in my father and my brothers.
141 So let no man ever be lawless in anything,
142 but keep in silence whatever gifts the gods
may give.
143 Such recklessness I see the suitors devising
here —
144 shearing away the goods, dishonoring the

wife

145 of a man who, I tell you, will not long be far
146 from his friends and his fathers' land. He is
very close. But you —20

147 may your own fate steal you home instead;
may you not meet him

148 the day he comes back to his own dear
country.

149 For not without blood, I think, will they be
parted,

150 the suitors and that man, once he comes in
under his roof."

151 So he spoke, and poured, and drank the
honey-sweet wine,

152 then gave the cup back into the hands of the
marshal of the people.

153 And that man went off down the hall with an
aching heart,

154 head sinking down: for his spirit foresaw the
evil.

155 But even so he did not escape his fate: Athena
bound him too,21

156 to be broken under the hands and spear of
Telemachus.

157 Back he went, and sat down on the chair from
which he had risen.

158 And now the goddess, gray-eyed Athena, put
it in the mind22

159 of Icarius' daughter, watchful-minded
Penelope,

160 to show herself to the suitors: so she might
open

161 their hearts wide as sails, and come to stand
more precious

162 in her husband's eyes, and her son's, than she
had been before.

163 She laughed — an empty laugh — and spoke a
word, and named her:23

164 "Eurynome, my heart longs — as it never has
before —

165 to show myself to the suitors, hateful as they
are.

166 And I would say a word to my son — the
better for him:

167 not to keep such company with the
overweening suitors,

168 who speak him fair and mean him evil
behind.”

169 And Eurynome the housekeeper answered
her:

170 “Yes, child — all this you have said as it should
be.

171 Go then, and speak your word to your son;
hide nothing.

172 But first wash your skin, and put a shine on
your cheeks:

173 do not go with your face all stained like this

174 with tears. Grief without respite makes
everything worse.

175 And your son is now the age you prayed the
deathless ones²⁴

176 so long to let you see: a bearded man.”

177 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
her:

178 “Eurynome, do not coax me so — out of love, I
know —

179 to wash my skin and put a gloss upon it.
180 Whatever bloom I had, the gods who hold
Olympus²⁵
181 destroyed it the day that man went off in the
hollow ships.
182 But tell Autonoe and Hippodamia to come
183 and stand beside me in the hall:
184 alone I will not go among men. I would be
ashamed.”
185 So she spoke; and the old woman went off
through the hall
186 to carry word to the women and hurry them
along.
187 Then the goddess, gray-eyed Athena, thought
of one thing more:
188 over Icarius’ daughter she poured sweet sleep,
189 and she slept, leaning back, and all her joints
went loose
190 right there on the couch. And meanwhile the
shining goddess
191 was giving her immortal gifts, to make the
Achaean stare.²⁶

192 First, for her beauty, she cleansed her lovely
face
193 with the ambrosial balm that crowned
Cytherea
194 anoints herself with, when she goes to the
Graces' lovely dance;
195 and she made her taller and fuller to the eye,
196 and made her whiter than sawn ivory.²⁷
197 That done, the shining goddess went away,
198 and the white-armed handmaids came in
from the hall,
199 talking as they came; and the sweet sleep let
her go.
200 She rubbed her cheeks with her hands and
said:
201 "Soft — the softest of trances wrapped me
round, for all my anguish.
202 If only pure Artemis would give me a death as
soft,²⁸
203 this very instant — so that I need no longer
mourn at heart,
204 wasting my life away, longing for my dear

husband

205 and his every excellence: for he stood out
among the Achaeans.”

206 So speaking she came down from her shining
upper room —

207 not alone: two handmaids followed with her.

208 And when she reached the suitors, shining
among women,

209 she stood beside the pillar of the close-built
roof,

210 holding her glistening veil before her cheeks,

211 a trusted handmaid standing on either side.29

212 And their knees went slack on the spot, their
hearts spellbound with desire,30

213 and every man prayed to lie in bed beside her.

214 But she spoke to Telemachus, her dear son:

215 “Telemachus, your mind is no longer steady,
nor your thought.

216 While you were still a boy, you turned
shrewder plans than this;

217 but now that you are grown, come to the
measure of manhood,31

218 so that a stranger, looking at your height and
beauty,
219 would say you must be some rich man's son —
220 your mind and thought are no longer as they
should be.
221 What a thing has been done here in the halls:
222 you let the stranger be manhandled so!
223 What now — if a stranger, sitting in our
house,
224 should come to harm from such ugly hauling-
about?
225 On you the shame and the disgrace would fall,
among all men.”
226 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:
227 “Mother mine, I cannot resent your anger at
this.
228 But I do take note in my heart, I do know each
thing,
229 the good and the worse alike. Before, I was
still a child.
230 Yet I cannot manage to think out everything
wisely:

231 these men unhinge me — crowding me this
side and that,
232 plotting their mischief; and I have no helpers.
233 Still, the bout of the stranger and Irus did not
go
234 as the suitors intended: the stranger was the
stronger.
235 If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo! —32
236 the suitors in our house would nod their
heads
237 like that, beaten and broken, some in the
courtyard,
238 some inside the house, and the limbs of each
gone slack,
239 the way that Irus over there at the courtyard
gates
240 sits lolling his head like a man dead drunk,
241 and cannot stand upright on his feet, or go
242 home, wherever home is — since his own
limbs are slack.”
243 So they spoke to one another of such things.
244 And Eurymachus addressed Penelope with

words:

245 “Daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded

Penelope,

246 if all the Achaeans through Iasian Argos could
see you,

247 more suitors yet would be feasting in your
house

248 from tomorrow morning: for you surpass all
women

249 in form and stature, and in the balanced mind
within.”

250 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

251 “Eurymachus, my excellence — my face, my
figure —33

252 the deathless ones destroyed the day the
Argives

253 boarded ship for Ilium, and my husband
Odysseus with them.

254 If he came back — if he watched over this life
of mine —

255 my fame would be greater so, and lovelier.

256 Now I only grieve: so many evils the god has
driven at me.

257 Truly, when he went, leaving his fathers' land,

258 he took me by the right hand at the wrist and
said:34

259 'Wife — I do not think the strong-greaved
Achaean

260 will all come home from Troy unharmed and
whole:

261 the Trojans too, they say, are men of war,

262 spear-throwers, drawers of the bow,

263 mounters of swift-footed horses — such as
decide

264 soonest the great strife of leveling war.

265 So I cannot know whether the god will bring
me back,

266 or I go down there in Troy. Let everything
here be your care.

267 Remember my father and my mother in these
halls

268 as now, or even more, while I am far away.

269 But when you see our son a bearded man,35

270 marry whom you will, and leave your house
behind.’

271 So he spoke it, that man. And now it is all
being accomplished:

272 the night will come when the marriage I
loathe will meet me —

273 my cursed self, whose happiness Zeus has
torn away.

274 But this bitter shame comes over my heart
and spirit:

275 this is not what suitors’ custom used to be.**36**

276 Men who would woo a good woman, a rich
man’s

277 daughter, and contend with one another for
her —

278 they drive up cattle of their own, and fat
sheep,

279 a feast for the bride’s people, and they give
her shining gifts.

280 They do not devour another man’s living,
scot-free.”

281 So she spoke; and much-enduring noble

Odysseus was glad³⁷

²⁸² that she drew gifts out of them, charming
their hearts

²⁸³ with honeyed words, while her mind was bent
on other things.

²⁸⁴ Then Antinous answered her, Eupheithes' son:

²⁸⁵ "Daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded
Penelope,

²⁸⁶ the gifts — whatever any Achaeon wishes to
bring here,

²⁸⁷ accept them: it is not good manners to refuse
a gift.

²⁸⁸ But we are not going to our lands, nor
anywhere else,

²⁸⁹ until you marry whichever of the Achaeans is
best."

²⁹⁰ So spoke Antinous, and his word pleased
them well,

²⁹¹ and each man sent a herald off to bring his
gifts.

²⁹² For Antinous he brought a great embroidered
robe,³⁸

293 beautiful, and in it were brooches, twelve in
all,
294 of gold, fitted with well-bent clasps.
295 For Eurymachus one brought a necklace,
richly worked
296 in gold, strung with pieces of amber, bright as
the sun.
297 For Eurydamas two henchmen brought a pair
of earrings,
298 triple-dropped like mulberries; and much
grace glinted from them.
299 And out of the house of lord Peisander,
Polyctor's son,
300 a henchman brought a neck-band, a jewel of
great beauty.
301 And so one Achaean after another brought his
lovely gift.
302 Then she went up to her upper room, shining
among women,
303 and her handmaids carried the beautiful gifts
beside her.
304 But the men turned to the dance and to lovely

song

305 and took their pleasure there, and waited for
evening to come.

306 And as they took their pleasure, the black
evening came upon them.

307 At once they set up three braziers in the halls
308 to give them light, and heaped dry kindling
round —

309 long-seasoned, bone-dry, new-split with the
bronze —

310 and mixed in pine-brands. And turn by turn
the slave-women

311 of enduring-hearted Odysseus kept the flame
alive. And to them

312 he himself spoke, Zeus-born Odysseus of the
many designs:

313 “Slave-women of Odysseus, of your master so
long gone:

314 go through to the rooms where the honored
queen is;

315 turn the spindle at her side, and cheer her
heart,

316 sitting there in her chamber, or card the wool
with your hands.

317 I will keep up the light for all these men
myself.39

318 Even if they choose to wait for fair-throned
Dawn,

319 they will not outlast me. I am a very patient
man.”40

320 So he spoke; and they burst out laughing,
glancing at one another.

321 And fair-cheeked Melantho jeered at him
shamefully —41

322 Dolius fathered her, but Penelope brought her
up

323 and cherished her like her own child, and
gave her toys to her heart’s desire;

324 yet even so no grief for Penelope touched her
mind,

325 but she slept with Eurymachus, and loved
him.

326 She now jeered at Odysseus with words of
abuse:

327 “You sorry stranger — you must be some kind
of half-wit:

328 you will not go and sleep at the smithy’s
house,42

329 or some public shed — no, you stand here
running your mouth,

330 bold as brass among all these men, and your
heart feels

331 no fear. Either the wine has hold of your wits,
or your mind

332 is always of this sort — that is why you babble
so idly.

333 Or are you giddy because you beat that
vagrant Irus?

334 Watch out that no better man than Irus
stands up soon,

335 who will box both sides of your skull with his
heavy hands

336 and send you out of the house all fouled with
blood.”

337 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus
of the many designs replied:

338 “One word to Telemachus, you bitch, and I go
straight to him now,43

339 for what you are saying — and he will cut you
limb from limb on the spot.”

340 So speaking, he set the women scattering in
terror:

341 off they went through the house, and the
knees of every one

342 went slack with fear; they thought he spoke
the truth.

343 But he took his stand by the burning braziers,
tending

344 the light, and watched them all; and other
things his heart

345 was pondering deep within — things not
destined to fall short.44

346 And Athena would not let the lordly suitors

347 hold back from heart-stinging outrage — so
that pain might sink45

348 still deeper into Laertes’ son Odysseus.

349 So Eurymachus, Polybus’ son, began to speak
among them,

350 baiting Odysseus; and he raised a laugh
among his companions:

351 “Hear me, you suitors of the far-famed queen,
352 while I say what the heart in my breast
commands.

353 Not without god’s guidance has this man
come to Odysseus’ house —

354 at any rate the blaze of the torches seems to
me to come

355 straight off his head: for there is not one hair
on it, not a wisp.”**46**

356 He spoke, and turned to Odysseus, sacker of
cities:

357 “Stranger — would you take a hire, if I took
you on,

358 out at the end of my lands — your pay will not
fail you —

359 picking stones for walls and planting tall
trees?

360 There I would furnish you bread the year
round,

361 and put clothes on your body, and give you

sandals for your feet.

362 But no: you have learned bad ways, and you
will not⁴⁷

363 set yourself to work; you would rather cringe
through the town

364 begging, to feed that bottomless belly of
yours.”

365 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

366 “Eurymachus — if only the two of us could
have a match at work,⁴⁸

367 in the spring season, when the days grow
long:

368 at mowing — I with a well-curved scythe in
hand,

369 and you with one like it — a trial of work,

370 fasting right up to dark, and the grass still
standing thick.

371 Or oxen to drive — the very best oxen,

372 tawny and big, both of them fat with grass,

373 matched in age and pull, their strength no
trifle,

374 and a four-acre field, the soil giving under the
plow:

375 then you would see whether I could cut a
furrow straight and long.

376 Or if the son of Cronos stirred up war — from
anywhere —

377 this very day, and I had a shield and two
spears

378 and a helmet all of bronze, fitted to my
temples:

379 then you would see me mixed into the front
fighters,

380 and you would not talk and talk, jeering at
this belly of mine.

381 But no — you are full of insolence, and your
mind is hard,

382 and no doubt you fancy yourself a big man
and a mighty,

383 because you keep company with few — and
none of them good.49

384 But if Odysseus came — if he reached his own
country —

385 those doors, wide as they are, would all at
once

386 be too narrow for you, flying through the
porch for the street.”50

387 So he spoke; and Eurymachus grew the
angrier at heart,

388 and glaring from under his brows he spoke
winged words:

389 “Wretch — I will finish you off for good, for
the way you talk,

390 bold as brass among all these men, and your
heart feels51

391 no fear. Either the wine has hold of your wits,
or your mind

392 is always of this sort — that is why you babble
so idly.

393 Or are you giddy because you beat that
vagrant Irus?”

394 With that he seized a footstool. But Odysseus

395 sank down at the knees of Amphinomus of
Dulichium,

396 in fear of Eurymachus; and the stool struck

the cupbearer⁵²

³⁹⁷ on the right hand: his wine-jug rang on the floor where it fell,

³⁹⁸ and the man groaned and went over backward in the dust.

³⁹⁹ And the suitors raised a din through the shadowy halls,

⁴⁰⁰ and a man would say, with a glance at his neighbor:

⁴⁰¹ “If only the stranger had died on his wanderings somewhere else

⁴⁰² before he ever came! He would not have brought all this uproar.

⁴⁰³ Now here we are brawling over beggars; there will be no joy

⁴⁰⁴ even in the good feast, now the worse is winning out.”⁵³

⁴⁰⁵ And the sacred strength of Telemachus spoke among them:

⁴⁰⁶ “You are possessed — you have gone mad. You can no longer hide

⁴⁰⁷ what you have eaten and drunk. Some god is

goads you on.⁵⁴

⁴⁰⁸ No — you have feasted well: now go home and lie down,

⁴⁰⁹ whenever the spirit moves you. Not that I am driving anyone out.”

⁴¹⁰ So he spoke; and they all bit their lips and stared

⁴¹¹ in wonder at Telemachus, that he spoke so boldly.

⁴¹² Then Amphinomus rose and spoke among them —

⁴¹³ the shining son of Nisus, of the lord Aretias’ line:

⁴¹⁴ “Friends — no man should take offense at a just word spoken,

⁴¹⁵ and answer it with wrangling and hard speech.

⁴¹⁶ Do not knock the stranger about, nor any other

⁴¹⁷ of the slaves in the house of godlike Odysseus.

⁴¹⁸ Come — let the cupbearer pour first-drops in the cups,

419 so we can make libation and go home to bed;
420 and the stranger — let us leave him in the
halls of Odysseus
421 for Telemachus to see to: it is his dear house
the man has come to.”55
422 So he spoke, and the word he spoke pleased
all of them.
423 And the hero Mousieus mixed the bowl for
them,
424 the herald from Dulichium, Amphinomus’
henchman;
425 he served it round to all in turn; and they
poured
426 to the blessed gods, and drank the honey-
sweet wine.
427 And when they had poured, and drunk as
much as their hearts would have,
428 they went their ways to bed, each man to his
own house.56

Notes

NOTES

1. Irus, the poem's only other beggar with a name — two names: Arnaeus from his mother, "Irus" from the young men, a mock-masculine of Iris because he ran their messages. A "public beggar" (πανδήμιος) with a recognized beat, big, soft, and hungry: everything Odysseus is pretending to be, embodied by a man who is nothing else. The book opens the poem's cruelest mirror: the true king disguised as a beggar must fight the true beggar for the throne of the threshold. ↩
2. "To drive Odysseus from his own house" — the line's whole irony in five words. Every party to the fight mistakes the property claim: Irus defends a doorway he thinks is his territory, in a house belonging to the man he is evicting. ↩
3. "This threshold will hold the two of us" — the real beggar's ethic, offered by the false beggar: room for both, no grudging what belongs to others, fortune is the gods' to deal. Odysseus opens with solidarity and a warning; Irus, sponsored by the suitors' winks, refuses the offer. The poor man siding with the rich against the poorer is the book's first study in corruption. ↩
4. "Like an old woman at her oven" (γρηῖ καμνοῖ ἴσος) — a glimpse of working-class invective older than the epic: the crone who talks while she tends the kiln-fire. Irus' threats are all borrowed teeth — the sow image, the tooth-scattering — from a man whose flesh will shortly be "trembling on his limbs." ↩
5. "The sacred strength of Antinous" — the honorific periphrasis elsewhere reserved for King Alcinous (and for Telemachus at 60, where it belongs) here gilds the ringleader as he organizes

a beggar-fight for after-dinner sport. The formula is a rented crown: on Antinous it reads as the poem's straight-faced sarcasm. ↩

6. The prize: blood-and-fat sausages off the fire, plus a standing dinner invitation and a beggars' monopoly. Antinous invents the pauper's Olympics complete with purse and title — organized generosity, suitor-style: a cruelty with catering. ↩
7. Odysseus makes the whole company swear not to interfere — invoking oath-procedure, the suitors' own institutions, before throwing a single punch. They swear "as he demanded": the mob that respects no law of guest or god is punctilious about sporting rules. He is learning exactly how far their formality goes. ↩
8. Telemachus as guarantor, "and the kings second it, Antinous and Eurymachus, sound-thinking men both" (πεπνυμένω — his own epithet, handed to the two worst men present). The son has learned his father's art of the straight-faced compliment. ↩
9. The unveiling: thighs "beautiful, massive," broad shoulders, heavy arms, with Athena inflating the limbs for effect. The rags gape and the body of the sacker of cities shows through — the disguise's first deliberate crack, and the suitors stare straight at the evidence and see only a well-built old tramp. ↩
10. "Irus un-Irused" (Ἴρος Ἰῖρος) — the suitors' own pun: the messenger-beggar about to be stripped of the name, "a self-invited beating" (ἐπίσπαστον κακόν). The poem lets the mockers be witty; their laughter is the same instrument that will register as ash in Book 20. ↩

11. Echetus “the maimer of all mankind” — the bogeyman-king of the mainland, with his catalogue of mutilations (nose, ears, and worse to the dogs). Whether folk-monster or remembered tyrant, he is the suitors’ favorite threat (again at 116, and at 21.308): their imagination of justice is torture outsourced to a foreign specialist. ↩
12. The deliberation formula, applied to a punch: kill him outright, or tap him? He chooses the “gentle” blow so the Achaeans “would not take note of him” — operational security measured in foot-pounds. Even so the gentle version crushes the neck-bones under the ear: the poem lets us feel the coiled violence being throttled down, and what “gentle” means from this man. ↩
13. Irus goes down “bleating” (μακών) — the animal-verb; his heels drum the ground like a slaughtered beast’s. The sausage-prize and the sacrificial imagery close the circle: the suitors staged a beast-fight and got one victim ready for the altar. ↩
14. “Threw up their hands and died laughing” (γέλῳ ἔκθανον) — the poem’s grimmest idiom, chosen for men who are, on the schedule now running, going to do exactly that. Their laughter is proleptic; Book 20.345ff will literalize it into hysteria. ↩
15. Odysseus props the beaten man against the fence sitting up, folds the stick into his hand, and appoints him scarecrow: “keep off the pigs and dogs, and stop lording it over strangers and beggars.” Rough justice with a coronation parody in it — the stick a scepter, the fence a throne, the kingdom pigs. The true owner distributes offices in his own courtyard, and no one notices. ↩

16. The suitors' blessing — “may Zeus give you whatever you most desire, whatever is dear to your heart” — is the poem's textbook kledon: a chance utterance carrying more truth than the speaker knows. What he most desires is their deaths, and “noble Odysseus rejoiced at the omen of the words”: they have just prayed for their own funeral, formally, in his hearing. ↩
17. “You seem a civil man” — ἐπιτήης, the rare word of praise Athena herself gave Odysseus at 13.332. Amphinomus earns the poem's most personal warning because he shows the poem's most personal virtue. ↩
18. The speech to Amphinomus is the poem's deepest meditation, and its most famous: “The earth breeds nothing feebler than a man.” Not weaker in body — feebler in foresight: he cannot believe in future evil while his knees are quick. The lines are the beggar's credentials cashed as wisdom — only a man who has been both fortunate and ruined can testify to the whole arc. ↩
19. “It is weather — whatever day the father of gods and men brings on”: the mind of man is the day (ἐπ' ἡμαρ) Zeus sends. Identity as weather, selfhood as the day's light — the most quoted two lines of the Odyssey outside the proem, and they are spoken by a king in rags to the one decent man among his enemies, as a reason to go home. ↩
20. “He is very close” (μάλα δὲ σχεδόν) — the warning strips itself almost naked: the wronged man “will not long be far from his friends and his fathers' land.” Then the plea: may a god steal you home first; there will be blood. Odysseus offers

Amphinomus the exit Athena will lock (155–156). No one else among the suitors is offered anything. ↩

21. “But even so he did not escape his fate: Athena bound him too.” The poem’s hardest theological sentence: the man is warned, believes the warning (“his spirit foresaw the evil”), walks away heartsick — and the goddess pins him to his chair. Divine justice here is not persuasion but a net; Amphinomus’ half-goodness earns him only the full foreknowledge of his death at Telemachus’ spear (22.89ff). The poem does not explain; it reports. ↩

22. Athena’s stated triple purpose: open the suitors’ hearts like sails, and raise Penelope’s worth in the eyes of her husband and her son. The goddess choreographs an apparition with three audiences — and the queen experiences the impulse as inexplicable (“as it never has before,” 164). The scene runs on two wills, one of them unaware. ↩

23. “She laughed — an empty laugh” (ἄχρεϊον δ’ ἐγέλασσεν) — the most argued adverb in the poem. Pointless, forced, nervous — a laugh with no object, at her own inexplicable urge. Her second laugh in two books (17.542 rode an omen; this one rides an impulse from a goddess she cannot see). Between the two laughs the poem sketches a woman whose gaiety has lost its uses and flickers on anyway. ↩

24. Eurynome says it plainly: your son is bearded now — the very condition Odysseus set (269–270). The household knows the clock has struck; and when Penelope recites the terms below (257–270), the man who set them will be standing in the hall in

rags, hearing his own clause come due — and rejoicing (281–283). ↩

25. “The gods destroyed my bloom the day that man went off” — she says it to Eurynome here and repeats it to Eurymachus at 251–253: her beauty left with the fleet, twenty years ago, as far as she is concerned. The goddess’s cosmetics (187–196) are applied to a woman who has formally resigned from beauty; the gap between her self-account and her effect (212–213) is the scene’s engine. ↩
26. The makeover happens while she sleeps: Athena pours sleep on her, and while she lies unknowing applies the “immortal gifts” — the balm of Cytherea, height, fullness, ivory skin. Penelope is beautified the way Odysseus was (6.229ff, 23.156ff), but unconscious, and wakes wishing for death by Artemis’ soft arrow (202–205). She is the only recipient of a divine glow-up in the poem who was not asked and did not want it. ↩
27. “Whiter than sawn ivory” — *πριστοῦ ἐλέφαντος*: the simile is a craftsman’s, from the workshop bench (fresh-cut ivory, before handling yellows it). The poem beautifies her in materials, as it beautified Odysseus in metallurgy (gold over silver): the household arts supplying the language of divine cosmetics. ↩
28. The soft-death prayer to Artemis — the goddess’s “gentle arrows” (cf. 15.410–411 and note) as release from a life of longing. She will pray it again, expanded and more terrible, at 20.61–82. That the wish follows directly on the divine beauty treatment is the poem’s bleakest comedy: Athena giftwraps her for the suitors; she wakes and asks the other goddess for the arrow. ↩

29. The entrance repeats 1.333–335 to the letter — pillar, glistening veil, a handmaid on either side. Third strike of the fixed frame (16.415–416 lacked the handmaid line; here it is complete): the queen appears, cheeked in cloth, flanked, and each time the stakes have risen — a song stopped, a murder stopped, and now a hall of hearts to be opened like sails. ↩
30. “Their knees went slack on the spot, their hearts spellbound with desire, / and every man prayed to lie in bed beside her.” The knee-slackening formula is elsewhere what death does; the poem spends it here on desire, then re-spends it through the book — Irus’ broken limbs (238–242), the maids’ terror (341–342). Slack knees are Book 18’s connective tissue: lust, beating, fear — one physiology. ↩
31. Her rebuke measures her son against his own growth-spurt: big enough that a stranger would call him a rich man’s son, and yet he let a guest be mauled. News of the footstool has reached the upper room with its details intact (as at 17.492ff): the house’s reporting chains run true, and the queen audits xenia from behind a veil. ↩
32. “If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo!” — the wish-formula (4.341 = 17.132, Menelaus wishing Odysseus on the suitors) now in Telemachus’ mouth, wishing the suitors into Irus’ posture: heads lolling, limbs slack, “like a man dead drunk.” Menelaus wished it first; Telemachus carried it home in quotation; now he prays it in his own right — three soundings, two voices, and the poem stacks them like sworn depositions. ↩

33. Her answer to Eurymachus' gallantry is the same formula she gave Eurynome (180–181): my beauty died on departure day. Then — to the man who leads the suitors with charm — she produces the departure speech itself, quoted entire. To flirtation she answers with a marriage's founding document. ↩
34. "He took me by the right hand at the wrist" — the precise grip (ἐπὶ καρπῷ) of solemn undertaking, the gesture of weddings and pledges. Twenty years on she reproduces her husband's farewell wrist to word: his modesty about surviving ("the Trojans too, they say, are men of war" — from the man who would beat them), the household instructions, the parents, and the terrible codicil. ↩
35. "When you see our son a bearded man, marry whom you will" — the poem's time-bomb, quoted by the woman it is set to detonate under, in the hearing of the disguised man who set it. Eurynome has just confirmed the beard (176). Penelope is announcing, in open hall, that the term has run out — "the night will come when the marriage I loathe will meet me." Whether she knows the beggar is listening, or for whom the performance is meant, the poem leaves shut; what is certain is that the deadline is real and she has stopped pretending otherwise. ↩
36. Even surrendering, she invoices them: proper suitors bring cattle and sheep, feast the bride's kin, give shining gifts — "they do not devour another man's living, scot-free." The complaint is genealogy-deep (bride-price custom recited as law), and it works: gifts are sent for within twenty lines. She

converts her own capitulation announcement into a levy on the men who forced it. ↩

37. The crux of Book 18: Odysseus “was glad that she drew gifts out of them, charming their hearts with honeyed words, while her mind was bent on other things” (νόος δέ οἱ ἄλλα μενοίνα). What other things? The poem does not say — only that the husband, watching his wife work the room that is besieging her, recognizes the technique and delights in it. Whatever else the marriage is, it is two people who fleece a crowd the same way; the recognition scenes still to come are prefigured here as a recognition of *method*. ↩
38. The gift catalogue: a robe with twelve golden brooches, an amber necklace “bright as the sun,” triple-drop mulberry earrings, a neck-band of great beauty. The suitors finally pay bride-gifts — to the wife of the living king, at her rebuke, to his suppressed delight. Note the amber necklace to Eurymachus’ name: the third fatal necklace of the poem’s recent memory (Eriphyle’s at 15.247, the kidnappers’ at 15.460). ↩
39. Odysseus volunteers as lamplighter: “I will keep up the light for all these men myself.” The king takes the meanest station in his own hall — tending fire for his enemies’ pleasure — and converts it into a watchtower (“watched them all,” 344). The man who was the beacon of the house now literally holds its light. ↩
40. “I am a very patient man” — πολυτλήμων: he cites his own epic epithet (πολύτλας, “much-enduring”) as a job qualification for staying up all night. The disguise keeps doing this — telling the truth at an angle so acute it reads as banter. ↩

41. Melanthis, “fair-cheeked”: Dolius’ daughter, Melanthius’ sister — the disloyal siblings. Her biography is given in Eumaeus’ shape reversed: raised by Penelope “like her own child,” given toys “to her heart’s desire” — the same nursery intimacy Eumaeus had with Ctimaene (15.363ff) — and out of it came no grief for her mistress, only Eurymachus’ bed. The poem is explicit that kindness does not manufacture loyalty; it only reveals what receives it. ↩
42. The smithy and the public shed (λέσχη) — where the homeless actually slept warm in an Ithacan winter: the working town’s real geography of destitution, known to the slave-girl in detail. Her cruelty is informed cruelty — she knows exactly where beggars belong, having decided she will never be one. ↩
43. His reply to Melanthis is disproportionate and precise: one word to Telemachus “and he will cut you limb from limb.” The women scatter believing him. The threat is the book’s darkest foreshadowing — the twelve women die by Telemachus’ decision at 22.462ff, by hanging rather than the sword, “so they might die most pitifully.” Here already the punisher named is the son, not the father. ↩
44. The tableau: the beggar standing at the braziers, feeding light, “watching them all,” his heart pondering “things not destined to fall short” (οὐκ ἀτέλεστα — the same word as the suitors’ “work never to be finished,” 16.111, flipped: their feast has no completion; his plans have nothing else). One line of firelit surveillance carries the whole revenge in suspension. ↩
45. Athena’s goad again (as at 17.360ff but sharpened): she prevents the suitors from stopping their abuse, “so that pain might sink

still deeper” into Odysseus. The goddess is stoking her own champion — cruelty rationed to him as fuel. The economy of the revenge requires his rage topped up; his patroness sees to the supply chain. ↩

46. Eurymachus’ torch-and-bald-head joke — the firelight “comes straight off his head, for there is not one hair on it.” The wit lands on the man Athena balded by hand at 13.431. The suitors keep grading the disguise excellent without knowing there is a disguise; every joke doubles as an inspection passed. ↩

47. Lines 362–364 repeat Melanthius’ sneer at 17.226–228 nearly verbatim, person-shifted: “you have learned bad ways... to feed that bottomless belly of yours.” Master and goatherd run on the same script; the formula-system files Eurymachus and Melanthius as one voice in two stations (as it will pair him with Melantho at 390–393 — he shares insults with both disloyal siblings). ↩

48. The work-challenge: mowing “fasting right up to dark,” plowing a four-acre field behind matched oxen, or war with shield and two spears — “then you would see me.” The king’s résumé as laborer completes the servant’s résumé of 15.319–324: between them, Odysseus has now claimed competence at every station of his own household, from wine-pouring to plow to front rank. The aristocratic ideal underneath is αὐτάρκεια — the master who can out-work every man he owns. ↩

49. “You fancy yourself a big man... because you keep company with few — and none of them good”: the beggar diagnoses Eurymachus’ whole stature as a small-pond effect. It is the book’s most surgical insult, and true — the poem has shown us

no suitor who would rank anywhere among the men of Troy.



50. “Those doors, wide as they are, would be too narrow for you, flying”: the prophecy is exact. At 22.79ff Eurymachus will draw his sword, charge — and die at the tables, nowhere near the doors, which stay as wide as ever. The beggar keeps publishing the ending; the audience keeps hearing rhetoric. ↩
51. Lines 390–393 = 330–333, Melantho’s insult verbatim in Eurymachus’ mouth — “bold as brass... the wine has hold of your wits... giddy because you beat that vagrant Irus?” Mistress’s lover and slave-girl share one script for abusing beggars; the formula repetition is the poem’s evidence-tag: these two talk alike because they lie in the same bed. ↩
52. The second thrown stool of the day misses and breaks a servant: the cupbearer struck on the right hand, wine-jug clanging, the man himself groaning in the dust. The suitors’ violence, aimed at the invulnerable man, is beginning to land on bystanders — the collateral pattern of a house sliding toward the slaughter that will spare so few of its occupiers. ↩
53. “Now the worse is winning out” (τὰ χερεῖονα νικᾷ) — the anonymous suitor’s verdict on the evening comes closer to prophecy than he knows: brawling over beggars, joy gone from the feast, the worse winning. The chorus of nameless suitors keeps issuing true bulletins (as at 17.483ff) that the named ones override. ↩
54. Telemachus’ boldest speech yet: “You are possessed — you have gone mad... Some god is goading you on” — which is, at 346–348, literally the case; the boy diagnoses Athena’s hand

without knowing it. Then the perfect dismissal: eat well, go home when you like, “not that I am driving anyone out.” They bite their lips and wonder: the heir has begun speaking like the master of the house, with the reckoning barely a day away. ↩

55. Amphinomus ends the evening as he ended the murder-council (16.400ff): with the decent, small, insufficient proposal — libation, bed, leave the stranger to Telemachus. His goodness has exactly the reach of a nightcap. It is he the poem chooses to close the suitors’ last full day of life — proposing the round that Moulus the herald mixes and pours (423–425) for men Athena has already bound. ↩

56. “They went their ways to bed, each man to his own house” — the suitors still have houses, this one night more. The book that began with two beggars brawling for a doorway ends with every man sleeping behind his own door — an arrangement the poem is about to make permanent for one hundred and eight of them. ↩

Odyssey — Book 19

*The interview by the fire; the scar; the contest
announced.*

- 1 But noble Odysseus stayed behind in the hall,¹
- 2 plotting the suitors' slaughter with Athena's help.
- 3 At once he spoke winged words to Telemachus:
- 4 "Telemachus, the weapons of war must be laid away inside —
- 5 all of them; and the suitors — when they miss them and question you —
- 6 talk them around with soft words:
- 7 'I laid them out of the smoke: they no longer looked like the arms²
- 8 Odysseus left behind when he went to Troy —
- 9 they are fouled over, as far as the breath of the fire reached.
- 10 And a greater fear — this too a god has cast into my heart:

11 that in your wine you might raise a quarrel
among you
12 and wound one another, and shame the feast
13 and the wooing. For iron of itself draws a man
on.”
14 So he spoke; and Telemachus obeyed his dear
father,
15 and calling out the nurse Eurycleia he said:
16 “Nurse, come — shut the women in their
quarters for me
17 until I have stowed away in the storeroom my
father’s
18 beautiful arms, which the smoke dulls, uncared
for, all about
19 the house, since my father went away. I was
still a child then.
20 Now I want to lay them where the breath of
the fire will not reach.”
21 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered him:
22 “Yes, child — and if only you would take up the
good sense at last
23 to care for the house and guard all its

possessions!

24 But come — who then will fetch a light and
carry it for you,³

25 if the slave-women, who would have lit you,
may not come out?”

26 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:

27 “This stranger here. I will keep no man idle
who takes

28 from my grain-measure, however far he has
come.”

29 So he spoke; and for her the word stayed
wingless.

30 And she locked the doors of the well-settled
halls.

31 Then the two sprang up, Odysseus and his
shining son,

32 and carried in the helmets and the bossed
shields

33 and the sharp-pointed spears; and before them
Pallas Athena,

34 holding a golden lamp, made a light most
beautiful.⁴

35 And suddenly Telemachus said to his father:
36 “Father — here is a great wonder my eyes look
on!⁵
37 The walls of the hall — no question — and the
fine crossbeams,
38 the fir rafters, and the pillars rising high
39 shine in my eyes as if from a blazing fire.
40 Surely some god is in the house, one of those
who hold wide heaven.”
41 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:
42 “Quiet. Rein in your thought. Ask no questions.
43 This is the way of the gods who hold Olympus.
44 Go you to bed. I will remain behind here
45 to stir the slave-women a little more, and your
mother:⁶
46 in her grief she will ask me about every
particular.”
47 So he spoke; and Telemachus went out through
the hall
48 to his chamber, under the blazing torches, to
lie down

49 where he always slept when sweet sleep came
to him.

50 There he lay down now too, and waited for
shining Dawn.

51 But noble Odysseus stayed behind in the hall,
52 plotting the suitors' slaughter with Athena's
help.

53 And out of her chamber came watchful-
minded Penelope,

54 like Artemis, or golden Aphrodite.

55 They set her chair, where she always sat,
beside the fire —

56 a chair wound round with ivory and silver,
which the craftsman⁷

57 Icmalius once made, and fixed beneath it a
footrest

58 all of a piece with it, where a great fleece
would be thrown.

59 There she sat down now, watchful-minded
Penelope.

60 And the white-armed slave-women came in
from the hall

61 and cleared away the piles of bread, and the
tables,
62 and the cups from which the overbearing men
had drunk;
63 they raked the fire from the braziers to the
floor and stacked
64 fresh wood upon them, for light and for
warmth.
65 And Melantho went at Odysseus a second
time:⁸
66 “Stranger — are you going to plague us even
now, all through the night,
67 prowling around the house, spying on the
women?
68 Out the door, you wretch — and be glad of the
meal you got —
69 or you’ll go out quick enough with a torch-
brand at your back!”
70 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus
of the many designs replied:
71 “Woman possessed — why go for me with a
heart so angry?

72 Because I am dirty, because the clothes on my
body are bad,
73 because I beg through the land? Necessity is on
me:
74 that is what beggars and wandering men are
like.
75 I too once lived in a house among men,
76 a fortunate man in a wealthy one, and I often
gave to a wanderer,
77 whoever he might be and whatever need he
came in.
78 Slaves I had past counting, and everything in
plenty
79 by which men live well and get the name of
rich.
80 But Zeus the son of Cronos stripped it all —
such, no doubt, was his will.
81 So look to yourself, woman: take care you
never lose
82 all that shine of yours, that sets you off among
the slave-women —
83 in case your mistress turns on you in anger,

84 or Odysseus comes. For a portion of hope is left.

85 And even if he is dead as you think, and past returning,

86 by Apollo's grace there is his son by now,

87 such a son — Telemachus. Not one woman in these halls

88 escapes his eye at her mischief. He is past that age.”⁹

89 So he spoke; and watchful-minded Penelope heard him,

90 and rounded on the handmaid, and spoke a word, and named her:

91 “Be sure of this, bold face, dog past all shame: your grand¹⁰

92 performance is not lost on me — you will wipe it off on your own head.

93 You knew — every part of it — you heard it from my own mouth:

94 that I meant to question the stranger in my halls

95 about my husband, for whom I grieve past

telling.”

96 Then she spoke to Eurynome the housekeeper:

97 “Eurynome, bring up a bench, and a fleece on
it,

98 for the stranger to sit and speak his word and
hear me

99 out: I wish to question him through and
through.”

100 So she spoke; and the woman bustled to bring
the polished

101 bench and set it down, and threw a fleece
upon it,

102 and there much-enduring noble Odysseus sat.

103 And watchful-minded Penelope began to
speak among them:

104 “Stranger, this first will I myself ask you:

105 What man are you, and from where? Where
are your city and your parents?”¹¹

106 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

107 “Lady, no mortal man on the boundless earth

108 could find a fault in you: your fame goes up to

the wide sky —

109 like the fame of some blameless king, a god-
fearing man12

110 ruling among many people and mighty,

111 upholding straight judgments; and the black
earth bears

112 wheat and barley under him, and the trees
hang heavy with fruit,

113 the flocks throw firm young, the sea yields
fish,

114 all from his good governing; and under him
the people flourish.

115 So — question me now on any other matter,
here in your house,

116 but do not ask my race and my fathers'
country,

117 or you will fill my heart still fuller with pains

118 as I remember: I am a man of many sorrows.

And there is no need

119 to sit in a stranger's house grieving and
lamenting —

120 grief without respite makes everything worse

—
121 and one of the slave-women might take
offense — or you yourself —

122 and say I swim in tears because the wine has
weighed my wits.”

123 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

124 “Stranger, my excellence — my face, my figure
—13

125 the deathless ones destroyed the day the
Argives

126 boarded ship for Ilium, and my husband
Odysseus with them.

127 If he came back — if he watched over this life
of mine —

128 my fame would be greater so, and lovelier.

129 Now I only grieve: so many evils the god has
driven at me.

130 All the great men who hold power among the
islands —

131 Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus —

132 and those whose homes are round clear-skied

Ithaca itself:

133 they woo me against my will, and wear this
house away.

134 So I pay no mind to strangers, none to
suppliants,

135 none at all to heralds, the workers for the
people;

136 no — longing for Odysseus melts the heart in
me.

137 They press the marriage on; and I wind out
my skein of tricks.14

138 First it was the robe: a god breathed it into my
heart —

139 to set up a great loom in the halls and weave
at it,

140 fine-threaded, beyond all measure wide; and I
told them straightway:

141 ‘Young men, my suitors — since noble
Odysseus is dead,15

142 wait, though you burn for my wedding, till I
finish

143 this cloth — let my spinning not be wasted on

the wind —

144 a shroud for the hero Laertes, against the day
145 the ruinous doom of death that lays men low
will take him:

146 let no Achaean woman in the land hold it
against me

147 that a man who won so much should lie
without his winding-sheet.’

148 So I spoke, and their proud hearts were
persuaded.

149 Then every day I wove at the great loom,

150 and every night I unwove it by torchlight.

151 Three years my trick escaped them, and I kept
the Achaeans persuaded;

152 but when the fourth year came, as the seasons
rolled on,

153 the months waning away, the long tale of days
accomplished,

154 then — through my slave-women, those
careless bitches —

155 they came on me and caught me, and shouted
me down.

156 So I finished it — against my will, under force.
157 And now I can neither escape the marriage
nor find
158 any other design. My parents urge me hard16
159 to marry; and my son chafes as these men eat
his living —
160 he understands now: he is a man by now, fully
able
161 to care for a house that Zeus grants glory to.
162 But even so, tell me your stock, where you are
from:
163 you were not born of the oak in the old tales,
nor of a stone.”17
164 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:
165 “Honored wife of Laertes’ son Odysseus,
166 will you not leave off asking me my lineage?
167 Well — I will tell you. Though truly you hand
me over to sorrows
168 more than hold me now: that is the way of it,
when a man
169 has been gone from his country as long as I

have,

170 wandering through many cities of men,
suffering pains.

171 Even so, I will tell you what you ask and probe
for.

172 There is a land called Crete, out in the wine-
dark sea,18

173 beautiful and rich, ringed by the water; and in
it are people

174 past counting, and ninety cities:

175 tongue mixed with tongue — Achaeans there,

176 great-hearted native Cretans, Cydonians,

177 Dorians in their three clans, and noble
Pelasgians;

178 and among the cities is Cnossus, the great
town, where Minos

179 was king by nine-year terms, great Zeus's
intimate —19

180 the father of my father, great-hearted
Deucalion.

181 Deucalion fathered me, and lord Idomeneus;

182 but Idomeneus had gone in the beaked ships

183 to Ilium with the sons of Atreus. My famous
name is Aethon —20

184 the younger brother by birth; he was elder,
and the better man.

185 There I saw Odysseus, and gave him guest-
gifts:21

186 for the strength of the wind had brought him
down on Crete

187 as he made for Troy, driving him off course
past Malea.

188 He anchored at Amnisus, by the cave of
Eileithyia,

189 in that difficult harbor, and barely rode out
the squalls.

190 He came straight up to the town, asking for
Idomeneus:

191 his guest-friend, he said, beloved and honored.

192 But it was now the tenth dawn for Idomeneus,
or the eleventh,22

193 since he had gone with the beaked ships to
Ilium.

194 So I brought him to the house and gave him

welcome,

195 warm and openhanded — the house had
plenty in it —

196 and for the rest, for the companions who
followed with him,

197 I gathered barley-meal from the public store,
and sparkling wine,

198 and oxen for sacrifice, till their hearts were
satisfied.

199 Twelve days the noble Achaeans stayed with
me,

200 pinned there: the great North Wind held
them, and would not let them

201 stand even on shore — some hard god had
raised it.

202 On the thirteenth the wind dropped, and they
put out to sea.”

203 He made the many lies he told seem like the
truth.23

204 And as she listened her tears ran, and her
flesh melted —24

205 as snow melts away on the high crests of the

mountains,

206 snow the West Wind piled and the East Wind
thaws,

207 and as it melts the rivers run full with it:

208 so her beautiful cheeks melted with falling
tears,

209 as she wept for her own husband — sitting at
her side. And Odysseus

210 pitied his wife in his heart as she grieved,

211 but his eyes stood fixed as horn or iron,25

212 unwavering in their lids: with craft he hid his
tears.

213 And when she had taken her fill of tear-heavy
mourning,

214 she found words again, and answered him:

215 “Now, stranger, I think I shall put you to the
test:26

216 whether you truly hosted my husband there
in your halls

217 with his godlike companions, as you say.

218 Tell me what kind of clothes he wore on his
body,

219 and what kind of man he was, and the
companions who followed him.”

220 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

221 “Lady, that is hard — for one so long apart

222 to say. It is the twentieth year already

223 since he went from there and left my country
behind.

224 Even so I will tell you how my heart’s eye
pictures him.

225 Noble Odysseus wore a woolen mantle of sea-
purple,

226 a double fold; and the brooch on it was
fashioned of gold,

227 with paired sheaths for the pins; the face of it
was a marvel:

228 a hound held a dappled fawn between its
forepaws,²⁷

229 gripping it as it writhed. And everyone
wondered at them —

230 both of gold: the one gripping the fawn and
throttling it,

231 the fawn straining with its feet to escape,
even as it struggled.

232 And I noticed the tunic on his body, all a-
shimmer,

233 like the skin that slips from a dried onion:28

234 that soft it was, and bright as the sun itself.

235 Many the women, I tell you, who gazed at him
in wonder.

236 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in
your heart.

237 I do not know whether Odysseus wore these
things from home,

238 or some companion gave them to him
boarding the fast ship,

239 or perhaps some guest-friend, since to many
men Odysseus

240 was dear: few of the Achaeans were his
equals.

241 I too gave him things: a sword of bronze, a
folded mantle,

242 fine, sea-purple, and a fringed tunic,

243 and sent him off with honor on his well-

benched ship.

244 Also a herald attended him, a little older
245 than he was; and I will tell you what he looked
like too:

246 round in the shoulders, dark-skinned, curly-
headed,29

247 Eurybates his name; and Odysseus prized him
above

248 his other companions, for their minds ran
matched.

249 So he spoke; and he stirred in her still more
the longing for weeping,

250 as she recognized the tokens Odysseus
described so surely.30

251 And when she had taken her fill of tear-heavy
mourning,

252 then she found words again, and said to him:

253 "Now, stranger, pitiable as you were to me
before,

254 in my halls you shall be dear and honored.

255 It was I who gave him those clothes — I, the
very clothes you speak of —31

256 folded from the storeroom, and I pinned on
the shining brooch
257 to be his jewel. And I shall never welcome him
again
258 come home to his own dear fatherland.
259 By an evil fate Odysseus went in the hollow
ship
260 to look on Evil-Ilium, never to be named.”**32**
261 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:
262 “Honored wife of Laertes’ son Odysseus,
263 mar your lovely skin no more, and melt your
heart
264 no more away, weeping for your husband. Not
that I blame you at all:
265 any woman mourns the husband she has lost,
266 the man of her youth, whose children she
bore in love —
267 even a lesser man than Odysseus, whom they
call the equal of the gods.
268 But cease from weeping, and attend to my
word:

269 for I will speak the exact truth and hide
nothing:

270 I have already heard of Odysseus'
homecoming —33

271 near, in the rich land of the Thesprotian men,
272 alive; and he is bringing many fine treasures
home,

273 begging his way through the country. But his
trusted companions

274 he lost, and the hollow ship, on the wine-dark
sea,

275 on the way from the island of Thrinacia: for
Zeus and Helios

276 were set at odds with him — his companions
killed the Sun's cattle.34

277 They all perished in the surging sea;

278 but he rode the keel of the ship, and the wave
threw him ashore

279 on the land of the Phaeacians, whose birth is
next to the gods'.

280 They honored him from the heart like a god,

281 and gave him many things, and were

themselves ready to bring him

282 home unharmed. And Odysseus would have
been here

283 long since; but this seemed to his heart the
more profitable way:

284 to travel wide and gather wealth — for
beyond35

285 all mortal men Odysseus knows the profitable
turn:

286 no living man could rival him at that.

287 So Pheidon told me all of it, the king of the
Thesprotians;

288 and he swore an oath to me, pouring the
libation in his house,

289 that a ship was hauled down and a crew
standing ready

290 to convey him home to his own dear
fatherland.

291 But me he sent off first: for a Thesprotian ship

292 happened to be sailing for Dulichium, rich in
wheat.

293 And he showed me all the treasure Odysseus

had gathered:

294 truly it would feed a man's line to the tenth
generation,

295 such a store of the lord's goods lay there in
his halls.

296 Odysseus, he said, was gone to Dodona, to
hear

297 the will of Zeus out of the god's own high-
crowned oak:

298 how he should come home to his own dear
fatherland,

299 openly or in secret, after so long away.

300 So he is safe; so he will come — and soon now,

301 very near: not far from his friends and his
fathers' land

302 will he be for long. And still I will give you my
oath on it.

303 Now Zeus be my witness first — highest and
best of the gods —36

304 and the hearth of blameless Odysseus, to
which I have come:

305 all this shall be accomplished exactly as I say.

306 Within this very turning of the light Odysseus
will be here:

307 between this month's waning and the rising
of the next."

308 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

309 "Ah, stranger, if only that word might be
accomplished:37

310 then you would quickly know my friendship,
and gifts

311 in plenty from me — any man who met you
would call you blessed.

312 But this is how my heart forebodes it, and
how it will be:

313 Odysseus is not coming home; and you will
get no passage —

314 for there are no masters in this house

315 such as Odysseus was among men — if he ever
was —

316 to welcome honored strangers, and to send
them on.

317 But wash him, my handmaids, and lay out a

bed:38

318 bedstead and cloaks and shining blankets,
319 so he may come warm through to Dawn of the
golden throne.

320 And in the early morning bathe him and rub
him with oil,

321 so that here inside, at Telemachus' side, he
may look to his dinner,

322 seated in the hall. And the worse for any man
of them

323 who galls him — heart-destroyer: he will
accomplish nothing

324 here ever again, rage at it as he bitterly may.

325 For how will you learn of me, stranger,
whether I stand out39

326 at all among women in mind and thoughtful
counsel,

327 if all unwashed and badly dressed you sit at
meat

328 in my halls? Men are creatures of a short day.

329 The man who is hard himself, and knows hard
thoughts,

330 on him all mortals call down pains to come
331 while he lives, and when he is dead they mock
him, every one;
332 but the man who is blameless himself, and
knows blameless thoughts —
333 his fame the guests he served carry wide
334 to all mankind, and many call him noble.”
335 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:
336 “Honored wife of Laertes’ son Odysseus,
337 cloaks and shining blankets turned hateful to
me
338 the day I first put the snowy mountains of
Crete
339 behind me, going aboard the long-oared ship.
340 I will lie this night as I have lain through
sleepless nights before:
341 many the nights I have spent on some rough
bed,
342 waiting it out for shining fair-throned Dawn.
343 Nor do foot-washings bring my heart any
pleasure:

344 no woman shall touch this foot of mine⁴⁰
345 of all those who serve about your house —
346 unless there is some old woman, old and
faithful-hearted,
347 who has endured in her spirit as much as I
have endured:
348 such a one I would not grudge the touching of
my feet.”
349 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:
350 “Dear stranger — no man so discerning, of all
the guests
351 from far lands, ever came more welcome to
my house:
352 so shaped and thought-through is everything
you say.
353 I have an old woman whose breast is packed
with counsel,
354 who nursed and reared that unlucky man, my
husband —
355 took him into her arms the hour his mother
bore him:

356 she will wash your feet, feeble with age
though she is.

357 Up now, watchful-minded Eurycleia:41

358 wash him — a man the same age as your
master. And perhaps Odysseus

359 by now is like him in his feet, like him in his
hands:

360 for in misfortune mortal men age fast.”42

361 So she spoke; and the old woman hid her face
in her hands

362 and shed hot tears, and gave voice to words of
mourning:

363 “Ah me, child, and I helpless for you! Truly
Zeus43

364 hated you beyond all men — and yours was a
god-fearing heart.

365 For no mortal ever burned to Zeus who
delights in thunder

366 so many fat thigh-pieces, such choice
hecatombs,

367 as you gave him, praying you might come

368 to a sleek old age and raise your shining son.

369 And now from you alone he has cut off the
day of homecoming.

370 So too, I suppose, the women mocked him —

371 women of strangers in far lands, when he
came to some man's famous house —

372 just as these bitches here mock you, all of
them together:

373 it is to dodge their insults, their crowd of
taunts,

374 that you will not let the women wash you.

And I — not at all unwilling —

375 am ordered to it by Icarius' daughter,
watchful-minded Penelope.

376 So I will wash your feet — for Penelope's own
sake

377 and for yours as well; for the heart within me
is stirred

378 with sorrows. But come — take in the word I
say:

379 many a travel-worn stranger has come to this
house,

380 but never, I tell you, have I seen such a

likeness

381 as you have — in body, in voice, in feet — to
Odysseus.”44

382 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

383 “Old mother, so they all say who have seen
the two of us

384 with their own eyes: that we are very like
each other —

385 just as you yourself observe, and say.”45

386 So he spoke; and the old woman took the
shining basin

387 she used for washing feet, and poured in
water,

388 cold in plenty, then added hot to it. And
Odysseus

389 sat down at the hearth — and swung round
quickly toward the dark,46

390 for a fear came over his heart that as she took
hold

391 she might mark the scar, and the whole work
come open.

392 She came close and began to wash her master.
And at once she knew⁴⁷

393 the scar — the wound the boar dealt him with
its white tusk

394 when he went to Parnassus, to Autolycus and
his sons,

395 his mother's noble father, who outdid all men

396 in thievery and the oath: the god himself had
given it him —⁴⁸

397 Hermes: to him he burned welcome thigh-
pieces

398 of lambs and of kids, and the god
companioned him with a will.

399 Once Autolycus, coming to the rich land of
Ithaca,

400 found his daughter's son a baby newly born;

401 and Eurycleia laid the child on his knees⁴⁹

402 as he finished supper, and spoke a word, and
named him:

403 "Autolycus — find the name yourself, to give

404 your own child's child. He is a child of many
prayers."

405 Then Autolycus answered her and said:
406 “Son-in-law and daughter, give him the name
I say.
407 Since I have come to this place at odds with
many —**50**
408 with men and with women across the
nourishing earth —
409 let Odysseus, Man at Odds, be the name he
carries.
410 And for my part: when he is grown, and
comes to Parnassus,
411 to his mother’s great house, where my
possessions are,
412 I will give him a share and send him home
rejoicing.”
413 For those gifts Odysseus went: to receive his
shining presents.
414 And Autolycus and the sons of Autolycus
415 clasped his hands in welcome, and greeted
him with honeyed words;
416 and Amphithea, his mother’s mother, folding
Odysseus in her arms,

417 kissed his head, and both his beautiful eyes.51

418 Then Autolycus called to his glorious sons

419 to make the meal ready; and they heard his
urging:

420 at once they led in a bull of five years,

421 flayed it and dressed it, and split the whole in
pieces,

422 and jointed the meat with skill, and fixed it on
the spits,

423 and roasted it with care, and shared out all
the portions.

424 So then, the whole day long until the setting
of the sun,

425 they feasted; and no man's appetite went
short of the equal feast.

426 And when the sun went down and the dusk
came on,

427 they lay down then, and took the gift of sleep.

428 When Dawn appeared, the early-born, with
fingers of rose,

429 they went their way to the hunt — the hounds
and with them

430 the sons of Autolycus themselves; and noble
Odysseus

431 went along with them. They climbed the steep
mountain, mantled

432 in forest — Parnassus — and soon they
reached its windy folds.

433 The sun was just striking the plowlands,
rising**52**

434 out of the deep smooth stream of Ocean,

435 when the beaters came to a glen; ahead of
them

436 ran the hounds, casting for the scent, and
behind them

437 came the sons of Autolycus; and noble
Odysseus

438 moved close behind the hounds, swinging his
long-shadowed spear.

439 There, in a dense thicket, lay couched a great
boar.**53**

440 No force of wet-blowing winds could pierce
that covert,

441 no shaft of the shining sun could strike into it,

442 no rain drive through it, so dense it was,
443 and the fallen leaves lay heaped in it past
counting.
444 Around the boar came the din of feet — men's
and hounds' —
445 as they pressed in on him; and out of his lair,
head-on,
446 bristles ridged on his neck, fire standing in his
eyes,
447 he stood at bay, close in. And first of all
Odysseus
448 rushed him, the long spear high in his heavy
hand,
449 hungry to strike; but the boar was quicker —
gashed him
450 above the knee, charging in slantwise, and
ripped away
451 a long gouge of flesh with his tusk: but it did
not reach the bone.
452 And Odysseus struck home on the right
shoulder,
453 and the point of the shining spear went

through and through:

454 down in the dust he went, bleating, and the
life flew out of him.54

455 Then the dear sons of Autolycus busied
themselves with the carcass,

456 and the wound of blameless, godlike Odysseus

457 they bound with skill, and with a chanted
spell they stanchd55

458 the black blood; and quickly they came to
their father's house.

459 And Autolycus and the sons of Autolycus

460 healed him well, and gave him shining gifts,

461 and quickly sent him back rejoicing to his own
dear country,

462 to Ithaca. And his father and his honored
mother

463 rejoiced at his homecoming, and questioned
him on everything —

464 the scar, and what had happened; and he told
them all of it well:

465 how the boar's white tusk had gashed him at
the hunt

466 on his climb up Parnassus with the sons of
Autolycus.

467 That scar — as the old woman took his leg in
the flat of her hands⁵⁶

468 she knew it under her fingers. She let the foot
drop:

469 the shin fell in the basin; the bronze rang out;

470 the basin tipped over sideways, and the water
ran on the ground.

471 And joy and anguish seized her mind at once:
her eyes

472 filled up with tears; her welling voice stuck
fast.

473 She touched Odysseus on the chin, and said:

474 “You are Odysseus — dear child! And I did not
know you,⁵⁷

475 not before I had handled all of him — my
master.”

476 She spoke, and her eyes went toward
Penelope,

477 ready to tell her that her own husband was in
the house.

478 But Penelope could not meet the look or take
its meaning,

479 for Athena had turned her mind away. And
Odysseus,58

480 feeling for her throat, caught it with his right
hand,

481 and with the other pulled her closer to him,
and said:

482 “Nurse — why would you destroy me? You
yourself nursed me59

483 at this breast of yours. Now, after suffering
many pains,

484 I have come in the twentieth year to my
fathers’ land.

485 But since you have found it out, and a god has
put it in your heart,

486 be silent — let no one else in the halls learn of
it.

487 For I will say this outright, and it will be
accomplished:

488 if a god brings the haughty suitors down
beneath my hands,

489 I will not spare even you, my nurse though
you are, that day

490 I kill the other slave-women in my halls.”

491 Then watchful-minded Eurycleia answered
him:

492 “My child, what a word has slipped the fence
of your teeth!**60**

493 You know my strength — how it stands and
will not bend:

494 I will hold like solid stone, like iron.

495 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in
your heart.

496 If a god brings the haughty suitors down
beneath your hands,

497 then I will name you the women of the halls,
every one:

498 which of them dishonor you, and which are
guiltless.”

499 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

500 “Nurse, why would you name them? There is
no need.**61**

501 I will observe them well myself, and learn
each one.

502 No — keep the story silent. Leave it to the
gods.”

503 So he spoke; and the old woman went off
through the hall

504 to fetch fresh water for his feet: the first was
all spilled.

505 And when she had washed him and rubbed
him richly with oil,

506 Odysseus drew his bench again nearer the fire
507 to warm himself, and covered the scar with
his rags.⁶²

508 And watchful-minded Penelope began to
speak among them:

509 “Stranger, one small thing more I will ask you
myself —

510 for soon enough now comes the hour of sweet
rest,

511 for whomever sweet sleep will take, however
careworn.

512 But to me the god has dealt grief past

measuring:

513 by day my one delight is weeping and
lamenting,63

514 while I look to my work and the work of my
women in the house;

515 but when night comes, and rest takes all the
others,

516 I lie in my bed, and crowding round my
beating heart

517 the sharp anxieties torment me as I mourn.

518 As when the daughter of Pandareus, the pale-
green nightingale,64

519 sings beautifully at the first new standing of
spring,

520 perched in the thick leafage of the trees,

521 and pouring, turning, threads her many-noted
voice,

522 mourning her child, her beloved Itylus, whom
once with the bronze

523 she killed in her blindness of mind — the son
of lord Zethus:

524 so my heart too is torn two ways, this way and

that:65

525 do I stay by my son and keep everything
unmoved —

526 my goods, my slave-women, the great high-
roofed house —

527 respecting my husband's bed and the voice of
the people;

528 or do I follow now whichever of the Achaeans
is best

529 among my suitors in the halls, and offers
bride-gifts past counting?

530 My son — while he was still a child, and soft
in mind,

531 he would not have me marry and leave my
husband's house;

532 but now that he is grown, come to the
measure of manhood,

533 he prays me to go back home, out of these
halls —

534 chafing over the estate the Achaeans eat
away.

535 But come — hear this dream of mine, and read

it for me.**66**

536 I keep twenty geese about the house; they eat
wheat

537 softened in water, and it warms me to watch
them.**67**

538 And out of the mountain came a great hook-
beaked eagle

539 and broke all their necks, and killed them; and
they lay strewn

540 in a heap through the halls, while he was
borne up to the bright sky.

541 And I wept — I wailed aloud, though it was a
dream,

542 and around me gathered the fair-braided
Achaean women,

543 as I grieved most pitiably because the eagle
had killed my geese.

544 But back he came, and perched on the jut of
the roof-beam,

545 and with a man's voice he checked my
grieving:

546 'Take heart, daughter of far-famed Icarius:

547 this is no dream but a waking sight — a good
one, and it shall be accomplished.68

548 The geese are the suitors; and I — I was the
eagle-bird

549 before; but now I have come back, and I am
your husband,

550 and I will let loose an ugly doom on all the
suitors.’69

551 So he spoke; and the honey-sweet sleep let me
go;

552 and casting about, I saw the geese there in the
halls

553 pecking their wheat beside the trough, just
where they always were.”

554 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

555 “Lady, there is no way to wrench this dream
aside

556 to read it another way: Odysseus himself, no
other,

557 has shown you how he will end it: destruction
shows plain for the suitors —

558 for every man of them; not one shall slip out
of death and the fates.”70

559 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

560 “Stranger, dreams are hopeless things, and
their talk past sorting;

561 not everything in them is accomplished for
mortals.

562 For two are the gates of strengthless
dreams:71

563 one pair is fashioned of horn, and one of
ivory.

564 Those dreams that come through the gate of
sawn ivory

565 cheat and beguile: they carry words that come
to nothing.

566 But those that come out through the gate of
polished horn

567 accomplish true things, whenever a mortal
sees them.

568 But my strange dream, I fear, did not come
from there —

569 ah, welcome as that would be to me and to my
child.

570 And another thing I will tell you: lay it up in
your heart.

571 Here now comes the dawn of the evil name,
that will cut me72

572 away from the house of Odysseus. For now I
will set the contest:

573 the axes he used to stand up in a row in his
halls,

574 like the props of a ship on the stocks — twelve
in all;73

575 and standing far back he would shoot an
arrow through them.

576 Now I will set this contest before the suitors:

577 whoever strings the bow most easily in his
hands,

578 and shoots an arrow through all twelve axes
—

579 him I will follow, forsaking this house,

580 this house of my marriage, this beautiful
house, full of all

581 that sustains life. I think I shall remember it
even in my dreams.”74

582 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

583 “Honored wife of Laertes’ son Odysseus,
584 do not put off this contest in your house one
hour.

585 For Odysseus of the many designs will be here
first —75

586 before these men, handling and handling the
polished bow,

587 can string the cord and shoot through the
iron.”

588 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

589 “Stranger, if you were only willing to sit by
me in the halls76

590 and give me pleasure, sleep would never
settle on my eyes.

591 But there is no way men can go sleepless
forever:

592 the deathless ones have set a portion for each

thing

593 mortals do on the grain-giving earth.

594 So I will go up now to my upper room

595 to lie on the bed that has become a bed of
groaning for me,⁷⁷

596 forever stained with my tears, since the day
Odysseus

597 went to look on Evil-Ilium, never to be named.

598 There I will lie; and you lie down in this house

—

599 spread something on the floor, or let them set
you a bed.”

600 So speaking she climbed to her shining upper
room,

601 not alone: her handmaids went up with her.

602 Climbing to her upper room with her serving-
women,

603 she wept there for Odysseus, her dear
husband, until

604 gray-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her
eyelids.⁷⁸

Notes

NOTES

1. Lines 1–2 return verbatim at 51–52, bracketing the arms-removal like a refrain: the man alone in the hall, “plotting the suitors’ slaughter with Athena’s help.” The book of the poem’s most intimate conversation opens and re-opens on the murder being arranged around it. ↩
2. The smoke-speech, delivered as scripted at 16.286–294 — cover story, soot damage, and the proverb, word for word as his father dictated (with one variant: “a god has cast into my heart” for “the son of Cronos”). Telemachus will perform it flawlessly. The plan is now running on rehearsed lines; the poem lets us hear the rehearsal and the performance two books apart. ↩
3. Eurycleia’s question is pure household logistics — who carries the light if the women are locked in? — and it earns the poem’s answer: Athena herself will (33–34). The gap between the nurse’s lamp-problem and its divine solution measures the whole night: ordinary housekeeping, extraordinary guests. ↩
4. Athena with the golden lamp — the only *λύχνος* in Homer. The goddess as lamp-bearer for two men carrying weapons: the humblest divine service in the poem, and the most intimate — the household’s true light restored for one night’s secret work. ↩

5. Telemachus senses the theophany — not seeing her (16.161's rule holds), but seeing the glow on rafters and pillars. His father's response is liturgical discipline: "Quiet... This is the way of the gods." The son is being trained in the etiquette of divine partnership: notice, do not name, keep working. ↩
6. "To stir the slave-women a little more, and your mother" — ἐρεθίζω, the verb of provoking. He announces the interview as a probe: even the meeting with his wife is framed, to his son, as a test to run. What the night actually becomes exceeds the operational language that scheduled it. ↩
7. The chair of Icmalius — ivory and silver, the maker named, the footrest built in one piece. Furniture with a pedigree, like the basin and the bed to come: the poem is beginning its inventory of the objects that know the family. She sits where "she always sat"; the stranger watches his wife take her place in the furniture of a house he knows to its joints. ↩
8. Melantho's second attack (the first at 18.327ff) — now with the torch-brand threat. Her taunt "spying on the women" is exactly right: he is auditing the women; she is failing the audit in real time, twice, with the mistress listening. ↩
9. The warning to Melantho maps every exit: the mistress may turn on you, Odysseus may come ("a portion of hope is left" — ἐλπίδος αἴσα, the phrase Murray's text lost from 16.101 restored to the living text here), and if not, Telemachus is of age and misses nothing. Three jurisdictions, all closing; she hears rhetoric and is dead within days under the middle one. ↩

10. Penelope's rebuke — "dog past all shame... you will wipe it off on your own head" — is queenly rage with an exact idiom of blood-guilt: the deed will be wiped clean on the doer. The mistress has just cursed her fosterling (18.322–323) in terms the gallows will honor. ↩
11. She asks the poem's identity-formula herself — "What man are you, and from where?" — the question Telemachus put to Athena (1.170), Eumaeus to the beggar (14.187), Theoclymenus to Telemachus (15.264). The formula's greatest asking: wife to disguised husband, by the fire. ↩
12. He answers "who are you?" with "what you are": the just-king simile — straight judgments, black earth bearing wheat and barley, trees heavy, flocks throwing firm young, the sea yielding fish, the people flourishing. It is the poem's fullest political theology (kingship as fertility), and he lays it on her: Penelope's fame is the fame of the good king. The compliment is also a report card — and a husband's thanks smuggled through a beggar's flattery. ↩
13. Her reply opens with the bloom-destroyed lines she gave Eurymachus (18.251–253) — her standing preface — then modulates the suitor-catalogue of 1.245–248 into first person: "they woo me against my will, and wear this house away." The poem's fixed materials, re-keyed to the widow's own voice. ↩
14. "They press the marriage on; and I wind out my skein of tricks" — *τολυνεύω*, a wool-working verb: to wind off into balls. Her metaphor for plotting is her craft; *μητις* in this house spins. The line is her self-portrait as her husband's equal — he tells lies like truth, she winds stratagems like yarn. ↩

15. The web story, told by the weaver herself (139–156 ≈ 2.94–110, where Antinous told it as an indictment). The two tellings are nearly verbatim — same quoted speech to the suitors, same three years, same betrayal — and opposite in genre: his was a complaint about female cunning; hers is a veteran’s account of a defensive war, ending not in triumph but “against my will, under force.” A suitor’s ghost will tell it a third time in Hades (24.128–146); each teller’s version is a verdict on the teller. ↩
16. “My parents urge me hard to marry” — confirming Athena’s claim at 15.16ff, which had seemed like the goddess’s motivational invention. The pressure is real from every side now: parents, son, deadline. The poem quietly closes the gap between what Athena said and what is true. ↩
17. “Not born of the oak in the old tales, nor of a stone” — the proverb for having ordinary human origins (already old when Hesiod used it). Her curiosity is warm and worldly: everyone comes from somewhere; produce your parents. ↩
18. Crete again — the fifth Cretan tale (13.256ff, 14.199ff, 16.62 relayed, 17.523 relayed, now the full aria): ninety cities, five peoples, “tongue mixed with tongue” — the densest ethnography in Homer, true in every checkable detail. He builds the lie’s floor out of the real world; the fiction stands only on the top course. ↩
19. Minos “king by nine-year terms, great Zeus’s intimate” (έννέωρος... όαπιστής): the nine-year kingship renewed in conference with Zeus — a glimpse of Bronze Age sacral kingship. The liar gives himself the best pedigree in the

Aegean: grandson of Zeus's confidant, brother of Idomeneus.



20. "My famous name is Aethon" — "Blaze," "Burnt-brown." His third alias (unnamed to Eumaeus, "Epēritos" waits for Laertes at 24.306); this one, ominously, is a fire-name worn beside his own hearth. ↩
21. The masterstroke of the lie: he hosted Odysseus. He invents a twelve-day guest-friendship with himself, itemized — the harbor at Amnisus, the public barley, the oxen. He gives his wife the gift of her husband seen, fed, honored — a kindness folded inside an imposture, and reconnaissance: her grief at the story is the proof he came for. ↩
22. "The tenth dawn, or the eleventh" — the liar's calibrated vagueness: an honest witness is precise about scenery and hazy about numbers. The poem has already told us the technique's name (13.295, Athena admiring); here we watch the brushwork. ↩
23. "He made the many lies he told seem like the truth" (ἵσκε ψεύδεα πολλὰ λέγων ἐτύμοισιν ὁμοῖα) — the most self-referential line in Homer: it is what Hesiod's Muses say of themselves ("we know how to speak many lies like the truth"). Spoken over Odysseus mid-performance, it is the poet certifying his hero as a poet — and confessing what epic itself is made of. ↩
24. The snow simile: her face melts as the West Wind's snow melts under the East Wind's thaw, "and as it melts the rivers run full." Twenty years of winter breaking up in one listening. The simile's tenderness is geographic — high mountains, spring

flood — as if her weeping watered the kingdom the just-king simile just described. ↩

25. “His eyes stood fixed as horn or iron” — while she melts, he petrifies; one marriage, two states of matter. Horn returns at 562 as the gate of true dreams — the eyes that will not weep are made of the same stuff as the gate truth comes through. “He wept for his wife in his heart” is literal: the tears happen; only their exit is closed, “with craft.” ↩
26. “I think I shall put you to the test” — πειρήσεσθαι: she uses the family verb. Odysseus tests everyone (his word at 16.305, 313); now his wife runs the procedure on him — demand verifiable detail, check against private knowledge. The clothes-test is flawless method: only she knows what she packed. ↩
27. The brooch: a golden hound throttling a dappled fawn that “strained with its feet to escape, even as it struggled.” The ekphrasis is Odysseus in miniature — predator craft caught mid-kill, beauty made of applied violence — and, this night of all nights, a forecast: the hound is in the hall, the fawns are asleep in their own houses (cf. the lion’s-lair simile, 4.335ff = 17.126ff). ↩
28. The tunic like “the skin that slips from a dried onion” — soft, glistening, close: the homeliest simile in Homer applied to a king’s shirt, and instantly convincing for that reason. Only someone who had handled the garment would reach for the kitchen to describe it; she supplied the garment, and the description tells her so. ↩
29. Eurybates the herald: “round in the shoulders, dark-skinned, curly-headed” — the most particular physical description of

any Greek in the poem, honoring a real companion (he appears in Iliad 2.184). Prized “for their minds ran matched”: the detail no imposter would invent is the affection. ↩

30. “She recognized the tokens” — σήματα: the recognition-word, rehearsing for Book 23 where the σήματα will be the bed. The poem is running the machinery of recognition at half-power: tokens verified, husband confirmed dead by the evidence of his living presence. ↩
31. “It was I who gave him those clothes — I” — the test returns its result and it is worse than failure: the beggar’s description proves he saw Odysseus in the very clothes she folded, pinned, and chose. The proof of contact becomes proof of loss (“I shall never welcome him again”). Grief by verification: the scene’s cruelest turn, engineered by the husband who is its object. ↩
32. “Evil-Ilium, never to be named” (Κακοίλιον οὐκ ὀνομαστήν) — her coinage: Troy renamed as a curse, with the superstitious rider that saying the name feeds its power. She repeats it at 597. In her private theology the war has no name, only an epithet of hatred. ↩
33. The Thesprotian tale, third performance (14.316ff to Eumaeus; relayed to her at 17.526–527; now direct): Pheidon, the treasure, the oath, Dodona — stable in every strut, with the Phaeacian truth freshly built in. To his wife he adds what Eumaeus didn’t get: Thrinacia, Zeus and Helios, the keel that carried him off the wreck — his real story, distributed to a fiction one island off. ↩
34. “Zeus and Helios were set at odds with him” — ὀδύσαντο: the name-verb (see 1.62, 5.340), planted inside the lie. Even his

fictions pun on him; the “man at odds” narrates his own wreck under an alias and cannot keep his name’s grammar out of it. The naming-scene forty lines ahead (407–409) will unpack the same verb in earnest. ↩

35. “Beyond all mortal men Odysseus knows the profitable turn” (κέρδεα) — the beggar praising Odysseus for the very trait currently deceiving the listener. The self-endorsement doubles as an excuse for delay (he stayed away to gather wealth) — planted so the real homecoming’s poverty of explanation will have cover. ↩

36. The oath repeats his oath to Eumaeus (14.158–162) almost word for word — Zeus, the hearth of blameless Odysseus, and the dating-formula: “Within this very turning of the light... between this month’s waning and the rising of the next.” He swears by his own hearth, standing at it, and sets the deadline that the festival of Apollo (20.156, 276) will keep: tomorrow is the dark of the moon. ↩

37. The blessing-formula a third time (15.536–538, 17.163–165) — Telemachus, then Penelope to Theoclymenus, now Penelope to the beggar: the same courteous three lines each time, meeting prophecy — dynastic in Book 15, of return since — with structured disbelief. The family meets hope with a fixed liturgy: bless the speaker, refuse the content. Then her flat overrule: “Odysseus is not coming home; and you will get no passage” — hope’s administrator denying both claims in one breath. ↩

38. From despair she pivots to hospitality’s checklist — bath, bed, blankets, morning oil — and the reason (325–334) is the just-

king simile handed back: guests carry fame; the blameless man's name travels. She answers his political theology with hers: her kingdom is conduct, its export is reputation, "men are creatures of a short day" and are remembered by what they served. ↩

39. "How will you learn of me... whether I stand out at all among women in mind and thoughtful counsel" — she wants the stranger to certify her μῆτις, not her face. It is the exact wish her husband can grant and no one else fully could; the poem lets them audition for each other all night under assumed identities. ↩
40. The foot-washing condition: no young woman shall touch him — only an old one "who has endured in her spirit as much as I have endured." The sentence is a targeting instruction: it describes exactly one person in the house. He engineers his own recognition-risk — pride, tenderness, or the plan needing Eurycleia inside it; the poem lets all three stand. ↩
41. "Up now, watchful-minded Eurycleia" — Penelope lends the nurse her own epithet (περίφρων), a dignity the poem otherwise grants only the queen and the housekeeper Eurynome. Two watchful minds are about to share a room with the man neither can quite see. ↩
42. "Perhaps Odysseus by now is like him in his feet, like him in his hands... in misfortune mortal men age fast." She keeps walking to the edge of the truth and providing herself the railing: the resemblance is real, therefore explained. Her rationality is the disguise's best ally — Athena needs to intervene (479) only once all night; Penelope's good sense does the rest. ↩

43. Eurycleia's lament is addressed to the absent Odysseus — "Ah me, child, and I helpless for you" — over the head of the present one. She catalogues his piety, Zeus's ingratitude, and then turns the mockery of serving-women into a mirror: as these bitches taunt you, so some far country's maids must have taunted him. Every clause lands on its hidden target; the poem gives her forty lines of dramatic irony as devotion. ↩
44. "In body, in voice, in feet — to Odysseus": the strongest pre-recognition statement in the poem, from the woman who has known that body since its first hour. Voice — which Athena's wand never altered — is the tell no disguise covers. She sees it, says it, and hands it to him as a curiosity. ↩
45. His parry is perfect poise: "so they all say... we are very like each other." Confirm the observation, drain its danger — the resemblance becomes a known fact about two men, attested by witnesses he invents on the spot. The truth, filed under coincidence, with forged supporting papers. ↩
46. He swings toward the dark on instinct — one beat too late, and the poem knows it: the fear "that as she took hold she might mark the scar" arrives with the water already poured. For once the master of foresight has missed a variable: he asked for the one washer who bathed the leg ten thousand times. ↩
47. "At once she knew the scar" — and the poem, at the exact instant of contact, opens a seventy-five-line window onto Parnassus. The scar digression is the most famous narrative suspension in literature (Auerbach built *Mimesis* on it): between her fingers touching the scar and the shin hitting the basin, the poem inserts the scar's whole biography —

grandfather, naming, hunt, wound, healing, homecoming. Recognition, the poem insists, is not a point but a depth: what Eurycleia touches is a story, so the story must be told. ↩

48. Autolycus, “who outdid all men in thievery and the oath” — sanctioned by Hermes himself. The grandfather’s arts are the oblique oath and the profitable theft: Odysseus’ μήτις has a maternal pedigree, god-given, two generations deep. The poem does not blush: the best man of his age descends from the best thief of his. ↩
49. Eurycleia laid the newborn on Autolycus’ knees and asked for the name — the very woman now holding the leg the name grew into. The digression’s frame is exact: the woman who asked for the name is his recognizer; Autolycus chose it, and she has been present at both ends of it. ↩
50. The naming: “Since I have come to this place at odds with many... let Odysseus, Man at Odds, be the name he carries.” Autolycus names the child from his own condition (ὀδυσσάμενος — having incurred wrath, being at odds), the pun this translation has shadowed since 1.62 (“at odds with Odysseus”) and 19.275 (ὀδύσαντο). The name is a grandfather’s grudge made hereditary — a life sentence of friction with gods and men, handed down at supper. “Child of many prayers” (πολύαρητος, 404) was the alternative reading; the poem chose both: prayed-for and at odds — the whole man in two etymologies. ↩
51. Amphinthea’s greeting — “kissed his head, and both his beautiful eyes” — is the family’s fixed embrace: Eumaeus greeted Telemachus with it (16.15), Penelope her son (17.39). Three

generations, one gesture; the digression roots the family's own formulas in the grandmother's arms. ↩

52. Dawn strikes the plowlands “out of the deep smooth stream of Ocean” as the hunt climbs Parnassus: the boyhood memory keeps epic time, with sunrise from Ocean and the mountain's windy folds. The digression is built like a miniature epic day — feast, sleep, dawn, aristeia, wound, healing, homecoming — Odysseus' whole life-pattern rehearsed in boyhood. ↩
53. The boar's lair — windproof, sunproof, rainproof, deep in dead leaves: the same three-fold impenetrability as the thicket where Odysseus slept on Scheria (5.478ff). The poem beds its hero and the beast in the same shelter, a generation apart: the boar is his older double, dug into the island of his blood. ↩
54. “Down in the dust he went, bleating, and the life flew out of him” — the boar dies in Irus' line (18.98: “he went down bleating in the dust”). Man and beast take the same formula at the two ends of the hero's fighting life: the boyhood hunt, the latest knockdown. The scar was bought with the same sentence it now interrupts. ↩
55. The incantation (ἐπαοιδή) that stanches the black blood — the only spell in Homer. The sons of the thief-lord practice song-medicine: words that close wounds, in the family whose gift is words that open them. The poem's oldest magic is a bandage. ↩
56. The return from Parnassus is one syllable of contact: “she knew it under her fingers.” Then the poem's most famous sound-effect — shin, basin, bronze, water: recognition as a kitchen accident, the clang the whole digression has been holding

back. Homer routes the identity of his hero through an old woman's hands and a dropped foot-bath. ↩

57. "You are Odysseus — dear child! And I did not know you, not before I had handled all of him — my master." Touch as knowledge — she says it herself: not sight, not voice, handling. The nurse's epistemology is a lifetime of bathing, and her sentence stumbles between second and third person (you — him — my master) as the two men, patient and lord, snap into one. ↩

58. Athena turns Penelope's mind aside — the poem's most debated intervention. Eurycleia's eyes go to the queen; the queen cannot receive the look. Whether this protects the plan, or Penelope, or dramatizes what she cannot yet afford to know, the mechanics are stark: the recognition is contained by divine censorship, three feet from the wife it concerns. ↩

59. The throat-grip: the hand she nursed "at this breast of yours" closes on her windpipe while the other pulls her close — menace and embrace in one motion, the book's body-language for the whole disguise. And the threat is not idle: "I will not spare even you... that day I kill the other slave-women." He shows his nurse the executioner first and the child second; she takes both without flinching. ↩

60. Her answer opens with the household's own formula for shocking speech — "what a word has slipped the fence of your teeth!" (1.64's line, the family idiom) — then gives the vow: "I will hold like solid stone, like iron." The materials are his (his eyes at 211 were horn and iron); the nurse certifies herself in the metallurgy of her master's discipline. ↩

61. She offers the audit of the women (as she will deliver it at 22.417ff); he declines — “I will observe them well myself” — holding to the method Telemachus amended at 16.313ff: test in place, trust your own eyes, defer lists. Between the nurse’s intelligence and his surveillance, the house’s women are now bracketed by two watchers. ↩
62. “Covered the scar with his rags”: the wound that just detonated the scene is tucked away under costume, and the interview resumes as if the clang had not happened. The rags — the poem’s cheapest prop — are asked to hold down the poem’s heaviest fact. ↩
63. “By day my one delight is weeping” — *τέρπομαι*, the pleasure-verb, given to grief: mourning as her craft and recreation at once (cf. 15.399ff, “we two will take our pleasure in each other’s grim sorrows”). Then the nights: the lying awake, “sharp anxieties crowding round my beating heart” — the poem’s clinical picture of chronic grief, drawn by the patient. ↩
64. The nightingale: Pandareus’ daughter, who killed her own son Itylus “in her blindness of mind” and sings for him always, “pouring, turning, threading her many-noted voice.” Grief that became song, made of a mother’s fatal error. Penelope reaches for the myth where a wrong choice kills a child — her exact terror: choose wrongly (stay, go, marry, wait) and destroy her son. The simile is a confession wearing plumage. ↩
65. The divided heart, in nearly her son’s words (16.73–77: bed of her husband, voice of the people, best of the Achaeans) — mother and son carry the same fixed description of her

dilemma. But hers adds what his omitted: the son himself now “prays me to go back home, chafing over the estate.” The last brace holding her in the house has asked her to leave it. ↩

66. “Hear this dream of mine, and read it for me”: she commissions an interpretation from the beggar — the dream already contains its own interpreter, who is also its subject, who is also the man she asks. The poem builds a hall of mirrors and sits the married couple down inside it. ↩

67. The twenty geese: “it warms me to watch them” (ιαίνομαι) — and when the eagle kills them she weeps and wails *in the dream*, and checks on them, relieved, on waking. The famous crux: the suitors’ deaths, forecast, are mourned. Perhaps the geese are not the suitors to her but the filled house itself — the waiting-life’s furniture, wretched but hers, that revenge will sweep away with everything else. The dream knows what the plot does not admit: that even a rescue is a bereavement to the life it interrupts. ↩

68. “No dream but a waking sight” (οὐκ ὄναρ, ἀλλ’ ὕπαρ ἐσθλόν): the eagle files its own vision under reality. The dream deposes that it is not a dream — the strongest available warrant, delivered inside the very form it disclaims. Her skepticism at 560ff answers this claim, not just the content. ↩

69. The eagle’s exegesis borrows Menelaus’ words (4.340 = 17.131): “I will let loose an ugly doom on all the suitors” — the deer-in-lion prophecy’s exact clause, now spoken by the husband-bird in her sleep. The poem’s prophecies have begun quoting each other; every channel — seer, omen, beggar, dream — now carries the same sentence. ↩

70. His reading ends in her own words: “not one shall slip out of death and the fates” = 17.547–548, her response to the sneeze-omen. Husband and wife now complete each other’s death-sentences verbatim without knowing they share a text. The marriage of true minds, conducted entirely in formulas. ↩
71. The gates of horn and ivory — six lines that founded the West’s dream-lore (Virgil took the gates for the Aeneid’s most troubling exit). The Greek runs on two puns this translation can only shadow: dreams through ivory (ἐλέφας) *deceive* (ἐλεφαίρονται); dreams through horn (κέρας) *accomplish* (κράινουσι). Ivory-cheat, horn-fulfill: language itself sorting dreams by sound. Note what she is doing: armoring herself against the night’s second true prophecy — and note his eyes at 211, “fixed as horn”: the true gate has been looking at her all evening. ↩
72. “The dawn of the evil name” (δυσώνυμος) — the morning itself gets an epithet of hatred, like Evil-Ilium: her lexicon curses what it cannot prevent. Then, from the floor of her despair, she produces the poem’s deus ex machina: the contest of the bow — announced to a beggar, deep in the night, on the eve of the dark of the moon. ↩
73. The axes “like the props of a ship on the stocks” (δρυόχους ὥς) — twelve in a row, the arrow threaded through: Odysseus’ old trick-shot, his private gymnastics remembered by his wife in shipwright’s language. Whatever the rig actually was (socket-rings? helve-eyes? — antiquity already argued), the poem’s point is proprietary: only its inventor can repeat it, and she has just made it the bride-price. ↩

74. “This house of my marriage, this beautiful house, full of all that sustains life. I think I shall remember it even in my dreams.”
The saddest sentence she speaks — surrender phrased as a forwarding address for her dreams. Whether the contest is despair, intuition, or collusion below the level of knowledge (the debate is eternal), her timing is the plot’s salvation: she arms her husband on exactly the right night, for reasons she does not let herself examine. ↩
75. “Odysseus of the many designs will be here first” — he backs the contest under his own full formulaic name, the disguise thinned to one layer of grammar: third person. Every word true; the sentence’s speaker its only fiction. πολύμητις Ὀδυσσεύς endorsing the plan of πολύμητις Ὀδυσσεύς. ↩
76. “If you were only willing... sleep would never settle on my eyes”: the interview’s almost-avowal. She has spent the night being charmed like the man in Eumaeus’ singer-simile (17.518ff), and says so — then invokes mortal limits (the gods “have set a portion for each thing”) and rises. The scene ends at the exact edge of what the plot can survive: one more hour and no wand could have held the marriage apart. ↩
77. The bed of groaning, “forever stained with my tears” = her words to Telemachus (17.102–104), now with Evil-Ilium in the third line: her fixed nocturne. She describes the marriage bed to her husband as an instrument of grief — the same bed whose secret will remake it as proof of joy four books from now. ↩
78. Lines 602–604 repeat 1.362–364 to the word — the refrain of all her nights, closing the greatest of them as it closed the first we

saw: she climbs, she weeps for Odysseus, Athena seals her eyes.
The poem ends its long night exactly where it began its first
book — except that tonight the man she weeps for is
downstairs, lying in the porch, planning sunrise. ↩

Odyssey — Book 20

*The night before; the omens of the last day; the ox-hoof;
Theoclymenus sees the dark.*

- 1 But noble Odysseus made his bed in the fore-hall:
- 2 he spread an undressed oxhide down, and over it
- 3 many fleeces of the sheep the Achaeans kept slaughtering,¹
- 4 and Eurynome threw a mantle over him where he lay.
- 5 There Odysseus lay awake, his heart devising
- 6 evils for the suitors; and out of the hall came the women,
- 7 the ones who all along had been sleeping with the suitors,
- 8 setting each other laughing, trading their good cheer.²
- 9 And the heart was roused in his breast,

10 and he weighed it long in his mind and in his
heart —

11 whether to spring after them and deal out
death to each,

12 or let them mix with the overweening suitors

13 one final and last time. And the heart inside
him snarled —

14 as a bitch standing over her soft-boned pups,³

15 facing a man she does not know, snarls and is
wild to fight:

16 so his heart snarled within him, in outrage at
their evil doings.

17 But he struck his chest and called his heart to
order:

18 “Bear up, my heart. A more dog-vile thing you
bore than this⁴

19 the day the Cyclops, his force past holding, ate

20 my brave companions — and you endured it,
till cunning

21 led you out of the cave where you thought to
die.”

22 So he spoke, reproving the dear heart in his

breast;

23 and his heart, in deep obedience, held fast

24 and endured without a break. But the man
himself turned this way and that.

25 As when a man before a great blazing fire

26 turns a paunch packed full of fat and blood⁵

27 this way and that, longing to have it roasted
quickly,

28 so he rolled from side to side, turning over

29 how he could lay his hands on the shameless
sutors,

30 one man against so many. And Athena came
close to him,

31 down from the sky; and in body she was like a
woman;

32 and she stood above his head and spoke to him:

33 “Why awake again, most luckless of all men?⁶

34 Here is your house; here in the house is your
wife,

35 and your child — a son such as any man would
pray for.”

36 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered

her:

37 “Yes, goddess — all this you have said as it
should be.

38 But there is a thing my heart keeps turning
over:

39 how I am to lay hands on the shameless suitors
—

40 I, one man alone; and they always inside in a
crowd.

41 And this greater thing besides I keep turning
over:7

42 even if I kill them, by the will of Zeus and by
yours,

43 where do I run from what follows? Think that
out for me, I say.”

44 Then the goddess answered him, gray-eyed
Athena:

45 “Hard man! A person will trust a weaker friend
than me,8

46 one who is mortal, and does not know such
counsels;

47 but I am a god, and I guard you through

48 to the end of every labor. I will tell you
outright:

49 if fifty companies of mortal men stood round

50 the two of us, hot to kill us in the fight,

51 even so you would drive away their cattle and
fat sheep.⁹

52 Come — let sleep take you too. There is misery
in watching

53 all night awake. You will rise up out of your
evils now.”

54 So she spoke, and poured down sleep upon his
eyelids,

55 and went back herself to Olympus, the shining
goddess.

56 And as sleep seized him, loosing the cares of
his heart,

57 loosing his limbs, his true-hearted wife
awoke,¹⁰

58 and wept, sitting up on her soft bed.

59 And when she had had her fill of weeping,

60 first to Artemis prayed that woman shining
among women:

61 “Artemis, sovereign goddess, daughter of Zeus
— would that now¹¹

62 you would plant an arrow in my breast and
take my life

63 this very instant — or a storm-wind snatch me
up

64 and carry me off down the ways of gloom

65 and fling me down where backward-flowing
Ocean empties.

66 As when the storm-winds carried off
Pandareus’ daughters:¹²

67 the gods had destroyed their parents, and they
were left

68 orphans in the halls; and shining Aphrodite
reared them

69 on cheese and sweet honey and pleasant wine,

70 and Hera gave them beauty and good sense

71 beyond all women, and pure Artemis their
height,

72 and Athena taught them the making of
glorious work.

73 But while shining Aphrodite was on her way to

high Olympus

74 to ask for the girls the crown of blossoming
marriage —

75 gone to Zeus who delights in thunder, for he
knows all things well,

76 the fortune and the misfortune of mortal men
—

77 meanwhile the snatching-winds carried the
girls away

78 and gave them over to the hateful Furies, to
serve them.**13**

79 So may the dwellers on Olympus blot me out of
sight,

80 or fair-braided Artemis strike me, that with
Odysseus

81 before my eyes I may pass even under the
hateful earth,**14**

82 and never gladden the mind of a lesser man.

83 And yet an evil is bearable, when a person

84 weeps through the days, grieved to the packed
core of the heart,

85 and the nights hold sleep at least — for sleep

makes one forget

86 everything, the good and the bad, once it has
wrapped the eyelids —

87 but to me the god sends evil even in dreams.

88 For this very night one slept beside me — like
him,¹⁵

89 his very likeness as he was when he went with
the army; and my heart

90 rejoiced: I thought it no dream, but the waking
truth at last.”

91 So she spoke; and at once Dawn of the golden
throne came on.

92 And noble Odysseus caught the sound of her
weeping,

93 and mused; and it seemed to him, in the drift
of his heart,

94 that she knew him already, and stood beside
his head.¹⁶

95 He gathered up the mantle and the fleeces he
had slept in

96 and set them on a chair in the hall; the oxhide

97 he carried outside and laid down; and lifting

his hands he prayed to Zeus:

98 “Father Zeus — if you gods willed it, and
brought me home

99 over dry land and water, after all your hard
usage,

100 let someone of the people waking in the
house speak me

101 a word of omen; and outside, let another sign
of Zeus appear.”17

102 So he prayed; and Zeus the counselor heard
him,

103 and at once he thundered out of gleaming
Olympus,

104 down from on high, out of the clouds. And
noble Odysseus was glad.

105 And the word of omen came from a woman
grinding at the mill,

106 close by, where the mills of the shepherd of
the people stood.

107 Twelve women in all kept them turning,

108 making barley meal and wheat flour, the
marrow of men.18

109 The others were asleep, their wheat all
ground;
110 only one had not finished — the frailest one of
all.
111 She stopped her stone now, and spoke the
word — a sign for her master:
112 “Father Zeus, you who rule the gods and
mankind:
113 how loud you thundered out of the starry sky
—
114 and no cloud anywhere! You show this as a
sign to someone.
115 Then accomplish now for wretched me the
word I say:
116 may the suitors, on this day, for the last and
latest time,¹⁹
117 take up their lovely feasting in the halls of
Odysseus —
118 the men who have loosed my knees with
heart-grinding labor
119 as I make their barley meal: may they sup now
their last!”

120 So she spoke; and noble Odysseus rejoiced at
the omen of her word²⁰

121 and at the thunder of Zeus. He told himself
the guilty would pay.

122 Now the other slave-women, gathering in the
beautiful house of Odysseus,

123 were kindling on the hearth the never-
wearying fire.

124 And Telemachus rose from his bed, a man like
a god,

125 and put on his clothes, and hung his sharp
sword at his shoulder,

126 and under his shining feet he bound the
beautiful sandals,

127 and took his strong spear, tipped with
sharpened bronze,

128 and paused on the threshold, and said to
Eurycleia:

129 “Dear nurse, have you honored the stranger in
our house²¹

130 with bed and food? Or does he lie untended,
as he may?

131 That is my mother's way — sensible woman
though she is:

132 she honors the worse of mortal men on
impulse,

133 and sends the better man away unhonored.”

134 Then watchful-minded Eurycleia answered
him:

135 “Child, do not blame the blameless woman
now.²²

136 He sat and drank his wine as long as he
himself would;

137 and bread — he said he hungered for none:
she asked him.

138 And when he began to think of rest and sleep,

139 she told the slave-women to spread him a
proper bed;

140 but he — like a man wholly wretched, out of
luck —

141 refused to sleep on a bedstead under blankets:

142 on an undressed oxhide and the fleeces of
sheep

143 he slept in the fore-hall. We laid a mantle over

him ourselves.”

144 So she spoke; and Telemachus went out
through the hall,

145 spear in hand; two swift dogs followed with
him,

146 and he went to the assembly-place, to the
strong-greaved Achaeans.

147 And she called out to the slave-women, that
woman shining among women —

148 Eurycleia, daughter of Ops, Peisenor’s son:23

149 “Come — to work! Some of you sweep the
house, and briskly,

150 and sprinkle it, and lay the crimson coverings

151 on the well-made chairs; others take sponges

152 and wipe down all the tables, and rinse the
mixing-bowls

153 and the wrought double-handled cups; and
the rest of you away

154 for water at the spring — go quick, and quick
back with it.

155 The suitors will not be long out of the hall this
morning:

156 they will come very early. It is festival for
everyone today.”²⁴

157 So she spoke; and they listened well and
obeyed:

158 twenty went off to the spring of dark water,
159 and the others worked away skillfully about
the house.

160 Then the Achaeans’ serving-men came in, and
split

161 firewood, well and skillfully; and the women
came back

162 from the spring; and after them came the
swineherd,

163 driving three fatted hogs, the best of all he
had.

164 He left them to feed at large in the fine yard-
fences,

165 and himself spoke to Odysseus, and his words
were kind:

166 “Stranger — do the Achaeans look on you any
better now,

167 or do they still dishonor you through the hall,

as before?”

168 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

169 “Ah, Eumaeus, may the gods pay back the
outrage

170 these men in their insolence keep devising —

171 reckless things, in another man’s house. They
have no share of shame.”

172 So they spoke to one another of such things.

173 And Melanthius came up close to them, the
goatherd,²⁵

174 driving the goats that stood out in all the
herds,

175 a dinner for the suitors; and two herdsmen
followed with him.

176 He tethered the goats under the echoing
porch,

177 and himself spoke to Odysseus, and his words
were taunts:

178 “Stranger — still here? Still going to plague
this house,

179 begging from the men? Still not out the door?

180 I don't imagine, now, we two will settle this
business
181 before we've tasted each other's fists. There is
no decency
182 in the way you beg. And there are other feasts
among the Achaeans."
183 So he spoke; and Odysseus of the many
designs said nothing:
184 he only shook his head, silent, brooding evils
deep in his heart.²⁶
185 And a third came in upon them — Philoetius, a
leader of men,²⁷
186 driving a barren heifer for the suitors, and fat
goats.
187 Ferrymen had brought them over — the ones
who carry
188 other travelers too, whoever comes to them.
189 He tethered his beasts well under the echoing
porch,
190 and came up close to the swineherd and asked
him:
191 "Swineherd — who is this stranger, newly

come

192 to our house? What men does he claim for his
people?

193 Where are his family and his fathers' fields?

194 Poor devil — and yet, truly, in build he is like a
lord, a king.28

195 But the gods sink far-wandering men in
misery

196 when they spin hard sorrow even for kings.”

197 He spoke, and coming up he gave him his
right hand in welcome,

198 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words:

199 “Your health, father stranger! May happiness
be yours29

200 in time to come — though now you are held
fast in many evils.

201 Father Zeus — no other god is deadlier than
you:30

202 you have no pity on men, though you begot
them

203 yourself, for tangling them in misery and
grinding pains.

204 I broke sweat when I saw him, and my eyes
stand full of tears,³¹
205 remembering Odysseus: for he too, I think,
206 wears rags like these, and wanders
somewhere among men —
207 if indeed he lives, and sees the light of the
sun.
208 But if he is dead already, down in the house of
Hades —
209 ah me, blameless Odysseus! — who set me
over his cattle
210 when I was still a boy, in the land of the
Cephalenians.
211 And now they are past all counting: no other
man
212 could have a breed of broad-browed cattle
bear richer, like standing wheat.³²
213 And strangers order me to drive them in for
them
214 to eat! They care nothing for the son in the
house,
215 they do not tremble at the gods' watching eye:

they are wild

216 to divide up the goods of the master so long
away.

217 As for me, this thought keeps rolling over and
over

218 in the heart in my breast: it is a very bad
thing,

219 while the son lives, to go off to a country of
strangers,

220 cattle and all, to foreign men; but colder still
to stay

221 suffering here, sitting over cattle that others
claim.33

222 And long ago I would have run, fled to some
other

223 of the high-handed kings — for this is past all
bearing —

224 but still I think of that unlucky man: what if
he came

225 from somewhere, and made a scattering of
the suitors through the house!”

226 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered

him:

227 “Cowherd — since you seem no bad man and
no fool,

228 and I can see for myself that good sense has
reached your heart,

229 I will tell you something, and swear a great
oath upon it:

230 Now Zeus be my witness, first of the gods, and
this table of friendship,³⁴

231 and the hearth of blameless Odysseus, to
which I have come:

232 while you are here, Odysseus will come home;

233 and with your own eyes, if you wish it, you
shall see

234 the killing of the suitors who play lord and
master here.”

235 Then the cowherd answered him, the master
of the oxen:

236 “Ah, stranger, if only the son of Cronos would
accomplish that word!

237 Then you would learn my strength — and how
my hands follow it.”³⁵

238 And in the same way Eumaeus prayed to all
the gods

239 that Odysseus of the many designs might
come home to his own house.

240 So they spoke to one another of such things.

241 And the suitors, meanwhile, were framing
death and doom

242 for Telemachus — when a bird came by on
their left hand:

243 an eagle flying high, gripping a trembling
dove.**36**

244 And Amphinomus rose and spoke among
them:

245 “Friends, this plan of ours will not run
smooth —

246 the killing of Telemachus. Let us think of the
feast.”**37**

247 So spoke Amphinomus, and his word pleased
them well.

248 They came into the house of godlike Odysseus

249 and laid their mantles down on the couches
and chairs

250 and slaughtered big sheep and fat goats,
251 slaughtered sleek hogs and a heifer of the
herd.
252 They roasted the innards and served them
round, and mixed
253 the wine in the mixing-bowls; and the
swineherd passed the cups,
254 and Philoetius, a leader of men, passed them
bread
255 in beautiful baskets; and Melanthius poured
the wine.**38**
256 And their hands went out to the good things
spread before them.
257 But Telemachus — his craft at work — seated
Odysseus**39**
258 inside the strong-built hall, beside the stone
threshold,
259 setting him a battered stool and a little table;
260 he put a portion of the innards by him, and
poured him wine
261 in a golden cup, and said to him:
262 “Sit here now among the men, and drink your

wine.

263 The taunts and the fists of all the suitors — I
myself

264 will hold them off you. This is no public
house:

265 it is Odysseus' house — and he won it for
me.**40**

266 And you, you suitors, hold your hearts back
from insult

267 and fists, so no strife and quarreling break
out.”

268 So he spoke; and they all bit their lips and
stared

269 in wonder at Telemachus, that he spoke so
boldly.**41**

270 And Antinous spoke among them, Eupeithes'
son:

271 “Hard as it is, Achaeans, let us take the word

272 of Telemachus — though how he threatens as
he talks!

273 Zeus the son of Cronos would not have it;
otherwise

274 we would have silenced him in the halls long
since — so clear a speaker.”42

275 So spoke Antinous; but he took no heed of his
words.

276 Now the heralds were leading through the
town the holy hecatomb

277 of the gods; and the long-haired Achaeans
gathered43

278 under the shady grove of Apollo who shoots
from afar.

279 And when they had roasted the outer flesh
and drawn it off,

280 they divided the portions and feasted the
glorious feast;

281 and the serving-men set beside Odysseus a
share

282 equal to the ones they drew themselves: for
so ordered

283 Telemachus, dear son of godlike Odysseus.

284 And Athena would not let the lordly suitors

285 hold back from heart-stinging outrage — so
that pain might sink

286 still deeper into Laertes' son Odysseus.44

287 There was among the suitors a man versed in
lawlessness:

288 Ctesippus was his name, and his home was on
Same;45

289 sure of his fabulous wealth, he had come

290 to woo the wife of Odysseus, the master so
long away.

291 He now spoke out among the overweening
suitors:

292 "Hear me, you lordly suitors, while I say a
word.

293 The stranger has long had his portion — an
equal one,

294 as is proper: it is not fine, and it is not just, to
stint

295 the guests of Telemachus, whoever comes to
this house.

296 But come — let me too give him a guest-gift,
so he in turn46

297 can hand a prize to the bath-woman, or to
some other

298 of the slaves in the house of godlike
Odysseus.”

299 So speaking, he snatched an ox-hoof out of
the basket

300 where it lay, and hurled it with his thick
hand. But Odysseus

301 dodged it with a quick tilt of his head, and
smiled in his heart

302 a smile most sardonic; and it struck the well-
built wall.⁴⁷

303 And Telemachus lashed Ctesippus with his
words:

304 “Ctesippus — count it clear profit for your
own heart:

305 you missed the stranger. He dodged the throw
himself.

306 Otherwise I would have run you through the
middle with my sharp spear,

307 and instead of a wedding your father would
be busy here

308 with a funeral. So: let no man show his
ugliness⁴⁸

309 in this house of mine. For now I take note and
I know each thing,

310 the good and the worse alike. Before, I was
still a child.

311 But even so we endure it and look on:

312 the flocks slaughtered, the wine drunk down,

313 the bread — for it is hard for one man to check
many.

314 Come then, do me no more evil in your
malice.

315 But if you are set on killing me — me myself —
with the bronze,

316 even that I would choose: it would be far
better

317 to die than look on forever at these
disgraceful doings:49

318 guests roughly handled, and men hauling the
slave-women

319 shamefully through the beautiful house.”

320 So he spoke; and they all fell silent and still.

321 At last Agelaus spoke, Damastor’s son:

322 “Friends — no man should take offense at a

just word spoken,⁵⁰

³²³ and answer it with wrangling and hard
speech.

³²⁴ Do not knock the stranger about, nor any
other

³²⁵ of the slaves in the house of godlike Odysseus.

³²⁶ But to Telemachus, and to his mother, I would
say

³²⁷ a gentle word — if it might find favor with the
hearts of both.

³²⁸ As long as the hearts in your breasts kept
hope

³²⁹ that Odysseus of the many designs would
come home to his own house,

³³⁰ no one could resent your waiting, or your
holding off

³³¹ the suitors in the halls: that was the better
way

³³² if Odysseus had returned, come back at last to
his house.

³³³ But now it is plain that he is past returning.

³³⁴ Go then, sit by your mother, and lay it out for

her:

335 marry the best man, the one who offers most

—

336 so you may keep and enjoy all that was your
father's,

337 eating and drinking, and she may keep
another's house."51

338 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered
him:

339 "No, by Zeus, Agelaus — and by the sufferings
of my father,

340 who far from Ithaca has perished, or still
wanders:

341 I do not delay my mother's marriage. I urge
her

342 to wed the man she chooses; and I offer gifts
past counting.

343 But I am ashamed to drive her from the hall
against her will

344 with a word of compulsion. May god never
bring that to pass."52

345 So spoke Telemachus. And in the suitors

Pallas Athena

346 set off unquenchable laughter, and knocked
their wits askew.**53**

347 And now they were laughing with jaws no
longer their own;

348 the meat they ate was dabbled in blood; and
their eyes

349 brimmed full of tears; and the heart in them
wanted to wail.

350 And godlike Theoclymenus spoke out among
them:

351 “Wretched men — what evil is this you suffer?
Night — your heads**54**

352 are shrouded in night, and your faces, and
your knees beneath;

353 wailing has caught like fire; cheeks are
streaming tears;

354 the walls are spattered with blood, and the
fine crossbeams;

355 and the porch is full of ghosts — the courtyard
full of them —

356 ghosts hurrying down to Erebus, under the

gloom; the sun

357 has perished out of the sky, and an evil mist
runs over everything.”

358 So he spoke; and they all laughed at him
sweetly.55

359 And Eurymachus, Polybus’ son, began to
speak among them:

360 “The stranger is raving — this new one, fresh
from abroad.

361 Quick, young men — see him out of the house
and on his way

362 to the assembly-place, since he finds it night
in here.”

363 Then godlike Theoclymenus said to him:

364 “Eurymachus, I ask no escort of you for my
going.

365 I have eyes, and ears, and both my feet,56

366 and a mind in my breast in no way meanly
made.

367 With these I am going out that door — for I
see evil coming

368 on you, evil no man will escape or dodge,

369 no man of you suitors, you who in the house
of godlike Odysseus

370 batter men with outrage and devise your
reckless deeds.”

371 So speaking he went out of the well-settled
house

372 and came to Piraeus, who received him
gladly.⁵⁷

373 And the suitors all, eyeing one another,

374 went to work needling Telemachus, laughing
at his guests;

375 and a man of the arrogant young men would
say:

376 “Telemachus, no man is unluckier in his
guests than you.

377 Look at this one you keep — this pawed-over
vagrant⁵⁸

378 who wants his bread and wine, who has no
skill for work

379 and no strength either: a dead weight on the
good earth.

380 And then the other one — he stood up to play

the prophet!

381 If you would listen to me, the profit is all
yours:

382 let us pitch your guests into a many-benched
ship

383 and send them to the Sicilians. There they
would fetch you a worthy price.”59

384 So the suitors talked; but he took no heed of
their words.

385 He watched his father in silence — waiting,
always,60

386 for the moment he would lay his hands on the
shameless suitors.

387 And she — she had set her beautiful chair
across from them:

388 Icarius’ daughter, watchful-minded Penelope,

389 and heard each man’s word in the halls.61

390 For laughing they had made their dinner
ready —

391 a sweet meal and a hearty one, for they had
slaughtered lavishly.

392 But no supper could ever be more graceless

than the supper

393 a goddess and a strong man were soon now to
set

394 before them. For they had begun it: the
shameful devising was theirs.62

Notes

NOTES

1. The bed itself is an indictment: an undressed oxhide, and fleeces “of the sheep the Achaeans kept slaughtering” — bedding that arrives tagged with its provenance: the king lies down on the by-products of his own devoured estate. The mantle on top is Eurynome’s small mercy. ↩
2. The disloyal women go out to the suitors “setting each other laughing” — past the master lying in the porch. The night audit he refused from Eurycleia (19.500ff) happens anyway, involuntarily: they file past his bed toward their own sentence. ↩
3. The bitch simile — his heart snarls over the household like a mother-dog over “soft-boned pups” facing a stranger. The tenderest guardian-image in the poem given to a rage for slaughter; what the heart wants to protect and what it wants to do are the same growl. This is the poem’s only look inside Odysseus at war with his own organ of feeling. ↩

4. “Bear up, my heart. A more dog-vile thing you bore” — κύντερον, “more dog-like,” snapping back at the dog-simile two lines up: the heart snarls like a bitch and is told it once endured something *doggier*. The self-address — struck chest, quoted speech to his own heart — became the archetype of self-command (Plato quotes it twice); the argument is a veteran’s: we survived the cave by craft, we outlast this by craft. ↩
5. The paunch simile: he tosses like a blood-sausage being turned over a blaze, “longing to have it roasted quickly.” The comparison is deliberately gross and deliberately chosen: it was the beggars’ prize at 18.44–45 — paunch “packed full of fat and blood” — and now the man who won that contest *is* one, stuffed with heat and urgency, almost done. Homeric similes rarely joke; this one does, at its hero’s expense. ↩
6. Athena’s opening is a goddess’s tease — “Here is your house; here is your wife” — as if the twenty-year problem were solved and the man merely forgetful. What she omits (the hundred and eight men between him and both) is exactly what he answers with. ↩
7. The second worry is the remarkable one: “even if I kill them... where do I run from what follows?” — the blood-feud. Odysseus is the only person in the poem planning past the climax: the suitors’ kin, the vendetta arithmetic of a small island. Book 24 will prove the worry exactly right; Athena’s answer here, as there, is essentially *I am the exit*. ↩
8. “Hard man!” — σκέτλιε, the same address she opened with at 13.293: her fond exasperation at a mortal who audits even a goddess’s guarantees. The rebuke that follows (“a person will

trust a weaker friend — a mortal one”) is the closest the poem comes to Athena stating what she is to him. ↩

9. “If fifty companies of mortal men stood round the two of us... even so you would drive away their cattle and sheep.” The promise is scaled in raids — not survival but *profit*: you would leave with the livestock. Athena knows her man; the reassurance is denominated in his own currency. ↩
10. The stagger of the sleepers: as sleep takes him, she wakes. All night the house has held one waking griever at a time, husband and wife trading the watch without knowing it — the poem’s image for the marriage itself these twenty years. ↩
11. The prayer to Artemis expands the wish of 18.202–205 into the poem’s darkest devotion: the arrow now, or the whirlwind — annihilation without burial, snatched off “down the ways of gloom” to the mouths of Ocean. She prays for the fate of the storm-taken, the worst end the Greek imagination offered a woman, in preference to “gladdening the mind of a lesser man.” ↩
12. The daughters of Pandareus — second tale from that house in a single night (the nightingale, 19.518ff, was their sister). Orphaned, fostered by four goddesses — Aphrodite’s food, Hera’s beauty and sense, Artemis’ height, Athena’s handwork — and, on the very day of their betrothal negotiations, carried off by the snatching-winds to serve the Furies. The myth is a machine for her meaning: divine care lavished for years, then annulled in an hour between promise and wedding — her own biography, read as a warning against hoping. ↩

13. “The snatching-winds carried the girls away and gave them over to the hateful Furies”: ἄρπυιαι — the harpies as functionaries of a transaction between storms and vengeance-spirits. The bureaucratic horror of it (girls “given over to serve”) is the point: some fates are not deaths but permanent disappearances into service — which is also a description of slavery, the poem’s other abyss. ↩
14. “That with Odysseus before my eyes I may pass even under the hateful earth”: the prayer’s kernel — she will accept Hades if she can go down still *seeing* him (ὄσσομένη — with him before her mind’s eye). Not reunion; just unreplaced. The alternative — a lesser man gladdened — is what this very day’s contest offers, and this prayer is her true position on it. ↩
15. The dream that torments her is a good one: Odysseus beside her “as he was when he went with the army” — young, and she “thought it no dream, but the waking truth at last” (ὕπαρ — the word of 19.547). The cruelty is in the waking; the accuracy is in the timing; a man like him *is* in the house tonight. Her dreams are now running ahead of her information. ↩
16. He hears her weeping and half-dreams awake: “it seemed to him... that she knew him already, and stood beside his head.” His fantasy and her dream reach for each other across the house — she dreamed him beside her; he imagines her beside him, *recognizing*. Two rooms apart, the marriage is dreaming symmetrically; only the plot holds the doors shut. ↩
17. The double-omen prayer: a φήμη (spoken omen) from someone waking indoors, and a τέρας of Zeus outside. He specifies the evidentiary standard — two independent channels — like the

strategist he is; Zeus fills the order in reverse: thunder from a clear sky, then the mill-woman. ↩

18. The mills, “the marrow of men” (μυελὸν ἀνδρῶν) — barley and wheat as civilization’s bone-fill, ground by twelve women. Twelve: the number of the disloyal maids (22.424). The poem’s arithmetic of the household keeps its books in dozens. ↩
19. The mill-woman’s kledon — the frailest of the twelve grinders, the last one at the stone, is granted the poem’s decisive curse: “may they sup now their last!” Her authority is her exhaustion (“who have loosed my knees”) — the suitors’ feast priced in one worker’s body. Zeus thunders for her; the great revenge is countersigned at the bottom of the labor hierarchy. ↩
20. “Rejoiced at the omen of her word” — the kledon-formula of 18.117 again. Twice now the suitors’ doom has been ratified by chance speech: their own blessing then, a slave’s curse now. He “told himself the guilty would pay” — τίσασθαι: the ledger-verb; the day’s business is now booked. ↩
21. Telemachus’ morning question needles his mother in absentia — she honors the worse man, slights the better “on impulse” (ἐμπλήγδην). It is camouflage (he must not seem to prize the beggar) laid over real grievance, and it is unjust; Eurycleia’s correction (135ff) is precise: the guest got everything he would accept. The performance of casualness now runs even inside the family. ↩
22. “Do not blame the blameless woman” — Eurycleia’s report is an innkeeper’s docket: wine as long as he liked, bread declined and offered, bed refused, mantle laid over him anyway. The

house's kindness is documented against the boy's slander; the nurse audits even her masters. ↩

23. Eurycleia gets her full formal genealogy — “daughter of Ops, Peisenor’s son” — as she issues the day’s work orders. The poem dignifies the head-of-staff with a patronymic at the exact moment the house is scrubbed for its own liberation: sweep, sprinkle, crimson coverings, sponges, rinsed bowls — the massacre’s venue is being cleaned for it. ↩
24. “It is festival for everyone today” — the feast of Apollo, the archer-god, casually flagged by a housekeeper. The deadline sworn twice by the beggar (14.161–162 = 19.306–307: “between this month’s waning and the rising of the next”) lands today, the dark of the moon, Apollo’s day: the bow’s own god presides over the bow’s return to work. ↩
25. Melanthius abuses the beggar again (17.217ff, the kick; now the fists-threat) — strikes entered in the record a day apart; his sentence (22.474ff) will be read against this docket. Odysseus answers with the fixed line of silence — the head-shake, the deep-brooded evils (= 17.465 = 17.491). ↩
26. The fixed line of endured insult — head shaken, silence kept, “brooding evils deep in his heart” — now in its third appearance (17.465 after the footstool, 17.491 the son’s copy, here after Melanthius’ taunt). The formula has become the beggar’s standard receipt: abuse deposited, nothing said, interest accruing. ↩
27. “A third came in — Philoetius, a leader of men” (ῥαχαιὸς ἀνδρῶν, Eumaeus’ own title): the cowherd, the poem’s last major loyalist, introduced at dawn on the last day. The trio is

now assembled — swineherd, goatherd, cowherd: loyal, traitor, loyal — the estate's whole moral range walking in with its animals. ↩

28. Philoetius reads the beggar in one look: “in build he is like a lord, a king” — then supplies the theology that explains the rags: the gods sink wanderers in misery “when they spin hard sorrow even for kings.” He sees through the disguise to the *type* and reasons correctly about the god-spun exception; no one in the poem gets closer on sight alone. ↩
29. His greeting repeats Amphinomus' toast word for word (18.122–123): “Your health, father stranger!...” — the loyal cowherd and the doomed half-decent suitor share one blessing-formula. The poem files them together deliberately: the two men in the hall who wished the beggar well — one will be armed by him, the other killed by his son. ↩
30. “Father Zeus — no other god is deadlier than you: you have no pity on men, though you begot them yourself.” The boldest theological complaint in Homer — spoken not by a hero in a storm but by a herdsman upset about cattle. Philoetius arraigns Zeus for fathering men into misery, then goes straight on weeping about his master's rags: doctrine and devotion in one breath, the working man's metaphysics. ↩
31. “I broke sweat when I saw him” (ἰδίων) — grief as a physical event: the cowherd sweats at the sight of a beggar because the beggar makes him *see* Odysseus in rags somewhere. His body recognizes what his mind dare not: the sweat is for the man in front of him. ↩

32. The herd report: broad-browed cattle come on “like standing wheat” — increase past counting, all of it requisitioned by “strangers” who “do not tremble at the gods’ watching eye” (ἄπις — divine surveillance). Philoetius’ complaint doubles as the estate’s account-book: the wealth is intact, the extraction is total, the auditor is standing in front of him disguised. ↩
33. The loyalist’s dilemma, stated exactly: flee with the herds to a foreign king (betray the son), or stay and serve the thieves (suffer). He has chosen the “colder” option — staying — held by one hypothesis: “what if he came from somewhere...!” Eumaeus’ loyalty is love of persons; Philoetius’ is loyalty *under stated analysis*, which the poem may rate even higher: he has done the math and stayed anyway. ↩
34. The oath to Philoetius = the oath to Eumaeus (14.158–160): Zeus, the table of friendship, the hearth of blameless Odysseus. The formula’s third swearing (19.303–304 to Penelope between them), and this time the payoff is explicit: “with your own eyes, if you wish it, you shall see the killing of the suitors.” Each loyalist is issued the same bond; redemption falls due before the day is out. ↩
35. “Then you would learn my strength — and how my hands follow it.” Philoetius answers the oath with an enlistment; Eumaeus co-signs with a prayer. The muster is complete: the hall now holds four fighters, and only one of them knows it. ↩
36. The eagle-with-dove on the left — the same sign that blessed Telemachus’ departure (15.525ff) now blocks his murder: omens keep intervening between the suitors and the boy. Amphinomus reads it instantly and correctly — his third and

last decent act, once again the minimum: not “stop,” only “not today; let us think of the feast.” The feast he defers to is the one the mill-woman cursed. ↩

37. “This plan of ours will not run smooth” — συνθεύσεται, a racing word: the plot won’t *run with us*. Amphinomus’ idiom is a gambler’s, and accurate: every start the suitors make now is scratched by heaven. ↩

38. The service of the last feast: Eumaeus passes cups, Philoetius the bread, Melanthius pours the wine. The staffing chart is the battle-plan in embryo — two loyalists and the traitor handling the suitors’ food and drink; within hours the same three hands will hold the doors, the arms-store, and nothing. ↩

39. “His craft at work” (κέρδεα νωμῶν) — Telemachus seats his father inside the hall by the stone threshold, with a battered stool, a little table, an equal portion, and a golden cup: degradation staged to the eye, parity delivered in fact. The arrangement is tactical (the threshold is where the bow will be shot from) and filial in the poem’s peculiar key — the son can honor his father only in the grammar of hospitality to a beggar. ↩

40. “This is no public house: it is Odysseus’ house — and he won it for me.” The plainest property-law sentence in the poem, spoken over the property’s owner drinking from the golden cup. Every word doubles: the house is indeed not public, is indeed Odysseus’, and the *he won it* (ἐκτήσατο) quietly asserts the acquisition ethic — this estate was earned, and its earner is present. ↩

41. Lips bitten, bold speech marveled at = 18.410–411 verbatim: the second time in two days the hall has had to swallow Telemachus whole. The formula's return marks the trend: each performance of authority is stronger, and the silences after them longer. ↩
42. Antinous' reply concedes everything in a sneer: "Zeus would not have it; otherwise we would have silenced him long since." The confession is casual and complete — only heaven's veto has kept Telemachus alive — and it is spoken as a complaint. The suitors now blame Zeus for their own unfinished murder; the theology is truer than they know. ↩
43. The town's festival procession — hecatomb through the streets, the people gathering in Apollo's shady grove — runs in parallel montage with the hall's last feast: outside, Ithaca worships the archer; inside, the archer's day is being kept another way. The cut back and forth is the poem's quiet liturgical joke. ↩
44. Athena's goad, verbatim from 18.346–348: the outrage must not slacken, "so that pain might sink still deeper." The goddess re-administers the dose on schedule — the second day running — topping up the rage this very day will spend. Divine cruelty as fuel logistics. ↩
45. Ctesippus, "a man versed in lawlessness" — ἀθεμίστια εἰδώς, the Cyclopes' adjective (9.106): the poem introduces its newest suitor with the vocabulary of monsters. Rich, from Same, and defined before he acts: what follows is not a lapse but a credential. ↩
46. The "guest-gift" speech is the suitors' cruelty at its most refined: a parody of xenia protocol — the stranger has had his

portion, propriety demands I add a ξείνιον — with the gift an ox-hoof from the scrap basket. Where Antinous threw in rage and Eurymachus in drunken pique, Ctesippus throws as *satire*: the institution itself mocked. It is the escalation that matters: the abuse has become theater. ↩

47. The dodge and the smile: “a smile most sardonic” — σαρδάνιον, the first occurrence in literature of the word that became “sardonic.” A smile in the heart, behind the face, at the moment a bone aimed at his head hits the wall: the whole disguise in one adverb. The etymology was debated even in antiquity (the Sardinian herb that twists the mouth of the dying?); the poem’s usage needs no botany — it is the smile of a man filing a debt. ↩

48. “Instead of a wedding your father would be busy here with a funeral”: Telemachus’ threat runs on the same rails as the beggar’s curse on Antinous (17.476, death “before any wedding”) — marriage and burial as the two feasts a suitor might get. For Ctesippus the account settles at 22.285ff, when Philoetius’ spear takes him — with a taunt about ox-hooves attached. ↩

49. Lines 316–319 repeat, nearly word for word, what the disguised Odysseus said at 16.106–111: better to die than watch guests manhandled and slave-women hauled through the beautiful house. Telemachus was in the hut when his father said it; now he speaks it as his own in open hall. The father’s ethic, overheard once, has become the son’s public platform — the poem’s way of showing an inheritance delivered. ↩

50. Agelaus opens with Amphinomus' exact lines (18.414–417: no offense at a just word; hands off the stranger and the slaves) — the reasonable-suitor script now circulating as a formula. The decency of the doomed is interchangeable; the poem keeps showing that moderation without withdrawal is just politeness on the way to the same spear (Agelaus falls at 22.293). ↩
51. Agelaus' proposal is the suitors' case in its best dress: the waiting was honorable while hope lasted; hope is gone; sit by your mother and settle the marriage — you keep the estate, she keeps another's house. It is reasonable, humane in tone, and rests entirely on one premise ("now it is plain that he is past returning") that is false by the width of the room. ↩
52. Telemachus' oath — "by Zeus, and by the sufferings of my father" — swears by the very thing the room denies exists. His position is exact and unimpeachable: the marriage is urged, dowered, and un-forced; "I am ashamed to drive her out against her will." He has said it before (2.130ff); saying it *now*, with his father listening and the contest hours away, it becomes the last word on the subject the suitors will ever hear. ↩
53. The Athena-maddened laughter — the most frightening lines in the poem. She "knocked their wits askew," and they laugh "with jaws no longer their own" (γναθμοῖσι ἄλλοτρίοισιν); the meat runs blood; their eyes fill with tears while the laughter continues; "the heart in them wanted to wail." Possession as comedy breaking down into grief — the body's future (bleeding, wept-over) surfacing through its present (feasting, laughing). The suitors experience their own deaths as a mood

they cannot account for; 18.100's idiom ("died laughing") has begun to come literally true. ↩

54. Theoclymenus' vision — the apocalypse of the noonday hall: night shrouding heads, faces, knees; wailing "caught like fire"; blood on walls and crossbeams; porch and courtyard packed with ghosts "hurrying down to Erebus"; the sun perished from the sky; the mist running over everything. Seven lines of second sight, every clause redeemed in Book 22 (the shrouded heads, the spattered walls, the following dusk). This is the seer's third and greatest utterance — after the omen (15.531ff) and the hearth-oath (17.155ff) — and the poem's only sustained prophetic *vision*: not a bird read but the thing itself seen — a sun perished at noon, which no dark of the moon can explain. ↩

55. "They all laughed at him sweetly" (ἡδὺ γέλασσαν) — the same "sweet" laughter that has run through their scenes since Book 2, now directed at a man describing their corpses. The possession-laughter of 345–349 has subsided into ordinary mockery: they have been shown the ending and find it funny. No damnation in the poem is more complete than this amusement. ↩

56. Theoclymenus' exit speech is the dignity of the functioning senses: "I have eyes, and ears, and both my feet, and a mind in no way meanly made" — inventory of a working prophet, walking out on his own equipment. He needs no escort *because he can see* — the precise faculty the room has just proven it lacks. His final sentence, evil "no man of you will escape or dodge," closes the seer's own tally of refused warnings: omen, thunder, vision, and the man who read them all. ↩

57. He goes to Piraeus — the same harbor-friend who took him in at 15.539ff. The seer's arc closes where it began: received by the one reliably hospitable man in the town. He exits the poem here, the only guest who saw everything and left before it happened — Ithaca's Cassandra, believed by no one and unbloodied. ↩
58. The anonymous suitor's résumé of the beggar — “no skill for work and no strength either: a dead weight on the good earth” (ἄχθος ἀρούρης, Achilles' own phrase of self-reproach, Il. 18.104) — grades the man who out-plowed and out-mowed their kind in his challenge-speech (18.366ff) and will string the great bow of the house within the day. The mockery inventory is exactly inverted; every clause is about to be refuted with a corpse. ↩
59. “Send them to the Sicilians — there they would fetch you a worthy price” (ἄξιον... ἄλφοι): the slave-sale idiom of Eumaeus' childhood (15.388, 429 — “he paid a worthy price”) aimed now at Odysseus and Theoclymenus. Selling guests west into slavery is the suitors' final proposal on the subject of hospitality; the word “price” is the last item in their xenia file. ↩
60. “He watched his father in silence — waiting, always, for the moment”: Telemachus' whole interior compressed to a gaze. The line is built of the plan's key words (16.274ff: endure, watch, wait for the sign); the discipline ordered in the hut is now visible as posture at the feast. Around him the hall laughs; the son is a cocked trigger politely passing bread. ↩

61. Penelope's chair, set "across from them" — she has positioned herself to hear every word in the hall: the taunts, her son's oath, the seer's vision. The queen sits through the last feast as its audience, in plain view and listening; whatever she knows or half-knows when she rises to fetch the bow, the poem has put her within earshot of everything. ↩
62. The closing sentence sets the two feasts side by side: the dinner they cooked "laughing" — sweet, hearty, lavish — and the supper "a goddess and a strong man were soon now to set before them," than which "none could ever be more graceless" (ἀχαρίστερον: without χάρις, grace, thanks, pleasure — the unfeast). The last clause is the poem's whole verdict on the revenge, delivered as table-manners: *they had begun it; the shameful devising was theirs*. Book 21 opens with the bow. ↩

Odyssey — Book 21

The bow: pedigree, contest, recruitment, and the stringing.

- 1 And now the goddess put it in her mind — gray-eyed Athena,
2 in the mind of Icarius' daughter, watchful-minded Penelope —
3 to set before the suitors the bow and the gray iron
4 in the halls of Odysseus: the contest, and the beginning of the slaughter.¹
5 She climbed the high stairway of her house
6 and took the bent key in her strong hand —
7 a beautiful key of bronze, with an ivory handle —²
8 and went her way with her attendant women
9 to the last storeroom. There the master's treasures lay:
10 bronze, and gold, and iron wrought with labor.

11 And there lay the backsprung bow, and the
quiver
12 for the arrows, with many groan-laden shafts
inside —³
13 gifts that a guest-friend gave him when they
met in Lacedaemon:
14 Iphitus, Eurytus' son, a man like the
immortals.⁴
15 The two had crossed paths in Messene,
16 in the house of thoughtful Ortilochus.
Odysseus
17 had come to collect a debt the whole people
owed him:
18 for Messenian men had lifted sheep out of
Ithaca —
19 three hundred, with their herdsmen — in their
many-benched ships.
20 For their sake Odysseus came that long road on
embassy,
21 a boy still, sent out by his father and the other
elders.⁵
22 And Iphitus came hunting horses — twelve

mares

23 he had lost, with hard-working mules at suck
beneath them —

24 the same mares that afterward became his
death and doom,

25 when he came to the strong-hearted son of
Zeus,

26 the man Heracles, that expert in great deeds,

27 who killed him — a guest in his own house.⁶

28 Ruthless: no shame before the gods' watching
eye, nor for the table

29 he himself had set the man; he killed him even
so,

30 and kept the strong-hoofed mares in his own
halls.

31 Asking after these, Iphitus met Odysseus, and
gave him the bow

32 that great Eurytus carried in the old days, and
left

33 to his son at his death in the high house.

34 And Odysseus gave him a sharp sword and a
strong spear —

35 the start of a binding friendship; but they
never knew
36 each other's tables: before that, the son of Zeus
killed
37 Iphitus, Eurytus' son, that man like the
immortals,
38 who gave the bow. And noble Odysseus never
39 took it with him going to war in the black
ships:
40 it stood in his halls at home, a memorial
41 of a beloved guest-friend; on his own land he
carried it.⁷
42 And when she reached that storeroom, the
shining among women,
43 and stepped up on the oak threshold — which
a carpenter once
44 planed with skill and trued to the line,
45 and fixed the doorposts in it, and hung the
shining doors —
46 at once she quickly loosed the thong from the
hook,
47 slid in the key, and shot back the bolts of the

doors

48 with a straight thrust. And they bellowed like a
bull⁸

49 at pasture in a meadow — so loud the beautiful
doors

50 bellowed at the key's stroke; and they flew
open before her.

51 She stepped up onto the high floor, where the
chests

52 stood full of clothing laid away in fragrance.

53 Reaching up from there she took the bow off
its peg,

54 bright in the bow-case that enclosed it.

55 And she sat down right there, with the case on
her knees,

56 and wept aloud, and shrill, and drew out the
master's bow.⁹

57 And when she had taken her fill of tear-heavy
mourning,

58 she went her way to the hall, to the lordly
suitors,

59 holding in her hand the backsprung bow and

the quiver

60 for the arrows, with many groan-laden shafts
inside;

61 and beside her handmaids carried the box
where the iron

62 lay in plenty, and the bronze: the master's gear
of contest.

63 And when she reached the suitors, shining
among women,

64 she stood beside the pillar of the close-built
roof,

65 holding her glistening veil before her cheeks,

66 a trusted handmaid standing on either side,10

67 and spoke at once among the suitors, and said
her word:

68 "Hear me, you lordly suitors, who have
fastened on this house11

69 to eat and drink your way through it without
ever a pause,

70 its master long gone; nor could you offer any
other

71 excuse in all this time, any word at all,

72 except your lust to marry me and take me to
wife.

73 Well then, you suitors — come: here stands
your prize before you.

74 I set out the great bow of godlike Odysseus.

75 Whoever strings the bow most easily in his
hands

76 and shoots an arrow through all twelve axes —

77 him I will follow, forsaking this house,

78 this house of my marriage, this beautiful
house, full of all

79 that sustains life. I think I shall remember it
even in my dreams.”¹²

80 So she spoke, and told Eumaeus, the noble
swineherd,

81 to set the bow before the suitors, and the gray
iron.

82 In tears Eumaeus took them and laid them
down;

83 and the cowherd wept on his side, when he
saw the master’s bow.¹³

84 And Antinous rebuked them, and spoke a

word, and named them:

85 “Idiot rustics! — brains that stop at the day’s
end!”¹⁴

86 Wretched pair, why are you streaming tears,
and stirring up

87 the heart in the woman’s breast? Her heart lies
deep enough

88 in grief already, since she lost her dear
husband.

89 Sit and feast in silence — or take your bawling

90 outside, the two of you, and leave the bow
right here,

91 a trial for the suitors none will slip through: for
I do not think

92 this polished bow is going to be strung with
ease.

93 There is no man in this whole company

94 such as Odysseus was. I saw him myself —

95 I remember it well — though I was still a
witless child.”¹⁵

96 So he spoke; but the heart in his breast was
hoping

97 that he would string the bow and shoot
through the iron.

98 In fact he was to be the first to taste an
arrow¹⁶

99 from the hands of blameless Odysseus — the
man he was dishonoring

100 that moment, sitting in his hall, and egging
on all his companions.

101 And the sacred strength of Telemachus spoke
among them:

102 “Ah — Zeus the son of Cronos has made me
witless!¹⁷

103 My own dear mother — sensible as she is —
declares

104 she will follow another man and forsake this
house;

105 and I laugh, and enjoy it, with my witless
heart.

106 Come then, you suitors — since here stands
your prize:

107 a woman whose like there is not now in all
Achaëa,

108 not in holy Pylos, not in Argos or Mycenae,
109 not on Ithaca itself, not on the dark mainland

—

110 but you know that yourselves. Why should I
praise my mother?

111 Come — no dodges, no dragging it out; no
more

112 hanging back from the stringing of the bow.
Let us see it!

113 And I myself might make a trial of the bow as
well:

114 for if I string it, and shoot through the iron,
115 then it would be no grief to me that my
honored mother

116 should leave this house and follow another
man — since I would stay behind

117 man enough at last to lift my father's beautiful
prizes.”**18**

118 He spoke, and flung the crimson cloak from
his shoulders,

119 rising to his full height, and put off the sharp
sword from his shoulder.

120 First he set up the axes, digging one long
trench

121 for all of them, trued to a line,

122 and stamped the earth firm round them.

Amazement took every man

123 who watched — how squarely he set them,
who had never seen it before.19

124 Then he went and stood on the threshold and
began to try the bow.

125 Three times he set it shaking, hot to draw it
home;

126 three times he eased his force, hoping still in
his heart

127 to string the cord and shoot through the iron.

128 And now, hauling a fourth time, his strength
would have strung it —

129 but Odysseus shook his head, and checked
him, keen as he was.20

130 And the sacred strength of Telemachus spoke
among them again:

131 “Ah — so I will be a weakling and a coward all
my days!

132 Or I am too young yet, and cannot trust my
hands

133 to defend a man when someone picks a
quarrel first.²¹

134 Come then, you who are stronger than I am —
135 come try the bow, and let us finish out the
contest.”

136 So speaking he set the bow away from him on
the ground,

137 leaning it against the joined and polished
panels,

138 with the swift arrow propped on the fine
door-hook there,

139 and sat back down on the chair from which he
had risen.

140 And Antinous spoke among them, Eupheithes’
son:

141 “Up, all you companions — in order, left to
right,

142 starting from where the wine is always
poured.”²²

143 So spoke Antinous, and his word pleased them

well.

144 And the first to rise was Leodes, the son of
Oenops,

145 who was their sacrifice-diviner, and always sat

146 in the farthest corner by the beautiful mixing-
bowl: to him alone

147 their reckless outrages were hateful; he was
indignant at all the suitors.²³

148 He now was first to take the bow and the swift
arrow,

149 and went and stood on the threshold and
began to try the bow.

150 He could not string it: long before that,
hauling, his hands

151 gave out — his soft, unhardened hands; and he
said among the suitors:

152 “Friends, I cannot bend it. Let another take it
now.

153 Many chief men this bow is going to strip²⁴

154 of life and breath — since truly it is better far

155 to die than live on and miss the mark we
gather here for

156 day upon day, forever, waiting on hope.
157 Now every man of you hopes, every heart is
set
158 on marrying Penelope, Odysseus' bedmate.
159 But once he has tried the bow, and seen —
160 well, let him woo some other fair-robed
Achaean woman
161 with his bride-gifts then, and seek her; and let
this one
162 marry the man who gives the most, and
comes as her fate.”
163 So he spoke his say, and set the bow away
from him,
164 leaning it against the joined and polished
panels,
165 with the swift arrow propped on the fine
door-hook there,
166 and sat back down on the chair from which he
had risen.
167 And Antinous rebuked him, and spoke a word,
and named him:
168 “Leodes — what a word has slipped the fence

of your teeth!²⁵

¹⁶⁹ A dreadful word, a bitter one — I am angry
just to hear it —

¹⁷⁰ that this bow, if you please, will strip our chief
men

¹⁷¹ of life and breath — because you cannot string
it!

¹⁷² No: your honored mother did not bear you the
kind of man

¹⁷³ who has it in him to draw a bow and shoot;

¹⁷⁴ but the other lordly suitors will string it, and
soon.”

¹⁷⁵ So he spoke, and gave his orders to Melanthius
the goatherd:

¹⁷⁶ “Look alive, Melanthius — light a fire in the
hall,

¹⁷⁷ and set a big bench by it with a fleece on top,

¹⁷⁸ and bring out the great wheel of lard from the
stores inside,

¹⁷⁹ so we young men can warm the bow, and
grease it

¹⁸⁰ with the fat, and try it, and finish out the

contest.”

181 So he spoke; and Melanthius quickly kindled
the unwearying fire,

182 and carried up the bench and set it there with
a fleece on it,

183 and brought out the great wheel of lard from
the stores inside.

184 With that the young men warmed the bow
and made their trials — and still

185 they could not string it: they fell far short of
the strength it took.26

186 But Antinous still held off, and godlike
Eurymachus,

187 the suitors’ chiefs: in prowess they were far
the best of them.27

188 Now out of the house those two had gone
together,

189 the cowherd and the swineherd of godlike
Odysseus,

190 and after them Odysseus himself, the noble
one, came out.

191 And when they were outside the doors and

the courtyard,

192 he raised his voice and spoke to them with
gentle words:

193 “Cowherd — and you, swineherd — shall I say
a thing to you, 28

194 or keep it to myself? My heart tells me to say
it.

195 What kind of men would you be, to fight for
Odysseus,

196 if he came from somewhere — like that, out of
nowhere — some god bringing him?

197 Would you fight for the suitors, or for
Odysseus?

198 Speak out, as your heart and spirit bid you.”

199 Then the cowherd answered him, the master
of the oxen:

200 “Father Zeus, if only you would accomplish
this desire:

201 that the man himself come back, and a god
guide him home — 29

202 then you would learn my strength, and how
my hands follow it!”

203 And in the same way Eumaeus prayed to all
the gods

204 that Odysseus of the many designs might
come home to his own house.

205 And when he had proof of the true mind in
both of them,

206 he found words again, and said to them in
answer:

207 “He is home — here — I am the man myself.
After suffering many pains,³⁰

208 I have come in the twentieth year to my
fathers’ land.

209 And I know that of all my slaves, to you two
only

210 my coming is what you prayed for. Of the rest
I have heard

211 not one man praying that I come home
again.³¹

212 So to you two I will tell the whole truth of
what shall be.

213 If a god brings the haughty suitors down
beneath my hands,

214 I will find wives for you both, and give you
possessions,
215 and houses built near mine; and from that day
216 you shall be to me the companions and
brothers of Telemachus.**32**
217 And come — I will show you a plain sign
besides,
218 so you may know me for certain and trust it in
your hearts:
219 the scar — the wound the boar dealt me with
its white tusk
220 when I went to Parnassus with the sons of
Autolycus.”**33**
221 So speaking, he drew the rags back from the
great scar.
222 And when the two had seen it, and taken in
each detail,
223 they wept, and threw their arms round
thoughtful Odysseus,
224 and kissed his head and shoulders, welcoming
him home;
225 and in the same way Odysseus kissed their

heads and hands.**34**

226 And the light of the sun would have gone
down on their weeping

227 had not Odysseus himself checked them, and
said:**35**

228 “Enough of weeping and wailing — someone
coming out

229 of the hall might see, and tell them there
inside.

230 Go back in one at a time, not all together:

231 I first, you after. And let this be the signal:

232 all the others — all the lordly suitors — will
refuse

233 to let the bow and quiver be given to me;

234 but you, noble Eumaeus, carry the bow up the
hall

235 and set it in my hands; and tell the women

236 to bar the close-fitted doors of their quarters,

237 and if any one of them hears groaning or the
crash of men

238 inside our walls, let her not run out,

239 but stay where she is, at her work, in silence.

240 And you, noble Philoetius: your charge is the
courtyard gates —
241 bolt them with the bar, and quickly lash the
fastening on.”**36**
242 So speaking he entered the well-settled house
243 and went and sat on the stool from which he
had risen;
244 and then the two slaves of godlike Odysseus
came in too.
245 Eurymachus by now was handling the bow,
246 warming it this side and that at the glow of
the fire —
247 and even so he could not string it. His proud
heart groaned aloud,
248 and bursting out in anger he spoke a word
and named it:
249 “Damn it — here is a grief for me, for myself
and for us all!
250 It is not the marriage I mourn so much,
though that stings too:
251 there are plenty of other Achaean women,
some right here

252 in sea-circled Ithaca, some in other towns.

253 No — it is that we fall so far short in strength

254 of godlike Odysseus that we cannot string

255 his bow. A disgrace for even men unborn to

hear of!”**37**

256 Then Antinous answered him, Eupheithes’ son:

257 “Eurymachus, it will not stand so — and you

know it yourself.

258 Today, through all the land, is the feast of the

god —

259 his holy day. Who could be bending bows? No

—**38**

260 set it down and be easy. And the axes: why

not leave them

261 standing, all of them? No one, I think, will

carry them off —

262 no thief is coming into the hall of Laertes’ son

Odysseus.**39**

263 Come — let the cupbearer pour first-drops in

the cups,

264 so we can make libation, and lay aside the

curved bow;

265 and in the morning tell Melanthius the
goatherd
266 to drive in goats, the pick of all his herds,
267 so we can lay thigh-pieces on the altar of
Apollo, lord of the bow,
268 and then try the bow, and finish out the
contest.”
269 So spoke Antinous, and his word pleased
them well.
270 And heralds poured water over their hands,
271 and young men crowned the mixing-bowls
with drink
272 and served it round to all, with first-drops in
the cups.
273 And when they had poured, and drunk as
much as their hearts would have,
274 Odysseus of the many designs, with craft in
mind, spoke among them:
275 “Hear me, you suitors of the far-famed queen,
276 while I say what the heart in my breast
commands.
277 To Eurymachus above all, and to godlike

Antinous,

278 I make my plea — since he spoke this word
too as it should be:

279 for now, let the bow rest; turn it over to the
gods;

280 and in the morning the god will give the
mastery to whom he will.**40**

281 But come — give me the polished bow, so
among you

282 I can try my hands and my strength: whether
the force

283 is still there, that once lived in my supple
limbs,

284 or wandering and neglect have destroyed it
by now.”**41**

285 So he spoke; and they were all outraged past
measure,

286 in dread that he would string the polished
bow.**42**

287 And Antinous rebuked him, and spoke a word,
and named him:

288 “You wretched stranger — not a grain of

sense in you, not a trace!

289 Is it not enough that you feast at your ease
with us,

290 the great ones — never stinted of the meal,
listening in

291 on all our speeches and our talk? No other
stranger,

292 no beggar, gets to listen to our speeches.43

293 It is the wine that has you — the honey-sweet:
it damages

294 any man who gulps it wide-mouthed past his
measure.

295 Wine — it was wine that maddened the
Centaur, famous Eurytion,44

296 in the hall of great-hearted Peirithous,

297 on his visit to the Lapiths. And when the wine
had maddened his wits,

298 raving mad he did his evil in Peirithous'
house;

299 and grief seized the heroes, and they leapt up
and dragged him

300 out through the porch to the open air, and

shore away

301 his ears and nose with the pitiless bronze; and
he, his wits

302 destroyed, went off in his witless heart,
hauling his ruin with him.

303 From that came the feud between Centaurs
and men;

304 but he found the evil first for himself, heavy
with wine.

305 Just so I proclaim great trouble for you, if you
should string

306 that bow. You will meet no kindness

307 in this land of ours — we will pack you
straight off in a black ship

308 to King Echetus, the maimer of all
mankind, 45

309 and out of his hands nothing will save you. Sit
easy,

310 drink, and do not set yourself against younger
men.”

311 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

312 “Antinous — it is not fine, and it is not just, to
stint⁴⁶

313 the guests of Telemachus, whoever comes to
this house.

314 Do you think — if this stranger strings the
great bow of Odysseus,

315 trusting his hands and his own strength —

316 that he will lead me home and make me his
wife?

317 He himself has no such hope in his breast.⁴⁷

318 Let none of you sit at the feast here grieving

319 over that: it would not be seemly — no, and it
is not thinkable.”

320 Then Eurymachus, Polybus’ son, answered
her:

321 “Daughter of Icarius, watchful-minded
Penelope,

322 it is not that we think he will lead you off —
unthinkable —

323 but we shrink from the talk of men and
women:

324 that one of the baser Achaeans may say

someday,

325 'Men far weaker are wooing a blameless man's

326 wife — and they cannot even string his
polished bow;

327 and then some other man, a wandering
beggar, came

328 and strung the bow with ease, and shot
through the iron.'

329 So they will say; and for us that would be
shame heaped on shame."48

330 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

331 "Eurymachus — there is no fair fame in the
land, and cannot be,

332 for men who dishonor and devour the house

333 of their better. Why count this thing your
shame?49

334 The stranger here is very tall, and firmly
built,

335 and declares himself the son of a well-born
father.

336 Come — give him the polished bow. Let us see

it.

337 For I will say this outright, and it will be
accomplished:

338 if he strings it — if Apollo grants him that
glory —

339 I will dress him in a cloak and a tunic, fine
clothing,⁵⁰

340 and give him a sharp javelin, to keep off dogs
and men,

341 and a two-edged sword; and I will give him
sandals for his feet,

342 and send him wherever his heart and spirit
bid him go.”

343 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered her:

344 “Mother mine — the bow: no Achaean has
better right than I

345 to give it or to refuse it to whomever I will —

346 not one of all who lord it through rocky
Ithaca,

347 nor in the islands over toward horse-grazing
Elis:

348 not one of them shall force me against my

will, not even if I choose

349 to give the stranger this bow outright, to
carry off for good.

350 Go into the house and see to your own work,
351 the loom and the distaff, and command your
handmaids

352 to go about their work. The bow belongs to
men —

353 to all men, and to me above all: mine is the
power in this house.”51

354 In wonder, she went back into the house,
355 for she laid her son’s clear-headed word to
heart.

356 Climbing to her upper room with her serving-
women,

357 she wept there for Odysseus, her dear
husband, until

358 gray-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her
eyelids.52

359 And the noble swineherd had taken up the
curved bow and was carrying it —

360 and the suitors, all of them, burst out

shouting through the halls;

361 and a man of the arrogant young men would
say:

362 “Where are you carrying that curved bow, you
pitiful swineherd —

363 you drifter? Soon enough, out with your pigs,
alone, away from men,

364 the swift dogs you raised yourself will eat you
— if Apollo

365 will only be gracious to us, and the other
deathless gods.”53

366 So they spoke; and he set the bow down
where he stood, carrying it no further,

367 frightened, because the crowd of them was
shouting through the halls.54

368 But Telemachus, from the other side, called
out his threat:

369 “Old father — carry the bow on. You will soon
be sorry, obeying them all.

370 Watch out, or younger though I am I will
chase you into the fields

371 pelting you with stones. In strength I am the

better man.

372 If only I stood as far above all the suitors
373 in this house — in force of hands and strength
—

374 I would soon send more than one of them off
in misery,

375 out of our house: for they devise evils.”

376 So he spoke; and all the suitors laughed at
him sweetly,55

377 and let go their bitter anger against
Telemachus.

378 And the swineherd carried the bow up the
hall

379 and stood by thoughtful Odysseus and set it in
his hands.

380 Then he called out the nurse Eurycleia and
said:

381 “Telemachus commands you, watchful-
minded Eurycleia:

382 bar the close-fitted doors of the women’s hall,

383 and if any woman hears groaning or the crash
of men

384 inside our walls, let her not run out,
385 but stay where she is, at her work, in silence.”
386 So he spoke; and for her the word stayed
wingless.**56**
387 And she barred the doors of the well-settled
halls.
388 In silence Philoetius slipped out of the house
389 and barred the gates of the well-fenced
courtyard.
390 Under the colonnade there lay a curved ship’s
cable
391 of byblus fiber; with it he lashed the gates,
and went back in,**57**
392 and went and sat on the stool from which he
had risen,
393 with his eyes on Odysseus. And he was
handling the bow already,
394 turning it round and round, testing it this way
and that,
395 for worms that might have eaten the horn
while its master was away.**58**
396 And a man would say, with a glance at his

neighbor:

397 “Quite the connoisseur of bows! An expert eye
— a thief’s!59

398 No doubt he has bows like this one laid up at
home —

399 or means to make one. Look how he turns it
over,

400 this way and that — the vagrant schooled in
trouble!”

401 And another of the arrogant young men
would say:

402 “May all his profit in life come out exactly

403 as his luck in ever managing to string that
thing!”60

404 So the suitors talked. But Odysseus of the
many designs,

405 the moment he had hefted the great bow and
eyed it everywhere —

406 as when a man skilled in the lyre and in
singing

407 easily stretches a string around a new peg,

408 making the twisted sheep-gut fast at either

end —

409 so without haste, without effort, Odysseus
strung the great bow.61

410 Then his right hand took hold and tried the
string,

411 and under his touch it sang sweet, like a
swallow's voice.62

412 A great ache took the suitors; the color
changed

413 in every face; and Zeus thundered loud,
showing his signs.63

414 And much-enduring noble Odysseus was glad

415 that the son of crooked-counseled Cronos sent
him an omen;

416 and he took up the swift arrow that lay bare
on the table

417 beside him — the rest were stored inside the
hollow quiver,

418 the ones the Achaeans were shortly going to
taste.64

419 He set it on the bridge of the bow, drew back
the string and the notched butt

420 from the very stool where he sat, and let the
arrow fly

421 with a straight aim, and did not miss a single
axe —

422 from the first helve-ring clean on through:
the arrow

423 heavy with bronze passed through and out.
And he said to Telemachus:65

424 “Telemachus — the guest who sits in your
halls does not

425 disgrace you: I did not miss the mark, and I
was not long

426 about stringing the bow. My strength stands
yet unbroken —

427 not as the suitors’ taunts would have it, in
their disrespect.

428 But now it is time that supper too be made for
the Achaeans,

429 while there is light — and after that, the other
entertainments:

430 the dance and the lyre. For these are the
garnish of a feast.”66

431 He spoke, and signaled with his brows. And he
slung on his sharp sword,
432 Telemachus, the dear son of godlike Odysseus,
433 and closed his hand around his spear, and
there beside him,
434 close by his chair, he stood — armed in the
flashing bronze.⁶⁷

Notes

NOTES

1. The opening names the double agency that runs the whole book: Athena puts it in Penelope's mind. Whose act is the contest? The line's last words refuse consolation: the bow is set out as "the contest, and the beginning of the slaughter" (ἀέθλια καὶ φόνου ἀρχήν) — prize and price in one breath. Whatever Penelope knows, the poem knows, and says so in line four. ↩
2. The key: bent, bronze, ivory-handled — the most lovingly detailed lock-hardware in ancient literature, and she takes it "in her strong hand" (χειρὶ παχείῃ), a formula elsewhere reserved for the thick hands of warriors (Ctesippus threw the ox-hoof with it, 20.299). The poem arms Penelope with an epithet before it arms her husband with the bow. ↩

3. “Groan-laden shafts” (στονόνεντες δίοτοί) — the arrows carry their future tense in their epithet: freighted with the groans they will cause. Stored beside the treasures for twenty years, the quiver has been holding Book 22 in escrow. ↩
4. The bow’s pedigree is a *xenia* tragedy in miniature: given by Iphitus in Lacedaemon — a guest-gift beginning a friendship the two men never got to use, because Heracles killed Iphitus *as a guest in his own house*, shameless “before the gods’ watching eye, nor for the table he himself had set.” The weapon that will punish the abuse of hospitality enters the poem wrapped in the paradigm crime against it. Even Heracles, son of Zeus, is filed here as *σχέτλιος* — the poem’s morality outranks its heroes. ↩
5. Odysseus “a boy still,” sent on embassy over a raid of three hundred sheep: the earliest datum in his biography besides the naming and the scar (19.393ff) — and it is debt-collection. The poem’s economy is consistent from the cradle: he began his public life recovering stolen livestock, and today he finishes it the same way. ↩
6. The Heracles digression cuts both ways: it damns the guest-killer, and it quietly warns that even a hero’s house can become an abattoir — which is what this house becomes by nightfall. The difference the poem insists on: Heracles killed his guest; Odysseus will kill the men who made themselves no guests at all. ↩
7. The bow never went to Troy: it stayed home, “a memorial of a beloved guest-friend,” carried only on his own land. So the poem’s climactic weapon is not war-gear but a relic of

friendship — kept out of the epic's great war precisely so that it could wait here, domestic and sacred, for the war that matters: the defense of the house itself. ↩

8. The storeroom doors “bellowed like a bull at pasture” at the key's stroke: the house has a voice, and it lows like the herds everyone in it keeps stealing. Long shut, the room protests its opening — or announces it: the sound is a fanfare exactly as loud as an omen. ↩
9. She sits with the bow-case on her knees and weeps before drawing out “the master's bow” — the second time an object has stood in for the man (his clothes at 19.255ff; the bed still to come). She holds the bow as one holds a child or a corpse; then she carries it to the suitors. The gesture contains the whole book: grief in the storeroom, statecraft in the hall. ↩
10. The veil entrance, fourth and final performance (1.333–335; 16.415–416; 18.209–211): pillar, veil, two handmaids. Every prior entrance stopped something — a song, a plot, a mood. This one starts something: the formula that always marked her intervention in the men's world now delivers the instrument of its ending. ↩
11. Her speech to the suitors is an indictment disguised as an invitation: you have eaten this house “without ever a pause,” and in all these years could produce no pretext but wanting me. Then the terms, repeated verbatim from her midnight announcement (19.577–581), down to the sentence that broke on the beggar's ears: “I think I shall remember it even in my dreams.” ↩

12. “Whoever strings the bow most easily” — ῥηίτατα: ease, not strength alone, is the criterion she sets, and ease is exactly how the poem stages the winner (409: “without haste, without effort”). Her contest specifies its victor in the adverb. ↩
13. Eumaeus weeps taking the bow; Philoetius weeps at the sight of it. The two sworn men cry in public over their master’s weapon minutes before they are recruited by their master’s scar — grief as credentials, publicly filed. Antinous reads it as rustic sentimentality; the poem reads it as the muster-roll. ↩
14. “Brains that stop at the day’s end” (ἐφημέρια φρονέοντες) — Antinous’ sneer at the herdsmen accidentally quotes the beggar’s great doctrine (18.136–137: the mind of man is the day the father sends). What was wisdom in Odysseus’ mouth is contempt in his: the suitor flings the poem’s deepest anthropology as an insult at the men who will help kill him. ↩
15. Antinous’ memory — “I saw him myself... though I was still a witless child” — is the book’s strangest tenderness: the ringleader is old enough to remember Odysseus, and the memory surfaces as awe (“there is no man in this whole company such as Odysseus was”). For one line he tells the truth about the house he is destroying; then he organizes the queue to take it. ↩
16. The narrator hangs Antinous in open court: “he was to be the first to taste an arrow from the hands of blameless Odysseus.” The tasting returns in the English at 418 for all of them (the Greek varies its verb). Twenty-one books of restraint, and the poem cannot keep its own secret the last three hundred-odd

lines to the payoff — the prolepsis is a reader's mercy and a judge's sentence. ↩

17. Telemachus' clowning — "Zeus has made me witless! ... I laugh, and enjoy it, with my witless heart" — is tactical: the armed conspirator plays the giddy boy so the room reads the day as farce. Under it, one true sentence stands at 110: "Why should I praise my mother?" — the son declining to auction his mother's worth to her buyers. ↩

18. His secret motive, stated in the open where no one can hear it: if I string the bow, I could bear her leaving — the master's gear would still have a master in the house. The contest has a third contestant no one invited, playing for a different prize: not the bride but the succession — proof that the bow stays home whoever takes the wife. ↩

19. The axes: one long trench, trued to a line, earth stamped firm — and amazement takes the room, "who had never seen it before." Never seen the trick, or never seen the boy do a man's engineering? Both: the set-up is itself a feat, executed from inherited instinct by a son who was an infant when the bow last sang. The stage crew for his father's masterpiece is his own blood. ↩

20. The three pulls, and the fourth that "would have strung it — but Odysseus shook his head." The poem's quietest enormous moment: the succession is real — the boy is one haul from his father's equal — and it is deferred, not denied, by a headshake. Telemachus obeys an instruction no one else saw, swallowing the triumph of his life. The plot needs the bow in older hands

today; the epilogue of the gesture is that someday it will not.



21. His cover-speech recycles his own words from 16.71–72 (“too young... cannot trust my hands to defend a man”) — a self-description that was true then, deployed now as camouflage precisely because it no longer is. The poem lets us hear the difference between the sentence meant and the sentence performed. ↩
22. “Left to right, starting from where the wine is poured” — Antinous organizes the failure procession with liturgical tidiness: sunwise, from the cupbearer’s station, like a libation. The suitors do everything in feast-order to the end; the deaths, hours away, will begin with the man who set the rotation. ↩
23. Leodes: the suitors’ own diviner, seated “farthest in” by the mixing-bowl, the only one who hates their outrages. The poem builds an ethical gradient even inside the mob — and then makes its decent man’s hands “soft, unhardened” priest’s hands, first to fail. His plea at 22.310ff will cite exactly what the poem certifies here; Odysseus will answer that a diviner who stayed prayed daily for the master never to come home. Decency without departure, once again, saves no one. ↩
24. Leodes’ outburst is prophecy in its working clothes: “Many chief men this bow is going to strip of life and breath.” He means it figuratively — the contest will kill their hopes and it were better to die than keep missing the mark. The diviner speaks truer than his own reading; the bow will take him literally. ↩
25. Antinous answers the true prophecy with the household’s shock-formula — “what a word has slipped the fence of your

teeth!" (1.64's line, last used by Eurycleia to Odysseus' death-threat, 19.492). The formula for unspeakable words keeps attaching itself to speech that is exactly accurate. ↩

26. The lard, the fire, the warming: the young men treat the great bow like a stiff boot — grease it, soften it, coax it. The technology of failure is lovingly itemized; what the bow wants is not fat but its owner. Meanwhile the two chiefs "held off" — rank as an excuse for postponing the test rank cannot pass. ↩

27. "In prowess far the best of them" — the poem's flat concession that Antinous and Eurymachus are the real men of the company, granted at the moment both are dodging the trial. Best of the suitors is a measurement the bow is about to calibrate exactly. ↩

28. The recruitment question is a masterpiece of operational caution: hypothetical ("if he came from somewhere"), theological ("some god bringing him"), binary, and unsigned. He asks the two men to declare a side before revealing there is a side to declare. Philoetius answers with his 20.237 vow verbatim; Eumaeus with his standing prayer. Only then — "when he had proof of the true mind in both of them" — does the grammar change person. ↩

29. "That the man himself come back, and a god guide him home" — Philoetius unknowingly repeats Eumaeus' prayer at the fountain (17.243) word for word. The two loyalists have never coordinated; the formula system testifies that loyalty in this poem is one text with several readers. ↩

30. "He is home — here — I am the man myself" (ἐνδὸν μὲν δὴ ὅδ' αὐτὸς ἐγώ): the syntax stumbles homeward — *inside; this man*;

myself; I. Four ways of saying the same noun, stacked, after twenty years of aliases. To his son he said “I am your father”; to his slaves he says “I am the man” — each audience gets the identity in the grammar it prayed in. ↩

31. “To you two only... Of the rest I have heard not one man praying that I come home.” The intelligence file is cold: among all he has personally overheard in the disguise, the prayers for his return number two — and the loyalty roll he can vouch for is two herdsmen, a nurse, a son, and a wife. The killing, hours away, is scaled to that arithmetic. ↩
32. The promises: wives, possessions, houses built near his, and the title “companions and brothers of Telemachus.” Nothing in Homer comes closer to a manumission scene — and what it offers is not freedom downward into mere liberty but elevation toward kinship: slave-brothers of the heir in everything but name. The poem’s answer to the slavery it has documented so unflinchingly is not abolition (it cannot imagine that) but embrace. ↩
33. The scar again — shown now voluntarily, “so you may know me for certain”: the wound Eurycleia found by accident becomes a credential presented on purpose. Same verse as 19.393: the boar, the white tusk, Parnassus, the sons of Autolycus. The body is the document; this is its third notarization (nurse, herdsmen; the fourth, for Laertes, waits at 24.331). ↩
34. The embrace is symmetrical: they kiss his head and shoulders, “and in the same way Odysseus kissed their heads and hands.” The master kisses the slaves’ hands — the hands he has just contracted for the fight. No other Homeric king kisses a slave;

the poem spends the gesture here, where the class line matters most and holds least. ↩

35. “The light of the sun would have gone down on their weeping” — the same line that closed the father-son recognition (16.220). Reunions in this family run on past sundown unless someone stops them — there it was Telemachus, here Odysseus — happiness cut short on schedule. Grief-discipline is the family art: weep fully, then exactly stop. ↩

36. The orders, distributed by station: Eumaeus delivers the bow *against the room’s will* and carries the word to Eurycleia to bar the women’s hall; Philoetius bars the courtyard. Bow, women, gates — weapon, witnesses, exits. Twenty years of siegecraft compressed into three assignments — and the locking itself is done, as it should be, by the housekeeper’s own hands (387). ↩

37. Eurymachus’ grief is the truest sentence he ever speaks, arrived at for the vainest reason: “It is not the marriage I mourn so much... it is that we fall so far short of godlike Odysseus.” The comparison is the disgrace — “for even men unborn to hear of.” He has, for one moment, exactly measured himself; posterity got the report he feared, in this poem. ↩

38. Antinous’ theology of postponement: it is the archer-god’s holy day — “who could be bending bows?” The answer is sitting in the hall with the bow already promised to him. On Apollo’s feast, Apollo’s own instrument comes back to tune; the piety that defers the contest hands it to the one man the god’s day fits. ↩

39. “No thief is coming into the hall of Laertes’ son Odysseus” — Antinous reassures the room about the axes with the poem’s

finest unwitting joke: the man in the hall is not coming for the axes, is no thief (he owns them), and is the grandson of the greatest thief in Greece. Every clause wrong in a different direction. ↩

40. Odysseus seconds Antinous' motion — “since he spoke this word too as it should be” — praising the postponement he is about to make irrelevant. The courtesy is real strategy: by ratifying “tomorrow for the contest,” he reframes his own request as no contest at all, just an old man's curiosity about his strength. The suitors' rules are always his best tools. ↩

41. “Whether the force is still there... or wandering and neglect have destroyed it” — the request wears the beggar's whole biography as its cover story, and it is also, under the mask, a true question. Twenty years, the sea, Calypso, the rags: the man does not entirely know what the trial will show. The poem lets the suspense be real even for its rigger. ↩

42. “In dread that he would string the polished bow”: the room's fear has been gathering its evidence all along — the thighs and shoulders under the rags (18.66–74), Irus dropped with one careful blow. The dread is the truth in them that their mockery keeps down; they refuse him the bow because some animal part of every suitor has already recognized its owner. ↩

43. Antinous' catalogue of the beggar's privileges — he eats with “the great ones,” he *hears our speeches* — offered as generosity, lands as evidence: the man has indeed heard everything. The suitor's boast of inclusion is the prosecution's exhibit list. ↩

44. The Centaur parable: Eurytion, wine-mad in Peirithous' hall, dragged through the porch, ears and nose shorn off — “he

found the evil first for himself.” Antinous means it as a warning to the drunk beggar; the poem means it as a mirror: a feast, an outrage, a mutilation in the doorway — it is Melanthius’ exact fate (22.474ff) and the suitors’ general one. He proclaims “great trouble for you if you string that bow”; the trouble is his, and the bow is already in the hall. The mythological threat is the book’s most complete boomerang.



45. Echetus again (= 18.85, the same verse): the offshore bogeyman-king as the suitors’ all-purpose deterrent. Their imagination of punishment is always elsewhere, outsourced, someone else’s hands; the punishment actually scheduled is local, in-house, and the man they are threatening holds its instrument. ↩
46. Penelope opens on Ctesippus’ own line (20.294–295): “it is not fine, and it is not just, to stint the guests of Telemachus.” The words that dressed an ox-hoof as a guest-gift come back washed — mock-courtesy re-minted as real justice, in the mouth of the woman of the house. The formula system runs its quiet court: the suitors’ phrases keep being subpoenaed. ↩
47. “He himself has no such hope in his breast” — the poem’s dramatic irony at its most delicious, and possibly its most double. She is right for the room’s purposes (a beggar cannot mean marriage) and wrong in every other register: the stranger’s whole hope is precisely to lead her home — he is already there. Whether some part of her says it *because* it can be said safely, the poem keeps sealed. ↩
48. Eurymachus’ nightmare gossip — “a wandering beggar came and strung the bow with ease, and shot through the iron” — is

an advance transcript of what is about to happen in this hall, accurate in every substance if not in wording. He drafts the case posterity will make and calls it the unbearable one. The poem grants him full authorship of his own disgrace: no bard said it better. ↩

49. Her retort dismantles the shame-logic at its root: men who “dishonor and devour the house of their better” have no fair fame left to protect — the reputational account they are guarding is already empty. It is the shortest complete moral audit of the suitors anyone delivers, and it comes from the person they propose to marry. ↩
50. The clothing-promise, final and fullest form: cloak and tunic, plus javelin, sword, sandals, and the fixed close “send him wherever his heart and spirit bid him go” (14.516–517 → 15.337–339 → 16.79–81 → 17.550 → now). The earlier promises clothed the beggar; Penelope’s version arms him. She proposes, in open hall, to equip the stranger with weapons — one sentence before her son sends her upstairs and the equipping happens another way. ↩
51. Lines 350–353 repeat Telemachus’ first assertion of manhood (1.356–359) with one word changed: μῦθος has become τόξον — “the word belongs to men” is now “the bow belongs to men.” The poem measures the whole epic’s arc in that substitution: in Book 1 the boy claimed speech; in Book 21 the man claims the weapon — and the claim’s real content is operational: she must be out of the hall before the arrows. The famous line does its tender, brutal work twice at once — asserting the son’s authority and saving the mother’s life. ↩

52. Her exit = 1.360–364 entire, the refrain's last performance:
wonder, the son's word laid to heart, the stairs, the weeping,
Athena's sleep. She will sleep through the slaughter — the
goddess's anesthesia, sparing her the hall she has managed for
twenty years at the one hour it cannot be managed. When she
next wakes, the poem will owe her a husband. ↩
53. The threat to Eumaeus — his own dogs will eat him among his
pigs, “alone, away from men” — is the suitors' cruelty in its
purest form: they curse the swineherd with the exact solitude
in which his loyalty lives. The Apollo-clause tacked on (“if
Apollo will only be gracious”) keeps their piety current while
they threaten a slave with dog-death on the god's feast day. ↩
54. The plan's one wobble: Eumaeus, shouted at by the whole hall,
sets the bow down mid-carry. The poem allows its most
faithful man a moment of ordinary fear — a hallful of lords
screaming at a slave — so that Telemachus can rescue the
delivery, and so that we see the bow's last meters to its owner's
hands are walked on courage, not script. ↩
55. Telemachus saves the handoff with comedy: the mock-threat to
stone the old swineherd back to the farm, the rueful wish to be
stronger than the whole room. The suitors laugh “sweetly” —
and their anger dissolves precisely as the bow completes its
journey. He has learned to weaponize his own harmlessness:
the boy-act buys the bow its last steps. ↩
56. The wingless word, third flight (17.57; 19.29 and now, Eurycleia
both these times): she obeys without a syllable and bars the
doors. The formula for wordless obedience has become the

sound of the trap closing — softly, on well-oiled hinges, with the housekeeper's own hands. ↩

57. Philoetius bars the gates with a ship's cable of byblus — Egyptian papyrus rope, ocean gear. The sea that kept Odysseus from the house for ten years now lends its tackle to lock the house shut around his enemies: the poem's maritime half reaches ashore for one last knot. ↩
58. The worm-check: the master turns his bow "this way and that," inspecting the horn for twenty years of beetle damage, in front of men who read the inspection as a vagrant's covetousness. It is the book's thesis in dumb-show: knowledge looks like presumption to those who cannot imagine the knower. He is not admiring the bow; he is auditing his own long absence. ↩
59. "An expert eye — a thief's!" (ἐπίκλοπος): the mocker reaches for an insult and lands, blind, on genealogy — the man is Autolycus' grandson, heir of the master-thief "in thievery and the oath" (19.396). Taunt after taunt in this book lands as accidental documentary; the suitors have been right about him all day in every register but the one that counts. ↩
60. The luck-wish — may his life's profit match his chance of stringing it — is the last kledon of the poem, and like all the others it executes exactly as worded: his profit and the stringing come out identical, both total. The suitors have now blessed him twice (18.112ff) and cursed him once, and every utterance has filed itself on his side of the ledger. ↩
61. The stringing simile: as a singer stretches a new string on his lyre's peg — easy, familiar, both ends made fast — "so without haste, without effort, Odysseus strung the great bow." The

poem's final self-portrait: bard and bowman are one craft, tension mastered into music. The man who told lies like truth (19.203, the poet's simile) now strings death like a lyre. Everything the Odyssey believes about skill — that its summit looks like ease — is in the two words ἄτερ σπουδῆς. ↩

62. He plucks the string and it “sang sweet, like a swallow’s voice”: the bow speaks under its owner’s thumb again, and the note is birdsong — and the swallow is the spring migrant, the bird that returns to the house it nested in. The whole homecoming compressed into an instrument-check; the room hears a chirp, the poem hears the year turning. ↩
63. The triple response: the suitors’ ache and change of color (their bodies, again, ahead of their minds — cf. 20.345ff); Zeus’s thunder, second of the day (20.103), the god countersigning; and Odysseus “glad” — the same quiet joy he took in the kledones. Sky and flesh have both voted; only the arrow remains to publish the result. ↩
64. The bare arrow on the table — singular, unquivered, lying in the open all through the feast like a loaded fact — “the rest... the ones the Achaeans were shortly going to taste” (in the English an echo of 98; the Greek varies its verb). The inventory is exact: one for the axes, the quiver for the house. ↩
65. The shot: seated, from his stool, no stance, no rise — through all twelve, “from the first helve-ring clean on through.” The contest specified ease (75); the champion performs it from a chair. Every failed suitor stood braced on the threshold; the owner does it sitting down, the way a man signs his name. ↩

66. The coded speech: “supper... while there is light — and after that... the dance and the lyre: the garnish of a feast.” Every noun is a codeword the room cannot read: the supper is the “graceless” one promised at 20.392–394; the lyre has just been strung; the dance is Book 22. He announces the massacre in the vocabulary of hospitality — the language the suitors abused for four years, handed back to them with its meanings loaded. ↩
67. The nod — the eyebrow-signal the son has been watching for — and the final tableau: the father seated with the strung bow, the son standing at his shoulder “armed in the flashing bronze.” No suitor has moved; the room still thinks it is at dinner. The book ends in the drawn breath between the omen and the arrow — Book 22 will name the target eight lines in. ↩

Odyssey — Book 22

The slaughter in the hall.

- 1 But he stripped himself of his rags, Odysseus of
the many designs,¹
- 2 and leapt to the great threshold with the bow
and the quiver
- 3 full of arrows, and poured out the swift shafts
- 4 there at his feet, and spoke among the suitors:
- 5 “So: that contest-past-all-contest is
accomplished.²
- 6 Now for another mark — one no man has ever
hit —
- 7 and I shall know if I strike it: if Apollo gives me
that glory.”
- 8 He spoke, and leveled the bitter arrow at
Antinous.
- 9 And he — he was that instant lifting a beautiful
cup,
- 10 a golden one, two-eared, turning it in his

hands

11 to drink the wine; and slaughter was not in his
thoughts:3

12 for who would think, among men at dinner,
that one man

13 in the middle of many — however strong he
might be —

14 would bring on him foul death and the black
doom?

15 But Odysseus took aim at his throat, and shot,
16 and the point went clean on through the soft of
the neck.

17 He sagged to one side; the cup dropped out of
his hand

18 as the arrow hit; and at once a thick jet came
19 up through his nostrils — human blood; and
quick, with a kick,

20 he shoved the table from him and spilled the
food to the floor:

21 the bread and the roast meats fouled in it. And
the suitors

22 broke into uproar through the house when

they saw the man fallen;

23 up from their chairs they started, driven
through the hall,

24 eyes darting every way along the well-built
walls —

25 and nowhere was there a shield or a strong
spear to seize.⁴

26 And they raged at Odysseus with words of fury:

27 “Stranger, you shoot at men — and it will cost
you! No more contests

28 for you: now your own sheer destruction is
certain.

29 The man you have killed was the very noblest
of the young men

30 of Ithaca. For this the vultures will eat you —
here.”

31 So each man guessed: for indeed they thought
he had killed

32 the man unwilling. The fools — they had not
seen it yet:

33 that on every one of them the cords of death
were fastened.⁵

34 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus
of the many designs replied:
35 “You dogs! You kept on saying I would never
come home again⁶
36 out of the land of Troy: and so you sheared
away my house,
37 and lay with my slave-women by force,
38 and courted my own wife while I was still alive,
39 fearing neither the gods who hold wide heaven
40 nor any vengeance of men, to come hereafter.
41 Now on you — on all of you — the cords of
death are fastened.”
42 So he spoke; and the pale terror took hold of
them all,
43 and every man peered round for a way to
escape sheer destruction.
44 Only Eurymachus found words, and answered
him:
45 “If you are truly Odysseus of Ithaca, come
home again,⁷
46 then all you say is just — all the Achaeans have
done,

47 reckless things in plenty in the hall, in plenty
on the land.

48 But there he lies — the man to blame for
everything:

49 Antinous. He was the one who set these doings
on —

50 not so much needing the marriage, or wanting
it,

51 but with another purpose, which the son of
Cronos never granted:

52 to be king himself in the land of well-built
Ithaca,

53 and to ambush your son and kill him.

54 Now he is killed, as was his portion. You —
spare your own

55 people; and we hereafter, making it good
through the land,

56 all that has been drunk and eaten in your halls,
57 each of us bringing a payment of twenty oxen's
worth,

58 will pay you back in bronze and gold, until
your heart

59 is warmed. Till then, no one could blame your
anger.”⁸

60 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus
of the many designs replied:

61 “Eurymachus — not if you handed over all your
patrimonies,

62 everything you now have, and added more
from elsewhere,

63 not even so would I hold my hands back from
the killing

64 before the suitors had paid for the whole
trespass.”⁹

65 Now the choice lies before you: fight me face to
face,

66 or run — whoever can slip his death and doom.

67 But I do not think one man of you escapes
sheer destruction.”

68 So he spoke; and their knees went slack where
they stood, and their hearts.

69 And Eurymachus called out among them a
second time:

70 “Friends — this man will not now hold his

invincible hands.

71 He has the polished bow and the quiver: he will
shoot

72 from the smooth threshold until he has killed
us all.

73 Then let our minds be on battle! Draw your
swords,

74 put up the tables against the arrows of quick
death,

75 and let us all go at him in one body — see if we
can

76 shove him off the threshold and out of the
doors,

77 then through the town, and the alarm raised at
once!

78 Then this man would soon have shot his
last.”**10**

79 So speaking, he drew his sharp sword,

80 bronze, two-edged, and leapt at him

81 with a blood-freezing yell. But in the same
instant noble Odysseus

82 let the arrow fly, and struck his chest beside

the nipple,

83 and drove the swift shaft into his liver. Out of
his hand

84 the sword dropped to the ground; he doubled
over the table

85 and crumpled, sprawling across it, and spilled
the food to the floor

86 and the two-eared cup. His forehead beat the
earth

87 in his heart's agony; both feet kicked out,

88 rattling the chair; and the mist poured down
over his eyes.11

89 Then Amphinomus went for glorious
Odysseus,

90 charging him head-on, his sharp sword drawn,

91 to see if he might give way from the doors. But
Telemachus

92 was too quick: he caught him from behind with
the bronze spear

93 square between the shoulders, and drove it
through his chest,

94 and he fell with a crash, and struck the ground

full with his forehead.**12**

95 And Telemachus sprang back, leaving the long-shadowed spear

96 there in Amphinomus: for he feared that as he pulled

97 the long spear out, some Achaean might rush in

98 and cut him with a sword, or strike him as he stooped.

99 He ran, and came quickly to his dear father,

100 and standing close he spoke winged words:

101 “Father — now I will bring you a shield and two spears

102 and a helmet all of bronze, fitted to your temples;

103 and I will arm myself as I go, and give the swineherd

104 the same, and the cowherd. Armored is better.”

105 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered him:

106 “Run — bring them, while I still have arrows

to fight with,

107 or they will force me from the doors, one man alone.”

108 So he spoke; and Telemachus obeyed his dear father

109 and went to the storeroom where the famous arms were lying.

110 He took out four shields, and eight spears,

111 and four bronze helmets thick with horsehair,

112 and came carrying them fast to his dear father.

113 He girded the bronze on his own body first,

114 and in the same way the two slaves put on the fine armor,

115 and they took their stand around Odysseus — the deep mind, the shifting counsels.13

116 And he, so long as he had arrows to fight with,

117 kept aiming, and dropping suitors in his own house,

118 one man after another: they fell in heaps.

119 But when the arrows failed the master archer,

120 he leaned the bow against the doorpost of the

strong-built hall,

121 to stand there by the shining entrance-wall,

122 and threw about his shoulders a shield of four
hides,

123 and set on his mighty head a well-made
helmet,

124 horsehair-crested, the plume nodding terror
from the top,

125 and took up two strong spears, headed with
bronze.14

126 Now there was a raised side-door in the well-
built wall,15

127 and level with the top of the threshold of the
strong hall

128 an exit to a passage, closed with well-fitted
boards.

129 Odysseus set the noble swineherd to watch it,

130 posted close: it was the single way out.

131 And Agelaus spoke to them all, putting the
word to everyone:

132 “Friends — could not someone climb through
the side-door

133 and get word to the people, and the alarm be
raised at once?
134 Then this man would soon have shot his last.”
135 Then Melanthius the goatherd answered him:
136 “No way, Agelaus, Zeus-nurtured: the fine
gates of the courtyard
137 are terribly near, and the mouth of the
passage is cruel:
138 one man could hold it against all comers —
any man with strength in him.
139 No — wait: let me bring you armor from the
storeroom
140 to harness you. For it is in there, I am certain
— nowhere else —
141 that Odysseus and his shining son have stowed
the arms.”**16**
142 So speaking, Melanthius the goatherd climbed
up
143 through the smoke-vents of the hall to the
storerooms of Odysseus,
144 and took out twelve shields, as many spears,
145 as many bronze helmets thick with horsehair,

146 and came back fast and gave them to the
suitors.

147 And then the knees of Odysseus went slack,
and his heart,

148 when he saw them buckling on the armor and
brandishing

149 the long spears in their hands: the work now
looked great to him.17

150 And quickly he spoke winged words to
Telemachus:

151 “Telemachus — one of the women in the halls
is stoking

152 the evil war against us — that, or it is
Melanthius.”

153 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

154 “Father, the fault is mine — my own, no
other’s —

155 I left the storeroom’s close-fitted door

156 standing ajar. Their lookout was sharper than
I was.18

157 Go, noble Eumaeus: close the storeroom door,

158 and find out whether it is one of the women

doing this,

159 or Dolius' son Melanthius — he is the one I
think it is.”

160 So they spoke to one another of such things.

161 And Melanthius the goatherd went again to
the storeroom

162 to bring out more fine armor. But the noble
swineherd marked him,

163 and quickly said to Odysseus, standing near:

164 “Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices —

165 there he goes again, that ruinous man, the
one we guessed:

166 into the storeroom. Tell me straight out:

167 do I kill him — if I prove the better man —

168 or bring him here to you, to pay for the
trespasses,

169 the many, that man has schemed in your
house?”

170 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

171 “I and Telemachus will hold the lordly suitors

172 penned inside the hall, rage as they may.
173 You two: twist his feet and hands behind him,
174 throw him into the storeroom, tie boards fast
at his back,
175 make a braided rope fast to him, and haul him
176 up the tall pillar, up close to the roof-beams —
177 so that he lives on a long while, suffering hard
pains.”¹⁹

178 So he spoke; and they listened well and
obeyed:

179 they went to the storeroom — the man inside
did not see them —

180 and there he was, hunting armor in the
room’s far corner,

181 while the two of them stood waiting either
side of the doorposts.

182 And as Melanthius the goatherd came over
the threshold,

183 in one hand carrying a beautiful helmet,

184 in the other a broad shield, an old one,
mottled with mildew —

185 the hero Laertes’ shield, which he carried in

his young days,

186 long since laid by, the stitches of its straps
rotted out —20

187 the two of them sprang and seized him, and
dragged him in by the hair,

188 and threw him to the floor for all his anguish
of heart,

189 and bound his feet and hands with a heart-
grieving knot,

190 wrenched hard behind him, through and
through, as ordered

191 by Laertes' son, much-enduring noble
Odysseus;

192 then they made a braided rope fast to him,
and hauled him

193 up the tall pillar, up close to the roof-beams.

194 And taunting him you spoke, Eumaeus the
swineherd:21

195 “Now you will keep watch indeed, Melanthius
— the whole night through,

196 stretched out on the sort of soft bed you
deserve;

197 and the early-born one out of Ocean's streams
will not

198 slip past you as she comes, on her golden
throne, at the hour

199 you drive in goats for the suitors, to make
their feast in the hall."

200 So he was left there, racked in the deadly
binding;

201 and the two got into their armor, shut the
shining door,

202 and went back to Odysseus — the deep mind,
the shifting counsels.

203 There they stood, breathing fury: on the
threshold

204 four men; inside the hall, many men, and
good ones.

205 And now Athena, daughter of Zeus, came near
them,

206 likened to Mentor in body and in voice.

207 Odysseus was glad at the sight of her, and
said:

208 "Mentor — beat off ruin! Remember your old

companion,

209 who did you good service — and you my own
age-mate!”22

210 So he spoke, guessing it was Athena, rouser of
armies.

211 And the suitors on their side bellowed
through the hall,

212 Agelaus, Damastor’s son, first to threaten her:

213 “Mentor — don’t let Odysseus talk you around
214 into fighting the suitors and defending him.

215 For here is how I think our purpose will be
accomplished:

216 when we have killed these two, father and
son,

217 you will be killed with them — for the things
you are minded

218 to do in this hall. Your own head will pay the
price.

219 And when the bronze has stripped the force
from all of you,

220 everything you own, indoors and out,

221 we will pool with the goods of Odysseus. Your

sons

222 we will not let live in your halls; your
daughters

223 and your true-hearted wife will not walk free
in the town of Ithaca.”23

224 So he spoke; and Athena’s heart grew angrier
yet,

225 and she lashed Odysseus with words of fury:

226 “Odysseus — where is your strength gone?
Where is the fight in you —

227 you who for Helen’s sake, the white-armed,
the nobly fathered,

228 nine years on end battled the Trojans without
a break

229 and killed many men in the terrible fighting?

230 By your counsel the wide-wayed city of Priam
was taken!

231 How is it that now, come home to your own
house and goods,

232 face to face with the suitors, you whimper
about being brave?24

233 Here, old friend — stand by me and watch the

work,

234 and learn what kind of man, among enemy
fighters,

235 Mentor, Alcimus' son, is at repaying
kindness."

236 She spoke — and did not yet grant victory
outright to either side,

237 but went on testing the strength and fight

238 of Odysseus and of his glorious son.

239 And she herself darted up to the roof-beam of
the smoke-stained hall

240 and perched there — like a swallow, face-
on.25

241 Now Agelaus, Damastor's son, rallied the
suitors,

242 with Eurynomus, Amphimedon,
Demoptolemus,

243 Peisander Polyctor's son, and Polybus the
shrewd:

244 for these were far the best of the suitors in
prowess,

245 of all who still lived and fought for their lives

—
246 the rest the bow and the crowding arrows had
brought down.

247 And Agelaus spoke to them all, putting the
word to everyone:

248 “Friends — now this man’s invincible hands
will stop.

249 Mentor has left him — after the empty
boasting —

250 and they are alone at the outer doors.

251 So do not throw your long spears all together:

252 come — you six throw first, and see if Zeus

253 will grant that Odysseus be hit, and we win
the glory.

254 The rest are no concern, once that man
falls.”**26**

255 So he spoke; and they all threw as he ordered,

256 hungry for it. And Athena made every cast
come to nothing:

257 one man’s spear struck the doorpost of the
strong-built hall,

258 another’s the close-fitted door itself,

259 another's ash shaft, heavy with bronze,
slammed into the wall.

260 And when they had weathered the suitors'
spears,

261 much-enduring noble Odysseus began among
his men:

262 "Friends — now it is mine to say it: throw!

263 Into the crowd of the suitors — men wild to
strip our corpses

264 on top of the wrongs they did before."27

265 So he spoke; and they all threw their sharp
spears,

266 aiming straight ahead: Odysseus killed
Demoptolemus;

267 Telemachus, Euryades; the swineherd, Elatus;

268 and the man in charge of the cattle killed
Peisander.

269 All of those together bit the vast floor with
their teeth,

270 and the suitors fell back into the deep of the
hall;

271 and the others charged, and pulled their

spears from the corpses.

272 Again the suitors threw their sharp spears,

273 hungry for it; and Athena made the many
casts come to nothing:

274 one man's spear struck the doorpost of the
strong-built hall,

275 another's the close-fitted door itself,

276 another's ash shaft, heavy with bronze,
slammed into the wall.

277 But Amphimedon caught Telemachus on the
wrist —

278 a graze: the bronze just broke the surface of
the skin;

279 and Ctesippus, over the shield, scratched
Eumaeus

280 on the shoulder with his long spear: it
skipped and fell to earth.28

281 Then those around Odysseus — the deep
mind, the shifting counsels —

282 threw their sharp spears into the crowd of
the suitors:

283 and this time Eurydamas fell to Odysseus,

sacker of cities;

284 Amphimedon to Telemachus; Polybus to the
swineherd;

285 and then Ctesippus fell to the man in charge
of the cattle,

286 struck full in the chest; and he crowed over
him:

287 “Son of Polytherses — you lover of a good
jeer! — never again

288 give way to your folly and talk big. Leave the
word

289 to the gods: they are far stronger than you.

290 This is your guest-gift in return — to match
the ox-hoof

291 you gave godlike Odysseus once, when he
begged through his own hall.”29

292 So spoke the herdsman of the spiral-horned
cattle. And Odysseus

293 wounded Damastor’s son, close in, with the
long spear;

294 and Telemachus wounded Leocritus, Evenor’s
son,

295 clean in the flank with his spear, and drove
the bronze through:
296 he pitched forward and struck the ground full
with his forehead.
297 And now Athena raised the aegis that wastes
mankind,30
298 high from the roof; and their wits scattered in
terror,
299 and they stampeded through the hall like a
herd of cattle
300 when the darting gadfly falls on them and
whirls them wild
301 in the season of spring, when the long days
come in.
302 And the others — like vultures with hooked
claws and curving beaks
303 that come down out of the mountains on the
smaller birds:
304 these skim the plain, cowering away from the
clouds,
305 but the vultures stoop and kill them; no
defense,

306 no flight — and men delight to watch the
hunting:
307 so those four, rushing the suitors through the
house,
308 struck them down left and right; and hideous
groaning rose
309 as heads were smashed, and the whole floor
smoked with blood.
310 But Leodes ran in and caught Odysseus by the
knees,
311 and clasping them in supplication spoke
winged words:
312 “By your knees, Odysseus — respect me, pity
me!
313 I tell you I never said a word to any woman
314 in your halls, never did one reckless thing —
no: I kept trying
315 to stop the others, the suitors, when one
would do such things.
316 But they would not listen, would not hold
their hands from evil,
317 and so through their own recklessness they

have met an ugly fate.

318 And I, their sacrifice-diviner, having done
nothing,

319 am to lie down with them: no thanks,
hereafter, for good service!"31

320 Then, glaring from under his brows, Odysseus
of the many designs replied:

321 "If you declare yourself their sacrifice-diviner,
322 then many a time, no doubt, you must have
prayed in my halls

323 that the accomplishment of my sweet
homecoming be far away —

324 that my dear wife go with you, and bear you
children.

325 For that you shall not slip beneath a death
that lays men low."32

326 So speaking, he took up in his strong hand a
sword

327 that lay there — Agelaus had dropped it to the
ground

328 as he was killed — and drove it through the
middle of his neck:

329 and while he was still speaking, his head
mixed with the dust.33

330 But the singer still dodged the black doom —
Terpes' son,

331 Phemius, who sang among the suitors under
compulsion.34

332 He stood with the clear lyre in his hands

333 close by the side-door, and his mind was split
two ways:

334 whether to slip out of the hall to the great
altar of Zeus

335 of the Courtyard, and sit there on the
masoned stone

336 where Laertes and Odysseus had burned so
many

337 thighbones of oxen — or rush forward and
clasp Odysseus' knees.

338 And as he weighed it, this seemed to him the
better way:

339 to take hold of the knees of Laertes' son
Odysseus.

340 So he set the hollow lyre down on the ground

341 between the mixing-bowl and the silver-
studded chair,³⁵

342 and rushed forward himself and caught
Odysseus by the knees,

343 and clasping them in supplication spoke
winged words:

344 “By your knees, Odysseus — respect me, pity
me!

345 On you yourself the grief will fall hereafter, if
you kill

346 a singer — me — who sing for gods and for
men.

347 I am self-taught: a god has planted in my
heart³⁶

348 all the pathways of song; and I am fit to sing
beside you

349 as beside a god. Do not be hungry to cut my
throat.

350 And Telemachus would tell you this — your
own dear son:

351 that it was never by my will, never for want of
mine,

352 that I came to your house to sing at the
suitors' feasts:

353 they were more, and stronger — they
marched me here by force.”

354 And the sacred strength of Telemachus heard
him,

355 and quickly spoke to his father, standing near:

356 “Stop! He is guiltless — do not cut him with
the bronze.

357 And Medon the herald let us save as well, who
always

358 cared for me in our house when I was a child
—

359 unless Philoetius has killed him already, or
the swineherd,

360 or he met you as you stormed along the
hall.”³⁷

361 So he spoke; and Medon heard him — a man of
sensible mind —

362 for he lay cowering under a chair, wrapped up

363 in a fresh-flayed oxhide, dodging the black
doom.

364 Up from under the chair he came at once,
stripped off the oxhide,
365 and rushed forward and caught Telemachus
by the knees,
366 and clasping them in supplication spoke
winged words:
367 “Friend — here I am: myself! Hold back, and
tell your father,
368 before in his overmastering strength he cuts
me down with the sharp bronze
369 in his rage at the suitor-men — the men who
sheared away
370 his goods in the halls, and honored you not at
all, the fools.”**38**
371 And Odysseus of the many designs smiled at
him and said:
372 “Take heart: this man has pulled you clear and
saved you —
373 so you may know in your heart, and tell
another too,
374 how doing good outruns doing evil, and by
far.

375 Now out of the hall with you, and sit in the
courtyard,
376 away from the slaughter — you and the singer
of many songs —
377 while I finish in the house the work that I
must.”**39**
378 So he spoke; and the two of them went out of
the hall
379 and sat down by the altar of great Zeus,
380 peering about on every side, expecting death
each moment.
381 And Odysseus peered through his own house,
for any man
382 still living, hiding there, dodging the black
doom.
383 But he saw them all, the whole count of them,
in blood and dust
384 fallen — so many, like fish that fishermen**40**
385 have hauled from the gray sea in the mesh of
a net
386 onto the curved beach: heaped on the sand
they lie,

387 all of them, aching for the waves of the sea,
388 and the shining Sun takes the life out of
them:

389 so the suitors lay heaped on one another.

390 Then Odysseus of the many designs said to
Telemachus:

391 “Telemachus — go, call me the nurse
Eurycleia,

392 so I can tell her the word that is on my mind.”

393 So he spoke; and Telemachus obeyed his dear
father,

394 and rattling the door he called the nurse
Eurycleia:

395 “Up with you, and come, old woman born
long ago —

396 you who are overseer of our serving-women
in the halls.

397 Come: my father calls you; he has something
to say.”

398 So he spoke; and for her the word stayed
wingless.⁴¹

399 She opened the doors of the well-settled halls

400 and came; and Telemachus led the way before
her.

401 And she found Odysseus among the bodies of
the slain,

402 spattered with blood and gore, like a lion⁴²

403 that comes from feeding on an ox of the
farmstead:

404 all his chest, and his cheeks on either side,

405 are bloody, and he is terrible to look in the
face:

406 so was Odysseus spattered — feet, and hands
above them.

407 And she — when she saw the corpses and the
sea of blood,

408 she opened her mouth to raise the cry of
triumph: such a work

409 she saw accomplished. But Odysseus checked
her, and held her back,

410 hot as she was, and spoke winged words to
her:

411 “In your own heart rejoice, old woman — and
hold it in: no cries.

412 It is unholy to glory over slaughtered men.
413 These men the doom of the gods has broken,
and their own ruthless deeds:
414 for they honored nobody on this earth,
415 bad man or good, whoever came among them

—

416 and so through their own recklessness they
have met an ugly fate.

417 But come now, name me the women of the
halls:

418 which of them dishonor me, and which are
guiltless.”**43**

419 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered him:

420 “Then I will tell you, child, the whole truth of
it.

421 You have fifty serving-women in your halls —

422 slave-women we have taught to work their
work,

423 to card the wool and to bear the lot of slavery.

424 Of these, twelve in all have walked the road of
shamelessness:

425 no respect for me — none for Penelope

herself.

426 Telemachus is only newly grown; his mother
427 would not let him give commands to the
serving-women.

428 But come — let me climb to the bright upper
room

429 and tell your wife. Some god has laid a sleep
on her.”44

430 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

431 “Do not wake her yet. Tell them to come here
—

432 the women who all this while contrived their
shamelessness.”

433 So he spoke; and the old woman went off
down the hall

434 to carry word to the women and hurry them
along.

435 And he called Telemachus to his side, and the
cowherd,

436 and the swineherd, and spoke winged words
to them:

437 “Begin carrying out the dead, and set the
women to it;
438 and after that, the beautiful chairs and the
tables —
439 have them cleaned with water and porous
sponges.
440 And when you have set the whole house in
order,
441 lead the serving-women out of the strong-
built hall
442 to the spot between the roundhouse and the
good courtyard fence,
443 and cut them down with the long swords, till
you have stripped
444 the life from all of them, and they have
forgotten Aphrodite —
445 the sweetness they took under the suitors,
coupling in secret.”⁴⁵
446 So he spoke; and the women came in a
huddle, all of them,
447 wailing terribly, the big tears streaming down.
448 First they carried out the corpses of the dead

449 and laid them under the portico of the well-
fenced courtyard,
450 propping them against each other; and
Odysseus commanded,
451 hurrying the work himself; and they carried
them out — under force.46
452 And after that they cleaned the beautiful
chairs and the tables
453 with water and porous sponges;
454 and Telemachus, with the cowherd and the
swineherd,
455 scraped the floor of the strong-founded house
456 with hoes, and the slave-women carried the
scrapings out of doors.
457 And when they had set the whole hall in
order,
458 they led the serving-women out of the
strong-built hall
459 to the spot between the roundhouse and the
good courtyard fence,
460 and penned them in the narrow place, where
there was no way out.

461 And clear-headed Telemachus began, and
spoke among them:

462 “By no clean death will I take the lives of
these —

463 these who poured their insults on my head,
464 on my own mother, and slept beside the
suitors.”47

465 So he spoke; and he made the cable of a dark-
prowed ship

466 fast to a great pillar, and flung it round the
roundhouse,

467 stretched taut, up high, so no foot could reach
the ground.

468 And as when thrushes with their long wings,
or doves,

469 strike into a snare set up in a thicket,

470 heading in to roost, and a hateful bed receives
them:

471 so the women held their heads in a row, and
round every

472 neck a noose was laid, that they might die
most pitiably.

473 They kicked out with their feet a little while
— not very long.**48**

474 And Melanthius they dragged out through the
porch and the courtyard:

475 they sliced away his nose and ears with the
pitiless bronze

476 and tore out his genitals, raw meat for the
dogs to share,

477 and lopped off his hands and feet in their fury
of heart.**49**

478 Then they washed their own hands and feet

479 and went into the house to Odysseus: the
work was accomplished.

480 And he spoke to the dear nurse Eurycleia:

481 “Bring sulfur, old woman — the cure of evils —
and bring me fire,

482 so I can fume the hall with it. And bid
Penelope

483 come down to me, with her attendant
women;

484 and rouse all the serving-women in the house
to come.”**50**

485 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered him:

486 “Yes, my child — all this you have said as it
should be.

487 But come, let me bring you clothes, a cloak
and a tunic:

488 do not stand in your halls like this, with your
broad shoulders

489 wrapped in rags. That would be a thing to
blame.”**51**

490 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

491 “First of all: let there be fire for me in the
hall.”

492 So he spoke; and the dear nurse Eurycleia did
not disobey,

493 but brought the fire and the sulfur; and
Odysseus

494 fumed through and through the hall, the
house, the courtyard.**52**

495 And the old woman went off up through the
beautiful house of Odysseus

496 to carry word to the women and hurry them

along;

497 and out of the hall they came, torches in their hands,⁵³

498 and they poured around Odysseus, and embraced him,

499 and kissed his head and his shoulders, welcoming him,

500 catching and clasping his hands; and a sweet longing seized him

501 to weep and to sob: for in his heart he knew them all.

Notes

NOTES

1. The book opens on the shedding of the rags — γυμνώθη, “he was stripped bare”: the disguise falls in a single verb, and the leap to the threshold follows in the same breath. Nine books of costume come off in half a line; the arrows pour out at his feet like the truth arriving all at once. ↩
2. “That contest-past-all-contest is accomplished. Now for another mark — one no man has ever hit”: the transition from game to war is announced as a change of target. The prayer-tag — “if

Apollo gives me that glory” — keeps the archer-god’s feast day in play: he asks the god of the day for the day’s real event. ↩

3. Antinous dies mid-luxury: the golden two-eared cup just raised in his hands, “and slaughter was not in his thoughts.” The poem pauses to defend his obliviousness — who could imagine one man among so many? — and by defending it convicts the whole party: their safety-in-numbers was their moral arithmetic all along. The beggar’s curse (17.475–476: death “before any wedding”) and the narrator’s sentence (21.98–100: first to taste an arrow) are both paid here, at the throat, through the soft of the neck. ↩
4. “Nowhere was there a shield or a strong spear to seize” — the smoke-speech’s payoff, one book late: the walls the suitors scan were emptied by two men in Book 19 under a golden lamp. The furniture of their doom was arranged while they slept at home. ↩
5. The suitors’ first theory — the beggar shot a man by accident — is a masterpiece of self-blindness, and the narrator files it under the poem’s oldest word for them: νήπιοι, fools. The cords-of-death line (33) then returns in Odysseus’ own mouth at 41 — the narrator’s judgment become the executioner’s sentence, re-inflected for the man who will carry it out. ↩
6. “You dogs!” — the reveal-speech is an indictment in four counts: the house sheared away, the slave-women forced, the wife courted with the husband alive, and the double fearlessness — no fear of gods, no fear of men’s vengeance to come. It is the poem’s whole case-file read aloud in six lines; the verdict (“the cords of death are fastened”) had already been delivered by

the narrator. Note what he does not say: his name. The proof is the shot; identity here is competence. ↩

7. Eurymachus' "if you are truly Odysseus" concedes and negotiates in one motion — every charge admitted ("all you say is just"), the blame posthumously assigned to Antinous, complete with a new theory (he wanted the kingship and the boy's death, not the bride), and then the offer: twenty oxen per man, bronze and gold "until your heart is warmed." It is the best speech available to a doomed man — and an exact repetition of his method with Penelope (16.434ff): soothe, flatter, redirect, lie.

↩

8. "Now he is killed, as was his portion" — ἐν μοίρῃ: Eurymachus files his friend's corpse under destiny while it is still warm, the better to argue the account closed. The suitors' solidarity dissolves at the first arrow; the second-in-command's eulogy for the first is a plea-bargain. ↩

9. The refusal is absolute and financial: not all their patrimonies, "and added more from elsewhere," would stay his hands "before the suitors had paid for the whole trespass" (ὑπερβασίην ἀποτῖσαι) — the payment metaphor turned back on the men offering payment. Restitution is refused because the debt is not denominated in oxen. Then the terms: fight or run — with the codicil that no one escapes. It is the only speech in the poem where Odysseus tells the complete truth about the immediate future. ↩

10. Eurymachus' battle-order is tactically excellent — swords out, tables for shields, mass rush to shove the archer off the threshold, raise the town. It is exactly what might have

worked, and the poem lets him say it before killing him mid-charge: the ablest suitor dies proving the analysis right — “this man will not now hold his invincible hands” — as prophecy, not plan. ↩

11. Eurymachus’ death lands on the furniture of his crimes: arrow in the liver, he doubles “over the table” and spills the food to the floor — dying across the banquet he ate for four years, kicking the chair, his forehead beating the ground. At 18.384–386 the beggar promised him the doors would be too narrow for his flight; he never reaches them — the table catches him first. ↩
12. Amphinomus charges — and dies from behind, on Telemachus’ spear, exactly as Athena bound him at 16.155–156 (“to be broken under the hands and spear of Telemachus”). The one suitor who was warned, believed the warning, and stayed anyway, is killed by the son of the man who tried to save him. The poem grants him a warrior’s rush and no speech: his story was finished in Book 18; this is only the date falling due. ↩
13. Telemachus arms first, then the two slaves, “and they took their stand around Odysseus.” The four-man phalanx of the house: father, son, swineherd, cowherd — the loyalty audit of twenty books compressed into a defensive formation. The epithet-pair given Odysseus here (δαΐφρων ποικιλομήτης, “the deep mind, the shifting counsels”) is the war-Odysseus of the Iliad, recalled to duty. ↩
14. The transition from bow to spear: the bow — its work done — is leaned against the doorpost “by the shining entrance-wall,” retired mid-battle like a tool returned to its rack, and the

Iliadic panoply comes on piece by piece: four-hide shield, horsehair crest “nodding terror.” The Odyssey’s weapon yields to the Iliad’s; the poem shifts genre in an arming-scene. ↩

15. The side-door and the passage: the poem stops mid-battle for architecture, because the battle is architecture — one raised door, one cruel-mouthed alley, one man posted. Agelaus’ sensible plan (raise the town) dies against a doorway; Ithaca’s civic world stays sealed outside its own crisis until Book 24. ↩
16. Melanthius’ counter-proposal — armor from the storeroom — is the battle’s one real reversal, and it comes from the household traitor who knows the house: he climbs “through the openings of the hall” (ῥῶγες — whatever exactly they were, he knows them). Twelve shields, twelve spears: the goatherd arms a dozen dead men and seals his own mutilation. ↩
17. “The knees of Odysseus went slack, and his heart” — the formula of terror-at-death, last applied to him amid the Book 5 storm and landing (5.297, 5.406). The sea’s worst fear-line comes ashore here: the plan’s single unraveling, armed suitors in his own hall, everything won and suddenly at stake again. “The work now looked great to him” — μέγα ἔργον: the same flat phrase as ever, doing enormous duty. ↩
18. “The fault is mine — my own, no other’s”: Telemachus’ confession, instant and complete, in front of the men he armed by his lapse. No excuse, no deflection — the door left ajar named as his own. The poem has been growing this boy for twenty-one books; his manhood arrives not with the spear-kill at 93 but here, in the unforced admission of error under fire. ↩

19. The order for Melanthius: not death — storage. Trussed backward, boarded, hauled up the pillar “close to the roof-beams, so that he lives on a long while, suffering hard pains.” The man who slept soft and ate at the suitors’ table is hung in the rafters of the storeroom he looted, alive, to wait. Odysseus’ cruelty is architectural: each punishment fitted to its crime’s location. ↩
20. In Melanthius’ hands as he is caught: Laertes’ shield — “an old one, mottled with mildew... the stitches of its straps rotted out.” The traitor is arrested holding the grandfather’s rotted war-gear: three generations of the house in one object, dishonored twice over — by decay, and by the hands carrying it. ↩
21. The apostrophe, in its cruelest key: “And taunting him you spoke, Eumaeus the swineherd” — the poet’s tender second-person address now introducing a torture-taunt. Eumaeus’ mockery is built of dawn-formulas: the golden-throned early-born one will not “slip past” the trussed man — the loveliest lines in the poem’s repertoire, recited to a man hanging in a storeroom. The gentle swineherd has a war voice; the poem does not pretend otherwise. ↩
22. Odysseus greets “Mentor” with a veteran’s claim — remember your companion, we are age-mates — “guessing it was Athena.” The double consciousness is the whole relationship: he plays the scene as written (an old friend asked for help) while trusting his guess that his interlocutor built the theater. Faith, in this poem, is continuing to act well in a play you believe you have seen through. ↩

23. Agelaus' threat to Mentor is the suitors' whole world-view in miniature: they will kill the old man for helping, pool his goods with Odysseus', kill his sons, and forbid his wife and daughters the town. Even now — their leaders dead, the archer revealed — their imagination runs on confiscation and the control of women. It is the last policy speech of the suitor regime. ↩
24. Athena's rebuke is the goddess's oldest trick — rage as fuel: where is the man of the nine years, of the wooden horse ("by your counsel the wide-wayed city of Priam was taken")? The taunt "you whimper about being brave" is unfair and deliberate, and it is also the poem's only direct set-piece linking this hall to Troy: the Iliadic résumé read out at the door of the dining room, to shame the hero into being himself. ↩
25. She tests, withholds victory, "and perched on the roof-beam — like a swallow, face-on." The bowstring sang "like a swallow's voice" at 21.411; now the goddess takes the same bird's shape above the killing. The swallow — house-bird, spring-bird, returner — has become the emblem of the whole revenge: the small dark shape under the roof, singing that the year has turned. ↩
26. Agelaus' fire-discipline — six at a time, concentrate on Odysseus, "the rest are no concern" — is sound doctrine, and the poem honors the suitors' best men with real tactics before Athena voids them. Every volley lands in doorpost, door, and wall: the house itself absorbs their war, as it absorbed their feasting. ↩

27. Odysseus' counter-order is four words of Greek and a justification: they mean "to strip our corpses on top of the wrongs they did before" — even now, the offense is framed as the suitors' next planned outrage. The volley that follows is the battle's turn: four throws, four dead, the names ticked off in three tight lines. ↩
28. The defenders' entire casualty list: a grazed wrist, a scratched shoulder. The poem permits the suitors two touches — enough to prove Athena is testing, not puppeteering — and no more. Amphimedon's graze will be his one mark on the story; his shade will retell this battle to Agamemnon in Book 24. ↩
29. Philoetius kills Ctesippus and delivers the receipt: "This is your guest-gift in return — to match the ox-hoof you gave godlike Odysseus." The ξεινίῳν-joke of 20.296 comes back with the same word and a spear behind it; the cowherd even appends the moral ("leave the word to the gods"). The poem's economy of insult is exact: mock hospitality once, and hospitality's ledger sends a herdsman to collect. ↩
30. The aegis, raised "high from the roof" — no more testing: the rout. The two similes that follow split the scene by species: the suitors are herd-cattle scattered by the gadfly in lengthening spring days; the killers are hook-clawed vultures out of the mountains, and "men delight to watch the hunting." That last clause is the poem daring us to admit where we sit. ↩
31. Leodes' plea carries the poem's partial warrant: 21.144–147 showed him alone hating the suitors' outrages. But only the indignation is certified — "I did nothing," "I tried to stop them" are his own claims, entered unwitnessed. His argument

is the just man's: "no thanks, hereafter, for good service!" — the bitter proverb of the falsely lumped-in — and it is the book's hinge question: can presence alone convict? ↩

32. The answer: yes. "If you were their diviner, you must often have prayed... that my sweet homecoming be far away." Odysseus convicts him not on acts but on office — the mob's chaplain prayed the mob's prayers — and on desire: "that my dear wife go with you." No evidence is offered; none, in this hall, is required. The head "mixed with the dust" while still speaking: the sentence outruns the plea mid-word. This is the killing the poem makes hardest to applaud, and it means to. ↩
33. The sword is Agelaus' — dropped as he died. Odysseus does not even spend his own weapon on the diviner: the suitors' gear executes the suitors' priest. The economy is total now; everything in the hall has changed sides. ↩
34. Phemius, "Terpes' son" — Delight's son, the poem's own trade fully pedigreed — who sang "under compulsion" (the narrator vouches; ἀνάγκη). His deliberation — Zeus's altar or Odysseus' knees — weighs sanctuary against supplication and picks the human option: in this hall today, the man is more present than the god. ↩
35. Before he begs for his life he puts down the lyre — "between the mixing-bowl and the silver-studded chair." Two lines of stage direction on which the whole scene turns: a man who sets his instrument down properly while expecting his own beheading has proved his vocation better than any plea. The poet saves the singer; first the singer saves the song. ↩

36. “I am self-taught: a god has planted in my heart all the pathways of song” — the most important sentence about poetry in Homer. Self-taught *and* god-planted: originality and inspiration claimed in one breath, no contradiction felt. Every argument about the poet’s craft for the next three millennia is folded into this couplet, spoken by a man on his knees between corpses. ↩
37. Telemachus’ interventions save the two spared lives of the massacre: the singer (“he is guiltless”) and the herald who minded him as a child. The son’s mercy-list is exactly as long as his evidence; the poem lets the boy who chose the maids’ deaths also be the voice that stops two wrongful ones. Justice in this house runs through his testimony either way. ↩
38. Medon under the chair in a fresh-flayed oxhide — terror as low comedy, the herald hidden in the very upholstery of the feast. He springs out at the sound of his own reprieve. The poem, ankle-deep in blood, permits itself one clown-beat — and even that beat carries the theme: survival goes to those the household’s children vouch for. ↩
39. Odysseus “smiled at him” — the first smile of the aftermath (the sardonic one at 20.301 came before the killing): this one real. His maxim to the spared — “doing good outruns doing evil, and by far” — is the massacre’s official moral, delivered while the floor still smokes. He sends both survivors out to the altar: the god skipped for the knees now receives the saved. ↩
40. The fish simile: the dead heaped like a netted catch poured out on the sand, “aching for the waves of the sea, and the shining Sun takes the life out of them.” The suitors die a second death

in the image — gasping landward creatures who belonged to another element. It is the poem's pitiless pity: no blame in the simile at all, just bodies that wanted to live, expiring in the light. The sea-poem gives its land-battle a drowning in reverse.



41. The wingless word, fourth and last (17.57; 19.29; 21.386):
Eurycleia obeys the summons in silence. Every occurrence has attended a woman receiving instructions at the plot's hinges; the formula retires here, at the door between the massacre and the house of women. ↩
42. The lion simile for the man himself: blood to the cheeks, "terrible to look in the face." Eurycleia finds not her nursling but the predator of the deer-in-lair prophecy (4.335ff = 17.126ff) standing in its accomplished den. The poem has promised this lion since Sparta; it delivers him gore-fed, in his own dining room. ↩
43. The rebuke of the ololyge — the book's moral summit: "In your own heart rejoice, old woman — and hold it in: no cries. It is unholy to glory over slaughtered men." He does not deny the joy — he licenses it, inwardly — but the victory-shriek over corpses is forbidden as ὀσίη, sacrilege. Then the theology: "these men the doom of the gods has broken, and their own ruthless deeds" — two causes yoked in one breath, with the killer grammatically absent. It is either the profoundest piety in the poem or its most sublime self-exculpation; the poem's answer is that they are the same sentence. ↩
44. The audit Eurycleia has waited three books to deliver (19.495ff): fifty women; twelve "walked the road of shamelessness." She

adds the mitigation herself — Telemachus was too young to command them; the mistress kept the discipline. The nurse’s arithmetic is careful and damning at once — and her move to wake Penelope is blocked again: the reunion must wait its own book. ↩

45. The orders sequence the horror with domestic precision: corpses out, furniture sponged, house set in order — *then* the women out between roundhouse and fence, “and cut them down with the long swords.” The killing is scheduled like a chore at the end of the cleaning, and the sentence’s stated target is memory itself: “till they have forgotten Aphrodite.” The dead men dined; the women who slept are to be erased. ↩
46. The twelve carry out the bodies of their lovers, prop them against each other under the portico, sponge the chairs, scrape the floor — made to clean the scene of the massacre as their last work, with Odysseus “hurrying the work himself.” The poem does not spare us the interval between sentence and execution; forced labor at your own gallows-site is part of the punishment, and the poem knows it. ↩
47. Telemachus overrides the sword: “By no clean death...” — καθαρό θανάτω: the sword is *clean*, and cleanness is more than they deserve for insults “poured on my head, on my own mother.” The son escalates his father’s sentence on his own authority — command exercised in his own right, as when he saved Phemius and Medon moments before. Mercy and cruelty have the same source in him: personal testimony. This is the poem’s most terrible verse, and it belongs to the boy. ↩

48. The hanging: ship's cable, pillar, roundhouse; and the simile — thrushes or doves flying home to roost, striking the snare, “and a hateful bed receives them.” Birds coming home; a bed — the imagery convicts and pities in the same breath (their crime was beds; their deaths are a perverted homecoming). Then the poem's most unflinching line and a half: heads in a row, nooses on every neck, “that they might die most pitifully. They kicked out with their feet a little while — not very long.” No other ancient text ends an atrocity on so quiet a clock. The poem does not defend this; it makes us watch it, and the watching is the judgment it leaves to us. ↩
49. Melanthius' end: nose, ears, genitals to the dogs, hands, feet — outdoing the partial catalogues Antinous rehearsed as threats (Echetus' nose, ears, and genitals at 18.85ff; the Centaur's ears and nose at 21.299ff), executed by the household “in their fury of heart” (κεκοτηότι θυμῷ — the poem noting, not endorsing, the rage). Every mutilation the suitors' side imagined for others lands on their collaborator, and more. The revenge's arithmetic more than closes; its humanity is left an open wound. ↩
50. Sulfur, “the cure of evils” (κακῶν ἄκος) — fire and brimstone as purification: the hall is fumigated like a sickroom. After the theology (413–414) and the executions, the pollution is treated as physical — burnable, ventable. The oldest chemistry of atonement: what blood makes unclean, sulfur smoke makes habitable. ↩
51. Eurycleia's first thought after Armageddon: he cannot stand around in rags — “that would be a thing to blame” (νεμεσσητόν). The nurse's propriety, absurd and magnificent,

reasserts the household's ordinary law over the extraordinary scene. His answer — fire first — is the last postponement of comfort in a life made of them. ↩

52. He fumes “the hall, the house, the courtyard” himself — the king as his own priest, smoking out his own pollution. The man who offered to keep the suitors’ torches burning (18.316ff) as a beggar now carries the purifying fire as owner: his relationship to this house’s flames has run lamptender, avenger, priest inside two days. ↩
53. The last lines belong to the loyal women: out of the hall with torches, pouring around him, kissing head, shoulders, hands — the family embrace-formula given to the whole faithful staff at once. “And a sweet longing took hold of him — to weep, to sob: for in his heart he knew them all.” After one hundred and eight corpses, the book ends with the man undone not by killing but by recognition — every face known, twenty years of names intact. The slaughter needed disguise and iron; it is the housemaids who finally break him open. ↩

Odyssey — Book 23

The bed; the test that Penelope wins; the long night held back.

- 1 And the old woman climbed to the upper room,
laughing aloud,¹
- 2 to tell her mistress that her own dear husband
was in the house;
- 3 her knees were pumping fast, her feet stumbled
with hurry.
- 4 She stood over Penelope's head and spoke to
her:
- 5 "Wake, Penelope, dear child — so you can see
- 6 with your own eyes what you have longed for
all your days!
- 7 Odysseus is here — he has come home —
however late.
- 8 And he has killed the lordly suitors, the men
who plagued
- 9 his house, and ate his goods, and bullied his

son.”

10 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered her:

11 “Dear nurse, the gods have made you mad. The
gods can strike²

12 even the full of sense to foolishness,

13 and set the empty-headed on the road of
wisdom:

14 they have unstrung you. Your mind was
straight before.

15 Why do you mock me, when my heart is all one
grief,

16 telling wild tales — and shake me out of the
sleep,

17 the sweet sleep that had bound me, folding my
eyelids under?

18 I have not slept so sound since the day
Odysseus

19 went to look on Evil-Ilium, never to be named.³

20 Go on — down with you now, back to the hall.

21 If any other of my women had come to me

22 with news like this, and shaken me out of
sleep,

23 I would soon have sent her packing back to the
hall

24 and roughly. You — your old age spares you
that, at least.”

25 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered her:

26 “I do not mock you, dear child. It is true:

27 Odysseus is here — he has come home, just as I
tell you —

28 the stranger, the one they all dishonored in the
hall.

29 Telemachus knew long since that he was
here,⁴

30 but kept his father’s purposes hidden, cool of
head,

31 till he should punish the violence of those
overbearing men.”

32 So she spoke; and Penelope, all joy, sprang out
of bed

33 and clung to the old woman, tears spilling
from her eyelids,

34 and lifting her voice she spoke winged words
to her:

35 “Come then, dear nurse — tell me truly:
36 if he has really come home, as you say he has,
37 how did he lay his hands on the shameless
suitors —
38 one man alone, when they were always in
there in a pack?”
39 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered her:
40 “I did not see, I did not ask. I heard only the
groaning⁵
41 of men being killed. We sat in the corner of our
strong-built
42 quarters, struck dumb — the close-fitted doors
held us in —
43 until the hour your son called me out of the
hall,
44 Telemachus: his father had sent him to call me.
45 And then I found Odysseus standing among the
bodies
46 of the slain; and they, around him, on the
trodden floor
47 lay heaped on one another. It would have
warmed your heart —⁶

48 Now they are all together at the courtyard
gates,
50 and he is purging the beautiful house with
sulfur,⁷
51 and has built a great fire; and he sent me to call
you.
52 Come with me now — so both of you can set
your dear hearts
53 in the way of gladness at last: you have
suffered so much evil.
54 Now, this time, the long desire is
accomplished:
55 he has come himself, alive, to his own hearth;
and he has found you
56 and his son still in the halls; and the men who
wronged him,
57 the suitors — he has punished them all in his
own house.”
58 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
her:
59 “Dear nurse — no crowing yet. Hold back your
laughter.

60 You know how welcome the sight of him would
be

61 to everyone in this house — most of all to me
and to our son.

62 But this tale cannot be true, not as you tell it:

63 no — some one of the immortals has killed the
lordly suitors,⁸

64 outraged at their heart-stinging insolence and
their evil deeds.

65 For they honored nobody on this earth,

66 bad man or good, whoever came among them;

67 so through their own blind folly they have
suffered. But Odysseus —

68 far away he has lost his homecoming, lost out
of Achaea; he himself is lost.”

69 Then the dear nurse Eurycleia answered her:

70 “My child, what a word has slipped the fence
of your teeth!⁹

71 Your husband is here — at his own hearthside
— and you declare

72 he will never come home! Your heart was
always unbelieving.

73 Come then — I will give you another sign, and a plain one:

74 the scar the boar dealt him long ago with its white tusk.

75 I found it as I washed him, and I wanted to tell you —

76 you yourself — but he clapped his hand across my mouth

77 and would not let me speak: his mind is full of cunning.¹⁰

78 But come. And I will stake my own life on it:

79 if I am deceiving you, kill me by the most pitiful death there is.”

80 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered her:

81 “Dear nurse — the counsels of the gods who are forever:

82 it is hard for you to fathom them, sharp-witted as you are.¹¹

83 But even so, let us go down to my son, so I may see

84 the suitors dead — and the man who killed

them.”

85 So speaking she went down from the upper
room; and her heart

86 churned: should she question her dear
husband from a distance,

87 or go to him, and take his head and hands, and
kiss them?**12**

88 And when she came in, and crossed the stone
threshold,

89 she sat down opposite Odysseus, in the light of
the fire,

90 against the other wall. And he, by the tall
pillar,

91 sat looking at the ground, waiting to learn
whether

92 his strong-built wife would speak to him, once
her eyes had seen.

93 But she sat a long while silent, wonder
flooding her heart:

94 with her eyes now she would gaze at him, full
in the face;

95 now fail to know him — in the bad clothes on

his body.¹³

⁹⁶ And Telemachus rebuked her, and spoke a word, and named her:

⁹⁷ “Mother mine — no mother! — with your unbending heart,¹⁴

⁹⁸ why do you hold apart from my father so? Why not

⁹⁹ sit close beside him, and question him, and ask him everything?

¹⁰⁰ No other woman would harden her heart like this,

¹⁰¹ and stand apart from a husband who, after suffering much,

¹⁰² came in the twentieth year to his own fatherland.

¹⁰³ But your heart is harder than stone — as it has always been.”

¹⁰⁴ Then watchful-minded Penelope answered him:

¹⁰⁵ “My child, the heart in my breast is stunned to stillness:

¹⁰⁶ I cannot speak one word to him, cannot ask a

question,

107 cannot look him in the face. But if he is truly

108 Odysseus — if he has come home — then
surely we two

109 shall know one another, and better than
anyone: for we have

110 signs between us — hidden signs, that we two
know and no one else.”15

111 So she spoke; and much-enduring noble
Odysseus smiled,16

112 and quickly he spoke winged words to
Telemachus:

113 “Telemachus — let your mother test me in the
halls

114 as she will: she will soon see more clearly.

115 Now, because I am filthy, and the clothes on
my body are bad,

116 she holds me cheap, and will not yet say I am
the man.

117 But we — let us think how this can come out
best.

118 For a man who has killed even one man in the

land —

119 one man, with few behind him to avenge him
after —

120 goes into exile, leaving his kin and his fathers'
country.

121 And we have killed the prop of the city — far
the noblest

122 of the young men in Ithaca. Think on that, I
say.”17

123 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

124 “You look to it yourself, dear father. Yours,
they say,

125 is the best mind among mankind: no mortal
man

126 could set himself against you there.

127 As for us — we are with you, blazing for it; and
I say we shall not

128 come short in courage, such strength as is in
us.”18

129 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

130 “Then I will say how it seems best to me.

131 First: bathe yourselves, and put clean tunics
on,
132 and tell the serving-women in the halls to
dress;
133 and let the godlike singer, with the clear lyre
in his hands,
134 lead us all in the steps of the playful dance —
135 so that anyone who hears it from outside will
say, ‘A wedding!’ —19
136 a passer-by on the road, or one of our
neighbors round about —
137 so that the wide rumor of the suitors’ killing
does not run
138 down through the town before we can get
away
139 out to our orchard-farm among the trees.
There, after,
140 we shall see what profit the Olympian puts
into our hands.”
141 So he spoke; and they listened well and
obeyed.
142 First they bathed themselves, and put clean

tunics on,

143 and the women dressed; and the godlike
singer took up

144 the hollow lyre, and woke in all of them the
craving

145 for the sweetness of song and the blameless
dance.

146 And the great house rang around them to the
footfalls

147 of men at play and fair-belted women
dancing;

148 and a man would say, hearing it from outside
the house:

149 “So! Someone has married the much-wooed
queen at last.

150 Hard woman — she had not the heart to keep
her wedded

151 husband’s great house through to the end,
until he came.”**20**

152 So a man would say. And they did not know
how things stood.

153 And meanwhile, inside his house, great-

hearted Odysseus

154 was bathed by the housekeeper Eurynome,
and rubbed with oil,

155 and she put a beautiful mantle round him, and
a tunic;

156 and over him, from the head down, Athena
poured great beauty:

157 taller to look at, and broader, and down from
his head

158 she made the locks flow in curls, like the
hyacinth flower.

159 As when a man lays gold over silver — a
craftsman

160 whom Hephaestus and Pallas Athena have
taught

161 art of every kind, and he finishes works full of
grace —

162 so she poured grace over his head and
shoulders.**21**

163 Out of the bath he came, in build like the
immortals,

164 and sat back down on the chair from which he

had risen,

165 opposite his wife, and spoke his word to her:

166 “Strange woman! To you beyond all

womankind22

167 the dwellers on Olympus gave an unyielding
heart.

168 No other woman would harden her heart like
this,

169 and stand apart from a husband who, after
suffering much,

170 came in the twentieth year to his own
fatherland.23

171 Well then, nurse — make me up a bed, so I can
lie down

172 by myself at least. The heart in this one’s
breast is iron.”

173 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

174 “Strange man! I am not being proud, and I am
not slighting you —

175 nor am I too much amazed. I know very well
what you were

176 when you went from Ithaca on your long-
oared ship.**24**

177 Well then — Eurycleia: make up the packed
bedstead for him

178 outside the well-built bridal chamber — the
bed he made

179 with his own hands. Move the packed
bedstead out there for him,

180 and pile the bedding on: the fleeces, the
cloaks, the shining blankets.”**25**

181 So she spoke — testing her husband. And
Odysseus

182 flared out in anger at his true-hearted wife:

183 “Woman — that is a wounding word you have
spoken!**26**

184 Who has set my bed somewhere else? That
would be hard

185 even for a skilled workman — unless a god in
person came

186 and set it down, at his easy will, in some other
place:

187 no living mortal man, not one in his best

young strength,

188 could lightly lever it aside. For a great sign is
built

189 into that worked bed — and I made it: I, no
other man.

190 A bush of olive grew inside the courtyard
fence, long-leaved,

191 full-grown and flourishing, its trunk thick as a
pillar.

192 Around it I built our chamber, and I worked at
it till it was done —

193 close-set stone; and I roofed it well above,

194 and hung the jointed doors on it, close-fitting.

195 Then — and only then — I cut back the long-
leaved olive's crown,

196 trimmed the trunk up from the root, and with
the bronze I planed it

197 smooth all round, with skill, and trued it to
the line:

198 a bedpost worked from the living tree. And I
bored it all with the auger,

199 and starting from that post I planed out the

bed, until I finished,

200 inlaying it with gold and silver and ivory,

201 and I stretched across its frame an oxhide
strap, bright with crimson.27

202 There is our sign — I show it to you. What I do
not know,

203 woman, is whether my bed still stands fast, or
by now

204 some man has cut the olive off at the root and
moved it.”28

205 So he spoke; and her knees went slack where
she sat, and her dear heart,

206 as she recognized the tokens Odysseus
described so surely;29

207 and bursting into tears she ran straight to
him, and threw

208 her arms around Odysseus’ neck, and kissed
his head, and said:

209 “Do not be angry with me, Odysseus — you
who in everything

210 understood the most of men. It was the gods
who gave us sorrow —

211 the gods, who begrudged that we two, staying
side by side,
212 should have the joy of our youth and come to
the doorsill of old age.**30**
213 But do not be angry with me now, do not hold
it against me
214 that at first, when I saw you, I did not
welcome you like this.
215 For always the heart here in my breast kept
shivering:
216 terror that some man would come and cheat
me with his talk —
217 and men enough there are who plot such
wicked profits.**31**
218 Not even Argive Helen, daughter of Zeus,
219 would have joined in love and bed with a man
from another land
220 had she known that the warlike sons of the
Achaeans
221 would carry her home again to her own dear
country.
222 A god it was who stirred her to the shameful

thing she did;

223 and not until too late did she lay to heart that
folly,

224 the ruinous folly from which grief first came
— to us as well.32

225 But now — now you have told over the plain
tokens

226 of our own bed, which no other mortal has
laid eyes on:

227 only you and I, and one single serving-
woman,

228 Actoris, whom my father gave me when I first
came here,

229 who kept the door of our close-built bridal
chamber —

230 now you persuade my heart, unbending as it
is.”33

231 So she spoke; and in him she stirred a still
greater longing to weep,

232 and he wept, holding the wife of his heart, the
true, the steadfast.

233 And as when land shows welcome to men

swimming for it —

234 men whose well-made ship Poseidon has
smashed

235 on the open sea, driving it under wind and
heavy wave,

236 and few of them swim clear of the gray sea to
the shore,

237 their bodies caked with all the brine of it,

238 and glad at last they step on land, escaped
from evil:

239 so welcome was her husband to her, as her
eyes gazed at him,

240 and she could not once let her white arms go
from his neck.34

241 And Dawn of the fingers of rose would have
risen on their weeping,

242 had not the goddess thought of one thing
more — gray-eyed Athena:

243 she held the long night back at the world's
edge, and penned

244 gold-throned Dawn at Ocean, and would not
let her yoke

245 her quick-footed horses that carry the light to
men,

246 Lampus and Phaethon, the colts that draw the
Dawn.**35**

247 And then Odysseus of the many designs spoke
to his wife:

248 “Lady — we have not yet come to the end of
every trial:

249 there is still to be one labor past all measure,
250 long and hard, and I must carry it through to
the last.

251 For so the ghost of Teiresias prophesied to me
252 the day I went down into the house of Hades
253 seeking a homecoming for my companions
and myself.

254 But come, wife — let us go to bed, so that at
last

255 we can lie down and take the sweetness of our
sleep.”**36**

256 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

257 “Your bed is there for you whenever your

heart

258 wishes it — now that the gods have brought
you home

259 to your own well-built house and your
fathers' land.

260 But since you have thought of it — since a god
has put it in your heart —

261 come, tell me the trial: for I shall hear of it
later

262 anyway, I think, and it is no worse to know it
now.”³⁷

263 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
her:

264 “Strange woman — why do you press me so,
and order me

265 to speak? Well, I will tell it, and hide nothing.

266 Your heart will take no joy in it; no more does
mine:

267 for he ordered me on through many towns of
mortals yet,

268 traveling with a well-shaped oar in my hands,

269 until I come to men who know nothing of the

sea,

270 men who eat no food that is mixed with salt,

271 who know nothing of red-cheeked ships,

272 nothing of well-shaped oars, which are wings
for ships.

273 And he told me a sign, unmistakable. I will not
hide it from you:

274 when another traveler, meeting me on the
road,

275 says I carry a winnowing-fan on my shining
shoulder,

276 then and there he ordered me to fix the oar in
the earth

277 and offer fine victims to the lord Poseidon —

278 a ram, a bull, and a boar that has mounted
sows —

279 and turn away home, and offer holy
hecatombs

280 to the deathless gods who hold wide heaven,

281 to all of them, each in order. And death will
come to me

282 from the sea, so gentle a death, and take me

283 worn down under sleek old age; and around
me the peoples

284 will be prosperous. All this, he said, will be
accomplished.”38

285 Then watchful-minded Penelope answered
him:

286 “If the gods are really bringing on a better old
age,

287 then there is hope there will be an escape
from our evils.”39

288 So they spoke to one another of such things.

289 And meanwhile Eurynome and the nurse
made up the bed

290 with soft coverings, under the light of blazing
torches.

291 And when they had spread the packed
bedstead, working quickly,

292 the old woman went away to her own room to
sleep,

293 and Eurynome the chamber-woman led them
on

294 their way to bed, a torch in her hands;

295 she brought them to the chamber, and went
back. And they —

296 glad, they came to the rite of their own old
bed.⁴⁰

297 And Telemachus and the cowherd and the
swineherd

298 rested their feet from the dance, and rested
the women,

299 and lay down to sleep themselves through the
shadowy halls.

300 And when the two had taken their fill of the
loveliness of love,

301 they took their pleasure in words, telling each
other everything:

302 she, the shining among women, all she had
endured in the halls,

303 watching that deadly crowd of suitor-men

304 who on her account kept slaughtering so
many beasts,

305 oxen and fat sheep, while the wine drained
out of the jars by the vatful;

306 and Zeus-born Odysseus, all the sorrows he

had dealt

307 to other men, and all he had toiled through in
his own grief —

308 he told it all; and she delighted in the
listening,

309 and no sleep fell upon her eyelids till he had
told everything.41

310 He began with how he beat the Cicones first,
and came

311 from there to the rich plowland of the Lotus-
eaters;

312 and all the Cyclops did, and how he took the
price from him

313 for the brave companions he had eaten
without pity;

314 and how he came to Aeolus, who received him
kindly

315 and sent him on — but it was not yet his
portion to reach

316 his own dear country: the storm-wind
snatched him up again

317 and drove him, groaning heavily, over the

fish-filled sea;

318 and how he came to Telepylus of the
Laestrygonians,

319 who destroyed his ships and all his strong-
greaved companions —

320 all of them: Odysseus alone got clear in his
black ship;

321 and he told her Circe's guile and her many
wiles,

322 and how he went down into the dank house of
Hades

323 to consult the ghost of Theban Teiresias,

324 in his many-benched ship, and saw all his
companions,

325 and his mother, who bore him and reared him
when he was little;

326 and how he heard the voice of the thronging
Sirens,

327 and came to the Clashing Rocks, and dread
Charybdis,

328 and Scylla, whom men have never yet slipped
past unhurt;

329 and how his companions killed the cattle of
the Sun;
330 and how Zeus who thunders on high struck
the fast ship
331 with a smoking bolt, and his brave
companions perished
332 all together — and he alone escaped the evil
fates;
333 and how he came to the island of Ogygia and
the nymph Calypso,
334 who kept him there, aching to have him for
her husband,
335 in her hollow caves, and fed him, and kept
promising
336 to make him deathless and ageless all his days
—
337 yet she never persuaded the heart in his
breast;
338 and how, after much suffering, he came to the
Phaeacians,
339 who honored him from the heart, like a god,
340 and sent him home with a ship to his own

dear country,

341 with gifts of bronze and gold and clothing in
plenty.42

342 That was the last word he spoke, as the sweet
sleep

343 that unstrings the limbs leapt on him, loosing
the cares of his heart.43

344 Then the goddess thought of one thing more,
gray-eyed Athena:

345 when she judged that Odysseus in his heart
had taken

346 his fill of the bed of his wife, and his fill of
sleep,

347 at once she roused the gold-throned early-
born one out of Ocean,

348 to carry her light to mankind. And Odysseus
rose

349 from the soft bed, and laid this charge on his
wife:

350 “Lady — by now we have had our fill of trials,

351 the two of us both: you here, weeping over

352 my homecoming with all its cares, while Zeus

and the other gods

353 nailed me in pain far from my own country,
straining home.44

354 Now that we both have come to the bed we
longed for,

355 you must care for the property I have inside
the halls;

356 as for the flocks the overweening suitors
wasted —

357 many I will raid back myself, and the
Achaean

358 will give the rest, until they fill up every
fold.45

359 But now I am going out to the orchard-farm
and its trees,

360 to see my noble father, who grieves for me so
hard.

361 And on you, wife, I lay this charge — wise as
you are:

362 with the rising sun the story will be out and
running —

363 the suitors, the men I killed here in the halls.

364 Go up to the upper room with your attendant women

365 and sit there. Look at no one. Ask no questions.”46

366 He spoke, and drew the beautiful armor over his shoulders,

367 and roused Telemachus and the cowherd and the swineherd,

368 and told them all to take up weapons of war in their hands.

369 They did not disobey: they harnessed themselves in bronze,

370 and opened the doors, and went out; and Odysseus led.

371 By now the light was over the earth; but Athena

372 hid them in night, and led them quickly out of the town.47

Notes

1. Eurycleia climbs “laughing aloud” (καγχαλώσσα), knees pumping, feet stumbling — the poem gives the great announcement to an old woman’s hurrying body. She has kept the secret since the basin clanged (19.478ff); the pent-up news practically carries her up the stairs. ↩
2. Penelope’s first response to the truth is a lecture on divine psychiatry: the gods can make the wise mad and the foolish sane, “they have unstrung you.” Twenty years of discipline speak here — hope is an intoxicant she has learned to refuse at the door. And the sleep she resents being woken from was Athena’s own (21.357–358): the goddess anesthetized her through the massacre; the nurse gets scolded for ending the anesthesia. ↩
3. “I have not slept so sound since the day Odysseus / went to look on Evil-Ilium, never to be named” — her own coinage from 19.260 and 597, the war’s curse-name, now marking the exact span of her insomnia: twenty years bracketed between his departure and this one drugged night. The best sleep of the war ends with the news the war is over. ↩
4. Eurycleia’s aside — Telemachus knew all along and “kept his father’s purposes hidden, cool of head” — quietly files the son’s achievement where it belongs: the boy who could not hold a thought in Book 1 has held the poem’s biggest secret for six books. ↩
5. “I did not see, I did not ask. I heard only the groaning of men being killed.” The massacre from the women’s quarters: shut doors, held breath, sound only. The poem has already shown us the slaughter from inside; one line now shows what it was

from the other side of a door — the household's war experienced as pure audio. ↩

6. “It would have warmed your heart —”: the dash is the translation's; the Greek rounds off its clause before plunging into what she actually saw — Odysseus “like a lion” among the corpses (the simile she leaves at 22.402ff). Murray's text omits the next verse (49 — the numbering skips it): the gap falls, fittingly, in the middle of an old woman's breathless run-on. ↩
7. The report ends in housework: everyone at the courtyard gates, the house being sulfured, a great fire going — the apocalypse rendered as a domestic status update. Then the summary that carries the poem's whole plot in three lines: he came, alive, to his own hearth; he found you and his son; he punished them all. ↩
8. Her counter-theory — “some one of the immortals has killed the lordly suitors” — repeats Odysseus' own theology from 22.413–416 almost clause for clause (they honored nobody, good or bad; their folly destroyed them) while denying his existence. Wife and husband explain the same corpses the same way before they have exchanged a word: the poem's proof of like minds, run as dramatic irony. Her closing line — “lost” twice in one breath (ῥῆσε... ῥῆτο) — is grief's grammar: the homecoming lost, the man lost. ↩
9. The tooth-fence formula (1.64; 3.230; 5.22; 19.492; 21.168) — now the nurse to the queen, on the poem's last unspeakable utterance: the husband is at his hearth and the wife says he will never come. And then the trump: the scar, offered secondhand, with the story of the clapped hand and the

poem's driest tribute — "his mind is full of cunning" — and her own life staked on it. Penelope declines even this: washing-water evidence is not bed evidence. ↩

10. "He clapped his hand across my mouth" — Eurycleia finally gets to tell the story the throat-grip suppressed (19.479ff), and softens it in the telling: the terrifying seizure has become a hand on the lips. The nurse edits her master's violence into charm; loyalty writes the memoir. ↩

11. "The counsels of the gods... hard for you to fathom, sharp-witted as you are" — her courteous agnosticism: even conceding a wonder happened, its author is unproven. Then the pivot the whole book turns on: she will go down not to greet a husband but "to see the suitors dead — and the man who killed them." Observer's language; the inspection tour of a woman who has been fooled by every hope for twenty years. ↩

12. Her deliberation on the stairs — interrogate from a distance, or go kiss his head and hands? — is the poem's standard decision-formula, and it dissolves unresolved into 93: she does neither. She sits in the firelight opposite him and does not speak. The strongest scene-setting in the poem is two chairs, one fire, and silence. ↩

13. The flicker: "now she would gaze at him, full in the face; / now fail to know him — in the bad clothes on his body." Recognition strobes — face says yes, rags say no — and the poem holds her honestly in between. This is the same double vision the disguise has forced on everyone (Philoetius saw "a king in ruin," 20.194); only she refuses to resolve it on insufficient data. ↩

14. “Mother mine — no mother!” (μητέρα ἐμή, δύσμητερ):
Telemachus coins an insult inside the address — the un-mothering mother, “heart harder than stone.” His indignation is the plot’s own impatience made audible; and the poem sets it up precisely so that her answer can rebuke the poem itself: there are things two people know that no one else can hurry.
↩
15. Her manifesto: “we have signs between us — hidden signs, that we two know and no one else” (σήμαθ’... κεκρυμμένα). The recognition-scenes so far have all run on public tokens — a scar any nurse can wash. Penelope announces a higher protocol: cryptography with a key-pair of exactly two holders. It is the most rigorous epistemology in the poem, and it belongs to the person with the most to lose from error. ↩
16. Odysseus *smiles* — his third smile (the sardonic one, 20.301; at Medon, 22.371), and the warmest: the champion of tests, recognizing a fellow professional at his own game. “Let your mother test me” — πειράζειν, the family verb — and his serene “she will soon see more clearly” is wrong in the most instructive way possible: he assumes the obstacle is his rags. He is about to learn otherwise. ↩
17. In the very middle of the reunion-in-suspension, the strategist reroutes to consequences: the blood-feud arithmetic (one killing means exile — and we killed “the prop of the city”). His worry of 20.41–43 returns with the body count now actual. The poem keeps insisting: the massacre has a morning after, and Odysseus is the only person planning for it. ↩

18. Telemachus' answer is the son's whole arc in four lines: yours is the best mind among men — and we will follow "blazing." Deference and ferocity, correctly distributed. The boy who needed Athena to imagine a father now hands his father the planning and reserves only the courage for himself. ↩
19. The sham wedding: bathing, dressing, the lyre, dancing "so that anyone who hears it from outside will say, 'A wedding!'" The cover story is chosen with a jeweler's irony — the house must counterfeit the exact event the suitors died failing to force, on the night the real marriage resumes. The lie, as always in this poem, is made of truth. ↩
20. The passer-by's verdict: "Someone has married the much-wooed queen at last. Hard woman — she had not the heart to keep her husband's great house through to the end." The poem lets an anonymous voice speak the town's whole uncomprehending cruelty — wrong in every fact, and in the fiction's frame *also right*: there is a wedding tonight. Penelope is convicted of infidelity by gossip at the very hour her twenty-year fidelity completes itself; the poem files the injustice without comment, "and they did not know how things stood." ↩
21. Lines 157–162 repeat the beautification of 6.230–235 word for word — the hyacinth curls, the gold-over-silver craftsman taught by Hephaestus and Athena. The ledger's oldest promised echo, paid at last: the glow first applied for Nausicaa on the beach is reapplied for Penelope by the fire. Same divine cosmetics, two women, sixteen books apart — and this time the audience it is aimed at will not be moved by appearances at all, which is the joke and the point. ↩

22. “Strange woman!” (δαίμονή) — the same baffled vocative he has thrown at the beggar Irus (18.15) and the maid Melantho (19.71), now softened by helplessness into wonder, and she will hand it straight back at 174: “Strange man!” (δαίμόνιε). The couple’s first exchange in twenty years opens with the identical word in both mouths — matched blades, courteously crossed. ↩
23. His complaint repeats Telemachus’ rebuke of 100–102 verbatim — “No other woman would harden her heart...” Father and son, unaware, share one text about her (as father and son shared the silence-formula at 17.465/491). What neither man grasps: the sentence is a compliment. No other woman *would* — that is precisely the specification of Penelope. ↩
24. Her reply is a masterpiece of cool: not proud, not slighting — and then the sentence that springs the trap while sounding like a concession: “I know very well what you were / when you went from Ithaca.” *What you were* — twenty years ago; whether this is that man is exactly the open question, and she has designed the examination while he was being handsome at her. ↩
25. The trap in nine words: “make up the packed bedstead for him / *outside* the well-built bridal chamber — the bed he made.” One moved preposition. The order is given to Eurycleia — the servant who knows it cannot be obeyed — over the head of the man being tested. If he embraces the bed’s mobility, he is a stranger; only the builder knows it cannot leave the room. She has invented the security question whose answer cannot be researched: it can only be *remembered from inside the marriage*. ↩

26. “So she spoke — testing her husband” (πόσιος πειρωμένη): the poem names the maneuver with the family verb and awards her the round in the same line — *her husband*: the narrator has already graded the test she is still administering. And Odysseus — the man who dodged an ox-hoof without blinking — “flared out in anger” (ὀχθήσας). The one provocation in twenty-four books that breaks his control is a piece of furniture in the wrong place. ↩
27. The bed-speech is the poem’s deepest image doing its work at last: the living olive — the tree of Athena, of the thicket he slept in on Scheria, of the stake that blinded the Cyclops — planed and trued into a bedpost still rooted in the earth, the chamber built around it, the whole house in effect grown from the marriage at its center. The σῆμα is architectural: this marriage cannot be moved without cutting it off at the root — which is precisely what he now, in anguish, asks whether some man has done. The rage and the proof are the same thing: only the builder could be this hurt. ↩
28. “There is our sign” — and then the question that hands her the victory: he does not know; she does. For one line the omniscient strategist stands fully exposed — every operational secret of the poem was his, and the last secret of all is hers to confirm. The bed-test reverses twenty-four books of information flow in a single couplet. ↩
29. Her knees go slack (the death-and-desire formula, 18.212, 22.68) “as she recognized the tokens Odysseus described so surely” — the identical line that ended the clothes-test at 19.250. Same verse, transformed: there the tokens proved contact with a dead man and produced grief; here they prove the man

himself, and produce the run across the room. The formula system saves its finest rhyme for the marriage. ↩

30. Her apology begins with the gods, not herself: they “begrudged that we two, staying side by side, / should have the joy of our youth and come to the doorsill of old age.” The grievance is stated as a couple’s — *we two* — the grammar already repaired. Note where the blame lands: not on him for leaving, not on her for doubting; on heaven, for the stolen middle of a marriage. ↩
31. The defense proper: “always the heart in my breast kept shivering — terror that some man would come and cheat me with his talk.” Given the poem she is in — where her actual visitor has spun false autobiography after false autobiography since he landed — her paranoia is simply accuracy. The test was not coldness; it was the only sane response to a world (and a husband) made of plausible fictions. ↩
32. The Helen defense: even Helen “would not have joined in love and bed with a man from another land / had she known” — the poem’s most argued-over lines. Penelope reaches for the worst woman in the family archive and extends her the same analysis she demands for herself: error under deception, “a god stirred her” — and from Helen’s ruin “grief first came — to us as well.” It is not exoneration; it is jurisprudence: judge the deceived by what they knew. She acquits Helen provisionally in the course of explaining why she refused to become her. ↩
33. The certificate: the bed’s tokens are known to “you and I, and one single serving-woman, Actoris” — her dowry-servant, doorkeeper of the bridal chamber, presumably long dead. The key-pair had one trusted witness, chosen by her father before

the marriage began. “Now you persuade my heart, unbending as it is” — ἀπηνέα, the very adjective her son threw at her (97): what he called cruelty was the tempering; the unbending heart is why the certification means anything. ↩

34. The reversed simile — the poem’s most celebrated: land welcome to swimmers, Poseidon-wrecked, brine-caked, “glad at last they step on land” — and the swimmer is *her*: “so welcome was her husband to her.” Twenty years of his shipwrecks are handed to the wife who never left the island; the poem declares her voyage equal — the house was her open sea, the suitors her storm, and the man in her arms the shore. One marriage, one simile, both survivors in it. ↩
35. Athena stops the sunrise: night held “at the world’s edge,” Dawn penned at Ocean, her named colts — Lampus and Phaethon, “Shiner” and “Blazer” — kept from the yoke. The goddess who has scheduled every hour of this plot now bends the cosmos itself for the reunion: the poem’s single most romantic use of divine machinery, spending a miracle not on battle but on time to talk. ↩
36. In the held night he chooses honesty at its most expensive: before the bed, the future — “we have not yet come to the end of every trial.” The man of managed information gives his wife, unprompted, the one piece of bad news he could have kept for years: Teiresias’ final errand. After the bed-test, full disclosure is the marriage’s new constitution — and this clause is its first enactment. ↩
37. Her response to “there will be more suffering” is the poem’s definition of her: “Your bed is there for you whenever your

heart wishes it” — then, “tell me the trial: I shall hear of it later anyway... no worse to know it now.” No wail, no plea; the intelligence-officer’s preference for early data. They are two of a kind to the last exchange: he tests, she tests; he discloses, she debriefs. ↩

38. The prophecy retold: lines 269–284 repeat Teiresias’ words from 11.122–137 nearly verbatim — the salt-less eaters, the winnowing-fan mistake, the planted oar, Poseidon’s ram and bull and boar, and the death “from the sea, so gentle... under sleek old age,” the peoples prosperous around him. The poem’s strangest and most beautiful prophecy is spoken twice: once in Hades to the hero, once in bed to the wife. Marriage, in this poem, is where the underworld’s secrets are finally filed. ↩
39. Her verdict on the oar-journey and the gentle death: “If the gods are really bringing on a better old age, / then there is hope there will be an escape from our evils.” Conditional, guarded, exact — hope granted an *if* clause and nothing more. The last sentence Penelope speaks in the poem is in her native grammar: optimism under audit. ↩
40. “Glad, they came to the rite of their own old bed” (λέκτροιο παλαιοῦ θεσμὸν ἵκοντο) — θεσμός: ordinance, institution, rite. The bed has a *law*, and they return to it as to a ritual long suspended. The Alexandrian critics Aristophanes and Aristarchus marked this line as the “end” (τέλος) of the Odyssey — the poem’s true destination reached, with everything after it epilogue. Whatever one decides about Book 24, the ancient judgment honors what this line is: the sentence the whole epic sailed toward. ↩

41. The night's second act is narrative: love first, then "they took their pleasure in words" — the same verb of delight (τερπέσθην). She tells her siege; he tells his wanderings; "she delighted in the listening, and no sleep fell upon her eyelids till he had told everything." The marriage of the poem's two great storytellers resumes as an exchange of stories — and the poem quietly makes listening the final act of love. ↪
42. The précis (310–341): the *Odyssey* summarizes itself in bed — Cicones to Calypso to Phaeacia, one adventure per breath, in narrative order rather than the poem's own folded telling. What the summary drops is instructive: no Cretan tales, no beggar-craft — the fictions go unmentioned in the marriage's audit; and Calypso's offer of immortality is included with its refusal ("she never persuaded the heart in his breast") — the one clause in the whole catalogue addressed, quietly, to the listener beside him: he was offered forever, and chose this bed. ↪
43. "That was the last word he spoke, as the sweet sleep / that unstrings the limbs leapt on him" — the teller falls asleep inside his own telling, mid-story delivered, the poem's narrator-hero finally unconscious at the exact moment his tale is fully told. The *Odyssey*'s image of consummation is not the love-making — it is a man allowed, at last, to stop narrating. ↪
44. The morning speech opens with the marriage's balance-sheet: "we have had our fill of trials, / the two of us both" — her weeping and his detention entered side by side, ἀμφοτέρω, both. The poem's final settlement of its double plot: both sufferings on the same page, in the same sentence. ↪

45. And immediately: inventory. Guard the property; the wasted flocks “many I will raid back myself, and the Achaeans / will give the rest, until they fill up every fold.” The morning after the miracle, Odysseus is doing agricultural arithmetic — raid-economics (Athena’s own idiom, 20.49–51) as pillow-talk. The poem’s realism about restoration: even resurrection has a livestock ledger. ↩
46. His last orders to her — upstairs, the women, see no one, ask nothing — prescribe the posture the poem has always found her in, re-assumed for one more morning. The poem’s tenderest structural rhyme: she returns to the upper room exactly as always, except that now the waiting has a fixed end and a known face. ↩
47. The book’s final image: full daylight over the earth, and Athena hiding four armed men in a portable night, leading them out of town. The goddess who held back one dawn now carries darkness into another — the poem’s last stage-management, walking the plot toward Laertes’ orchard with the light switched off. Book 24 will open in the other darkness, among the ghosts. ↩

Odyssey — Book 24

The second Nekyia; Laertes and the trees; the peace of Ithaca.

- 1 And Hermes of Cyllene was calling out the
souls¹
- 2 of the suitor-men. He held in his hands the rod,
3 beautiful, golden, with which he charms men's
eyes
4 to sleep, whose eyes he wills, and wakes others
from their slumber;
5 with this he set them moving and led them, and
they followed, squeaking.
- 6 As when bats in the corner of a wondrous cave²
7 flit squeaking, when one drops off
8 the chain of them clinging to the rock and to
each other:
9 so these went with him, squeaking; and Hermes
10 the kindly led them down along the dank ways.
11 Past the streams of Ocean they went, past the

White Rock,³

¹² past the gates of the Sun and the country of
dreams,

¹³ and soon they came to the meadow of
asphodel,

¹⁴ where the souls have their dwelling — the
phantoms of the worn-out dead.⁴

¹⁵ There they found the soul of Achilles, Peleus'
son,

¹⁶ and of Patroclus, and of blameless Antilochus,

¹⁷ and of Ajax, who was first in beauty and in
build

¹⁸ of all the Danaans after the blameless son of
Peleus.⁵

¹⁹ These were gathered around Achilles; and close
to them

²⁰ came the soul of Agamemnon, Atreus' son,

²¹ grieving; and around him others were gathered
— all who died

²² beside him in Aegisthus' house, and met their
fate.

²³ And the soul of Peleus' son spoke to him first:

24 “Son of Atreus, we used to say that you, of all
25 the hero-men, were dear to Zeus who delights
in thunder
26 all your days — because you were lord over
many strong men
27 in the land of the Trojans, where we Achaeans
suffered.
28 And yet it was to you that ruinous doom
29 would come so early — the doom no man born
escapes.
30 If only, in the fullness of the honor you were
lord of,⁶
31 you had met your death and fate in the land of
the Trojans:
32 then all the Achaeans together would have
made your tomb,
33 and you would have won great fame for your
son hereafter.
34 As it was, your portion was to be caught by the
most pitiful of deaths.”
35 Then the soul of Atreus’ son answered him:
36 “Blessed son of Peleus, Achilles like the gods,

37 who died at Troy, far from Argos — and around
you the others
38 fell, the best of the sons of Trojans and
Achaean,
39 fighting over your body; and you in the swirl of
the dust
40 lay great in your greatness, your
horsemanship forgotten.⁷
41 And we fought the whole day through, and
would never
42 have ceased from the fighting, had Zeus not
stopped us with a storm.
43 And when we had carried you out of the battle
to the ships,
44 we laid you on a bier, and cleansed your
beautiful body
45 with warm water and with oil; and over you
the Danaans
46 shed many hot tears, and cut their hair.
47 And out of the sea your mother came, with the
deathless sea-women,
48 when she heard the news; and a cry went up

over the deep,

49 unearthly — and trembling took hold of all the Achaeans.

50 They would have sprung up then and fled to the hollow ships,

51 had not a man held them back, one deep in old wisdom:

52 Nestor, whose counsel had shown truest long before.

53 With good will toward them he spoke out and said:

54 ‘Hold, Argives! Do not run, young men of the Achaeans!

55 It is his mother coming out of the sea, with the deathless

56 sea-women, to look on the face of her dead son.’

57 So he spoke, and the great-hearted Achaeans checked their flight.

58 And around you stood the daughters of the old man of the sea,

59 mourning piteously; and they wrapped you in

imperishable clothing.

60 And the Muses, all nine, answering voice to
lovely voice,⁸

61 sang the dirge. Not one Argive could you have
seen

62 unweeping then, so keen was the clear Muse's
song.

63 Seventeen days together, nights and days alike,

64 we mourned you — deathless gods and mortal
men;

65 on the eighteenth we gave you to the fire, and
around you

66 slaughtered fat sheep in plenty and spiral-
horned cattle.

67 You burned in the clothing of the gods, in oil in
plenty

68 and in sweet honey; and many Achaean heroes

69 moved in armor around your burning pyre,

70 men on foot and horsemen, and a great roar
went up.

71 And when the flame of Hephaestus had made
an end of you,

72 at dawn we gathered your white bones,
Achilles,
73 into unmixed wine and oil. Your mother gave
74 a golden two-eared jar — a gift of Dionysus,⁹
75 she said, and the work of famous Hephaestus.
76 In that lie your white bones, shining Achilles,
77 mingled with the bones of dead Patroclus,
Menoetius' son,
78 and apart lie Antilochus', whom you honored
beyond
79 all your other companions after Patroclus died.
80 And over them all we heaped a great and
blameless tomb —
81 we, the sacred army of Argive spearmen —
82 on a jutting headland over the broad
Hellespont,
83 so it might be seen far off, from the open sea,
84 by men now living and by men to come.¹⁰
85 And your mother asked the gods for prizes of
great beauty
86 and set them in the middle of the field, for the
best of the Achaeans.

87 You have stood by now at the funeral games of
many

88 heroes — when a king has died, and the young
men

89 belt themselves and make ready for the prizes
—

90 but had you seen those, your heart would have
wondered most:

91 what beautiful prizes the goddess set out in
your honor,

92 silver-footed Thetis. For you were most dear to
the gods.

93 So not even in death did you lose your name:
forever,¹¹

94 among all mankind, your fame will be noble,
Achilles.

95 But I? What joy of it had I, when I had wound
the war to its end?

96 On my homecoming Zeus devised a wretched
death for me

97 at the hands of Aegisthus and my accursed
wife.”

98 So they spoke to one another of such things.

99 And the guide came near them, the slayer of
Argus,

100 leading down the souls of the suitors
Odysseus broke;¹²

101 and the two, amazed, went straight toward
them at the sight.

102 And the soul of Agamemnon, Atreus' son,
knew

103 the dear son of Melaneus, far-famed
Amphimedon:

104 for he had been his guest-friend, with his
home in Ithaca.

105 The soul of Atreus' son spoke to him first:

106 "Amphimedon, what has happened to you,
that you plunge under the dark earth,

107 all of you picked men, all of an age? A man
choosing

108 the best in a city could not have chosen
better.

109 Did Poseidon break you in your ships,

110 raising cruel winds and long waves?

111 Or did enemies on land destroy you
112 while you were cutting out their cattle and
fine flocks of sheep,
113 or as they fought for their city and their
women?**13**

114 Answer what I ask: I declare myself your
guest-friend.

115 Do you not remember when I came to your
house there,
116 with godlike Menelaus, to urge Odysseus
117 to follow with us to Ilium on the well-benched
ships?

118 A whole month it took us to cross all that wide
sea,
119 and hard work to win over Odysseus, sacker of
cities.”**14**

120 Then the soul of Amphimedon answered him:
121 “Most glorious son of Atreus, Agamemnon
lord of men,
122 I remember all of it, Zeus-nurtured, as you tell
it;
123 and I will recount to you everything, fully and

truly —

124 the evil end of our death, how it was brought
to pass.

125 We were courting the wife of Odysseus — of
the man so long away.

126 She neither refused the marriage she loathed,
nor would she make an end,

127 plotting for us death and the black doom;15

128 no — here is another trick her heart devised:

129 she set up a great loom in the halls and wove
at it,

130 fine-threaded, beyond all measure wide, and
told us straightway:

131 ‘Young men, my suitors — since noble
Odysseus is dead,

132 wait, though you burn for my wedding, till I
finish

133 this cloth — let my spinning not be wasted on
the wind —

134 a shroud for the hero Laertes, against the day

135 the ruinous doom of death that lays men low
will take him:

136 let no Achaean woman in the land hold it
against me
137 that a man who won so much should lie
without his winding-sheet.’
138 So she spoke, and our proud hearts were
persuaded.
139 Then every day she wove at the great loom,
140 and every night she unwove it by torchlight.
141 Three years her trick escaped us, and she kept
the Achaeans persuaded;
142 but when the fourth year came, as the seasons
rolled on,
143 the months waning away, the long tale of days
accomplished,
144 then one of her women, who knew it all, told
us,
145 and we caught her unweaving the shining
web.
146 So she finished it — against her will, under
force.**16**
147 And when she had shown us the robe — the
great web woven

148 and washed — and it shone like the sun or the
moon,17

149 just then some evil god brought Odysseus
from somewhere

150 to the border of the land, where the
swineherd had his house.

151 There came also the dear son of godlike
Odysseus,

152 back in his black ship out of sandy Pylos;

153 and the two of them plotted an evil death for
the suitors

154 and came to the famous town — Odysseus

155 later; it was Telemachus who led the way
before him.

156 The swineherd brought the master, in bad
clothes on his body,

157 in the likeness of a beggar, wretched and old,

158 leaning on a stick, with miserable clothing on
his body;

159 and not one of us could know him for the man
he was,

160 breaking on us suddenly like that — not even

the older men —

161 no: we went at him with ugly words, and with
things thrown.

162 And he for a while endured it in his own halls,

163 pelted and taunted, with an enduring heart;

164 but when the mind of Zeus who bears the
aegis roused him,

165 with Telemachus he lifted the beautiful armor
away

166 and stowed it in the storeroom and shot the
bolts,

167 and then — his cunning at work — he ordered
his wife¹⁸

168 to set before the suitors the bow and the gray
iron,

169 the contest for us star-crossed men, and the
beginning of the slaughter.

170 And not one of us could stretch the string

171 of that strong bow: we fell far, far short of it.

172 But when the great bow came into Odysseus'
hands,

173 then all of us together shouted out threats

174 not to give him the bow, however much he
pleaded;

175 only Telemachus urged him on and
commanded it.

176 And he took it in his hand, much-enduring
noble Odysseus,

177 and strung the bow with ease, and shot
through the iron,

178 and went and stood on the threshold, and
poured out the swift arrows,

179 glaring terribly — and he shot Antinous the
king.

180 And then he sent his groaning shafts into the
others,

181 aiming straight ahead; and they fell in heaps.

182 It was plain some god was their helper in the
fight:

183 for storming down the hall in their fury they
killed

184 left and right, and hideous groaning rose

185 as heads were smashed, and the whole floor
smoked with blood.

186 So we perished, Agamemnon — and even now
187 our bodies lie uncared-for in the halls of
Odysseus:19
188 for the friends in each man's house do not yet
know —
189 the ones who would wash the black gore from
our wounds
190 and lay us out with wailing: for that is the
portion of the dead.”
191 Then the soul of Atreus' son answered him:
192 “Blessed son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many
devices —20
193 truly you won a wife of great excellence!
194 How sound the mind of blameless Penelope,
195 Icarius' daughter! How faithfully she kept the
memory
196 of Odysseus, her wedded husband! And so the
fame of her excellence
197 will never perish; and the deathless ones will
make
198 a song for those on earth, a song of grace, for
steady-hearted Penelope —21

199 not like the daughter of Tyndareus, who
plotted evil,
200 who killed her wedded husband: a song of
loathing
201 she will be among mankind; and she brings
hard fame
202 on all women — on womankind, even on
those who do right.”²²
203 So the two of them spoke to one another of
such things,
204 standing in the house of Hades, under the
hidden places of the earth.²³
205 And the others — when they had gone down
from the city, they soon reached
206 the beautiful well-worked farm of Laertes,
which Laertes himself
207 had won long ago, when his labors for it were
many.²⁴
208 There was his house, and running all around
it the sheds
209 where the bound slaves ate, and sat, and slept

—

210 the ones whose labor did his will.
211 And in the house was an old Sicilian woman,
who cared
212 for the old man devotedly, out on the farm far
from the town.
213 And there Odysseus spoke to the slaves and to
his son:
214 “You now — go inside the well-built house,
215 and slaughter for dinner, right away, the best
of the pigs;
216 and I will make a trial of my father —25
217 whether he will know me, whether his eyes
will make me out,
218 or fail to know a son so long away.”
219 So speaking he handed the slaves his weapons
of war.
220 They went quickly on into the house; and
Odysseus
221 moved up toward the fruited orchard, testing.
222 And going down into the great garden he
found no Dolius,
223 none of the slaves, none of the sons: they had

gone off

224 gathering fieldstones for the orchard wall,

225 and the old man had led them the way.

226 So he found his father alone in the well-
worked orchard,

227 spading round a young tree — in a filthy
tunic,

228 patched, disgraceful; round his shins he had
bound

229 stitched leggings of oxhide, to fend off the
scratches,

230 and gloves on his hands because of the
thorns; and on his head

231 he wore a goatskin cap — feeding his
sorrow.26

232 And when much-enduring noble Odysseus
saw him —

233 broken with old age, the great grief packed
inside him —

234 he stopped beneath a towering pear tree, and
wept.27

235 Then he weighed it in his mind and in his

heart:

236 to kiss his father, and hold him, and tell him
everything —

237 how he had come, how he had reached his
fathers' land —

238 or question him first, and test him through
and through.

239 And as he weighed it, this seemed to him the
better way:

240 to try him first with words that bite.

241 With this in mind, noble Odysseus went
straight up to him.

242 He was holding his head down, spading round
his tree,

243 and standing beside him his shining son
spoke to him:

244 “Old man — no lack of skill in you at tending

245 an orchard! Everything is beautifully kept: not
one thing —

246 no plant, no fig tree, no vine, no olive,

247 no pear tree, no vegetable bed — goes
untended in this garden.

248 But another thing I will say — and do not take
anger into your heart:

249 you — you are not well kept. Hard old age is
on you,

250 and with it you are shabby with grime, and
clothed in disgrace.

251 It cannot be for idleness that your master
neglects you;

252 and there is nothing of the slave to be seen in
you,

253 in your face or your stature: you look like a
kingly man.28

254 You look like one who, after his bath and his
dinner,

255 should sleep on softness: for that is the right
of the old.

256 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

257 Whose slave are you? Whose orchard do you
tend?

258 And tell me this too, honestly, so that I may
know it:

259 is this land we have come to truly Ithaca, as

that man

260 told me who met me on the road just now —

261 not too well furnished in the wits: he had not
the patience

262 to tell me everything or hear out my question

263 about a guest-friend of mine — whether he
lives still,

264 or is dead by now, and down in the house of
Hades.

265 For I will tell you this; mark it and hear me:

266 I once played host, in my own dear country, to
a man

267 who came to our place; and never has another
mortal

268 of all the far-come strangers been more
welcome in my house.

269 He declared his stock was out of Ithaca; he
said

270 his father was Laertes, Arceisius' son.

271 So I brought him to the house and gave him
welcome,

272 warm and openhanded — the house had

plenty in it —

273 and I gave him gifts of friendship, such as
fitted:

274 seven talents of well-worked gold I gave him,

275 a mixing-bowl all silver, worked with flowers,

276 twelve single cloaks, as many coverlets,

277 as many beautiful mantles, tunics with them,

278 and besides all this, four women skilled in
blameless

279 handwork, good-looking ones — his own
choice, whichever he would.”29

280 And his father answered him, weeping:

281 “Stranger, you have come indeed to the land
you ask for —

282 but violent men hold it now, men lost to
decency.

283 The gifts you showered on him — the
countless gifts — were wasted.

284 If you had found him alive in the land of
Ithaca,

285 he would have sent you off well matched in
gifts,

286 well hosted too: that is the law, for whoever
begins the kindness.**30**

287 But come, tell me this, and tell it to me truly:

288 how many years is it since you hosted him —

289 that guest of yours, that luckless man — my
son, if he ever was:**31**

290 my ill-starred son? Whom, far from his
friends and his fathers' land,

291 either the fish have eaten in the sea, or on dry
ground

292 he has become the spoil of beasts and birds;
and his mother

293 never shrouded and mourned him, nor his
father — we who bore him;

294 nor did his richly dowered wife, steady-
hearted Penelope,

295 keen over her own husband on the bier, as
was fitting,

296 or close his eyes: and that is the portion of the
dead.**32**

297 And tell me this too, honestly, so that I may
know it:

298 What man are you, and from where? Where
are your city and your parents?33

299 And where is the fast ship standing that
brought you here

300 with your godlike companions? Or did you
come a passenger

301 on another's ship, which set you down and
went on?"

302 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

303 "Then I will tell you everything exactly.

304 I am from Alybas, where I have my famous
house:

305 son of Apheidas, the son of lord Polypemon;

306 my own name is Eperitus. But a god34

307 drove me wandering here from Sicania,
against my will,

308 and my ship stands off the fields, away from
the town.

309 As for Odysseus — this is now the fifth year

310 since he went from there, and left my country

—

311 the ill-starred man! And yet the birds were
good when he set out:
312 on the right; and I rejoiced in them as I sent
him off,
313 and he rejoiced as he went. And the heart in
both of us hoped
314 we would meet again as guest-friends, and
give each other shining gifts.”35
315 So he spoke; and a black cloud of grief closed
over the old man:
316 with both hands he scooped up the scorched
gray dust
317 and poured it down over his white head,
sobbing thick and fast.36
318 And the heart of Odysseus was shaken; up
through his nostrils
319 shot the sharp sting of tears — his father
before his eyes.37
320 He sprang to him, and caught him in his arms,
and kissed him:
321 “Father — I am he. I myself, the man you ask
for,38

322 come home in the twentieth year to my
fathers' land.

323 Stop now — no more weeping, no more tears
and mourning.

324 For I tell you this — and the need to hurry is
very great:

325 I have killed the suitors in our own halls;

326 I have punished their heart-stinging outrage
and their evil deeds.”

327 Then Laertes answered him and said:

328 “If you are truly Odysseus — my son — come
home,

329 tell me some sign, some plain one, so I can
believe.”**39**

330 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

331 “First — this scar: see it with your own eyes —

332 where the boar dealt me its white tusk, on
Parnassus,

333 the time I went there. It was you who sent me
— you and my honored

334 mother — to Autolycus, her dear father, to

collect

335 the gifts he promised me, and nodded to,
when he came here.⁴⁰

336 And then — come — let me tell you the trees
in the well-worked orchard

337 you gave me once. I was begging you for each
of them,

338 a little boy, trailing you through the garden.
We wound

339 among these very trees, and you named them
one by one:

340 you gave me thirteen pear trees, and ten
apple trees,

341 and forty fig trees; and you named fifty rows
of vines

342 as mine to come, each one ripening in its own
turn —

343 clusters of every kind hanging along them —

344 whenever the seasons of Zeus came down and
weighed them low.”⁴¹

345 So he spoke; and the old man’s knees went
slack where he stood, and his dear heart,

346 as he recognized the tokens Odysseus
described so surely.⁴²

347 He threw his arms around his dear son — and
fainting

348 he was caught against him by much-enduring
noble Odysseus.

349 And when he had got his breath, and the
spirit gathered back into his heart,

350 once more he found his words, and answered:

351 “Father Zeus — you gods are still there on
high Olympus,⁴³

352 if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless
outrage!

353 But now the terror in my heart is this: that
soon

354 the men of Ithaca will all come here against
us,

355 and send out messengers everywhere, to
every Cephallenian town.”

356 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

357 “Courage. Do not let that trouble the heart in

your breast.

358 Come — let us go to the house that stands
here by the orchard:

359 I sent Telemachus ahead there, with the
cowherd

360 and the swineherd, to make the meal as
quickly as they can.”

361 So the two of them talked, and made their
way to the beautiful house.

362 And when they came to the well-settled
house,

363 they found Telemachus and the cowherd and
the swineherd

364 carving meat in plenty and mixing the
sparkling wine.

365 Meanwhile the great-hearted Laertes, in his
own house,

366 was bathed by the Sicilian serving-woman,
and rubbed with oil,

367 and she threw a beautiful cloak around him;
and Athena

368 came and stood close by, and filled out the

limbs of the shepherd

369 of the people: taller than before she made
him, and broader to the eye.

370 Out of the bath he came; and his dear son
wondered at him,

371 seeing him face to face like the deathless
gods,44

372 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words to
him:

373 “Father — surely one of the gods who are
forever

374 has made you finer to look at, in beauty and in
stature!”

375 Then Laertes the clear-headed answered him:

376 “If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo! —45

377 such a man as I was when I took Nericus, the
strong-built

378 citadel on the mainland cape, lording it over
the Cephalenians —

379 such a man, in armor, I had stood beside you
yesterday

380 in our own house, and beaten at the suitor-

men:

381 then I would have unstrung the knees of
many of them

382 there in the halls — and the heart in you
would have been glad!”

383 So they spoke to one another of such things.

384 And when the others had finished their work
and made the meal,

385 they sat down in order on the benches and
the chairs,

386 and were just putting their hands to the food,
when up came

387 the old man Dolius, and with him the old
man’s sons,46

388 tired out from their field-work: their mother
had gone out

389 and called them — the old Sicilian woman,
who raised them

390 and tended the old man devotedly, now that
age had hold of him.

391 And when they saw Odysseus, and their
hearts took it in,

392 they stopped in the hall, astounded. But
Odysseus
393 fastened on them with gentle words and said:
394 “Old man — sit down to dinner, and all of you,
forget your wonder.
395 We have been waiting in the hall a long while,
eager
396 to put our hands to the bread, expecting you
every minute.”
397 So he spoke; and Dolius came straight at him,
both arms
398 spread wide; and he caught Odysseus’ hand
and kissed it at the wrist,⁴⁷
399 and lifting his voice he spoke winged words:
400 “Dear master — since you have come home to
us who longed for you
401 and had given up believing, and the gods
themselves have brought you:
402 health, and all joy to you, and may the gods
give you happiness!
403 But tell me this thing truly, so that I may
know it:

404 does watchful-minded Penelope know already
405 that you are home — or shall we send a
messenger?”48

406 Then Odysseus of the many designs answered
him:

407 “Old man, she knows already. Why should you
be busied with that?”49

408 So he spoke; and Dolius sat back down on the
polished stool.

409 And in the same way the sons of Dolius,
around famous Odysseus,

410 pressed his hands and welcomed him with
words,

411 and sat down in order beside Dolius their
father.

412 So they were busy with dinner in the house.

413 But Rumor the messenger went darting
through the city everywhere,50

414 crying the hateful death and doom of the
suitors.

415 And the people heard it all at once, and
gathered

416 from every side, with groans and wailing,
before the house of Odysseus.

417 Each family carried its dead out of the house,
and buried them;

418 and the dead of the other cities they sent
home,

419 laying each man aboard the fishermen's fast
ships;**51**

420 and they went in a body to the assembly-
place, grieving at heart.

421 And when they were assembled, all gathered
together,

422 Eupeithes rose among them and spoke:

423 for a grief there was no forgetting lay upon
his heart —**52**

424 for his son, Antinous, the first man noble
Odysseus killed;

425 weeping for him he rose and spoke among
them:

426 "Friends — a monstrous work this man has
wrought against the Achaeans!

427 Some he led off in the ships — many men, and

brave ones —

428 and he lost the hollow ships, and lost the
people;53

429 and some he has killed on his return — far the
best of the Cephallenians.

430 Come then — before he can get away quickly
to Pylos,

431 or to shining Elis, where the Epeians hold
power —

432 let us move! Or we hang our heads in shame
forever after.

433 This is a disgrace even for men unborn to
hear of,54

434 if we do not take vengeance on the murderers
of our sons

435 and our brothers. For me — there would be no
sweetness left

436 in living: I would rather die at once and be
among the perished.

437 Move — before they get across the water and
away from us!”

438 So he spoke, weeping; and pity took hold of

all the Achaeans.

439 But now Medon came up to them, and the
godlike singer,

440 out of the halls of Odysseus, for sleep had let
them go;

441 they stood in the middle of them; and
amazement took every man.

442 And Medon, whose mind knew wisdom, spoke
among them:

443 “Hear me now, men of Ithaca. Not without the
will

444 of the deathless gods did Odysseus devise
these things.

445 I myself saw a deathless god, who stood

446 close beside Odysseus, and looked in all things
like Mentor;

447 and this deathless god now showed in front of
Odysseus,

448 heartening him — and now he stormed the
hall,

449 stampeding the suitors; and they fell in
heaps.”55

450 So he spoke; and the pale terror took hold of
them all.

451 And the old hero Halitherses spoke among
them,

452 Mastor's son — for he alone saw before and
behind:56

453 with good will toward them he spoke out and
said:

454 “Hear me now, men of Ithaca, hear what I say.

455 By your own fault, friends, these things have
come to pass:57

456 you would not listen to me, nor to Mentor,
shepherd of the people,

457 and make your sons leave off their reckless
folly —

458 your sons who did a monstrous work in their
wicked blindness,

459 shearing away the goods and dishonoring the
wife

460 of a man of the first rank, saying he would
come home no more.

461 So now — let it rest here. Do as I say:

462 do not march. Some of us may draw the evil
down on his own head.”

463 So he spoke; and more than half leapt up
464 with a great battle-shout — but the rest
stayed there in a body:58

465 for the word did not please them in their
hearts; it was Eupeithes

466 they followed; and they rushed at once for
their weapons.

467 And when they had cased their flesh in the
flashing bronze,

468 they gathered in a body before the wide-
spaced town;

469 and Eupeithes led them, in his folly:

470 he was sure he would avenge the killing of his
son — and he was never

471 to come back again: he was to meet his own
fate there.59

472 And now Athena spoke to Zeus, the son of
Cronos:

473 “Father of us all, son of Cronos, highest of the
mighty,

474 answer me when I ask: what is your mind
hiding now within?

475 Will you push on with evil war and the
terrible battle-din,

476 or set the two sides now in friendship?"⁶⁰

477 Then Zeus who gathers the clouds answered
her:

478 "My child, why do you ask me? Why question
me on this?

479 Was it not you who framed this plan yourself
—

480 that Odysseus should come home and pay
those men in full?

481 Do as you will. But I will tell you what is
fitting.

482 Now that noble Odysseus has paid the suitors
out,

483 let them cut faithful oaths — he to be king all
his days —

484 and let us, for our part, set a forgetting of the
killing

485 of sons and of brothers. Let them love one

another

486 as before; and let wealth and peace be there
in plenty.”**61**

487 So speaking he stirred Athena — eager long
before —

488 and down she went darting from the peaks of
Olympus.

489 Now when they had put from them the desire
for honey-hearted food,

490 much-enduring noble Odysseus began among
them:

491 “Someone go out and look — in case they are
close, and coming.”

492 So he spoke; and a son of Dolius went out, as
he ordered,

493 and stood on the threshold, and saw them —
all of them — near,

494 and quickly he spoke winged words to
Odysseus:

495 “Here they are — close! Quick — to arms!”

496 Up they sprang and got into their armor —

497 the four around Odysseus, and the six sons of

Dolius;

498 and with them Laertes and Dolius got into
armor too,

499 gray though they were: fighters because they
must be.62

500 And when they had cased their flesh in the
flashing bronze,

501 they opened the doors and went out; and
Odysseus led.

502 And near them came the daughter of Zeus,
Athena,

503 likened to Mentor in body and in voice;

504 and much-enduring noble Odysseus was glad
at the sight of her,

505 and quickly he spoke to Telemachus his dear
son:

506 “Telemachus — now you will learn it for
yourself, standing where

507 men fight it out, and the best are sorted from
the rest:

508 shame nothing of your fathers’ line. In
strength and manhood

509 we have excelled from of old across the whole
earth.”**63**

510 Then clear-headed Telemachus answered him:

511 “You will see me, if you care to look, dear
father, in this temper

512 shaming nothing of your line — as you have
said.”

513 So he spoke; and Laertes exulted, and cried
out:

514 “What a day this is for me, dear gods! Great is
my joy:

515 my son and my son’s son are striving over
excellence!”**64**

516 And gray-eyed Athena came and stood by him
and said:

517 “Son of Arceisius — far the dearest of all my
companions —**65**

518 pray to the gray-eyed girl, and to Zeus her
father,

519 then swing the long-shadowed spear up, and
let it fly.”

520 So spoke Pallas Athena, and breathed great

strength into him;

521 and he prayed then to the daughter of great
Zeus,

522 and swung the long-shadowed spear up, and
let it fly,

523 and struck Eupeithes through the bronze-
cheeked helmet:

524 the helmet did not stop the spear; the point
drove through,

525 and he fell with a crash, and his armor
clattered upon him.66

526 And Odysseus and his shining son fell on the
front-fighters,

527 hacking with swords and double-pointed
spears;

528 and they would have destroyed them all, cut
them off from homecoming,

529 had not Athena, daughter of Zeus who bears
the aegis,

530 cried out with her voice, and checked the
whole array:

531 “Hold back, men of Ithaca, from grinding war

—

532 separate now, quickly, and without blood!”67

533 So spoke Athena; and the pale terror seized
them:

534 out of their frightened hands the weapons
flew,

535 and all fell on the ground at the goddess’s cry,

536 and they turned toward the city, aching to
live.68

537 And terribly then cried out much-enduring
noble Odysseus,

538 and gathering himself he swooped like a high-
flown eagle.

539 But then the son of Cronos let fly his smoking
bolt,

540 and it fell in front of the gray-eyed one, the
great Father’s daughter.69

541 And then gray-eyed Athena said to Odysseus:

542 “Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the
many devices,

543 hold! Stop the strife of leveling war —

544 for fear the son of Cronos be angered with

you: Zeus of the wide voice.”

545 So spoke Athena. He obeyed — and his heart
was glad.⁷⁰

546 And a sworn peace between the two sides, for
all days to come,

547 was set by Pallas Athena, daughter of Zeus
who bears the aegis,

548 likened to Mentor in body and in voice.⁷¹

Notes

NOTES

1. Hermes as soul-guide — only here in Homer does he perform the office that later Greece made his title (psychopompos). The rod is his rod from 5.47–48, in the same two lines: the wand that lulls and wakes the eyes of men now herds the suitors to Erebus. One instrument, both ends of the poem: enchantment and death were always the same tool. ↩
2. The bat simile: souls squeak like bats in a cave’s corner when one drops off the clinging chain. The suitors — feasters, shouters, throwers of stools — are reduced to a sound: τρίζειν, the thin squeak. No underworld image in Homer is more contemptuous or more pitiful; the men who filled a hall now cannot fill a whisper. ↩

3. The itinerary of the dead: Ocean's streams, the White Rock, the gates of the Sun, the country of dreams. The poem's far geography files its last report — and “the country of dreams” (δῆμον οὐείρων) lies on the road to death, one stop before the asphodel: Penelope's gates of horn and ivory (19.562ff) were border-crossings of this same land. ↩
4. “The phantoms of the worn-out dead” — εἴδωλα καμόντων: the dead as *the exhausted*, images of men who labored. The Odyssey's underworld was always a place of fatigue rather than fire; its last visit keeps the accent. ↩
5. The quartet: Achilles, Patroclus, Antilochus, Ajax — the Iliad's heart, waiting together, with Ajax's grudge (11.543ff) apparently outlived. The second Nekyia opens the poem's final ledger: before Odysseus' triumph can close, it must be measured once more against Troy's dead. ↩
6. Achilles' condolence inverts the first Nekyia: there (11.488ff) he spurned the consolations of glorious death — better a hired hand alive than king of the dead. Here he wishes Agamemnon had died at Troy for the tomb's and the son's sake. Death has not changed his mind; the two speeches agree — nothing redeems dying, but since die you must, the funeral and the fame are all that can be salvaged. ↩
7. “You in the swirl of the dust / lay great in your greatness, your horsemanship forgotten” — the Iliad's own line for Cebriones (Il. 16.775–776), re-spent on Achilles himself. The most beautiful epitaph in Greek: sheer size outlasting skill, the body still magnificent when everything it knew is gone. ↩

8. The Muses — all nine, “answering voice to lovely voice” — sing the dirge: their only full appearance in Homer. Poetry’s patronesses attend the funeral of poetry’s subject; epic sings at its own hero’s burial. Agamemnon’s report is the closest the tradition comes to describing its own birth: grief, organized into antiphonal beauty, until no Argive could keep from weeping. ↩
9. The golden amphora, “a gift of Dionysus... the work of famous Hephaestus”: wine-god’s gift, smith-god’s craft, holding the mixed bones of Achilles and Patroclus. The Iliad’s promise (23.83ff, Patroclus’ request) is confirmed kept, by a witness speaking from the far side of every death involved. ↩
10. The tomb on the Hellespont headland, “seen far off, from the open sea, by men now living and by men to come” — fame as coastal navigation-mark. Achilles’ immortality is architectural and real: sailors will steer by his death. This is the exact glory Agamemnon envies — a sightline — and the contrast with his own unmarked murder is the speech’s engine. ↩
11. The exchange’s two verdicts, set side by side: “not even in death did you lose your name” — and “But I? What joy of it had I...?” The poem’s oldest pairing (fame against homecoming) is settled by the dead themselves: Achilles won the name and lost everything; Agamemnon wound up the war and was butchered at dinner. Between them stands the absent third term — the man who got home *and* will get the song — about to be announced by the arriving shades. ↩
12. The suitors arrive in Hades as their killer makes his way out to his father’s farm. The poem’s two final locations — asphodel

and orchard — run in deliberate parallel: the dead explaining downward, the living replanting above. ↩

13. Agamemnon's guesses at how a hundred picked men died — shipwreck, cattle-raid, war for a city and its women — are the heroic economy's complete menu of respectable deaths. The truth (shot at dinner for eating another man's house) fits no category he can imagine; the suitors managed to die in a way the Iliad has no word for. ↩
14. Agamemnon's memory: a month's voyage and "hard work to win over Odysseus" — the tradition of the reluctant draftee (the madness feigned at the plow, in the cycle) surfacing for a moment. The man who had to be dragged from his wife is the one whose wife crowned his homecoming — while the king who mustered him got the knife; the poem lets the connection stand unspoken. ↩
15. Amphimedon's version adds a motive the poem never showed: Penelope delayed "plotting for us death and the black doom." From below, her stalling reads as premeditated murder — the web, the bow, all one design with her husband. The dead man's error (he also has Odysseus *ordering* her to set the contest, 167–168) is the famous crux: the last retelling of the plot is subtly wrong exactly where Penelope's independence was the truth. The suitors die as they lived — unable to imagine that her choices were her own. ↩
16. The web-story's third and last performance (2.94ff, Antinous' complaint; 19.139ff, her own account; now the victims' obituary). Same lines, third key: what was outrage in the suitor's mouth and stratagem in hers is here elegy — the trick

that measured out their deaths retold by its objects, verbatim, under the earth. The poem's most repeated passage is repeated once per perspective; the formula system as a rotating court.



17. Only this telling shows the finished shroud: "it shone like the sun or the moon." Laertes' burial-cloth, woven as a delaying fiction, emerges as a masterpiece — and the man it was woven for is alive in his orchard, about to be found by the son whose absence the weaving mourned. The web outlived its pretext into pure beauty — still a shroud, still waiting for its old man, but woven free of its trick; the poem gives the suitors' shade the honor of reporting it. ↩
18. "His cunning at work — he ordered his wife": wrong. Athena moved her (21.1ff), and the poem was explicit that Odysseus learned of the contest only as it happened. Amphimedon's reconstruction is rational, coherent, and false — the standing lesson of the Odyssey applied posthumously: the plausible story is not the true one. Agamemnon's great praise of Penelope (192ff) is built on this flawed brief and is still correct — the rare case of a right verdict from wrong findings. ↩
19. "Even now our bodies lie uncared-for" — the shade's complaint is settled before the book ends: at 417–419 the families bury them. The poem allows the dead their grievance and then quietly closes it, as if even the underworld's paperwork must be filed before the epic can end. "That is the portion of the dead" (γέρας θανόντων) — the phrase Laertes will use of the unmourned Odysseus at 296: burial rites as the one inheritance no one should lose. ↩

20. The macarism: “Blessed son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices — truly you won a wife of great excellence!” Agamemnon’s last word in literature is a beatitude for another man’s marriage. The ceremonial vocative (Calypso spoke it first, 5.203) is bent from “Zeus-born” to “Blessed” — ὀλβιε: the poem’s final ranking of its hero’s fortunes puts the wife above the war-fame. ↩
21. “The deathless ones will make a song for those on earth, a song of grace, for steady-hearted Penelope.” The Odyssey names itself: this poem is the song the gods made for Penelope. Twenty-three books were framed as the hero’s; the poem’s own certificate of contents, issued in Hades by the poem’s greatest victim of marriage, is made out in her name. ↩
22. And the counter-song: Clytemnestra as “a song of loathing” (στυγερὴ αἰοιδή). The double frame that opened the poem (1.32ff, Aegisthus) closes it: two wives, two songs. But Agamemnon cannot stop there — “she brings hard fame on all women, even on those who do right.” His last clause slanders the sex in the very breath that crowns its best member; the poem lets the bitterness stand, uncorrected, as the residue of his story — and its distance from Odysseus’ own conclusions is the measure of the two marriages. ↩
23. Farewell to the dead: “standing in the house of Hades, under the hidden places of the earth.” The poem leaves them mid-conversation — Achilles unconsolated, Agamemnon still explaining, the suitors still fresh — and surfaces for good. No judgment scene, no punishment: Homer’s underworld remains a place where the dead simply go on talking about what happened. ↩

24. Laertes' farm, "which Laertes himself had won long ago, when his labors for it were many" — κτεάτισσεν: acquired, earned. The estate is self-made, like the bed, like the orchard walls his slaves are out gathering stones for. Father and son hold things because they worked them; it is the ground of the whole coming scene. ↩
25. "I will make a trial of my father" — πειρήσομαι, the family verb, one last time. The most debated decision in the poem: why test a broken old man? The poem's own answers stand in layers: testing is his identity (he tested wife, son, slaves, father — everyone but the dog); recognition in this epic must be earned through σήματα or it is worthless; and the deliberation at 235–240 shows the alternative fully considered — kiss him and tell everything — and set aside. What the poem does not do is defend him; it lets the cruelty and the method be one thing, visibly, to the end. ↩
26. Laertes' costume: patched filthy tunic, stitched oxhide leggings, thorn-proof gloves, goatskin cap — the poem inventories it like armor. A king dressed below his own slaves, "feeding his sorrow": grief as deliberate self-abasement, the exact mirror of his son's chosen rags — Laertes' worn for years, Odysseus' for days. The recognition scene is two disguises meeting. ↩
27. Odysseus weeps under the pear tree before he can speak — the plan nearly dies at the sight of the old man. The pear tree is one of *the* trees (340); he cries under his own inheritance. Then the deliberation formula, and the coldest choice in the poem: "to try him first with words that bite" (κερτομίσις). The heart breaks and the method proceeds anyway; that is Odysseus, complete, in three lines. ↩

28. The tease is built on the book's true paradox: the orchard immaculate, the orchardist ruined — “everything is beautifully kept... you — you are not well kept.” And inside the cruelty, the recognition that keeps escaping the disguise's victims all poem: “nothing of the slave to be seen in you... you look like a kingly man” (Philoetius' exact perception of the beggar, 20.194). The son does to the father what the world did to him: sees the king through the wreck and asks the wreck to explain itself. ↩
29. The last false autobiography — a guest-tale of hosting Odysseus five years past, with a gift-list (gold, silver bowl, cloaks, four women) itemized in the same breath as 19's inventions. It is aimed, like the tale to Penelope, at producing evidence of grief; and it works instantly and terribly. ↩
30. “The gifts you showered on him — the countless gifts — were wasted”: Laertes answers a fiction with the deepest law of the poem — reciprocity broken by death. He grieves, in the middle of everything, for the *guest*: the stranger's gifts can never now be returned, “and that is the law, for whoever begins the kindness.” Even destroyed, the old king's first thought is the *xenia*-ledger. ↩
31. “My son, if he ever was” — εἴ ποτ' ἔην γε: Penelope's identical phrase (19.315), and Telemachus' before her (15.268). Son, wife, father — three members of one family have reached for the same broken-grammared doubt: whether the past itself was real. It is the poem's formula for grief so long it corrodes memory backward. ↩

32. The unmourned-corpse fantasy: fish in the sea or beasts and birds on land, no shroud from the mother, no keening wife, no closed eyes. Laertes has rehearsed his son's missing funeral in exact liturgical detail for years — the same nightmare Telemachus voiced (1.161ff) and Eumaeus (14.133ff). The family's shared image of the worst is precisely what the poem has spent 24 books preventing. ↩
33. The identity-question formula — “What man are you, and from where?” — asked for the last time in the poem, by the oldest asker, of the son it has pursued since Telemachus first put it to a disguised god at 1.170. The poem retires its oldest question here, where the answer will finally be given un-disguised. ↩
34. The last alias is a rebus of the truth: Eperitus (“Man of Strife” — the contested one) son of Apheidas (“Unsparing”) son of Polypemon (“Much-Suffering”), from Alybas (echoing ἀλάομαι, “wander”), driven from Sicania “against my will.” Read the genealogy straight and it confesses: a much-suffering, unsparing, strife-marked wanderer. Five books of fictitious selves end with a name-chain that is nothing but his own biography in etymological drag. ↩
35. “The fifth year... and the birds were good when he set out: on the right” — the fiction's cruelest instrument: dated hope with favorable omens attached. It is calibrated to make the old man compute — five years, good birds, no return — and it does; the grief-cloud closes over him on schedule. The tester has measured the exact dose that will break the subject. ↩
36. The dust: both hands, the scorched gray handfuls, poured over the white head, “sobbing thick and fast.” The oldest mourning

gesture in the epic tradition (Achilles at Il. 18.23ff), performed by a father over a living son standing an arm's length away. It is the strongest image in the book, and the experiment's result: grief confirmed genuine — at the price of causing it. ↩

37. “Up through his nostrils shot the sharp sting” — *δριμὺ μένος*: grief as physiology, the acrid rush before tears. The tester's system fails at last: not at the rags, not at the weeping, but at the dust on the white head. Every other test in the poem ran to completion; this one is aborted by the experimenter's own body. ↩
38. “Father — I am he. I myself, the man you ask for”: the poem's last self-revelation, and its shortest. To the son: “I am your father.” To the slaves: “I am the man himself.” To the father, the plainest of all — *κεῖνος ἐγώ*: *that man — I*. The pronoun the whole poem has been hiding is handed over bare. ↩
39. Laertes, shattered, mid-grief, his son's arms around him, still says: “tell me some sign, some plain one, so I can believe.” The family method holds at its weakest link — no recognition without evidence, not even here. Odysseus' father is the final proof of where Odysseus came from. ↩
40. The scar's fourth and last showing (Eurycleia, the herdsmen, now the father) — this time with its provenance spoken to the man who was part of it: “It was you who sent me — you and my honored mother.” The wound's biography (19.393ff) is finally recited to its origin; the *σῆμα* completes its circuit through the whole family. ↩
41. The trees: thirteen pear, ten apple, forty fig, fifty rows of vines “each one ripening in its own turn.” The poem's final

recognition-token is not a wound or a bed but an inheritance recited — a little boy trailing his father through the garden, begging for each tree, and the father naming them one by one. Proof of identity is here proof of having been loved as a child, in countable units still standing and bearing. No recognition in literature is gentler, and none more secure: only the boy who was given the trees can number them. ↩

42. Knees slack, tokens recognized — the identical couplet that felled Penelope (23.205–206), which itself repeated the clothes-test line (19.250). Wife, then father: the family falls to the same two verses, one by one. The formula system's last great rhyme; and this time the recognized man must catch the recognizer bodily — the father faints into the son's arms, the poem's final embrace of the generations. ↩

43. Laertes' theology, restored in one clause: "you gods are still there on high Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid." Divine existence proven by executed justice — the old man's faith was not lost but suspended pending evidence, like everything else in this family. And his second sentence is already tactical (the town will come): joy, theology, and threat-assessment in a single breath. He is Odysseus' father. ↩

44. Laertes bathed, oiled, cloaked, and filled out by Athena — the family glow-up's last recipient (Odysseus 6.229ff and 23.156ff, Penelope 18.190ff, Telemachus 2.12ff). The son "wondered at him, seeing him face to face like the deathless gods": the man found in rags and goatskin at noon stands god-like by dinner. The restoration of the house is rendered, as always in this poem, cosmetically — grace poured over those it reclaims. ↩

45. “If only — father Zeus, Athena, Apollo!” — the wish-formula’s final firing (Menelaus 4.341, relayed 17.132; Telemachus 18.235), now from the grandfather, wishing himself into yesterday’s battle with his Nericus-taking strength. Guest-friend, grandson, grandfather: the same optative wish has crossed the poem to land at last inside the family, its grammar of longing uniform down the line. ↩
46. Dolius — father of Melanthius and Melantho, though the poem breathes no word of it here. The old man greets his master with open arms while his son lies mutilated and his daughter hanged in the town house. Whether Homer suppresses the connection, or the Dolius of the farm was always distinct in the tradition, the silence sits like a held breath over the scene: the loyal father of the disloyal children asks after Penelope’s happiness. ↩
47. Dolius kisses Odysseus’ hand “at the wrist” — the precise clasp Penelope remembered of her husband’s farewell (18.258). The gesture-vocabulary of the house passes through its oldest servant intact. ↩
48. Dolius’ question — does Penelope know, “or shall we send a messenger?” — is the old retainer’s protocol-mind at work: the mistress must be informed. The last words spoken about Penelope in the poem are a servant’s worry for her feelings. ↩
49. “Old man, she knows already. Why should you be busied with that?” — clipped, faintly amused, and the poem’s final line concerning its heroine: *she knows already*. As epitaphs for Penelope go, the accidental one is perfect. ↩

50. Rumor (Ῥοσσα) as messenger — the divine personification that sped news at 1.282–283 now runs the massacre through the town. The poem’s information-economy closes its books: the secret held by disguise, oath, locked doors, and a faked wedding-dance is finally released as pure Ossa, everywhere at once. ↩
51. The burials — each family carries out its own, the foreign dead shipped home on fishermen’s boats — quietly answer Amphimedon’s complaint (186–190) before the assembly even meets. The poem does its last logistics: every corpse routed, every household in mourning, the stage cleared for the question of what the living will do about it. ↩
52. “A grief there was no forgetting” — ἄλαστον πένθος — lies on Eupheithes’ heart. Mark the word: the peace sixty lines away will be built on ἔκκλησις, *forgetting*, imposed by the gods (485). The book stages its final conflict as a duel between two nouns: the grief that cannot forget and the amnesty that commands it. ↩
53. Eupheithes’ indictment reaches back past the suitors to the fleet: “he lost the hollow ships, and lost the people” — the twelve ships’ companies of twenty years ago (9.159), never before charged to Odysseus’ account on Ithaca. The town’s whole ledger is opened: two generations of sons dead in this man’s wake. The poem does not rebut the charge — it is true — and Eupheithes’ grief is real; his own unpaid debt (saved from the mob by Odysseus, 16.424ff) is the one entry he omits. ↩
54. “A disgrace even for men unborn to hear of” — Eurymachus’ shame-formula from the bow-contest (21.255), now in the

father's mouth: the same posterity-panic that kept the suitors failing publicly at the bow drives their fathers to the vendetta. The idiom is hereditary, and it kills in both generations. ↩

55. Medon's eyewitness theology — "I myself saw a deathless god... like Mentor" — is precisely accurate reportage, for once believed. The herald saved for good deeds spends his reprieve on the truth, and "the pale terror" (the Nekyia's fear-formula, now loose above ground) does what argument could not. ↩
56. Halitherses, "who alone saw before and behind" — the seer whose eagle-reading the suitors mocked in Book 2 (2.157ff) with Eurymachus' "many birds fly about under the sun." His verdict now: "By your own fault, friends" — the fathers indicted for not curbing the sons, the poem's collective-responsibility clause. His counsel splits the city: more than half spring up at his word and quit the field, and it is the remnant that stays with Eupheithes and arms. After god, omen, massacre, and confession, the majority can at last be persuaded; the poem's last word on crowds is quieter than its reputation. ↩
57. "By your own fault" (ὅμετέρη κακότητι) — the assembly-scene of Book 2 replayed with the accusations reversed: there Telemachus blamed the fathers' sons; here the seer blames the sons' fathers, and the same men shout both times. Ithaca's civic machinery has learned exactly nothing — which is why the ending must be imposed from above. ↩
58. The split: "more than half" rise at the seer's word and go home; the rest, unpersuaded, arm and march. The poem is unsentimental about the peace it is about to declare — already

chosen by the many, it must still be enforced on the last armed few by divine amnesia. Utopia does not conclude the Odyssey; a managed settlement does. ↪

59. “Eupeithes led them, in his folly... never to come back: he was to meet his own fate there.” The narrator’s death-notice formula, served on the vendetta’s leader before the march begins — as it was served on Antinous (21.98ff). Father and son get identical advance obituaries, one book apart: the house of Eupeithes is the poem’s control experiment in how grief without wisdom breeds in place. ↪

60. The last Olympian scene mirrors the first: Athena raising Odysseus’ case with Zeus (1.44ff), now raising its epilogue — “war, or friendship between the two?” The poem’s entire action is bracketed by this daughter managing this father; and his answer here — “was it not you who framed this plan yourself? Do as you will” — is the same amused delegation that launched Book 1. The Odyssey is, first to last, Athena’s project with Zeus’s countersignature. ↪

61. The settlement’s terms: oaths cut, Odysseus king “all his days,” and — the extraordinary clause — “let us set a forgetting of the killing of sons and of brothers” (ἐκλῆσιν θέωμεν): whether a literal blotting of memory or an amnesty in the word’s oldest sense, a laying-down of the grievance, the text does not say. The poem of memory — whose hero is saved by remembering, whose heroine proves love by remembering, whose recognition-tokens are all memories — ends by prescribing an ordained forgetting, however administered, as the price of civil peace. “Let them love one another as before; and let wealth and peace be there in plenty”: the most beautiful and

most troubling sentence of political theology in Homer, and the poem offers it without irony as what it costs to stop the cycle. ↩

62. The muster: twelve — Odysseus' four, Dolius' six, and the two old men, "gray though they were: fighters because they must be" (ἀναγκαῖοι πολεμισταί). The house's whole remaining manhood, from grandfather to field-hand's sons, in one rank. Against them, the town. The poem's last battle-roster is a family and its farm. ↩
63. The father's last instruction: "shame nothing of your fathers' line. In strength and manhood we have excelled from of old across the whole earth." Not tactics — lineage. And the son's answer deploys his whole arc in one cool sentence: *watch, if you care to*. The boy who needed a goddess to imagine his father now invites his father to spectate. ↩
64. Laertes' cry — "What a day this is for me, dear gods! Great is my joy: my son and my son's son are striving over excellence!" The poem's final happiness is the grandfather's: three generations armed in one line, competing in ἀρετή. For this one line the Odyssey becomes what the Iliad never could: an epic in which the generations survive to stand together. It is the book's true summit, and the poem places it — with perfect judgment — in the mouth of the man who had been digging round a tree in a goatskin cap that morning. ↩
65. "Son of Arceisius — far the dearest of all my companions": Athena's tenderness for the old man, addressed by the grandfather-patronymic, admitted to the company of her ἑταῖροι. She scripts his aristeia — pray, swing, throw — and

breathes the strength in. The poem grants its last kill to its oldest fighter. ↩

66. Laertes' single throw kills Eupheithes through the bronze-cheeked helmet. The symmetry is the poem's last arithmetic: Antinous, first-killed, was Eupheithes' son; now Antinous' father falls to Odysseus' father. Grief against grief, father against father — the vendetta's own logic executed once, exactly. It is the last kill the poem narrates, though father and son fight on until Athena calls the halt (526–544); the old man who missed yesterday's battle (379–382) gets his one spear-cast in compensation. ↩

67. "They would have destroyed them all, cut them off from homecoming" — ἀνόστους: made *nostos*-less. The poem's ultimate curse-word, nearly inflicted by its own hero on his neighbors. Athena's cry — "separate now, quickly, and without blood!" (ἀναίμωτῇ) — arrives one death too late to be literal; the word is aspiration, not description, and the poem knows it. ↩

68. The pale terror's last seizure: weapons fly from hands at a goddess's voice, and the townsmen turn for home "aching to live" (λιλαϊόμενοι βιότοιο). The suitors were never once described as aching to live; their fathers, at the last moment, are — and are spared for it. Wanting life, in this poem, has always been the beginning of deserving it. ↩

69. And Odysseus does not stop. He cries out terribly and swoops "like a high-flown eagle" — the omen-bird of his own return (15.161ff, 19.538ff, 20.243) become the man himself, stooping on the routed. It takes Zeus' thunderbolt, dropped at Athena's

feet, to check him: heaven must interdict its own champion, in the last forty lines, to keep the poem from ending as the Iliad. The war-reflex twenty years deep does not switch off; it is *commanded* off. ↩

70. The final address is the full ceremonial vocative, one last time: “Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices — hold!” The title that summoned him to councils and stratagems all poem long is used, at the end, to tell him to stop. “He obeyed — and his heart was glad” (χαῖρε δὲ θυμῷ): the last interior note of the Odyssey is relief — the man of wrath and craft glad, at the end, to be prevented. Of all the poem’s homecomings, this is the innermost one: permission to stop fighting, received with joy. ↩
71. The coda: the sworn peace “for all days to come,” set by Pallas Athena “likened to Mentor in body and in voice.” The poem ends not on the couple, not on the family, but on the polity — pacified by oath and enforced forgetting — and its very last line is a disguise: the goddess wearing, to the end, the borrowed shape of an old Ithacan friend. The Odyssey closes as it worked: divinity in a familiar face, and the future held together by a carefully constructed appearance. Whatever the Alexandrians thought of Book 24, the poem’s final image is its signature — μήτις, wearing a human face, making peace stick. The song the gods made for Penelope, and for the man at odds, is complete. ↩

Index of Names and Places

Every named person, god, people, and place in the poem, with a pronunciation (*Say:*), epithets, aliases, kin, and line citations. Each citation is a link — tap a **book.line** number to jump to that verse. Pronunciations give the traditional anglicized reading; **stress falls on the capitalized syllable**.

Achaea (Ἀχαιῶα) · PLACE — *Say:* uh-KEE-uh

The Greek mainland, the Achaeans' homeland, named in passing as the country Odysseus's men and Penelope's suitors alike measure their exile or their marriages against.

Refs: [11.166](#), [11.481](#), [21.107](#), [23.68](#).

See also: Achaeans.

Achaeans (Ἀχαιοί) · PEOPLE — Say: uh-KEE-unz

The poem's default name for the Greeks who sailed to Troy and for their descendants on Ithaca and elsewhere; interchangeable throughout with Argives and Danaans. Invoked constantly as the collective audience, army, or assembly against which individual action is measured.

Epithets: “the long-haired Achaeans” (κάρη κομόωντες Ἀχαιοί, 1.90); “the strong-greaved Achaeans” (ἔυκνήμιδες Ἀχαιοί, 2.72); “the bronze-shirted Achaeans” (χαλκοχίτωνες Ἀχαιοί, 1.286).

Also called: Argives; Danaans — synonyms for the same host, metrically convenient variants, not distinct peoples.

Refs: 1.90, 1.239, 1.272, 1.286, 2.7, 2.72, 3.79, 3.100, 3.137, 4.106, 4.330 ...and throughout. Books 1–24.

See also: Achaea, Troy.

Acheron (Ἀχέρων) · PLACE — Say: AK-uh-ron

One of the underworld's rivers, named at the

meeting of the waters where Circe directs
Odysseus to perform the rites that summon the
dead.

Refs: 10.513.

See also: Aeaëa.

Achilles (Ἀχιλλεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-KIL-eez
Greatest of the Achaeans at Troy, remembered
throughout the poem as the standard against
which other heroes and other deaths are
measured. His ghost, met in the underworld,
rejects Odysseus's consolations: he would
rather serve as a hired hand to a landless man
than rule over all the dead (11.486ff). In the
underworld's final scene his shade is reunited
with the ghosts of the newly dead suitors,
hearing of Odysseus's homecoming vengeance.
Also called: "Aeacides," son of Peleus and
grandson of Aeacus (11.471, 11.538); "the
blameless son of Peleus."

Kin: son of Peleus.

Refs: 3.106, 3.109, 3.189, 4.5, 8.75, 11.467, 11.471,
11.478, 11.482, 11.486, 11.538, 11.546, 11.558,

24.15, 24.19, 24.36, 24.72, 24.76, 24.94. Books 3–4, 8, 11, 24.

See also: Ajax, Antilochus, Agamemnon.

Actoris (Ἀκτορίς) · MORTAL — *Say:* ak-TOR-is
Penelope's slave-woman, given to her by her father when she first came to Ithaca; she alone knew the secret of the bedchamber door, and Penelope cites her as the one living witness who could confirm the bed's construction — though by the time of the recognition scene she is dead.

Refs: 23.228.

See also: Penelope.

Adreste (Ἀδρήστη) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-DRES-tee
One of Helen's handmaids in Sparta, who sets out her reclining chair when Helen enters the hall to greet Telemachus.

Refs: 4.123.

See also: Alcippe, Alcandre.

Aeaea (Αἶαῖα) · PLACE — Say: ee-EE-uh or ay-EE-uh

Circe's island, where Odysseus's crew lands after the Laestrygonian disaster; the ship returns there after the underworld voyage before the final sailing past the Sirens and through the strait of Scylla and Charybdis.

Refs: 9.32, 10.135, 11.70, 12.3, 12.268, 12.273.

See also: Acheron.

Aeetes (Αἰήτης) · MORTAL — Say: ee-EE-teez

Sorcerer-king of Aea, son of Helios and brother of Circe; named as a genealogical marker of Circe's fearsome bloodline and, in Book 12, as one whose home the sun rises from in Circe's directions.

Kin: son of Helios; brother of Circe.

Refs: 10.137, 12.70.

See also: Aeaea, Helios, Circe.

Aegae (Αἰγαί) · PLACE — Say: EE-jee

Poseidon's seat beneath the sea, where he keeps his glittering golden palace; named as the

god descends to watch Odysseus's raft from the mountains of the Solymi.

Refs: 5.381.

See also: Poseidon.

Aegisthus (Αἴγισθος) · MORTAL — Say: ee-JIS-thus
Son of Thyestes and cousin to Agamemnon;
while Agamemnon fights at Troy he seduces
Clytemnestra, murders the king at his
homecoming feast, and rules Mycenae for years
until Orestes kills him in vengeance. Zeus opens
the poem citing him (1.29–43) as proof that
mortals bring ruin on themselves “beyond their
portion,” and Nestor and Menelaus both retell
the story to Telemachus as the poem's standing
counter-example to Odysseus's own return.

Epithets: “blameless Aegisthus” (ἄμύμων
Αἴγισθος, 1.29); “Aegisthus of the crooked
counsels” (Αἴγισθος δολόμητις, 1.300).

Kin: son of Thyestes; paramour of Clytemnestra.

Refs: 1.29, 1.35, 1.42, 1.300, 3.194–198, 3.235–310
(Nestor's telling), 4.518–537, 11.389, 11.409,

24.22, 24.97. Books 1, 3–4, 11, 24.

See also: Agamemnon, Orestes.

Aegyptius (Αἰγύπτιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ee-JIP-tee-us

Aged Ithacan, bent with years, who opens the assembly Telemachus calls in Book 2; his own son Antiphus had sailed to Troy with Odysseus and was later killed by the Cyclops.

Kin: father of Antiphus.

Refs: 2.15.

See also: Antiphus.

Aeolus (Αἴολος) · GOD — *Say:* EE-oh-lus

Warden of the winds, son of Hippotes; he hosts Odysseus for a month and sends him off with the storm winds bound in a leather bag, keeping only the West Wind free to carry the ships home. His men's greed opens the bag within sight of Ithaca, and when the storm blows them back to his island a second time, Aeolus refuses to help further, certain the gods

hate his guest.

Kin: son of Hippotes.

Refs: 10.1–60, 11.237, 23.314. Books 10–11, 23.

See also: Odysseus.

Aeson (Ἀΐσων) · MORTAL — *Say:* EE-son

Son of Tyro and Cretheus, named among Tyro's sons in the underworld catalogue; father of Jason in the wider tradition, though the poem itself says no more of him.

Kin: son of Tyro and Cretheus; brother of Pheres and Amythaon.

Refs: 11.259.

See also: Amythaon.

Aethon (Ἀἴθων) · MORTAL — *Say:* EE-thon

The false name Odysseus gives himself in the fictitious autobiography he tells Penelope in Book 19, claiming to be the younger brother of Idomeneus of Crete who once hosted the real Odysseus storm-driven at Amnisus.

Refs: 19.183.

See also: Amnisus, Odysseus.

Aetolians (Αἰτωλοί) · PEOPLE — Say: ee-TOH-lee-unz

The people of the mainland stranger who once cheated Eumaeus with a false tale about Odysseus, the memory of which makes the swineherd wary of the next wandering beggar's story.

Refs: 14.379.

See also: Eumaeus.

Agamemnon (Ἀγαμέμνων) · MORTAL — Say: ag-uh-MEM-non

Overlord of the Achaean host at Troy, elder son of Atreus and brother of Menelaus. Murdered by Aegisthus and Clytemnestra at his homecoming, his shade meets Odysseus in the underworld (11.387ff) and his fate is retold by Nestor, by Proteus through Menelaus, and finally by his own ghost again in Book 24 — the

poem's recurring paradigm of the ruined return, set against Odysseus's own.

Epithets: "shepherd of the people" (ποιμὴν λαῶν, 3.156).

Also called: "son of Atreus" / "Atreides" — but so is Menelaus; the referent is Agamemnon in the underworld and homecoming-paradigm scenes, Menelaus in the Telemachy (see canon.md).

Kin: son of Atreus; husband of Clytemnestra; father of Orestes; brother of Menelaus.

Refs: 1.30, 3.143–164, 3.234–264, 4.532–584, 8.77, 9.263, 11.168, 11.387–397, 13.384, 14.70–497, 24.20–186. Books 1, 3–4, 8–9, 11, 13–14, 24.

See also: Aegisthus, Menelaus, Orestes.

Agelaus (Ἀγέλαος) · MORTAL — Say: aj-uh-LAY-us
Son of Damastor and one of the leading suitors in the final fight in the hall; he urges the others on and is among the last killed, cut down by Odysseus after Athena's aegis turns the tide.

Kin: son of Damastor.

Refs: 20.321, 20.339, 22.131, 22.136, 22.212,

22.241, 22.247, 22.327. Books 20, 22.

See also: Antinous, Eurymachus.

Ajax (Αἴας) · MORTAL — *Say:* AY-jaks

Two heroes share the name. The greater Ajax, son of Telamon, was second only to Achilles among the Achaeans at Troy; in the underworld his shade alone refuses to speak to Odysseus, still raging over the contest for Achilles's armor that Odysseus won against him (11.543–553). A second, lesser Ajax, son of Oileus, drowns at sea on the voyage home after boasting he escaped the gods' will — the wreck Menelaus recounts hearing of from Proteus (4.499).

Kin: the greater, son of Telamon; the lesser, son of Oileus.

Refs: 3.109, 4.499, 11.469, 11.543–553, 24.17.

Books 3–4, 11, 24.

See also: Achilles, Agamemnon.

Alcandre (Ἀλκάνδρη) · MORTAL — *Say:* al-KAN-dree

Egyptian woman, wife of Polybus of Thebes, who gave Helen a silver basket among the gifts the couple brought back from Egypt.

Refs: 4.126.

See also: Adreste, Alcippe.

Alcimus (Ἀλκιμος) · MORTAL — *Say:* AL-sih-mus

Father of Mentor, named once when Mentor's household is identified during the suitors' final assault.

Kin: father of Mentor.

Refs: 22.235.

See also: Mentor.

Alcinous (Ἀλκίνοος) · MORTAL — *Say:* al-SIN-oh-us

King of the Phaeacians on Scheria and Odysseus's last host before Ithaca. He receives the shipwrecked stranger, presides over the games and feast at which Odysseus is moved to tell his wanderings, and sends him home asleep on a Phaeacian ship laden with gifts — the act for which Poseidon later turns that ship to

stone.

Epithets: “great-hearted Alcinous” (μεγαλήτωρ Ἀλκίνοος, 6.17); “the sacred strength of Alcinous” (ἱερὸν μένος Ἀλκινόοιο, 7.167).

Kin: son of Nausithous (himself a son of Poseidon), brother of Rhexenor; marries his niece Arete; father of Nausicaa and Laodamas.

Refs: 6.12–17, 6.139–303, 7.10–346 (the reception and the genealogy), 8.2–421 (games and feast). Books 6–9, 11, 13.

See also: Arete, Nausicaa, Poseidon.

Alcippe (Ἀλκίππη) · MORTAL — *Say:* al-SIP-ee

One of Helen’s handmaids in Sparta, who brings a rug of soft wool as Helen enters to greet Telemachus.

Refs: 4.124.

See also: Adreste, Alcandre.

Alcmaeon (Ἀλκμαίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* alk-MEE-on

Son of the seer Amphiaraus, named alongside

his brother Amphilochus in Theoclymenus's account of his own ancestry.

Kin: son of Amphiaraus.

Refs: 15.248.

See also: Amphiaraus, Amphilochus.

Alcmene (Ἀλκμήνη) · MORTAL — *Say:* alk-MEE-nee
Wife of Amphitryon; lying with Zeus, she bore Heracles. Named among the great women's shades Odysseus meets in the underworld, and invoked earlier by Antinous as a byword for the cunning of legendary women, in his backhanded praise of Penelope's web-trick.
Kin: wife of Amphitryon; mother of Heracles by Zeus.

Refs: 2.120, 11.266. Books 2, 11.

See also: Amphitryon.

Alector (Ἀλέκτωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-LEK-tor
Spartan whose daughter marries Megapenthes, Menelaus's son, in the double wedding feast under way when Telemachus arrives at Sparta.

Refs: 4.10.

See also: Menelaus.

Aloeus (Ἄλωεύς) · MORTAL — Say: uh-LEE-us or al-OH-yoos

Putative father, by marriage to Iphimedeia, of the giant twins Otus and Ephialtes — though Iphimedeia claims she lay with Poseidon himself. Named in the underworld catalogue of famous women.

Kin: husband of Iphimedeia.

Refs: 11.305.

See also: Poseidon.

Alpheus (Ἄλφειός) · PLACE — Say: al-FEE-us or AL-fee-us

The great river of Elis, treated as a god in its own right; ancestor, several generations back, of Ortilochus and so of the Spartan house that hosts Telemachus.

Refs: 3.489, 15.187.

See also: Achaea.

Alybas (Ἄλυβας) · PLACE — Say: AL-ih-bas

The distant town Odysseus invents as his home when he tests Laertes in disguise at the poem's end, claiming to be one Eperitus, son of Apheidas, from Alybas.

Refs: 24.304.

See also: Apheidas.

Amnisus (Ἀμνισός) · PLACE — Say: am-NY-sus

Cretan harbor by the cave of Eileithyia, where in the fictitious Aethon-tale Odysseus tells Penelope the storm once drove the real Odysseus ashore on his way to Troy.

Refs: 19.188.

See also: Aethon.

Amphiaraus (Ἀμφιάραος) · MORTAL — Say: am-fee-uh-RAY-us

Seer and warrior, son of Oicles, beloved of Zeus and Apollo; he dies at Thebes, brought down by a woman's bribe (the necklace given his wife to persuade him into the fatal expedition). Named

in Theoclymenus's account of his own descent from the seer's line; father of Alcmaeon and Amphilochus.

Kin: son of Oicles; father of Alcmaeon and Amphilochus.

Refs: 15.244, 15.253. Book 15.

See also: Alcmaeon, Amphilochus, Amythaon.

Amphilochus (Ἀμφίλοχος) · MORTAL — *Say:* am-FIL-oh-kus

Son of the seer Amphiaraus, named alongside his brother Alcmaeon in Theoclymenus's ancestral catalogue.

Kin: son of Amphiaraus.

Refs: 15.248.

See also: Amphiaraus, Alcmaeon.

Amphimedon (Ἀμφιμέδων) · MORTAL — *Say:* am-FIM-uh-don

Son of Melaneus and one of the suitors killed in the hall; his ghost, arriving in the underworld among the newly dead, narrates the whole

courtship and slaughter to the shade of Agamemnon in Book 24 — the poem's last long retelling of its own climax.

Kin: son of Melaneus.

Refs: 22.242, 22.277, 22.284, 24.103–120. Books 22, 24.

See also: Agamemnon, Antinous.

Amphinomus (Ἀμφίνομος) · MORTAL — Say: am-FIN-oh-mus

Son of Nisus and the least brutal of Penelope's suitors, well-spoken enough that Odysseus, in disguise, tries to warn him away from the household's doom — advice he cannot bring himself to heed, since Athena has bound him to die by Telemachus's spear.

Kin: son of Nisus.

Refs: 16.351–406, 18.119–424, 20.244–247, 22.89–96 (his death). Books 16, 18, 20, 22.

See also: Antinous, Eurymachus.

Amphion (Ἀμφίων) · MORTAL — Say: am-FY-on

Two men share the name. One, son of Zeus and Antiope, co-founds and walls Thebes with his brother Zethus (11.262). The other, son of Iasus, ruled Minyan Orchomenus and was father of Chloris, Nestor's mother (11.283).

Refs: 11.262, 11.283. Book 11.

See also: Antiope.

Amphithea (Ἀμφιθέη) · MORTAL — Say: am-FITH-ee-uh

Wife of Autolycus and Odysseus's grandmother; she embraces him with joy when he arrives at his grandfather's house as a boy, in the tale of the boar-hunt that gave Odysseus his scar.

Kin: wife of Autolycus.

Refs: 19.416.

See also: Anticleia.

Amphitrite (Ἀμφιτρίτη) · GOD — Say: am-fih-TRY-tee

The sea personified as goddess, wife of

Poseidon; invoked in descriptions of the deep waters Odysseus must cross, especially in the storm off Scheria.

Kin: wife of Poseidon.

Refs: 3.91, 5.422, 12.60, 12.97. Books 3, 5, 12.

See also: Poseidon.

Amphitryon (Ἀμφιτρυών) · MORTAL — *Say:* am-FIT-ree-on

Mortal husband of Alcmene and Heracles's putative father, named alongside his wife in the underworld catalogue of famous women.

Kin: husband of Alcmene.

Refs: 11.266, 11.270. Book 11.

See also: Alcmene.

Amythaon (Ἀμυθάων) · MORTAL — *Say:* am-ih-THAY-on

Son of Tyro and Cretheus, named among her sons in the underworld catalogue of women.

Kin: son of Tyro and Cretheus; brother of Aeson and Pheres.

Refs: 11.259.

See also: Aeson, Amphiaraus.

Andraemon (Ἀνδραίμων) · MORTAL — Say: an-DREE-mon

Father of Thoas, named only as a patronymic in the fictitious Trojan-War anecdote Odysseus tells Eumaeus in disguise: Thoas, Andraemon's son, is the one who jumps up to carry a message from a dream.

Kin: father of Thoas.

Refs: 14.499.

See also: Aetolians.

Anticleia (Ἀντίκλεια) · MORTAL — Say: an-tih-KLEE-uh or an-tih-KLY-uh

Odysseus's mother, who died of grief in his long absence without learning of his fate; her shade is the first Odysseus recognizes in the underworld, and their failed embrace — his arms closing three times on empty air — is one of the poem's starkest images of loss.

Kin: daughter of Autolycus; wife of Laertes;
mother of Odysseus.

Refs: 11.85.

See also: Laertes, Amphithea.

Anticlus (Ἄντικλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* AN-tih-klus
Achaean hidden with Odysseus inside the
wooden horse; when Helen, circling it, calls out
in the voices of their wives, Anticlus alone is on
the point of answering, and Odysseus clamps
his hands over the man's mouth to save them
all.

Refs: 4.286.

See also: Odysseus.

Antilochus (Ἀντίλοχος) · MORTAL — *Say:* an-TIL-
oh-kus
Nestor's son and Achilles's close friend, killed at
Troy; recalled in Nestor's own account of the
war's losses and named among the shades
gathered around Achilles in the underworld.
Kin: son of Nestor.

Refs: 3.112, 4.187, 4.202, 11.468, 24.16, 24.78.

Books 3–4, 11, 24.

See also: Achilles, Ajax.

Antinous (Ἀντίνοος) · MORTAL — Say: an-TIN-oh-us

Son of Eupeithes and the most violent of Penelope's suitors; with Eurymachus he leads them, openly hostile where Eurymachus is smooth. He masterminds the ambush laid for Telemachus's return (4.660ff, 16.363–418) and hurls a stool at the disguised Odysseus in the hall (17.462ff), the worst outrage of the beggar-baiting.

Kin: son of Eupeithes.

Refs: 1.383–389, 2.84–321, 4.628–773, 16.363–418, 17.374–500, 18.34–292, 20.270–275, 21.84–269. Books 1–2, 4, 16–18, 20–21.

See also: Eupeithes, Eurymachus, Penelope.

Antiope (Ἀντιόπη) · MORTAL — Say: an-TY-oh-pee
Daughter of Asopus; lying with Zeus she bore

Amphion and Zethus, the twin founders of Thebes. Named in the underworld catalogue of women.

Kin: mother of Amphion and Zethus by Zeus.

Refs: 11.260.

See also: Amphion.

Antiphates (Ἀντιφάτης) · MORTAL — *Say:* an-TIF-uh-teez

Two men share the name. One is the Laestrygonian king who wrecks Odysseus's fleet, hurling a boulder-sized rock and seizing a scout for his dinner before his people sink all but one ship (Book 10). The other is a mortal seer, son of Melampus's grandson Mantius, named in Theoclymenus's ancestral catalogue as father of Oicles (Book 15).

Refs: 10.106, 10.114, 10.199, 15.242, 15.243.

See also: Amphiarus.

Antiphus (Ἀντίφος) · MORTAL — *Say:* AN-tih-fus

Two men share the name. One is Aegyptius's

son, who sailed with Odysseus to Troy and was later killed and eaten by the Cyclops Polyphemus. The other is a loyal old Ithacan, a companion of Odysseus's father from the beginning, who sits with Mentor and Halitherses as Telemachus slips away from the suitors.

Refs: 2.19, 17.68. Books 2, 17.

See also: Aegyptius, Polyphemus.

Apeire · PLACE — Say: uh-PY-ree

The land from which Nausicaa's nurse Eurymedusa was carried off in ships, long before entering the Phaeacian royal household.

Refs: 7.8, 7.9.

See also: Scheria.

Apheidas (Ἀφείδας) · MORTAL — Say: uh-FY-das

Invented father — “son of lord Polypemon” — in the false identity Odysseus gives himself when he tests Laertes in disguise, claiming to be Eperitus of Alybas.

Refs: 24.305.

See also: Alybas.

Aphrodite (Ἀφροδίτη) · GOD — *Say:* af-roh-DY-tee
Goddess of love, here daughter of Zeus and
Dione; her one extended appearance is
Demodocus's song at the Phaeacian feast,
caught in bed with Ares by Hephaestus's
invisible net and displayed to the laughing gods
(8.267–362). Elsewhere she is invoked chiefly as
a standard of beauty, for Helen, Penelope, and
Nausicaa alike.

Epithets: “laughter-loving Aphrodite”

(φιλομμειδῆς Ἀφροδίτη, 8.362).

Refs: 4.14, 4.261, 8.267–362, 17.37, 18.193, 19.54,
20.68–73, 22.444. Books 4, 8, 17–20, 22.

See also: Ares, Hephaestus.

Apollo (Ἀπόλλων) · GOD — *Say:* uh-POL-oh
Archer-god of the silver bow, invoked as a
standard of deadly and beautiful skill
throughout — Odysseus prays men could shoot

like him, Telemachus is compared to him, and it is on Apollo's own festival day that the suitors are slaughtered. Demodocus sings that Apollo warned Agamemnon of coming strife between Odysseus and Achilles at Troy.

Also called: Phoebus (3.279, 8.79, 9.201).

Refs: 3.279, 6.162, 7.65, 8.79–339, 9.198–201, 15.245–526, 17.132–494, 18.235, 19.86, 20.278, 21.267–364, 22.7, 24.376. Books 3–4, 6–9, 15, 17–22, 24.

See also: Artemis.

Arceisius (Ἀρκείσιος) · MORTAL — Say: ar-SEE-see-us

Odysseus's grandfather and father of Laertes; the line “son of Arceisius” marks Laertes's own royal descent, and Odysseus later prays to Zeus by his grandfather's name before the final battle with the suitors' kinsmen.

Kin: father of Laertes; grandfather of Odysseus.

Refs: 4.756, 14.181, 16.118, 24.270, 24.517. Books 4, 14, 16, 24.

See also: Laertes, Odysseus.

Ares (Ἄρης) · GOD — Say: AIR-eez

War-god, Aphrodite's lover in Demodocus's song, caught with her in Hephaestus's net and shamed before the gods (Book 8); elsewhere invoked as the standard of ferocity in battle and the eponym of martial vigor.

Refs: 8.115–355, 8.517, 11.537, 14.216, 15.169, 16.269. Books 8, 11, 14–16.

See also: Aphrodite, Hephaestus.

Arete (Ἀρήτη) · MORTAL — Say: uh-REE-tee

Queen of the Phaeacians, Alcinous's wife and niece; Athena tells Odysseus his whole reception depends on winning her favor, and it is Arete who first recognizes the clothes she wove as the ones she gave Odysseus, prompting the question of his identity.

Kin: daughter of Rhexenor; wife of her uncle Alcinous.

Refs: 7.54–66, 7.141–335, 8.423–438, 11.335, 13.57–66. Books 7–8, 11, 13.

See also: Alcinous, Nausicaa.

Arethusa (Ἀρέθουσα) · PLACE — Say: a-ruh-THOO-zuh

Spring by Raven's Rock where Eumaeus's pigs drink, named in the description of the swineherd's steading.

Refs: 13.408.

See also: Eumaeus.

Aretus (Ἄρητος) · MORTAL — Say: uh-REE-tus

One of Nestor's sons at Pylos, who helps prepare the bath and the chariot for Telemachus's visit.

Kin: son of Nestor.

Refs: 3.414, 3.440.

See also: Antilochus, Peisistratus.

Argives (Ἀργεῖοι) · PEOPLE — Say: AR-jyvz or AR-gyvz

One of the poem's three interchangeable names for the Greek host at Troy, alongside Achaeans and Danaans — from Argos, the Peloponnesian homeland of the expedition's leaders. It carries

no separate ethnic sense from the others; the poet reaches for whichever fits the meter.

Refs: 1.61, 3.133, 4.184, 8.578, 11.369, 11.500, 17.119, 19.125, 24.61 ...and throughout. Books 1–4, 8, 10–12, 15, 17–19, 23–24.

See also: Achaeans, Danaans, Argos.

Argo (Ἀργώ) · OTHER — Say: AR-goh

The ship “known to all,” Jason’s vessel returning from Aeetes’ land; among all ships that have ever tried the Wandering Rocks, it alone got through, and only because Hera favored Jason. Circe cites it to Odysseus as the sole precedent for surviving that passage.

Refs: 12.70.

See also: Charybdis, Scylla.

Argos (Ἄργος) · PLACE — Say: AR-gos

The Peloponnesian city and region ruled by the house of Atreus — distinct from Argus the hound, though the two names collide in English. It anchors the Achaean world

geographically: Menelaus's Sparta and Agamemnon's Mycenae both fall within its orbit, and "Argive" derives from it.

Refs: 1.344, 3.180, 4.99, 4.726, 15.80, 15.239, 18.246, 21.108, 24.37. Books 1, 3–4, 15, 18, 21, 24.
See also: Argives, Agamemnon, Menelaus.

Argus (Ἄργος) · OTHER — Say: AR-gus

Odysseus's old hound, raised as a pup and left behind when his master sailed for Troy. Neglected and dying on a dung-heap outside the hall, he alone among the household recognizes the beggar-disguised Odysseus — he lays back his ears and wags his tail, and the moment he has seen his master again, "the doom of black death took him" (17.326). Not to be confused with the Argus of "slayer of Argus," Hermes's epithet for a different, giant figure (see Hermes).

Refs: 17.292 (introduced), 17.300, 17.326 (dies), 24.99 (recalled). Book 17.

See also: Hermes, Odysseus, Eumaeus.

Ariadne (Ἀριάδνη) · MORTAL — Say: a-ree-AD-nee
Daughter of Minos of Crete; Theseus carries her off from Crete toward Athens but never wins his joy of her — Artemis kills her first, on the island of Dia, on Dionysus's word. Odysseus glimpses her shade among the heroines in the underworld.

Refs: 11.321.

See also: Crete, Minos (see Cnossus).

Arnaeus (Ἀρνᾱῖος) · MORTAL — Say: ar-NEE-us
The real name of the beggar everyone in Odysseus's hall calls Irus, given him by his mother at birth.

Refs: 18.5.

See also: Antinous.

Artacia (Ἀρτακίη) · PLACE — Say: ar-TAY-shee-uh
The spring in the land of the Laestrygonians, where Odysseus's men meet the giant king's daughter drawing water — the first contact before the slaughter of the fleet.

Refs: 10.108.

See also: Cicones.

Artemis (Ἄρτεμις) · GOD — *Say:* AR-tuh-mis

Virgin archer-goddess, sister of Apollo; the poem invokes her chiefly as the sender of sudden, painless death to women — Penelope prays for such an end more than once, and the phrase recurs of dead heroines. She also kills Ariadne on Dionysus's word (11.324) and lends her form and grace to similes for Nausicaa and Penelope alike.

Epithets: “of the golden shafts” (4.122 and elsewhere).

Refs: 4.122, 6.102, 6.151, 11.172, 11.324, 15.410, 17.37, 18.202, 19.54, 20.60. Books 4–6, 11, 15, 17–20.

See also: Apollo, Penelope, Nausicaa.

Arybas (Ἀρύβακς) · MORTAL — *Say:* AR-ih-bas

A rich Phoenician named in Eumaeus's life-story — his old nurse's homeland belonged to

Arybas before Phoenician traders and a treacherous nursemaid carried the boy Eumaeus off into slavery.

Refs: 15.426.

See also: Eumaeus.

Asopus (Ἄσωπός) · GOD — Say: uh-SOH-pus

A river-god, father of Antiope, whom Zeus loves; their sons Amphion and Zethus later found and wall the city of Thebes. Named as Odysseus catalogues the heroines in the underworld.

Refs: 11.260.

See also: Cadmeians.

Asphalion (Ἀσφαλίων) · MORTAL — Say: as-FAL-ee-on

An attendant of Menelaus in his Spartan hall, mentioned once as he serves at the feast.

Refs: 4.216.

See also: Menelaus.

Asteris (Ἄστερίς) · PLACE — Say: AS-tuh-ris

A small islet in the strait between Ithaca and Same where the suitors lie in wait to ambush Telemachus's ship on his return from Pylos and Sparta.

Refs: 4.846.

See also: Antinous.

Athena (Ἀθήνη) · GOD — Say: uh-THEE-nuh

Daughter of Zeus and Odysseus's divine patron; the intelligence behind the whole plot. She wins his release from Calypso at the gods' council, rouses Telemachus to act and sail, guides him to Pylos and Sparta, transforms and shields Odysseus on Ithaca, fights at his side in the hall, and imposes the final peace between him and the suitors' kin. More than any other god she moves in disguise — as Mentès, as Mentor, as unnamed mortals.

Epithets: “gray-eyed Athena” (γλαυκῶπις Ἀθήνη, 1.44).

Also called: Pallas / Pallas Athena; “daughter of Zeus.” *Disguises:* Mentès, in Book 1; Mentor,

from 2.267 on — canon.md’s rule distinguishes the goddess-in-disguise from the mortal Mentor, a real Ithacan who also speaks as himself.

Kin: daughter of Zeus.

Refs: 1.44, 1.80, 1.118, 2.267, 3.12, 4.289, 4.502 ... and throughout. Books 1–9, 11, 13–24.

See also: Zeus, Odysseus, Telemachus, Mentor.

Athens (Ἀθῆναι) · PLACE

City of Erechtheus, whom Athena once guarded in his own temple there; named as a waypoint on legendary voyages, including Theseus’s flight with Ariadne.

Refs: 3.278, 3.307, 7.80, 11.324. Books 3, 7, 11.

See also: Athena, Ariadne.

Atlas (Ἄτλας) · GOD — *Say:* AT-lus

The Titan who “knows the depths of every sea” and grips with his own hands the tall pillars that hold earth and heaven apart; father of Calypso, whose island prison for Odysseus he

thereby stands behind.

Epithets: “the deadly-minded” (1.52).

Kin: father of Calypso.

Refs: 1.52, 7.245.

See also: Calypso.

Atreus (Ἄτρεΰς) · MORTAL — *Say*: AY-tree-us or AY-troos

King of Mycenae, father of Agamemnon and Menelaus; his name recurs constantly as the patronymic “son of Atreus,” which the poem applies to either brother depending on scene (Menelaus in the Telemachy, Agamemnon in the underworld and homecoming-paradigm passages — see canon.md).

Kin: father of Agamemnon and Menelaus.

Refs: 1.36, 3.156, 3.193, 4.51, 4.316, 9.263, 11.397, 15.51, 17.104, 24.20, 24.121 ...and throughout.

Books 1, 3–5, 9, 11, 13–15, 17, 19, 24.

See also: Agamemnon, Menelaus.

Autolycus (Αὐτόλυκος) · MORTAL — Say: aw-TOL-ih-kus

Odysseus's maternal grandfather, "who outdid all men in thievery and the oath" — a gift from his patron Hermes. He names the infant Odysseus at Ithaca ("Man at Odds," playing on the hero's name), and years later, when the grown Odysseus visits Parnassus to claim his promised gifts, a boar gores him on the hunt, leaving the scar by which Eurycleia later recognizes him.

Kin: father of Anticleia, maternal grandfather of Odysseus.

Refs: 11.85, 19.394, 19.399, 19.403, 19.405 (names him), 19.414, 19.437, 19.466 (boar hunt and scar), 21.220, 24.334. Books 11, 19, 21, 24.

See also: Odysseus, Anticleia, Eurycleia, Hermes.

Autonoe (Αὐτονόη) · MORTAL — Say: aw-TON-oh-ee

One of Penelope's handmaids, named once among those who attend her.

Refs: 18.182.

See also: Penelope.

Boethous (Βοηθόος) · MORTAL — *Say:* boh-EE-thoh-us

Father of Eteoneus, Menelaus's herald and attendant at Sparta; named only in the patronymic.

Refs: 4.31, 15.95, 15.140.

See also: Menelaus.

Cadmeians (Καδμεῖοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* kad-MEE-unz

The Thebans, people of Cadmus; named as Oedipus's subjects in the underworld catalogue of heroines.

Refs: 11.275.

See also: Cadmus, Asopus.

Cadmus (Κάδμος) · MORTAL — *Say:* KAD-mus

Legendary founder of Thebes, father of Ino (later the sea-goddess Leucothea); named once

in Ino's introduction as she rises to save
Odysseus's raft.

Refs: 5.333.

See also: Cadmeians.

Calypso (Καλυψώ) · GOD — Say: kuh-LIP-soh

The nymph, daughter of Atlas, who holds
Odysseus for seven years on her island Ogygia,
wanting him for her husband and offering him
immortality if he stays. Zeus at last sends
Hermes to compel his release; she yields,
bitterly, and helps him build the raft that
carries him toward Scheria.

Epithets: “shining among goddesses” (δῖα
θεάων, 5.77).

Also called: “daughter of Atlas”; her name plays
on the Greek for “the Concealer.”

Kin: daughter of Atlas.

Refs: 1.14, 4.557, 5.14, 5.116, 5.180, 5.263, 7.245,
9.29, 12.389, 23.333. Books 1, 4–5, 7–9, 12, 17, 23.

See also: Atlas, Odysseus, Hermes.

Cassandra (Κασσάνδρα) · MORTAL — Say: kuh-SAN-druh

Priam's daughter, taken by Agamemnon from fallen Troy; Clytemnestra kills her over Agamemnon's body at the homecoming feast. Agamemnon's shade recalls her death-cry as the most pitiful sound of that slaughter.

Refs: 11.422.

See also: Agamemnon, Clytemnestra.

Castor (Κάστωρ) · MORTAL — Say: KAS-tor

The name Odysseus invents for his own false father in the Cretan lie he tells Eumaeus and later Penelope — “son of Hylax,” a rich Cretan (11.300). Distinct from the mortal Castor, Helen's brother and one of the Dioscuri (Leda's sons by Tyndareus), whom the poem also names but never conflates with the fictional figure.

Also called: “son of Hylax” (in Odysseus's lie).

Refs: 11.300, 14.203.

See also: Odysseus, Crete.

Cauconians (Καύκωνες) · PEOPLE — Say: kaw-KOH-nee-unz

A people of the western Peloponnese, named once as Athena (disguised as Mentor) claims she must visit them to collect a debt, her cover for leaving Telemachus at Pylos.

Refs: 3.366.

See also: Athena, Nestor.

Centaurs (Κένταυροι) · OTHER — Say: SEN-tawrz

The half-horse creatures whose most notorious member, Eurytion, gets drunk at Peirithous's wedding feast among the Lapiths and runs wild — the Lapiths mutilate and drive him out. Antinous cites the tale as a warning against wine's power just before the disguised Odysseus strings the bow.

Also called: “the Centaur” = Eurytion, the exemplary offender.

Refs: 21.295, 21.303.

See also: Antinous.

Cephalenians (Κεφαλλῆνες) · PEOPLE — Say: sef-uh-LEE-nee-unz

Odysseus's own subjects, named for his mainland and island holdings collectively; mustered by Telemachus for the boar-hunt scar story's setting and again as Odysseus's fighting men in the final battle with the suitors' kin.

Refs: 20.210, 24.355, 24.378, 24.429. Books 20, 24.
See also: Odysseus, Ithaca.

Chalcis (Χαλκίς) · PLACE — Say: KAL-sis

A stream in Elis that Telemachus and Peisistratus pass on their overnight sail back from Pylos, avoiding Nestor's son Noemon's territory.

Refs: 15.295.

See also: Crouni.

Charybdis (Χάρυβδις) · GOD — Say: kuh-RIB-dis

The devouring whirlpool paired with Scylla in the strait Odysseus must run; three times a day she sucks down and spews up the sea, and Circe

warns that no ship caught in her draw escapes. Odysseus loses his raft and nearly his life to her on the return past the strait after his crew eats the Sun's cattle, clinging to a fig tree until the mast and keel resurface.

Refs: 12.104, 12.235, 12.428, 12.436, 12.441, 23.327. Books 12, 23.

See also: Scylla, Crataeis.

Chios (Χίος) · PLACE — *Say:* KY-os or KEE-os

An island off the Ionian coast on the sea-route the Achaean fleet debates at its stormy, divided departure from Troy — part of Nestor's account of who sailed which way home.

Refs: 3.170, 3.171, 3.172.

See also: Nestor.

Chloris (Χλωρίς) · MORTAL — *Say:* KLOR-is

Youngest daughter of Amphion of Orchomenus; Neleus marries her for her beauty with bride-gifts beyond number, and she bears him Nestor, Chromius, Periclymenus, and the much-courted

Pero. Seen among the heroines in the underworld.

Kin: wife of Neleus, mother of Nestor, Chromius, Pero.

Refs: 11.281.

See also: Nestor, Chromius, Neleus.

Chromius (Χρομῖος) · MORTAL — *Say:* KROH-mee-us

A son of Neleus and Chloris, brother of Nestor, named in the underworld genealogy of the Pylian house.

Kin: son of Neleus and Chloris, brother of Nestor.

Refs: 11.286.

See also: Nestor, Chloris.

Cicones (Κίκονες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* sih-KOH-nee-z
Thracian allies of Troy at Ismarus, Odysseus's first landfall on the way home. He sacks their city, but lingers too long over the plunder; the Cicones rally their inland neighbors and rout

his men on the beach, costing six men from each ship — the wanderings' first loss and first lesson in restraint ignored.

Refs: 9.39, 9.47, 9.59, 9.66 (the raid and rout), 9.165, 23.310. Books 9, 23.

See also: Odysseus.

Cimmerians (Κιμμέριοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* sih-MEER-ee-unz

A people who live at the edge of Ocean, wrapped always in mist and cloud and never seen by the sun — the poem places the entrance to Hades in their sunless land.

Refs: 11.14.

See also: Hades (underworld).

Circe (Κίρκη) · GOD — *Say:* SUR-see

Witch-goddess of Aeaea, daughter of Helios; she drugs Odysseus's men and turns them to swine — bodies of pigs, minds unchanged — until Hermes's counter-herb and Odysseus's drawn sword force her to restore them and take him

to her bed instead. He stays a year; she then tells him how to reach the underworld and, on his return, warns him of Scylla, Charybdis, and the Sirens.

Epithets: “of the lovely braids” (ἐυπλόκαμος, 10.221 and elsewhere); “the dread goddess.”

Kin: daughter of Helios.

Refs: 9.31, 10.136, 10.221, 10.241 (the transformation), 10.480, 11.8, 12.9, 12.273, 23.321. Books 8–12, 23.

See also: Helios, Hermes, Odysseus.

Cleitus (Κλεῖτος) · MORTAL — *Say:* KLY-tus

Grandson of the seer Melampus, carried off by Dawn for his beauty — a brief mythic aside in the genealogy Theoclymenus gives of his own seer’s line.

Refs: 15.249, 15.250.

See also: Theoclymenus.

Clymene (Κλυμένη) · MORTAL — *Say:* KLIM-uh-nee
or kly-MEE-nee

One of the heroines Odysseus glimpses among the crowd of women's shades in the underworld, named without further story.

Refs: 11.326.

See also: Ariadne.

Clymenus (Κλύμενος) · MORTAL — *Say:* KLIM-uh-nus

Father of Eurydice, Nestor's wife; named only in Nestor's household genealogy at Pylos.

Kin: father of Eurydice, Nestor's wife.

Refs: 3.452.

See also: Nestor.

Clytemnestra (Κλυταιμνήστρα) · MORTAL — *Say:* kly-tem-NES-truh

Agamemnon's wife; she takes Aegisthus as her lover while her husband is at Troy and joins him in murdering Agamemnon at his homecoming feast, killing Cassandra too.

Agamemnon's shade holds her up to Odysseus as the standing warning against trusting a wife

— the counter-exemplar the poem sets
Penelope against.

Also called: “of the crooked counsels” (11.422).

Kin: wife of Agamemnon, mother of Orestes.

Refs: 3.266, 11.422, 11.439. Books 3, 11.

See also: Agamemnon, Aegisthus, Cassandra,
Orestes, Penelope.

Clytius (Κλυτίος) · MORTAL — *Say:* KLIT-ee-us

Father of Piraeus, the Ithacan friend who
houses Theoclymenus for Telemachus; named
only in the patronymic.

Refs: 15.540, 16.327.

See also: Theoclymenus.

Clytoneus (Κλυτόνηος) · MORTAL — *Say:* kly-TOH-
nee-us

A son of Alcinous and Arete; he wins the
footrace at the Phaeacian games in Book 8.

Kin: son of Alcinous and Arete.

Refs: 8.119, 8.123.

See also: Alcinous, Nausicaa.

Cnossus (Κνωσός) · PLACE — Say: NOS-us or kuh-NOS-us

Minos's capital on Crete, named once as the setting Odysseus invokes in the Cretan lie he tells Penelope.

Refs: 19.178.

See also: Crete, Ariadne.

Cocytus (Κωκυτός) · PLACE — Say: koh-SY-tus

A river of the underworld, a branch of the Styx, named by Circe as she gives Odysseus directions to the entrance of Hades.

Refs: 10.514.

See also: Cimmerians.

Constellations · OTHER

The stars Odysseus steers by on his solitary raft-voyage from Ogygia, watching them as Calypso instructed: the Wain (the Bear), which alone never bathes in Ocean, Boötes, and the Pleiades, along with Orion. The same star-lore returns as Odysseus lies sleepless before the

contest of the bow.

Also called: the Wain / the Bear; Boötes; the Pleiades.

Refs: 5.272, 5.273, 20.18. Books 5, 20.

See also: Calypso.

Crataiis (Κραταίις) · GOD — *Say:* kruh-TAY-is

Mother of Scylla, named once by Circe in her warning as she describes the monster's lineage.

Kin: mother of Scylla.

Refs: 12.124.

See also: Charybdis.

Creon (Κρέων) · MORTAL — *Say:* KREE-on

Theban king, father of Megara, whom Heracles marries; named in the underworld catalogue of heroines as Odysseus sees Megara's mother-in-law's line.

Kin: father of Megara.

Refs: 11.269.

See also: Cadmeians.

Cretans (Κρητες) · PEOPLE

The people of Crete, whose polyglot, many-cited island and seafaring reputation make it Odysseus's favorite backdrop for the false identities he improvises for Eumaeus, the suitors, and Penelope alike.

Refs: 14.205, 14.234, 14.382, 19.176. Books 14, 19.

See also: Crete, Odysseus.

Crete (Κρήτη) · PLACE

The great southern island, “ninety cities” and many peoples according to Odysseus's own description; it furnishes the recurring setting of the elaborate false autobiographies he tells Athena, Eumaeus, and Penelope on Ithaca, always with a plausible Cretan pedigree.

Refs: 3.191, 3.291, 11.323, 13.256, 14.199, 14.300, 16.62, 19.172, 19.338. Books 3, 11, 13–14, 16–17, 19.

See also: Cretans, Cnossus, Ariadne.

Cretheus (Κρηθεύς) · MORTAL — Say: KREE-thee-us

Husband of Tyro, who bears him Aeson, Pheres, and Amythaon even as she secretly bears Poseidon's sons Pelias and Neleus; named in the underworld catalogue as Odysseus meets Tyro's shade.

Kin: husband of Tyro; father of Aeson, Pheres, Amythaon.

Refs: 11.237, 11.258.

See also: Chloris, Nestor.

Cronos (Κρόνος) · GOD — Say: KROH-nos

The Titan father of Zeus, Poseidon, Hades, and Hera; almost every occurrence of his name in the poem is the patronymic “son of Cronos,” meaning Zeus. Cronos himself never appears as an actor, only as the genealogical root behind the ruling generation of gods.

Also called: “son of Cronos” / Cronion = **Zeus** (see canon.md).

Kin: father of Zeus, Poseidon, Hades, Hera.

Refs: 1.45, 3.88, 9.552, 12.399, 16.291, 21.415,

24.539. Books 1, 3–4, 8–22, 24.

See also: Zeus, Poseidon, Hades.

Crouni (Κρουνοί) · PLACE — Say: KROO-nee

A spring-place in Elis, named alongside Chalcis as a landmark Telemachus’s ship passes on the night-run home from Pylos.

Refs: 15.295.

See also: Chalcis.

Ctesippus (Κτήσιππος) · MORTAL — Say: tih-SIP-us

A suitor from Same, “versed in lawlessness,” rich and arrogant; he hurls an ox-hoof at the disguised Odysseus as a mocking “guest-gift,” but misses — Telemachus rebukes him for it on the spot (20.288, 20.303–304). In the hall fight he wounds Eumaeus with a spear-graze before Philoetius kills him, crowing over the body and calling it payment for the ox-hoof (22.279, 22.285).

Also called: “son of Polytherses.”

Refs: 20.288, 20.303, 20.304, 22.279, 22.285.

Books 20, 22.

See also: Antinous, Odysseus, Philoetius.

Ctesius (Κτήσιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* TEE-see-us

Eumaeus's father, king of Syrie, named once in the swineherd's life-story as the father whose household the Phoenician nursemaid betrayed.

Refs: 15.414.

See also: Eumaeus, Arybas.

Ctimene (Κτιμένη) · MORTAL — *Say:* TIM-uh-nee

Odysseus's younger sister, raised alongside Eumaeus in Laertes' house; the swineherd recalls her in the same breath as Odysseus among the children he tended before her marriage sent her off to Same.

Kin: sister of Odysseus.

Refs: 15.363.

See also: Eumaeus, Laertes.

Cyclopes (Κύκλωπες) · GOD — *Say:* sy-KLOH-peeZ

The lawless one-eyed race Odysseus's crew

meets in Book 9 — herdsmen with no assemblies, no laws, no ships, “trusting in the deathless gods” though they scorn Zeus outright. Polyphemus, Poseidon’s son, is one of them; his blinding and the curse he calls down on Odysseus drive the rest of the poem’s wanderings. Their island neighbors a fertile, uninhabited isle the poem surveys with a colonist’s eye.

Refs: 1.71, 6.5, 7.206, 9.106–125 (the ethnography), 9.166, 9.275, 9.399, 9.510. Books 1, 6–7, 9.

See also: Polyphemus, Poseidon.

Cydonians (Κυδῶνες) · PEOPLE — Say: sih-DOH-nee-unz

A people of western Crete, named in the false Cretan tale Odysseus spins for Penelope and again by Eumaeus’s tale of Crete.

Refs: 3.292, 19.176.

Cyllene (Κυλλίνη) · PLACE — Say: sih-LEE-nee

The Arcadian mountain sacred to Hermes; the poem opens Book 24 with the god leading the suitors' souls out from its heights.

Refs: 24.1.

See also: Hermes.

Cyprus (Κύπρος) · PLACE

The island of Aphrodite's Paphian shrine, where the goddess is bathed and anointed after her exposure with Ares; it also figures in the beggar-Odysseus's invented travels, where he claims a king named Dmetor once hosted him.

Refs: 4.83, 8.362, 17.442–448.

See also: Aphrodite, Dmetor.

Cythera (Κύθηρα) · PLACE — Say: sih-THEER-uh

Island off Cape Malea; a fierce north wind drives Odysseus's ships past it and off course toward the Lotus-eaters.

Refs: 9.81.

Damastor (Δαμάστωρ) · MORTAL — Say: duh-MAS-tor

Father of the suitor Agelaus, named only in the patronymic “Agelaus, Damastor’s son” that recurs through the hall-fighting of Book 22.

Refs: 20.321, 22.212, 22.241, 22.293.

See also: Agelaus.

Danaans (Δαναοί) · PEOPLE — Say: DAN-ay-unz or DAN-uh-unz

One of the poem’s three interchangeable names for the Greek host at Troy, alongside Achaeans and Argives; used freely in the underworld catalogue of heroes and in Nestor’s and Menelaus’s reminiscences.

Refs: 1.350, 4.278, 4.725, 5.306, 8.82, 11.470, 11.526, 24.18, 24.45.

See also: Achaeans, Argives.

Dawn (Ἠώς) · GOD

Personified daybreak, whose rising opens nearly every day of the action in the poem’s

fixed formula: “with fingers of rose,” “the early-born,” coming “on her fair throne” or “the golden throne.” She marks time rather than acts in it, but her recurrence is the poem’s clock, from the Telemachy through the wanderings to the final battle’s dawn.

Epithets: “with fingers of rose” (ρόδοδάκτυλος Ἠώς, 2.1); “the early-born” (ἡριγένεια, 2.1); “on her fair throne” (ἐύθρονος Ἠώς, 6.48); “Dawn of the golden throne” (χρυσόθρονος Ἠώς, 10.541).

Refs: 2.1, 5.1, 6.48, 8.1, 9.76, 10.144, 12.4, 13.18, 17.1, 19.428, 23.241, 23.244, 23.246 ...and throughout. Books 2–6, 8–10, 12–20, 23.
See also: Helios.

Deiphobus (Δηίφοβος) · MORTAL — Say: dee-IF-oh-bus

Trojan prince, Paris’s brother; Helen recalls circling the wooden horse with him among the Trojans who tried to draw out the hidden Greeks, and Odysseus’s shade-companions recall the fighting before his house on the night

Troy fell.

Refs: 4.276, 8.518.

See also: Helen.

Delos (Δῆλος) · PLACE — *Say:* DEE-los

Apollo's sacred island; Odysseus tells Nausicaa that only there, beside the god's altar, has he seen a young palm to match her beauty.

Refs: 6.162.

See also: Apollo, Nausicaa.

Demeter (Δημήτηρ) · GOD — *Say:* dih-MEE-tur

Grain-goddess; the poem recalls, in a list of goddesses who loved mortal men, that she lay with Iasion in a thrice-plowed field, for which Zeus struck him with the thunderbolt.

Refs: 5.125.

Demodocus (Δημόδοκος) · MORTAL — *Say:* dih-MOD-oh-kus

The blind bard of the Phaeacian court,
“honored among the people,” to whom a god

gave song “beyond all others.” He sings the quarrel of Achilles and Odysseus, the adultery of Ares and Aphrodite, and the fall of Troy by the wooden horse — the last song moving Odysseus to tears and forcing his identity into the open.

Epithets: “the trusted singer” (ἐρίηρος ἀοιδός, 8.62).

Refs: 8.44 (Alcinous calls for him), 8.106, 8.254–262, 8.472–487 (the Troy song), 8.537, 13.28.

Books 8, 13.

See also: Alcinous, Phaeacians.

Demoptolemus (Δημοπτόλεμος) · MORTAL — Say: dee-mop-TOL-uh-mus

A suitor; one of the hall’s best fighters, he joins Agelaus’s rallied volley against Odysseus in Book 22 and is killed by Odysseus’s own spear in the return cast.

Refs: 22.242, 22.266.

See also: Agelaus, the suitors.

Deucalion (Δευκαλίων) · MORTAL — Say: dyoo-

KAY-lee-on

Son of Minos and father of Idomeneus, named in the elaborate false Cretan genealogy the disguised Odysseus gives Penelope.

Refs: 19.180, 19.181.

See also: Idomeneus.

Dia (Δία) · PLACE — Say: DEE-uh

The sea-ringed island (later identified with Naxos) where Artemis kills Ariadne on Dionysus's testimony, in the underworld catalogue of women.

Refs: 11.325.

See also: Dionysus.

Diocles (Διοκλῆς) · MORTAL — Say: DY-oh-kleez

Lord of Pherae, son of Ortilochus; he hosts Telemachus and Peisistratus overnight on both legs of their journey between Pylos and Sparta.

Refs: 3.488, 15.186.

See also: Telemachus, Peisistratus.

Diomedes (Διομήδης) · MORTAL — Say: dy-oh-MEE-deez

Son of Tydeus, the Argive hero; Nestor names him among the few who reached home safe from Troy, a foil to the disasters the poem is otherwise cataloguing.

Also called: “son of Tydeus.”

Refs: 3.181.

Dionysus (Διόνυσος) · GOD — Say: dy-oh-NY-sus

The wine-god; in the underworld catalogue his testimony is cited as the cause of Artemis’s killing of Ariadne on Dia, and in Book 24 Agamemnon recalls that Thetis’s golden funeral urn for Achilles’s bones was Dionysus’s gift, made by Hephaestus.

Refs: 11.325, 24.74.

See also: Ariadne, Achilles.

Dmetor (Δμήτωρ) · MORTAL — Say: DMEE-tor or DEE-tor

“Son of Iasus,” the invented king of Cyprus in

one of the beggar-Odysseus's fictitious travel tales, who supposedly hosted him after a shipwreck.

Refs: 17.443.

See also: Cyprus.

Dodona (Δωδώνη) · PLACE — *Say:* doh-DOH-nuh

Site of Zeus's oracular oak grove in Epirus; the disguised Odysseus twice claims (to Eumaeus and to Penelope) to have gone there to learn from the god's leaves whether to return openly or in secret.

Refs: 14.327, 19.296.

See also: Zeus.

Dolius (Δολίος) · MORTAL — *Say:* DOH-lee-us

Laertes's old slave and gardener, father of Melanthius and Melantho; the poem never voices the connection between the loyal old man and his disloyal, executed children. He greets the returned Odysseus with tears and a kiss at the wrist — the same clasp Penelope

remembered from his departure — and arms himself with his six sons and Laertes for the final skirmish.

Kin: father of Melanthius and Melantho.

Refs: 4.735, 17.212, 18.322, 22.159, 24.222, 24.387–411 (the reunion), 24.497–498 (arming for battle). Books 4, 17–18, 22, 24.

See also: Laertes, Melanthius, Melantho.

Dorians (Δωριέες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* DOR-ee-unz

One of the several peoples inhabiting Crete, named in the disguised Odysseus's account of the island's mixed population.

Refs: 19.177.

Dulichium (Δουλίχιον) · PLACE — *Say:* dyoo-LIK-ee-um

An island near Ithaca, home to the largest single contingent of Penelope's suitors; named repeatedly alongside Same and Zacynthus as the suitors' home islands.

Refs: 1.246, 9.24, 14.335, 14.397, 16.123, 16.247,

16.396, 18.127, 19.131, 19.292.

See also: the suitors.

Dymas (Δύμας) · MORTAL — *Say:* DY-mus

A Phaeacian sea-captain “famed for ships”;
Athena takes the shape of his daughter, a girl
Nausicaa’s own age, to visit Nausicaa in her
sleep and set the laundry expedition in motion.

Refs: 6.22.

See also: Nausicaa, Athena.

Earth (Γαῖα) · GOD

Personified Earth, invoked with Heaven and the
waters of Styx in the gods’ most solemn oath —
the oath Calypso swears to Hermes and
Poseidon swears at his own council.

Also called: Gaia.

Refs: 5.184, 7.324, 11.576.

See also: Zeus, Poseidon.

Echeneus (Ἐχένηος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ek-uh-NEE-

us

The eldest of the Phaeacian lords, “elder-born beyond the others,” whose counsel the court heeds: he prompts Alcinous to raise the suppliant Odysseus from the hearth-ashes in Book 7, and later speaks up again in the assembly that hears Odysseus’s tale.

Refs: 7.155, 11.342.

See also: Alcinous, Phaeacians.

Echephron (Ἐχέφρων) · MORTAL — Say: eh-KEF-ron

A son of Nestor, present at the sacrifice and feast when Telemachus arrives in Pylos.

Refs: 3.413, 3.439.

See also: Nestor.

Echetus (Ἐχέτοϛ) · MORTAL — Say: EK-uh-tus

The proverbial mainland ogre-king, “the maimer of all mankind,” whom the suitors repeatedly threaten to ship the beggar-disguised Odysseus and Irus off to for mutilation — their favorite image of outsourced

cruelty.

Epithets: “the maimer of all mankind” (βροτῶν δηλήμονα πάντων, 18.85).

Refs: 18.85, 18.116, 21.308.

See also: Irus.

Egypt (Αἴγυπτος) · PLACE

The land — and, in the Greek, also the river, i.e. the Nile — of Menelaus’s long detour home; he is becalmed there and must trap Proteus before the god will release him. Odysseus’s fictitious tales to Eumaeus and the suitors likewise send his invented self raiding and stranded in Egypt.

Refs: 3.300, 4.127, 4.351, 4.355 (Menelaus’s detour), 4.477, 4.483, 4.581, 14.247, 14.257, 14.275, 17.426, 17.448. Books 3–4, 14, 17.

See also: Menelaus, Proteus, Egyptians.

Egyptians (Αἰγύπτιοι) · PEOPLE

The people of Egypt, encountered both in Menelaus’s true account of his detour and in

Odysseus's invented raiding tales.

Refs: 4.83, 4.229, 14.264, 14.286, 17.433.

See also: Egypt.

Eidothea (Εἰδοθέη) · GOD — *Say:* eye-doh-THEE-uh

Sea-nymph, daughter of Proteus; pitying the stranded Menelaus, she tells him how to ambush and hold her shape-shifting father until he answers his questions.

Refs: 4.366.

See also: Proteus, Menelaus.

Eileithyia (Εἰλείθυια) · GOD — *Say:* eye-lih-THY-uh

or eye-LEE-thee-uh

Goddess of childbirth, invoked in the underworld catalogue as the power who eased Alcmene's and other heroines' labors.

Refs: 19.188.

Elatus (Ἑλατος) · MORTAL — *Say:* EL-uh-tus

A suitor; killed by the swineherd Eumaeus in the fighting of Book 22, in the same volley that

falls Demoptolemus and Peisander.

Refs: 22.267.

See also: Eumaeus, the suitors.

Elis (Ἠλῖς) · PLACE — *Say:* EE-lis

Region of the western Peloponnese, home of the Epeians; named as a place of horse-pasture Odysseus once visited and as a landmark in the suitors' geography.

Refs: 4.635, 13.275, 15.298, 21.347, 24.431.

See also: Epeians.

Elpenor (Ἐλπήνωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* el-PEE-nor

The youngest of Odysseus's crew, "no great fighter, no steady mind on him" — he sleeps off wine on Circe's roof, wakes at the crew's departure, and falls to his death. His unburied shade meets Odysseus first in the underworld, ahead even of Teiresias, and begs for burial and an oar planted over his grave; Odysseus keeps the promise to the letter on returning to Aeaea.

Refs: 10.552, 11.51, 11.57 (his shade, first to

appear), 12.10 (the funeral). Books 10–12.

See also: Circe.

Elysium (Ἠλύσιον) · PLACE — Say: ih-LIZ-ee-um or
ih-LIZH-ee-um

The deathless plain at the world's edge that
Proteus promises will be Menelaus's afterlife, in
place of death, because he is Zeus's son-in-law
through Helen.

Also called: the Elysian plain.

Refs: 4.563.

See also: Menelaus, Proteus.

Enipeus (Ἐνιπέύς) · GOD — Say: ih-NY-pee-us

A river(-god) of Thessaly; Tyro loves him,
haunting his beautiful streams, and Poseidon
takes his likeness to lie with her at the river's
mouth, fathering Pelias and Neleus.

Refs: 11.238, 11.240.

See also: Poseidon.

Epeians (Ἐπειοί) · PEOPLE — Say: eh-PEE-unz

The people of Elis in the western Peloponnese, named among the lands Odysseus's herds and reputation reach.

Refs: 13.275, 15.298, 24.431.

See also: Elis.

Epeius (Ἐπειός) · MORTAL — Say: eh-PEE-us

Builder of the wooden horse, “with Athena’s help,” celebrated in Demodocus’s song and recalled again by Odysseus’s shade-companions in the underworld.

Refs: 8.493, 11.523.

See also: Demodocus.

Eperitus (Ἐπήριτος) · MORTAL — Say: eh-PEE-rih-tus

The false name Odysseus gives Laertes in their reunion, part of a last testing lie built from a genealogy of speaking names — “son of Apheidas, son of Polypemon,” from an island city evoking wandering — before he abandons

the disguise and reveals himself with the scar and the orchard trees.

Refs: 24.306.

See also: Laertes, Odysseus.

Ephialtes (Ἐφιάλτης) · MORTAL — Say: ef-ee-AL-teez

Giant brother of Otus, son of Poseidon and Iphimedeia; the two grew nine fathoms tall in nine years and piled Ossa on Olympus and Pelion on Ossa to storm heaven, before Apollo killed them short of manhood.

Refs: 11.308.

See also: Otus, Poseidon.

Ephyra (Ἐφύρη) · PLACE — Say: EF-ih-ruh

A town on the Greek mainland; Odysseus is remembered (by Antinous, recalling Odysseus's own past, and again in Telemachus's cover story) as having gone there seeking deadly arrow-poison.

Refs: 1.259, 2.328.

Epicaste (Ἐπικάστη) · MORTAL — Say: ep-ih-KAS-tee

Homer's name for the mother of Oedipus (later tradition's Jocasta): she unknowingly marries her own son, and when the gods reveal it she hangs herself, while Oedipus goes on ruling Thebes in grief, "hounded by a mother's Furies." Odysseus sees her shade in the underworld catalogue of women.

Also called: Jocasta (later tradition's name).

Refs: 11.271.

See also: Oedipus.

Erebus (Ἔρεβος) · PLACE — Say: ER-uh-bus

The nether darkness of the dead; the shades Odysseus summons rise from it, and the phrase recurs as the underworld's name through the Nekyia and again in the second, ghost-led descent of the suitors' souls in Book 24.

Refs: 10.528, 11.37, 11.564, 12.81, 20.356.

See also: Hades.

Erechtheus (Ἐρεχθεύς) · MORTAL — Say: eh-REK-

thee-us

Earthborn king of Athens, into whose rich temple Athena withdraws when she leaves Scheria after the games.

Refs: 7.81.

See also: Athena.

Erembi (Ἐρεμβοί) · PEOPLE — Say: eh-REM-by

A far-off people Menelaus names among those he visited on his long detour home, grouped with the Ethiopians, Sidonians, and Libyans as the outer edge of his wanderings.

Refs: 4.84.

See also: Menelaus.

Eriphyle (Ἐριφύλη) · MORTAL — Say: er-ih-FY-lee

A woman of the underworld catalogue, condemned in the poem's one open moral judgment there: she "took precious gold as the price of her own husband," betraying

Amphiaraus to his death for a bribe.

Refs: 11.326.

Erymanthus (Ἐρύμανθος) · PLACE — Say: er-ih-MAN-thus

An Arcadian mountain; the simile comparing Nausicaa among her handmaids to Artemis hunting names it as one of the goddess's ranges.

Refs: 6.103.

See also: Nausicaa.

Eteoneus (Ἐτεωνεύς) · MORTAL — Say: et-ee-OH-nee-us

Son of Boethous, Menelaus's attendant at Sparta; he greets Telemachus and Peisistratus at the gate and later announces the disguised Odysseus's arrival on Ithaca's shore.

Also called: "son of Boethous."

Refs: 4.22, 4.31, 15.95.

See also: Menelaus.

Ethiopians (Αἰθίοπες) · PEOPLE — Say: ee-thee-OH-pee-unz

“The remotest of men,” split into two peoples at the world’s eastern and western edges; Poseidon is feasting among them when the gods’ council decides Odysseus’s release, and Menelaus visits them on his detour.

Refs: 1.22, 1.23, 4.84, 5.282, 5.287.

See also: Poseidon.

Euanthes (Εὐάνθης) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-AN-theez

Father of Maron, the priest of Apollo whose potent wine Odysseus carries into the Cyclops’s cave.

Refs: 9.197.

See also: Cyclopes.

Euboea (Εὐβοία) · PLACE — Say: yoo-BEE-uh

The long island off the Greek mainland; Nestor recalls the fleet’s fast crossing there on the way home from Troy, and the Phaeacians cite it as

the farthest sail their ships have ever made,
ferrying Rhadamanthys.

Refs: 3.174, 7.321.

See also: Phaeacians.

Eumaeus (Εὐμαῖος) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-MEE-us

The loyal swineherd, “a leader of men,” once a stolen prince of Syrie sold into slavery as a child and raised in Laertes’s house. He shelters the disguised Odysseus, unknowingly hosts and feeds him at length, tells his own story of abduction, and stands with Philoetius at Odysseus’s side in the slaughter of the suitors.

Also called: “the swineherd.”

Epithets: “the noble swineherd” (δῖος ὑφορβός, 14.3); “the swineherd, a leader of men” (συβώτης, ὄρχαμος ἀνδρῶν, 14.22).

Kin: son of Ctesius, king of Syrie.

Refs: 14.55 (his hut, first), 14.360, 14.440, 15.325, 15.486, 16.7, 16.464, 17.199, 17.579, 21.80, 21.234, 22.157, 22.279 (the slaughter) ...and throughout.

Books 14–17, 20–22.

See also: Odysseus, Philoetius, Melanthius.

Eumelus (Εὐμηλος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-MEE-lus

Husband of Iphthime, Penelope's sister, and lord of Pherae; Athena shapes a dream-phantom in Iphthime's likeness to comfort the weeping Penelope, naming Eumelus only to place her.

Kin: husband of Iphthime, Penelope's sister.

Refs: 4.798.

See also: Penelope.

Eupeithes (Εὐπείθης) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-PY-theez

Antinous's father, an Ithacan noble. When word of the suitors' slaughter reaches the town he rouses the assembly to arms, weeping over his son's death, and leads the suitors' kinsmen out to avenge them — against Halitherses' and Medon's warnings. Laertes, with Athena guiding his throw, spears him through the helmet before Athena halts the fighting and imposes the peace that closes the poem.

Kin: father of Antinous.

Refs: 1.383, 4.660, 16.363, 18.42, 20.270, 21.140, 24.422 (rouses the assembly), 24.465, 24.469, 24.523 (killed by Laertes' spear). Books 1, 4, 16–18, 20–21, 24.

See also: Antinous, Halitherses, Laertes.

Euryades (Εὐρύαδης) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RY-uh-deez

One of the suitors; Telemachus kills him with a spear-throw in the general volley of Book 22, alongside Odysseus's killing of Demoptolemus and Eumaeus's of Elatus.

Refs: 22.267. Book 22.

See also: the suitors, Telemachus.

Euryalus (Εὐρύαλος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RY-uh-lus

A young Phaeacian noble, “the equal of man-destroying Ares,” second only to Laodamas in looks. At the Book 8 games he goads the grieving Odysseus, calling him a profit-minded trader with no gift for contests; Odysseus

answers with an angry speech and a record discus-throw. Shamed by Alcinous's rebuke, Euryalus makes amends with a fine sword and a gracious apology.

Kin: son of Naubolus.

Refs: 8.115 (rises for the games), 8.127 (wrestling), 8.140 (taunt), 8.158, 8.396–400 (apology and gift). Book 8.

See also: Alcinous, Laodamas, Phaeacians.

Eurybates (Εὐρυβάτης) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIB-uh-teez

Odysseus's herald at Troy, described in the disguised Odysseus's tale to Penelope as round-shouldered, dark-skinned, and curly-haired — a man Odysseus honored above his other companions for his good sense.

Refs: 19.247. Book 19.

See also: Odysseus.

Eurycleia (Εὐρύκλεια) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-rih-KLEE-uh or yoo-rih-KLY-uh

Odysseus's old nurse, bought by Laertes in her youth and honored in his house like a wife, though he never touched her bed. She raised both Odysseus and Telemachus, manages the women's quarters, and — washing the disguised beggar's feet — recognizes Odysseus by the boar-scar on his thigh (19.401); he seizes her throat and swears her to silence. She later helps identify the executed slave-women and rouses Penelope after the slaughter.

Also called: “the Nurse” (μαῖα, the household's address for her); daughter of Ops, son of Peisenor.

Refs: 1.429, 2.361, 4.742, 17.31, 19.357, 19.401, 19.491 (the scar), 20.128–148, 22.391–492, 23.25–39, 23.69, 23.177. Books 1–2, 4, 17, 19–23.

See also: Odysseus, Telemachus, Penelope, Laertes.

Eurydamas (Εὐρυδάμας) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RID-uh-mus

A suitor; falls to Odysseus's spear in the fighting of Book 22.

Refs: 18.297, 22.283. Books 18, 22.

See also: the suitors.

Eurydice (Εὐρυδίκη) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RID-ih-see

Nestor's wife, youngest daughter of Clymenus; she bathes Telemachus at Pylos.

Refs: 3.452. Book 3.

See also: Nestor.

Eurylochus (Εὐρύλοχος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIL-oh-kus

Odysseus's second-in-command and kinsman by marriage. He leads the party that finds Circe's house and alone escapes her drugging, then talks Odysseus into landing on Thrinacia against Tiresias's and Circe's warnings; when the crew starves, he persuades them to slaughter the cattle of Helios — the crime that dooms the whole company. He earlier balks openly, pleading with Odysseus not to go back for the trapped men (10.244–271).

Refs: 10.205–207 (chosen by lot), 10.232 (stays outside, suspecting a snare), 10.244–271 (confrontation), 12.278–297 (Thrinacia landing), 12.339–352 (urges the slaughter). Books 10–12.

See also: Odysseus, Circe, Helios.

Eurymachus (Εὐρύμαχος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIM-uh-kus

Son of Polybus and, with Antinous, a leader of the suitors — smoother-tongued than Antinous but no less rapacious, and secretly courting the maid Melantho. He answers first when Odysseus reveals himself, tries to shift the blame to the dead Antinous, then rallies the suitors to rush the archer; Odysseus's arrow takes him through the liver, the second suitor to die.

Kin: son of Polybus.

Refs: 1.399–413, 2.177–209, 15.17, 16.434, 18.244–396, 20.359–364, 21.186 (fails to string the bow), 21.245–331, 22.44–61 (answers Odysseus), 22.69 (death). Books 1–2, 4, 15–18,

20–22.

See also: Antinous, Penelope, the suitors.

Eurymedon (Εὐρυμέδων) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-RIM-uh-don

King of the overweening Giants in the Phaeacians' deep genealogy; his people destroyed themselves and him, but his daughter Periboea bore Nausithous to Poseidon — making him the Phaeacians' maternal great-grandfather.

Kin: father of Periboea (mother of Nausithous by Poseidon).

Refs: 7.58. Book 7.

See also: Giants, Nausithous, Alcinous, Poseidon.

Eurymedusa (Εὐρυμέδουσα) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-rih-muh-DOO-suh

An old woman brought from Apeire as a prize of honor for Alcinous; she nursed Nausicaa and serves now as her chamber-keeper.

Refs: 7.8. Book 7.

See also: Nausicaa, Alcinous.

Eurymus (Εὐρύμωχος) · MORTAL — Say: YOO-rih-mus
Father of the seer Telemus, who foretold
Polyphemus's blinding at Odysseus's hands.

Refs: 9.509. Book 9.

See also: Polyphemus.

Eurynome (Εὐρύνομη) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIN-oh-mee

Penelope's housekeeper, trusted with news and errands in the household's last days — she comforts Penelope after Antinous strikes the beggar, helps bathe and dress her before she faces the suitors, and attends the recognition of Odysseus.

Refs: 17.495 (adds her word after Antinous's blow), 18.164–178, 19.96–97, 20.4, 23.154–293.

Books 17–20, 23.

See also: Penelope, Eurycleia.

Eurynomus (Εὐρύνομος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIN-oh-mus

A suitor, son of Aegyptius; he is among the ringleaders Agelaus rallies for the last stand in the hall.

Kin: son of Aegyptius.

Refs: 2.22, 22.242. Books 2, 22.

See also: Aegyptius, the suitors.

Eurypylus (Εὐρύπυλος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-RIP-ih-lus

Son of Telephus; a strikingly handsome Trojan ally, killed at Troy by Achilles's son Neoptolemus, whose exploit Odysseus recounts to the shade of Achilles.

Kin: son of Telephus.

Refs: 11.520. Book 11.

See also: Neoptolemus, Achilles.

Eurytus (Εὐρυτος) · MORTAL — Say: YOO-rih-tus

The archer of Oechalia who rivaled the gods themselves at the bow and died for it, killed by

Apollo in his anger. His great bow, kept afterward by his son Iphitus, eventually reaches Odysseus as a guest-gift and becomes the weapon of the suitors' slaughter.

Refs: 8.224–226 (Odysseus declines to rival him), 21.14 (the bow's pedigree), 21.32, 21.37. Books 8, 21.

See also: Iphitus, Heracles.

Evenor (Εὐήνωρ) · MORTAL — Say: eh-VEE-nor

Father of the suitor Leocritus.

Kin: father of Leocritus.

Refs: 2.242, 22.294. Books 2, 22.

See also: the suitors.

Furies (Ἐρινύες) · GOD

The avenging spirits who enforce the deepest taboos — oaths, the claims of parents, and the rights of suppliants and beggars. Telemachus fears his mother's curse would summon them if he expelled her against her will; Epicaste's death bequeaths Oedipus "a mother's Furies";

the poem invokes them elsewhere against those who wrong parents or mistreat beggars and suppliants.

Also called: the Erinyes.

Refs: 2.136, 11.280, 17.475, 20.78. Books 2, 11, 17, 20.

See also: Oedipus (Epicaste).

Geraestus (Γεραιστός) · PLACE — Say: juh-REE-stus

The Euboean headland where storm-driven Achaean ships find safe landfall on the voyage home from Troy, as Nestor tells it.

Refs: 3.177. Book 3.

See also: Nestor.

Giants (Γίγαντες) · PEOPLE

A lawless mythic race; their king Eurymedon fathered Periboea, the Phaeacians' ancestral mother by Poseidon, before destroying his own reckless people and himself. Alcinous also cites the Giants and the Cyclopes as beings who, like the Phaeacians, live close to the gods.

Refs: 7.59, 7.206, 10.120. Books 7, 10.

See also: Eurymedon, Phaeacians.

Gorgon (Γοργώ) · OTHER — Say: GOR-gon

The monstrous severed head Odysseus fears
Persephone might send up from Hades against
him, driving him back to his ship at the end of
the underworld visit.

Refs: 11.635. Book 11.

See also: Persephone.

Gortyn (Γόρτυν) · PLACE — Say: GOR-tin

A city in Crete, near the rocks off which a
squadron of Menelaus's ships is wrecked on the
way home from Troy.

Refs: 3.294. Book 3.

See also: Menelaus.

Graces (Χάριτες) · GOD

Attendant goddesses of beauty; they bathe and
anoint Aphrodite at Paphos after her exposure
with Ares, and their gift of grace is invoked

elsewhere as what the gods lend to human charm.

Also called: the Charites.

Refs: 6.18, 8.364, 18.194. Books 6, 8, 18.

See also: Aphrodite.

Gyrae (Γυραί) · PLACE — *Say:* JY-ree

The rocks where Poseidon drowned the lesser Ajax, son of Oileus, as Proteus tells Menelaus.

Refs: 4.501, 4.507. Book 4.

See also: Proteus, Menelaus.

Hades (Ήιδης) · GOD — *Say:* HAY-deez

Lord of the dead; by extension “the house of Hades” names the underworld itself, the destination the poem holds over every mortal peril and the setting of Odysseus’s Book 11 consultation with Tiresias and the shades of the dead, including his mother and his old companions from Troy.

Refs: 3.410, 4.834, 6.11, 9.524, 10.502 (Circe’s directions), 11.47–634 (Odysseus among the

dead), 12.21, 14.208, 23.252, 24.204 ...and throughout. Books 3–4, 6, 9–12, 14–15, 20, 23–24.

See also: Persephone, Tiresias.

Halitherses (Ἀλιθέρσης) · MORTAL — *Say:* hal-ih-THUR-seez

The old Ithacan seer, unmatched at reading birds, who interprets the eagle-omen at the Book 2 assembly as doom for the suitors and repeats the same warning — unheeded — when Eupeithes musters the suitors' kin in Book 24.

Also called: son of Mastor.

Refs: 2.157 (reads the eagle-omen), 2.253, 17.68, 24.451 (repeats the warning). Books 2, 17, 24.

See also: Eupeithes, Mentor.

Halios (Ἅλιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* HAL-ee-us

A son of Alcinous, one of the Phaeacian dancers who perform the ball-dance for Odysseus in Book 8.

Kin: son of Alcinous.

Refs: 8.119, 8.370. Book 8.

See also: Alcinous, Laodamas.

Hebe (Ἥβη) · GOD — *Say:* HEE-bee

Goddess of youth, daughter of Zeus and Hera;
wife of the deified Heracles, who feasts among
the immortals while his phantom appears to
Odysseus in the underworld.

Kin: daughter of Zeus and Hera; wife of
Heracles.

Refs: 11.603. Book 11.

See also: Heracles, Zeus, Hera.

Helen (Ἑλένη) · MORTAL — *Say:* HEL-un

Menelaus's wife, whose abduction caused the
Trojan War; now restored to Sparta, sharing
rule with her husband. In the Telemachy she is
a gracious, knowing hostess — recognizing
Telemachus by his likeness to his father, telling
her own tale of Odysseus's spying mission into
Troy, and dosing the wine with a drug against
grief. Shades and mortals elsewhere invoke her

name as the war's cause and, in the underworld, the standard against which Agamemnon's murder is measured.

Refs: 4.12, 4.121–130, 4.219 (the drugged wine), 4.296–305, 11.438, 15.58–171 (her parting gift to Telemachus), 17.118, 22.227, 23.218. Books 4, 11, 14–15, 17, 22–23.

See also: Menelaus, Agamemnon.

Helios (ἥλιος) · GOD — *Say:* HEE-lee-os

The sun-god, who sees and hears all things. His sacred cattle graze untouched on Thrinacia until Odysseus's starving, storm-bound crew — over Eurylochus's oath and Odysseus's warning — slaughter them; Helios demands vengeance from Zeus, who wrecks the ship and drowns every man but Odysseus. Father of Circe.

Also called: Helios Hyperion; the Sun.

Refs: 1.8, 8.271, 10.138, 12.128–133, 12.263–274 (the warning), 12.343–398 (the slaughter and its portents), 19.275, 23.329. Books 1, 8, 10–12, 19, 22–24.

See also: Eurylochus, Circe, Zeus.

Hellas (Ἑλλάς) · PLACE — Say: HEL-us

Northern Greece; paired with “mid-Argos” as a stock phrase for the Greek mainland as a whole.

Refs: 1.344, 4.726, 4.816, 11.496, 15.80. Books 1, 4, 11, 15.

See also: Achaeans.

Hellespont (Ἑλλήσποντος) · PLACE — Say: HEL-uh-spont

The strait near the mound of the Achaean dead, cited in the underworld as the site of Achilles’s tomb-monument, visible to sailors from far out at sea.

Refs: 24.82. Book 24.

See also: Achilles.

Hephaestus (Ἥφαιστος) · GOD — Say: hih-FES-tus or hih-FEE-stus

The lame smith-god. In Demodocus’s Book 8 song he traps his wife Aphrodite and her lover Ares in an invisible net of his own forging and summons the gods to witness their shame —

the poem's comic double of its own plot of craft catching strength. He also forged the golden handmaids and other wonders of his own house.

Epithets: “the famous god of the two strong arms” (περικλυτὸς ἀμφιγυήεις, 8.300); “Hephaestus of the many designs” (Ἡφαιστος πολύφρων, 8.297).

Kin: husband of Aphrodite.

Refs: 4.617, 6.233, 7.92, 8.268–359 (the snare of Ares and Aphrodite), 15.117, 23.160, 24.71–75.

Books 4, 6–8, 15, 23–24.

See also: Aphrodite, Ares.

Hera (Ἥρα) · GOD — Say: HEER-uh or HAIR-uh

Wife of Zeus, mother of Hebe; named chiefly in passing epithets and formulas rather than acting directly in the poem.

Kin: wife of Zeus; mother of Hebe.

Refs: 4.513, 8.465, 11.604, 12.72, 15.112–180, 20.70. Books 4, 8, 11–12, 15, 20.

See also: Zeus, Hebe.

Heracles (Ἡρακλῆς) · MORTAL — Say: HER-uh-
kleez

The great hero, son of Zeus; his phantom
appears among the dead in Book 11 — Heracles
himself feasts deified among the gods, married
to Hebe — recalling his labor of fetching the
Hound of Hades. Earlier in the poem he is
remembered as the guest-killer who murdered
Iphitus for his mares, and as an archer who, like
Eurytus, “rivalled the immortals with the bow.”

Refs: 8.224 (Odysseus declines to rival him),
11.267 (his mother Alcmene, among the
shades), 11.601 (his phantom in the
underworld), 21.26 (kills Iphitus). Books 8, 11,
21.

See also: Hebe, Iphitus, Eurytus.

Hermes (Ἑρμῆς) · GOD — Say: HUR-meez

Messenger of the gods. Sent by Zeus, he carries
the gods’ decree to Calypso that frees Odysseus
from her island (5.28–54); later he waylays
Odysseus on the way to Circe’s house and gives
him the herb moly, which blunts her drugs

(10.277–307). He also ferries the suitors' souls to the underworld in Book 24 and is named repeatedly, with Athena, as Odysseus's divine benefactor.

Epithets: “the slayer of Argus” / “the guide, the slayer of Argus” (Ἀργεΐφόντης).

Refs: 1.38–42, 1.84, 5.28–54 (sent to Calypso), 5.85–195, 8.323–335, 10.277–307 (gives the moly), 11.626, 14.435, 16.471, 24.1–9 (leads the suitors' ghosts). Books 1, 5, 8, 10–12, 14–16, 19, 24.

See also: Zeus, Calypso, Circe.

Hermione (Ἑρμιόνη) · MORTAL — Say: hur-MY-oh-nee

Daughter of Menelaus and Helen, sent off in marriage to Achilles's son Neoptolemus in the same season Telemachus visits Sparta.

Kin: daughter of Menelaus and Helen.

Refs: 4.14. Book 4.

See also: Menelaus, Helen.

Hippodamia (Ἱπποδάμεια) · MORTAL — Say: hip-

oh-duh-MY-uh

One of Penelope's household maids, named among the women at the feast in Book 18.

Refs: 18.182. Book 18.

See also: Penelope.

Hound-of-Hades · OTHER

The monstrous hound of the underworld — Heracles's last and hardest labor was to drag it up out of Hades, with Hermes and Athena as his escorts, as his phantom recalls to Odysseus.

Also called: Cerberus.

Refs: 11.623, 11.625. Book 11.

See also: Heracles, Hades.

Hylax (Ύλαξ) · MORTAL — Say: HY-laks

The grandfather Odysseus invents for himself in the false Cretan genealogy he spins for Eumaeus.

Refs: 14.203. Book 14.

See also: Eumaeus.

Hyperēia (ὑπέρεια) · PLACE — Say: hy-puh-RY-uh

The Phaeacians' former home, near the overbearing Cyclopes, before Nausithous led them to Scheria.

Refs: 6.4. Book 6.

See also: Phaeacians, Nausithous, Scheria.

Hyperesia (ὑπερησῖη) · PLACE — Say: hy-puh-REE-see-uh

A town named in the pedigree of the seer Theoclymenus recites to Telemachus.

Refs: 15.254. Book 15.

See also: Theoclymenus.

Iardanus (Ἰάρδανος) · PLACE — Say: ee-AR-duh-nus

A river in Crete, near the Cydonians, named in Odysseus's tale of Menelaus's storm-driven ships.

Refs: 3.292. Book 3.

See also: Crete.

Iasion (Ἰασίων) · MORTAL — Say: eye-AY-see-on

A mortal loved by Demeter, who lay with him in a thrice-plowed field; Zeus struck him dead with a lightning-bolt on hearing of it — the example Calypso cites of the gods' jealousy toward goddesses who take mortal lovers.

Refs: 5.126. Book 5.

See also: Calypso, Zeus.

Iasus (Ἰάσος) · MORTAL — Say: EYE-uh-sus

Name of two different fathers in the poem: father of Amphion of Orchomenus (named among the underworld shades) and, separately, father of Dmetor, king of Cyprus, whom Odysseus invents as his master in a false tale.

Refs: 11.283, 17.443. Books 11, 17.

See also: Dmetor.

Icarius (Ἰκάριος) · MORTAL — Say: ih-KAIR-ee-us

Penelope's father; she is repeatedly addressed as "daughter of Icarius." His household is the standing alternative the suitors keep

threatening to send her back to, should
Telemachus give up the fight for his mother's
hand.

Kin: father of Penelope.

Refs: 1.329, 2.53, 2.133, 4.797, 11.446, 16.435,
18.159, 19.375, 20.388, 21.2, 24.195. Books 1–2, 4,
11, 16–21, 24.

See also: Penelope.

Icmalius (Ἰκμάλιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ik-MAY-lee-
us

The craftsman who made Penelope's inlaid,
silver-and-ivory chair.

Refs: 19.57. Book 19.

See also: Penelope.

Idomeneus (Ἰδομενεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* eye-DOM-
uh-nyoos or eye-DOM-ih-nee-us

The Cretan king who led his people to Troy; a
stock figure in the disguised Odysseus's
invented tales, in which Odysseus claims to
have hosted him on Crete, or to be his kinsman.

Refs: 3.191, 13.259, 14.237, 14.382, 19.181–192.

Books 3, 13–14, 19.

See also: Crete.

Ilus (Ἴλος) · MORTAL — Say: EYE-lus

Lord of Ephyra whom the young Odysseus visited seeking a lethal poison for his arrows; Ilus refused it, fearing the gods' displeasure, though another host — Anchialus, father of Mentès, the guise in which Athena tells the story — gave it to him out of love. Athena recalls the episode wishing that such an Odysseus might fall upon the suitors.

Also called: son of Mermerus.

Refs: 1.259, 1.262. Book 1.

See also: Athena.

Ino (Ἰνώ) · GOD — Say: EYE-noh

A sea-goddess, once mortal, daughter of Cadmus; she pities the shipwrecked Odysseus in Poseidon's storm, rises from the waves as a shearwater, and gives him her immortal veil to

bind beneath his chest as a charm against drowning, telling him to abandon the raft and swim for the Phaeacians' shore.

Also called: Leucothea, the White Goddess.

Refs: 5.333–461 (gives Odysseus the veil, reclaims it). Book 5.

See also: Poseidon, Phaeacians.

Iolcus (Ἰωλκός) · PLACE — *Say:* eye-OL-kus

The city of Pelias, from which the Argo sailed; named in the underworld catalogue of women in the story of Tyro and Pelias.

Refs: 11.256. Book 11.

See also: Hades.

Iphicles (Ἰφικλῆς) · MORTAL — *Say:* IF-ih-kleez

Owner of the prized cattle in the underworld tale of Pero and the seer Melampus: Neleus would give his daughter Pero only to the man who could drive off Iphicles' cattle from Phylace, a feat the seer's brother undertook and, after a year's imprisonment, achieved.

Refs: 11.290, 11.296. Book 11.

See also: Hades.

Iphimedeia (Ἰφιμέδεια) · MORTAL — *Say:* if-ih-muh-DY-uh

Wife of Aloeus who claimed to have lain with Poseidon; she bore him two short-lived sons, the giant Aloadae, seen among the shades in the underworld catalogue of women.

Kin: wife of Aloeus; lover of Poseidon.

Refs: 11.305. Book 11.

See also: Poseidon.

Iphitus (Ἰφίτος) · MORTAL — *Say:* IF-ih-tus

Son of Eurytus; he meets the young Odysseus in Messene while searching for lost mares, and the two exchange guest-gifts — Iphitus giving Odysseus his father's great bow, Odysseus giving a sword and spear. Heracles later kills Iphitus in his own house for those same mares. The bow, kept at home as a memorial of the friendship, becomes the instrument of the

suitors' deaths in Book 21.

Kin: son of Eurytus.

Refs: 21.14 (the gift of the bow), 21.22 (killed by Heracles), 21.31–37. Book 21.

See also: Eurytus, Heracles.

Iphthime (Ἰφθίμη) · MORTAL — *Say:* if-THY-mee

Penelope's sister, daughter of Icarius and wife of Eumelus of Pherae. Athena shapes a phantom in her likeness and sends it to Penelope's bedside to still her fear for Telemachus, a comfort she gives but does not stay to explain.

Kin: daughter of Icarius; sister of Penelope; wife of Eumelus.

Refs: 4.797.

See also: Penelope, Athena.

Irus (Ἴρος) · MORTAL — *Say:* EYE-rus

The town beggar of Ithaca, born Arnaeus but nicknamed Irus by the young men for running their errands; big-bodied and gluttonous but

without strength. He tries to drive the disguised Odysseus from his own porch and the suitors stage a boxing match between them for sport; Odysseus, holding back his full strength, breaks his neck-bone with one blow and drags him out by the hall door.

Also called: Arnaeus (his given name).

Refs: 18.6, 18.25, 18.38, 18.56, 18.73, 18.75, 18.88, 18.95, 18.233, 18.239, 18.333, 18.334, 18.393.

See also: Odysseus, Antinous.

Ismarus (Ἴσμαρος) · PLACE — *Say:* IS-muh-rus

The city of the Cicones on the Thracian coast, the first landfall of Odysseus's homeward voyage. His men sack it, kill the men, and divide the plunder; lingering to feast against his orders costs them a counterattack and six men per ship.

Refs: 9.40, 9.198.

See also: Cicones, Maron.

Ithaca (Ἰθάκη) · PLACE — Say: ITH-uh-kuh

Odysseus's rugged island kingdom west of the Greek mainland, the goal of the whole poem's homeward drive. It is the seat of his household, Penelope's twenty-year vigil, and the suitors' occupation of his hall, and the poem's structure alternates between the Telemachy and Apologoi abroad and the long return to it in Books 13–24.

Epithets: “sea-circled Ithaca” (ἁμφιάλος Ἰθάκη, 1.386); “rocky Ithaca” (Ἰθάκη κραναή, 1.247).

Refs: 1.18, 1.57, 1.88, 2.25, 4.555, 9.21, 9.531, 11.480, 13.97, 13.212, 14.98 ...and throughout. Books 1–4, 9–24.

See also: Odysseus, Penelope, Telemachus, Laertes.

Ithacus (Ἰθακος) · MORTAL — Say: ITH-uh-kus

Eponymous founder of Ithaca; with Neritus and Polyctor he is remembered as builder of the town's fountain, which the disguised Odysseus and Melanthius pass on the road.

Kin: named alongside Neritus and Polyctor.

Refs: 17.207.

See also: Ithaca.

Itylus (Ἴτυλος) · MORTAL — Say: IT-ih-lus

The young son killed, by mishap, by his own mother Aedon, who mourns him forever as the nightingale; Penelope compares her own divided heart to Aedon's song as she debates whether to stay or leave Odysseus's house.

Kin: son of Aedon.

Refs: 19.522.

See also: Penelope.

Jason (Ἰήσων) · MORTAL — Say: JAY-sun

Leader of the Argonauts; his ship Argo, "whom all minds know," is named as the one vessel ever to have passed safely between the Wandering Rocks, sailing home from Aeetes — the single precedent Circe cites when she steers Odysseus toward Scylla and Charybdis instead.

Refs: 12.72.

See also: Circe, Aeetes.

Lacedaemon (Λακεδαίμων) · PLACE — Say: las-uh-DEE-mun

The region of which Sparta is the city, Menelaus and Helen's home; Telemachus and Peisistratus drive there by chariot from Pylos, and it recurs as the byword for Menelaus's court throughout the Telemachy.

Refs: 3.326, 4.1, 4.313, 5.20, 13.414, 15.1, 17.121, 21.13.

See also: Menelaus, Sparta.

Laerces (Λαέρκης) · MORTAL — Say: lay-UR-seez

The goldsmith Nestor summons to gild the horns of the heifer sacrificed to Athena at Pylos.

Refs: 3.425.

See also: Nestor, Athena.

Laertes (Λαέρτης) · MORTAL — Say: lay-UR-teez

Odysseus's aged father, who has withdrawn in grief to his farm in the hills, refusing to set foot in town while the suitors despoil his son's

house. He appears throughout the poem as a measure of Odysseus's long absence, and in Book 24 Odysseus reveals himself to him in the orchard, naming the very trees his father once gave him as a boy — the poem's last and gentlest test of identity, restoring him briefly to youth and armor for the final skirmish.

Kin: son of Arceisius; father of Odysseus by Anticleia; grandfather of Telemachus.

Refs: 1.189, 1.430, 4.111, 9.19, 11.405, 16.118, 22.185, 22.336. Books 1–2, 4–5, 8–24.

See also: Odysseus, Anticleia, Telemachus.

Laestrygonians (Λαιστρυγόνες) · PEOPLE — Say:
lees-trih-GOH-nee-unz

A race of cannibal giants ruled from the city of Lamus; when Odysseus's fleet puts in at their harbor, they hurl boulders down from the cliffs, sink the ships, and spear the crews like fish, destroying eleven of his twelve vessels at a stroke — the single worst loss of the wanderings.

Refs: 10.82, 10.106, 10.119, 10.199, 23.318.

See also: Antiphates, Lamus.

Lampetie (Λαμπετία) · GOD — *Say:* lam-PEE-shee
Nymph, daughter of Helios and Neaera, who
with her sister Phaethusa herds and guards the
Sun's sacred cattle on Thrinacia; she carries
word to her father when Odysseus's starving
men slaughter the herd.

Kin: daughter of Helios; sister of Phaethusa.

Refs: 12.132, 12.375.

See also: Helios, Phaethusa.

Lampus (Λάμπος) · OTHER — *Say:* LAM-pus
One of the two colts — with Phaethon — that
draw the chariot of Dawn as she rises on the
day of the bow-contest.

Refs: 23.246.

See also: Dawn.

Lamus (Λάμος) · PLACE — *Say:* LAY-mus
Founder-eponym of Telepylus, the

Laestrygonian city, “where herdsman hails herdsman” at the meeting of night and day.

Refs: 10.81.

See also: Laestrygonians.

Laodamas (Λαοδάμας) · MORTAL — Say: lay-OD-uh-mus

Son of Alcinous and Arete, foremost of the young Phaeacian athletes; he urges the shipwrecked Odysseus to join the games at Book 8’s contest and, when Odysseus balks, needles him toward the discus-throw that proves his strength.

Kin: son of Alcinous and Arete; brother of Nausicaa.

Refs: 7.170, 8.117, 8.119, 8.130, 8.153, 8.207, 8.370.

See also: Alcinous, Arete, Nausicaa, Phaeacians.

Lapiths (Λαπίθαι) · PEOPLE — Say: LAP-iths

The people who, at Peirithous’s wedding feast, fought and defeated the drunken Centaurs —

the paradigm Odysseus (disguised) invokes
when he predicts Antinous's ruin.

Refs: 21.297.

See also: Antinous.

Leda (Λήδη) · MORTAL — *Say:* LEE-duh

Mother, by Tyndareus, of Castor and
Polydeuces; Odysseus glimpses her shade
among the heroines paraded before him in the
underworld.

Kin: mother of Castor and Polydeuces.

Refs: 11.298.

See also: Odysseus.

Lemnos (Λῆμνος) · PLACE — *Say:* LEM-nos

The island home of Hephaestus, named in the
song Demodocus sings of Ares and Aphrodite's
adultery — Hephaestus departs for Lemnos, the
affair he leaves to catch is exposed by the sun-
god.

Refs: 8.283, 8.294, 8.301.

See also: Hephaestus, Aphrodite.

Leocritus (Λεώκριτος) · MORTAL — Say: lee-OK-rih-tus

Son of Evenor; a suitor who mocks Mentor and breaks up the Book 2 assembly, unwittingly prophesying his own side's ruin — a prophecy the poem fulfills when Telemachus's spear takes him through the flank in the slaughter.

Kin: son of Evenor.

Refs: 2.242, 22.294.

See also: Mentor, Telemachus, the suitors.

Leodes (Λεώδης) · MORTAL — Say: lee-OH-deez

Son of Oenops; the suitors' soothsayer and sacrificer, and — the poem insists — the one among them who genuinely hated their outrages and tried to stop them. He clasps Odysseus's knees and begs by that innocence, but Odysseus convicts him on his office, not his acts — as their diviner he must have prayed for the suitors' success — and beheads him mid-plea.

Kin: son of Oenops.

Refs: 21.144, 21.168, 22.310.

See also: Odysseus, the suitors.

Lesbos (Λέσβος) · PLACE — *Say:* LEZ-bos

The island where a young Odysseus once wrestled and beat Philomeleides; Nestor, Menelaus, and the disguised Odysseus himself all cite the crossing at Lesbos as a landmark of sea-judgment.

Refs: 3.169, 4.342, 17.133.

See also: Odysseus.

Leto (Λητώ) · GOD — *Say:* LEE-toh

Mother of Apollo and Artemis by Zeus; invoked as the mother of the archer-twins and, in the underworld catalogue, as the goddess whose assault by Tityus earns him eternal punishment.

Kin: mother of Apollo and Artemis (by Zeus).

Refs: 6.106, 11.318, 11.580.

See also: Apollo, Artemis.

Libya (Λιβύη) · PLACE

The North African land Menelaus describes as endlessly rich in flocks, where lambs are born horned and ewes may lamb three times a year; Eumaeus's false Cretan tale also passes through it.

Refs: 4.85, 14.295.

See also: Menelaus, Eumaeus.

Lotus-eaters (Λωτοφάγοι) · PEOPLE

A gentle people whose flower-food erases all wish for home; three of Odysseus's scouts taste it and must be dragged weeping back to the ships and bound under the benches — the wanderings' first lesson in what threatens the return.

Refs: 9.84, 9.91, 9.92, 9.96, 23.311.

See also: Odysseus.

Maera (Μαῖρα) · MORTAL — Say: MEE-ruh

A heroine Odysseus glimpses among the shades of famous women in the underworld.

Refs: 11.326.

See also: Odysseus.

Maia (Μαῖα) · GOD — *Say:* MY-uh or MAY-uh
Nymph, mother of Hermes by Zeus; named
when Eumaeus's tale touches the god's lineage.
Kin: mother of Hermes (by Zeus).

Refs: 14.436.

See also: Hermes.

Malea (Μαλέα) · PLACE — *Say:* muh-LEE-uh
The stormy cape at the southern tip of the
Peloponnese where homeward-bound fleets are
scattered; it drives Odysseus off course to the
Cicones and Lotus-eaters and recurs in
Nestor's, Menelaus's, and Amphimedon's
accounts as the place where fair voyages turn
to disaster.

Refs: 3.288, 4.515, 9.80, 19.187.

See also: Odysseus.

Mantius (Μάντιος) · MORTAL — Say: MAN-tee-us

Son of the seer Melampus, father of
Polyphoides and Cleitus, in the genealogy
Theoclymenus recites of his own line of seers.
Kin: son of Melampus; father of Polyphoides and
Cleitus.

Refs: 15.242, 15.249.

See also: Melampus, Theoclymenus.

Marathon (Μαραθών) · PLACE — Say: MAR-uh-thon

Attic town Athena passes on her way to Athens,
named in the brief itinerary of her flight from
Scheria after guiding Odysseus's ship.

Refs: 7.80.

See also: Athena.

Maron (Μάρων) · MORTAL — Say: MAY-ron

Son of Euanthes, priest of Apollo at Ismarus;
Odysseus and his men spared him and his
family out of reverence when they sacked the
town, and in gratitude he gives Odysseus the
potent, richly diluted wine that will later fell

the Cyclops.

Kin: son of Euanthes.

Refs: 9.197.

See also: Ismarus, Polyphemus, Apollo.

Mastor (Μάστωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* MAS-tor

Father of Halitherses, the Ithacan elder and seer.

Kin: father of Halitherses.

Refs: 2.158, 24.452.

See also: Halitherses.

Medon (Μέδων) · MORTAL — *Say:* MEE-don

The herald of Odysseus's house; he warns Penelope of the suitors' ambush plot against Telemachus, and in the slaughter he is spared, along with the singer Phemius, at Telemachus's plea — the herald "who always cared for me when I was a child," found cowering under a chair wrapped in an oxhide.

Refs: 4.677, 4.696, 4.711, 16.252, 16.412, 22.357,

22.361, 24.439, 24.442.

See also: Phemius, Telemachus, Penelope.

Megapenthes (Μεγαπένθης) · MORTAL — *Say:* meg-uh-PEN-theez

Menelaus's son by a slave-woman, born late to him since the gods gave Helen no more children after Hermione; he is married off in the same double wedding-feast that greets Telemachus's arrival at Sparta.

Kin: son of Menelaus (by a slave-woman).

Refs: 4.11, 15.100, 15.103, 15.121.

See also: Menelaus.

Megara (Μεγάρᾱ) · MORTAL — *Say:* MEG-uh-ruh

Daughter of Creon and wife of Heracles; Odysseus sees her shade among the famous women paraded before him in the underworld.

Kin: daughter of Creon; wife of Heracles.

Refs: 11.269.

See also: Odysseus.

Melampus (Μελάμπους) · MORTAL — Say: muh-LAM-pus

The seer-ancestor of Theoclymenus's line. To win his brother a bride — Neleus's daughter — he stole the cattle of Iphiclus and was caught and bound for a year in bitter chains at Phylacus's hall; he escaped with the cattle, drove them to Pylos, paid off Neleus, and won the woman for his brother before founding a new line in Argos.

Refs: 15.225, 15.231.

See also: Mantius, Theoclymenus, Neleus.

Melaneus (Μελανεύς) · MORTAL — Say: mel-uh-NEE-us

Father of Amphimedon, one of the suitors; named in Amphimedon's shade's account of the massacre in the underworld.

Kin: father of Amphimedon.

Refs: 24.103.

See also: Amphimedon.

Melanthius (Μελάνθιος) · MORTAL — Say: muh-

LAN-thee-us

Dolius's son, the treacherous goatherd who insults the disguised Odysseus, arms the suitors from Odysseus's own storeroom during the final battle, and is caught in the act carrying Laertes' mildewed old shield. Odysseus and Eumaeus truss him and hang him alive from a roof-beam to suffer through the fighting; after the suitors fall he is dragged out and mutilated — nose, ears, hands, feet, and genitals torn away.

Kin: son of Dolius.

Refs: 17.212, 17.247, 17.369, 20.173, 21.176, 22.135, 22.159, 22.182, 22.474.

See also: Odysseus, Eumaeus, Dolius, Melantho.

Melantho (Μελανθώ) · MORTAL — Say: muh-LAN-thoh

An insolent slave-woman in Odysseus's household and Eurymachus's mistress; she taunts the disguised Odysseus and is later hanged with the other disloyal slave-women.

Refs: 18.321, 19.65.

See also: Eurymachus, Melanthius, Odysseus.

Memnon (Μέμνων) · MORTAL — *Say:* MEM-non

Son of Dawn, a Trojan-war ally killed at Troy;
Odysseus names him, alongside Achilles, as one
of the great dead when he flatters Achilles's
shade in the underworld.

Kin: son of Dawn (Eos).

Refs: 11.522.

See also: Achilles.

Menelaus (Μενέλαος) · MORTAL — *Say:* men-uh-
LAY-us

King of Sparta, Helen's husband, and younger
brother of Agamemnon; Telemachus visits him
in Book 4 to ask news of his father, and
Menelaus recounts his own storm-tossed
detour to Egypt and his wrestling-match with
Proteus, who told him of Odysseus stranded on
Calypso's island. He is the referent of "son of
Atreus" / "Atreides" in the Telemachy, as

opposed to Agamemnon elsewhere.

Epithets: “fair-haired Menelaus” (ξανθὸς Μενέλαος, 1.285); “Menelaus of the great war-cry” (βοῆν ἄγαθὸς Μενέλαος, 3.311).

Also called: “son of Atreus” / “Atreides” (context-dependent; Menelaus in the Telemachy, Books 3–4, 15).

Kin: son of Atreus; brother of Agamemnon; husband of Helen; father of Hermione and Megapenthes.

Refs: 1.285, 3.141, 4.2, 4.147, 4.235, 4.316, 4.561 (Proteus’s news of Odysseus), 15.5, 15.87. Books 1, 3–4, 8, 11, 13–15, 17, 24.

See also: Helen, Agamemnon, Telemachus, Proteus.

Menoetius (Μενοίτιος) · MORTAL — Say: muh-NEE-tee-us

Father of Patroclus, Achilles’s close companion; named when Agamemnon’s shade describes the two men’s bones mingled in a single golden urn after Achilles’s funeral.

Kin: father of Patroclus.

Refs: 24.77.

See also: Achilles.

Mentes (Μέντης) · MORTAL — *Say:* MEN-teez

Chieftain of the Taphians and a guest-friend of Odysseus's line; Athena takes his shape to visit Telemachus at the poem's opening, urge him to call the assembly, and set him sailing for news of his father.

Refs: 1.105, 1.180, 1.418.

See also: Athena, Telemachus.

Mentor (Μέντωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* MEN-tor

Odysseus's companion, entrusted with his whole household when he sailed for Troy. He alone speaks up for Telemachus at the Book 2 assembly, rebuking the people's silence — and Athena repeatedly borrows his exact shape and voice afterward (2.268, 22.206, 24.503), so that "Mentor" in later scenes is the goddess herself in his likeness rather than the man.

Kin: Odysseus's steward-companion.

Refs: 2.225 (the real Mentor, speaking for himself), 2.268 (Athena first as Mentor), 3.22, 4.654, 17.68, 22.206, 22.235, 24.446, 24.503, 24.548.

See also: Athena, Odysseus, Telemachus.

Mermerus (Μέρμερος) · MORTAL — Say: MUR-muh-rus

Father of Ilus of Ephyra, the poison-dealer
Odysseus once sought out; named only in that
genealogical aside.

Kin: father of Ilus.

Refs: 1.259.

See also: Odysseus.

Mesaulius (Μεσαύλιος) · MORTAL — Say: muh-SAW-lee-us

A slave Eumaeus bought with his own means,
from Taphian traders, while his master was
away — his private property rather than part of
the household stock.

Refs: 14.449, 14.455.

See also: Eumaeus.

Messene (Μεσσήνη) · PLACE — Say: muh-SEE-nee

The region where a young Odysseus, sent to collect a debt, first met and befriended Iphitus, who gave him the bow he keeps at home ever after.

Refs: 21.15.

See also: Odysseus, Iphitus.

Mimas (Μίμας) · PLACE — Say: MY-mus

The headland opposite Chios that marks a turn on the sailing route Nestor recounts from the fall of Troy.

Refs: 3.172.

See also: Nestor.

Minos (Μίνως) · MORTAL — Say: MY-nos

King of Crete in his lifetime, “shining son of Zeus”; in the underworld Odysseus sees him seated with a golden scepter, delivering

judgment among the dead as they plead their cases before him.

Kin: son of Zeus.

Refs: 11.322, 11.568, 17.523, 19.178.

See also: Odysseus, Zeus.

Moly (μῶλυ) · OTHER — *Say:* MOH-lee

The god-given herb, black-rooted with a milk-white flower, that Hermes gives Odysseus to make him proof against Circe's drug before he confronts her.

Refs: 10.305.

See also: Hermes, Circe.

Moulius (Μούλιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* MOO-lee-us

Herald of the suitor Amphinomus, briefly named in his master's service.

Refs: 18.423.

See also: Amphinomus.

Muses (Μοῦσαι) · GOD

The nine goddesses of song, invoked by the

narrator in the poem's opening line ("Sing to me, Muse...") and, in Agamemnon's account of Achilles's funeral, appearing in the story itself: all nine sing the dirge over his body, "answering voice to lovely voice" — poetry's patronesses mourning poetry's own hero.

Refs: 1.1, 8.63, 8.480, 24.60, 24.62.

See also: Demodocus, Achilles.

Mycenae (Μυκῆνη) · PLACE — Say: my-SEE-nee
Agamemnon's city; Nestor recounts that Aegisthus ruled there seven years after murdering Agamemnon, before Orestes returned to kill him. Telemachus later invokes it, with Pylos and Argos, as a byword for a woman's fame in praising Penelope.

Refs: 3.305, 21.108.

See also: Agamemnon, Orestes, Mycene.

Mycene (Μυκῆνη) · MORTAL — Say: my-SEE-nee
A heroine of the old days, "of the lovely crown," named beside Tyro and Alcmene in the

catalogue of legendary women; the eponym of Agamemnon's city Mycenae.

Refs: 2.120.

See also: Mycenae.

Myrmidons (Μυρμιδόνες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* MUR-mih-donz

Achilles's Thessalian people, named when his kingdom and son Neoptolemus are discussed in the Telemachy and the underworld.

Refs: 3.188, 4.9, 11.495.

See also: Achilles.

Naiads (Νηϊάδες) · GOD — *Say:* NY-adz or NAY-adz

The water-nymphs of the sea-cave sacred at the head of the harbor of Phorcys in Ithaca, where Odysseus once offered them hecatombs and where the Phaeacians lay him, still asleep, with his treasure on his return. Athena cites the cave's exact details to prove to Odysseus that he is truly home, and his first act on recognizing Ithaca is to pray to these "nymphs of the

springs, daughters of Zeus.”

Also called: “the nymphs” (generic).

Refs: 13.104, 13.348, 13.356, 14.435, 17.240.

See also: Ithaca, Phorcys.

Nausicaa (Ναυσικάα) · MORTAL — Say: naw-SIK-ay-uh

Daughter of Alcinous and Arete, out washing linens with her handmaids when she finds the shipwrecked, naked Odysseus on the shore (Book 6). She guides him to her parents’ hall with tact and self-possession, and is the last woman he meets before Penelope; Odysseus’s parting blessing to her (6.180ff) is one of the poem’s tenderest speeches. She reappears briefly at the Book 8 games.

Epithets: “white-armed Nausicaa” (Ναυσικάα λευκώλενος, 6.101).

Kin: daughter of Alcinous and Arete; sister of Laodamas.

Refs: 6.17 (first, “daughter of great-hearted Alcinous”), 6.25, 6.49, 6.101, 6.186, 6.213, 6.251,

6.276, 7.12, 8.457, 8.464.

See also: Alcinous, Arete, Phaeacians, Scheria.

Nausithous (Ναυσίθοος) · MORTAL — *Say:* naw-SITH-oh-us

Former king of the Phaeacians, son of Poseidon and Periboea, who led his people away from the Cyclopes' neighborhood and settled them on Scheria. Father of Rhexenor and Alcinous; already dead by the time of Odysseus's visit, but Alcinous cites his father's old warning that Poseidon resents the Phaeacians' habit of ferrying every stranger home unharmed (8.564–566) — the warning that comes true against Odysseus's own ship.

Kin: son of Poseidon and Periboea; father of Rhexenor and Alcinous.

Refs: 6.7, 7.56–63 (the genealogy), 8.564.

See also: Alcinous, Poseidon, Periboea, Scheria.

Neaera (Νέαιρα) · GOD — *Say:* nee-EE-ruh

A nymph named only once, by Helios as the

mother of the herdswomen who tend his cattle and sheep on Thrinacia — Phaethusa and Lampetie.

Kin: consort of Helios.

Refs: 12.133.

See also: Helios.

Neion (Νήϊον) · PLACE — *Say:* NEE-on

A height on Ithaca above the harbor, named in passing as Telemachus's ship sets out and again in the muster for the suitors' funeral ambush.

Refs: 1.186, 3.81.

See also: Ithaca.

Neleus (Νηλεΰς) · MORTAL — *Say:* NEE-lee-us

Former king of Pylos, father of Nestor; son of Poseidon and Tyro, who bore him and his twin Pelias in secret. He is already gone by the poem's present, but his house still stands: his daughter Pero was won by a suitor who first had to drive off the cattle of Iphicles, and several of his other sons are named among

Nestor's dead brothers.

Kin: son of Poseidon and Tyro; father of Nestor, Chromius, Periclymenus, Pero, and others.

Refs: 3.4, 3.79, 3.202, 3.247, 3.409, 3.465, 11.254–257 (birth), 11.281–288 (Pero and the cattle-feat), 15.229–237.

See also: Nestor, Pero, Pelias, Tyro.

Neoptolemus (Νεοπτόλεμος) · MORTAL — *Say:* nee-op-TOL-uh-mus

Achilles's son, fetched from Scyros to fight at Troy; in the underworld Odysseus tells Achilles's ghost of his son's courage and success in the war — news meant to comfort a father who cannot know it himself.

Kin: son of Achilles.

Refs: 11.506.

See also: Achilles, Peleus.

Nericus (Νήρικος) · PLACE — *Say:* NER-ih-kus

A mainland town that Laertes once captured while he was still king in his strength, recalled

in the poem's closing book as a measure of the old man's former vigor.

Refs: 24.377.

See also: Laertes.

Neriton (Νήριτον) · PLACE — *Say:* NER-ih-ton

The tall, wooded mountain that dominates Ithaca's skyline, named as a landmark visible from the sea and invoked in similes of visibility and height.

Refs: 9.22, 13.351.

See also: Ithaca.

Neritus (Νήριτος) · MORTAL — *Say:* NER-ih-tus

One of the legendary founders associated with Ithaca, named once and distinct from the mountain Neriton that bears a similar name.

Refs: 17.207.

See also: Ithaca, Neriton.

Nestor (Νέστωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* NES-tor

Aged king of Pylos, son of Neleus, and the sole

surviving elder statesman of the generation that sailed to Troy. Telemachus visits him first in his search for news of his father (Book 3); Nestor cannot say what became of Odysseus but retells the Achaeans' quarrelsome breakup after Troy and Agamemnon's murder at length, then sends Telemachus on to Sparta with his son Peisistratus as escort. Telemachus recalls the visit again to Penelope in Book 17, and Agamemnon's shade recalls Nestor's steadying counsel at Achilles's funeral in Book 24's retelling of Troy.

Epithets: "Gerenian Nestor the horseman" (Γερήνιος ἵππότης Νέστωρ, 3.68).

Kin: son of Neleus; father of Peisistratus, Antilochus (dead at Troy), Thrasymedes, and others.

Refs: 1.284, 3.17–79 (the arrival and sacrifice), 3.102–474 (his long telling), 4.21, 11.286, 11.512, 15.4–202 (Telemachus's departure) ...and throughout Books 3–4, 15, 17, 24.

See also: Neleus, Peisistratus, Telemachus, Pylos.

Nisus (Νίσος) · MORTAL — Say: NY-sus

Lord of Dulichium and father of the suitor
Amphinomus, named only to identify his son.

Kin: father of Amphinomus.

Refs: 16.395, 18.127, 18.413.

See also: Amphinomus.

Noemon (Νοήμων) · MORTAL — Say: noh-EE-mon

An Ithacan, son of Phronius, who lends
Telemachus the ship for his secret voyage to
Pylos and later unwittingly tips off the suitors
that he has gone.

Also called: “son of Phronius.”

Refs: 2.386, 4.630, 4.648.

See also: Telemachus, the suitors.

Ocean (Ὠκεανός) · PLACE

The great river that the poem imagines
encircling the flat world; beyond its stream lie
the sunless land of the dead and other far
horizons. Odysseus crosses it to reach the
underworld (Book 10–11), and it recurs as a

boundary-marker in similes and geography throughout.

Refs: 4.567, 5.275, 10.139, 10.508–511, 11.13–21, 11.158, 11.639, 12.1, 19.434, 20.65, 22.197, 23.244–347, 24.11.

See also: the underworld, Persephone.

Odysseus (Ὀδυσσεύς) · MORTAL — Say: oh-DIS-ee-us or oh-DISS-yoos

King of Ithaca, son of Laertes, husband of Penelope, father of Telemachus; the poem is his homecoming. Detained by Calypso, wrecked on Scheria, he tells the Phaeacians his ten years of wandering (Books 9–12) — the Cicones, the Lotus-eaters, Polyphemus (whom he blinds and tricks with the name “Nobody”), Circe, the underworld, the Sirens, Scylla and Charybdis, and Thrinacia — then sails home alone, disguised by Athena as a beggar, to test his household, win the bow-contest, and slaughter the suitors before revealing himself to Penelope and Laertes.

Epithets: “much-enduring noble Odysseus”

(πολύτλας δῖος Ὀδυσσεύς, 5.171); “Odysseus of the many designs” (πολύμητις/πολύφρων Ὀδυσσεύς, 1.83, 2.173); “noble Odysseus” (δῖος Ὀδυσσεύς, 1.196); “Odysseus, sacker of cities” (πτολίπορθος Ὀδυσσεύς, 8.3).

Also called: “Nobody” (Οὔτις), the trick-name given to Polyphemos in Book 9.

Kin: son of Laertes and Anticleia; husband of Penelope; father of Telemachus.

Refs: 1.21 (opening line), 1.48, 1.196, 2.173, 3.163 ...and throughout every book, 1–24.

See also: Penelope, Telemachus, Laertes, Athena, Calypso, Polyphemos.

Oechalia (Οἰχαλία) · PLACE — *Say:* ee-KAY-lee-uh

The city ruled by Eurytus, the great archer whose bow Odysseus later strings; named once in the catalogue of that bow’s history.

Refs: 8.224.

See also: Eurytus.

Oedipus (Οἰδίπους) · MORTAL — Say: EE-dih-pus or ED-ih-pus

Named in the underworld as the son and unwitting husband of Epicaste (Jocasta), who hanged herself in horror once the truth of their marriage came out; Odysseus sees her ghost among the heroines.

Kin: son and husband of Epicaste.

Refs: 11.271.

See also: the underworld.

Oenops (Οἶνοψ) · MORTAL — Say: EE-nops

Father of the suitor Leodes, named only to identify his son.

Kin: father of Leodes.

Refs: 21.144.

See also: Leodes, the suitors.

Ogygia (Ὠκυγῖη) · PLACE — Say: oh-JIJ-ee-uh

Calypso's remote island, "the navel of the sea," where Odysseus spends seven years before the gods intervene to send him home.

Refs: 1.85, 6.172, 7.244–254, 12.448, 23.333.

See also: Calypso.

Oicles (Οἰκλῆς) · MORTAL — *Say:* OY-kleez

Father of the seer Amphiaraus, named in
Theoclymenus's genealogy.

Kin: father of Amphiaraus.

Refs: 15.243–244.

See also: Theoclymenus, Amphiaraus.

Olympus (Ὀλυμπος) · PLACE — *Say:* oh-LIM-pus

The gods' mountain seat, set above weather and
mortal change; the site of the divine councils
that open and close the poem's action (1.102,
24.351–488) and the standing address of the
immortals throughout.

Refs: 1.102, 3.377, 6.42–240, 8.331, 10.308,
11.315, 12.337, 14.394, 15.43, 18.180, 19.43,
20.55–103, 23.167, 24.351–488.

See also: Zeus, Athena.

Onetor (Ὀνήτωρ) · MORTAL — Say: oh-NEE-tor

Father of Phrontis, the Sparta-bound helmsman
Menelaus lost off Sunium, named only in that
aside.

Kin: father of Phrontis.

Refs: 3.282.

See also: Menelaus.

Ops (Ὀψ) · MORTAL — Say: OPS

Father of Eurycleia, Odysseus's old nurse; the
patronymic recurs every time she is formally
introduced. He is himself "Peisenor's son" — a
different Peisenor from the Ithacan herald of
Book 2 (see Peisenor).

Kin: father of Eurycleia.

Refs: 1.429, 2.347, 20.148.

See also: Eurycleia, Peisenor.

Orchomenus (Ὀρχομενός) · PLACE — Say: or-KOM-uh-nus

The Minyan city of legendary wealth, twice
invoked in the underworld book as a byword

for riches — once by Tyro's line, once ranked
alongside Egyptian Thebes.

Refs: 11.284, 11.459.

See also: the underworld.

Orestes (Ὀρέστης) · MORTAL — *Say:* oh-RES-teez
Agamemnon's son, who avenges his father's
murder by killing Aegisthus; the gods and
Athena repeatedly hold him up to Telemachus
as the model of the heir who acts, the poem's
counter-example to Telemachus's own
hesitation.

Kin: son of Agamemnon and Clytemnestra.

Refs: 1.30, 1.40, 1.298, 3.306, 4.546, 11.461.

See also: Agamemnon, Aegisthus, Telemachus.

Orion (Ὠρίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* oh-RY-un

The great hunter: Dawn once loved and carried
him off, until the gods' envy brought Artemis's
arrows down on him in Ortygia; in the
underworld his ghost still strides the asphodel
meadow driving the beasts he killed in life. Also

named as the constellation Calypso tells
Odysseus to watch by.

Refs: 5.121–123, 5.274, 11.310, 11.572–574.

See also: Ortygia, Artemis, the underworld.

Ormenus (Ὀρμενός) · MORTAL — *Say:* OR-muh-nus
Father of Ctesius in Eumaeus's account of his
own ancestry, named only there.

Kin: father of Ctesius.

Refs: 15.414.

See also: Eumaeus.

Orsilochus (Ὀρσίλοχος) · MORTAL — *Say:* or-SIL-
oh-kus
Son of Idomeneus in the false tale Odysseus
spins for Athena on the Ithacan shore, claiming
to have killed him in an ambush over war-
spoils.

Kin: (in the lying tale) son of Idomeneus.

Refs: 13.260.

See also: Odysseus, Idomeneus.

Ortilochus (Ὀρτίλοχος) · MORTAL — Say: or-TIL-oh-kus

Son of the river-god Alpheus and father of Diocles of Pherae, the host who lodges Telemachus and Peisistratus on their road to and from Sparta.

Kin: son of Alpheus; father of Diocles.

Refs: 3.489, 15.187, 21.16.

See also: Diocles, Peisistratus.

Ortygia (Ὀρτυγίη) · PLACE — Say: or-TIJ-ee-uh

The island where Artemis's gentle arrows struck down Orion; named again in Eumaeus's account of his distant homeland.

Refs: 5.123, 15.404.

See also: Orion, Artemis.

Ossa (Ὀσσα) · PLACE — Say: OS-uh

One of the two mountains — with Pelion — that the giants Otus and Ephialtes piled on Olympus in their assault on heaven.

Refs: 11.315.

See also: Otus, Pelion, Olympus.

Otus (Ὠτος) · MORTAL — *Say:* OH-tus

Giant son of Iphimedeia and Poseidon, twin of Ephialtes; the pair grew to monstrous size and beauty and piled Ossa on Olympus and Pelion on Ossa to storm heaven, before Apollo destroyed them young.

Kin: son of Iphimedeia (by Poseidon); twin of Ephialtes.

Refs: 11.308.

See also: Ossa, Pelion, Olympus.

Paeon (Παῖων) · GOD — *Say:* pee-EE-on

The physician of the gods, invoked by Helen in an aside about Egyptian medicine as the source of healing skill.

Refs: 4.232.

See also: Helen.

Pandareus (Πανδάρειος) · MORTAL — Say: pan-

DAIR-ee-us

Father of the nightingale-woman Aedon, whose grief at accidentally killing her own son is the simile for Penelope's sleepless sorrow (19.518), and father too of the daughters swept off by the storm-winds after the gods orphaned them (20.66).

Kin: father of Aedon and of the storm-snatched daughters.

Refs: 19.518, 20.66.

See also: Penelope.

Panopeus (Πανοπέυς) · PLACE — Say: puh-NOP-ee-

us

A Phocian town, named as a landmark near which the giant Tityus lies stretched out in torment in the underworld.

Refs: 11.581.

See also: the underworld, Tityus.

Paphos (Πάφος) · PLACE — Say: PAF-os or PAY-fos

Aphrodite's sacred precinct on Cyprus, where she withdraws after her affair with Ares is exposed, to be bathed and anointed by the Graces.

Refs: 8.363.

See also: Aphrodite.

Parnassus (Παρνησός) · PLACE — Say: par-NAS-us

The mountain where young Odysseus hunted with his uncles and took the boar-gash on his thigh that becomes his identifying scar, recognized first by Eurycleia and later by Laertes.

Refs: 19.394–466, 21.220, 24.332.

See also: Odysseus, Eurycleia, Autolycus.

Patroclus (Πάτροκλος) · MORTAL — Say: puh-TROH-klus

Achilles's closest companion at Troy; his ghost appears beside Achilles's in the underworld, and the two share a single funeral mound, their

ashes mixed as they had asked.

Kin: companion of Achilles.

Refs: 3.110, 11.468, 24.16, 24.77–79.

See also: Achilles, the underworld.

Peirithous (Πειρίθοος) · MORTAL — Say: py-RITH-oh-us

Lapith king and companion of Theseus, seen among the famous women's train of shades that Odysseus does not linger to describe; also the host in whose hall the drunken Centaur Eurytion committed his outrage, the paradigm of wine-fueled violence cited against the suitors.

Kin: companion of Theseus.

Refs: 11.631, 21.296–298.

See also: Theseus, the underworld.

Peisander (Πείσανδρος) · MORTAL — Say: py-SAN-der

Son of Polyctor, one of the suitors; struck dumb with fear at the first killings and cut down by

Philoetius in the hall-fight.

Also called: “son of Polyctor.”

Kin: son of Polyctor.

Refs: 18.299, 22.243, 22.268.

See also: the suitors.

Peisenor (Πεισήνωρ) · MORTAL — Say: py-SEE-nor

Two different men share this name in the poem: an Ithacan herald of “clear-headed counsel” who attends the Book 2 assembly (2.38), and — a generation earlier — the father of Ops and so the grandfather of Eurycleia, invoked whenever she is introduced by her full patronymic (1.429, 2.347, 20.148).

Refs: 1.429, 2.38, 2.347, 20.148.

See also: Ops, Eurycleia.

Peisistratus (Πεισίστρατος) · MORTAL — Say: py-SIS-truh-tus

Nestor’s youngest son, still unwed in his father’s halls, who shares a bed with Telemachus at Pylos and drives him on by

chariot to Sparta and back, a steady companion through the Telemachy's second half.

Kin: son of Nestor.

Refs: 3.36, 3.400–415, 3.454, 3.482, 4.155, 15.46–48, 15.131, 15.166.

See also: Nestor, Telemachus.

Pelasgians (Πελασγοί) · PEOPLE — *Say:* puh-LAZ-jee-unz

One of the several peoples of Crete named in Odysseus's account of that island's mixed population to Penelope.

Refs: 19.177.

See also: Crete.

Peleus (Πηλεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* PEE-lee-us

Father of Achilles; in the underworld Achilles's ghost anxiously asks Odysseus for news of him, and Odysseus can only say he has heard nothing — a father's fate left open, unlike his son's, whose death and glory Odysseus can report in full.

Kin: father of Achilles.

Refs: 5.310, 8.75, 11.467–494 (Achilles’s ghost), 11.505 (Odysseus has no news of him), 11.551–558, 24.15–36.

See also: Achilles, Neoptolemus.

Pelias (Πηλίας) · MORTAL — *Say:* PEE-lee-us or PEL-ee-us

Son of Tyro and Poseidon, twin of Neleus, who became king in Iolcus; named in Tyro’s genealogy among the underworld shades.

Kin: son of Poseidon and Tyro; twin of Neleus.

Refs: 11.254–256.

See also: Neleus, Tyro.

Pelion (Πήλιον) · PLACE — *Say:* PEE-lee-on

The mountain of “shivering leaves” that the giants Otus and Ephialtes piled atop Ossa in their attempt to storm heaven.

Refs: 11.316.

See also: Ossa, Otus, Olympus.

Penelope (Πηνελόπεια) · MORTAL — Say: puh-NEL-uh-pee

Odysseus's wife, daughter of Icarius, who holds off 108 suitors for twenty years through grief, guile, and the unraveled weaving-trick, never certain her husband still lives. She tests the disguised beggar's knowledge of Odysseus, sets the axe-contest that only he can win, and — even after the suitors' deaths — makes Odysseus prove himself with the secret of their marriage-bed before she accepts him.

Epithets: “watchful-minded Penelope” (περίφρων Πηνελόπεια, 1.329); “steady-hearted Penelope” (ἑχέφρων Πηνελόπεια, 4.111).

Also called: “daughter of Icarius.”

Kin: daughter of Icarius; wife of Odysseus; mother of Telemachus.

Refs: 1.223, 1.329, 4.111, 4.675–830 (learns of the ambush), 16.409–459, 18.159–285 (before the suitors) ...and throughout Books 1–2, 4–5, 11, 13–24.

See also: Odysseus, Telemachus, Icarius, Eurycleia.

Periboea (Περίβοια) · MORTAL — Say: per-ih-BEE-uh

Mother of Nausithous by Poseidon, named once in the Phaeacian royal genealogy Alcinous recites.

Kin: consort of Poseidon; mother of Nausithous.

Refs: 7.57.

See also: Nausithous, Poseidon.

Periclymenus (Περικλύμενος) · MORTAL — Say: per-ih-KLIM-uh-nus

A son of Neleus, named among Nestor's brothers in Tyro's line of descendants seen in the underworld.

Kin: son of Neleus; brother of Nestor.

Refs: 11.286.

See also: Neleus, Nestor.

Perimedes (Περιμήδης) · MORTAL — Say: per-ih-MEE-deez

One of Odysseus's crewmen, steady at his side holding the sacrificial sheep during the

underworld rite in Book 11 and named again performing the same office in Circe's instructions recalled in Book 12.

Refs: 11.23, 12.195.

See also: Odysseus.

Pero (Πηρώ) · MORTAL — *Say:* PEE-roh

Neleus's daughter, "a wonder of mortals," courted by every neighboring man; her father would give her only to whoever could drive off the cattle of mighty Iphicles, a feat her suitor Melampus's brother eventually undertakes.

Kin: daughter of Neleus.

Refs: 11.287.

See also: Neleus.

Perse (Πέρση) · GOD — *Say:* PUR-see

An Oceanid, daughter of Ocean, who bears Circe and Aeetes to Helios — named once in Circe's own genealogy as Odysseus's crew land on her island.

Kin: daughter of Ocean; consort of Helios;

mother of Circe and Aeetes.

Refs: 10.139.

See also: Circe, Helios, Ocean.

Persephone (Περσεφόνη) · GOD — *Say:* pur-SEF-oh-nee

Queen of the dead, invoked alongside Hades in the underworld rite (11.47) and the power who marshals the ghosts of the great heroines to come drink the blood and speak with Odysseus (11.213–226). She is the one who could, if she chose, send the Gorgon’s head against him — the fear that finally drives him from the underworld.

Epithets: “dread Persephone” (11.47, 10.491–564).

Refs: 10.491–564, 11.47, 11.213–226, 11.385, 11.634.

See also: Hades, the underworld.

Perseus (Περσεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* PUR-see-us

A son of Nestor, named among his brothers

greeting Telemachus at Pylos.

Kin: son of Nestor.

Refs: 3.414, 3.444.

See also: Nestor.

The Phaeacian competitors · MORTAL

The young Phaeacian noblemen — Acronaeus, Ocyalus, Elatreus, Nauteus, Prymneus, Anchialus, Eretmeus, Ponteus, Proreus, Thoon, Anabesineus, Amphialus, Euryalus, and Alcinous's sons Laodamas, Halius, and Clytoneus among them — who rise together and compete in the running, wrestling, jumping, and discus at the Book 8 games.

Refs: 8.111–129.

See also: Alcinous, Laodamas, Phaeacians, Scheria.

Phaeacians (Φαίηκες) · PEOPLE — Say: fee-AY-shunz

The seafaring people of Scheria, ruled by Alcinous and Arete, and Odysseus's last hosts

before Ithaca. Renowned above all peoples for shipcraft, they receive the shipwrecked stranger, stage the games and feast at which he tells his wanderings, and finally carry him home asleep aboard one of their crewless ships — the passage for which Poseidon punishes them by turning the returning ship to stone within sight of their own harbor.

Epithets: “the Phaeacians of the long oars, men famed for ships” (Φαίηκες δολιχήρετμοι, ναυσίκλυτοι ἄνδρες, 8.191).

Refs: 5.35, 6.3, 6.195, 7.11, 7.39, 8.5, 8.191, 8.386 ...and throughout. Books 5–8, 11, 13, 16, 19, 23. *See also:* Alcinous, Arete, Nausicaa, Scheria, Poseidon.

Phaedimus · MORTAL — *Say:* FEE-dih-mus

King of Sidon in Phoenicia and a host of Menelaus on his travels; he gives Menelaus the silver mixing-bowl, rimmed with gold and the work of Hephaestus, that Menelaus later presents to Telemachus as a parting gift.

Refs: 4.617, 15.117.

See also: Menelaus, Phoenicia.

Phaedra · MORTAL — *Say:* FEE-druh or FAY-druh

A heroine whose shade Odysseus glimpses in the underworld's catalogue of famous women, named in the same line as Procris and Ariadne.

Refs: 11.321.

See also: Procris.

Phaestus (Φαιστός) · PLACE — *Say:* FEE-stus or FES-tus

A town on Crete, named as the place by whose reef Menelaus's fleet is wrecked on the voyage home from Troy.

Refs: 3.296.

Phaethon · OTHER — *Say:* FAY-uh-thon

One of the two colts, "Shiner" and "Blazer," that draw the chariot of Dawn; Athena holds him and his yoke-mate short of the sky when she prolongs the night of Odysseus and Penelope's

reunion.

Refs: 23.246.

Phaethusa (“Shining”) · GOD — Say: fay-uh-THOO-suh

One of the two nymphs, with her sister
Lampetie, whom Helios sets to guard his cattle
and sheep on Thrinacia.

Kin: daughter of Helios and Neaera.

Refs: 12.132.

See also: Helios.

Pharos · PLACE — Say: FAIR-os or FAR-os

The island just off the mouth of Egypt where
Poseidon becalms Menelaus’s fleet for twenty
days; there, guided by Eidothea, Menelaus
ambushes and questions Proteus.

Refs: 4.355.

See also: Proteus, Menelaus.

Pheae · PLACE — Say: FEE-ee

A coastal town of the western Peloponnese,

passed by Telemachus's ship on the night-sail
back from Pylos.

Refs: 15.297.

Pheidon · MORTAL — Say: FY-don

King of the Thesprotians in the fictional
wanderings Odysseus tells Eumaeus and, later,
Penelope: he takes the castaway in without
price, swears an oath over libation that the real
Odysseus is alive and en route home with
treasure, and has a ship readied for his passage.

Refs: 14.316, 19.287.

Phemius · MORTAL — Say: FEE-mee-us

Son of Terpes, the bard kept at the suitors' hall;
the narrator twice stresses he sings for them
“under compulsion.” When Odysseus and
Telemachus cut down the suitors, Phemius
pleads for his life on that same ground and is
spared.

Also called: “Terpes' son” (patronymic).

Refs: 1.154, 1.337, 17.262, 22.331.

See also: Telemachus.

Pherae · PLACE — *Say:* FEE-ree

A waypoint on the chariot road between Pylos and Sparta, where Telemachus and Peisistratus lodge with Diocles both going and returning; also the name of a separate Thessalian town, home of Eumelus.

Refs: 3.488, 4.798, 15.186.

Pheres · MORTAL — *Say:* FEE-reez

Son of Tyro and Cretheus, named among Tyro's sons in the underworld catalogue of heroines.

Kin: son of Tyro and Cretheus.

Refs: 11.259.

Philoctetes · MORTAL — *Say:* fil-ok-TEE-teez

The great archer of the Trojan War, son of Poias; Nestor confirms he came home safe, and Odysseus, boasting of his own skill with the bow, admits only Philoctetes surpassed him at

Troy.

Kin: son of Poias.

Refs: 3.190, 8.219.

See also: Poias.

Philoetius · MORTAL — *Say:* fil-EE-tee-us

The loyal cowherd, “a leader of men,” who arrives on the household’s last day driving cattle for the suitors’ table. He reads through Odysseus’s beggar-disguise to guess at a king in ruin, weeps over his master’s bow, and once sworn to the cause bars the courtyard gates, arms himself, and kills the suitor Ctesippus with a spear-taunt answering Ctesippus’s earlier ox-hoof insult.

Refs: 20.185, 20.227, 20.254, 21.193, 21.240, 21.388, 22.359.

See also: Eumaeus, Odysseus.

Philomeleides · MORTAL — *Say:* fil-oh-muh-LY-deez

King of Lesbos whom Odysseus once out-

wrestled on a challenge, on the voyage back from Troy — a feat of strength Menelaus and, later, Odysseus's own disguise-tale each recall.

Refs: 4.343, 17.134.

Phoenicia · PLACE — *Say:* fih-NISH-uh

The Levantine trading coast, home of the Sidonians; source of the fine goods that pass through the poem's gift-economy, and also of the traders who steal Eumaeus as a child.

Refs: 4.83, 14.290.

See also: Phoenicians.

Phoenicians (Σιδόνιοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* fih-NISH-unz

The seafaring traders and slavers of Sidon. They bring fine goods to courts across the poem's world, and a treacherous Phoenician woman, nurse to Eumaeus's childhood household, sells him into slavery — the same people who deal honestly in luxury goods and dishonestly in people.

Refs: 13.272, 14.288, 15.415, 15.417, 15.419, 15.473.

See also: Phoenicia, Eumaeus.

Phorcys · GOD — *Say:* FOR-sis

A sea-god, “lord of the barren salt sea”; his daughter Thoosa lies with Poseidon and bears Polyphemus. Ithaca’s principal harbor, where the Phaeacians set the sleeping Odysseus ashore, is called by his name, and the text twice describes it as belonging to “the old man of the sea” — a description of Phorcys, distinct from Proteus’s own fixed epithet.

Kin: father of Thoosa (by whom Poseidon fathers Polyphemus).

Refs: 1.72, 13.96, 13.345.

See also: Polyphemus, Poseidon.

Phronius · MORTAL — *Say:* FROH-nee-us

Father of Noemon, the young Ithacan who lends Telemachus the ship for his voyage to Pylos.

Kin: father of Noemon.

Refs: 2.386, 4.630, 4.648.

Phrontis · MORTAL — *Say:* FRON-tis

Son of Onetor and Menelaus's helmsman, unmatched at steering a ship through storm-winds; Apollo kills him at the tiller off holy Sunium on the voyage from Troy, and Menelaus stops there to bury him.

Also called: "son of Onetor" (patronymic).

Kin: son of Onetor.

Refs: 3.282.

See also: Menelaus.

Phthia · PLACE — *Say:* FTHY-uh or THY-uh

Achilles's homeland in Thessaly; in the underworld Odysseus tells Achilles's shade that his son is honored fully "through Hellas and Phthia."

Refs: 11.496.

See also: Achilles.

Phylace · PLACE — Say: fih-LAY-see

The town of Phylacus in the tale of the seer Melampus, who is held captive there a year for attempting to steal Iphicles's cattle before he is released and drives the herd to Pylos.

Refs: 11.291, 15.236.

See also: Phylacus.

Phylacus · MORTAL — Say: FIL-uh-kus

Lord of Phylace and owner of the cattle at the center of the Melampus tale; Melampus is imprisoned in his halls for a year before winning the herd.

Refs: 15.231.

See also: Phylace.

Phylo · MORTAL — Say: FY-loh

Helen's handmaid in Sparta, who brings her silver workbasket and wool when she joins Menelaus and their guests.

Refs: 4.125, 4.133.

See also: Helen.

Pieria · PLACE — Say: py-EER-ee-uh

The mountain over which Hermes swoops down from Olympus on his way to Calypso's island, Ogygia.

Refs: 5.50.

See also: Hermes, Calypso.

Piraeus · MORTAL — Say: py-REE-us

Son of Clytius and one of Telemachus's trusted companions on the voyage from Pylos; Telemachus entrusts him with Theoclymenus and his gifts, and Piraeus shelters and honors the seer through the poem's later books, receiving him again after Telemachus warns him off the perilous house.

Epithets: "famous for the spear" (δουρικλυτός, 15.544).

Kin: son of Clytius.

Refs: 15.539, 15.540, 15.544, 17.55, 17.71, 17.74, 17.78, 20.372.

See also: Theoclymenus, Telemachus.

Planctae · PLACE — Say: PLANK-tee

The Wandering (or Clashing) Rocks, the crashing hazard that only the Argo ever passed safely; Circe warns Odysseus off that route in favor of Scylla and Charybdis, and Odysseus later summarizes the choice for Penelope. *Also called:* the Wandering Rocks; the Clashing Rocks.

Refs: 12.61, 23.327.

See also: Scylla, Charybdis, Circe.

Poias · MORTAL — Say: POH-yas

Father of the archer Philoctetes.

Kin: father of Philoctetes.

Refs: 3.190.

See also: Philoctetes.

Polites · MORTAL — Say: poh-LY-teez

A crewman of Odysseus, “closest and dearest” of all his companions, who first urges hailing the singer at the loom in the woods of Aea — the discovery that leads the men into Circe’s

house.

Refs: 10.224.

See also: Circe.

Polybus · MORTAL — Say: POL-ih-bus

The name covers four distinct men:

Eurymachus's father, invoked throughout as "Polybus' son" (1.399, 16.345); a skilled Phaeacian craftsman who made the ball used in Alcinous's games (8.373); an Egyptian of Thebes, husband of Alcandre, who gives Helen her silver basket (4.126); and a suitor killed by Eumaeus in the hall-fight (22.243, 22.284).

Refs: 1.399, 4.126, 8.373, 16.345, 22.243, 22.284.

See also: Eurymachus.

Polycaste · MORTAL — Say: pol-ih-KAS-tee

Nestor's youngest daughter; she bathes and dresses Telemachus at Pylos, the guest-honor after which he rises "with the body of an immortal."

Kin: daughter of Nestor.

Refs: 3.464.

See also: Nestor.

Polyctor · MORTAL — Say: poh-LIK-tor

The name covers two men: one of the legendary founders of Ithaca, commemorated with Ithacus and Neritus in the fountain by the town's edge; and, separately, father of the suitor Peisander, named among the suitors' four best fighters.

Refs: 17.207, 18.299, 22.243.

Polydamna · MORTAL — Say: pol-ih-DAM-nuh

An Egyptian woman, wife of Thon, who gives Helen the potent grief-erasing drug she mixes into the wine at Sparta.

Refs: 4.228.

See also: Helen.

Polydeuces · MORTAL — Say: pol-ih-DYOO-seez

The immortal twin, brother of Castor; seen by Odysseus in the underworld among Leda's sons,

the pair share life and death turn about, a day each, an honor equal to the gods’.

Kin: son of Leda and Tyndareus; brother of Castor.

Refs: 11.300.

Polypemon · MORTAL — Say: pol-ih-PEE-mon
“Much-Suffering” — the invented grandfather in the fictitious genealogy Odysseus gives Laertes before revealing himself: Eperitus, son of Apheidas, son of Polypemon. The invented names, read for their etymology, spell out Odysseus’s real story.

Refs: 24.305.

See also: Laertes.

Polypheides · MORTAL — Say: pol-ih-FY-deez
Seer son of Mantius; Apollo makes him a great prophet, and he fathers Theoclymenus.

Kin: son of Mantius; father of Theoclymenus.

Refs: 15.249, 15.252.

See also: Theoclymenus.

Polyphemus (Πολύφημος) · GOD — Say: pol-ih-FEE-mus

The one-eyed Cyclops, son of Poseidon and the nymph Thoosa. Odysseus and his men are trapped in his cave on the voyage home, and he devours several of them before Odysseus gets him drunk, blinds his single eye with a fire-hardened stake, and escapes lashed under the rams' bellies — tricking him first with the false name “Nobody.” His dying curse, that Odysseus reach home late, ruined, and in another's ship, sets Poseidon's wrath in motion for the rest of the poem.

Also called: “the Cyclops”; deceived by “Nobody” (Οὔτις), Odysseus's alias.

Kin: son of Poseidon and Thoosa (daughter of Phorcys).

Refs: 1.69, 9.296, 9.319, 9.403, 9.407, 9.475, 9.502, 9.548. Books 1–2, 9–10, 12, 20, 23.

See also: Poseidon, Phorcys, Odysseus.

Polythorses · MORTAL — Say: pol-ih-THUR-seez
Father of the suitor Ctesippus; named only

when Philoetius, having just killed his son,
taunts the corpse as “son of Polythereses.”

Kin: father of Ctesippus.

Refs: 22.287.

Pontonus · MORTAL — *Say:* pon-TON-oh-us

Alcinous’s herald and wine-steward on Scheria,
who mixes and serves the feast at the king’s
command and seats the disguised Odysseus
among the guests.

Refs: 7.179, 7.182, 8.65, 13.50, 13.53.

See also: Alcinous.

Poseidon (Ποσειδῶν) · GOD — *Say:* poh-SY-dun

God of the sea and Odysseus’s chief divine
antagonist, brother of Zeus. Enraged when
Odysseus blinds his son Polyphemus, he curses
him to a late, ruined homecoming and spends
the poem harrying him — wrecking his raft off
Scheria, and, after the Phaeacians finally see
him home, turning their returning ship to
stone in sight of harbor as punishment for

defying him. He is absent from the gods' council that frees Odysseus, visiting the Ethiopians, and is reconciled only after that final blow lands.

Epithets: “the earth-shaker” / “shaker of earth” (ἐνοσίχθων/έννοσίγαιος, 1.74); “who holds the earth” (γαιήοχος, 1.68); “with the blue-black hair” (κυανοχαίτης, 3.6).

Kin: son of Cronos, brother of Zeus; father of Polyphemos (by Thoosa) and, through Nausithous, ancestor of the Phaeacian royal line.

Refs: 1.20, 1.68, 1.74, 5.366, 8.322, 9.526, 9.528, 13.159, 23.234. Books 1, 3–9, 11, 13, 23–24.

See also: Polyphemos, Zeus, Phaeacians, Nausithous.

Priam · MORTAL — Say: PRY-am

King of Troy against whom the Achaeans fought for nine years and whose city they finally sacked — the war and its sack recur throughout the poem as the shared backdrop of every veteran's story; one of his daughters is

glimpsed among the pitiful voices Odysseus hears in the underworld, and Athena invokes his fallen city to shame Odysseus into battle-rage before the suitor-fight.

Refs: 3.107, 3.130, 5.106, 11.421, 11.533, 13.316, 14.241, 22.230.

See also: Troy.

Procris · MORTAL — *Say:* PROK-ris

A heroine seen by Odysseus among the famous women of the underworld, named beside Phaedra and Ariadne.

Refs: 11.321.

See also: Phaedra.

Proteus (Πρωτεύς) · GOD — *Say:* PROH-tee-us

The shape-shifting sea-god of Egypt, Poseidon's seal-herding "under-servant." Menelaus, on Eidothea's advice, ambushes him disguised in sealskins and holds him fast through his transformations until he answers truly — the poem's one god forced bodily into telling the

truth, who reveals the fates of the Achaean captains and Menelaus's own promised end in Elysium.

Epithets: “the unerring Old Man of the Sea” (γέρων ἄλιος νημερτής, 4.349).

Refs: 4.365, 4.385.

See also: Menelaus, Poseidon.

Psyria · PLACE — *Say:* SY-ree-uh

An islet in the eastern Aegean, weighed as a routing option — keeping it to the left, past Chios — when the fleet debates the crossing home from Troy.

Refs: 3.171.

Pylians · PEOPLE — *Say:* PY-lee-unz

Nestor's people, the folk of sandy Pylos; they crowd the shore for Poseidon's festival when Telemachus arrives, and Telemachus meets them again on his return leg.

Refs: 3.59, 15.216, 15.227.

See also: Pylos, Nestor.

Pylos (Πύλος) · PLACE — Say: PY-los

Nestor's kingdom on the western Peloponnese, "sandy Pylos." Athena, disguised as Mentor, guides Telemachus there on the first leg of his search for news of his father; Nestor receives him at a beachside festival for Poseidon, tells his own homecoming and recalls Agamemnon's death, and sends him on to Sparta with Peisistratus. Telemachus passes through Pylos again on his voyage home, evading the suitors' ambush.

Refs: 1.93, 2.214, 3.4, 3.182, 3.485, 4.599, 15.193, 15.541. Books 1–5, 11, 13–17, 21, 24.

See also: Nestor, Pylians, Telemachus.

Pyriphlegethon · PLACE — Say: pir-ih-FLEJ-uh-thon

"Fire-blazing" — one of the underworld's rivers, a branch of the Styx that, with Cocytus, pours into Acheron at the rock where Circe directs Odysseus to make his offerings to the dead.

Refs: 10.513.

See also: Circe.

Pytho · PLACE — Say: PY-thoh

Delphi, seat of Apollo's oracle. Agamemnon consults it before Troy, in the prophecy Demodocus later sings, and it recurs as the site near which Apollo punishes Tityus for assaulting Leto on the road there.

Refs: 8.80, 11.581.

See also: Apollo.

Rhadamanthus · MORTAL — Say: rad-uh-MAN-thus

Fair-haired judge of the dead, dwelling at the world's edge in Elysium — the painless afterlife Proteus promises Menelaus for having married Helen. The Phaeacians once ferried him, in a single day, to visit the giant Tityus, proof of their ships' supernatural speed.

Refs: 4.564, 7.323.

See also: Menelaus, Proteus, Phaeacians.

Rheithron · PLACE — Say: REE-thron

The Ithacan harbor, under wooded Neion, where "Mentes" — Athena in disguise — says

her ship lies at anchor.

Refs: 1.186.

See also: Athena.

Rhexenor · MORTAL — Say: rek-SEE-nor

Son of Nausithous and brother of Alcinous; he dies young, “still without a son,” leaving his daughter Arete, whom Alcinous then marries.

Kin: son of Nausithous; brother of Alcinous; father of Arete.

Refs: 7.63, 7.64, 7.146.

See also: Alcinous, Arete, Nausithous.

Rumor (Ῥοσσα) · GOD

News personified, said to travel from Zeus and reach mortals with no visible source. Athena invokes her to Telemachus as one possible way to learn his father’s fate; at the poem’s close, Rumor herself runs through Ithaca’s streets crying the suitors’ slaughter.

Also called: Ossa.

Refs: 1.282, 2.216, 24.413.

See also: Zeus.

Salmoneus · MORTAL — *Say:* sal-MOH-nee-us

Father of Tyro, named when her shade introduces herself to Odysseus in the underworld.

Kin: father of Tyro.

Refs: 11.236.

Same · PLACE — *Say:* SAY-mee or SAH-mee

An island of Odysseus's Ithacan realm, also called Samos; grouped with Dulichium and Zacynthus in the poem's roll-call of his kingdom, it supplies twenty-four of the suitors, including the wealthy, lawless Ctesippus.

Also called: Samos.

Refs: 1.246, 9.24, 16.123, 16.249, 20.288.

See also: Ithaca, Ctesippus.

Scheria (Σχερία) · PLACE — *Say:* SKEER-ee-uh

The Phaeacians' island, Odysseus's last stop

before Ithaca. Athena calls it sea-ringed and set apart from other mortals at the world's edge — the setting of Books 6–13, where Nausicaa finds the shipwrecked stranger and Alcinous sends him home laden with gifts.

Also called: the land of the Phaeacians.

Refs: 5.34, 6.8, 7.79, 13.160.

See also: Alcinous, Nausicaa, Phaeacians.

Scylla (Σκύλλα) · GOD — Say: SIL-uh

A six-headed, twelve-footed monster lairing in a cliff-cave opposite Charybdis, daughter of Crataeis. Circe directs Odysseus to hug Scylla's crag rather than risk Charybdis's whirlpool; as the ship passes, Scylla snatches six companions from the deck — the poem's bitterest arithmetic, “far better to mourn six... than all together” (12.109–110).

Kin: daughter of Crataeis.

Refs: 12.85–101 (her lair and anatomy), 12.108–125 (Circe's counsel), 12.223–261 (the killing), 12.310, 12.430, 12.445, 23.328 (retold to

Penelope).

See also: Charybdis, Circe, Odysseus.

Scyros (Σκυῖρος) · PLACE — *Say:* SKY-ros

The island where Achilles hid the young Neoptolemus; Odysseus recalls fetching the boy from there to fight at Troy, in his account to the shade of Achilles.

Refs: 11.509.

See also: Neoptolemus, Achilles.

Sicania (Σικανία) · PLACE — *Say:* sih-KAY-nee-uh

Sicily, named as the edge of the known world in the last of Odysseus's false identities — the disguise he wears to test his father Laertes in Book 24.

Refs: 24.307.

See also: Sicilians, Laertes.

Sicilians (Σικελοί) · PEOPLE — *Say:* sih-SIL-yunz

The people of Sicania; the word also names a particular old servant of Laertes' household, a

Sicilian slave-woman who tends him on his farm and helped raise Dolius's children.

Refs: 20.383 (suitors threaten to sell Theoclymenus and Piraeus to the Sicilians), 24.211, 24.366, 24.389.

See also: Laertes, Dolius.

Sidon (Σιδών) · PLACE — *Say:* SY-don

The Phoenician city; source of the silver mixing-bowl King Phaedimus gives Menelaus (4.615–619, 15.117–119), and, by her own account, the birthplace of the Phoenician nurse who kidnaps the child Eumaeus.

Refs: 13.285, 15.425.

See also: Sidonians, Eumaeus.

Sidonians (Σιδόνιοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* sy-DOH-nee-unz

The people of Sidon in Phoenicia, famed for craftwork; Menelaus names their king Phaedimus as the giver of his finest guest-gift, a silver mixing-bowl “the work of Hephaestus.”

Refs: 4.84, 4.618, 15.118.

See also: Sidon, Menelaus.

Sintians (Σίντιες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* SIN-tee-unz

The wild-tongued people of Lemnos to whom Ares withdraws after Hephaestus's snare exposes his affair with Aphrodite — named once, in passing, in Demodocus's song.

Refs: 8.294.

See also: Ares, Hephaestus, Aphrodite.

Sirens (Σειρῆνες) · GOD — *Say:* SY-runz

Two singers whose song promises knowledge and fame but lures listeners to a meadow heaped with the bones of the dead. On Circe's instruction Odysseus has his men bind him to the mast and stop their own ears with wax, so he alone hears the song and lives to tell it.

Refs: 12.39–52 (Circe's warning), 12.158–200 (the passage), 23.326 (retold to Penelope).

See also: Circe, Odysseus.

Sisyphus (Σίσυφος) · MORTAL — Say: SIS-ih-fus

One of the great sinners Odysseus sees punished in the underworld, condemned to shove a boulder up a slope forever, only to watch it roll back down each time he nears the crest.

Refs: 11.593–598.

See also: Tantalus, Tityus.

Solymi (Σόλυμοι) · PEOPLE — Say: SOL-ih-my

An eastern people whose hills give Poseidon, returning from the Ethiopians, his vantage point for spotting Odysseus's raft near Scheria — the sighting that triggers the storm of Book 5.

Refs: 5.283.

See also: Poseidon.

Sparta (Σπάρτη) · PLACE

Menelaus's city in Lacedaemon; Telemachus's second stop on his journey, after Pylos, where Menelaus and Helen tell him of Proteus's report

on Odysseus, and where Peisistratus escorts him there and back.

Refs: 1.93, 2.214, 4.10 (Menelaus's wedding-feast), 11.460, 13.412 (Athena's errand to fetch Telemachus).

See also: Menelaus, Helen, Telemachus.

Spinners (Κλωθες) · GOD

“Destiny and the grave Spinners” — personified Fates who spin a man's thread at birth. Alcinous invokes them once, promising Odysseus safe passage only as far as the beach; what happens after is theirs, already spun.

Also called: the Fates.

Refs: 7.197.

See also: Zeus.

Stratius (Στράτιος) · MORTAL — Say: STRAT-ee-us

One of Nestor's sons at Pylos, present at the sacrifice to Athena that opens Telemachus's visit; he and Echephron lead the sacrificial heifer by the horns.

Kin: son of Nestor, brother of Peisistratus and Thrasymedes.

Refs: 3.413, 3.439.

See also: Nestor, Thrasymedes.

Styx (Στύξ) · PLACE — *Say*: STIKS

The river of the underworld by which the gods swear their most binding oath. Calypso swears by “the down-dripping water of Styx” that she means Odysseus no harm; Circe cites it among the gods’ great oaths.

Refs: 5.185, 10.514.

See also: Calypso, Circe.

Sunium (Σούνιον) · PLACE — *Say*: SOO-nee-um

The Attic headland where Apollo’s “gentle arrows” strike down Phrontis, Menelaus’s helmsman, delaying the fleet’s homeward voyage — from Nestor’s telling of the Returns.

Refs: 3.278.

See also: Menelaus, Nestor.

Syrie (Συρίη) · PLACE — Say: SEE-ree

Eumaeus's home island, said to lie "above Ortygia, where the turnings of the sun are" — a near-paradise of no famine and no sickness, where he was born a prince before Phoenician traders and his own nurse sold him into slavery.

Refs: 15.403.

See also: Eumaeus.

Tantalus (Τάνταλος) · MORTAL — Say: TAN-tuh-lus

Punished in the underworld by hunger and thirst that can never be satisfied: the water recedes when he stoops to drink, the fruit lifts out of reach when he grasps for it. Odysseus sees him among the great sinners.

Refs: 11.582–589.

See also: Sisyphus, Tityus.

Taphians (Τάφιοι) · PEOPLE — Say: TAF-ee-unz

Seafarers and slave-raiders of the island Taphos; their chief Mentes is the shape Athena wears to visit Telemachus in Book 1, and

Taphian pirates are blamed for an old raid on the Thesprotians that once brought Eupheithes to Ithaca as a fugitive.

Refs: 1.105 (Athena as Mentes), 1.181, 1.419, 14.452, 15.427, 16.426 (Eupheithes' history).

See also: Mentes, Taphos, Athena.

Taphos (Τάφος) · PLACE — Say: TAF-os

The island home of the Taphian seafarers, and of Mentes, the guise Athena takes to visit Telemachus.

Refs: 1.417.

See also: Taphians, Mentes.

Taygetus (Ταΰγετος) · PLACE — Say: tay-IJ-uh-tus

A mountain of Laconia, named in the simile that compares Nausicaa among her handmaids to Artemis hunting “down long Taygetus” among her nymphs.

Refs: 6.103.

See also: Nausicaa, Artemis.

Telamon (Τελαμών) · MORTAL — Say: TEL-uh-mon

Father of the greater Ajax, named only by patronymic when Odysseus meets his son's unforgiving shade in the underworld.

Kin: father of Ajax.

Refs: 11.543, 11.553.

See also: Ajax.

Telemachus (Τηλέμαχος) · MORTAL — Say: tuh-

LEM-uh-kus

Odysseus's son, an infant when his father sailed for Troy, and the poem's other protagonist, who comes of age across its length. Sore at heart among the suitors in Book 1, he is roused by Athena to call an assembly and sail to Pylos and Sparta for news of his father; he returns in time to help hide the hall's weapons, spring the trap on the suitors, and fight at Odysseus's side through the slaughter and the final peace.

Epithets: "clear-headed Telemachus"

(Τηλέμαχος πεπνυμένος, 1.213); "godlike Telemachus" (Τηλέμαχος θεοειδής, 1.113).

Kin: son of Odysseus and Penelope.

Refs: 1.113 (first named), 1.345–359 (“mine is the power in this house”), 2.1–14 (calls the assembly), 3.14ff (Pylos), 4.1ff (Sparta), 16.155–234 (reunion with his father), 19.1–52 (hides the arms), 22.90ff (fights in the hall), 24.505–515 (armed beside his father) ...and throughout. Books 1–24.

See also: Odysseus, Penelope, Athena, Mentor.

Telemus (Τήλεμος) · MORTAL — Say: TEL-uh-mus
Son of Eurymus, a seer among the Cyclopes who long ago foretold that Odysseus would blind Polyphemus — a prophecy Polyphemus recalls, too late, as Odysseus’s ship pulls away.
Also called: son of Eurymus.

Refs: 9.509.

See also: Polyphemus.

Telephus (Τήλεφος) · MORTAL — Say: TEL-uh-fus
Father of Eurypylus, the Mysian hero Odysseus tells Achilles’s shade about, killed at Troy fighting on the Trojan side.

Kin: father of Eurypylus.

Refs: 11.519.

See also: Eurypylus, Achilles.

Telepylus (Τηλέπυλος) · PLACE — *Say:* tuh-LEP-ih-lus

The Laestrygonian stronghold, city of King Lamus, where the giant cannibals destroy all of Odysseus's ships but one, spearing his men in the harbor like fish.

Refs: 10.82, 23.318 (retold to Penelope).

See also: Laestrygonians.

Temese (Τεμέση) · PLACE — *Say:* TEM-uh-see

The copper-trading port Athena, disguised as Mentès, claims to be sailing toward with a cargo of iron — a rare glimpse of the poet's own Iron Age trade inside the poem's Bronze Age fiction.

Refs: 1.184.

See also: Mentès, Taphians.

Tenedos (Τένεδος) · PLACE — Say: TEN-uh-dos

The island off Troy where the homeward-bound Greeks first put in and sacrifice, in Nestor's account of the fleet's disastrous, divided departure.

Refs: 3.159.

See also: Nestor, Troy.

Terpes (Τέρπης) · MORTAL — Say: TUR-pee-z

Father of Phemius, the Ithacan singer forced to perform for the suitors; named only by patronymic as Phemius pleads for his life before Odysseus in the slaughter.

Also called: Terpius.

Kin: father of Phemius.

Refs: 22.330.

See also: Phemius.

Thebes (Θῆβαι) · PLACE

Two cities share the name in the poem:
Boeotian Thebes of the seven gates, founded by
Amphion and Zethus and later ruled by

Oedipus, and the site of Amphiaraus's death; and Egyptian Thebes of the hundred gates, the fabulously wealthy city of Alcandre and Polybus, source of a silver basket given to Helen. Tiresias, whom Odysseus consults in the underworld, is repeatedly called "the Theban."
Refs: 4.126 (Egyptian Thebes), 11.165, 11.263–275 (Boeotian Thebes founded), 12.267, 15.247 (Amphiaraus), 23.323 (Tiresias "the Theban").
See also: Tiresias, Zethus, Amphiaraus.

Themis (Θέμις) · GOD — *Say:* THEM-is
Goddess of order and assembly, who "seats and dissolves" the gatherings of men; Telemachus swears by her, alongside Zeus, when he begs the Ithacan assembly for a fair hearing.
Refs: 2.68.
See also: Zeus, Telemachus.

Theoclymenus (Θεοκλύμενος) · MORTAL — *Say:*
thee-oh-KLIM-uh-nus or thee-oh-KLY-men-us
A fugitive seer, great-grandson of Melampus,

who has killed a man in Argos and begs passage on Telemachus's ship at Pylos. He accompanies Telemachus home, reads a hawk-and-dove omen as proof that Odysseus's line will rule Ithaca, and later, at the height of the suitors' feasting, sees a vision of blood and death that the suitors laugh off.

Epithets: "godlike Theoclymenus" (Θεοκλύμενος θεοειδής, 15.271).

Refs: 15.256–286 (meets Telemachus), 15.508–534 (the hawk omen), 17.151 (prophecy to Penelope), 20.350–363 (the vision of doom).
See also: Telemachus, Melampus.

Theseus (Θησεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* THEE-see-us

The Athenian hero, named twice in the underworld's catalogue of the illustrious dead: once as the man who carried off Ariadne and lost her to Artemis, once among the "glorious children of the gods" Odysseus hoped, but failed, to see.

Refs: 11.322, 11.631.

See also: Ariadne, Pirithous.

Thesprotians (Θεσπρωτοί) · PEOPLE — Say: thes-PROH-shunz

The mainland people, and land, that Odysseus repeatedly invents as the setting of his most recent adventures in the false tales he tells on Ithaca — claiming news there of a living, treasure-laden Odysseus about to sail home under King Pheidon's escort.

Refs: 14.315–316, 14.334, 16.65, 17.526, 19.271, 19.287–291 (the fullest telling, to Penelope).

See also: Odysseus, Penelope.

Thetis (Θέτις) · GOD — Say: THEE-tis or THET-is
Sea-goddess, mother of Achilles; Agamemnon's shade recalls her rising from the sea with her sister Nereids to mourn her son and set out the funeral games' prizes.

Kin: mother of Achilles.

Refs: 24.92.

See also: Achilles.

Thoas (Θόας) · MORTAL — Say: THOH-as

Son of Andraemon, a warrior Odysseus invents as a companion in the false night-ambush tale he tells Eumaeus.

Also called: son of Andraemon.

Refs: 14.499.

See also: Eumaeus.

Thon (Θών) · MORTAL — Say: THON

The Egyptian husband of Polydamna, who gave Helen the drugs “that undo grief and anger” — the nepenthe she mixes into the wine at Sparta.
Kin: husband of Polydamna.

Refs: 4.228.

See also: Helen.

Thoosa (Θόωσα) · GOD — Say: thoh-OH-suh

A sea-nymph, daughter of Phorcys, who bore Polyphemus to Poseidon in her sea-caves — the reason Poseidon’s grudge against Odysseus, for blinding his son, runs so deep.

Kin: daughter of Phorcys; mother of

Polyphemus by Poseidon.

Refs: 1.71–73.

See also: Polyphemus, Poseidon.

Thrace (Θρήικη) · PLACE

The northern land Ares flees to after
Hephaestus's snare exposes his affair with
Aphrodite — named once, in Demodocus's song.

Refs: 8.361.

See also: Ares, Cicones.

Thrasymedes (Θρασυμήδης) · MORTAL — Say:

thras-ih-MEE-deez

A son of Nestor at Pylos; he sits beside his
father and brother Peisistratus when
Telemachus arrives, and strikes the axe-blow at
the sacrifice to Athena the next morning.

Kin: son of Nestor, brother of Peisistratus and
Stratius.

Refs: 3.39, 3.414, 3.442, 3.448.

See also: Nestor, Stratius.

Thrinacia (Θρινακίη) · PLACE — Say: thrih-NAY-shuh

The island of Helios's sacred cattle, guarded by his daughters Phaethusa and Lampetie. Both Tiresias and Circe warn Odysseus to leave the herds untouched; his starving crew kill them anyway, and Zeus destroys the ship for it — the disaster that leaves Odysseus alone.

Refs: 11.107 (Tiresias's warning), 12.127–137 (Circe's warning), 19.275 (recounted to Penelope).

See also: Helios, Tiresias, Circe.

Thyestes (Θυέστης) · MORTAL — Say: thy-ES-teez

Brother of Atreus and father of Aegisthus; blown off course, Menelaus lands by chance at the border of the country that was once Thyestes' — now Aegisthus's — on the very day of Agamemnon's murder.

Kin: brother of Atreus; father of Aegisthus.

Refs: 4.517–518.

See also: Aegisthus, Atreus, Agamemnon.

Tiresias (Τειρεσίας) · MORTAL — Say: ty-REE-see-us

The blind seer whose ghost, alone among the dead, keeps his understanding after drinking the sacrificial blood in the underworld. He gives Odysseus the poem's central prophecy: the danger from Poseidon, the warning about Thrinacia's cattle, the slaughter of the suitors to come, and a strange final journey inland with an oar, ending in a "gentle" death from the sea.

Also called: "the Theban."

Refs: 10.492, 10.524–540 (Circe sends him there), 11.90–151 (the prophecy), 12.267, 23.251–284, 23.323 (retold to Penelope).

See also: Odysseus, Circe, Thrinacia.

Tithonus (Τιθωνός) · MORTAL — Say: tih-THOH-nus

The mortal husband of Dawn, granted endless life but not endless youth; the book of Odysseus's shipwreck near Scheria opens with Dawn rising from his bed, a pointed frame for the immortality Calypso has just been ordered

to give up.

Kin: husband of Dawn (Eos).

Refs: 5.1.

See also: Calypso.

Tityus (Τιτυός) · MORTAL — *Say:* TIT-ee-us

A giant, son of Earth, punished in the underworld for assaulting Leto: he lies sprawled over nine acres while two vultures forever tear at his liver. Alcinous also cites him as proof of how far the Phaeacians' ships can sail in a day.

Kin: son of Earth (Gaia).

Refs: 7.324 (Alcinous's boast), 11.576–581 (his punishment).

See also: Leto.

Trojans (Τρῶες) · PEOPLE

The people of Troy, the Achaeans' enemy in the ten-year war underlying the whole poem; they recur throughout the recollections of Nestor, Menelaus, and Helen, and in Odysseus's own

tales of the horse and the sack.

Refs: 1.237, 3.85–100, 4.243–275 (Helen’s and Menelaus’s dueling tales), 8.503–520 (the wooden horse), 11.383–547 (the underworld), 22.228, 24.27–38 (Agamemnon’s shade).

See also: Troy, Achaeans, Helen.

Troy (Τροίη) · PLACE

The sacked city, also called Ilium, whose ten-year siege and fall stand behind the whole poem: the war Odysseus and the other Achaean leaders fought, and the wreck of homecomings it produced. The proem opens with its sack (1.2); the Apologoi, the underworld, the Telemachy, and Demodocus’s songs all keep returning to it, and Penelope names it, in her own coinage, “Evil-Ilium, never to be named” (19.260, 597).

Also called: Ilium.

Refs: 1.2, 2.172, 3.130ff (Nestor’s Returns), 4.99, 8.499–520 (Demodocus’s horse-song), 9.39, 11.169 (Anticleia), 24.27ff ...and throughout. Books 1–24 passim.

See also: Trojans, Achaeans, Agamemnon, Menelaus.

Tydeus (Τυδεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* TY-dee-us
Father of Diomedes, named only by the patronymic “son of Tydeus” as Nestor and Menelaus recall him among the Achaean leaders at Troy and inside the wooden horse.
Kin: father of Diomedes.
Refs: 3.167, 4.280.
See also: Diomedes.

Tyndareus (Τυνδάρεως) · MORTAL — *Say:* tin-DAIR-ee-us
The mortal husband of Leda; in the underworld’s catalogue of heroines she is named as his wife and, by him, the mother of Castor and Polydeuces. Agamemnon’s shade later calls Clytemnestra “the daughter of Tyndareus” in bitter contrast to Penelope.
Kin: husband of Leda; father, in the poem, of Castor and Polydeuces.

Refs: 11.298–299, 24.199.

See also: Leda, Clytemnestra.

Tyro (Τυρώ) · MORTAL — *Say:* TY-roh

Daughter of Salmoneus, who fell in love with the river Enipeus; Poseidon took the river's shape to lie with her, and she bore him Pelias and Neleus — making her, through Neleus, ancestress of Nestor's whole line. Antinous cites her among the legendary women whose cunning still falls short of Penelope's.

Kin: daughter of Salmoneus; mother of Pelias and Neleus by Poseidon.

Refs: 2.120 (Antinous's comparison), 11.235–259 (her story in full).

See also: Poseidon, Nestor.

Winds ("Άνεμοί) · GOD

The four winds appear both as ordinary weather and, at key moments, as personified agents: Aeolus's bagged winds, the storm Poseidon raises against Odysseus's raft, the

squall that wrecks the crew off Thrinacia.

Athena can still their courses or rouse a single fair one at will.

Also called: Boreas (North Wind), Notos (South Wind), Euros (East Wind), Zephyrus (West Wind).

Refs: 5.295–332 (Poseidon’s storm, all four at once), 9.67, 10.25 (Aeolus’s bag), 12.325–426 (Thrinacia), 14.253, 19.200 ...and throughout. Books 2–5, 7, 9–10, 12–14, 19.

See also: Aeolus, Poseidon, Athena.

Zacynthus (Ζάκυνθος) · PLACE — *Say:* zuh-SIN-thus

A wooded island of Odysseus’s realm, named among Ithaca’s neighbors and among the islands whose leading men count themselves Penelope’s suitors.

Refs: 1.246, 9.24, 16.123, 19.131.

See also: Ithaca, Dulichium, Same.

Zethus (Ζῆθος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ZEE-thus

Son of Zeus and Antiope; with his brother

Amphion he founded and walled seven-gated Thebes. He is also, in Penelope's nightingale simile, the father of Itylus, the son his wife killed by mistake — the myth Penelope reaches for to describe her own divided heart.

Kin: son of Zeus and Antiope; brother of Amphion.

Refs: 11.262–263, 19.523.

See also: Thebes, Amphion.

Zeus (Ζεύς) · GOD — *Say:* ZOOS

Father of gods and men, and the poem's guarantor of *xenia*, oaths, and the plot's overall justice. He opens the poem musing on Aegisthus as proof that mortals bring ruin on themselves “beyond their portion” (1.32–43), approves Athena's plan to bring Odysseus home, restrains Poseidon's grudge within limits, and at the end sanctions both the killing of the suitors and the amnesty that follows.

Epithets: “Zeus who gathers the clouds” (νεφεληγερέτα Ζεύς, 1.63); “Zeus of the wide voice” (εὐρύοπα Ζεύς, 2.146); “(Zeus) who

thunders on high” (ὑψιβρεμέτης, 5.4); “aegis-bearing Zeus” (αἰγιόχοιο Διός, 3.42).

Also called: “son of Cronos” / “Cronion” — but “Cronos” alone names the Titan father, per canon.

Kin: son of Cronos; father of Athena, Apollo, Artemis, Hermes, Aphrodite (here by Dione), Ares.

Refs: 1.28–43 (Aegisthus speech), 1.63–79 (council on Odysseus), 5.21–42 (dispatches Hermes), 12.415–419 (destroys the ship), 13.128–158 (Poseidon and the Phaeacian ship), 24.477–486 (sanctions the peace) ...and throughout. Books 1–24.

See also: Athena, Poseidon, Hera.
